



INSIDE ARABIC MUSIC

Arabic Maqam Performance *and* Theory in the 20th Century

JOHNNY FARRAJ & SAMI ABU SHUMAYS



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IN THE 20TH CENTURY

Johnny Farraj and Sami Abu Shumays

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This book is dedicated to our wives, Maria Hantzopoulos and Robin Shumays.

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Preface

I HAVE BEEN listening to Arabic music all my life. Ironically, I only started passionately studying and performing it after I left my native Lebanon to live in the United States. When I began my journey as an Arab musician in 1998, I searched hard for a good introductory book on Arabic music theory and performance. Although I found quite a few books covering various aspects of Arabic music both in Arabic and English, none of them met my needs, for multiple reasons.

The books I found in English were by and large academic, and while they serve an important purpose in that realm, they were written in a formal style and language that made that rich and complex subject difficult for nonacademics to digest. Some academic books were thorough to a fault with their research—listing all possible (and sometimes contradictory, inconsistent, or out-of-date) narratives side by side before drawing their conclusions—and some relied more on written references and less on personal performance/learning experience. Finally, many of the English books only covered a narrow subtopic in Arabic music (e.g., singer Umm Kulthum, *tarab*) or one region (e.g., the music of Egypt, Syria, or Palestine), and even those with wider coverage still did not include the broad range of topics that I needed to learn as a beginner musician.

Books in Arabic had their shortcomings, too, as they were either too focused on a narrow topic (e.g., the Arabic *maqam* or the *muwashshah* genre), too theoretical, too focused on history rather than performance, or too out of date in their content. Many were out of print or were extremely hard to find in a bookstore. Another

problem with the Arabic books is that although written by Arab music practitioners and subject matter experts, they were published in different parts of the Arab world at different periods, and as a result they did not all agree when it came to theory (a state of affairs that unavoidably trickled back into the English references previously mentioned).

In order to immerse myself in Arabic music, I started studying the oud with Palestinian *‘ud* virtuoso Simon Shaheen, then attended the Arabic Music Retreat’s intensive summer program for six consecutive years and studied the *riqq*, the *‘ud*, voice, and *maqam* theory. At the same time, I started performing regularly with other Arab musicians in commercial venues, theaters, museums, and universities, as well as in private jam sessions. By then, most of the practical knowledge I had acquired was handed down orally from more experienced musicians, and only a small portion was acquired from written sources. In parallel, I collected a huge archive of Arabic music recordings and spent many years extensively and attentively listening to the rich repertoire of traditional Arabic music from the mid-20th century.

My first attempt to fill the gap for an introductory Arabic music reference in English was made in the early 2000s, by building MaqamWorld.com, a website that covers Arabic music theory and performance and focuses on the Arabic *maqam* (the system of scales that traditional/classical Arabic music is based on). While it was relatively concise, it was rich in audio samples and explained the material in English using simple language and a very down-to-earth pedagogical approach. The website proved to be hugely popular and filled an obvious gap in online Arabic music resources. MaqamWorld quickly became the de facto Internet reference for Arabic music and *maqam* theory. In 2016, MaqamWorld was the recipient of a grant from the Arab Fund for Arts and Culture (AFAC) in the research, training, and regional (RTR) events category.

During that period, I frequently performed with my friend, violinist Sami Abu Shumays, with whom I also engaged in many discussions on Arabic *maqam* theory and musical practice. Abu Shumays was also one of the contributors to MaqamWorld as a music theory consultant and the performer of the violin *maqam* scale audio samples.

On a parallel track, Abu Shumays started developing his MaqamLessons.com website in 2006–2007, then published two papers on Arabic music theory: “Intonation in Maqam: Using Arabic Music as a Lens for Music and Language Cognition,” presented at the 2009 Annual Conference of the Society for Ethnomusicology, and “Maqam Analysis: A Primer” (*Music Theory Spectrum* 35, no. 2 [Fall 2013]). At his website and in his papers, Abu Shumays introduced a new approach to describing Arabic music theory by starting from the aural repertoire and analyzing it in order

to arrive at the best-suited theory, rather than relying on existing theory(ies) to retroactively explain the behavior in the repertoire.

Having seen the wide appeal that MaqamWorld had among Arabic musicians, I decided to turn it into an introductory book that covers Arabic music theory and performance in much more detail. I set out to write a general readership book that could become the definitive Arabic music primer for musicians and listeners alike—in short, the book that I wish had existed when I started learning Arabic music almost twenty years ago. I started working on this book project in 2008, in my spare time. But while the performance chapters (dealing with instruments, forms, ornamentation, arrangement, improvisation, and *tarab*) flowed effortlessly by drawing from my own performance experience, the theory chapters (dealing with *jins*, *maqam*, intonation, modulation, and *sayr*) were more difficult to write because I had to reconcile a lot of existing inconsistent and archaic material, both in written references and in the oral body of knowledge.

Meanwhile, Abu Shumays's work was gaining momentum among the music theory community as it brought a much-needed modernizing view to specific topics that have long been inconsistently defined. Among them, for example, is the size of a *jins* (*maqam* scale fragment) and its corollary issues: chaining of *ajnas*, octave equivalence, and the size of a *maqam* scale. His approach also challenged the widespread Greek tetrachord model and introduced a new view of *jins* and *maqam* that is much more consistent with the way Arabic music is performed in practice.

Abu Shumays and I had engaged in ongoing conversations about the gap between traditional Arabic music theory and musical performance practice, and he frequently introduced his new ideas to me and asked for my feedback as a practitioner and theorist. As an example of this gap, one of our pet peeves was the obsession in Arabic music theory with measuring the precise intonation of every note in every *maqam* scale, a feat that had been attempted at the 1932 Cairo Arabic Music Congress and had failed miserably. To highlight how misguided that idea was, Abu Shumays and I recorded a podcast in 2007 in which we demonstrated the wide range of possible intonations for some notes.

Given that background, I felt that Abu Shumays was the obvious choice for a collaborator on the book, and I invited him to work on the project, initially as a music content editor, and later as a coauthor for the theory chapters, as well as a reviewer/content editor for the performance chapters. His role continued to expand as we worked together; he is in fact the lead author for the content in the *maqam* theory chapters, which by and large reflect his own innovations in understanding *maqam*, and he provided numerous important insights and wrote additional sections in other chapters as well. He partnered with me in figuring out the overall structure, content, and tone of the book. But more than any specific contribution, this book

reflects in many ways the nearly two-decades-long dialogue the two of us have had about Arabic music.

In order to maintain the emphasis on the oral performance tradition as a primary source for the book's material, I invited my friend, Syrian violinist Dr. Samer Ali, to contribute with research, fact checking, and musical content editing on the performance chapters. Dr. Ali brought a vast knowledge of traditional Arabic music (especially the Aleppan tradition), poetry, and language, acquired in Syria through years of study, listening, and performance.

The result is a book that draws heavily on the body of knowledge learned and transmitted orally among musicians and relies only minimally on references. In most cases where references are cited/quoted, this is done to illustrate issues with the traditional understanding of Arabic music theory and to present an alternative view. This is consistent with the fact that most Arabic musicians acquire most of their knowledge orally, through years of communal experience, not by reading about it.

This book's pedagogy aims to put complex and detailed subjects within reach of a general readership, and the book's language and style are tailored accordingly. For this reason, only a handful of Arabic terms are used as is (without translation), while remaining terms and concepts are bridged to the realm of the Western reader using appropriate translations, metaphors, examples, and anecdotes.

Given how rich and diverse Arabic music is, this book is certainly not comprehensive. It does not cover every genre of Arabic music; every single instrument used; or every famous singer, composer, or instrumentalist, and it certainly doesn't cover every *maqam* from the many regions of the Arab world. The primary bias of this book is *maqam*-based music that was practiced in the Eastern Mediterranean region (Syria though Egypt) from the 1930s to the 1960s (a period referred to as the Golden Age of Arabic Music). This is the repertoire that we the authors are experts in and have listened to and performed extensively over decades, and as such the material presented here is based on our firsthand expertise, rather than on researching material that we are less familiar with.

In recognition of the book project's cultural dimension and potential impact, it was awarded a grant in 2012 from AFAC in the RTR category, which includes studies in cultural and artistic fields, and cultural documentation.

Among authors who have covered the subject of Arabic music in great depth, Dr. Scott L. Marcus's scholarship deserves an extra mention here. Based on our subsequent review of his work, we find that he has documented thoroughly and clearly the whole scope of oral concepts of *maqam* theory, matching what we learned from our teachers over the years. As he points out repeatedly, he found an enormous gap between theory and practice, and his scholarship is predicated on filling that gap

with the theoretical knowledge and concepts known to musicians, most of which have not made it into formal theory.

In that regard, we are in agreement with his conclusions, and his review of this book's proposal and manuscript has helped us to clarify the ways our conclusions are distinct from or additional to those. Fundamentally, we find that the rich oral theory of *maqam* he successfully presents nevertheless contains contradictions and inconsistencies and lacks a comprehensive rationale or explanation for why the music is as it is. This is where our project has been to *expand* upon that knowledge, by attempting to reconcile contradictions, and to provide a comprehensive new theory accounting for the *maqam* system as a whole. It is not that we find the oral concepts of *maqam* theory to be fundamentally *wrong*—either as learned from our teachers or as documented by Marcus since 1989—but that we find the theory incomplete. We have made an attempt to add to what we inherited in the pages that follow.

Johnny Farraj
New York, February 2018

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Approach to Music Theory

Inside Arabic Music is, in part, a book about music theory. Since our approach to music theory is unconventional in a number of ways, it is useful to start with an explanation of our perspective. As we view it, music theory is really two different things: (1) the explicit conventions underlying a musical genre (descriptions of scales and rhythmic cycles, rules of harmony or melodic motion, typical structures of various musical forms, etc.); and (2) the implicit structures as understood, often unconsciously, by practicing musicians and listeners. This is as true of Arabic music as it is of any other genre; it is also helpful to compare it with spoken language here: there are explicit grammatical rules learned in the classroom, and there is implicit grammar that exists in the language of speakers, whether or not they have ever been in a classroom.

In the field of linguistics, it has long been recognized that the implicit grammar of speakers is the actual object of study, because it is far richer, deeper, and broader than explicit grammar (which is only the “tip of the iceberg” of language). We do not find the analogous recognition to be tremendously widespread in the field of music theory, however, and it is for that reason that we have taken a different path.

The approach taken in *Inside Arabic Music* is to articulate what we have understood from the implicit structures of *maqam*-based music, learned through decades of immersion in the oral tradition and practice of the music we love so much. In many cases, these observations contradict, or differ significantly from, the traditional conventions of Arabic music theory—and we have not shied away from critiquing that theory where our practical observations point in a different direction.

But in articulating the implicit structures underlying this music, we do not seek to replace oral tradition. We recognize that none of the content that follows can compare with the knowledge gained by musicians through practice and learning repertoire by ear. Rather, we provide an outline of what that practice looks like. One might reasonably ask: If we feel that practice is so much richer than explicit theory, why publish a book at all?

The answer is that we do so in part to correct misconceptions that have arisen from the misunderstandings within explicit theory, many of which have even infected what remains of the community of practitioners. The contemporary understandings of Arabic music theory have drawn from two significant sources: (1) the writings of ancient Greek music theorists, as (mis)understood and (mis)applied by medieval Arab theorists and then passed down over the last millennium; and (2) the misconceptions of Europeans, as forced upon modern Arabs in the colonial period and then adopted by Arabs ourselves in our attempts to modernize and assimilate to Western culture.¹

These misconceptions and misunderstandings range from issues of intonation, to the rigid conception of the scale and the tetrachord, to the differences in types of formality mentioned in the Introduction. We find that even master practicing musicians repeat false descriptions of the music, which don't even match what they themselves are doing. So we have followed this principle: "Learn what they do, not what they say."

These misconceptions obviously don't get in the way of developing a deeper understanding of the music through oral tradition for those able to be immersed in it; however, due to the decline of these traditions in their home countries (including especially a decline in learning aurally), the spread of Arab musicians in a wider diaspora, and the interest among non-Arabs, these misconceptions are more dangerous. In Western contexts in particular, where most musicians are used to learning through notation and interpreting musical information through particular Western frameworks, misunderstandings about what is really going on in the music can lead the unfamiliar student down the wrong path. We are attempting to clear the brambles from the beginning of the correct path, as it were.

This book promises to lead you "inside" Arabic music—we take you under the hood for a closer look at the engine and transmission and provide a practical guide to how the parts fit together. In this analogy, the *maqam* theory we inherited is analogous to Newton's Laws of Motion: having some truth to it, but not very useful in terms of getting your hands dirty with the mechanics of automobiles. It is our hope that by providing this more realistic "operation manual," the reader will be motivated to get behind the wheel and start driving!

¹ Maalouf (2002) and Marcus (1989b).

A Note on Transliteration and Spelling

This book follows the Arabic transliteration system of the *International Journal of Middle East Studies* (IJMES). As such, the Arabic letters ‘*ayn* and *hamza* (the glottal stop) are represented with the [‘] and [’] symbols, respectively. However, in order to make it accessible to a wider, nonacademic readership, diacritical markings above and below letters are omitted. Transliterated Arabic musical terms are italicized throughout the book and listed individually in the glossary, along with their Arabic spellings.

Arabic plurals are used as much as possible (e.g., *maqam* pl. *maqamat*, *jins* pl. *ajnas*, *bashraf* pl. *basharif*), except when they are awkward for the reader, in which case the English plural is used by adding an unitalicized “-s” to end the Arabic word (e.g., *sayr* pl. *sayr-s* not *suyur*, *tabl baladi* pl. *tabl baladi-s* not *tubul baladiyya*, *buzuq* pl. *buzuq-s* not *buzuqat*). In the case of multiple Arabic plurals, one plural is chosen and used consistently (e.g. *lazima* pl. *lazimat* not *lawazim*).

Some proper names deviate from the IJMES system in order to reflect the most common spelling used for artists who are already well-documented in the Latin alphabet. The common spellings selected here will prove to be the most useful when readers conduct online searches using an artist’s name (e.g., Abdel Halim Hafez not ‘Abd al-Halim Hafidh, Muhammad Abdel Wahab not Muhammad ‘Abd al-Wahhab, and Marcel Khalife not Marsil Khalifa). This is especially true for Arab artists who live in the West or have already chosen their transliterations (e.g., Simon Shaheen, Lotfi Bouchnak). Non-Arabic proper names (e.g., Marie [Jubran], Laure [Daccache], and George Michel) are not transliterated.

Maqam names, *jins* names, *iqa'* names, and historic note names are treated as proper names and as such are not italicized (e.g., Maqam Rast not *maqam rast*, Jins 'Ajam not *jins 'ajam*, Iqa' Maqsum not *iqa' maqsum*, and the note Nawa not *nawa*). As proper names, some of these names follow the most common spelling in English, especially when these words are not Arabic in origin (e.g., Dukah, Sikah, and Jiharkah not Duka, Sika, and Jiharka).

Colloquial Arabic words such as song titles, lyrics, and expressions rely less on the IJMES standard and more on the phonetics of the word, as a whole new category of vowels exists in colloquial Arabic, like “o,” “ei,” and “eh” besides the “a,” “u,” and “i” in *fusha*. Colloquial pronunciation (e.g., the “g” Egyptian colloquial pronunciation of letter “j”) is transliterated as it was recorded in musical works. This is especially true for lyrics used in transcribed music samples, as each Arabic syllable must be aligned with its corresponding note(s) in the staff (e.g., *yalla-gma'u* not *yalla ijma'u*). Vowels at the end of Arabic words (*harakat* and *tanwin*) in lyrics are spelled out to match what is actually sung, for example, *bayna qasiyunin* not *bayn qasiyun*, *rihu-s-saba* not *rih al-saba*, and *ash-shamsu wa-l-qamaru* not *al-shams wa al-qamar*.

INSIDE ARABIC MUSIC

INTRODUCTION

“ARABIC MUSIC” COLLECTIVELY describes the wide range of musical traditions and genres that originated and are performed in the Arab world. Any vocal music with Arabic lyrics, and any instrumental music played predominantly on traditional Arabic instruments, is considered Arabic.

As Arab countries extend from Morocco to Iraq and include hundreds of millions of people, they are home to many diverse local traditions in the folk, pop, classical, and religious genres. The broad musical regions within the Arab world are Iraq; the Arab Gulf (*al-khalij*); the Near East (*al-sharq*,¹ literally the East, spanning Egypt, Palestine, Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria); and North Africa (Libya, Tunisia, Algeria, and Morocco), referred to as *al-maghrib* (the West, literally the direction of the sunset). Of course within each of these broad regions are subregions and many local genres particular to them. A case in point is that entire books² have been devoted to the music of Egypt alone.

Moreover, Arabic music was not conceived by Arabs in isolation, but evolved over many centuries in a region where old civilizations interacted. The Arab region extending from Egypt through Syria to Iraq was at the center of the old world, and as Arabic music developed locally, it also incorporated regional elements from

¹ A less commonly used synonym for *al-sharq* is *al-mashriq*, literally the direction of the sunrise.

² Lagrange (1996); Marcus (2007).

neighboring Turkish, Byzantine, Persian, and Indian music, as well as, among others, sub-Saharan African indigenous music. What constitutes Arabic music today is a hybrid amalgamation that has come to be accepted as one “ethnic” tradition. This cultural cross-fertilization wasn’t limited to music, of course, and also manifested itself in, for example, language, architecture, and cuisine.

Given that a book covering the entire breadth of Arabic music would have to be more general, this book covers only one Arabic musical tradition in depth: the tradition that flourished in the Near East from the beginning of the 20th century until roughly the 1970s, especially during the period that began in the 1930s, often called the Golden Age of Arabic Music.

The Golden Age of Arabic Music ---

The Golden Age of Arabic music flourished from 1930 to 1970, in what today is called the Near East, the geographical region spanning Syria to Egypt, with Cairo as its epicenter. That period witnessed unparalleled musical growth, proliferation, and innovation, and its music achieved a wide reach across the Arab world, initially propelled by phonographic technology in the first decade of the 20th century and later by radio, cinema, and eventually television. As a result, music from the Golden Age traveled extremely well and became universal in the Arab world. For better or for worse, the music of the Golden Age is often used as the single or the most prominent representative of Arabic music, both in the Arab world and abroad.

The Golden Age came at the end of a cultural renaissance called *al-nahda* (literally, “the awakening”), during which the Arab world reclaimed its identity from Ottoman control, and Arabic music experienced a revival³ alongside Turkish/Ottoman music. The *nahda* era music practiced at the beginning of the 20th century was largely a remnant of 19th-century music, but it laid the foundation and paved the way for the Golden Age.

In *The Seven Greats of Contemporary Arabic Music*, historian and ethnomusicologist Victor Sahhab (1987) credits seven musical pioneers with ushering in a new musical era that started in the early 20th century, explaining that “before them Arabic music was one thing, and with them it became something else.”⁴ These pioneers were Sayed Darwish (1892–1923), Muhammad al-Qasabgi (1892–1966), Zakariyya Ahmad (1896–1961), Muhammad Abdel Wahab (c. 1902–1991), Umm Kulthum

³ Marcus discusses the revival of Arabic music in Egypt in the 1800s as evidenced by the popularity of Shihab al-Din’s 1840 book *Safinat al-Mulk* (*The Royal Ship*), which included 365 *muwashshahat* arranged in thirty *waslat* (Marcus, 2015b, p. 136).

⁴ Sahhab (1987, p. 6).

(born Fatima Ibrahim al-Sayyid al-Biltagi, c. 1904–1975), Riyad al-Sunbati (1906–1981), and Asmahan (born Amal al-Atrash, 1917–1944).

Several factors enabled the Arabic music of the Golden Age to reach a critical mass; the numbers of composers, singers, instrumentalists, listeners, and producers all grew, and they all fed on each other. The most prominent singers, composers, and performers from the Near East reached unprecedented heights of stardom throughout these years. Egypt's beloved diva Umm Kulthum (nicknamed *kawkab al-sharq*—the Star of the East); Leila Mourad (born Lillian Zaki Mordechai, 1918–1995); Muhammad Abdel Wahab (nicknamed *musiqar al-ajyal*—the Musician of Generations); Abdel Halim Hafez (born 'Abd al-Halim 'Ali Shabbana, 1929–1977; nicknamed *al-'andalib al-asmar*—the Tan Nightingale); Warda⁵ (born Warda Fatuki, 1939–2012; nicknamed *al-jaza'iryya*—the Algerian, after her father's nationality); Syria's Farid al-Atrash (1915–1974); Asmahan, Muhammad Khayri (born Muhammad Khayr Julaylati, 1935–1981); Sabah Fakhri (born Subhi Abu Qaws, 1933); and Lebanon's Wadih al-Safi (born Wadi' Francis, 1921–2013), Sabah (born Jeanette Feghali, 1927–2014; nicknamed *al-shahrura* after her native mountain village of Wadi Shahrur), and Fairouz (born Nuhaḍ Haddad, 1935) represented the very best this era had to offer, and they contributed to the impressive canon of Arabic music from that period. Umm Kulthum, whose career spanned over five decades, embodied the music of the Golden Age so much that one could consider the year of her death, 1975, synonymous with the end of that era.

The influence of European classical music in the region was evident well before the Golden Age, as many Arab musicians were already using the violin to replace indigenous varieties of spike fiddles. The Golden Age saw the introduction of more Western instruments like the piano, the electric organ, the electric guitar, and the double bass, and the influence of Western music continued to manifest itself through the gradual move toward the standardization of Arabic scale intonations across different Arab regions; the gradual shift toward equal-tempered tuning; the adoption of the Western staff notation system; the increased use of harmony; the growth of the traditional Arabic chamber group (the *takht*) to the size of a large orchestra; and last but not least, the use of a conductor.

Perhaps the “Seven Greats’” most important achievement was to negotiate the tremendous influence exerted by European Western music while remaining faithful to the principles that gave Arabic music its character and had distinguished it for centuries: an emphasis on vocal music, improvisation, and the Arabic *maqam* tradition as a modal music framework. As such, this book's coverage of Arabic music focuses primarily on *maqam*-based Arabic music from the Golden Age.

⁵ Warda was married to composer Baligh Hamdi from 1972 to 1979.

The Arabic *Maqam*

Arabic music is founded on a centuries-old melodic framework called the Arabic *maqam* (pronounced “ma-QAHM”). In short, the Arabic *maqam* is a system of scales, habitual melodic phrases, modulation possibilities, ornamentation norms, and aesthetic conventions that together form a very rich artistic tradition. The *maqam* is used both in composed and improvised music and can be performed as either vocal or instrumental music. Although *maqam* music is very rich in rhythms, the Arabic *maqam* does not define a rhythmic component as such.

The word *maqam* (pl. *maqamat*) in Arabic means place or position and shares its root with the verb *aqama* (to dwell/to reside). It came to be used in its current musical context probably because each *maqam* is based on a hand position and is the place where the melody occurs. Other words are used for *maqam* in the Arab world, such as *nagham* (melody) in Syria and *tabʿ* (character or nature) in Tunisia. Over time the word *maqam* acquired a second and related meaning; it is used to describe the entire *maqam* system used to build Arabic music and the general melodic and modal approach to music that is fundamental to this system.

The Arabic *maqam* broadly fits the description of a “melodic mode,” which is why the word *maqam* is sometimes translated that way in English. However, this translation is not precise because the word “mode” in Western music is also used in a simpler context to mean a scale or a set of tonal intervals (e.g., the major and minor modes). For this reason, this book uses the Arabic word *maqam* rather than an English translation.

Given the geographical span of the Arab world, many regional Arabic *maqam* systems exist, each with its own history, aesthetics, forms, naming conventions, and individual character. *Maqamat* prevalent in North African Arab countries (Morocco, Algeria, and Tunisia), for example, are different than *maqamat* in the central part of the Arab world (Egypt to Syria), and these are quite different than the Iraqi *Maqam*, which has a lot more in common with the Persian *dastgah*. Thus, there isn’t a single Arabic *maqam*, but rather several regional Arabic *maqamat*.

This book primarily focuses on the *sharqi* Arabic *maqam* tradition that flourished in the Near East/Eastern Mediterranean (from Cairo to Aleppo) during the early to middle 20th century. This regional tradition is the most well-known among local Arabic *maqam* traditions and is sometimes incorrectly assumed to be the only Arabic *Maqam* tradition (and however unfair that may be, it is nonetheless the focus of this book).

The Wider *Maqam* Phenomenon

The Arabic *maqam* tradition is part of a wider phenomenon that is prevalent in the music of countries from North Africa all the way to Central Asia. These traditions include Byzantine music, the *makam* in Turkish music, the *dastgah* in Persian music, the *mugam* in Azerbaijani music, the *meqam* in Kurdish music, the *makam* in Assyrian music, the Shash Maqom in Tajik/Uzbek music, and the *mugam* in Uyghur music in China⁶. These traditions are all centuries old and have influenced one another to the extent that their geography and history have allowed.

Over the centuries, the Arabic *maqam* has given and taken a great deal of material from the two immediately neighboring local *maqam* traditions: earlier the Persian *dastgah* and later the Turkish *makam*. While these have been gradually changing over time, they have proven easier to standardize and document than Arabic music.⁷ One possible reason is that both traditions are rooted in a single country (Turkey and Iran, respectively), whereas Arabic music spans many countries, creating local *maqam* flavors in the same way that Arabic language has many dialects.

As most of the Arab world was part of the Ottoman Empire for four centuries, the influence of Ottoman Turkish *makam* on the Arabic *maqam* is stronger than any other. As a testament to this influence, Arab musicians still perform and compose music in Ottoman instrumental forms, such as the *sama'i*, *bashraf*, and *longa*, a century after the end of the Ottoman Empire.

The commonality between the Arabic *maqam* and its Turkish and Persian cousins goes beyond the modal approach to the music. Many of the commonly used Arabic *maqamat* (e.g., Bayati, Rast, Sikah, Hijaz, Nahawand, and 'Ajam) exist in some form in all three traditions, although they may not necessarily have the same exact names, intonation, or melodic pathways. The names of many Arabic *maqamat* can be traced to the Persian language: for example, Farahfaza (from Farah Faza); Suzidil, Dalanshin (from Dil Nishin); Suznak, Rast, Sikah (from Seh Gah); Bastanikar (from Basta Nigar); Jiharkah (from Chehar Gah); and Nairuz (from Nowruz). The reverse is also true, with Persian *gusheh* (scale fragment) names taken from Arabic, such as Hejaz (from Hijaz), Hosseyni (from Husayni), and Oshshagh (from 'Ushshaq). Similarly, many Arabic *maqam* names come from the Turkish *makam* system, such as Sultani Yakah and Buselik, while some Turkish *makam* names, for example, Hiçâz, Irak, Huseyni, Sünbüle, and Uşşak, trace their origins to Arabic.

⁶ The 2018 Maqom Art International Forum held in Shahrisabz, Uzbekistan included performers from Turkey, Uzbekistan, Azerbaijan, Tajikistan, and Turkmenistan, as well as from many Arab countries.

⁷ A very mixed blessing for those traditions, in our view.

Oral Transmission

Prior to the 20th century, music in the Arab world was preserved and transmitted orally (only lyrics were historically preserved in writing). Oral transmission of music fits within a broader framework of oral transmission of other cultural forms in the Arab world, including literature, poetry, and religious texts.

In music, oral transmission entails a student learning the fundamentals of music (a repertoire of pieces, instrumental or vocal technique, and music theory, either formal or informal) by ear—either on his or her own, through immersion in the musical culture and practice, or directly from a music teacher—over a period of many years, without the aid of music notation. During that process, the student is able to absorb many intricate performance details that are extremely difficult to notate, such as intonation, ornamentation, and phrasing. Thus, the student eventually inherits the body of knowledge and aesthetics (some local only to that region) available in his or her tradition.

The modern-day version of oral transmission is a hybrid approach in which a student takes lessons with a teacher, privately or within an established curriculum in a music conservatory, while also making use of notated music. Depending on how much the student relies on sheet music, the hybrid approach may come close to matching oral transmission's benefits, although today the reliance on memory is declining, and most contemporary musicians don't have as prodigious memories as their forebears.

One interesting feature of oral transmission is that some compositions mutate over time into slightly different versions. This multiplicity of versions happens most often with *muwashshahat* (a classical vocal form), which were passed on orally before the advent of music notation or recording in the early 20th century. Information that is retained and transmitted by human memory among large numbers of people over long periods of time is prone to change. Culturally, these differences in versions are not seen as a flaw, but are accepted as contributions to the richness of Arabic music.

A Vocal Tradition

Arabic music is overwhelmingly vocal. Indeed, a live performance is synonymous with a vocal performance, and *tarab* (the type of musical pleasure that is particular to Arabic music) is embodied by the presence of a *mutrib/mutriba* (literally, “the person who creates/conveys *tarab*”). Although performances on traditional Arabic instruments like the *‘ud*, violin, *qanun*, or *nay* can produce much *tarab*, no instrumentalist, no matter how virtuosic, is ever called a *mutrib*. For this reason, entirely instrumental Arabic music recordings are very rare, unlike other musical traditions

such as jazz or classical, in which a sizable share of recordings and performances is instrumental.

The vocal quality permeates many aspects of Arabic music, such as the traditional instruments' tonal range to their dynamic range (volume). Traditional phrasing, even when used in instrumental compositions, mimics the possibilities of the human voice and usually stays within a *jins* (a 3- to 5-note *maqam* scale fragment), avoiding large jumps. This can be clearly seen⁸ in the *taqsim* (traditional instrumental improvisations) performed on the 'ud by, for example, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Riyad al-Sunbati, Sayed Makkawi, Muhammad al-Qasabgi, and Wadih al-Safi.

While Arabic music includes many instrumental forms like the *taqsim*, the *dulab*, the *muqaddima*, and the *maqtu'a* (as well as the borrowed Ottoman instrumental forms *sama'i*, *bashraf*, and *longa*), they rarely constitute a performance by themselves; instead they serve to complement the vocal pieces, which are the meat of any *wasla* (suite) or concert.

A Communal Character

Traditional Arabic music has a communal character. It sounds best when performed in a live setting for a relatively small, attentive, experienced, and responsive audience. The ideal setting for traditional Arabic music is a *jalsa* (a sit-down gathering), which consists of half a dozen musicians in a large room or small hall with an audience numbering in the dozens. In such a setting, musicians can play acoustically and still hear themselves and each other and be heard by the audience.

Arabic music sounds much better when the musicians can see and hear their listeners well. For this reason, recording Arabic music in a studio⁹ is challenging, and even the best studio recordings lack a certain warmth felt by musicians when they are encouraged by their audience. This is because recording separates the musician from his or her audience, interrupting a connection called "audience feedback," which is indispensable for the artist's creative process.¹⁰ Only live concert recordings capture the full potential of Arabic music, especially when improvisations are involved. Understandably, there is a difference between improvising for a microphone and a sound engineer and improvising for an experienced, attentive, and ecstatic crowd expressing a reaction after every little musical feat. As such, the audience plays an essential role in Arabic music making.

⁸ El-Mallah (1997, p. 24).

⁹ Racy (2003) covers in depth the issue of reaching and conveying *tarab* in a studio without any listeners present.

¹⁰ Racy (1978).

Experienced listeners are called *sammi'a* (literally, “people who listen attentively”). The *sammi'* is any person who enjoys Arabic music and has heard it for many years, to the point that he or she knows a decent chunk of a favorite repertoire by heart and has a clear expectation of what good Arabic music should sound like.

The *sammi'a* have one musical mission, to seek *tarab* (musical joy). In a concert, they are the ones who follow a *taqsim* (traditional instrumental improvisation) like hawks, note for note, and exclaim “Allah!” when an interesting modulation takes place. Each *sammi'* feels like the musician is performing for him or her, and therefore the *sammi'a* feel that they have a right to respond personally and loudly to the performer. But their input is far from disruptive; it is what fuels the performer to excel.

The *sammi'a* can be appreciative of a phrase or section even when it's not improvised. In that case, a beautiful delivery or ornamentation can move the eager listeners. Many long songs have short composed solo lines, especially during a long instrumental introduction. These lines can be on the violin, the *qanun*, the electric guitar, or any instrument appropriate for a solo. Umm Kulthum's violinist Ahmad al-Hifnawi and her *qanun* player Muhammad Abdo Saleh often get applause for their composed short solo lines, even when they repeat them two or three times.

Listening and Readiness

Traditional Arabic music is improvisational and highly personalized. Although improvisation has been slowly disappearing from mainstream Arabic pop music in the late 20th and early 21st centuries, when discussing Arabic music, this book's emphasis is on the mid-20th-century period or the Golden Age, when music was ripe with both vocal and instrumental improvisations. The abundance of improvisation keeps the music from sounding too rigid and makes it much more personal. The effect of improvisation is to constantly assert the presence of the performer and the essential relationship between him or her and the listener.

Because of its richness in ornamentation, Arabic music is not required to faithfully follow a composition note for note and can therefore be highly personalized. Heterophony (when different musicians simultaneously ornament the same melody differently) is a dynamic exercise, one that cannot be composed or notated. It happens in a live performance and needs a type of musician who devotes more energy to listening than to reading sheet music. Therefore, experienced Arabic musicians develop a resilient disposition that allows them to be attentive and quick to react to the other musicians' playing.

In a well-oiled ensemble, a singer and an attentive audience feed off each other, and the musical tradition affords performers a fair amount of room (as far as the

official musical composition/score is concerned) to interpret pieces according to the mood of the performance. Singers in Arabic music are given a relatively wide license to repeat sections or to insert a short *mawwal* (traditional vocal improvisation) at convenient junctures in a long song. Although these additions may be planned, often they depend on the mood of the performer and that of the audience; therefore, they can be unpredictable and require the ensemble to be ready to act on short notice.

In a bootleg recording of the long song “*hayyarti albi ma’ak*,” recorded live at the Azbakiyya Gardens in Cairo, singer Umm Kulthum skipped a beat and started the vocal line “*hayyarti . . .*” a quarter note too early. It took the orchestra—made up of dozens of musicians—less than a measure to follow her and shift the entire performance to her timing. Without an ensemble that is ready, a conductor, no matter how capable and alert, could not have achieved that rapid adaptation. And this is not something that the ensemble could have done either had its members all been busy reading the song’s musical score or watching the conductor. That formidable group reflex only succeeded because every individual musician was independently listening carefully, ready to react.

The benefit of such readiness is not only the ability to cope with mistakes; these are a rare occurrence. The real benefit is that the music that results is less rigid, and the ensemble moves together, constantly adjusting and adapting to its members and to the singer. It is a continuous negotiation, a live exercise in consensus building.

One downside of this spontaneous aspect of Arabic music is that it doesn’t easily lend itself to being recorded using overdubbing (a recording technique in which different instruments are recorded at different times, then later mixed together). Overdubbing Arabic music takes away the ability of musicians to tailor their playing (speed, dynamics, level of ornamentation, and especially solos) to each other in real time. Unfortunately, today Arabic music is losing its spontaneous quality due to modern studio recording techniques, and rigidity can be heard in most contemporary Arabic recordings.

Standards of Formality

To a Western observer, Arabic music may appear “informal” in many respects: musicians vary the composition with each performance, sometimes even simultaneously; audience members react vocally—sometimes loudly—to things they like in the music; and music is transmitted orally, with variation in versions and the addition of individual or regional characteristics.

While these aspects of Arabic music (and others discussed here) may appear to be *informal* compared with Western classical music, it is important to recognize that in

reality, they reflect different standards of formality than Western music does—and Arabic music adheres as closely to its standards as Western music does to its own.

As an example, one very obvious area in which the standard in Arabic music is far stricter than in Western music is intonation. In Western music, numerous compromises exist in intonation because of the development of harmony (see chapter 11: Tuning System), and as a result the intonation of performers tends to be fuzzier and less precise than it is in Arabic music. There is a greater tolerance for imprecise intonation in Western music than in Arabic music, even among the ranks of the top professional classical musicians (though this tolerance is rarely explicitly perceived by musicians or audiences, as glaring as it may appear to experienced Arab musicians and listeners). In Arabic music, because the slightest difference in intonation can suggest an entirely different *maqam* (there are so many different notes identified in between the notes of the Western equal-tempered scale), and because there is no harmony to confuse matters, the standard for intonation is much more stringent. Thus, we could say that Western music is *more informal* than Arabic music in terms of intonation—or we could say that the two traditions have different standards of formality.

Another example of apparently “greater formality” in Arabic music has to do with improvisation. In a traditional improvisation, the opening and closing phrases are more or less completely set by tradition for each *maqam* and are completely familiar to audiences, who expect to hear certain melodies (albeit with ornaments and variations) open an improvisation in a given *maqam*. There is room for a great deal of unique variation in the middle of the performance, but the ending is also standard. This type of formality doesn’t exist in Western improvisation today, and not enough is known about improvisation in the time of, for example, Mozart to know whether there was that level of formalism in the past.¹¹

There are also numerous ways in which Arabic music doesn’t adhere to Western standards of formality. The main priority of Arabic music is to create *tarab* and to please and entertain the audience. For this reason, the protocols governing the audience’s behavior during a live concert are informal and more accommodating than in Western classical music. In live recordings with large orchestras and iconic singers such as Umm Kulthum, Warda, or Abdel Halim Hafez, the cheering of the audience could stop a new section halfway and force the orchestra to restart the previous section, which the audience enjoyed greatly and didn’t get enough of. In one video recording of an Umm Kulthum concert, the last song had actually ended and the curtains were closed, but the audience started screaming “*iftah! iftah!*” (Open!

¹¹ Though we suspect, based on Gjerdingen’s (2007) work on Galant-period musical schema, that improvisation was more constrained at that time.

Open!), after which the curtain was reopened and the orchestra started playing the entire last song over again, starting from the introduction. We know that this type of thing used to occur in Western music in the time of Beethoven, for example, but it no longer happens today.

Musical transmission (oral or notated) is another area of Arabic music with different standards than Western music. A composed piece can be transcribed and/or performed multiple times and can include minor variations from the original with every adoption by a different musician. This is because most compositions from the 20th century were recorded but never had their official musical scores published. Subsequent versions would simply transcribe them from the recording, which is an imprecise process, and then a new performance would add another layer of personalization on top of that. Such minor discrepancies between originals and their cover versions can be seen in works like, for example, the *dawr* “*inta fahim*,” recorded by both its composer Zakariyya Ahmad and the Lebanese singer Su’ad Muhammad (1926–2011); the long song “*lis-sabri hudud*,” recorded by both its composer Muhammad al-Mougi and the singer Umm Kulthum; or the *qasida* “*ya jarat (garat) al-wadi*,” recorded by both Muhammad Abdel Wahab and Lebanese singer Nour al-Hoda (born Alexandra Badran, 1924–1998). Instead of viewing these discrepancies as a weakness, Arabic musicians and audiences are very accommodating about these differences and prefer that their favorite songs come in many recorded versions that do not match note for note, as this adds to the richness of the repertoire.

A video recording of an Umm Kulthum concert illustrates this point. As the diva was performing the long song “*ba’id ‘annak*,” she stopped singing after the phrase “*tiftikirli lahza hilwa*” and did a long *tafrid* (a repetition of one or more phrases on a slightly improvised melody), then started the next verse with a different melody, in Jins Nahawand instead of Jins Nikriz (while maintaining the same lyrics and rhythm). The alternative melody was a sort of counterpoint to the original melody. The informality of the compositional structure of the music (and arguably, her incomparable clout) afforded her the opportunity of searching for *tarab* by changing a composed section. Her orchestra, which was extremely well trained to listen and adapt, continued playing the new melody without any apparent difficulty.

Perhaps the best example of “informality” in Arabic music is heterophony, in which, to the uninitiated listener, the music may appear to be messy or disorganized, with every musician playing a slightly different version of the same melody. This could sound very disconcerting to a listener who comes from a musical tradition that values precise unison above all. But in Arabic music, precise unison (military style) is not the goal, and the informal approach to unison leaves a lot of room for interpretation and ornamentation, which in turn produces richer Arabic music.

1

MELODIC INSTRUMENTS

ARABIC MUSIC IS performed on a wide variety of instruments, some traditional (see figure 1.1) and some more recently adopted. While they can be classified, according to the Western scheme, as string, woodwind, brass, and percussion instruments (or, alternatively, as idiophones, membranophones, chordophones, and aerophones), these classifications are not the most useful in practice because they do not reflect how instruments are used within Arabic music. Instead, Arabic musical instruments are organized in this book based on their roles as melodic and percussion (rhythm) instruments. Within the melodic family, they are further divided into sustaining and percussive (not to be confused with percussion) instruments based on the way they create sound. This chapter also discusses in depth how precisely melodic instruments can perform the Arabic *maqam* scale intonation (see chapter 11: Tuning System), ranging from the most precise to the least precise.

The Two Clans: Melodic and Percussion

The classification of a melodic versus a percussion instrument is the most basic one in Arabic music, and it spills over to the designation of musicians who play these instruments. Melodic instrumentalists and percussionists belong to two broad clans or subcultures. Many melodic instrumentalists learn and master several melodic



FIGURE 1.1 A collection of traditional Arabic instruments, including an 'ud, a qanun, a violin, a set of nayat, a buzug, and a riqq. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

instruments before even considering learning a percussion instrument, and very few among them master a percussion instrument. Similarly, accomplished percussionists can master several percussion instruments before venturing into the melodic instrument world, and very few master a melodic instrument. Musicians who can master both worlds are a very small minority, and as a result they possess a broader understanding of Arabic music performance.

Aside from the acoustic and technical differences present in the two instrument families, they also demand different roles from their performers. Percussionists express rhythm and manage the speed and liveliness of a piece by listening to the melodic players and the singer and acting as the arbiter. They also play a principal role in signaling upcoming rhythmic, tempo, or dynamics changes to the ensemble. In practice, they more or less play the role of conductor, depending on the type and size of an ensemble. On the other hand, although musicians in both instrumental families

can deliver a virtuosic and masterful performance, *tarab* (enchantment) as a feeling or state of mind comes principally from melodic instruments. A beautiful *riqq* filling or *tabla* solo can entertain, thrill, and engage the audience, but *tarab* implies melodic/modal enchantment and relies first and foremost on delivering a beautiful *maqam* performance. Percussion instruments certainly contribute a great deal to *tarab*, but they do it indirectly, by supporting melodic instrumentalists and singers.

The Melodic Families: *Sahb* and *Naqr*

The most common and useful classification of Arabic melodic instruments is based on the way they articulate sound. The *sahb* (“pulling” in Arabic) family consists of sustaining instruments like wind instruments or bowed string instruments. The violin, the cello, and the *nay* are examples of *sahb* instruments used in the Arabic ensemble. The *naqr* (“tapping” in Arabic) family consists of “percussive” melodic instruments, such as plucked or hammered string instruments, which produce brief and accented notes. The *‘ud*, the *qanun*, and the *buzuq* are examples of *naqr* instruments. Instruments such as the double bass and the cello can join either family, depending on whether they are bowed or plucked during a performance.

Naqr-family melodic instruments, especially ones that include a lower register (such as the *‘ud*, the plucked cello, and the plucked double bass) contribute to supporting percussion instruments and accenting the rhythm, especially the *dum* notes.

Each family offers very different ornamentation possibilities. Sustaining melodic instruments lend themselves more to vibratos, glissandos, slurs, tremolos, and pitch bending, while percussive melodic instruments lend themselves to trills, tremolos, and occasional harmony, chords, and arpeggios. Because of their differences, the two groups create a simple division of labor in which percussive instruments accent the rhythm while sustaining instruments maintain and prolong the intonation. A well-balanced ensemble includes instruments from both families in order to leverage the full range of possible ornamentations. This is a long-standing practice in Arabic music, understood for more than a millennium. The *takht*, the core ensemble of traditional instrumentalists most popular in Egypt and Syria at the turn of the 20th century, still sets the standard for ensemble design for many contemporary groups, as it is perfectly balanced between *sahb* and *naqr* instruments, as well as in register, by including the *‘ud* and the *qanun* on the one hand and the violin and the *nay* on the other.

When combining a sustaining and a percussive instrument to form a duet, the *‘ud* with the violin or the *qanun* with the *nay* are very popular pairings that are compatible as far as timbre and tonal range. The human voice is very much a sustaining

TABLE 1.1

Comparison of Instruments Used in Arabic Music Based on Intonation Precision			
High (Continuous Tunability)	High (with More Effort)	Fair (Selective 24-Tone ET*)	Low (12-Tone ET)
Voice	<i>Qanun</i>	Arabic accordion	Piano
‘ <i>Ud</i>	<i>Nay</i>	Arabic keyboard	Electric piano
Violin	<i>Buzuq</i>	<i>Org</i>	Acoustic guitar
Cello	Arabic trumpet	Arabic piano	Electric guitar
Double bass	Arabic saxophone		Electric bass guitar

* Equal-tempered tuning (see chapter 11: Tuning System in this volume).

instrument, which is why pairing it with the percussive ‘*ud* or *qanun* works a lot better than pairing it with the sustaining violin or *nay*.

Intonation Precision

Another criterion used to classify Arabic melodic instruments is how accurately they can perform the Arabic microtonal *maqam* scales. Table 1.1 displays all these possible intonation abilities side by side and ranks instruments from most precise to least precise.

On the finer end of the spectrum are the human voice, the ‘*ud*, the violin, and the *nay*. Other fretless instruments in the violin family (the viola, the cello, and the double bass) are equally capable of delivering precise intonation. The *qanun* and the *buzuq* come close but are not as accurate as the ‘*ud* and violin.

The Arabic trumpet, the Arabic saxophone, and the clarinet allow varying degrees of pitch bending and can do a better job at rendering the microtonal Arabic scale than 24-tone equal-tempered instruments.

While electronic keyboards come preprogrammed with an equal-tempered scale (including quartertones), some keyboards allow a very fine pitch alteration of any given note (usually down to 1 percent of a semitone). Although such a feature makes it possible to preprogram one completely accurate Arabic *maqam* scale, as soon as a modulation or transposition is attempted the next *maqam* scale may not be as accurate. For this reason, such features are not very useful in practice, and keyboards are most commonly used with their equal-tempered programming unchanged.

In the bottom half of the tonal precision spectrum are the hybrids. Rigid 24-tone equal-tempered instruments divide the Arabic microtonal scale into 24 equal parts per octave, each part equaling a theoretical quartertone (50 cents, or half a semitone). These include the Arabic accordion, the *org* (Arabic electric organ of the 1960s), and the (mostly experimental) Arabic pianos that were mechanically altered to produce some quartertones.

On the coarsest end of the spectrum are the rigid 12-tone equal-tempered instruments. These are the purely Western instruments like the acoustic piano, electric piano, acoustic guitar, electric guitar, and electric bass guitar.

Traditional Arabic Instruments

Traditional Arabic musical instruments are numerous and diverse. This section focuses on the four main instruments used in the traditional urban Arabic music chamber ensemble, called the *takht* (originally from Persian, literally a throne, bed, or raised platform that musicians sit on during a live performance, later used to refer to the ensemble itself). The standard *takht*, which was popular late in the 19th century and in the first half of the 20th century, consists of four melodic instruments—the ‘*ud*, the violin, the *nay*, the *qanun*—and one percussion instrument, the *riqq*. The *takht* instruments are the cornerstones of any Arabic ensemble, small or large, and give Arabic music its distinctive and recognizable “sound.” In addition, this section covers one traditional/folk Arabic instrument in detail: the *buzuq*.

THE ‘UD

The ‘*ud* (also transliterated as “oud”) is a fretless short-necked lute and the undisputed king of Arabic musical instruments. (See figure 1.2.) The word ‘*ud* in Arabic means “a thin strip of wood,” and some references say it acquired this name because of the ribs used to build its rounded, pear-shaped sound box, while others say it was probably given to it because of its wooden soundboard that replaced natural skin on older versions of the instruments like the Persian *barbat* (literally, “duck skin”). One thing is for certain: the name ‘*ud* continues to live in this instrument’s European descendants such as the lute (from “*al-‘ud*”) and the Greek *lauto*. Regional varieties of the ‘*ud* also exist in Turkey, Greece, and Iran, although ‘*ud*-s made in each region (including different regions within the Arab world) have their own technical peculiarities, ornamentation aesthetics, and recognizable timbre.

The ‘*ud*’s body is pear shaped and is often intricately decorated or inlaid with wood or mother of pearl. The neck of the ‘*ud*, which is short in comparison to the



FIGURE 1.2 Two Arabic 'ud-s, made by Nahat brothers, Damascus, 1902 (right) and Muhammad Fadil Husayn, Baghdad, 1975 (left). Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

body, has no frets; this contributes to its mellow and warm timbre compared to fretted string instruments.

Historically, 'ud strings used to be made of animal gut, while modern 'ud strings may be made of nylon or steel, and some are made of a silk core with copper or silver-plated copper wire wound around it. 'Ud strings are typically plucked rather than played directly with the fingers. Historically, 'ud players used a sharpened eagle quill,

giving the plectrum its Arabic name *risha* (literally, “feather”). Today eagle quills are rare, and most musicians use shaved animal horn, tortoise shell, or plastic.

Until the beginning of the 20th century, ‘*ud*-s commonly had five double courses of strings, tuned to a low G followed by series of ascending just fourths, starting a step higher with A, then D, G, and C.¹ During the 20th century, a sixth course became normal, and today the most common ‘*ud* tuning is C₂, F₂, A₂, D₃, G₃, and C₄, although F₂, A₂, D₃, G₃, C₄, and F₄ is also popular in Egypt. Some ‘*ud*-s today have seven² courses by combining the two previous combinations (going from C₂ to F₄). As such, all open string intervals except for F₂-A₂ are just fourths.

Unfortunately, because tuning successive strings in just fourths is time consuming and error prone, many ‘*ud* players take a shortcut and use an electronic tuner to tune all their ‘*ud* strings to a 12-tone equal-tempered (piano) tuning. This takes the ‘*ud* further away from being able to accurately perform the Arabic scale, but has one redeeming advantage: it brings its tuning closer to modern members of the Arabic ensemble like the accordion, *org*, and electric guitar, which are all 24-tone equal-tempered instruments (see the discussion in chapter 11: Tuning System on the importance of these distinctions).

Being a fretless instrument, the ‘*ud* has very few constraints standing in the way of complete pitch control. Having said that, the one main constraint is that open strings have fixed tuning, which makes some *maqam* transpositions on the ‘*ud* quite challenging. For example, transposing Maqam Rast from C to B $\flat$ or from C to C $\sharp$ would be hard. Instead, a common strategy is to retune the ‘*ud* to accommodate difficult transpositions.

The ‘*ud* is a hugely popular instrument, for many good reasons. First, it works very well with either vocal or instrumental music. It sounds good in an ensemble because, as a percussive melodic instrument, it conveys the melody while also marking the rhythm. The ‘*ud* sounds equally good as a solo instrument, and ‘*ud taqsim* recordings are more popular and available than those on any other instrument. In addition, it sounds good with voice because it can match its intonation precision and doesn’t overshadow it with a loud volume.

The ‘*ud* is also the ideal instrument ergonomically for a singer to accompany himself or herself while singing (the *nay* would be impossible, the violin impractical, and the *qanun* too cumbersome). Finally, its wide tonal range of over three octaves makes it a very versatile tool for composers because it is wider than the human voice range at both the lower and higher ends. Indeed, most composers prefer to compose their melodies on the ‘*ud*. This was certainly the case for composers like Muhammad

¹ Marcus (2015a, p. 286).

² An ‘*ud* fitted with seven strings is called ‘*ud sab’awi* (derived from *sab’a*, the number seven).

al-Qasabgi, Riyad al-Sunbati, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Muhammad al-Mougi, and Baligh Hamdi, who were all excellent *‘ud* players.

Many vocalists accompany themselves on the *‘ud* across the Arab world, and voice plus *‘ud* is a common practice for very intimate performances. Many of the most famous singers/composers, historically as well as in modern times, have been proficient *‘ud* players, including Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Zakariyya Ahmad, Sayed Makkawi (1927–1997), Sheikh Imam, and Wadih al-Safi. Farid al-Atrash, in addition to being a prominent singer, composer, and actor, was also a renowned *‘ud* master. He was called *malik al-‘ud* (The King of *‘Ud*) for his sheer technique, for his innovative style, and for bringing his flamboyant *‘ud* solos to a wide audience.

For all the stated reasons, the *‘ud* has become the standard Arabic instrument, much like the guitar in American blues, folk, and rock and roll music, or the piano in classical music: the one instrument an ensemble can’t do without.

The most influential *‘ud* players in the 20th century were Muhammad al-Qasabgi (Egypt, 1892–1966), Riyad al-Sunbati (Egypt, 1906–1981), Farid al-Atrash (Syria, 1915–1974), George Michel (Egypt, 1917–1998), Gomaa Muhammad ‘Ali (Egypt, 1924–1975), Munir Bashir (Iraq, 1930–1997), Saïd Chraïbi (Morocco, 1951–2016), Simon Shaheen (Palestine, b. 1955), Amer Ammouri (Syria, b. 1961), and Naseer Shamma (Iraq, b. 1963).

THE *QANUN*

The *qanun* is a plucked trapezoidal zither consisting of approximately 78 to 81 strings stretched over a trapezoidal sounding board. (See figure 1.3.) The word *qanun* means “law” in Arabic, synonymous with the word *canon* in English and derived from *kanon* in Greek,³ and it was probably chosen because of the instrument’s loudness and consistency in imposing fixed pitches. The *qanun* occupies a principal role as a *naqr* instrument in the ensemble and is the favorite instrument to perform *tarjama* (accompaniment of a singer during a vocal improvisation) or to accent an *iqā‘* (rhythmic cycle) like Ciftetelli. The *qanun* is a historical relative of the Persian *santur*.

Today’s *qanun*-s consist of a wooden soundboard that is rectangular on the right side and trapezoidal on the left side. A long bridge on the right-hand side of the instrument rests on four or five rectangular windows covered with stretched goat, calf, or fish skin. The bridge carries the sound of the strings to the soundboard, and the animal skin increases their volume.

³ See Sawa (2018) for the history of the adoption of the *kanon* of Euclid and Ptolemy by al-Farabi and later medieval Arab musicians and scholars.

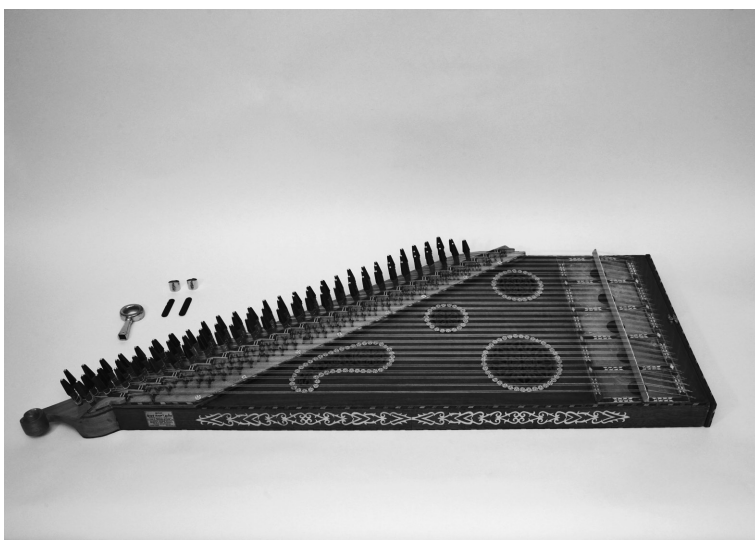


FIGURE 1.3 Arabic *qanun* made by Bashir Bij in Aleppo, Syria. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

Most *qanun* strings are stretched in groups of three identically tuned strings to a note (a few notes in the lower register have only two or a single string). This gives the *qanun* an impressive range of about three and a half octaves.

Using three strings to a note is what gives the *qanun* its loud, clear, and assured sound. The *qanun*'s strings are all open, which means they are able to ring freely and sustain their sound long after they are plucked (much like a piano with the sustain pedal permanently pressed). The exception to that is an ornamentation technique called *katm* (muting/muffling), in which the right thumb silences the ringing of a string shortly after it is plucked.

The instrument is placed flat on the knees or on a table in front of the musician. The strings are mainly plucked with thin plectrums made of animal horn that attach to the index fingers of both hands with metal rings, although the *qanun* player may sometimes pluck the strings directly with his or her fingers. Some *qanun* players use innovative plucking techniques that involve using multiple fingers on each hand in order to play some harmony or arpeggios, but these techniques are not considered part of the Arabic tradition.

On the left-hand side, each course of strings passes over a series of small brass levers that allow fine-tuning of each note by pressing a tiny metal bridge against each course of identical strings and very slightly shortening their length. The levers are called *urab* in Arabic (singular *urba*, meaning a slight lowering of the pitch) and are regularly lifted back and forth during a performance to make microtonal changes in pitch. *Qanun* levers are also called *mandals*, from the word *mandal* (the lever's name on a Turkish *kanun*—literally a latch). The number of levers per set of strings

varies with the quality of the *qanun* and the region where it is made. Arabic *qanun*-s usually have 5 to 9 levers per note, while Turkish *kanun*-s use anywhere from 12 to 17 levers per note, giving an even finer range of pitch control.

The levers are a relatively recent addition, as the pre-20th-century *qanun* did not have them and required the musician to retune the instrument's open strings to the exact scale of the song's *maqam*. Before the introduction of levers, major *maqam* changes required a retuning of some strings, while short *jins* or *maqam* modulations were dealt with using the *'afq* fingering technique (see later in the chapter).

Unlike a fretted string instrument, which has a fret for each semitone and some quartertones, the *qanun*'s main challenge is that it only includes seven notes per octave. To tune the *qanun*, the player sets all groups of levers to their midpoint and tunes the open strings to a major C scale. This is done with a fat tuning key made of aluminum that stays seated on one of the pegs during the entire performance. Tuning the *qanun* is by far the most tedious tuning job in an ensemble.

Before embarking on a particular *maqam*, the *qanun* player flicks the levers to slightly raise or lower the tuning of the open strings by up to a semitone. While that may make things easier if the melody is simply going up and down one *maqam* scale, that scale is very likely to change because of modulations. When players need to modulate to another *maqam*, they need to switch some levers back and forth with the left hand while playing with the right hand. The levers divide the semitone into multiple parts, and if sufficiently granular, they allow the player (with the flick of a switch) to alter the string's intonation by a fraction of a quartertone. Depending on the number of levers per group, this may or may not be as accurate as the *'ud*'s or violin's intonation. Dedicated *qanun* players may go so far as choosing the closest lever to their desired intonation, then fine-tuning the strings in question using the tuning key. This is obviously prohibitively difficult for a mere modulation, but can be done for long passages that stay in one *maqam*. The side effect is that modulations away from such a tuning may no longer have the most accurate pitch.

Quick modulations and accidentals can also be achieved by using the fingernail of the left thumb to press down on a string to temporarily raise its tuning. This technique, noted previously as being the original technique for modulations on the *qanun* before the introduction of *'urab*, is called *'afq* (pressing), and aside from allowing very fast changes in pitch, it adds a familiar slight buzz, which has become a trademark of *qanun taqasim*. The *'afq* technique today is as much an ornamentation technique as it is a pitch refinement technique, as it can be used to simply add accidentals to a melody.

In terms of ornaments, the *qanun* can add many accidentals and very easily play the melody doubled up with its lower octave. It can also add mini-harmonies (a brief

layering of thirds and fourths) and arpeggios to a melody for a little added Western color. The *qanun* can also do a very modest pitch bending that is limited in range (using fingering techniques), although such ornaments fall short of a true vibrato such as the one performed on the violin or the *'ud*. Overall the *qanun*'s sound is somewhat blunt and unwavering, since a given note will sound more or less the same during a piece even when plucked a thousand times. That, combined with the fact that most strings are in triplicates and are unmuted, is precisely what makes the *qanun* the authority on intonation.

Among the most memorable *qanun* players of the 20th century are Muhammad al-'Aqqad (Egypt, 1850–1931), Ibrahim al-'Aryan (Egypt, 1892–1953), Muhammad Abdo Saleh (Egypt, 1916–1970), Abdel Fattah al-Mansi (Egypt, 1924–1990), and Fihmi 'Awad (Egypt).

THE *NAY*

The *nay* (pl. *nayat*) is an end-blown reed flute, made of a reed that is open at both ends. (See figure 1.4.) It is a very old wind instrument whose name comes from the Persian word *ney* (meaning *reed*). It has existed in the Near East (the area from Egypt to Mesopotamia) in various forms for millennia and is by no means unique to Arabic music. Indeed, the *nay* is a principal instrument in both Turkish and Persian classical music, although each tradition uses slightly different manufacturing methods, playing techniques, and ornamentation aesthetics that set it apart. In much of the Middle East, the *nay* is used in folk genres as well as in more formal classical genres



FIGURE 1.4 A collection of seven Arabic *nayat* made by 'Atif Wehbi in Lebanon. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

and Sufi music. With its warm and breathy timbre, the *nay* is a staple of the *takht* and shares the job of the sustaining (*sabb*) instrument with the violin.

Although it looks very simple, the *nay* is one of the most difficult Arabic instruments to play and requires an intricate technique to master it. The *nay* has nine joints and is blown using a lip technique called bilabial blowing, in which both lips are used to partially close the end of the beveled tube opening. The *nay* has six holes in the front and one hole underneath for the thumb. The holes are closed with the pads of the fingers. Normally, the finger completely covers the hole, except when a technique called half-holing is used; in that case, the hole is only partially closed, which produces a note that falls in between the open and closed hole.

A well-constructed *nay* needs to be made of a reed of appropriate thickness, not too thick or too thin. A thick reed will allow for an easier and clearer tone on the low register at the cost of the higher register, and vice versa. Striking the right balance is the challenge of the *nay* maker. The *nay* must also be periodically oiled (preferably with almond oil) to prevent cracking and improve sound clarity, especially on the highest and lowest notes, which are the most difficult to produce.

Aside from changing the pitch by opening and closing the holes, the pitch is also manipulated by changing the blowing angle. Using a combination of half-holing and varying the blowing angle, a skilled *nay* player can produce continuous slurs or glissandos that span one or more semitones, or simply produce micro-tonal variations in order to adjust the pitch of certain notes in a *maqam* scale beyond the pitches designed for the hole positions. These techniques are very important, as they allow the *nay* player to accurately reproduce the Arabic *maqam* scale intonations.

As with most wind instruments, by increasing the blowing intensity, the player can produce notes that rise in pitch along the harmonic series, first generating an octave of the original note (2nd harmonic), then a fifth above the octave (3rd harmonic), then a double octave (4th harmonic). In practice, the 2nd harmonic falls in the middle of the *nay*'s range and is treated like the starting note, from which the player can go up by a fifth, then by a fourth, to the octave.

As a result, the *nay* is very well suited to playing the just fifths and fourths used in the Arabic tuning system and can be as precise as string instruments like the *'ud* and the violin, tuned in just fourths or fifths. This also gives the *nay* a range of over two octaves that can be covered using different hole-fingering techniques in conjunction with the previously described blowing techniques.

Nayat are made in different transpositions, by altering their length. Each *nay* is tuned to a specific pitch and is named after the note produced with the bottom hole open. A well-equipped *nayati* (*nay* player) will typically use a set of seven *nayat*, with

the Dukah (D) being the principal *nay*. The most common *nayat* are in the seven keys matching the notes of a major scale starting on C, and they carry the historic (archaic) Arabic note names listed in table 1.2 (see chapter 11: Tuning System for an explanation of the Arabic note names). A complete set of *nayat* is made of 12 *nayat*, one *nay* tuned to every semitone in the major scale starting on C, all the way to the small octave C *nay*.

In order to accommodate different *maqam* scales in different keys, *nay* players need to carry not one *nay* but several whenever they perform. Picking the right *nay* allows *nay* players to tackle transpositions; however, some *maqam* modulations remain challenging because players cannot change the *nay* for the sake of one phrase or a short passage.

While *nay* players have learned to accept the fact that the instrument cannot deliver some *maqam* modulations quickly, conveniently, and correctly in tune, that limitation nevertheless has an impact not only on the choices players make when improvising, but also on the way the *nay* is used/arranged in an ensemble.

Interestingly, the grouping of *ajnas* (*maqam* scale fragments) according to their size and the frequent modulation among members of the same *jins* group in Arabic music is very intuitive on the *nay*, because of its fingering (see chapter 13: The *Jins* for an explanation of the sizes and classification of *ajnas*). A given *nay* lends itself to easily producing the *ajnas* Bayati, Hijaz, and Kurd, for example, on the same tonic (usually the *nay*'s key, produced with the first finger hole open). It also lends itself equally well to producing the *ajnas* Rast and Nikriz, for example, on the same tonic (usually one tone below the *nay*'s key, produced with all finger holes closed.) Maqam Nahawand, however, is not played from the tonic with all fingers closed on the *nay*. This is because the *nay* would require a half-hole fingering for the flat 6th degree

TABLE 1.2

Most Common Seven <i>Nayat</i> , Named after Archaic (24-Tone Arabic Scale) Note That Matches Their Key	
<i>Nay</i>	Key
Rast	C
Dukah	D
Buselik	E
Jiharkah	F
Nawa	G
Husayni	A
‘Ajam	B♭

above this tonic note. Instead, Nahawand is played from the note a fourth above the *nay*'s tonic key.

One weakness of the *nay* is that it cannot be retuned once made, although good-quality *nayat* are already accurately tuned to their main key. However, that tuning rises slightly with temperature and humidity, for example after playing the *nay* for five minutes. This means that even with a set of good-quality *nayat*, the *nay* player may not be able to comfortably play the same pitches as on other instruments. Once again the *nay* must correct that drift in pitch using intricate blowing and fingering techniques.

Among the prominent *nay* players in the 20th century were Amin al-Buzari (Egypt, 1855–1935), who was credited with introducing the *nay* to the *takht* after it was mostly confined to the Sufi practice; Sayed Salem (Egypt, 1920–1995), who started playing in the Umm Kulthum orchestra in 1946 and remained in that position for decades; Mahmud ‘Iffat (Egypt, 1935–1994), who was the principal *nay* player in the Diamond Orchestra (accompanying Warda and Abdel Halim Hafez) and authored a book⁴ in Arabic called *Learning the Nay*; Samir Siblani (Lebanon, 1946–2017), who was a *nay* player and maker; and Ziyad Qadi Amin (Syria), one of the most important *nay* players and *nay* makers in Syria today.

THE ARABIC VIOLIN

The Arabic violin is a standard Western classical violin, albeit using a different tuning scheme. Relative to the age of Arabic music, the violin is a very recent instrument, adopted in the second half of the 19th and early 20th centuries, with the help of pioneer violinists like Ibrahim Sahlun, Antoun al-Shawwa, and his son Sami al-Shawwa (captured on numerous recordings in the first decades of the 20th century). During that period, European classical music had started making its mark in the Arab world (in 1869 a Western opera orchestra in residence was established in Cairo, which performed *Rigoletto* that year and commissioned Verdi's famous opera *Aida* in 1871).

In urban music ensembles, the violin replaced a variety of indigenous bowed string instruments, such as the *rababa* in Egypt and the Levant, the *kamanja* (a two-string bowed fiddle) in Egypt, and the *joza* (literally, “coconut,” the origin of the *joza*'s round body) in Iraq. While these instruments still exist today in their original form, they are mostly confined to folk music or local and regional genres of Arabic music (the *joza* is still used to perform the Iraqi Maqam). Throughout the 20th century, the sound of the Western violin became an inseparable part of Arabic music; it is a

⁴ ‘Iffat (1968).

principal instrument that can convey immense beauty with a highly precise intonation. The historic Arabic name *kamanja* (from Persian *kamancheh*, literally “little bow”) and its short version, *kaman*, are still used today for the Arabic violin, and the derived noun *kamanjati* is still used to designate a violinist.

It is worth mentioning that the European violin actually evolved from the Arab *rababa*, which was brought to Europe by troubadours through Spain, Italy, and southern France during the medieval period. The Europeans called this instrument the *rebec*, eventually developing it into the viol and finally the violin.

The violin is ubiquitous as the sustaining string instrument in the Arabic ensemble and orchestra. Unlike the other melodic instruments in the *takht*, the violin is extremely well suited to layering and can be used to create a large string section with a rich and powerful sound. Adding violins is the principal way to build a large orchestra, while using more than one ‘*ud*, *qanun*, or *nay* is much less common, except in student ensembles.

Arabic violin technique doesn’t differ substantially from Western classical technique in a general sense. However, particular styles of bowing and ornamentation have been developed for Arabic music, consistent with Arabic music in general and vocal music in particular. The Arabic violin is a very versatile instrument because it may be bowed or played in pizzicato style (plucking). In that case, it can be used to support a rhythm or add rhythmic accents to the arrangement. The violin can also be played using the double-stop technique (bowing two strings at once). Most often one open string is used as a drone, and the other string is used to perform the melody.

Although various tunings are used with the Arabic violin, the one used by most Arabic violinists (as well as many Turkish violinists) is G₃, D₄, G₄, D₅, which is based on alternating fifths with a fourth. Some violinists, such as Sami al-Shawwa, Tawfiq al-Sabbagh, and a small number of contemporary players⁵ including Abdo Dagher, use the more archaic G₃, D₄, G₄, C₅ tuning, which is closer to the ‘*ud* tuning.

Similar to the ‘*ud*, its wide tonal range and dynamic range and its ability to deliver the finest intonation details make it a hugely popular instrument for *taqasim*. As far as executing the correct intonation, the violin does an excellent job, while sharing the same challenges as the ‘*ud* regarding the difficulty of some transpositions.

The remaining instruments in the violin family consist of the viola, the cello, and the upright (double) bass, and are commonly used in Arabic music. Being fretless instruments like the violin, they offer very accurate pitch control. In an Arabic ensemble, the double bass is usually plucked, but it can be bowed at times; the cello can be plucked as well as bowed, while the viola is usually bowed. None of these

⁵ Including one of this book’s coauthors, Sami Abu Shumays.



FIGURE 1.5 Two Lebanese *buzuq*-s. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

is commonly used to perform *taqasim*, except to some extent the cello. A large orchestra like the one used by Umm Kulthum in the 1950s and 1960s had multiple cellos, but usually only one double bass. The cello and bass play a dual role, as they are melodic instruments that can optionally participate in the rhythm section when plucked. This is especially true for the double bass, whose contribution to the rhythm by accenting the *dum* beats is as important as, if not more important than, its contribution to the melody.

Among the violinists who had a major impact on establishing the Arabic violin sound in the 20th century were Sami al-Shawwa (Syria, 1885–1965); Jamil ‘Uways (Syria, 1890–1955); Tawfiq al-Sabbagh (Syria, 1892–1964), who also wrote a book on Arabic music;⁶ Ahmad al-Hifnawi (Egypt, 1916–1990); Anwar Mansi (Egypt, d. 1961); Aboud Abdel Al (b. ‘Abd al-Rahman al-Jarshi,⁷ Palestine/Lebanon, 1925–2009); and the prolific, innovative, and self-taught Abdo Dagher (Egypt, b. 1936).

THE *BUZUQ*

The *buzuq* (also transliterated as *buzuk* or *bouzouk*) is primarily a folk instrument that is very popular in the Near East (Syria, Lebanon, Palestine, and Jordan). (See figure 1.5.) The *buzuq* has a half-pear-shaped body with a long fretted neck. Compared to the ‘*ud*, the *buzuq*’s body is smaller, while its neck is much longer. The

⁶ al-Sabbagh (1954).

⁷ Rima Jarshi, niece, personal communication with the author, 2017, Lebanon.

buzuq is a very close relative of the Turkish *saz*, the Greek *bouzouki*, and the Persian *tar*, and derives its name from the Turkish word *bozuk*, which means “irregular” or “faulty,” probably taken from the expression “*bozuk düzen*” (irregular tuning) used for Turkish *baglama*-s.

The *buzuq* is plucked with a plectrum that can be made of animal horn or plastic. Traditionally the *buzuq* had two courses of metal strings, a double (C₄) and a triple (G₃), although in the second half of the 20th century more strings were added in order to expand its range. The modern *buzuq* has three courses of double (or in some cases triple) strings, usually tuned as C₃, G₃, C₄, although custom-made *buzuq*-s could have one more courses of single or double strings in order to expand the lower range further. There is no standard tuning for a four-course *buzuq*, but one possible tuning is A₂, D₃, G₃, C₄.

Modern *buzuq*-s use two strips of three metallic tuning pegs, similar to the guitar. The metal strings combined with the metal pegs give the instrument a bright tonal quality. The *buzuq*'s neck is fretted with frets made of wound nylon string. This is a technique used in other neighboring instruments, such as the Persian *tar*. The nylon string is usually wound three times and becomes thick enough to serve as a fret (between 1 mm and 2 mm in diameter).

Frets fall on notes of the chromatic scale (a semitone apart) as well as on the most popular quartertones, such as the E $\flat$, A $\sharp$ and B $\sharp$ notes. The number of quartertone frets varies with the *buzuq*'s manufacturing, as some *buzuq*-s are richer in frets than others.

The *buzuq*'s frets can be fine-tuned by the player in order to better match the correct tunings of the microtonal Arabic *maqam* scales used. Fine-tuning a fret by sliding it a few millimeters before the start of a song certainly allows the *buzuq* to make needed modifications, but is somewhat limited compared to having a fretless neck, because frets cannot be adjusted during a performance, when some modulations or transpositions are required.

As a regular *buzuq* player, Fadi Bardawil elaborates on the impracticality of constantly moving frets to achieve the precise intonation: “The E $\flat$ (Sikah) fret in Maqam Rast (on C) has a slightly higher intonation than the E $\flat$ in Maqam Bayati (on D), but it's tedious to constantly move that fret back and forth. Since I play Maqam Bayati a lot more often than Rast, I mostly leave that fret in the Bayati position.”⁸

Some players may go to the trouble of installing additional frets in order to play more precisely *maqamat* such as Jiharkah, Hijaz, or Sikah Baladi without moving any frets. Such *buzuq*-s are able to come closer to fretless (continuous) intonation,

⁸ Personal communication with the author, 2016.

although there is a practical limit to how many additional frets can be installed on the neck before it becomes too cluttered to be playable.

In terms of ornaments, the *buzuq* can add a lot of accidentals, modest harmonies made of fourth or fifth intervals, and upward and downward glides along its long slim neck. But its strength lies in generously droning on the lower octave note on the bottom string, a style of ornamentation that has become its signature and one that is expected of every *buzuq* player.

With the ability for players to move frets and install more granular frets, the *buzuq* has an acceptable enough intonation to contend with the traditional instruments of the *takht*. This enables it to be used in classical ensembles and tackle repertoires with complex modulations, although when playing demanding pieces in the *sama'i* and *longa* instrumental forms, for example, it faces its next limitation, which is speed. The *buzuq*'s long neck was not designed for fast-paced melodies that span multiple octaves and cannot match the agility and nimbleness of the violin or the *'ud*. Instead, the *buzuq* was designed for folk music in which *maqam* modulations are few and the range of the melody is usually confined to one *jins* at a time.

While the *buzuq* was originally a folk instrument and is often associated with itinerant musicians, it crossed over in a huge way to more popular genres in the second half of the 20th century. Major singers from the Near East, such as Fairouz, Sabah, and Farid al-Atrash, used it extensively in their songs and often gave it short solos. As a testimony to its popularity, in the 1970s the *buzuq* was fitted with electric pickups very similar to the electric guitar or the electric Turkish *saz*, and that instrument left its mark on many songs from that period, such as "*hilwa bi shakl*" by Farid al-Atrash and "*allo bayrut*" and "*'al-basata*" by Lebanese diva Sabah.

The *buzuq* is also a very versatile solo instrument, and *buzuq taqsim* were brought into the mainstream through the recordings of the late composer and virtuoso Muhammad Abdel Karim (Syria, 1911–1989), dubbed "The Prince of the Buzuq"; Muhyiddin Baayoun (Lebanon, 1868–1934), who recorded many *taqsim mursala* (unmetered improvisations) on the *buzuq* and was also a composer and singer of *mawawil* and *qasa'id*, and last but not least, Matar Muhammad (Lebanon, 1939–1995), whose recording *A Tribute to the Master of the Buzuq*, released in 1996, took the *buzuq taqsim* to a whole new level of mastery that matches any *'ud* or violin *taqsim* in its complexity.

Folk Melodic Instruments

Many indigenous instruments are used in various traditions of folk music around the Arab world. While we don't explore those music traditions in the scope of this

book, they had, and still have, an influence on the music we do cover; the city and the countryside in Egypt, Lebanon, and Syria are very close to each other and have experienced a great deal of contact and migration over millennia.

Media in the 20th century increased the cross-fertilization of urban music with nearby folk repertoires. Folk musicians and folk songs were included in musical films produced initially in Cairo and eventually in Lebanon and other countries; folk instruments were brought as additional arrangement colors in larger Arab orchestras (as described for the *buzuq*); and recordings from the many different genres and repertoires across the region were shared among people from both the cities and the countryside.

As a result, it is equally common in Egypt to hear ensembles of *mizmar*-s or *rababa*-s covering songs written for Umm Kulthum or Abdel Halim Hafez as it is to hear folk-inspired melodies, played on folk instruments, soloing in the instrumental introductions to long-songs composed in the mid-20th century. The Oriental keyboard (the modern synthesizer modified to play Arabic scales, using Arabic instrument samples) typically includes many folk instrument samples, so one might hear the sound of the *mijwiz* or *arghul* in a nightclub in New Jersey or Miami, mixed in with melodies based on samples from the *qanun*, string section, organ, and more. Those with an interest in the music covered in this book are likely to run across those nearby folk traditions, instruments, and repertoires. So here we offer a brief sketch of instruments readers may encounter, with the caveat that they are more or less entirely outside our expertise.⁹

*Rababa*¹⁰ refers to a variety of bowed string instruments found across the Middle East. The two most common forms in Egypt and Greater Syria are the *rababa* from the Sa'id (upper Egypt) and the Bedouin *rababa*. The Sa'idi *rababa* is still commonly played in Egypt and has even been included in the 1993 French documentary film *Latcho Drom*. Metqal Qinawi, a famous *rababa* player and singer in the late 20th century, was an international star who traveled across Europe as well as the Middle East and was featured in film and television.

The *rababa* itself is built from a hollowed-out coconut shell, covered in fish skin (the ideal fish skin is an extremely thin and strong skin from the Red Sea fish known as the skate), with a metal spike through the middle, connecting the coconut-shell body with a carved, wooden dowel around two feet long and around one inch in diameter, which serves as the neck. It typically has two strings, both of which may be metal, or which may be made of tightly stretched horsehair. The bow is a flexible, curved stick stretched with horsehair. The *rababa*'s sound is intense and squeaky, and it can be heard from a surprisingly great distance outdoors, although it cannot compete with the *mizmar*.

⁹ Except for the Egyptian *rababa*, which coauthor Abu Shumays plays at a modest level.

¹⁰ Not to be confused with the Afghani *rabob*, which is plucked.

The Bedouin *rababa* looks completely different, with a large, rectangular wooden body covered in heavier animal skin. That instrument usually has only one string and commonly accompanies epic poetry with simple, repeating melodies; the improvised *qasida*, described in chapter 22: Vocal Improvisation, has been practiced by Bedouins across the Arab world for millennia (the poetic form was developed by nomads in the Arabian Peninsula).

Other bowed instruments one may encounter include the Iraqi *joza* (also spelled *jowza* or *djowza*), a very close cousin of the Sa'idi *rababa*, which uses a slightly shallower cross-section of the coconut (for a gentler sound), fitted with a skin made of the pericardial membrane of water buffalo, and four metal strings. The *joza* is also a part of the urban Iraqi Maqam tradition.

The *kawala* is a cane flute that is a cousin of the *nay*; the major difference is that it doesn't have a thumb hole in the back, and it is slightly wider in diameter than the *nay*, giving it a sweeter, mellower sound. Many *nay* players play the *kawala* as well and bring it into the Arab orchestra as an additional color.

The *arghul* is a folk wind instrument popular in Egypt and Palestine, made up of two pipes tied together. The shorter pipe has holes and is used for playing the melody, while the other one is longer (therefore in a lower register), has no holes, and is used to play the drone continuously.

The *mijwiz* (whose name literally means doubled, or made of a pair) is similar to the *arghul*, with two pipes, but both of its pipes have similarly cut holes and play the melody simultaneously (with the player's finger stretching across the holes in both pipes). The minuscule differences in pitch between the two pipes give the *mijwiz* a rich, buzzy sound, as well as additional volume. The *mijwiz* is popular in Palestine, Lebanon, Jordan, Syria, and Iraq.

The Egyptian *mizmar* (similar to the *zurna* in Turkey) is one of the loudest acoustic instruments ever invented by humankind. Sometimes referred to colloquially as the "Egyptian Oboe," the *mizmar* is a double-reed instrument with a flared wooden bell and finger holes like a *nay*. It has a very narrow range, and depending on how the holes are cut, its scale can feel a little dissonant, although typically it is based in the Maqam Rast scale like the *nay* and is able to play a few of the microtonal *ajnas* (Rast, Bayati, Saba, Sikah, Hijaz).

The *arghul*, *mijwiz*, and *mizmar* all have a limited scalar range and share fingering similar to the *nay*; the greatest differences among them have to do with blowing technique. But all three can be played with a circular-breathing technique.

2

ARABIZED INSTRUMENTS

A NON-ARABIC INSTRUMENT that has been modified to play additional notes from the Arabic tuning system is described as *sharqi* (Eastern) or *musharraq* (Easternized) in Arabic, derived from *al-sharq* (the East). The word “Oriental” is often used in English to market such instruments, especially when it comes to keyboards, but we use “Arabized” in this chapter to emphasize that they have been modified from their original design. Arabized instruments are either manufactured or modified to expand their playable pitches by including a limited number of notes outside their original scale. Equipped with these additional notes, an Arabized instrument can tackle the most common Arabic *maqam* scales.

Most Arabized instruments start off Western, which means they are originally based on the 12-tone equal-tempered scale. In general, added quartertones in Arabized instruments are typically positioned exactly halfway (50 cents away) from their surrounding semitones and usually span as many octaves as the instrument allows.

In some cases, however, original Western instruments such as the trumpet and the saxophone are used without any alteration to perform Arabic *maqam* scales. Ultimately, any original Western musical instrument that can be utilized to perform monophonic Arabic *maqam* music (with its traditional phrasing, ornamentation,

and *sayr*) can be called Arabized or Arabic. An example is the Arabic guitar, when used monophonically.

The Arabic accordion is a good example of a typical Arabized instrument. Specialized shops can take a standard accordion and make mechanical alterations to allow it to produce some quartertones on demand. More modern Arabized instruments such as the Oriental keyboard are built from the start to include quartertone capability, or even finer microtonality. These instruments can be qualified as *sharqi* (Eastern) or more simply Arabic.

On some instruments, such as a guitar fitted with additional frets, the additional notes (the quartertones) exist alongside the original Western scale notes and can be played seamlessly. On other instruments, such as the Arabic accordion or the Arabic keyboard, the quartertones must be activated by means of a switch or a mechanical lever (or the direction of squeezing the bellows of the accordion) that requires the musician to switch them on and off during a performance (there is usually one switch for each quartertone, activating all octaves of that quartertone together). On these instruments, the same key can be used to play either a semitone (when the switch is off) or a quartertone (when the switch is on).

While most Arabized instruments fall short of delivering precise Arabic *maqam* intonation, they are pragmatic and consistent and have the advantage of producing intonation that blends seamlessly with equal-tempered Western instruments.

The Selective 24-Tone ET Scale

The tuning system resulting from adding 50 cent quartertones to a 12-tone equal-tempered scale is called 24-tone equal temperament (24-tone ET for short) because the new scale is divided into 24 equal intervals called quartertones (see chapter 11: Tuning System).

The term 24-tone ET is used throughout this book with the understanding that not every note out of all 24 notes is available on every 24-tone ET instrument; rather, the available notes fall exactly on the 24-tone equal-tempered scale. Indeed, most Arabized instruments don't support every possible quartertone out of 24. For this reason, such scales are better called "selective 24-tone ET."

Selective 24-tone ET instruments offer one practical advantage: their intonation is consistent and can be achieved without effort. Taking the intonation worry out of performance is a welcome advantage, but comes at a cost: 24-tone ET instruments cannot faithfully render Arabic *maqam* scales because their "quartertones" fall exactly 50 cents away from surrounding equal-tempered semitones, rarely matching

the correct intonation of traditional Arabic *maqam* scales.¹ Even notes designated (and notated) as semitones in Arabic scales may not coincide precisely with equal-tempered semitones and therefore cannot be played faithfully on 24-tone ET instruments.

The most egregious example of incorrect intonation on an Arabized instrument is the “Piano Hijaz.” The interval between the 2nd and 3rd degrees in Jins Hijaz is notated as 1½ tones but is played as a slightly smaller interval in practice. On 24-tone ET (and 12-tone ET) instruments, however, that interval is exactly 1½ equal-tempered tones and sounds foreign to Arabic music (see chapter 14: The Most Common *Ajnas* for a discussion of Jins Hijaz).

The Arabic Accordion

The accordion was brought to Alexandria, Egypt, during the late 19th and early 20th centuries by the substantial European (Italian, French, and Greek) populations that lived there. It was initially used, without any alteration, alongside traditional Arabic instruments in the orchestra.

Lebanese/Syrian dancer Badi’a Masabni (1892–1974) recounts in a television interview² how she introduced Western instruments, among them the accordion, to the *raqs sharqi* Arabic orchestra in her Cairo dance club in the 1920s in order to diversify its sound, although these Western instruments were unable to play some Arabic *maqamat*.

One of the earliest recordings to feature the Arabic accordion is Muhammad Abdel Wahab’s monologue “*marreit ‘ala beit il-habayib*” (1932), in which it was used to play simple chords over a tango rhythm (but no quartertones). In the decades that followed, the accordion was mechanically altered to allow the most common quartertones in the Arabic *maqam* scales to be played. The partnership between the Arabic accordion and the *raqs sharqi* genre flourished through the 1950s, as black-and-white Egyptian films featured *raqs sharqi* dancers, and continues to this day. That is by no means the only genre that uses the Arabic accordion, as it is also very popular in the *baladi*, *sha’bi*, and *tarab* musical genres.

Today, the Arabic accordion is a very popular instrument in Arabic music, especially in Egypt. Indeed, the Arabic accordion has gone through the same

¹ At the 1932 Cairo Arabic Music Congress, attempts were made to determine whether Arabic scales could be played correctly using selective 24-tone ET, and the conclusion was that they could not (Maalouf, 2002).

² From a 1966 television interview with Badi’a Masabni by Leila Roustom on the show *Nugum ‘ala al-Ard* [Stars on Earth], Beirut (date unknown).

“naturalization” process as the Arabic violin, and today it is barely thought of as a foreign instrument.

Besides the 12-tone equal-tempered scale, the Arabic accordion can play some quartertones on demand. Although there is no one standard mechanical way to activate quartertones, it is usually achieved by controlling the direction of the bellows (compressing or expanding). While one direction plays the original equal-tempered notes, the opposite direction results in quartertones on some of the same keys (which direction results in quartertones depends on the accordion and may be different for different sections of the keyboard).

At a minimum, an Arabic accordion should produce the E♭, A♭, B♭, and F♯ notes, usually by using the E, A, B, and F keys. More elaborate Arabic accordions include more quartertones, for example C♯, which allows additional *maqam* transpositions.

The E♭, A♭, and B♭ notes offer the possibility of playing the Rast family of *maqamat* on C or G, the Bayati family of *maqamat* on D or A, and the Sikah family of *maqamat* on E♭ or B♭. C♯ and F♯ notes offer the possibility of additional transpositions. Like other selective 24-tone equal-tempered instruments, the accordion falls short when uncommon *maqam* modulations or transpositions are involved.

Even when considering *maqam* scales that it can play, the Arabic accordion cannot achieve the same precision in intonation as traditional Arabic instruments such as the ‘*ud* and the violin because of its rigid (equal-tempered) semitones and quartertones, which are characteristic of a 24-tone equal-tempered instrument. Despite that limitation, the accordion blends extremely well in the Arabic ensemble and makes up for its rigid intonation with its versatile ornamentation and soulful breathing technique.

Like the Arabic *org*, the Arabic accordion is played either as a melodic instrument or as a polyphonic (harmonic) instrument. Playing harmony or chords on the Arabic accordion is rare, and the vast majority of the time the accordion is used as a melodic instrument, which places it in the sustaining (*sabb*) camp alongside the violin and the *nay*. Aside from contributing to the melody in a song or instrumental piece, the Arabic accordion is also a very popular solo instrument, with its own ornamentation aesthetic.

An important pioneer of the Arabic accordion was the Egyptian Faruq Salama (b. 1935), who was credited with being the first accordionist to modify his instrument to accommodate “quartertones.” Salama was discovered by composer Baligh Hamdi, who was eager to include the accordion in the arrangement of one of his compositions for Umm Kulthum, after Muhammad Abdel Wahab had introduced the electric guitar into his own compositions. Salama’s first public appearance with Umm Kulthum’s orchestra was on “*siret il-hubb*” in 1964, which led to many subsequent appearances throughout the 1960s and 1970s. Salama’s most memorable Arabic

accordion solos can be heard in Umm Kulthum's 1972 long-song "*ya msabharu*" (by Sayed Makkawi) in Maqam Rast.

Another accordionist worth mentioning is 'Ammar al-Shari'i (Egypt, 1948–2012), who, in addition to composing countless film scores and songs, also hosted a popular radio show about Arabic music called "*ghawwas bi bahr al-nagham*" ("A Diver in the Sea of Tunes"—although the word *nagham* is also a synonym for *maqam*).

The Arabic *Org*

The Arabic *org*³ (from *orgue*, French for organ) is a transistor organ that became very popular in Arabic music from the late 1960s throughout the 1970s. The *org* arrived on the Arabic music scene in 1969 when it was first used in Umm Kulthum's song "*aqbala al-laylu*" and became a staple of al-Firqa al-Masiyya (The Diamond Orchestra), which was conducted by maestro Ahmad Fouad Hassan (Egypt, 1928–1993) and accompanied megastars such as Abdel Halim Hafez, Warda, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, and Sabah.

The Arabic *org* was amplified using an electric amplifier and was electronically altered and fitted with custom buttons to allowed it to play the E♭, A♭, and B♭ notes using the E, A, and B keys when the appropriate buttons were pressed. All octaves of the same note changed together. The three quartertones were by far the most popular and, barring any unusual transpositions, would allow the instrument to play the vast majority of *maqam* modulations. The organist could switch back and forth between the natural note and its "Arabic" version, which is a quartertone (a half-flat) lower. In that sense, the Arabic organist's job was very similar to that of a *qanun* player who gets busy with flicking mechanical levers during a performance in order to go back and forth between different *maqam* scale tunings. Both the *qanun* player and the organist use the left hand for that purpose, while the right hand maintains the melodic line, and when the left hand is free it may play a bass drone, the same melody one octave lower, or some simple chords.

The Arabic *org*'s tonal palette was innovative relative to traditional Arabic instruments of that period. Arrangements that used the *org* were typically large orchestras that already had every traditional Arabic instrument they desired and only needed the Arabic *org* to provide new and interesting sounds. The *org* typically contributed heavily sustaining synthetic string sounds. Less frequently, it also contributed space-age buzzing tones that showed a clear desire on behalf of

³ This book uses the spelling of *org* first used in Rasmussen (1996).

the arranger to take a daring step beyond the traditional Arabic orchestra sound. An example of that can be heard in Abdel Halim Hafez's "*qari'at al-finjan*" and Warda's "*uhdunu il-ayyam*."

The *org* was played in two possible styles: as a monophonic (melodic) instrument or as a polyphonic (harmonic) instrument. The melodic style turned the *org* into a sustaining (*sabb*) instrument and placed it in the same camp as the *nay* and violin. Playing melodic style was very well suited to single-line solos and to carrying the melody alongside the singer and other instruments. The harmonic style, on the other hand, could be used to play long chords to support a whole measure, allowing it to mimic a group of sustaining instruments (e.g., a string section). But the most common usage of chords was to play them staccato in order to accent the *dum*-s and the *tak*-s (or any 16th note) of the underlying *iqā'*, allowing the *org* to act as a percussive (*naqr*) instrument.

When playing chords, the *org* was mostly limited to simple 3-note major and minor chords and never included intervals with quartertones as part of the chords. Major and minor chords were played with *maqamat* whose 3rd degree falls on a minor third (e.g., Bayati, Saba, Nahawand, and Kurd) or a major third (e.g., 'Ajam, Hijaz, and Nikriz/Nawa Athar). Other *maqamat* whose 3rd scale degree is neither major nor minor (e.g., Rast or Sikah) were not usually accompanied with chords.

The credit for pioneering the Arabic *org* technique goes to Egyptian keyboard player Magdi al-Husseini (b. 1960), who despite his very young age, quickly became the most established Arabic *org* player. Husseini was a friend of guitarist Omar Khorshid (Egypt, 1945–1981) and introduced the use of the Arabic *org* during the same period that Khorshid pioneered the use of the electric guitar in the Arabic orchestra. Both musicians came from a rock and roll background and had a desire to bring their Western instruments to the Arabic song at a time when composers and arrangers had that same vision. But Husseini and Khorshid didn't play their instruments in the style of rock and roll; instead, they developed a playing technique and ornamentation aesthetic compatible with Arabic music, effectively transforming their instruments into Arabic instruments.

Today the *org* is a vintage instrument that is immortalized in the recordings of major singers of the Golden Age such as Abdel Halim Hafez, Warda, Umm Kulthum, and Farid al-Atrash, to name but a few. But the singer who used the *org* most prolifically and innovatively in his arrangements was Abdel Halim Hafez, especially in his masterpiece "*qari'at al-finjan*" (composed by Muhammad al-Mougi). The black-and-white video for this song features Magdi al-Husseini, with his characteristic youthful smile and 1970s bushy hair, alongside his fellow Egyptian keyboard player Hani Mehanna (b. 1947) on the second *org*.

The Arabic Keyboard

The Arabic keyboard (also called the Oriental keyboard) is the technological successor of the Arabic *org*. It gradually became popular from the 1980s onward. The Arabic keyboard is an electronic synthesizer/sampler that includes many new features and improvements over the *org*, such as digital sampling, touch-sensitive and velocity-sensitive keys, keyboard transposition, keyboard tuning, keyboard splitting, a sustain pedal, and a pitch bender. However, instead of the Arabic keyboard being on a continuous upgrade path from the *org*, its new features have made it a very different instrument.

While the motivation behind introducing the *org* was to add an original color and an innovative sound to the Arabic orchestra, the keyboard is mostly used with samples that closely imitate traditional acoustic instruments. A keyboard can bring the sampled sounds of a *qanun* or a *nay* to the keyboard player's fingertips. In addition, it can bring non-*takht* instruments that are relatively less available in an average ensemble, such as the trumpet, the saxophone, the *rababa*, the *kawala*, the *mizmar*, and the *mijwiz*, to a dance floor, a wedding party, or a studio recording session.

Most Arabic keyboards today also include very sophisticated electronic rhythm boxes fully equipped with the most popular Arabic *iqā'at*, complete with fills that can be thrown in at the push of a button, often with automatic bass lines and supporting chords. Some keyboard players use two keyboards, one devoted to playing only *iqā'at* and the other to melody. With such a rich feature list, the keyboard is by far the most versatile, practical, and powerful instrument in Arabic music today, especially in live settings (e.g., a wedding or a dance party), where the band may simply consist of a singer, a keyboard player, and a *tabla* or *tabl baladi* player.

Arabic keyboards are manufactured with Arabic scales in mind and have a set of 12 small buttons laid out like piano keys to allow lowering the tuning of any of the notes in its 12-tone equal-tempered scale by a quartertone (see figure 2.1). This means that Arabic keyboards are the perfect and probably only example of a full 24-tone equal-tempered instrument on which every equal-tempered quartertone is available at the push of a button. This, along with keyboard transposition features, enables playing any *maqam* modulation or transposition to any key, albeit with a rigid equal-tempered intonation.

Some keyboards also allow fine-tuning of every note in the equal-tempered scale down to the precision of 1 cent (1 percent of an equal-tempered semitone). This fine-tunability could certainly make the Arabic keyboard as precise as the *'ud* or the violin if it could be easily applied selectively to different notes during a performance, in the same way that a *qanun* player alters the tuning using mechanical switches.



FIGURE 2.1 A set of 12 buttons on a Ketron Vega Oriental keyboard that change the tuning of any note in the chromatic scale down by an equal-tempered quartertone.

Unfortunately, in most keyboards, fine-tuning is preset before a performance, making its usability very limited in practice.

While most Arabized instruments have an established ornamentation style and technique, using an Arabic keyboard with multiple acoustic instrument samples requires a number of different ornamentation styles and techniques. In that case the keyboard player has to wear many hats, one for each instrument sample, and ornament in a way consistent with the original sampled instrument. For example, samples from sustaining instruments such as wind instruments can be slurred and bent using the pitch bender, but cannot make use of the keyboard's polyphonic features, as the phrasing of the sampled instrument can only carry a single melodic line. On the other hand, samples of a *qanun* can make use of full polyphony (in which multiple notes slowly decay together). This is a very demanding skill, as the keyboard player might well have to be a virtual *qanun*, *nay*, and *mijwiz* player during the same performance. Some keyboard players don't try to imitate real acoustic instruments and use the samples in "unnatural" ways, pitch bending a *qanun* or a '*ud* sample, for example, in order to add a new color to their sound palette.

The Arabic keyboard is part of an arms race that has raised the volume requirement in the Arabic ensemble. The other contenders in that race are the electric bass guitar and the drum set. Today these three loud instruments often come together as a set, and instead of supporting traditional Arabic instruments, they dominate the

sound's foreground while delicate acoustic instruments such as the *'ud* and the *nay* are often only faintly heard in the background (if included at all). On the rhythm front, the same phenomenon occurs when a loud and intractable electronic rhythm (coming from an Oriental keyboard) drives the beat with samples from multiple percussion instruments, while the live *tabla*, *katim*, *daff*, or *riqq* plays a supporting role.

The Arabic Piano

The piano is no stranger to Arabic music, as it was used by Sayed Darwish as early as the 1920s for the orchestral arrangements of his operettas, some of which included polyphony and harmony.⁴ Umm Kulthum only used a piano in one song's arrangement, in the opening of her *qasida* "*araka 'asiyya al-dam'i*," composed by Riyad al-Sunbati in 1965, although that piano mostly played chords and large arpeggios and arguably contributed more to harmony than to the melody. The Arabic piano discussed in this section, however, refers to a piano performance used to deliver Arabic *maqam* music without any harmony or polyphony.

The piano is a rare instrument to find in Arabic music and has a rather experimental existence. The Arabic piano is any regular Western piano that has been modified to include notes from some Arabic *maqam* scales that are outside its normal 12-tone equal-tempered scale. There is no standard technique to achieve that, as different musicians have arrived at their alternate tunings by different means. It could be done either by means of pedals that alter the tuning of some notes on demand (making it very similar to the Arabic *org* and accordion) or by simply retuning some notes using a piano tuning key (making it very similar to the 19th- and early 20th-century *qanun* that didn't include mechanical levers and could only perform one *maqam* scale with each tuning).

The invention of the first Arabic piano is credited to Lebanese composer and pianist Wadih Sabra (1876–1952), who worked in collaboration with a piano manufacturer while living in France in 1922 to create a piano equipped with quartertones. In 1932, Sabra headed the Lebanese delegation of leading musicians and scholars to the First Cairo Arabic Music Congress, where he presented his Oriental (Eastern) piano. Sabra was only able to play two "quartertones," which was not well received by the congress attendees, including Umm Kulthum.⁵

The next well-known pioneer of the Arabic piano was the Lebanese Abdallah Chahine (1894–1975), who was both a pianist and an engineer. Chahine

⁴ Roustom (2006).

⁵ Burkhalter (2013).

mechanically modified his Western piano to play common “quartertones” by means of a foot pedal. That allowed him to easily go back and forth between regular Western tuning and Arabic tuning (using selective 24-tone equal temperament) during the same piece. The result was a selective 24-tone equal-tempered instrument. In 1973, Chahine released a recording called “*al-nagham al-khaled: angham min al-sharq*” (The Immortal Melody: Tunes from the East/Orient), which included ten piano *taqasim* (instrumental improvisations) followed by one instrumental version of a well-known Arabic song in each of the Bayati, Rast, Sikah, ‘Ajam, Nahawand, Nikriz, Hijaz, and Saba *maqamat*. Chahine used the piano as a percussive (*naqr*) instrument and developed his own approach to playing the piano monophonically (with no harmony), ornamenting in a style that closely resembled that of the *qanun*. The result was surprisingly Arabic despite the fact that the piano is one of the most recognizably Western instruments, one that’s very strongly associated with Western European classical music.

The best known contemporary Arabic piano player is Lebanese composer, playwright, and multi-instrumentalist Ziad Rahbani (b. 1956). Rahbani, the son of Assi al-Rahbani (1923–1986) and singer Fairouz, uses both acoustic and electric pianos extensively in his compositions and plays them in both the Arabic piano and jazz piano styles. The piano solo used to introduce his song “*shu hal-iyyam*” (1985) is a great example of an Arabic piano improvisation that stays within the confines of modal music and the traditional melodic behavior of Maqam Nahawand. That solo used many of the elements of an Arabic *taqsim* despite the fact that Rahbani’s piano was not mechanically altered to produce quartertones.

While Western instruments such as the accordion, the *org*, and the guitar acquired original ornamentation aesthetics when they were used for Arabic music, the piano unexpectedly ended up mimicking the *qanun*, a very well-established *takht* instrument. Upon close examination, that resemblance in sound and ornamentation aesthetics is not surprising, as the *qanun* (and its cousin, the *santur*) has many mechanical similarities to the piano: a wooden body and metal strings that are tripled or quadrupled for each note and are left to vibrate freely after each note is struck.

The Arabic Electric Guitar

The Arabic electric guitar is an electric guitar (usually a Fender Stratocaster) that has acquired the “Arabic” qualifier because of the way it is played and ornamented in Arabic music. In some rare cases, the Arabic electric guitar has extra quartertone frets, but that is by no means the norm, nor is it a requirement to achieve its Arabic quality.

The electric guitar came to the Arabic orchestra in 1960s Egypt on the initiative of singer Abdel Halim Hafez and composer Baligh Hamdi.⁶ Hafez and Hamdi were young and innovative and wanted to try new sounds in their ensemble. They invited guitar player Omar Khorshid to join al-Firqa al-Masiyya (The Diamond Orchestra), after which his career took off. Khorshid's successor in the Diamond Orchestra, Galal Fouda, was another well-established Arabic electric guitar player during the Golden Age.

The electric guitar and the Arabic *org* took a similar path to widespread popularity in Arabic music, as their pioneers, guitarist Omar Khorshid and keyboard player Magdi al-Husseini, were already musical collaborators in a rock and roll band. But rather than playing the electric guitar rock and roll style, Khorshid adopted a new, understated style that was more compatible with the volume and the monophony of Arabic music.

The Arabic electric guitar was played with a pick, and pitch bending with the fingers was rare. Instead, its players borrowed a lot of its right-hand plucking technique from the *'ud*, including tremolos and layering the melody with a drone on the bass string, but it was played with a noticeably less virtuosic technique than the *'ud*. Effect pedals were rarely used (aside from some very light reverb), and its volume became in line with other acoustic melodic instruments in the orchestra.

At a time when guitar legends such as Jimi Hendrix, Jimmy Page, and B. B. King were showing off their virtuosic techniques and treating the electric guitar as a loud and rebellious instrument prominently featured in the foreground, one could argue that Khorshid's technique was comparatively sober and timid, and that it greatly underutilized that instrument's full potential. In all likelihood, however, Khorshid knew he was walking a fine line artistically and had to be careful not to shock the stars and the public he was dealing with. For better or worse, Khorshid's technique and ornamentation style remain to this day the standard for the Arabic electric guitar.

The Arabic electric guitar proved so popular that it was adopted by more established and comparatively more traditional musicians: singer Umm Kulthum and composer Muhammad Abdel Wahab. Abdel Wahab used the electric guitar in several long-songs that were composed for Umm Kulthum, such as "*inta 'umri*" (1964), "*amal hayati*" (1965), "*fakkaruni*" (1966), "*hadbihi laylati*" (1968), "*darit il-ayyam*" (1970), and "*leilet il-hubb*" (1972).

Around the same period, a variation of the Arabic guitar that was fitted with extra (quartertone) frets began to make an appearance in some recordings on the Egyptian scene. Singer Warda used such an electric guitar in her long-songs, such

⁶ From Fu'ad (2014).

as “*shu’uri nahiyetak*” (by Sayed Makkawi), in which the guitar gave an acceptably good rendition of Maqam Sikah. Abdel Halim Hafez also used the Arabic electric guitar in many of his arrangements. His recording of “*ayyi dam’it huzni la*” (by Baligh Hamdi) includes a short electric guitar solo in Maqam Bayati that is reminiscent of Farid al-Atrash’s ‘*ud* style.

The Arabic electric guitar is a percussive (*naqr*) instrument par excellence and is rarely used with any effects pedals (e.g., compression) that would allow it to sustain its notes longer than normal. In most cases, it is used to accompany vocal rather than instrumental music. When played monophonically (one note at a time), it can contribute to the song’s main melody or perform solos and *taqasim*. Alternatively, it can be played harmonically by strumming chords to accompany a song.

In the vast majority of cases, Arabic orchestras used an original (unaltered) electric guitar, which was confined to the 12-tone equal-tempered scale. With such a limitation, guitar solos or *taqasim* usually only tackled *maqam* families whose scales did not include any quartertones (the “semitonal” *maqamat*), such as Nahawand, ‘Ajam, Kurd, Hijaz, and Nikriz. For the remaining *maqamat*, when playing alongside other melodic instruments, the electric guitar players took a practical approach and skipped any notes that it could not produce (this approach is widely used by Arabic piano and electric bass players).

The harmonic guitar playing style was part of the wave of Westernization that superimposed minimal harmony on top of the modal and monophonic Arabic music. The guitar’s harmonic contribution was very similar to that of the Arabic *org* or accordion; the guitarist rarely ventured beyond simple 3-note chords, using major chords with *maqamat* families whose 3rd degree is a major third (e.g., ‘Ajam and Hijaz), and minor chords with *maqam* families whose 3rd degree is a minor third (e.g., Saba, Bayati, Nahawand, and Nikriz). Maqam Kurd is an exception, since more often than not it was accompanied by a major chord despite the fact that its 3rd degree is a minor third. Such a major chord on the Maqam Kurd tonic can be clearly heard at the end of the guitar solo used to introduce Umm Kulthum’s “*amal hayati*.”

The Arabic Trumpet

The Arabic trumpet is a standard Western trumpet that is used to play quartertone intervals. The most common way to achieve that is by making use of the slides on the first and third valves. These slides are available on all professional trumpets and can be used to lower a note by as much as a quartertone. However, producing quartertones on a standard trumpet is not easy: the fingerings are extremely awkward, and moving the slides constantly is very taxing. Some keys come very naturally, while

others prove very challenging to execute, especially with the quickness required in ornamenting in Arabic music.

Another less common way of playing quartertone intervals on a trumpet is by acquiring one that has been fitted with a fourth valve. The fourth valve lowers the pitch by an equal-tempered quartertone. It was pioneered by Lebanese musician Nassim Maalouf, who used it to perform Arabic *maqam* scales. However, the slide allows a continuous gradation of pitch, and therefore much finer pitch control than the fourth valve. For this reason, using the slide allows the player to more accurately perform correct Arabic scale intonation. It does, however, require learning to use nonstandard fingerings for almost all of the notes, as well as constant movement of both the first and third valve slides.

As the trumpet is a wind instrument that produces notes based on the harmonic series, it can produce just fourths and fifths, which makes it able to match the correct Arabic scale's microtonal intonation more faithfully than a rigid 12-tone equal-tempered instrument. This puts the trumpet in roughly the same camp as the *nay*, intonation-wise.

The trumpet was first used within the Arab world in military bands that were set up on a European model. Eventually, civilian brass bands such as the Egyptian Firqat Hasab Allah lil Funun al-Sha'biyya (Hasab Allah Orchestra for Popular Arts) started using the trumpet to play Arabic music at the turn of the 19th century. The Hasab Allah brass band still exists today and has made many appearances in movies.

But the credit for bringing the Arabic trumpet into the mainstream Arabic recording industry goes to Egyptian trumpeter Sami al-Babli (d. 2001), who, like other pioneers of Western instruments in the 1960s and 1970s, developed a style of playing and ornamenting the Arabic trumpet that is still widely followed today.

Despite its great intonation, the Arabic trumpet didn't follow the same prestigious path or widespread popularity as other Western instruments that were introduced in the same time period, such as the *org* and electric guitar. While the Arabic trumpet is regularly used at wedding *zaffat*, birthday parties, and even circumcision rituals in Egypt, it never made it into the most prestigious Egyptian orchestras such as the Umm Kulthum Orchestra and the Diamond Orchestra. Instead, it is most popular in the Egyptian *sha'bi* genre. Indeed, there was hardly a song by *sha'bi* icon Ahmad Adaweya (b. 1945) that didn't include Sami al-Babli on the Arabic trumpet in his all-star ensemble, which often included giants such as Hassan Anwar on the *riqq* and Abdo Dagher on the violin.

Today, the momentum of the Arabic trumpet is sustained by two young artists of Arab origin who have been able to successfully exploit it in Arabic music as well as in their jazz fusion compositions: Ibrahim Maalouf (a Lebanese-French composer and trumpet player, and the son of Nassim Maalouf) and Amir ElSaffar

(an Iraqi-American composer, vocalist, and *santur* player, who is also an active performer of the Iraqi Maqam tradition).

The Arabic Saxophone

The Arabic saxophone is usually an alto saxophone that is used to perform Arabic *maqam* scales. The alto saxophone's range is ideal for Arabic music (as it is close to the range of an alto female voice). The tenor and soprano saxophones have also been used, albeit less frequently.

Reasonably accurate *maqam* intonation (including quartertones) can be produced on the saxophone by an experienced player through a manipulation of the embouchure and by using alternate fingerings. There are, however, technical limitations, and executing fast passages in some key transpositions may be awkward. For this reason, most pieces that feature the Arabic saxophone tend to be anchored in "semitonal" *maqamat* such as Hijaz, Nahawand, Kurd, and 'Ajam.

While the saxophone itself is a foreign instrument to the Arab world, it is a modern descendant of Middle Eastern single-reed instruments such as the *arghul* and *mijwiz*, and its reed (as well as the clarinet's) is made from *arundo donax* (giant cane), which is the same plant used in making the *nay* and the *mijwiz* Arabic wind instruments.

The saxophone first entered the Arab world through military bands, along with the trumpet and the clarinet. Toward the end of the 19th century, these Western wind instruments started gradually replacing their more traditional predecessors found in *tabl* and *mizmar* ensembles, which performed at weddings and other festive occasions.

The Arabic saxophone came into the Arabic orchestra during the late 1960s, the same period that saw the arrival of the electric guitar and the Arabic *org*. During that period, Egyptian composers such as Muhammad Abdel Wahab and Baligh Hamdi wished to innovate and glamorize their traditional arrangements in order to appeal to a wider/younger audience and keep the Arabic song moving with the times. By playing the Arabic scale almost faithfully, saxophone players did not take away any of the *tarab* content; instead they succeeded in adding an original color slightly reminiscent of big-band jazz orchestras to the Arabic ensemble, albeit without the harmony component.

The Arabic saxophone's foremost pioneer was Egyptian saxophonist Samir Sourour (1933–2003), nicknamed "*ashiq al-sax*" (The Sax Lover). Sourour came from a background of military music and was already an established saxophone player in the 1950s. In the 1960s, Sourour met innovative Egyptian composer Baligh

Hamdi, who wanted to add the sound of the saxophone to Umm Kulthum's orchestra for his compositions. Sourour, who was 34 years old at the time, played a saxophone solo for the first time on Umm Kulthum's "*fat il-ma'ad*" in 1967, and a partnership between him and Baligh Hamdi was born, which also led to Sourour's very memorable solos in Umm Kulthum's "*alf leila we leila*" in 1969. Sourour was also featured in the arrangements of many major artists, such as Abdel Halim Hafez, Fayza Ahmad, and Nagat, with his saxophone. Abdel Halim Hafez's song "*zayy il-hawa*" (1970), for example, features Sourour's saxophone alongside other modern additions such as the electric guitar and the Arabic *org*. After having played with major singers of his generation, in the 1990s Sourour recorded six instrumental albums in a series entitled "*Ashiq al-Sax*," made up of covers of the greatest hits by composers and singers from the Golden Age of Arabic music.

Today the Arabic saxophone exists as a niche instrument, but it is ironically more present as a keyboard sound sample that, in the hands of a skillful Arabic keyboard player, can sound very similar to the original with a fraction of the technique it takes to play the Arabic saxophone. A good example of the Arabic keyboard performing a saxophone sound is the introduction of Warda's long-song "*batwannis bik*" (1991, composed by Salah al-Sharnubi).

3

PERCUSSION INSTRUMENTS

THE MOST BASIC classification of instruments in Arabic music is that of melodic versus percussion. That classification creates two distinct clans of musicians, who think and contribute to the music in slightly different ways.

Arabic percussion instruments are plentiful (see figure 3.1 for a sampling). Most are membranophones (made from stretching natural or synthetic skin over a wood, clay, or metallic round frame). Others, such as *sajat* (finger cymbals) and the Moroccan *qaraqib*, are idiophones.

The *riqq*, the *tabla*, and frame drum varieties are the most popular Arabic percussion instruments and are considered pan-Arab rather than regional. They were the principal percussion instruments in the Golden Age and have survived the test of time extremely well.

Skin Tuning

Historically, Arabic membranophones used animal skin such as fish, goat, deer, or calf stretched over a cylindrical frame. Arabic percussion instruments do not require tuning the skin to a precise pitch (as is the case with the Indian *tabla*, for example). This means that the Arabic *tabla*, the *riqq*, and the various *daff* (frame drum) varieties do not need to be tuned with each other or with any melodic instrument prior



FIGURE 3.1 A sampling of Arabic percussion instruments: four *riqq*-s, one *tabl baladi*, four *sajat*, two *daff*-s, one *tabla*, and one Egyptian *mazhar*. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

to being played together. Instead, they need to be tight enough to have a nice ring. In addition to being an aesthetic requirement, a tight skin is a lot more comfortable to play and requires less energy because hands, fingers, or sticks bounce off it more easily.

As the ideal drum tightness is not based on a pitch or range of pitches, this gives the stretched skin a margin of acceptable tightness. Traditional Arabic membranophones were therefore not tunable, but were built by stretching the skin to its limit of elasticity and permanently gluing it to the instrument. Some instruments, such as the clay *tabla* and the *tabl baladi*, as well as some *daff* varieties, use a netting of woven strings, ropes, or natural skin strips to maintain that tightness throughout the life of the instrument.

The main problem with percussion instruments made with natural skin is that they are very susceptible to humidity, which causes the skin to lose its tightness and sag enough to sound dull and become heavier to play. The extent of that problem varies a lot depending on the climate where these drums are used; it is a lot worse in the Mediterranean Arab regions than it is in desert climates farther inland. Moreover, regardless of the climate, a natural skin is also susceptible to moisture from the fingers and will start loosening after continued playing.

Arabic percussionists have used various techniques to combat the adverse effects of moisture on natural skins, from standing frame drums upright in the sun or in front of a campfire to using an electric light bulb inside a clay *tabla* during a performance. *Riqq* players also use a pair of fish skin *riqq*-s and play one song on one of

them while the other is being heated on an electric heating pad, then swap them for the next song.

While these techniques are effective and are still used today (especially by musicians who value the traditional sound of natural skin), a new generation of modern Arabic membranophones that use synthetic skin and allow skin tuning and replacement has by and large replaced traditional instruments. Today Arabic percussionists typically use the synthetic skin for the majority of their gigs and save the natural skin for special occasions.

The Daff

The *daff* (a generic word for a frame drum) is the most basic Arabic percussion instrument, one of the oldest percussion instruments in the world. Ancient Egyptian paintings depict musicians using frame drums (although the instrument is likely much older than that), and the instrument is used in music traditions all over the globe. The *daff* is a handheld frame drum made of a thin wooden frame covered on one side with a stretched membrane of animal skin or synthetic material. Many other Arabic names exist for the frame drum, depending on its manufacturing style and region, such as *mazhar* (common in the Levant/Egypt), *bandir* (more common in North Africa), and *tar* (more common in Egypt). (See figure 3.2.)

The frame is usually 3 to 5 inches deep, with a diameter ranging from 12 to 24 inches. As the diameter increases, the frame depth usually decreases to keep the



FIGURE 3.2 A 17-inch goat skin *mazhar* made in Aleppo (front) and a Tunisian 18½-inch *bandir* (back). Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

drum's weight reasonable. Frames on the deeper side may have an opening at the bottom that the drummer uses to hold and support the frame. The opening could be a round hole about 1 inch in diameter in the middle of the frame's width (used to insert the thumb), or a U-shaped, crescent-like cut from the open edge of the frame (opposite from the skin).

The most common animal skins used are goat, calf, or deer, although all of these are susceptible to losing their tightness when exposed to moisture. Synthetic skins are increasingly common and can be transparent or translucent, or have a printed pattern that mimics animal skin. Some frame drums have their skins decorated with geometric patterns or Arabic calligraphy.

Although natural skin produces a richer and more sought after sound than synthetic skin, it is susceptible to moisture and humidity to varying degrees (depending on the type of skin used, the frame drum's diameter, and how tightly the skin is stretched). The traditional method to tighten a loose skin is to place it in front of a heat source such as a fire or the sun. In modern times, the percussionist can tighten natural skin by placing the drum next to an incandescent lamp or on top of an electric heating pad. While these methods do work and are still used by some percussionists,¹ the more pragmatic alternative is to use synthetic skins, which can be permanently glued at a fixed tightness or can be tunable.

Many tuning mechanisms exist, and they can be used with both natural and synthetic skins. The most common tuning mechanism for tunable frame drums is a metal ring (or rim) that pulls the skin against the frame's beveled edge by means of multiple hexagonal head-tuning screws located outside the frame. Other innovative but less common mechanisms include a rim pushing the skin out from the inside of the drum by means of a number of tuning screws. This has the advantage of keeping the frame clear on the outside. Another tuning method is using a very thin inflatable rubber tube (similar to ones used in bicycle tires) to push the skin away from the rim. This method has the advantage that it can be very quickly tightened using a small air pump, and it has a perfectly even tone throughout its entire circumference.

Depending on their size and the style and musical genre they are used in, frame drums can be held with the left hand (for right-handed players) and played standing up or can be rested on the player's left knee with the player sitting down.

Frame drums are very versatile and allow the use of many techniques, ranging from delicate finger-based techniques to heavy hand-based techniques. The vocabulary of the frame drum resembles the *tabla* much more than it does the *riqq*, with the *dum* sound produced with the dominant hand toward the center of the drum and the *tak* sound making use of the rim and the skin immediately near the rim, producing very

¹ Including one of the coauthors, Johnny Farraj.

sharp and dry *tak*-s that have a sustained ring. Heavy and muffled *tak*-s can also be produced, by hitting the center of the skin with the palm or five fingers of the dominant hand (producing a rich flam if so desired).

Unlike the *riqq* or the *tabla*, frame drums lend themselves extremely well to being layered and used in multiples. There's virtually no aesthetic limit to how many frame drums can be played together, as long as they don't ornament too much. Having a lineup of frame drums without any other type of percussion instrument is very common in Sufi music throughout the Arab world. When accompanied by voice without any melodic instruments, the effect is very dramatic.

Frame drums can be supplemented with various devices that augment their sound palette. One such device is one or more nylon strings stretched across the diameter of the frame, touching the back of the skin. These act as snares and give the drum a distinctive buzz (*khazza* in Arabic), especially with sustained *dum* sounds. Depending on their design, some snares can be engaged on demand, then loosened again. Snares are common with *bandir*-s in North Africa.

Another way to augment the sound of frame drums is to use a system of very small metal rings or chains hanging on the inside of the frame, very close to the skin, in one or multiple rows layered together. This device is sometimes used with Aleppan frame drums and is reminiscent of instruments from neighboring traditions, such as the Persian *daff* and *dayereh*.

The Egyptian *Mazhar*

The most dramatic addition to the frame drum is five sets of four cymbals, similar to the *riqq*. The resulting instrument is a very heavy and bulky oversized *riqq* called *mazhar* (see figure 3.3) that is very popular in Egypt, especially in wedding processions (*zaffat*) or Sufi music. This type of instrument has a thick wood frame about 5 to 6 inches deep and 10 to 14 inches in diameter, and a crescent-like cutout at the bottom of the frame to allow holding it with the non-dominant hand. It requires a heavy-handed technique in which the player only hits the skin with the dominant hand, and the large clunky cymbals resonate as a result. The Egyptian *mazhar* usually accompanies other frame drums that do not have cymbals, as well as the *riqq* or the *tabla*, and adds a very generous amount of volume to the rhythm section.

The *Riqq*

The *riqq* (also spelled *riq*) is a small, handheld tambourine about 9 inches in diameter and 2½ inches deep (see figure 3.4). It is traditionally covered with a fish skin head, stretched and permanently glued to the wooden frame, which is often



FIGURE 3.3 An Egyptian tunable *mazhar* (13 inches in diameter, 5 inches deep), with a translucent white plastic head. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.



FIGURE 3.4 A pair of nine-inch antique fishskin *riqq-s* decorated with mother of pearl and wood geometric mosaic patterns. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

intricately inlaid with tiny mosaic tiles made of mother of pearl, bones, horn, or colored wood.

The *riqq* has five sets of two pairs of brass cymbals (about 2 inches in diameter) spaced evenly around the frame. The cymbals (called *sajat* in Arabic) produce the lively jingly sound that is particular to the *riqq*. Larger *riqq-s* exist but are less common; these may have six sets of cymbals instead of five and a larger diameter of 10 or 11 inches.

In many regions of the Middle East, the *riqq* is called *daff*, although *daff* is also a generic term for a frame drum. In English, the *riqq* may also be called the Egyptian or Arabic tambourine. The word *riqq* itself means thin skin or parchment and was given to the instrument because of its thin skin, which when stretched very tightly becomes translucent. The *riqq* is valued for the variety of sounds it can produce and appreciated for the subtle yet virtuosic manner in which it is played.

Since the 1980s, *riqq*-s with a Mylar head and a wooden or aluminum frame have been built and adopted by a number of professional *riqq* players. These modern *riqq*-s are tunable and allow the head to be replaced without having to be glued. The *riqq* made today by Kevork Kazanjian in Lebanon is the best example of a professional tunable *riqq* that combines excellent sound, ergonomics, aesthetics, functionality, and durability.²

In the first half of the 20th century it was common for the *riqq* to be the sole percussion instrument in the traditional *takht* (chamber group) and small ensembles. In the second half of the 20th century, as ensembles grew in size and large orchestras became popular, the *riqq* was supplemented with the *tabla*, one or more *daff*-s, and other foreign percussion instruments like the bongos. *Riqq* players in such ensembles adopted a technique that emphasizes the cymbals over the membrane sound, in order to be louder and to better complement the remaining instruments' timbres.

The *riqq* player plays the prestigious and demanding role of “*dabit al-iqua*” (“controller of rhythm”) in an ensemble. Because of that role, *riqq* players do more than play the *iqua*’ (rhythmic cycle), as they can singlehandedly control the speed and level of liveliness of an entire orchestra. For this reason, Egyptian traditional *riqq* player Adel Shams el-Din describes the *riqq* player as the ensemble’s “beating heart.” The *riqq*’s *dum* stroke, reinforced by a double bass and other percussion instruments, holds the ensemble’s rhythm together and is essential for a singer to stay in rhythm. Indeed, the sharp sound of the *riqq* can be heard above most instruments in the Arabic orchestra, even on a low-quality AM radio broadcast (in that respect, the *riqq* plays the same role as the *clave* in Afro-Cuban music). In addition, it also signals *iqua*’ changes, speed changes, and the starting and ending of sections. For all these reasons, the rhythm section never uses more than one *riqq*.

When a *tabla* is also present alongside a *riqq* in the rhythm section, who the rhythm leader should be has to be negotiated, since the *tabla*’s volume is overwhelmingly louder than the *riqq*’s. But even in such a situation, the *riqq* player would normally lead, mostly because that role is traditionally part and parcel of playing that instrument.

² Farraj (2013).

The *riqq* also mediates between the singer and the ensemble and often intervenes to recover from rhythmic mistakes by the singer and bring the ensemble back to safety. The practice of shifting the ongoing *iqā'* to follow a singer's digression is called *talbis*, which literally means fitting a person or object with a garment that matches his or her exact size. Even the revered Egyptian diva Umm Kulthum strayed outside the correct rhythm on rare occasions and relied on her trusted *riqq* player to instantly follow her and bring the entire orchestra to her. Her *riqq* player for decades was Ibrahim 'Afifi, and Umm Kulthum is quoted as saying: "Ibrahim 'Afifi protects my image and covers up my [rhythmic] mistakes."³

Among the most influential *riqq* players in the 20th century (based on the number of performances and recordings they took part in, as well as on their contribution to *riqq* technique, style, and vocabulary) are Ibrahim 'Afifi (Egypt, d. 1961), who was the *dabīb al-iqā'* in the Umm Kulthum orchestra for over four decades; Muhammad al-'Arabi (Egypt, d. 2009), who performed with the most important singers of the 20th century and was a veteran of the Cairo Opera House's Arabic Music Orchestra; Hassan Anwar (1939–2007), who played with the Diamond Orchestra (al-Firqa al-Masiyya) for decades and elevated the status of the *riqq* player to the level of soloist; Husayn Mu'awwad (Egypt, d. 1979), who gave up his career as a lawyer to join Umm Kulthum's orchestra in 1963 until her death in 1975; Michel Merhej Bakloui (Palestine/Lebanon, b. 1928), who performed with Fairouz and the Rahbani Brothers for decades; and Adel Shams el-Din (Egypt, b. 1950), who is diligently carrying on the tradition of playing the fish skin *riqq* in the 21st century.

The *Tabla*

The *tabla* is a handheld drum shaped like a goblet. (See figure 3.5.) The *tabla* is also called *dirbakki* in Syria and Lebanon (a distorted version of this name, *darbukah* or *darboukah*, though never used in the Arabic language, has become an alternative name outside the Arab world). The *tabla* player is called *tabbal* (which is occasionally used in a derogatory sense and suggests that beating on a drum takes very little skill compared to playing a melodic instrument).

Skin is stretched on the *tabla*'s wide neck, while the narrow end is left open. The traditional *tabla* body is made of baked clay, painted and glazed, and the head is fish, calf, or goat skin, pulled tightly with a system of woven strings, then permanently glued. That type of *tabla* is not tunable and is susceptible to moisture just as the *riqq* and *daff* are. Traditional *tabla* skins were heated in humid weather in order

³ Samu'il (2009).



FIGURE 3.5 A *tabla* made by Gawharet El-Fan (Egypt), with a cast aluminum body ornamented with geometric mosaic patterns and a tunable Mylar transparent head. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

to achieve tightness (one quick and inexpensive heating technique used with traditional *tabla*-s is to slide a bare electric light bulb inside the body).

Modern *tabla* bodies are made of cast aluminum alloy and are often ornamented with geometric mosaic patterns that include mother of pearl, calligraphy, or hand painting. Modern *tabla* heads are made of Mylar stretched using an aluminum frame that attaches to the body with six or eight bolts with hexagonal heads. These *tabla*-s, like modern *riqq*-s, have the advantage of being tunable and maintaining their tuning. The vast majority of Arabic percussionists today use such tunable *tabla*-s. The most popular and widely available brand is Gawharet el-Fan (The Jewel of Art) from Egypt.

The *tabla* rests horizontally on the left thigh of the (right-handed) player sitting down and is held in place with the performer's left elbow. The skin is then struck with both hands. In keeping with the Arabic percussion vocabulary, the *dum* sound (bassy and sustained) is produced with the dominant hand hitting the middle of the skin. The *tak* sound can be produced with either hand and usually makes use of part of the skin very close to the frame's edge. The *tabla* also produces a wide array of secondary *tak* sounds that have names such as *ra*, *ka*, and *sak*. The *tabla* can also be played standing up, by squeezing it under the left armpit or attaching it with a belt that wraps around the neck. Another position that allows the player to play standing up is to rest the left foot on a stool. Alternatively, the *tabla* player can kneel down on the right leg and rest the *tabla* on the left thigh.

Originally more of a folk instrument, the *tabla* is now by far the most popular and widely available percussion instrument throughout the Arab world. Its powerful

volume makes it a great instrument for outdoor use, such as loud, open-air parties and weddings. For this reason, it can be comfortably paired with other loud instruments, such as the *mizmar*. Its sound is very compelling and inviting to dance to, and as such the *tabla* is the principal percussion instrument featured in *raqs sharqi* (belly dance) ensembles. In that genre, the *tabla* player is afforded great freedom to solo in sync with the dancer and has far more visibility than other musicians.

The *tabla* crossed over from its folk setting to the more urban large ensemble or orchestra around the early part of the 20th century and played a supporting role to the *riqq* in providing the rhythm in more classical (especially vocal) genres, while the *riqq* was still the rhythm controller and the instrument that is more ornamented and improvised on. In more folk and dance genres, the *tabla* and the *riqq* contributed equally in terms of ornamentation and visibility in the arrangement.

The *tabla* makes a phenomenal solo percussion instrument because of the versatility of sounds that it can produce, and also for its extra wide dynamic range. An ideal setting for such a solo would be one with no melody and with other Arabic percussion instruments such as the *riqq*, *daff*, and *sajat* playing a supporting role.

The Arabic *tabla* family includes two more instruments that are slightly larger in diameter: the *sunbati* (also spelled *sombati*) and the *doholla*. These have bodies and manufacturing very similar to the *tabla*, except that they can be tuned to a lower pitch, resulting in a slightly bassier sound. While having more than one *tabla* in a rhythm section is uncommon, pairing a *tabla* with a *sunbati* is much more common. In such a pairing, the *tabla* would usually solo, while the *sunbati* would play a more skeletal version of the rhythm in a supporting role.

The *Tabl Baladi*

The *tabl baladi* (the village drum) is a drum made of a large cylindrical body (about 20 inches in diameter and 15–20 inches deep) with skins stretched on both sides (see figure 3.6). The skins are very thick natural skin (e.g., donkey), or may be synthetic, and are tightened to the body using pattern or ropes wound or woven between them. Some *tabl baladi*-s squeeze pieces of wood between the ropes and the body to increase their tightness (a system very similar to the one used in the Indian *tabla*).

The *tabl baladi* is played with two sticks, one with each hand, while it hangs from the shoulder by means of a belt. The player can walk freely and even perform simple dance steps while playing. The dominant hand uses a larger stick and produces the heavy *dum* beats, while the other hand beats the opposite skin as well as the rim with a thin stick that produces the *tak* sounds. Other sounds can be produced and are



FIGURE 3.6 A *tabl baladi* made of a wooden frame (20 inches in diameter, 11 inches deep) and a natural skin front and back. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

used to ornament the *iqāʿ*, for example by using the large stick with the dominant hand to hit the rim.

The *tabl baladi* is a traditional folk instrument that shines in outdoor settings such as a village party or a wedding, where it can produce a very powerful sound, enough to drive a line dance with dozens of people. In such settings, the *tabl baladi* is very compatible with equally loud instruments such as the *mizmar*. The *tabl baladi* is by no means exclusive to the Arab world, as neighboring regions like Turkey, Greece, and the Balkan countries have very similar local versions of the *tabl baladi* used with their local versions of line dances.

The *Katim*

The *katim* (Arabic for muffler/silencer) is a medium to large frame drum designed to be pounded on with the entire hand, without too much ornamentation. (See figure 3.7.) It is usually sturdier and heavier than the average frame drum and has a bassier sound. Its name comes from the fact that its design and its playing technique do not allow it to produce a long, sustained sound as other frame drums do.

Traditional *katim*-s were made of a heavy and thick wood frame, usually without much decoration. Their skins were usually of the thick variety, such as goat, calf, or even donkey. Modern *katim*-s can have a wood or fiberglass frame fitted with a metal ring used to stretch a synthetic skin. These types of *katim* are tunable, and their skin tension is not at all affected by humidity. Because of its heavy weight, the *katim* is



FIGURE 3.7 A *katim* made of a wooden frame (15½ inches in diameter, 6 inches deep) and a natural skin head. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

usually squeezed between the thighs of the player sitting down and played with both hands, unless the percussion group is mobile, as in a wedding procession (*zaffa*), in which case it is carried with the left hand just like a *daff*.

The *katim* is not made for virtuosic playing, nor does it lend itself to a delicate finger technique. Instead it is used to perform a bare-bones skeletal *iqa'* to support other percussion instruments such as the *tabla* or the *riqq*. The *katim* player may very well spend a performance playing nothing but the basic *dum*-s and *tak*-s of each *iqa'*. For this reason, the *katim* produces only minimal heterophony. It is very popular with *raqs sharqi* (belly dance), wedding processions (*zaffat*), and Arabic pop and dance ensembles.

The *Sajat*

Sajat (singular *saj*) are a set of four brass finger cymbals, attached to the thumb and middle finger of each hand using thick elastic strips. (See figure 3.8.) The word *saj* itself means a metallic dome such as the one used for baking bread in Arabic. *Sajat* (called *sagat* in colloquial Egyptian) are often called *zills* in English (borrowing the Turkish word *zil*, literally: cymbal or bell) and can come in different diameters ranging from 1½ inches to 6 inches or more. A finger cymbal over 6 inches in diameter is called *tura* (pl. *tuwar*).

Smaller sized cymbals have a very light and crisp sound, while larger ones have a deeper and louder sound. They are very popular with *raqs sharqi* dancers (who play



FIGURE 3.8 A pair of 2¼-inch brass *sajat*. Photo credit: Fouad Salloum, 2017.

them while dancing) because they are very practical to carry, they accentuate the ensemble's rhythm, and they draw attention to the dancer. Larger *sajat* are common in Sufi music and *sha'bi* genre music ensembles, where they nicely complement a large assortment of frame drums. In such arrangements, large *sajat* are used in order to avoid clashing with the *riqq*'s cymbals.

Despite their apparent simplicity, finger cymbals allow a wide range of techniques that can produce sustained and muted rings at different pitches. While finger cymbals are idiophones not membranophones, they nevertheless can produce distinct sounds that could clearly represent the *dum* and *tak*, basic Arabic *iqā'* building blocks (see chapter 6: Rhythm). In that case the open, sustained ringing is the *dum*, and the tight, closed sound is the *tak*. Other sounds exist in the *sajat* vocabulary, such as the edge or bell that may be named *tik* and *tok*.

The Drum Set

The drum set was used in many Arabic songs starting from the 1970s onward and was primarily intended to instill a Western pop music color in an Arabic composition. Two of Abdel Halim Hafez's songs from the 1970s illustrate this usage: "*nibtidi minein il-hikaya*" (1975) and "*qari'at al-finjan*" (1976), in which the drum set supplemented Arabic *iqā'at* alongside Arabic percussion instruments.

This trend continues today, as the drum set is a very common instrument in Arabic pop ensembles. In such arrangements, the drum set is usually not the only percussion instrument; instead it is accompanied by traditional Arabic percussion instruments, primarily the *tabla*, all the way up to the *katim* and *riqq*. The resulting sound is very heterogeneous because it is very difficult to ornament an *iqā'* according

to the Arabic tradition on the drum set. In that sense, the drum set is possibly the best example of a foreign instrument that was not successfully “Arabized,” but that serves the purpose it was designed for, which is to contribute presence and volume and add a Western pop music color.

The drum set was also used in many Western-style Arabic pop songs in the 1970s and 1980s as the only percussion instrument, as part of a predominantly Western arrangement. Such arrangements did not use Arabic *iqāʿat*; instead a generic and simple Western pop music rhythm (mostly in the $\frac{4}{4}$ time signature) was played on the drum set. Examples of these Western arrangements abound in the Rahbani Brothers’ compositions, for example Fairouz’s “*habbaytak bis-sayf*” (1970). Another example is the song “*saʿat saʿat*” (1995) by the other Lebanese diva, Sabah.

Electronic Percussion

Electronic percussion refers to any device that plays Arabic *iqāʿat* using the sampled or synthesized sounds of multiple percussion instruments. It can be a built-in function in an Arabic (Oriental) keyboard or a stand-alone beat box (rhythm machine). At a minimum, Arabic electronic percussion includes samples from a *riqq*, a *tabla*, a *katim*, and *sajat*, but can also include non-Arabic sampled instruments such as handclaps, bongos, and cymbals. Such rhythm generators come preprogrammed out of the box with a wide variety of Arabic *iqāʿat* to pick from. They also allow variable speed (measured in BPM, beats per minute) and can perform fills at the touch of a button, to mark the end of a measure.

Electronic percussion has transformed the world of Arabic rhythm in the same way that the synthesizer transformed the world of Arabic intonation (see chapter 11: Tuning System), making it much more rigid and impersonal. Electronic rhythms are numbingly repetitive, their tempo is unflinching, their dynamics are monotonous, the quality and timbre of every single note is constant, and they don’t include the diverse ornamentation and imaginative variations that only a live musician can provide.

What’s worse is that the feedback loop between the rhythm section and the melodic section is totally absent. The familiar give and take in speed, dynamics, and fills is absent, and so is the role of the percussionist as the conductor and signaler; the result is the melodic instrument section playing against a machine. Since constant listening and adapting one’s playing to other musicians is a principal ingredient in good Arabic music, music produced with electronic percussion is monotonous and feels harsher on the ear the longer it is heard.

Contemporary Egyptian percussionist and veteran fish skin *riqq* player Adel Shams el-Din summarized these points in an interview: “Electronic percussion instruments have no feeling, and are only there to keep time. We may be able to justify using them during rehearsals but they should not be used during recordings as these require a living percussionist. . . . The percussionist adds something from their feelings to the music, while the rhythm box’s effect on the percussionist is deadly.”⁴

Combining Percussion Instruments

Combining multiple percussion instruments is very common in Arabic music. The reasons for combining are the same as for melodic instruments. Besides the added volume, each percussion instrument has a unique palette of timbres, tonal range, and ornamentation possibilities; therefore, combining them creates a richer sound. The size of the rhythm section could be anywhere from one to a dozen instruments. The decision to combine instruments or not and which instruments to combine depends on the genre and style performed, as well as the size and makeup of the melodic instrument section. Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*zayy il-hawa*” is a good example of an Arabic orchestra that uses a large and diverse rhythm section.

Using multiple instruments of the same type creates volume and presence. Frame drums are the most common percussion instrument to be multiplied in that way. A Sufi music ensemble may consist entirely of frame drums, in which case ornamentation and heterophony are kept to a minimum in order to deliver a powerful version of the simple skeletal *iqā’*. Another very good example of using multiple identical percussion instruments is a wedding procession (*zaffā*), in which volume and presence are best served by using a large number of frame drums.

On the other hand, some percussion instruments defy having more than one in a rhythm section, partly because of their distinctive and detailed sound and their appetite for ornamentation, and partly because the role they play on stage cannot be shared. This is the case with the *riqq*. There can never be more than one *riqq* on stage, because when there is, multiple *riqq*-s create a very confusing and conflicting sound. And given the *riqq*’s special role in conducting, signaling, and mediating between the ensemble and the vocalist, having two *riqq*-s would be like having a bus with two drivers. *Tabla*-s are similar; there are rarely two *tabla*-s on stage because of their appetite for soloing and for being the loudest and most noticed percussion instrument.

Aside from using multiple instruments of the same type (layering), different percussion instruments are very often combined together. The most popular marriage

⁴ Diyab (2000).

in this department is the *riqq* and the *tabla*, as they complement each other beautifully because of their different tonal ranges, dynamic ranges, timbres, and styles of ornamentation. A *riqq* and a *tabla* won't clash, and each will bring its style of ornamentation to the mix. The resulting rhythm is heavily ornamented with two different simultaneous styles and sounds. The *riqq* can also be complemented with a *daff*, which brings in a strong *dum* to the mix; in such a pairing, the *daff* usually doesn't ornament much and leaves that to the *riqq*. Another popular marriage is a *tabla* and a *katim*, which provides a bassy layer by playing a very bare-bones version of the *iqā'* (without ornaments) in order to clear the stage for the *tabla* to ornament and solo at will. In turn, the *tabla* provides the punchy and sharp colors, and the supporting *katim* provides the depth and the grounding. In *raqs sharqi* arrangements, that combination can also afford a *riqq* or some *sajat* (finger cymbals) to contribute the high-pitched sound of the jingles that is an essential component of that genre.

In smaller, more classical ensembles, the *riqq* is usually the percussion instrument of choice and can be complemented with a *daff* playing lightly in the background without too much ornamentation. This combination leaves room for the *riqq* to be clearly heard, to be in the foreground, and to be in the driving seat. Finally, the combination of electronic percussion or a drum set supplemented with a *tabla*, *katim*, *riqq*, or *sajat* (or all of the above) is very common in today's Arabic pop music ensemble.

4

ENSEMBLES

THIS CHAPTER EXPLORES in detail typical ensemble formations that, including the standard *takht* (Arabic traditional chamber group), account for the vast majority of performances and recordings in the Golden Age.

The *Takht*

The *takht* (a Persian word that means bed or raised platform, historically used to seat the musicians) is a five-piece traditional Arabic chamber group. Since the late 19th century, the *takht* has comprised an *'ud*, a *qanun*, a violin, a *nay*, and a *riqq*. Before the adoption of the violin in Arabic music, the *takht* formation included a local variety of a *rababa* instead.

The *takht* combines two *naqr* (percussive) instruments (*'ud* and *qanun*) with two *sabb* (sustaining) instruments (violin and *nay*), and as such achieves the perfect instrumental balance between sustaining a tone over time and accenting the rhythm along with the percussion instrument. It also achieves great balance in volume, register, tonal range, and timbre mixtures. Given that, the *takht* is the best-suited ensemble to accompany a singer, without amplification, before a small crowd.

The traditional Arabic instruments used in the *takht* are often called *alat al-takht* (*takht* instruments) and are more precise than any others at performing the correct

Arabic *maqam* intonation. For this reason, *takht* instruments are the best suited to perform a *taqsim* (a traditional instrumental solo). Even when combined with additional instruments, the *takht* remains at the core of most larger ensembles or orchestras, as it delivers a traditional Arabic sound and a precise *maqam* scale intonation. This can be clearly seen in the large Umm Kulthum Orchestra, in which the singer placed the *takht* instruments immediately around her in order to hear the best possible version of the *maqam* scale, as well as the rhythmic pulses from the ‘*ud* and *qanun*.

The Midsize Ensemble

The simplest expansion of the Arabic ensemble starts by supplementing the *takht*, the core ensemble of traditional Arabic music, with more instruments such as the cello or the double (upright) bass. Because they are fretless, both of these instruments have the full intonation spectrum of a violin or ‘*ud* and therefore don’t compromise the overall intonation. When plucked, the cello can nicely beef up the rhythm section, and when bowed it can add a depth to the overall sound by filling in the lower tonal range. A similar effect can be achieved by adding a second ‘*ud* designated as a bass ‘*ud*, meaning that it always plays the melody an octave lower than the primary ‘*ud*.

The double bass is rarely bowed in traditional Arabic arrangements; instead it is plucked to create a rhythmic melodic line that supplements the percussion section. In most cases the bass doesn’t play the entire melody along with other melodic instruments, since that would be overwhelming and would defeat the purpose of having it. Instead, the bassist plays those notes that fall on the main beats of the *iqā’* (the *dum*-s and *tak*-s) and omits many of the notes in between. Generally speaking, the purpose of the bass in Arabic music is twofold: to accent rhythm while also supporting the melody by emphasizing notes and intervals (which sometimes results in implied harmony).

A very common early 20th-century strategy for expanding the ensemble, inspired by the presence of Western orchestras in residence in Cairo, which developed in tandem with the use of music in Egyptian cinema, is increasing the number of violins to create a string section. In that case, one principal violinist always takes the lead, and the other violinists follow. Adding more violins is a sure way to amplify the overall sound and is the most common way to increase the size and power of an ensemble. Violin sections always play in unison, except for the principal violinist, who sometimes solos or individually plays short phrases that serve as signals.

Having more than one *qanun* in the same ensemble is not common (unless, for example, it's a student ensemble), while having more than one *nay* is very unlikely (what is more likely would be to use another wind instrument, such as the *kawala*, alongside a *nay*, since they have different timbres). The *takht* can also be supplemented with additional percussion instruments such as the *tabla* or a frame drum variety (*daff*, *mazhar*, or *bandir*).

Adding instruments enriches the tonal range as well as the overall timbre and volume, but it comes at a price. Aside from instruments in the violin family (cello and double bass), no other instruments have the intonation precision of the traditional *takht* instruments. The price for the additional color and volume may be sacrificing the perfect *maqam* intonation of the overall sound.

A very nice midsize ensemble that achieves a beautiful combination of timbres without straying too far from precise *maqam* intonation is the one featured in Ziad Rahbani's recording "*Bil Afrab*" (1977). Rahbani's ensemble consisted of an '*ud*, a violin, a *qanun*, a *nay*, two *buzuq*-s, an Arabic accordion, a double bass, a *tabla*, and a *riqq*. The recording, which is entirely instrumental, is a masterpiece in arrangement because of the expert pairing of sustaining and percussive instruments and the lack of clutter (one never feels the entire weight of the ensemble all at once). Arranger Ziad Rahbani,¹ who also plays the accordion part, had small subgroups of instruments take turns playing the melody while the rest of the ensemble minimally backed them up. The result is a very clear, colorful, and surprisingly cohesive recording in its intonation despite the fact that the *buzuq* is a fretted instrument and the Arabic accordion is based on the 12-tone ET tuning system with a few added "quartertunes."

Another example of an excellent midsize ensemble is the one used by Farid al-Atrash on the soundtrack of his 1975 movie "*nagham fi hayati*" (A Tune in My Life). His midsize ensemble is featured in hit songs such as "*hibbina*" and "*ya habaybi ya ghaybin*" and combines the traditional *takht* ('*ud*, *qanun*, *nay*, violin, and *riqq*) with a *tabla*, double bass, accordion, *org* (Arabic electric organ), electric guitar, electric *buzuq*, and midsize violin section. The arrangement is very tight but not crowded and gives plenty of solo melodies to the *qanun*, the accordion, the electric *buzuq*, and the *org*. This ensemble's recordings come at the tail end of the Golden Age, when the inclusion of electric and Western instruments in the Arabic ensemble was a done deal, but old and new coexisted harmoniously to produce the sound typical of 1970s Arabic music.

¹ Rahbani composed two of the album's tracks: Fairouz's song "*sa'aluni el-nas*" and the instrumental "*muqaddimat sabriyye*."

The Arabic Orchestra

The Arabic orchestra (*firqa* in Arabic, plural *firaq*) became popular in Egypt from the 1940s through the 1980s, in a period when Arab composers and arrangers wished to increasingly imitate Western symphonic orchestras. Aside from the tremendous increase in volume and power compared to the intimate *takht*, the Arabic orchestra also provided the ideal arena for innovative additions of Western instruments such as the accordion, *org*, electric guitar, and saxophone. By the 1970s and 1980s, the combined sound resulting from such an orchestra had become the new norm for Arabic music.

Egypt was home to many famous orchestras (and conductors), who produced many recordings and hosted numerous live performances. The Diamond Orchestra (al-Firqa al-Masiyya), conducted by Ahmad Fouad Hassan, was one such orchestra, which survived a good 40 years (from the 1950s to the early 1990s) and regularly accompanied crooner Abdel Halim Hafez, as well as major singers like Sabah, Warda, and Fayza Ahmad. The state-sponsored Arabic Music Orchestra (Firqat al-Musiqa al-‘Arabiyya), based in the Cairo Opera House and conducted by maestro Abdel Halim Nowera from 1967 to 1985, specialized in the classical vocal repertoire of *adwar* and *muwashshahat* and included a large coed *jawqa* (choir).

But by far the most important orchestra was the one backing Egyptian singer Umm Kulthum. That orchestra combined the most talented and experienced performers of each era of her career and was the de facto benchmark that has never been surpassed. Umm Kulthum’s orchestra grew with the fashion and was largest in the 1960s and 1970s. At its height, it was made up of the following lineup: the traditional *takht* (*‘ud*, *qanun*, *nay*, lead violin, *riqq*), a double bass, two to four cellos, a violin section (up to two dozen playing in unison), and additional percussion instruments (*tabla*, *daff*, and sometimes bongos). The Arabic accordion was almost a fixture of the late version of her orchestra, while the electric guitar, the saxophone, and the *org* were occasional additions.

The seating arrangement was always the same, with the melodic inner circle (the *takht* minus the *riqq*) always immediately surrounding Umm Kulthum in order to provide her with the most accurate intonation possible (the exception to that seating was the principal violinist, who mostly stood at the head of the string section). The rhythm section (percussion, bass, and cellos) was always stage left, and the violin section, accordion, electric guitar, and electric organ were usually stage right.

Most solos were given to *takht* members plus the accordion, although occasionally the guest (non-Arabic) instruments like the electric guitar, *org*, and saxophone would solo, because composers like Muhammad Abdel Wahab and Baligh Hamdi wanted to feature them.

The Umm Kulthum orchestra had two features that made it a cut above all others: first, when its musicians performed they never read from sheet music (instead they learned each song by heart, usually directly from the composer on his *'ud*, over dozens of rehearsals), and second, they never had a conductor. Most of the time, start signals were given by a wave of the *qanun* player's hand or a nod of the principal violinist's head.

The Raqs Sharqi Orchestra

Raqs sharqi (literally, "Eastern Dance" in Arabic) is the internationally popular dance genre that is widely known in English as "belly dance." *Raqs sharqi* as it is practiced today originated in Egypt and became hugely popular with the advent of Egyptian cinema in movies that showcased star dancers such as Naima Akef, Tahia Carioca, Samia Gamal, and Nagwa Fouad, as well as starring male actors such as Muhammad Abdel Wahab and Farid al-Atrash, who were also among the best composers of *raqs sharqi* music during the Golden Age.

Raqs sharqi ensembles and orchestras are loud and energetic and heavily emphasize rhythm. Such ensembles have a beefed-up rhythm section that relies on the *tabla* as its cornerstone, then a *riqq* (played mainly in the open technique that highlights its cymbals), *sajat* (finger cymbals of various diameters), a *katim* (a very bassy frame drum used to emphasize the *dum* and *tak* elementary sounds), and optionally one or more frame drum varieties (*daff* and *mazhar*). Some ensembles also use bongos for a little Latin color, while modern ensembles also add a drum set and an electric (fretted) bass guitar to the rhythm section.

On the melodic side, the staple melodic instrument for *raqs sharqi* orchestras is the Arabic accordion, supported by instruments from the traditional *takht*, augmented with a violin section if needed. A more commercially viable alternative is adding the *org* or synthesizer, which can be louder than an entire violin section (but sadly lacks their accurate microtonal intonation control). The electric guitar is another possible choice to provide more volume and punch. Because of the emphasis on rhythms, the guitar is often played as a rhythm guitar, strumming simple major or minor chords to the beat.

The Arabic Pop Ensemble

Arabic pop music in the late 20th and early 21st centuries has relied predominantly on electric/electronic instruments because the emphasis in that genre is more on danceability and video-clip-worthiness (and more generally its commercial dimension).

Showcasing the virtuosity of the singer and instrumentalists (not to mention the beauty and richness of the Arabic *maqam*) is not a priority in that genre. Having said that, the Arabic pop world is quite diverse and involves hundreds of performers who create a continuous spectrum between tradition and modernity of arrangement.

The staple melodic instrument and ultimate workhorse of the Arabic pop ensemble is the Arabic/Oriental keyboard. A drum set or electronic drum samples typically drive the rhythm section. If a *riqq* and *tabla* are used, their role is to ornament and make the tracks sound alive, as well as to add a touch of tradition. Electric guitars are often present and mostly play in the rhythm guitar style (by strumming simple chords). Electric bass guitars are very common and can be replaced or supplemented with a synthesizer bass line. Remaining instruments in a pop ensemble can be a *qanun*, a *nay*, a *kawala* (very popular in Egypt), a trumpet, a saxophone, one or more violins, or a synthesized version of any of these.

Hybrid Songs and Ensembles

A new Arabic music genre became popular in the 20th century, propelled by some composers' desire to innovate and include harmony and Western instruments without losing the *maqam*-based foundation. That genre was a hybrid song that alternated between harmonic sections and *maqam*-based melodic sections. These hybrid compositions were pioneered in the early 20th century by innovative Egyptian composers such as Sayed Darwish and Muhammad al-Qasabgi, and were brought into the long-song genre in the mid-20th century by Baligh Hamdi, Muhammad al-Mougi, and Muhammad Abdel Wahab, among many others. Many examples of these hybrid songs exist in the repertoires of Abdel Halim Hafez (e.g., "*qari'at al-finjan*"), Umm Kulthum (e.g., "*fakkaruni*" and "*alf leila we leila*"), and Warda (e.g., "*fi youm we leila*").

The most common approach used in these hybrids was to have polyphonic Western instruments (*org*, electric guitar, or piano) lead the harmonic sections and traditional Arabic instruments lead the *maqam*-based sections. String instruments (violins, cellos, bass) supported both sections, although the violin section itself was rarely arranged to produce multiple-part harmony. The combination sounded like having two very different orchestras playing side by side and taking turns. The harmonic sections sounded foreign because of the presence of harmony and the use of Western instruments, but also because they lacked a precise Arabic *maqam* scale intonation as well as the *maqam*'s traditional *sayr*.

Two very famous examples of these hybrids are the tango "*sabirtu minhu al-layali*" (1935), sung and composed by Abdel Wahab, and the song "*ahwak*" (1959),

composed by Abdel Wahab for Abdel Halim Hafez. In both cases, the Western harmonic music provides the frame (tango in the case of “*sahirtu minhu al-layali*”), and the middle section of the song uses Arabic *maqam*. To make the contrast more striking, in both cases the *maqam* that Abdel Wahab chose is Maqam Sikah Baladi, which is impossible to play on Western instruments, because all of its intervals are microtonal. Farid al-Atrash’s composition “*layali al-unsu fi Vienna*” (nights of passion in Vienna) performed by his sister Asmahan in the 1944 movie “*gharam wa intiham*” uses an acoustic guitar and sounds very much like a waltz until it reaches a section in Jins Bayati.

Some of these hybrids (e.g., “*ana lik ‘ala tul*,” sung by Abdel Halim Hafez in 1955) were predominantly harmonic and only used Arabic *maqam* sections as an added flavor. In other hybrids, the *maqam*-based sections were the dominant ones, and harmony and Western instrumentation was the added color. In the latter songs, the composers never let the *maqam*-based foundation get overwhelmed with harmony “and seemed to remind us of that fact every time a harmony section ended and a *maqam* section started, as if to re-conquer the song’s territory and brand it again as Arabic.”² One very memorable example of the return of the Arabic *maqam* after a long harmonic section is in “*qari’at al-finjan*” (1976), in which a harmonic section with rich chords on the *org* ends and gives way to eight suspenseful measures of Iqa’ Wahda (¼) expertly delivered by Hassan Anwar on the *riqq*, followed by a much-anticipated return to a Maqam Bayati section.

Backing Vocalists

Some genres and forms require backing vocalists, called *madhhabjiyya* in Arabic (pl. of *madhhabji*, the person who sings the *madhhab* or the refrain). The job of the backing vocalists is an important one: to support the singer in a song that quickly alternates verse and refrain without too many instrumental interludes.

The size of the choir section depends on the size of the ensemble and can range from two or three singers to a dozen. The *madhhabjiyya* can be comprised of both women and men for a richer sound, in which case they may all sing in unison (with the men’s and women’s lines one octave apart), or they may take turns and sing different lines separately.

An informal and instant choir can be made up of the musicians themselves—a common practice in small *takht* ensembles. In that case, those with a good voice and correct singing skills can sing the refrains, as long as their instruments allow them

² Dr. Taoufiq Ben Amor, conversation with the author, 2005.

(that obviously excludes wind instrument players). Alternatively, an instrumentalist could momentarily stop playing in order to sing the refrain.

One characteristic of the *madhhab* singers is that they are not supposed to ornament much. The refrain should be delivered plainly, because their role is not to shine as singers but to keep the composition going while the solo singer rests in order to shine again during the verses.

Arabic Choirs

The Arabic music choir (called *jawqa*) is part of a long-standing tradition of monophonic choirs that includes Gregorian and Byzantine choirs, among others. These choirs always sing a single melody in unison, except during solos, when only one singer performs. Choirs in this context do not mean backing vocalists supporting a main singer, but rather a group of singers who deliver the vocal part as a unit.

While Arabic choirs were traditionally male only, in the 20th century Arabic choirs started emulating Western classical choirs by including both men and women and by using a conductor. These choirs may or may not be supported by an instrumental ensemble. By far the most common genre performed by modern Arabic choirs is the *muwashshah*, since historically that genre was a group singing exercise anyway.

Unlike Western classical music choirs that perform harmonic music and include multiple parts (soprano, alto, tenor, and bass), each singing a different melodic line, Arabic choirs do not have separate parts, nor do they use harmony. Instead they use a few basic arrangement techniques that help them avoid a long and monotonous unison for an entire performance. The men and the women often alternate parts instead of singing every line together. Some lines can be reserved for a solo singer. Solo lines can be either composed or improvised. This creates an opportunity for a call and response between the solo singer and the rest of the choir. Many *muwashshahat* have a section (called *khana*) that lends itself well to such an arrangement. In that case the soloist can repeat a line as many times as he or she wishes, and with every repetition he or she may slightly vary the melody, ornament it differently, or modulate into a new *maqam* (see chapter 5: Ornamentation for more discussion of this practice). The rest of the choir keeps singing a constant response until the soloist is done with his or her part and rejoins the unison.

Signaling

Signaling is the exchange of visual or aural cues between musicians during a live performance, in order for an ensemble to conduct itself. Since most Arabic ensembles

function without a conductor, signaling is a routine and important exercise during a live performance. Signaling helps manage the timely and correct starting and ending of sections, as well as the speed and the dynamics (loudness, busyness, and level of excitement) of a piece. It tends to happen very fast and mostly goes unnoticed by the audience.

Signaling could introduce changes that the ensemble expects, such as an upcoming tempo change, a change in *iqā'*, or a new section. In that case the signal serves as a reminder or a confirmation. The most common musician to be in charge of this type of signaling is the *riqq* player. The reasons for that privileged position are practical and historic. In small *takht* chamber ensembles, the *riqq* player is traditionally the only percussionist; hence that role naturally falls on that person. But practically speaking, the *riqq*'s timbre and loudness make it easily heard above any other instrument even in very large orchestras, making it ideal for that task. Musicians and listeners are conditioned to react to the *riqq*'s cymbals with excitement, so switching to the cymbals heightens the mood, while playing on the skin calms it down.

How do *riqq* players signal? To start a section or a piece, they could play two to four empty measures, or sometimes simply two *tak*-s. They could also establish strong eye contact, make sure everyone is ready, and nod their heads (that type of signal can be done by other musicians as well, especially the conductor-performer). Signaling changes in *iqā'* takes great artistry, as it must be obvious to musicians without being disruptive of the music. A common technique is to ornament the *iqā'* differently in the last half measure before a change so as to announce it. To signal changes in tempo, *riqq* players usually take down their ornamentation to a minimum in the measure or half measure before the change (reducing the *iqā'* to a near skeleton), then they accentuate *dum*-s and *tak*-s to clearly announce the new tempo (see chapters 5: Ornamentation and 6: Rhythm). For *riqq* players, signaling is central to their role as percussionists, for which they have earned the title *dabit al-iqā'* ("rhythm controller").

It is also very common for one of the senior musicians to signal the ensemble with a hand or with a nod. Umm Kulthum's *qanun* player Muhammad Abdo Saleh or her principal violinist Ahmad al-Hifnawi often signaled the ensemble, and so did Ahmad Fouad Hassan when leading his Diamond Orchestra while playing the *qanun*.

Signaling is indispensable for changes that the ensemble doesn't expect. Examples include a sudden urge by the singer to repeat a section in the heat of *tarab*, a decision by the singer to start a short *mawwal* or *tafrid* on a phrase, a request by the singer or the conductor-performer to speed up or slow down, and a request by the conductor-performer to insert a short instrumental solo in the heat of the moment.

Singers can signal with their hands behind their backs or to the side of their bodies, or they could quickly glance at the *riqq* player or the conductor-performer.

But charismatic singers can signal the changes they need and conduct a large orchestra without moving a muscle, just by singing assertively and grabbing control of the speed, by adding a few words at the end of a section to signal a repeat, or by signing the formulaic “*ya leil ya leil*” or “*aman aman*” instead of starting a new section, in order to request a short *layali* or *mawwal*.

When the singer signals, the ensemble must comply, since the singer is the focal point of the performance. A request to start a short *mawwal* could mean inserting an interlude using Iqa‘ Ciftetelli (as the tradition requires), or it could mean the singer needs a break from the meter and only requires the ensemble to perform some *tarjama* in the background (see chapter 22: Vocal Improvisation for a discussion of *tarjama*, the practice in which instrumentalists follow along with a singer’s improvisation). That gets decided based on the context, as iconic singers such as Umm Kulthum, Su‘ad Muhammad, Warda, or Sabah Fakhri often inserted *mawawil* when the excitement of the concert and their own mood reached a high.

In an instrumental piece, a soloist could snatch extra time for a short *taqsim*, much as a singer might, by starting the *taqsim* just before a new section of refrain. In that case the ensemble should react in time and play a supporting role either by droning or doing *tarjama*. The rhythm usually continues as normal. At the end of the *taqsim* the soloist could start the opening phrase of the refrain, asking everybody to follow him or her and continue the piece as normal.

The Conductor

Most Arabic music is performed without a conductor. Indeed, conductors are few and far between and only come into play when large and big-budget orchestras and/or choirs are involved. While today most small to medium ensembles don’t have a need for a conductor, many large ensembles (a dozen musicians or more) use one. Having a conductor can boost the image of the orchestra and contribute to its prestige, especially if the conductor is well known.

Having a conductor is a mid-20th-century addition to Arabic music, stemming from a desire to emulate Western classical music in many respects. Adding the conductor came hand in hand with the introduction of Western notation, Western instruments, and the expansion of the *takht* into a large orchestra. Eventually, successful conductors earned the title *maestro* (Italian for music director or conductor).

Conductors in Arabic music also double up as transcribers and arrangers, since notated Arabic music usually starts in simple melodic form, and someone has to arrange it for a large ensemble (see chapter 10: Arrangement). Conductors also run rehearsals and recruit, train, and pay musicians. The presence of a conductor in a live

performance helps keep the orchestra playing tightly together and puts an experienced person in charge of signaling, speed, and dynamics.

There is an ongoing debate, however, about whether putting one person in charge of the orchestra produces better music than the traditional system of shared control, listening and interacting, and live consensus building. This debate is part of a wider aesthetic debate about what constitutes good Arabic music. The modernist point of view supports Western classical music aesthetics and attempts to emulate them when performing Arabic compositions, while the traditionalist point of view favors an environment that allows Arabic music to maintain its cultural character: communal, interactive, informal in its compositional structure, highly improvisational, and personalized.

Having a conductor encourages closer adherence to the musical score, which in turn stifles ornamentation and heterophony, both of which are fundamental aspects of Arabic music. In addition, having a conductor usually means that the orchestra members are reading music, which takes away some of the energy that otherwise could be devoted to listening to and looking at each other. Another downside to conducting is that it blocks or replaces the constant negotiation and subtle recalibration that take place between the singer on one hand and the rhythm section and the rest of the ensemble on the other hand. That type of conducting coerces the singer into following instead of leading, and for this reason it is rarely used by confident and experienced singers who want to influence the ensemble's speed and dynamics through their singing. Instead, a better situation for using a conductor would be when the vocal part is performed by a choir.

One argument that is often presented in support of having a conductor is that a very large orchestra would be chaotic and could not function well without one. Yet historically, a prominent counterexample contradicts that argument: the Umm Kulthum Orchestra, which for decades was the absolute benchmark for Arabic music and *tarab*, but never had a conductor on stage (*il-sitt*—"The Lady"—would never have tolerated it).

One widely adopted compromise solution is to have a senior musician act as a part-time conductor while continuing to perform on his or her instrument. This is especially popular with medium-size ensembles (6 to 12 people), in which a dedicated conductor is unnecessary (not to mention costly), but the ensemble may be too large to run itself and needs to be led by one person. The conductor-performer usually sits or stands on the side of the ensemble so as to see and be seen by every musician while performing this double duty. The same thing happens in rehearsals, where the conductor-performer wears both hats.

In the example of Umm Kulthum's ensemble, the conductor-performer was often the *qanun* player, who didn't even stand up and face the ensemble; instead he kept

sitting down and faced the public while he waived his hand up and signaled section starts. The first violinist is also often the conductor, since he or she can conveniently stand up and turn around to face the orchestra if needed. Conductors in Arabic music don't often use a stick, but can still manage to conduct by waving their hands or nodding their heads. In a video recording of the long-song "*qari'at al-finjan*" by Abdel Halim Hafez, the *mutrib* (principal vocalist) himself turns around, faces the orchestra, and conducts long instrumental sections.

Tuning an Ensemble

The word for tuning in many Arabic dialects is *duzan* (originally from Turkish *düzen*, meaning order, regularity.) The word *duzan* (conjugated in Arabic as the verb *dawzana*) was also extended to mean intonation or pitch. Other words in classical Arabic are sometimes used, such as *dabt* (controlling), *ta'dil* (adjusting or straightening), *taswiya* (leveling out), and *islah* (correcting or straightening). Given that the variety of instruments that participate in a contemporary Arabic ensemble are not all created equal from an intonation viewpoint, the exercise of tuning them together before a performance is not always straightforward (see chapters 1: Melodic Instruments, 2: Arabized Instruments, and 11: Tuning System for more explanation of these challenges).

Some instruments, such as the piano, the accordion and the *nay* family members, are left alone since they are not tunable (even though the piano is tunable, in practice it is treated as if its intonation is set in stone). The challenge then is tuning string instruments such as the '*ud*, *qanun*, violin, and *buzuq*, and wind instruments such as the trumpet, clarinet, flute, and saxophone, from a reference note.

If a piano or an accordion is available, it gives the rest of the ensemble a reference note to tune from. In practice, notes that match open strings on string instruments are preferred, such as D, G, or A. *Qanun*-s are much like pianos: they are tunable in theory, but in practice, with dozens of strings, it could take a *qanun* player half an hour to an hour to retune an entire *qanun*. So, in the absence of a hard, nontunable instrument, everybody tunes to the *qanun*, unless the ensemble is investing in a perfect tuning job for a recording session or an important concert.

Although the *nay* is not a tunable instrument, it is not used as a reference for the rest of the ensemble, for two reasons. First, its manufacturing may be imperfect and its pitch may be slightly off. Second, the *nay*'s pitch can shift up or down slightly depending on the mouth blowing technique and the ambient humidity. For this reason, it is preferable to make sure that the ensemble is as close as possible to a good

pitch reference such as the *qanun* or an electronic tuner and to have the *nay* player adjust his or her pitch to match that using lip and blowing techniques.

In the absence of a piano, accordion, or *qanun*, an electronic tuner or a pitch pipe is used to provide that starting reference note for string instruments. Once the reference has been chosen, the *‘ud*, violin, and *buzuq* need to tune to it. In practice these are the instruments that retune casually and frequently before every performance. Once the reference note is established, tunable wind instruments such as the flute, trumpet, saxophone, and clarinet are simply fine-tuned to the reference note.

After all instruments are tuned as best as they can be, the next step is agreeing on the exact intonation of a particular *maqam* scale. This includes cultural negotiations (e.g., playing Egyptian Rast vs. Syrian Rast) as well as technical negotiations (fine-tuning sensitive notes such as the quartertones to make sure every instrument sounds as close as possible to the *‘ud* and the violin). It would not be unusual for large ensembles with a wide variety of instruments to play a *maqam* scale a few times in order to achieve a broad consensus,³ in the same way that players in a large symphony orchestra spend a few minutes tuning to each other before performing.

³ At which point our former teacher Simon Shaheen, in the role of conductor, would emphatically announce, “Let us unify our intonation!”

5

ORNAMENTATION

ONE OF THE most recognizable and distinguishing features of Arabic music is ornamentation (*zakhrafa* in Arabic): the art of taking a plain melody and embellishing it. Ornaments stamp melodies with the Arabic music fashion of a certain time and place, along with the musician's personal style. Ornamentation reflects several facets of Arabic music: how an instrument or voice is used in Arabic music, what the prevailing Arabic music tradition sounds like, and how the musician's creativity and vision is expressed within that tradition.

Ornamentation is not optional; it is a skill and an art that a musician learns along with the basic technique for an instrument (including, and especially, the voice). A musician who played or sang a melody perfectly in terms of intonation and rhythm, but didn't ornament it, would sound like a student rehearsing.¹ Conversely, non-Arabic music ornamented according to the prevailing Arabic music fashion can be transformed to sound much more like Arabic music. This idea can be simply demonstrated by playing "Happy Birthday" on the *'ud*, with Arabic ornaments.

Ornamentation styles, phrases, and techniques are established as a tradition that is passed down orally, but individual musicians use that tradition as a vocabulary,

¹ Although, given the inseparability of melodic phrases—including those considered "ornamental"—from the intonation of the *maqam* and the rhythm of the music, it is challenging for even an experienced performer to play a melody in correct rhythm and intonation without any ornamentation.

picking and choosing elements that suit them, reworking the elements to be more individual, and by doing that, gently stretching the tradition and taking it a step forward.

Two musicians playing the same melody on the same instrument would not play it exactly the same way, note for note, although there would be a lot of commonality. Even the same musician playing the same melody night after night on the same instrument would not typically ornament it in exactly the same way.² The more the musician is technically skillful and creative, the more elaborate and innovative his or her ornamentation is.

The musician can control the level of ornamentation, from very light to very heavy. The appropriate level depends on the musical genre, but also on the instrumental arrangement; the bigger the ensemble, the less room there is for each instrument to ornament (that relationship is discussed in more detail in the “Heterophony” section). For example, in a violin section with a dozen violins, ornamentation is on the conservative side, and any ornaments that do occur are usually played in unison by the entire section. On the other hand, in a vocal or instrumental solo, a high level of ornamentation is required in order to make the melody a lot richer and to showcase the soloist’s artistry and technical mastery.

Although both ornamentation and improvisation are based on combining a tradition with the musician’s spontaneous creative input, they are very different in format. An improvisation (e.g., a *taqsim* or *mauwval*) is a musical interlude that features the musician as a soloist, whereas every musician ornaments as a matter of course, at the same time, throughout the course of a performance. Having said that, the richest use of ornamentation is when it is combined with improvisation. There, the musician (whether an instrumentalist or a singer) is composing simultaneously on two levels; one is the improvised basic melody line, and the other is the way that melody line is ornamented and delivered. In practice, when a musician is improvising, the line blurs between what part of the effort is spontaneous composition and what part is ornamentation of that composition. The musician’s mind performs a very complex exercise that delivers the end result as one product (see chapters 21: The *Taqsim* and 22: Vocal Improvisation).

Ornamentation Techniques

How does a musician alter a basic melody to ornament it? It all depends on the instrument performing that melody. Ornaments can be as simple as adding one or

² Nettl and Riddle articulated this in 1973, but it has been central to the Arab music aesthetic for centuries.

more grace notes before a note from the melody. In richer ornamentation styles, more notes are added to the basic melody to decorate it, by drawing from traditional melodic patterns, idioms, and short phrases that make up the ornamentation vocabulary for each instrument. Another popular ornamentation technique is syncopation, rephrasing the melody in a slightly different rhythm, or turning notes into triplets.

Each instrument dictates a certain approach to ornamentation (this is what Marcus calls “specific instrumental idiom”³). On fretless string instruments such as the *‘ud* and the violin, the musician can use vibrato, glissandos, and slurs to ornament. Tremolos are very popular on percussive string instruments such as the *qanun*, *‘ud*, and *buzuq*, as well as on the violin, while trills and glissandos are popular on wind instruments such as the *nay*. In addition to these general techniques, the vocabulary of ornamentation also includes a number of specific melodic patterns of embellishment that musicians learn by ear.

Emphasizing special notes in a *maqam* scale is an important part of ornamentation, and it can be achieved by playing notes more often, playing them longer, or playing them louder (see chapter 20: *Sayr* for a discussion of special notes in the *maqam*). Another very common emphasis technique is doubling up a note with its lower octave or alternating between a note and its lower octave. A third technique is droning. On a sustaining instrument (e.g., the *nay* or violin), droning means extending the note over many measures, with or without vibrato. On a percussive melodic instrument (e.g., the *‘ud*, the *qanun*, or the *buzuq*), droning means interleaving the melody with frequent occurrences of the drone or just playing a tremolo (called *rashsh* in Arabic, which literally means “spraying”) on the note for extended periods.

Although these techniques require technical proficiency on the instrument, they are the bread and butter of ornamentation, and any skilled musician should be able to execute them. The basic style of playing these ornamentations becomes cliché and marks a particular region and period of time, after which innovative musicians update the ornamentations and rework them into the next generation of clichés.

Ornamentation can go much further than technical embellishment, to the point where the musician assimilates the melody and to a certain extent reinterprets it. In these cases, ornamentation feels more like interpretation combined with improvisation.

³ Marcus (2007).

Variation Among Regions and Time Periods

Ornamentation can help define the music's region, just as an accent does for speech. Taking an instrument such as the *'ud*, we find that the Iraqi *'ud* school, the Egyptian *'ud* school, and the Saudi *'ud* school, for example, all have different ornamentation styles, and the region can often be guessed from listening to a performance with a decent level of ornamentation.

Jamil Bashir, Munir Bashir, and Naseer Shamma, for example, played the *'ud* with an Iraqi accent; Muhammad al-Qasabgi, Riyad al-Sunbati, George Michel, and Farid al-Atrash (despite the fact that he was originally Syrian) played the *'ud* with an Egyptian accent; and Abadi al-Johar and Talal al-Maddah played the *'ud* with a Saudi accent. Granted, the instruments that they used differed slightly in their manufacturing and timbre across the three regions, and other factors such as the local intonation of their *maqam* scales and their phrasing repertoire helped brand a style from a certain region, but ornamentation is one of the principal factors in bringing out regional differences.

Just as intonation varies with both the region and time period (see chapter 11: Tuning System), ornamentation also varies across both dimensions; it brands the time period of a recording just as clearly as the region. Embellishment patterns go in and out of style, and innovative musicians often try to develop their own sound through the use of new types of embellishment, which can quickly become a new fashion if the musician is popular enough. For example, the style of ornamentation on the violin changed noticeably from Sami al-Shawwa (early 20th century), to Ahmad al-Hifnawi and Aboud Abdel Al (mid-20th century), to Abdo Dagher (late 20th century).

Learning Ornamentation

Ornamentation is an art and a science and can only properly be learned through the oral tradition. While books on *'ud* technique abound, as do books and online references about Arabic *maqam* theory, there are very few, if any, published books on the art of ornamentation (e.g., one cannot purchase books titled “*Ud* Ornamentation for Beginners” or “Advanced *Qanun* Ornamentation Techniques”). While this shortage may appear to be a deficiency, there is a good reason for it: ornamentation is complex and individual; thus it is difficult to quantify in a static book.

The most effective way to learn ornamentation is orally, from a teacher, alongside instrumental technique, or by observing live performances and listening to

recordings. Musicians continue to learn and perfect their ornamentation skills as they evolve musically, picking up techniques and ideas from other musicians (past and present). As their technique advances, so does the complexity and finesse of their ornamentation.

It is said that imitation is the sincerest form of flattery, and nowhere is this truer than in the case of junior musicians imitating the ornamentation of more accomplished musicians. Indeed, some *‘ud* players can perform famous *‘ud taqsim* by Farid al-Atrash note for note and very closely copy his way of ornamenting and interpreting melodies. This is not in itself a bad investment, since the best way to learn the tradition, as a starting point, is by extensive and repetitive listening to the masters and imitating them. But an accomplished musician shies away from sounding like an exact replica (or worse, a poor replica) of a master. Instead, accomplished musicians mentally compile all their favorite influences and produce their own unique sounds.

Establishing New Ornamentation Traditions

Instruments that were more recently added to the Arabic ensemble, such as the piano, accordion, and electric guitar, came from other musical traditions with their own established (foreign) ornamentation techniques and aesthetics. However, by incorporating them into the Arabic ensemble or orchestra, Arabic musicians introduced a new Arabic ornamentation tradition that transformed these instruments from Western to Arabic (see chapter 2: Arabized Instruments).

The accordion used in Egyptian *raqs sharqi* (belly dance) or *baladi* musical genres is stylistically a totally different instrument than the accordion used in Italian, French, or German folk music (even if we ignore the added reeds that produce quartertones; see chapter 2). The piano played by Abdallah Chahine or Ziad Rahbani is stylistically a totally different instrument than the European piano (even if we ignore the added mechanics in Chahine’s piano that produced quartertones). The opening piano solo by Ziad Rahbani in “*shu hal-iyam*” is a very convincing *taqsim* in Maqam Nahawand, even though the piano was not mechanically altered or retuned in any way to suit Arabic *maqam* scales. Interestingly, the common piano ornamentation arrived at by most Arabic pianists sounds much like the *qanun* ornamentation, due to their obvious mechanical similarities.

The violin is used in many musical traditions across the world, from European classical music, to Scandinavian, Irish, and American fiddle music, to musical traditions of the Middle East, North Africa, and India. In every case, the same physical instrument is transformed by different techniques and styles of ornamentation.

The electric guitar used in Omar Khorshid's *taqasim* and in Umm Kulthum's recordings is stylistically an entirely different instrument than the one used in rock and roll music of the same era. Through his pioneering vision, Omar Khorshid almost singlehandedly created the "Arabic electric guitar" style by establishing a tradition for ornamenting it. What's more remarkable about Omar Khorshid is that he managed to achieve that without modifying the guitar to perform quartertones or changing the placement of the 12-tone equal-tempered frets. His guitar sounded Arabic by virtue of his ornamentation and phrasing, even though it was confined to the equal-tempered tuning system.

Similarly, three other Egyptian pioneers of Western instruments—Sami al-Babli on the trumpet, Magdi al-Husseini on the *org* (Arabic electric organ), and Samir Sourour on the saxophone—brought foreign instruments into Arabic music and established new ornamentation traditions for them.

The opposite effect can also occur: taking established Arabic instruments and stripping them of their traditional ornamentation traditions produces "foreign" instruments. It's possible for non-Arabic ensembles (e.g., jazz fusion ensembles) to include the *'ud* or the *riqq* in order to add an exotic ingredient to their sound. In such cases, the performers often don't try to adhere to the instrument's inherited stylistic tradition, but instead explore its technical possibilities without bias, in order to create a new sound. For example, world percussionist Glen Velez can take a traditional fish skin Egyptian *riqq* and play it with formidable ornamentation techniques, including ones that are totally foreign in the Arabic tradition, effectively turning it into a hybrid or foreign instrument.

Interestingly, ornamentation can transform the same instrument over and over, as in the case of an Arabic keyboard loaded with samples from different traditional Arabic instruments. The keyboard player's fingering technique with both the keys and the pitch bender changes, as dictated by the sampled instrument playing at the time. For example, ornamenting the *qanun* sound on a synthesizer requires a different technique than ornamenting the *nay* or the *mizmar* sound, in order to sound authentic and traditional.

Vocal Ornamentation

The human voice is the most powerful and versatile instrument as far as ornamentation is concerned, because of its enormous flexibility. Although the voice has a smaller pitch range than most instruments, it has a wider dynamic range, and vocalists can alter the timbre of the voice using a wide variety of techniques that vary the position of the lips, mouth, and throat. In a predominantly vocal tradition such as

Arabic music, vocalists have the greatest liberty to ornament because the voice is the center of attention and all the other instruments are there to support it.

The most common vocal ornamentation technique is adding accidental (often very short) notes to enrich the phrase. These accidentals are called *‘urab* in Arabic (pl. of *‘urba*, literally, “a slight lowering of pitch”) and showcase the singer’s vocal mastery and control. Introducing accidental notes that hint at *maqam* modulations is another technique that requires a good understanding of *maqam* theory and modulation pathways established by tradition.

Vocal improvisations are very often melismatic, meaning singers extend a single syllable while moving among several different notes in quick succession. In most cases, the syllable is a vowel, but certain consonants (most commonly the continuants *m*, *n*, and *l*) can be extended and improvised upon.

Sliding in and out of the rhythm (singing slightly slower, falling behind momentarily then catching up) is also a possible vocal ornamentation technique. Lebanese singer Fairouz frequently used that technique. In fact, in many of Fairouz’s songs, she sang at the correct speed, but often a split second behind the ensemble. This technique gave her style a mellow quality.

Major Arabic singers from the 1930s to 1950s, such as Umm Kulthum, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Marie Jubran (1911–1952), Leila Mourad, and Asmahan, possessed very intricate and complex vocal ornamentation techniques. These intricate techniques gradually started falling out of fashion in the 1960s and 1970s, and the delivery of the following generation of singers such as Abdel Halim Hafez, Sabah, Warda, and Farid al-Atrash was relatively less ornate.⁴

The changing ornamentation aesthetic can easily be tracked by following the career of one singer, Umm Kulthum, over a period of five decades. In her recordings from the 1960s and 1970s, her ornamentation was much more subdued than in her 1930s recordings, because she was keenly attuned to the fashion of the times. Unfortunately, the changing fashion also meant that the technical prerequisites for becoming a singer from the 1970s onward became substantially lower than they were in the Golden Age.

Repetition

Repetition (*tikrar* in Arabic) is a very common technique used by singers, involving singing a word or phrase over and over again to emphasize different interpretations.

⁴ At least by comparison; unfamiliar listeners may find their singing to be quite ornate by Western standards—but in comparison to Umm Kulthum or Abdel Wahab’s recordings of the 1930s, or singers of the previous generation, such as Abu al-‘Ila Muhammad, Abdel Hayy Hilmi, or Salama Hegazi, it is quite bare.

Through repetition, singers can express their feelings and the beauty of the melody and text, and they can display a variety of ornamentations or modulations. Ultimately, the use of repetition with variation is a really good vehicle to create *tarab* (musical pleasure) in listeners.

In Arabic music, the composed piece is a guideline or a template that a singer or improviser can change during a live performance, if he or she sees fit and if the occasion calls for it. The goal of creating *tarab*, by any means necessary, far supersedes the goal of representing a composition as faithfully as possible.

Syrian master vocalists Muhammad Khayri and Sabah Fakhri, for example, had very experienced ensembles that were prepared for any changes on stage and were constantly in a listening mode, alert and ready to follow the singer. They never ruled out the possibility of the singer repeating a phrase, or even sometimes an entire verse if he or she was in the mood for it.

Umm Kulthum was a master of repetition. In the middle of a long-song, when she was really warmed up, she would pick a phrase and repeat it dozens of times, each time with a slightly different rendition. The melodic skeleton would be the same every time, but the ornamentation would be more and more varied. Far from being bored with the repetition, her public would delight in hearing her different deliveries of the same phrase. This repetition falls under a wider practice called *tafrīd* (literally, performing alone), when a performer improvises using the current section's lyrics and melody as a starting point.

In many of Umm Kulthum's live performances, the orchestra often didn't know at the end of one line (or phrase) if she was going to repeat it or move on to the next line. In many of her recordings, there's often a short moment of hesitation while the orchestra waits for her next syllable to lead the way for them. In some recordings, part of the ensemble would start to play the next phrase, only to change course one or two notes later, after realizing that she had decided to embark on another repetition.

Of course, the technique of repetition is not confined to vocalists; instrumentalists can equally use it. Many Umm Kulthum songs have a short precomposed solo on the violin or the *qanun* consisting of a mere few measures at the start of a section. With every repetition of the whole section, the short solo is repeated and ornamented differently.

In a live recording of Abdel Halim Hafez's "*qari'at al-finjan*," Arabic electric organ (*org*) players Magdi al-Husseini and Hani Mehanna, and *riqq* player Hassan Anwar exchange very short musical lines in a call-and-response fashion. They repeat that section over a dozen times and ornament their parts differently in each repetition. The audience at that concert raved about the variety introduced by repetition.

Heterophony

Heterophony (from the Greek, meaning “different sounds”) is the effect created when multiple instruments play the same basic melody but don’t play together in perfect unison (note for note). Since Arabic music is monophonic, what makes each melodic line differ slightly is the ornamentation. So heterophony, in the Arab context, means simultaneous multiple ornamentation (different ornamentation is performed simultaneously on the same melody by different musicians on different instruments). As such, heterophony fits somewhere between monophony (one melody on all instruments) and polyphony (multiple melodies on one or more instruments).

Each instrument has its timbre, tonal range, technical capabilities, and quintessential ornaments and clichés, as well as a body of tradition and repertoire that backs it up. All these factors guide the range of options available to the musician during heterophony. Not only does each instrument lend itself to different ornamentation techniques and styles, as we have said; in addition, each musician has a natural tendency to ornament differently based on his or her preferred aesthetic vision, experience, and technical abilities. Musicians might exercise some discretion about following the exact rhythm, since syncopating or playing some phrases slightly behind the beat is also considered a type of ornamentation. The result is an imperfect unison effect that adds a very recognizable quality and richness to Arabic music.

Heterophony is most clearly heard during *tarjama* (literally “translation”; see chapter 22: Vocal Improvisation), a technique in which melodic instrument players support a vocal improvisation by reiterating or summarizing every vocal phrase on their instruments. In that case, musicians don’t know what phrases they will be playing ahead of time, and instead take their cues from the singer’s last phrase. In their rush to simultaneously interpret that phrase in their own personal style on different instruments, they produce very obvious heterophony.

Heterophony can also be clearly heard in instrumental pieces in which multiple melodic instrument musicians are performing a composed melody in near unison. Of course, not every instrumental piece will necessarily result in heterophony, because heterophony is an aesthetic decision. The larger the ensemble, the more they will shy away from heterophony because of the potential of sounding too chaotic. The extent of heterophony used in a performance, like many other features of Arabic music, is a balancing act and a judgment call in the context of the guiding tradition and the aesthetic norms of the time and place where the music is being performed.

While heterophony may sound disorderly to the untrained ear (especially to a listener used to hearing Western classical music), it is in fact largely confined within aesthetic boundaries and is the result of a conscious decision to present a richer version

of the composed piece rather than performing it in strict unison. Moreover, the near absence of harmony and polyphony in Arabic music certainly leaves plenty of mental space for listeners to process and enjoy the multiple threads of ornamentation.

Today, however, there is a counter opinion, held by some Arabic composers, arrangers, and conductors, that heterophony is too outdated and that Arabic music would sound better if it were “tighter.” Some conductors go as far as requiring their violin sections to bow in sync to ensure perfect unison. In general, this school of thought became more prevalent in Arabic music starting in the second half of the 20th century, and with it came a move to reduce heavy ornamentation. As a result, it’s rare to hear today the level of heterophony found in recordings of the 1930s.

Notating Ornamentation

In theory, ornaments can be notated⁵ to the extent that music notation artifacts allow. In practice, however, very few ornaments are notated because notating ornaments in their full detail would quickly become unreadable. Another reason for not notating ornaments is that they are different for different instruments; this means notating ornaments would either only cover only one possible instrument or would require providing alternate versions for different instruments, which is hugely impractical.

But the more fundamental reason for not notating ornaments is cultural, not technical: ornaments are subjective and left up to the musician, which means the composer rarely wants to control that in advance. Ornamentation follows the style of the time period and region, and capturing that in a musical score would be far too restrictive and would quickly become outdated. In addition, many traditional pieces were not notated at the time they were composed and were passed down orally, so their composer could not have prescribed ornaments in writing.

The issue of separating the raw or basic melody from the ornamentation comes into play when transcribing a piece of music from a recording (this is discussed in detail in chapter 12: Notation). In that case, the transcriber has to make a judgment call about what constitutes ornamentation in order to distill the melody down to its bare-bones form. For this reason, multiple transcriptions based on one recording often exhibit minor discrepancies, since it would be almost impossible for two transcribers to produce the same score note for note. Even when several singers perform the same song over a period of time, the different performances or recordings typically exhibit differences. For example, Zakariyya Ahmad’s famous *dawr* “*inta fahim*” was recorded with his voice, and later by Lebanese singer Su’ad Muhammad. Each

⁵ See chapter 12: Notation for further discussion.

version is slightly different, not only because of differences in style and interpretation by different singers, but also because of different choices in terms of repetitions, melodic variations, and *tafrid*. Depending on which one is transcribed, the end result will be slightly different.

Composers or transcribers might explicitly notate ornaments when these are inseparable from the composed music itself; that is, when ornaments are actually composed with and for the melody. Typically, the level of ornamentation notated is minimal and may include some specific ornaments by specific instruments notated on a multi-instrument musical score. This approach to performing Arabic music, by adhering closely to a score, started in the mid-20th century and is borrowed primarily from Western classical music. When this approach is adopted, musicians are expected to follow notated music as closely as possible and keep their ornamentations to a minimum.

Finally, when the goal of notation is to faithfully document a piece in order to preserve it, analyze it, or teach it exactly as is, no distinction needs to be made between ornamentation and the basic melody, and the piece can be notated with its exact details intact.

6

RHYTHM

RHYTHM IN ARABIC music is displayed in two main forms: music using cyclical rhythmic patterns, and unmetered vocal/instrumental improvisations (melodic improvisations taking place in the absence of a regular beat, which still possess strong internal phrasing rhythms; see chapter 21: The *Taqsim*). This chapter focuses on the use of cyclical rhythmic patterns, known in the West as “meter.” While rhythm is not formally part of the Arabic Maqam framework, it is a principal component of Arabic music, and the combination of Arabic *maqamat* and Arabic rhythms is what gives Arabic music its full character (along with lyrics).

The word for rhythm in Arabic is *iqāʿ* (pronounced “ee-KAH”), plural *iqāʿāt* (from the verb *waqaʿa*, to fall/occur; literally making the beats fall). Another word for rhythm is *wazn* (literally, “weight”), and as such the word *mawzun* indicates a metered performance. The word *iqāʿ* is also used to describe a rhythmic cycle (rhythmic pattern). Although most Arabic music references in English informally use the general word “rhythm” to denote a rhythmic cycle, this book uses the more accurate Arabic word *iqāʿ*.

The concept of an *iqāʿ* with its own identity also exists in Turkish music, where it is called *usul* (the Turkish word *usul* is originally an Arabic plural word that literally means “origins” but in practice means “correct/appropriate behavior”). As one would expect from their shared history, many *iqāʿāt* used in Arabic music today are

original Turkish/Ottoman *usul* or variations thereof, and some Arabic references still use the archaic word *usul* to denote an *iqāʿ*.

Arabic *iqāʿat* performed today are very diverse, given the large geographical spread of the Arab world, which includes the broad regions of the Middle East (*al-sharq*), the Arab Gulf (*al-khalij*), and North Africa (*al-maghrib*). They are the result of accumulating indigenous *iqāʿat* as well as foreign ones. The influence of the Turkish/Ottoman neighboring tradition on Arabic *iqāʿat* is particularly strong (as it is in the *maqam* tradition), which is why many Turkish *iqāʿat*, for example Çifte Telli, Aksak, Curcuna, and Yürük Semai,¹ are still used in Arabic music today. Other *iqāʿat* with Persian origins and names, such as Nawakht and Khosh Rang, are also used today in Arabic music.

Arabic *iqāʿat* come in a large variety of time signatures, both odd and even, from the simple $\frac{2}{4}$, $\frac{4}{4}$, and $\frac{8}{4}$ to the more complex $\frac{5}{8}$, $\frac{6}{8}$, $\frac{7}{8}$, $\frac{8}{8}$, $\frac{9}{8}$, $\frac{10}{8}$, $\frac{11}{8}$, $\frac{13}{8}$, $\frac{14}{8}$, $\frac{17}{8}$, and longer. The smaller time signatures are mostly used in widespread genres such as pop and folk music, while the higher time signatures (especially $\frac{7}{8}$ and above) are mostly used by classical vocal genres (e.g., the *muwashshah* form) and instrumental genres (e.g., the *bashraf* and *samaʿi* forms). Odd-numbered time signatures are sometimes described in Arabic using the word *aʿraj* (limping).

Building Blocks

Arabic *iqāʿat* have a concise and prominent skeleton made of two basic building blocks or primary sounds: *dum* and *tak*.² The words *dum* and *tak* are onomatopoeias, derived from the actual sound produced on a typical membranophone such as the Arabic *tabla* (goblet-shaped drum) or the *daff* (frame drum). *Dum* is a general name for the bassy and sustained sound produced by hitting the drum skin closer to the center, while *tak* is a general name for the sharp and dry sound produced by hitting the side of the skin along the rim. On a Western drum kit, *dum* would be the sound of the bass drum, while *tak* would be the sound of the snare drum.

Arabic *iqāʿat* can be defined primarily using these two building blocks alone, by describing their sequence and timing in a prototypal single measure.³ Although a typical percussion instrument may have more than one variety of *dum* and *tak*

¹ For the remainder of this book, the Turkish spelling of Çifte Telli and Yürük Semai is simplified to Ciftetelli and Yuruk Semai.

² The correct Arabic transliteration for *dum* and *tak* is *dumm* and *takk*; however, this book uses the simpler spellings (*dum* and *tak*) in order to be consistent with the vast majority of published English references.

³ The prototypal rhythmic measure of an *iqāʿ* works very much like a *clave* pattern in Afro-Cuban music.

sounds, this does not change the makeup of the *iqā'*, as the vocabulary used to define the *dum* and the *tak* sounds is only loosely based on the actual timbre produced; *dum* and *tak* are generic/conceptual sounds and are not specific to one percussion instrument.

The *dum* and *tak* strokes that define an Arabic *iqā'*'s prototypical measure are not all necessarily equal in volume; some can be slightly more accented than others. For example, when two *dum*-s occur in succession (such as in the $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqā' Baladi), the second *dum* may be subtly more accented than the first. Another example is the $\frac{8}{8}$ Iqā' Bambi, in which the third *dum* is more accented than the first two. Similarly, when two *tak*-s occur in quick succession, the first may be subtly more accented than the second (such as in the $\frac{2}{4}$ Iqā' Malfuf or the $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqā' Maqsum), or the second may be more subtly accented (such as in the Jurjina $\frac{10}{8}$ *iqā'*). This aspect of *iqā'at* cannot be easily notated, and in Arabic music it is simply learned aurally, through careful listening and imitation.

Clapping and Vocalizing

While *iqā'at* are usually taught directly on a percussion instrument, they are also commonly communicated orally by vocalizing⁴ the *dum* and *tak* sounds in their actual tempo. This is very similar to the language used to communicate Indian *tabla* rhythms (known as *taal*). For example, the ubiquitous $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqā' Maqsum is vocalized by speaking the following phrase at constant speed:

dum tak (pause) tak dum (pause) tak (pause)

where pauses are rests (brief silences).

An *iqā'*'s skeleton can also be played on a melodic instrument (preferably a percussive one, such as the *qanun*, the *'ud*, or the violin played pizzicato) as a short and repetitive melodic line, in the manner of a guitar riff in pop music, an ostinato in classical music, or a vamp in jazz. A very common practice is to choose two notes in a *maqam* scale, using the lower-pitched note to play the *dum* and the higher-pitched note to play the *tak*. *Iqā'at* played on melodic instruments are described in more detail in chapter 10: Arrangement.

An *iqā'*'s skeleton can also be clapped, with the palm of the dominant hand hitting the other palm resting horizontally and facing up, to play the *dum* sound, then

⁴ Vocalizing Arabic *iqā'at* is explored in detail by al-Saqqa (2005).

using the back of the dominant hand to play the *tak* sound. Clapping the rhythm is a very common technique to aid singers in learning a vocal piece, especially in a music lesson or a rehearsal.

Vocalizing Rests

With longer or slower *iqāʿat*, it becomes necessary to mark rests (the space between *dum*-s and *tak*-s) with their own generic sound. Without that, vocalizing the *iqāʿ* would involve long pauses where rests exist, making it harder for the listener to accurately count the number of rests.

Rests are called *sakta* in Arabic (a brief silence). To vocalize rests, percussionists use the word *iss* (or alternatively, *ess*), which is another onomatopoeia derived from the sound of a *riqq* (handheld Arabic tambourine) cymbal. On a Western drum kit, the *iss* sound is the filling played on the hi-hat. *Iss*-es usually fall on eighth notes when a sparse level of filling is desired, while in a busier level of filling *iss*-es could fall on sixteenth or thirty-second notes.

Using the “*iss*” notes, the ١٩ Iqāʿ Samaʿi Thaḳil (of Turkish/Ottoman origin) can be vocalized by reading the following at constant pace:

dum iss iss tak iss dum dum tak iss iss

Shorthand Notation

The vocabulary to vocalize *dum*-s, *tak*-s, and *iss*-es can also be used to quickly transcribe an *iqāʿ* using written characters when staff notation is not practical (e.g., when using a computer keyboard). Over the last few decades, musicians who wished to type Arabic *iqāʿat* in emails, text messages, or web pages developed a shorthand notation using only characters available on an English keyboard: D/d for *dum*, T/t for *tak*, and “–” for *iss*. In this notation system, all letters have the same time duration. This shorthand notation system is very informal, as it is not governed by any strict standards, and is certainly not unique to Arabic music; it is frequently used to describe Turkish rhythms as well. Following is Iqāʿ Samaʿi Thaḳil again, this time using shorthand notation:

D – – T – DDT – –

The shorthand notation system can be more elaborate and can use the uppercase/lowercase differentiation to indicate the volume (accent) of a note. It can also include other letters to represent ornamental sounds on a particular percussion instrument

(e.g., R/r for “*ra*” and K/k for “*ka*” sounds on a tabla). Following is Iqa‘ Maqsum using a more detailed shorthand notation:

DT rk T D rk T tk (*pronounced dum tak raka tak dum raka tak taka*)

Notating Iqa‘at

Arabic *iqa‘at* are notated in a skeletal, unembellished form, with the *dum*-s and *tak*-s that define them shown in a single prototypical measure. Arabic *iqa‘at* notation is not as standardized as melodic notation is, and as such few conventions exist. The most established convention, found in most Arabic music theory textbooks and comprehensive *muwashshahat* references, uses a prototypical measure with a staff made of a single line, and musical notes for the *dum* and *tak* sounds.

By convention, the *dum* note’s stem points up like a *d*, while the *tak* note has its stem pointing down like a *p*. (In some cases, the opposite convention has been used, reversing the direction of the *dum* and *tak* stems.) The prototypical *iqa‘* measure includes the name of the *iqa‘* and its time signature (called *mizan* in Arabic). Some notated rhythms also include the letters *D* and *T* below each note to eliminate any ambiguity (a hyphen or the letter “s” is used for rests). Figure 6.1 shows how the ubiquitous $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqa‘ Maqsum is notated.



FIGURE 6.1 Notation of the $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqa‘ Maqsum.

In some cases (as in figure 6.1), the prototypical measure includes partitions using vertical dotted lines. The purpose of the partitions is to separate rhythmic syllables (or convenient mental divisions) within the measure, for clarity and ease of memorization. Rhythmic syllables are usually two or three beats long, and as such most complex *iqa‘at* can be very conveniently reduced to a combination of twos and threes. Syllabic partitioning is especially helpful for longer *iqa‘at*, although it may be used even with short ones. In the language of simple rhythmic syllables, the Dawr Hindi $\frac{3}{8}$ *iqa‘* is partitioned as 3-2-2, and the Sama‘i Thaql $\frac{10}{8}$ *iqa‘* is partitioned as 3-2-2-3.

The time value (duration) of the *dum* and *tak* notes is usually equal to the time signature’s denominator. For example, the Dawr Hindi $\frac{3}{8}$ *iqa‘* is notated using eighth notes and rests, and the Masmudi Kabir $\frac{8}{4}$ *iqa‘* is notated using quarter notes and rests. Some *dum* and *tak* notes can also be smaller than the time signature’s denominator, in order to notate faster rhythmic details or syncopations, or to reflect ornamentation

on a skeletal *iqāʿ*. For example, the Maqsum $\frac{2}{4}$ is notated using eighth notes and rests, and the Ciftetelli $\frac{8}{4}$ *iqāʿ* is notated using a combination of quarter and eighth notes and rests (see chapter 7: A Sampling of Arabic *Iqāʿat* for detailed notations).

There is more than one possible style for notating rests. One is to stretch each *dum/tak* note all the way to the next one, so as not to have any rests. The other extreme would be to have the smallest possible duration for the *dum/tak* notes so as to clearly show the rests (which in practice are filled in with more *tak*-s and *iss*-es). A range of notation possibilities exists for rests between these two extremes. Another issue in notating rests is whether to consolidate them into the longest possible time value or to break them into separate, smaller units. Both approaches are used, with the second approach adding more clarity to the practice of filling in rests with individual *tak*-s, *iss*-es, and ornaments. In any case, the notated *dum*-s, *tak*-s, or rests never cross the partitions (vertical dotted lines.) Figure 6.2 shows two possible styles for notating the Karachi ($\frac{2}{4}$) *iqāʿ*.



FIGURE 6.2 Two styles of notating the $\frac{2}{4}$ Iqāʿ Karachi.

Some *iqāʿat* have more than one form performed in the repertoire. For example, the $\frac{9}{8}$ Iqāʿ Aqsaq may have either a single *dum* or a double *dum* in the middle of its measure. The $\frac{13}{8}$ Iqāʿ Murabbaʿ is often performed with a syncopated *tak* after its second *dum*, to the point where this ornament has become part and parcel of its basic skeleton. Whether or not one form is considered the original and the other form a variation or an ornamentation of the first is largely an academic question; in practice, different references choose one over the other, with some references showing multiple forms. Figure 6.3 shows the two basic forms of Iqāʿ Aqsaq.

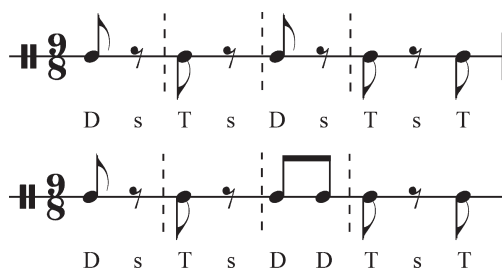


FIGURE 6.3 The two basic forms of the $\frac{9}{8}$ Iqāʿ Aqsaq.

Notating ornamentation in addition to the skeletal *dum*-s and *tak*-s in the prototypical measure is not common and is largely confined to the academic and teaching world (e.g., Arabic percussion instructional books), for the same reason that melodic ornaments are not notated in detail: it would be impractical and confining. The next two sections (“Interpreting *Iqa’at*” and “Ornamenting *Iqa’at*”) explain how percussionists play far more than the notated *iqa’* as a matter of course, as the notated *iqa’* is nothing but a skeleton.

When dealing with notated music, in the vast majority of cases only the names of the *iqa’at* used throughout a piece are printed above the staff. This is usually sufficient since percussionists have a wide discretion to interpret and ornament the rhythm, to mix (layer) different *iqa’at* together, or to modulate to new *iqa’at*. In practice, the *iqa’* name is treated as a guide, and how much the percussionists adhere to it depends on how formal the performance is.

In rare cases, the percussion instrument has its own staff in a musical score. This would happen if the composer or arranger uses an unusual *iqa’* or an *iqa’* composed specifically for that piece or requires the *iqa’* to be performed exactly as notated. Having a percussion staff in a musical score also helps melodic instrumentalists follow the *iqa’* more closely, especially if their own instruments have long pauses. In other equally rare cases, the composer or arranger may use a very short rhythmic phrase performed on percussion instruments to delineate sections, or as an ornament. These would have to be notated, as they practically become part of the composed melody, not the rhythm.

Interpreting *Iqa’at*

While Arabic *iqa’at* are defined very minimally, they are much richer and more complex when performed. Percussionists rarely play the basic skeleton of an *iqa’*, unless they’re in a music lesson or are in the role of backup percussionist (or when they open a song/piece with two measures of only percussion). Playing a bare-bones *iqa’* is very unusual and produces a dramatic effect, one that gets exploited a lot in Sufi music, in which singers are only accompanied with a large frame drum section playing exactly the skeletal *iqa’* in unison.

More commonly, percussionists fill in the *iqa’* skeleton with much more detail and transform it into a real-life *iqa’* that is consistent with the aesthetics of the genre being performed and that represents the musical tradition of a time and place. El-Mallah expresses this idea succinctly: “The percussionist always feels free in his

interpretation of the *iqāʿat*, that is to say, he merely feels obligated to the oral tradition in which he grew up.”⁵

This process (called *tashkil*⁶ in Arabic, literally “giving shape/form”) could be described as a constant interpretation that is very much aware of the context, or it could also be viewed as elaborate ornamentation and embellishment. And as with all ornamentation, the process varies with the instrument used and relies a great deal on the technique and artistry of the percussionist. It also depends on the formality of the performance and the genre of music performed. For example, ornamenting on the *riqq* for a *raqs sharqi* (belly dance) piece is markedly different from ornamenting on the *riqq* for a *tarab* (traditional vocal repertoire) piece. Finally, rhythmic ornamentation is also tailored to suit the performance of melodic instruments in the ensemble, as the percussionists and the melodic instrumentalists have what can be described as an ongoing musical conversation.

Percussionists need to exercise judgment in order to create a result that best suits the genre that they are accompanying. Different musical genres require a different choice of percussion instruments, as well as different ornamentation aesthetics. In practice, this task is somewhat easier than it seems, because a large body of communal vocabulary already exists for every genre, and percussionists use that as their starting point. Within these established traditions, every percussionist develops his or her own personal vocabulary that they recycle and gradually build on. For this reason, ornamentation in percussion is not exactly the same as a constant improvisation; it’s more like a constant live reinterpretation of the bread-and-butter established permutations of a possible *iqāʿ*, plus a few personal and original ones.

Veteran Lebanese percussionist Michel Merhej Baklout recounts that during a recording session for Lebanese singer Fairouz in which he played the *riqq*, he approached the composer/arranger Philemon Wehbe to ask him what *iqāʿ* he would like for a particular section. Wehbe replied: “You and Setrak [Sarkissian, the *tabla* player] are *asatidha* [sing. *ustadh*, teacher or highly educated person], I’m not going to tell you what to play.”⁷

While developing the *iqāʿ* during a performance, the percussionist also attempts to delineate a piece into sections, especially if the *iqāʿ* itself does not change throughout the piece. Verses are often ornamented more moderately than choruses,

⁵ El-Mallah (1997).

⁶ The word *tashkil* is borrowed from the fields of Arabic language and calligraphy where it refers to putting vowels on words (in the form of small accents) or writing/adding the vowels, dots, and other symbols after writing the skeleton of the word. Most Arabic scripts rely on *tashkil* for ornamentation and filling voids to create beautiful geometric shapes (Taoufiq Ben Amor, conversation with the author, 2018).

⁷ Conversation with the author, 2005.

instrumental sections more richly than vocal sections, and a repetition of a section more richly than the first instance. What often ends up happening is that the percussionist ornaments in blocks of four or eight measures in one style, then moves on to another style to reduce monotony. Even when a piece does not change melodically (e.g., a very long *mawwal* performed with the same *iqā'*), the percussionist may progressively go from a simple to a richer rendering of the same *iqā'* to avoid monotony and may mark important *maqam* modulations by changing or enriching the *iqā'*.

Ornamenting *Iqā'at*

Percussionists usually ornament by adding notes to the bare-bones *iqā'* (e.g., grace notes, flams,⁸ or triplets). The idea is to use rests and smaller subdivisions of the *iqā'* (usually eighth or sixteenth notes) to add ornaments made up of variations on the principal *dum* and *tak*. The *dum* and *tak* sounds themselves can also be used as fillers, as long as the accent is on the principal *dum* and *tak* notes defined in the skeleton of the *iqā'*.

Another ornamentation strategy is omission, by skipping expected *dum* and *tak* notes (from the skeleton) and replacing them with alternate sounds. Skipping an expected *dum*, for example, has a dramatic effect and creates tension that gets released in the next measure when the *dum* returns to the beat.

The vocabulary of rhythmic fillers is rich and depends a lot on the sounds that can be produced on a given percussion instrument. Any sound that is different than the main *dum* and *tak* can be used where an *iss* note falls. On a drum kit, this would be like using the different toms or hitting a rim shot on the snare drum. In general, Arabic percussion instruments have one *dum* sound and a multitude of choices for a *tak* sound. Instruments with cymbals (like the *riqq*) also offer a wide array of cymbal-based sounds to ornament with.

Unique sounds in the palette of an instrument often have names that are simple and informal onomatopoeias used to “speak” the ornamented *iqā'*. For example, the Arabic *tabla* can produce varieties of *tak*-s called *rak*, *ka*, and *sak*. These can be aggregated together to create patterns such as *ra-ka-ta-ka*. Some *riqq tak* varieties blended with cymbals are called *tish* and *kish*, while dry *tak*-s (without cymbals) are called *ka* and *trak* (as the name suggests, *trak* involves a flam). These sounds often vary depending on the player’s technique and aesthetic preferences.

⁸ In drumming, a flam is an ornamental stroke played immediately before another stroke so as to produce a thicker sound, in a way similar to a grace note in melodic ornamentation. In Arabic music, flams are usually used to ornament *tak*-s, resulting in the sound “*trak*.”

Timing Subtleties

Until the 20th century, Arabic *iqā'at* and their ornamentation were mostly transmitted orally, which allowed them to be passed on from percussionist to percussionist with a great level of detail. One aspect of rhythm that is best transmitted by ear (more precisely than with any notation artifact) is timing. Arabic *iqā'at* (like so many rhythmic traditions of the world) do not always adhere to the regular beats of a metronome, which divides each measure into equal subdivisions of quarter, eighth, sixteenth, or thirty-second notes. Instead, many *iqā'at* include beats that regularly fall a very subtle instant before or after the (hypothetical) metronome beat.

One very common example of timing subtlety is the Egyptian $\frac{2}{4}$ Iqa' Sa'idi, in which the first *tak* is played slightly earlier than its notated version. That has the effect of adding a sense of urgency and an extra kick to the rhythm.

Iqa' Ayyub experiences a timing shift as its tempo becomes progressively faster (this typically happens in Sufi *dhikr* ceremonies). The ornamented form of Ayyub notated in figure 6.4 shows a customary additional *tak* in the first half of the measure. When Ayyub speeds up, that *tak* is played slightly later, nearer to the second *dum*, to the point of almost sounding like a flam and featuring the second *dum* alone. This characteristic⁹ of Ayyub is shown in figure 6.5.



FIGURE 6.4 Normal-speed Iqa' Ayyub, with an added first *tak* as ornamentation.



FIGURE 6.5 The first *tak* in Iqa' Ayyub played slightly later as it speeds up.

The Wahda ($\frac{1}{4}$) and the Malfuf ($\frac{2}{4}$) *iqā'at* have the same relative rhythmic intervals when notated (with Wahda being twice as long as Malfuf), but when it comes to performing them with a traditional feel, a fast Wahda's timing is subtly different from

⁹ This notation is corroborated by Rashid Sabbagh in his booklet "*al-Iqā'at al-Sharqiyya*" (Eastern *Iqā'at*), for which we have no date or country of origin.

a slow Malfuf's, as Wahda's *tak*-s fall slightly later than their notated version, while Malfuf's *tak*-s fall slightly sooner. In Wahda, which is predominantly used for slow and highly ornamented vocal sections, this has the effect of opening up the measure and not rushing it, while Malfuf's timing gives it a feeling of added urgency and liveliness.

The Maqsum ($\frac{4}{4}$) and Fallahi ($\frac{2}{4}$) *iqā'at* also have the same rhythmic intervals when notated (with Maqsum being twice as long as Fallahi), but their timing is subtly different, as the first *tak* in Fallahi falls slightly earlier than it does in Maqsum, if they were to be compared at the same tempo. This again gives Fallahi a rapid feeling that supplements its faster tempo.

Such timing subtleties are part and parcel of an *iqā'*'s signature and are perceived by listeners, even if unconsciously. Omitting them and playing the *iqā'* exactly as notated would take away greatly from the rhythmic character and performance feel of Arabic rhythms. On the other hand, notating these minute timing subtleties (by resorting to much smaller subdivisions of a measure or by using extra symbols) would be prohibitively complex and impractical to read. It might also be inaccurate, since such timing subtleties may vary depending on performance and cannot be committed to a constant value.

Managing Tempo

Arabic music from the Golden Age does not treat tempo (the speed of a rhythm) as a constant; instead, different sections of a piece or suite might require small stylistic variations in tempo.

An example from the instrumental repertoire is the *samā'i* form, in which the first repetition of the last *taslim* (melodic refrain) is played slower than the remainder of the piece, and the second repetition is played much faster, only to come to a very slow ending that drags the very last measure all the way to a full stop.

Instrumental pieces with multiple sections are often composed and arranged with slightly different tempos (and possibly different *iqā'at*) in different sections. The *raqs sharqi* instrumental piece “*aziza*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab, for example, introduces a new section in Maqam 'Ajam toward the end, with a noticeable slowing down of the tempo; the original tempo resumes when the piece goes back to the refrain section. Another instrumental by Abdel Wahab, “*ibn il-balad*,” slows down its tempo when transitioning from Iqā' Malfuf to Iqā' Wahda wi Nuss, signaling the start of a section in Maqam Saba. The technical term for slowing down the tempo in order to mark the introduction of a new section is *tasdir* (literally, “to preface”), a practice first defined in music theory writings of the Abbasid period.¹⁰

¹⁰ Sawā (2009).

Other pieces speed up at the end, as is often the case in the *raqs sharqi* repertoire, especially when the last section is repeated two or three times; in that case, each repetition involves a gradual increase in speed.

Managing the tempo in a vocal piece from the *tarab* repertoire (e.g., a *dawr* or a long-song) is more complex. In long vocal pieces, the tempo tends to be slightly faster in instrumental sections and slower in vocal sections, especially when the *mutrib/mutriba* (the vocalist in the *tarab* genre) is singing over $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqa' Wahda. Wahda (which literally means "one" in Arabic, named after its single *dum* per measure) is the best-suited *iqa'* for slow vocal sections that are rich in repetition and ornamentation (including melismata) because it is the sparsest and least confining *iqa'* for a singer. During those sections, the *mutrib/mutriba* leads the tempo, and the percussion section (with the *riqq* player at the helm) follows and in turn leads the ensemble.

The *riqq* player must make sure that the ensemble and the singer all perform together, and that transitions between sections are smoothly executed and appropriately signaled ahead of time. For this reason, being a *riqq* player in the vocal repertoire requires the additional skill of following the singer's every syllable and adjusting the tempo accordingly, as well as thorough memorization of the melody and lyrics being performed. The more experienced the ensemble, and the more they know the piece performed and the singer, the more smoothly they can manage these changes in tempo as a unit.

Rhythmic Modulation

Rhythmic modulation is the very common practice of playing a different but related *iqa'* instead of the ongoing (or composed) *iqa'*, for a brief period of time. For a rhythmic modulation to be pleasant and successful, the listener must still be aware of the primary *iqa'* during the modulation; otherwise the new *iqa'* would be an *iqa'* change, not a modulation.

A good rhythmic modulation would be brief, typically on the order of four to eight measures, long enough to catch the listeners' attention but short enough to keep them aware of the starting *iqa'*. When multiple percussionists are collaborating, the modulation can be undertaken by a single player who stands out (contributing to rhythmic heterophony), or by multiple players.

The most common rhythmic modulation would be to layer or replace an *iqa'* with one that is related to it. Typically, a number of measures in one *iqa'* are replaced with a number of measures in another. The most straightforward example is replacing the original *iqa'* with another one that has the same time signature, for example replacing Malfuf ($\frac{2}{4}$) with Karachi or Ayyub (also $\frac{2}{4}$), a very popular modulation in

Aleppan arrangements. Another example is modulating among Maqsum, Baladi, Wahda, Zaffa, and Hacha', all in $\frac{4}{4}$. Having the old and the new *iqa'at* share the same time signature is not an absolute requirement but rather a useful rule of thumb, one that's very similar to the widespread melodic practice of modulating between two *ajnas* of the same size.

More complex modulations involve two *iqa'at* with different time signatures; in that case a number of new measures replace a different number of old measures. A very common example is replacing a measure of Maqsum ($\frac{4}{4}$) with two measures of Malfuf ($\frac{2}{4}$) or Karachi ($\frac{2}{4}$). Another example is replacing one measure of Masmudi Kabir ($\frac{8}{4}$) or Ciftetelli ($\frac{8}{4}$) with two measures of Maqsum ($\frac{4}{4}$) or Wahda ($\frac{4}{4}$).

A far more complex rhythmic modulation would be to replace one *iqa'* measure of a given time signature with another *iqa'* measure of a different time signature but of the same duration (i.e., starting and ending together). This means that one version's tempo will be different than the other version. An example of this type of modulation is replacing one measure of Jurjina ($\frac{19}{8}$) with one measure of Yuruk Semai ($\frac{8}{8}$). For that to work, the Yuruk Semai modulation would have to slow down the tempo to run concurrently with one Jurjina measure.

Rhythmic Heterophony

Heterophony is the sound that results from multiple instruments playing essentially the same music without playing in unison. In rhythm, this is achieved when every percussionist ornaments and/or modulates individually, while listening to each other and to melodic instruments and keeping the conversation ongoing among them. While heterophony exists to varying degrees in the melodic world of Arabic music, it is the norm in the rhythmic world.

As in the melodic instrument world, the level of heterophony increases with the diversity of instruments used in the rhythm section, as each instrument has its unique vocabulary for ornamentation. But what really promotes heterophony in the rhythm section is the fact that each percussionist has great flexibility in his or her individual interpretation (*tashkil*) of the *iqa'* from its skeletal version. This means that percussionists are in constant ornamentation mode as a matter of course. Indeed, in most genres it is undesirable for them to play in unison; instead, they exploit available opportunities for intertwining their ornamented *iqa'at* together.

Pleasing heterophony requires experience, careful listening, and the willingness to play in a team and invest in the overall sound, not the individual's sound. This means that every instrument should be heard and picked out of the combined sound, and no instrument should overshadow another. An experienced listener could hear

whether a group of percussionists are collaborating or competing, and the latter does not sound as good.

Heterophony should not be confused with the practice of building complex rhythmic cycles from different interlocking layers (or parts) that have to be simultaneously played on multiple percussion instruments. Interlocking or layered rhythms are very common in the music of Morocco and the Arab Gulf (*khaliji* genres) but are not practiced much in the music we cover in this book.

Melody and *Iqa'*

Melody and *iqa'* are two equal partners in creating the rich experience of Arabic music generally, and *tarab* specifically. To begin with, *iqa'at* are deeply embedded in Arabic melodies, as any rhythmic melody is anchored in a given *iqa'* (meaning that melodies are not built within a generic time signature, e.g., $\frac{4}{4}$). Even without hearing a percussion instrument play, most Arab musicians (and many audiences) can hear the *iqa'* from singing or instrumental playing alone. And in this case, we don't simply mean the $\frac{2}{4}$ or $\frac{3}{4}$ or $\frac{4}{4}$ "meter," but the specificity of the *iqa'* itself: melodies that are intended for Maqsum, Baladi, or Wahda (all of which are $\frac{4}{4}$ *iqa'at* suitable to the same tempo range) are distinguishable from each other without hearing a single *dum* or *tak* from a percussion instrument.

In some cases, this is because the strong and weak beats in the melodic phrasing (and the Arabic syllables, in the case of vocal music) align with the main *dum*-s and *tak*-s in the *iqa'*. That technique of manifesting the *iqa'* directly in the melody is particularly pronounced in odd-metered *muwashshahat*. In other cases, it is because the rhythmic phrasing of the melody deliberately *avoids* the strong beats of the *iqa'*, in order to create a kind of polyrhythmic effect between the melody and percussion line. That technique is particularly common in the even $\frac{4}{4}$ *iqa'at*, in which multiple kinds of syncopation from both the percussionists and the melody players are layered to produce a rich effect that keeps the music "floating" above the beat. While there isn't a formal polyrhythmic framework for this (e.g., analogous to Cuban music), there is a vocabulary of rhythmic phrasing used in melodies in Maqsum versus Wahda that plays on the contrast with the *iqa'* and forms part of the oral tradition influencing song composers.

This technique of knowing when to emphasize the *dum* and when to avoid it is taken to perfection in the *mawwal* or *taqsim 'ala al-wahda*—improvisation over the beat, most commonly using the even-metered *iqa'at* such as Wahda, Ciftetelli, and Bambi—all of which give enough room for instrumentalists or vocalists to vary their melodic rhythms within a fairly open beat framework. The master improviser

is able to create musical phrases that lead to various points within the *iqāʿ*, creating a sense of *tarab* around rhythmic expectation even without elaborate work within the *maqam*. When the improviser and percussionist understand each other well, there is a masterful interplay in which the *iqāʿ* is both present and not present, emphasized and ignored, and both partners dialogue with each other. Sometimes *both* partners can completely avoid the beat for several measures, while keeping it so vividly in play that the audience salivates for its return.

Finally, *iqāʿ* plays an important structural role in larger-scale melodic composition. In certain kinds of set genres (such as the *samāʿi*, among others), changes in *iqāʿ* clearly delineate changes in sections. But some of the techniques described previously for rhythmic variation (ornamentation, rhythmic modulation, variation, tempo, and timing subtleties) can also play important structural roles in composition, both within and between sections. This is often quite prominent when rhythmic changes are aligned with *jins* modulations, or changes in melodic register. In these cases, the change in mood resulting from the *maqam* change and the change in mood resulting from the *iqāʿ* change amplify each other, establishing a stronger delineation of melodic phrases within the overall *sayr*.

Matching changes in *jins* with changes in *iqāʿ*, while present in some *muwash-shahat* from Aleppo, was really developed most fully in Egypt in the mid-20th century. The easiest place to spot examples of this is in the *raqs sharqi* dance repertoire of the 1940s to 1960s, but the technique was also essential to the development of the long-song genre for Umm Kulthum and other singers. In those songs, rhythmic changes occur throughout the instrumental sections; the *iqāʿ* shifts dramatically for the vocal entrance, then shifts subtly within the verses themselves, building tension and excitement along with the melody and the *maqam*. Since many of those songs have a “chorus” section that follows each verse and returns to the main *maqam* of the song, rhythmic shifts (frequently to lively, energizing *iqāʿāt*) help emphasize that return to the chorus and build upon the sense of *tarab*.

Percussion Solos

A percussion solo is a musical section played on one or more percussion instruments, without any melodic instruments. Percussion solos are not as frequent as melodic instrument solos and do not qualify as a *taqsim* because that form is founded on exploring the *sayr* of an Arabic *maqam*.

Brief percussion solos may be performed at the beginning of a song or instrumental piece, by having one or more percussion instruments start with the *iqāʿ* only.

This is frequently done when opening the *sama'i* Turkish instrumental form, by playing two measures of Sama'i Thaquil ($\frac{10}{8}$). Egyptian composer Muhammad Abdel Wahab used the short opening percussion solo in "*bint il-balad*," which opens with two measures of Masmudi Kabir ($\frac{8}{4}$) played on the *riqq* and the *daff*. A short percussion solo is also the norm between repetitions of a *dulab* melody, in which one or more percussionists play two measures of the *dulab*'s *iqā'* as a solo.

Longer and more elaborate percussion solos are more common in the *raqs sharqi* (belly dance) repertoire and are meant to accompany an improvisation by the dancer. In this kind of solo, the *tabla* is the instrument of choice, as it combines loudness and a great diversity of sounds and ornaments. The *tabla* may play alone or may be accompanied by one or more instruments, such as the *riqq*, the *sajat* (finger cymbals), the *katim*, or the *daff*. A traditional belly dance percussion solo typically lasts three to four minutes and usually starts with heavily ornamented versions of common belly dance *iqā'at* (e.g., Masmudi Kabir $\frac{8}{4}$, Sa'idi $\frac{4}{4}$, Maqsum $\frac{4}{4}$, Malfuf $\frac{2}{4}$, Ayyub $\frac{2}{4}$) that the dancer interprets. The next (and shorter) part of the solo is usually a free-form rhythmic conversation between the percussionist and the dancer.

During that part, the dancer focuses a lot more closely on the percussionist, and her movements become very closely linked to the rhythmic phrases, to the point that every note the drummer strums can potentially cause a narrow muscle group movement in the dancer. That part is the climax of the joint *tabla* and dance solo, after which the drummer ends with a fast-paced *iqā'* (such as Malfuf or Ayyub) while the dancer exits.

Contemporary Issues

Over the last several decades, there have been several challenges standing in the way of preserving Arabic *iqā'at* as they were practiced in the 20th century (and earlier) and performing them with an authentic feel.

One challenge is the use of click tracks (a background metronome) in recording studios and the widespread practice of recording "takes" from different instruments at different times, then mixing them back. When two percussionists record their tracks at different times (with or without a click track), the result of mixing the two tracks together does not feel as lively or as realistic as a recording with musicians performing together in real time. This is because percussionists need to listen and adapt to each other in order to produce pleasing heterophony (the same is true for melodic musicians). A click track also prevents percussionists and melodic instrumentalists alike from making stylistic adjustments to the tempo as the piece requires, resulting in a more rigid rhythm.

Another challenge is the use of a conductor in a large ensemble or orchestra. Using a conductor goes against the traditional division of labor, in which the ensemble operates by consensus and the *riqq* player is the manager of that consensus (the traditional title for a *riqq* player is *dabit al-īqāʿ*, or the rhythm controller). Using a conductor takes away the rhythm section's ability to control the tempo and a degree of liveliness from the ensemble.

Finally, the increased reliance on notation to document, teach, and preserve Arabic *īqāʿat*, combined with the increased use of electronic percussion instruments (which deliver rigid *īqāʿat* exactly as notated) in Arabic ensembles and recordings, is eroding the timing subtleties and light accents that give each *īqāʿ* its feel and character.

Overall, the challenge facing Arabic *īqāʿat* today is the same one facing Arabic *maqam* intonation as a result of modern Arabic notation and the increased use of equal-tempered instruments in Arabic ensembles and recordings (see chapter 11: Tuning System). Notating Arabic music (with both its melodic and rhythmic components) is imperfect and misses the finer details. For this reason, Arabic music is best learned and transmitted orally, through careful listening and imitation, with notation set aside, in order to faithfully preserve its rich details.

7

A SAMPLING OF ARABIC *IQA'AT*

THIS CHAPTER LISTS some of the most popular Arabic *iqā'at* that were in use in the early to mid-20th-century repertoire from Egypt through Aleppo. This list is by no means comprehensive; rather, it highlights the most common *iqā'at* that underpinned the genres and forms discussed in this book.

Cataloging *Iqa'at*

Cataloging *iqā'at* is a challenging undertaking because, as with *maqamat*, there is no single or definitive reference on classification and naming of Arabic *iqā'at*. Many references exist from different time periods and different Arab regions, but they are not always in agreement (even those within the Near East). For this reason, the authors of this book have relied primarily on oral naming conventions used among percussionists, then made every effort to correlate that with written references. As a result, some *iqā'at* have multiple alternate names.

Some *iqā'at* have more than one possible form used in practice (the form is usually named after a geographical location). For the most part, this chapter does not attempt to be comprehensive, listing only one form per *iqā'* (with the exception of Bambi and Aqsaq, as both of these have two widespread forms that are listed here).

Notating each *iqa'* presented further challenges. For a start, it is sometimes difficult to separate the skeleton of an *iqa'* from its customary ornamentation, which with time has become part and parcel of its identity. Another notation issue is that the note value used in the time signature (the bottom part) of an *iqa'* can be inconsistent across different references. This is because Arabic *iqa'at* were conceived independently of the Western concept of tempo; as such they were traditionally taught only using the number of beats per measure (the top part of the time signature) and only later notated. As a result, some *iqa'at* (e.g., Ciftetelli, Aqsaq, Jurjina, and Awis) have more than one possible time signature mentioned, depending on their tempo.

The last notational challenge was how long to notate the *dum* and *tak* notes versus the rests. This dilemma is discussed in detail in the “Notating *Iqa'at*” section in chapter 6: Rhythm, but it means that several alternative notations may exist for each *iqa'*. This chapter lists only one notation style per *iqa'* and tries to be as consistent as possible. For all the reasons mentioned, *iqa'at* notated in this chapter may present small differences compared to other references that the reader is familiar with, but none of these styles or variations are strictly incorrect—and the ear and practice are the only true guides.

We have organized the *iqa'at* that follow by the number of beats per measure, in two groups: first those with two, four, and eight beats per measure; then all others, in increasing order of beats per measure.

Iqa' Ayyub (¾)

Ayyub (also spelled Ayoub; see figure 7.1) is also called Zar in Egypt (named after a folk healing ceremony led by women who play handheld percussion instruments). It is primarily used in Sufi music as well as in some folk music and *raqs sharqi*. Ayyub's feel is rapid, short, and cyclical. A customary ornamented form of Ayyub includes an additional *tak* in the first half of the measure (see figure 6.4 in chapter 6: Rhythm). “Ayyub” in Arabic is the biblical name “Job.”

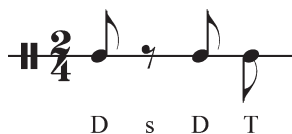


FIGURE 7.1 Iqa' Ayyub ¾

Iqa' Malfuf (2/4)

Malfuf (also spelled Malfouf; see figure 7.2) is primarily used in folk and popular Arabic music. The word *malfuf* in Arabic literally means “wrapped” or “spun around” (Malfuf’s feel is short and cyclical). For this reason, some regions call it Laff (wrapping/going around an object in circular fashion). Typical modulations from Malfuf are with Karachi and Ayyub. Malfuf also often modulates back and forth with Maqsum (by replacing one Maqsum measure with two Malfuf measures, and vice versa).



FIGURE 7.2 Iqa' Malfuf 2/4

Iqa' Karachi (2/4)

Karachi (see figure 7.3) is another member of the 2/4 *iqa'at* family, and as such it modulates frequently to and from Malfuf. It can be beautifully layered with Malfuf on two different percussion instruments. Karachi is also a possible modulation from Maqsum (by replacing one Maqsum measure with two Karachi measures, and vice versa). Although short and cyclical, Karachi does not have the rapidity and urgency of Malfuf and Ayyub; instead it feels lazy and can be played at much slower tempos. Karachi’s name comes from the city of Karachi in Pakistan.

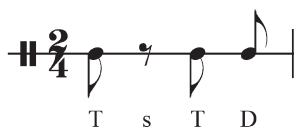


FIGURE 7.3 Iqa' Karachi 2/4

Iqa' Fox (2/4)

Fox (shortened from foxtrot; see figure 7.4) is a simple 2/4 *iqa'* that is usually played without too much ornamentation. This and the fact that it is often played at very fast tempos gives it a swift and urgent feel. This *iqa'* is very common in the originally Turkish/Eastern European *longa* form, in which sections in Fox often alternate with sections in Malfuf. A very well-known example of this usage is “Longa Farahfaza” (also known as “Longa Riyad”) by Riyad al-Sunbati. It is also used, although less frequently, in the *tarab* music genre, especially in introductions to songs such as Muhammad Abdel Wahab’s “*ya dunya ya gharami*” (1938), Umm Kulthum’s “*ghulubt asalih fi rouhi*” (1948) and “*yalli kan yishgik anini*” (1949), and Nour al-Hoda’s “*ya sa'a bil-wa'ti igri*” (1952).

FIGURE 7.4 Iqa' Fox $\frac{2}{4}$.

Iqa' Wahda Saghira ($\frac{2}{4}$)

Wahda Saghira (*saghira* means “little/small”; see figure 7.5), also known as Wahda Basita (*basita* means “simple”) or Wahda Sa'ira (*sa'ira* means “walking”), is a simple $\frac{2}{4}$ form of the $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqa' Wahda. This *iqa'* is mostly used in instrumental sections, while its longer form, Wahda, is used mostly in vocal sections. As a $\frac{2}{4}$ rhythm, Wahda Saghira is a possible modulation from Malfuf.

FIGURE 7.5 Iqa' Wahda Saghira $\frac{2}{4}$.

Wahda Saghira is featured in the instrumental introductions of Umm Kulthum's “*al-atlal*” (1966) and “*darit il-ayyam*” (1970) long-songs. It is also used in the introductions to Abdel Halim Hafez's songs “*nibtidi minein il-bikaya*” (1975) and “*ala hisb widad galbi*” (1953). Ziad Rahbani also uses Wahda Saghira in his introduction to “*il-hali ta'bani ya layla*” (1975).

Iqa' Fallahi ($\frac{2}{4}$)

Fallahi (also spelled Fellahi; see figure 7.6) is a fast-paced Egyptian *iqa'* suitable for folk music. Although it might resemble Maqsum played at double speed, it has a very different feel, as Fallahi flows very smoothly without a big contrast (in accents) between *dum* and *tak* beats. The word *fallabi* means “of the farmer/peasant.”

FIGURE 7.6 Iqa' Fallahi $\frac{2}{4}$.

Iqa' Maqsum ($\frac{4}{4}$)

Maqsum (also spelled Maqsoum; see figure 7.7) is by far the most recognizable and widely performed Arabic *iqa'*. It is used in *tarab*, folk, and popular music. Maqsum

modulates readily to Baladi ($\frac{4}{4}$) and Sa'idi ($\frac{4}{4}$), as well as to Malfuf or Fallahi (in which one measure of $\frac{4}{4}$ replaces two measures of $\frac{2}{4}$, and vice versa). The word *maqsum* means “divided” in Arabic and refers to the fact that the *iqā'* can be easily divided into two halves (illustrated by the divider in figure 7.7).

FIGURE 7.7 Iqa' Maqsum $\frac{4}{4}$.

Iqa' Baladi (Masmudi Saghir) ($\frac{4}{4}$)

Baladi (also spelled Beladi; see figure 7.8) is a very widespread *iqā'* used primarily in folk and popular Arabic music. It is a double-speed form of Masmudi Kabir, and as such it is alternatively called Masmudi Saghir (*saghir* means “little/small”). Baladi and Maqsum regularly modulate to one another, with Maqsum feeling lighter and faster and Baladi feeling comparatively heavier because of the double *dum* at the beginning. The word *baladi* in Arabic means “of the village/countryside.”

FIGURE 7.8 Iqa' Baladi (Masmudi Saghir) $\frac{4}{4}$.

Iqa' Sa'idi ($\frac{4}{4}$)

Sa'idi (also spelled Saidi; see figure 7.9) is an Egyptian *iqā'* from the Sa'id (pronounced “sa-EED”) region, south of Cairo. It is very popular with the *sa'idi* musical genre, especially to accompany dancing. Its characteristic feature is the double *dum* in the middle of the *iqā'*. This *iqā'* also utilizes a number of popular variations, typically heard in performances of *sa'idi* music (but also possible when Iqa' Sa'idi is included in *tarab* compositions). These variations include omission of the first *dum* (s T s D D s T s); omission of the first *dum* plus substitution of *dum*-s on the 2nd and 3rd beats, resulting in 4 *dum*-s in a row (s D D D D s T s); and others.

FIGURE 7.9 Iqa' Sa'idi $\frac{4}{4}$.

Iqa' Katakufi (Nawari) (4/4)

Iqa' Katakufi (see figure 7.10), also commonly called Nawari (from *nawar*, a slang and derogatory word that refers to the Roma people), is a variation on Sa'idi and Baladi that is used often in Levantine folk music and *dabke* line dances (e.g., Samira Tawfiq's song "*al-'ein mulayyitein*"); as such it works very well when played on a *tabl baladi*. The name *katakufi* comes from the Greek expression *ekato kofte* (false words, lying; literally "cut a hundred").



FIGURE 7.10 Iqa' Katakufi (Nawari) 4/4.

Iqa' Zaffa (4/4)

Iqa' Zaffa (see figure 7.11) is named after the *zaffa* (pl. *zaffat*), a wedding procession in which musicians accompany the groom and his entourage on his journey to pick up the bride, with loud music, singing, and cheering. Iqa' Zaffa is best played by a large ensemble combining diverse percussion instruments (e.g., *riqq*, *mazhar*, *tabla*, *daff*, and *tabl baladi*), along with a loud melodic instrument such as the *mizmar*. Iqa' Zaffa can be heard in Farid al-Atrash's wedding song "*duququ il-mazahir*" (1952), probably the most famous *zaffa* melody still in use at contemporary Arab weddings.

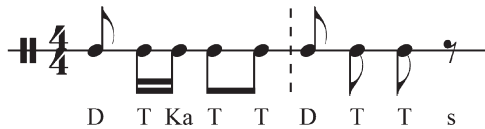
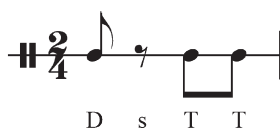


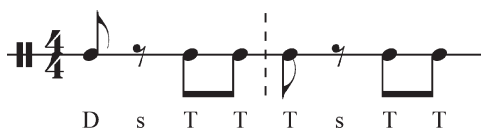
FIGURE 7.11 Iqa' Zaffa 4/4.

Iqa' Hacha' (2/4, 4/4, 6/8, or 8/8)

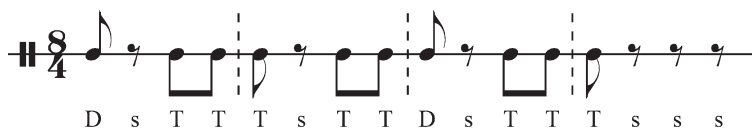
Hacha' (also pronounced Hadja') is a very popular Iraqi dance *iqa'* that made its way to Syria and beyond. The most basic form of Hacha' is in 2/4 (see figure 7.12) and is identical to Wahda Saghira in its notation, except that it is faster and more jumpy. This *iqa'* is used in many folkloric songs from Syria, such as "*al-maya*," or in Sufi songs such as "*tala'a al-badru 'alayna*."

FIGURE 7.12 Iqa' Hacha' $\frac{2}{4}$.

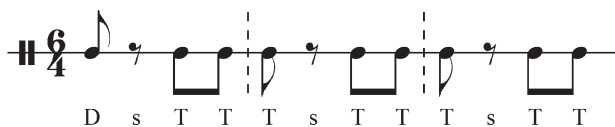
A $\frac{4}{4}$ form of Iqa' Hacha' is very common (see figure 7.13) and is a possible modulation from other $\frac{4}{4}$ *iqa'at* such as Maqsum and Baladi. A modulation to Hacha' in $\frac{4}{4}$ introduces a dramatic mood when it starts because it tends to slow down the groove, and also because of the contrast between its single *dum* and multiple *tak*-s, creating a jumpy (staccato) feel. It is a very popular *iqa'* in Sufi *dhikr* ceremonies and is the ideal *iqa'* for a repeated chanting of the word "Allah," divided into three syllables (a/al/lah) over the first three *tak*-s.

FIGURE 7.13 Iqa' Hacha' $\frac{4}{4}$.

An $\frac{8}{4}$ form of Iqa' Hacha' exists (see figure 7.14), made by combining a regular $\frac{4}{4}$ Hacha' measure followed by a second $\frac{4}{4}$ measure with the last two *tak*-s omitted. This $\frac{8}{4}$ form modulates well with Masmudi Kabir and creates a very solemn mood, especially when played very slowly, using only frame drums. The $\frac{8}{4}$ form of Hacha' is very well suited for meditative vocal and instrumental improvisations involving long phrases followed by long pauses.

FIGURE 7.14 Iqa' Hacha' $\frac{8}{4}$.

In another testimony to its versatility, Iqa' Hacha' exists in a $\frac{6}{4}$ form (see figure 7.15), which can be heard in the introduction to Umm Kulthum's song "*alf leila we leila*" by Baligh Hamdi.

FIGURE 7.15 Iqa' Hacha' $\frac{6}{4}$.

Iqa' Wahda ($\frac{4}{4}$)

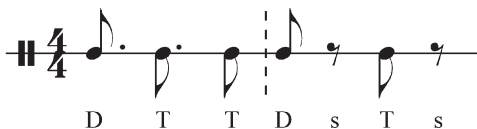
Wahda (see figure 7.16) is the main *iqa'* used with vocal music in the *tarab* genre. The word *wahda* means “one” in Arabic, and this *iqa'* is named after its single *dum*, which leaves a lot of room for vocalists to ornament their singing with melismata and stretch some vowels, in order to satisfy the *tarab* mood. As such, a percussionist playing Wahda follows the singer’s rhythm and every syllable attentively, rather than being the rhythm controller (*dabit al-iqa'*) at that moment.

FIGURE 7.16 Iqa' Wahda $\frac{4}{4}$.

Although Wahda is notated as a slowed down form of Malfuf, they differ in style and feel, as well as in accents and timing subtleties. Wahda and Maqsum usually complement each other in vocal music, where slow and heavily ornamented sections use Wahda and chorus and instrumental sections use Maqsum. This type of alternating between Wahda and Maqsum is usually accompanied with a change in pace and dynamics. Umm Kulthum’s “*il albi yi’sha’ kulli gamil*” is a masterful example of alternating between Wahda and Maqsum.

Iqa' Wahda wi Nuss ($\frac{4}{4}$)

Wahda wi Nuss (meaning “one and a half” in Arabic; see figure 7.17) is a syncopated form of Maqsum that is extremely popular in vocal music. It has the same pace and liveliness as Maqsum, with an added funkiness due to its syncopated first *tak* that is a sixteenth note later than Maqsum’s first *tak*. Wahda wi Nuss modulates smoothly and frequently with Maqsum and Baladi; it can be heard in the opening of Farid al-Atrash’s “*nura*” (1953), the opening of Sabah’s “*ya kawini ya ‘ali*” (1954), and much of Umm Kulthum’s “*ba’id annak*” (1965).

FIGURE 7.17 Iqa' Wahda wi Nuss $\frac{4}{4}$.

Iqa' Rumba (4)

The Arabic form of rumba (see figure 7.18) is a variation on the Latin American rhythm by the same name (Latin American music was in vogue in Egypt from the 1930s onward, and various elements were incorporated into Arabic music, especially in the 1940s and 1950s). It is not very common, but when used it gives the song or instrumental piece a foreign flavor. The most important notes to emphasize are the two *dum*-s, while the filling and ornamentation in between them may vary a lot and can be syncopated. What is notated in this example is one possibility among many. Rumba can be heard in Muhammad Abdel Wahab's "*al-fann*" (1945), in which Arabic percussion instruments are supplemented with what sounds like castanets. Another good recorded example of Rumba can be heard in Warda's "*shu'uri nahiyetak*" (1981, by Sayed Makkawi).



FIGURE 7.18 Iqa' Rumba 4.

Iqa' Ciftetelli (4 or 8)

Ciftetelli (pronounced *shaftatalli* in Arabic) is a Turkish *usul* that became popular in Arabic music. (Ciftetelli also is a very popular Greek line dance and rhythm, pronounced *Tsiftetelli*.) It is rarely used for composed melodies; its primary use is to underpin improvisations (both vocal and instrumental). Ciftetelli can be slow paced and stretched out, in which case it is notated in 8/4 (see figure 7.19), and can share the same tempo and pace as Masmudi Kabir. Alternatively, Ciftetelli can be performed faster and lighter, in which case it becomes very similar to Iqa' Wahda Wi Nuss in 4/4 (plus or minus some ornamentation), and can alternate back and forth with Maqsum. The name Ciftetelli comes from the Turkish words *Çifte Tellî* (meaning "double-stringed").

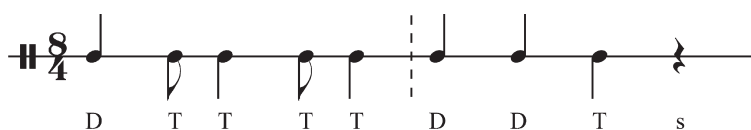


FIGURE 7.19 Iqa' Ciftetelli 8.

Iqā' Wahda Sunbati (Wahda Tawila) (8)

Wahda Sunbati (see figure 7.20), also called Wahda Tawila (*tawila* means “long”), is a stretched-out form of Iqā' Wahda; one measure of Wahda Sunbati is as long as two measures of Wahda. The first half of Wahda Sunbati is identical in notation and performance to a measure of Wahda, while the second half is very sparse (single *dum* and single *tak* over four beats), giving Wahda Sunbati a very open and relaxed feel. While Wahda Sunbati's notation resembles that of Ciftetelli (played with a single *dum* in the second half of the measure), they do not have the same feel. This *iqā'* is used in both vocal and instrumental music and can be heard in the opening of Muhammad Abdel Wahab's instrumental “*khatwit habibi*” (1953).

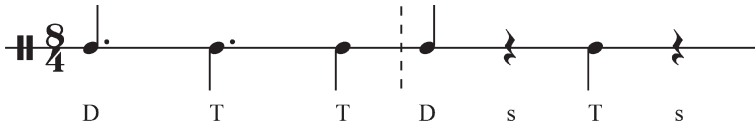


FIGURE 7.20 Iqā' Wahda Sunbati (Wahda Tawila) 8.

Iqā' Masmudi Kabir (8)

Masmudi Kabir (commonly called Masmudi for short; the word *kabir* means “big/large”) is a slow *iqā'* with a very formal and classical feel (see figure 7.21). It is popular in introductions and the *dawr* form, as well as in *qasā'id* such as the ones composed by Riyadh al-Sunbati. An excellent recorded example of Masmudi Kabir is the opening of Muhammad Abdel Wahab's instrumental and *raqs sharqi* classic “*bint il-balad*” (1951). A possible ornamentation would be to play a *dum* on the 3rd beat, creating a succession of three *dum*-s, which gives Masmudi Kabir a heavy, formal, and ceremonial feel. When played faster, this *iqā'* becomes Masmudi Saghir (*saghir* means “small/little”), also known as Baladi. In a typical instrumental composition, such as an introduction or a dance piece, sections in Masmudi Kabir often alternate with sections in Maqsum. Masmudi Kabir is sometimes used in the *muwashshah* genre, as in, for example, the *muwashshahat* “*ya shadi al-alhan*” by Sayed Darwish, “*ya fatin al-ghizlan*,” and “*zarani al-mahbub*.”

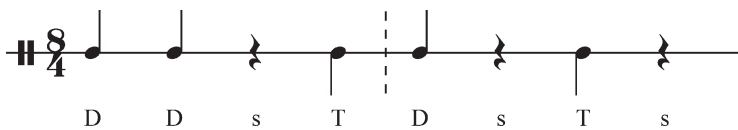


FIGURE 7.21 Iqā' Masmudi Kabir 8.

Iqa' Bambi (8)

Bambi is an Egyptian folk *iqa'* (the word *bambi* means the color “rose pink” in colloquial Egyptian). Its most common form is notated in figure 7.22. Percussionists start playing it from the 7th beat (this means it starts with three *dum*-s in succession, which is its distinguishing characteristic). Some players replace the second *dum* in the sequence of three with a *tak* or a rest, creating a bit of suspense between the first and the third *dum*-s. An example of this form is Muhammad Abdel Wahab's song “*gafnubu 'allam al-ghazal*” (1933).

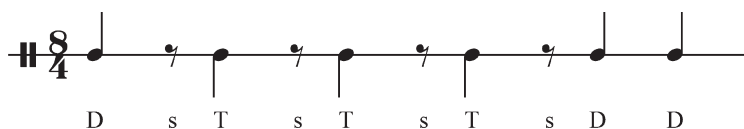


FIGURE 7.22 Iqa' Bambi 8/4 Form I.

Another form of Bambi (see figure 7.23) shifts the first form back by two quarter notes and starts from the 1st beat in the measure (which means it also starts with three *dum*-s in succession). That Bambi form was used by Muhammad Abdel Wahab in his instrumental “*layali lubnan*” (1954) and in the introduction to Warda's song “*andah 'aleik*” (1982, also composed by Abdel Wahab), in the introduction to Umm Kulthum's “*alf leila we leila*” (1969, composed by Baligh Hamdi), and in Fairouz's “*asamina*” (1989, composed by Philemon Wehbe).



FIGURE 7.23 Iqa' Bambi 8/4 Form II.

Iqa' Sama'i Darij (3)

Sama'i Darij (also commonly called Darij for short, meaning “widespread”/“in fashion”) is a very popular *iqa'* in instrumental genres (see figure 7.24). It is the principal *iqa'* in the *Sama'i Darij* instrumental form (see chapter 9: Instrumental Forms).

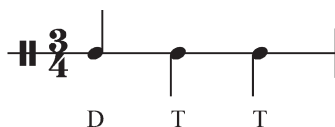


FIGURE 7.24 Iqa' Sama'i Darij 3/4.

This *iqa'* is identical in its time signature and skeletal notation to the European waltz, and while the waltz (referred to as “Iqa' Valse”) was indeed used in some

20th-century Arabic long-songs (e.g., Umm Kulthum's "*darit il-ayyam*") to add a European flavor, its feel remains different than that of Iqā' Sama'i Darij.

Iqā' Sama'i Saraband (Sama'i Ta'ir) (ḡ)

Sama'i Saraband (or Saraband for short), also called Sama'i Ta'ir (*ta'ir* means "flying"), is a fast and light *iqā'* popular in instrumental and *muwashshah* genres (see figure 7.25). This *iqā'* may modulate back and forth to Yuruk Semai (ḡ), and in doing so it alternates from having one *dum* to two *dum*-s per measure. A very common ornament for this *iqā'* is to replace the first *tak* (eighth note) with two *tak*-s (sixteenth notes), making its signature D tk T instead of D T T.

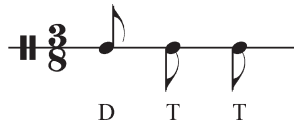


FIGURE 7.25 Iqā' Sama'i Saraband (Sama'i Ta'ir) ḡ.

Among the *muwashshahat* composed in this *iqā'* are "*ya ghusna naqa*" (in Maqam Huzam), "*bil-ladhi askara*" (in Maqam Bayati), and "*ya man la'ibat bihi shamulu*" (in Maqam Rast).

Iqā' Aqsaq Turki (Thurayya) (ḡ)

Iqā' Aqsaq Turki (see figure 7.26) comes from the Turkish *usul Ağır Aksak*. *Aqsaq* is a Turkish word that means "limping," and *turki* means "Turkish." Aqsaq Turki (also known as Thurayya) is quite rare, but is used by one well-known *muwashshah*: "*firroud ana shuft il-gamil*" (in Maqam Hijazkar Kurd) by Omar al-Batsh.

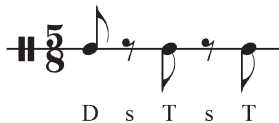


FIGURE 7.26 Iqā' Aqsaq Turki (Thurayya) ḡ.

Iqā' Yuruk Semai (ḡ)

Yuruk Semai (pronounced *yurk sama'i* in Arabic; see figure 7.27) was originally a Turkish *usul* that is very popular in folk music as well as in the *muwashshah* genre. It is used, for example, in the *muwashshahat* "*qum ya nadim*" in Maqam Nahawand by Omar

Iqa' Nawakht (7/4)

Nawakht (see figure 7.30) is a very popular *muwashshah iqa'*, used in, for example, the *muwashshahat* “*ya hilalan*” (in Maqam Nairuz) and “*badru timmin*” (in Maqam Hijazkar). A popular variation is to start the melody on the 3rd beat (the first *tak*), as in the *muwashshahat* “*khala al-idhar*” (in Maqam Husayni), “*jalla man qad sagha badran*” (in Maqam Bayati Shuri), “*qultu lamma ghaba ‘anni*” by Omar al-Batsh (in Maqam Nahawand), and “*ijma’u bil-qurbi shamli*” (in Maqam Bayati). Nawakht should not be confused with Dawr Hindi, even though the latter may appear to be a slower form of it; Dawr Hindi is played much faster and has a different feel and ornamentation. *Nawakht* is a Persian verb for either singing or playing a musical instrument.¹

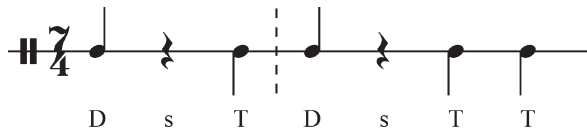


FIGURE 7.30 Iqa' Nawakht 7/4.

Iqa' Aqsaq (9/8)

Aqsaq is the Arabic name of Turkish *usul Aksak* (literally, “limping”). It was probably thus named because it has an odd time signature and one extra beat compared to an 8/8 *iqa'*. The most common form of Iqa' Aqsaq is notated in figure 7.31.

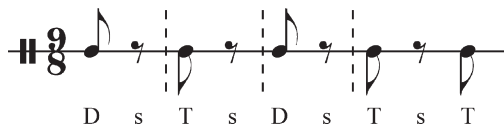


FIGURE 7.31 Iqa' Aqsaq 9/8 Form I.

A very popular alternative form of Aqsaq (notated in figure 7.32) has two *dum*-s in the middle instead of one (falling on beats 6 and 7). This second form is ideal for stitching together a piece in Iqa' Aqsaq with a piece in Iqa' Sama'i Thaql without stopping the rhythm (the two successive *dum*-s in both Aqsaq and Sama'i Thaql create a feeling of continuity). A slower form of Aqsaq may be notated in 9/4. Aqsaq is very common in *muwashshahat*, such as “*ayyuha al-saqi*” (in Maqam Huzam) by Majdi al-Aqili; “*ana min wajdi*” (in Maqam Rahat al-Arwah); “*adhdhibuni*” (in Maqam Hijazkar Kurd) by Omar al-Batsh; and “*ma-btiyali*” (in Maqam Hijaz)

¹ Dr. Kamran Rastegar, conversation with the author, 2017.

by Ahmad Abu Khalil al-Qabbani, which starts the melody on the 3rd beat (the first *tak*).

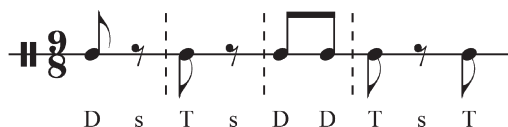


FIGURE 7.32 Iqa' Aqsaq $\frac{9}{8}$ Form II.

Iqa' Sama'i Thaqil ($\frac{10}{8}$)

Sama'i Thaqil (also called Sama'i for short; the word *thaqil* means “heavy”) was originally a Turkish *usul* called *Aksak Semai*. It is used to accompany the *saz semai* Turkish instrumental form (still in use in Arabic music, called *sama'i*). Sama'i Thaqil (see figure 7.33) is also a popular *muwashshah iqa'*, used in, for example, the *muwashshahat* “*lamma bada yatathanna*” (in Maqam Nahawand), “*mala al-kasat*” (in Maqam Rast) by Muhammad 'Uthman, “*imlali al-aqdaha sirfan*” (in Maqam Bayati), “*rashiq al-qadd*” (in Maqam Bayati), “*tarraz al-rayhan*” (in Maqam Bayati), and “*atini biker al-dinan*” (in Maqam Nahawand).

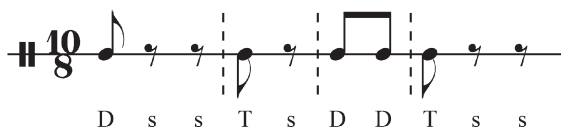


FIGURE 7.33 Iqa' Sama'i Thaqil $\frac{10}{8}$.

Iqa' Jurjina ($\frac{10}{8}$)

Jurjina (sometimes incorrectly transliterated as Georgina; see figure 7.34) is a widely used *iqa'* in Iraq and Iran, as well as in the Turkish and the Kurdish repertoires, both in the folk and classical genres. A slower form of Jurjina can be notated in $\frac{5}{4}$. Originally this was a Turkish *usul* called *Curcuna* (pronounced *jurjuna*, meaning “uproar” or “loud noise”). It is infrequently used in the *sharqi* repertoire, but nevertheless it is listed here because it is widely known among *sharqi* percussionists. Iqa' Jurjina is used in the *muwashshah* “*ya hulu al-lama*” (in Maqam Bayati) and in the opening of Muhammad Abdel Wahab's duet “*tal intizari*” with Leila Mourad. Examples of Jurjina abound in the Iraqi repertoire, such as in the very popular folk song “*ya umm il-'uyun il-sud*.”

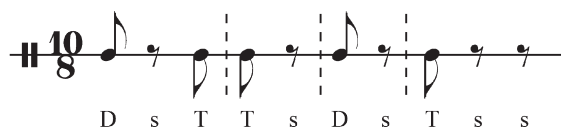
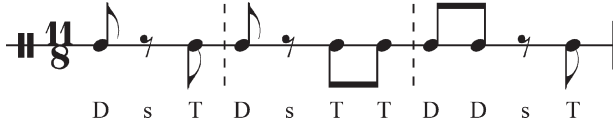


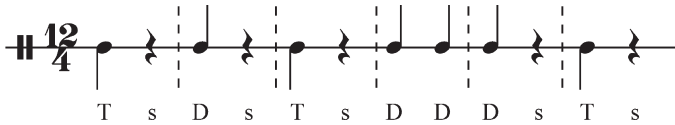
FIGURE 7.34 Iqa' Jurjina $\frac{10}{8}$.

Iqā' 'Awis ($\frac{11}{8}$)

'Awis (see figure 7.35) is mostly used with the *muwashshah* genre. Some 'Awis pieces start from the 3rd beat (the first *tak*), for example the *muwashshah* “*munyati man rumtu qurbubu*” (in Maqam Rast) by Omar al-Batsh. The *muwashshah* “*hibbi da'ani lil-wisal*” (in Maqam Bayati Shuri) by Darwish al-Hariri starts the melody on the 11th beat (the last *tak*). A slower form of 'Awis can be notated in $\frac{11}{4}$. The word 'awis in Arabic means “very difficult.”

FIGURE 7.35 Iqā' 'Awis $\frac{11}{8}$.Iqā' Mudawwar ($\frac{12}{4}$)

Iqā' Mudawwar (see figure 7.36) has many regional variations, such as Mudawwar Masri (Egyptian), Mudawwar Halabi (from Aleppo), Mudawwar Turki (Turkish), and Mudawwar Shami (from *al-sham*—Damascus), all sharing a $\frac{12}{4}$ time signature. This *iqā'* is mostly used in *muwashshahat*, for example in “*fika kullu ma ara hasan*” (in Maqam Bayati), “*nabbih al-nudman sahi*” (in Maqam Hijazkar), and “*adhbkur al-hubba*” (in Maqam Nawa Athar) by Dawud Husni. Many Mudawwar pieces start from the 11th beat (the last *tak*). The word *mudawwar* means “round” or “circular.”

FIGURE 7.36 Iqā' Mudawwar $\frac{12}{4}$.Iqā' Dharafat ($\frac{13}{8}$)

Iqā' Dharafat (also spelled Zarafat; see figure 7.37) is mostly used with *muwashshahat*, such as “*tif ya durri*” (in Maqam Hijazkar Kurd) by Omar al-Batsh² and “*wal-ladhi wallaka qalbi*” (in Maqam Bayati). Using this *iqā'* outside the *muwashshah* genre (e.g., in a popular song) has the effect of adding a

² Although the two *muwashshahat* references (al-Darwish, 1955; al-Hilu, 1965) attribute the melody of the *muwashshah* “*tif ya durri*” to Omar al-Batsh, most oral sources attribute the first two *adwar* (verses) to Sayed Darwish and only the *khana* to Omar al-Batsh.

classical color by evoking the former repertoire. This is what composer Baligh Hamdi achieved, for example, by using Dharafat in the introduction of Umm Kulthum's long-song "*il-hubbi kullo*" (1971) and the introduction of Aziza Jalal's "*mistanniyak*" (1983).

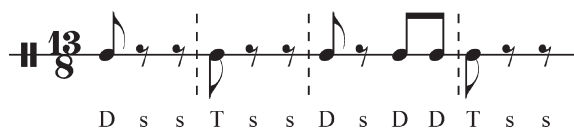


FIGURE 7.37 Iqa' Dharafat $\frac{13}{8}$.

Iqa' Murabba' ($\frac{13}{4}$)

Iqa' Murabba' (see figure 7.38) is very popular in the *muwashshah* genre. It is used, for example, in "*ya 'udhayb al-marshaf*" (in Maqam Rast) by Sayed Darwish; "*ramani bi sahmi hawahu*" (in Maqam Nahawand) by Dawud Husni; and "*hayyar al-afkar*" (in Maqam Rast) and "*isqini al-rah*" (in Maqam Hijazkar), both by Muhammad 'Uthman. Unrelated to its number of beats per cycle, the word *murabba'* in Arabic means "square/squared," or "based on the number four" (*arba'a* in Arabic).



FIGURE 7.38 Iqa' Murabba' $\frac{13}{4}$.

Iqa' Muhajjar ($\frac{14}{4}$)

Muhajjar (see figure 7.39) is a very popular *iqa'* for *muwashshahat*. It is used, for example, in "*badat min al-khidri*" (in Maqam Bayati), "*hal 'ala al-astar*" (in Maqam Husayni), "*hajarni habibi*" (in Maqam Hijaz), "*munyati 'azza-stibari*" (in Maqam Nahawand) by Sayed Darwish, and "*ya tura ba'd al-bi'adi*" (in Maqam Rast) by Sayed Darwish. The word *muhajjar* in Arabic means "made of stone."

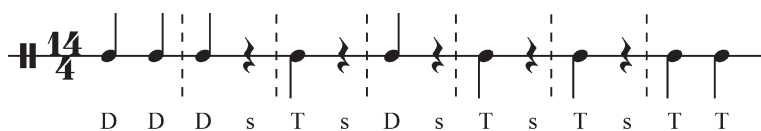


FIGURE 7.39 Iqa' Muhajjar $\frac{14}{4}$.

Iqā' Mukhammas (16)

Iqā' Mukhammas (see figure 7.40) is mostly used in the *muwashshah* genre, for example in “*badri adir kas al-tila*” (in Maqam Hijaz) and “*wajhak mushriq bil-anwar*” (in Maqam Huzam) by Muhammad ‘Uthman. It also commonly used in the Turkish/Ottoman composed instrumental form *bashraf*. Unrelated to its number of beats per cycle, the word *mukhammas* in Arabic means “based on the number five” (*khamasa*).

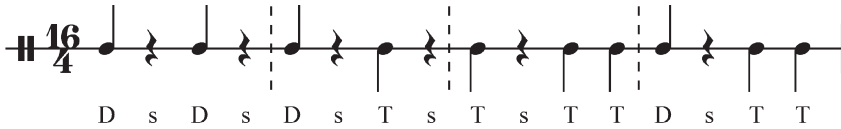


FIGURE 7.40 Iqā' Mukhammas 16.

Iqā' Khosh Rang (17)

Khosh Rang (from the Persian, *khosh rang*, meaning “good/pretty color”) is the only documented *iqā'* used in Arabic music with 17 beats (see figure 7.41). It is extremely rare, yet is well known among classical Arabic music connoisseurs. There is probably only one *muwashshah* known today composed in Khosh Rang: “*salla fina al-lahdha bindiyya*” (“Her Eyes Slashed Me Like an Indian Sword”) in Maqam Hijaz.



FIGURE 7.41 Iqā' Khosh Rang 17.

Iqā' Fakhit (20)

Fakhit (see figure 7.42) is a relatively long *iqā'* that spans five measures of $\frac{4}{4}$, resulting in a $\frac{20}{4}$ time signature. This *iqā'* is rare outside the *muwashshah* genre. It can be heard in the *muwashshahat* “*bi sifatin ja'alatni*” (in Maqam Rast); “*idha da'ana al-siba*” by Omar al-Batsh (in Maqam Zanjaran); and “*zarani taht al-ghayahib*,” also by Omar al-Batsh (in Maqam Nikriz).



FIGURE 7.42 Iqā' Fakhit 20.

Iqa' Sittatu 'Ashar Masri ($\frac{32}{4}$)

Sittatu 'Ashar Masri ("Egyptian Sixteen"; see figure 7.43), also known for short as Sittatu 'Ashar, is a very long *iqa'* that spans eight measures of $\frac{4}{4}$, resulting in a $\frac{32}{4}$ time signature. This *iqa'* is rare, even in the *muwashshah* genre, but can be heard in the *muwashshah* "*badat min al-khidri*," where it is used to start the *khana* section.

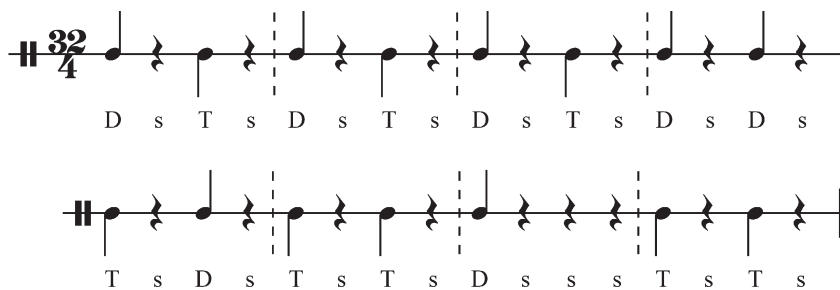


FIGURE 7.43 Iqa' Sittatu 'Ashar Masri $\frac{32}{4}$

8

SONG FORMS

ARABIC MUSIC IS first and foremost vocal music. Dozens of Arabic vocal forms exist, especially when considering the number of countries and regions where Arabic music is performed and when including both religious and secular forms. This chapter presents the primary secular forms that flourished in urban music during the first half of the 20th century into the 1960s in Egypt and Greater Syria. These forms are the pillars that supported Arabic *maqam* music and acted as the primary vehicles for *tarab*.

The Composed *Qasida*

Qasida (pl. *qasa'id*) is the Arabic word for a metered poem written in classical Arabic language, as well as the vocal form that uses that poem for its lyrics. The *qasida* musical form is performed by a solo vocalist and is usually accompanied by a *takht* or larger ensemble. This is one of the few musical genres shared by both urban and folk traditions in the Arab world.

The *qasida* poetry form is the oldest form of Arabic-language poetry, dating back to pre-Islamic Arabia. Each *qasida* has a single rhyme throughout the entire poem and a uniform meter (any one of the 16 traditional Arabic poetry meters, called *al-buhur*). The *qasida* consists of many lines, sometimes over a hundred. Each line is

divided into two equal parts and should contain a complete and concise idea that allows it to be self-sufficient when heard alone. This is very convenient, as it allows composers and singers to use a cut-down version of the *qasida*, or to pick and choose lines and change their order, while keeping the lyrics meaningful and interesting.

The topic of a *qasida* is most often romantic or divine love, but it could also be about patriotism, longing for the homeland, or any other subject with a human dimension. An example of a very well-known *qasida* is “*al-burda*” (The Mantle), written in the 11th century by Imam Muhammad Ibn Sa‘id al-Busayri (1213–1294) in praise of the Prophet Muhammad, with a frequently quoted section advocating wisdom and moderation in old age and shedding the excesses of youth. To this day, this *qasida* still supplies lyrics to both the secular and religious (Sufi) repertoires.

In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, the *qasida* form relied on an improvised melody with the support of the ensemble. The improvised *qasida* is discussed in detail in chapter 22: Vocal Improvisation. Gradually, a new form emerged, with a semi-composed (rather than fully improvised) melody. In each performance, the singer used the original composition as a guideline and performed possible variations (as well as the usual degree of ornamentation). The change was more pronounced when a new singer covered the same *qasida*.

In the semi-composed *qasida*, the ensemble supporting the singer doesn’t play the *qasida*’s melody as they normally would a formally composed melody, since the singer can repeat some parts of the melody, interpret one part slightly differently, or even extend another part into a long improvisational section; in short, the singer is in control. Instead, the ensemble plays a combination of rhythmic melodic lines around the *maqam*’s tonic to accent the rhythm, as well as short melodic phrases called *lazimat* (singular *lazima*) that fill in between the singer’s melodic phrases while he or she takes a breath. When the singer modulates to a new *jins* on a new tonic, the ensemble shifts their rhythmic lines to emphasize that new tonic, then return when the modulation is done.

Sheikh Abu al-‘Ila Muhammad (Egypt 1884–1942) was a prolific singer who recorded many *qasa’id* with the nascent Egyptian recording industry; he was also Umm Kulthum’s first mentor and sponsor. He composed the melody for Umm Kulthum’s landmark *qasida* “*wa haqqika anta al-muna wa al-talab*” (It is Your Right to Wish and to Ask) by Imam ‘Abd Allah al-Shabrawi, and initially recorded it himself in 1928.

The next generation of *qasida* composers was spearheaded by Muhammad Abdel Wahab, who composed and recorded the landmark *qasida* “*ya jarat al-wadi*” (O Neighbor of the Valley, referring to the Lebanese mountain city of Zahleh) by Egyptian poet Ahmad Shawqi in 1928. That *qasida* became very popular and was later reinterpreted by Lebanese diva Fairouz in a new arrangement. Abdel Wahab also recorded the *qasa’id* “*ruddat al-ruh*” (The Soul Returned) in 1928, “*‘allamuhu*

kayfa yaifu fa jafa” (They Taught Him How to Withhold His Love) in 1932, and the very popular “*mudnaka jafahu marqaduhu*” (Your Exhausted Lover Never Sleeps) in 1938, all written by Ahmad Shawqi, nicknamed the “Prince of Poets” and considered one of the most important poets of his generation and a master of the *qasida* form.

Starting from the late 1930s, a fully composed version of the *qasida* form appeared, in which the singer was not left much room to interpret or spontaneously compose the melody. In that sense, a fully composed *qasida* is no different than any other long-song (*ughniya*), except that the lyrics are based on a *qasida* poem. A fully composed *qasida* could run into tens of minutes and have a long instrumental introduction.

Umm Kulthum teamed up with one of her major composers, Riyad al-Sunbati, and the poet Ahmad Shawqi to produce some very successful composed *qasa'id*. Among these are “*salu ku'us al-tila*” (Ask the Liquor Glasses, 1946) and “*nahj al-burda*” (The Trail of the Mantle, 1946, which was inspired by and written in the same meter as Busayri's *al-burda*). Riyad al-Sunbati also composed the melody for the *qasa'id* “*ruba'iyyat al-khayyam*” (1949), from the collection of quartets by Persian poet Omar al-Khayyam, translated into Arabic by Egyptian poet and longtime Sunbati collaborator Ahmad Rami; “*araka 'asiyya al-dam'i*” (You Defy the Tears, 1965), by classical poet Abu Firas al-Hamdani;¹ and “*al-atlal*” (The Ruins, 1966), written by Egyptian poet Ibrahim Nagi, and considered by some to be the pinnacle of Umm Kulthum's songs. Riyad al-Sunbati proved to be the most prolific composer of the fully composed *qasida* musical form in the 20th century, and he certainly made the form his signature and his niche.

The *Muwashshah*

The *muwashshah* (pl. *muwashshahat*), like the *qasida*, is an Arabic poetic genre that became a genre of song. As a literary form, the *muwashshah* appeared approximately in the 9th century and was adopted by Andalusian men of letters during the Umayyad era. The *muwashshah* was considered a modern innovation and a break from the *qasida* tradition because it introduced multiple rhymes, nontraditional meters, and a variable structure. The best analogy to English poetry would be lyric poetry (the *muwashshah*) rather than epic poetry (the *qasida*); like lyric poetry, the

¹ The *qasida* “*araka 'asiyya al-dam'i*” (You Defy the Tears), written by poet Abu Firas al-Hamdani in the 10th century, was so popular that it was put to music by various composers in the 20th century. Umm Kulthum performed a version of that *qasida* composed by 'Abdu al-Hamuli in the 1920s, then a version composed by Zakariyya Ahmad in the 1940s, and finally the most well-known version, by Riyad al-Sunbati, in 1965.

muwashshah includes some colloquial vocabulary and tends to be lighter in theme and tone than the *qasida*.

The name *muwashshah* itself is derived from the word *wishah*, a highly ornamented scarf used by women in the Andalusian period, which included complex patterns of pearl and precious stones. Hence the *muwashshah* is a more “decorative” and ornamental style of poetry than the *qasida*.

In modern times, the *muwashshah* is known primarily as a song genre centered in Aleppo, Syria, where it has blossomed since the 17th century. While these songs frequently used poetry written during the Andalusian period, most of the melodic repertoire for *muwashshahat* we know today was actually composed in the 19th and 20th centuries by Egyptian and Syrian composers.

The major *muwashshah* composers of the 20th century were Sayed Darwish, Dawud Husni, Mahmud Subh, Muhammad ‘Uthman, Kamil al-Khula‘i, and Darwish al-Hariri from Egypt, and ‘Ali al-Darwish, Omar al-Batsh (1885–1950), Majdi al-‘Aqili, and Ahmad Abu Khalil al-Qabbani from Syria. Nevertheless, Andalusia² is still an inseparable part of the form’s name for historic reasons, and some musicians simply (and inaccurately) refer to the *muwashshah* repertoire as “Andalusiyyat.” Fairouz’s “*Andalusiyyat*” album, for example, was composed and released in 1966 and combines centuries-old poetry with (relatively) contemporary music.

The *muwashshah* tradition is especially big in Syria, in cities such as Aleppo (where it flourished and was well preserved orally for centuries) and later in the capital, Damascus. In the 20th century, the *muwashshah* tradition in Syria was sustained by excellent singers such as Bakri al-Kurdi (1909–1978), Sabri al-Mudallal (1918–2006), Muhammad Khayri, and Sabah Fakhri. Khayri and Fakhri were both extremely well versed in the *muwashshah* repertoire and had their share of beautiful concerts and recordings until Khayri’s death in 1981, at which point Sabah Fakhri became the most well-known and recorded Syrian *muwashshah* singer.

The subject of a *muwashshah* is almost predominantly love (or more specifically, unrequited love), although it could also be about the drinking of fine wine, a metaphor often used in Sufism for divine intoxication. The lyrics of a *muwashshah* are traditionally in *fusha* (classical Arabic language), although a few *muwashshahat* occasionally break that rule and instead include some lyrics in colloquial (regional) spoken Arabic (*‘ammiyya*). For example, the *muwashshahat* “*fi-r-roud ana shuft il-gamil*” (by Omar al-Batsh), “*ya bahjit ir-rouh*” (by Sayed Darwish), and “*inq il-malih il-ghali*” all have some lyrics in Egyptian or Syrian colloquial Arabic. Moreover, some foreign words, such as *aman*, *janim*, and *‘umrim*, started creeping

² Andalusia, its music and nostalgia are discussed in great detail in Shannon’s book *Performing Al-Andalus* (Shannon, 2015).

in from the Turkish language in the 19th century and have become an inseparable component of *muwashshah* lyrics.

Each *muwashshah* is named after the first few words of its opening line. The number of words depends on how long the words are, but in general it is between two and four. The tradition of naming a song after its opening line instead of assigning it a title is a very long established one in Arabic music. The result is very pragmatic, since listeners can learn a song's name just by listening to the opening line.

The two principal books that document the *muwashshah* repertoire are *Min Kunuzina* (From Our Treasures) by Nadim 'Ali al-Darwish (son of Aleppan composer 'Ali al-Darwish) and Dr. Fu'ad Raja'i (1955, Damascus), and *al-Muwashshahat al-Andalusiyya, Nash'atuba wa Tatawuriha*, by Lebanese music professor Salim al-Hilu (1965, Beirut). Both books catalog about 200 *muwashshahat* and include notation, lyrics, the *iga'* name and prototypal measure, as well as the composer and lyricist names for each *muwashshah*. The repertoire is organized by *maqamat*, with one chapter per *maqam*, and the books cover the nine most common *maqamat* (Rast, Bayati, Sikah, Saba, Hijaz, Kurd, Nahawand, 'Ajam, and Nikriz) in their simple form, with a few additions for *maqamat* within the same family. This organization is based on practical reasons: *muwashshahat* are usually performed in groups organized as a suite in one *maqam* at a time (see the "*Wasla*" section later in this chapter).

The *muwashshah* is melodically divided into multiple sections. The first section is called the *dawr* (a repeating or cyclic melody). The *dawr* introduces the *muwashshah's* principal *maqam* with its main *ajnas* and should be repeated at least twice (a few *muwashshahat* repeat the *dawr* three or four times, e.g., "*ya man la'ibat bihi shamulu*"). Many *muwashshahat* introduce another melodic section called *khana* (a generic word for verse or section) after the second *dawr*. The *khana* explores modulations from the principal *maqam* and is likely to include a *tafrid* (a solo improvisation on the composed melody by one or more singers). When a *khana* exists, it is usually followed by a section called *ghita'*, which is melodically identical to the *dawr* and brings the listener back to the principal *maqam* where the *muwashshah* ends. Most *muwashshahat* are therefore structured as *dawr*—*dawr*—[*dawr* . . .], for example "*ya shadi al-alhan*," or *dawr*—*dawr*—*khana*—*ghita'*, for example "*ramani bi sahmi hawahu*" and "*lamma bada yatathanna*." Any of these sections could span one or more lines of poetry.

The lyrics repeated during solo improvisations are typically very short and simple and may consist entirely of the standard *muwashshah* verbal fillers (*ah*, *aman*, *leil*, *ya leil*, *yalaalalli*,³ *janim*, and *'umrim*, many of which were borrowed from the Turkish

³ The filler word *yalaalalli* is so evocative of the *muwashshah* form that Lebanese singer Rima Khcheich used it as a title for her debut album in 2006, which included *muwashshahat* as well as original compositions.

language) stretched out to create melismata. As an example, the very popular *muwashshah* “*ma-htiyali*” has a long *khana* solo section that repeats the phrase “*yalaalalli aman*,” while the *muwashshah* “*mala il-kasat*” repeats the phrase “*aman aman yalaalalli*.”

The *muwashshah* is traditionally performed by a singer, accompanied by an ensemble as well as a choir of backing vocalists (often, in smaller ensembles, these are the instrumentalists themselves). The soloist and the choir usually alternate sections or repetitions of sections in what becomes a call-and-response exchange. While the choir sing their parts exactly as composed, the soloist (as the name suggests) may use the composed melody as a basis for improvisation, modulation, and a great deal of ornamentation, while keeping the same rhythm and using the same lyrics (*tafrid*). Some *muwashshah* performances don’t have a designated soloist; instead, the choir members take turns soloing. Solo improvisation sections alternate with choir sections several times before the soloist returns to the composed melody. While in theory any *muwashshah* can be performed in that fashion, in practice some *muwashshahat* lend themselves more to solo improvisation because of their rich melody, or simply for historic reasons.

Starting in the mid-20th century, *muwashshahat* were also recorded with one *mutrib/mutriba* and a *takht* (no choir), or with only a choir and an ensemble. As many *muwashshah* singers learned music in Sufi religious circles, where no instruments are used except for the frame drum, some later maintained the same accompaniment in their *muwashshah* performances. The name given to the small choir of backing vocalists (usually two to three men) supporting a Sufi *munshid* (cantor) is *batana* (literally, “the lining of a garment,” a name given to the backing vocalists because their voices line and thicken the singer’s own voice), a term that was eventually borrowed by secular genres such as *tarab* and *muwashshah*. A good *muwashshah* recording that uses only voices and frame drums is the triple album *The Aleppo Suites*, recorded in 2009 by Hassan al-Haffar (nicknamed *karawan halab*—“The Nightingale of Aleppo”) and his ensemble of Sufi *munshid*-s; it includes an impressive total of 43 *muwashshahat*.

Muwashshahat make use of a wide variety of *iqa’at* (rhythmic cycles; see chapter 6: Rhythm), which are chosen to be compatible with their poetic meters. While a few *muwashshahat* use short time signatures such as Ayyub (2/4), Sama’i Saraband (3/8), Wahda (4/4), or Thurayya (5/8), one of the distinguishing features of the *muwashshah* genre is its use of relatively longer, more complex *iqa’at* (having many syllabic partitions) and often odd-metered *iqa’at*. On the shorter side are Yuruk Semai (6/8), Dawr Hindi (3/8), Nawakht (7/4), and Masmudi Kabir (8/4). *Muwashshah* *iqa’at* can be even longer, starting with Aqsaq (9/8), Sama’i Thaql (10/8), ‘Awis (11/8), Mudawwar (12/8), Dharafat (13/8), Murabba’ (14/8), Muhajjar (14/4), Mukhammas (16/4), and

Khosh Rang (17). Chapter 7: A Sampling of Arabic *Iqa'at* lists these *iqa'at* in detail, along with examples of well-known *muwashshahat* that use them.

It is customary to chain several *muwashshahat* together as part of a *wasla* and join one to the next seamlessly so that the rhythm doesn't stop (if they are based on different *iqa'at*, joining is still possible, although it requires additional skill to stitch together two measures of different time signatures). On the other hand, some *muwashshahat* are composed with more than one *iqa'*, such as the *muwashshah* “*badat min al-khidri*,” which starts in Muhajjar (14), then moves to Sittatu ‘Ashar Masri (32) and ends with Yuruk Semai (8). Similarly, the *muwashshah* “*qultu lamma ghaba ‘anni*” by Omar al-Batsh starts with Nawakht (4), moves to Sama'i Saraband (8), and then to Dawr Hindi (8), before ending back in Nawakht.

Muwashshahat are considered a benchmark for a singer because they demand more advanced vocal skills in diction, breathing, complex phrasing, and ornamentation. The *muwashshah* also stands apart from other vocal forms in its rhythmic complexity and the intricate way the lyrics are fitted to the melody. Although some *muwashshahat* are simple to grasp, for the most part the singer has to be keenly aware of the rhythm when delivering the lyrics. It's very common for singers to clap or tap the *dum* and *tak* beats of the *iqa'* with their hands when they practice a *muwashshah*, especially one with an *iqa'* that spans 10 beats or more per measure.

Studying and performing *muwashshahat* is a great learning tool for musicians and is usually a required step in classical Arabic vocal training. Together, the *dawr* and *muwashshah* forms are the established benchmark for a virtuosic classical singer. Unfortunately, just like *adwar*, the repertoire of *muwashshahat* today is for the most part no longer growing, and it is rare for contemporary composers to write a new *muwashshah*. Thankfully, the existing repertoire encompasses hundreds of beautiful *muwashshahat* in most of the *maqam* families, which continue to be performed and recorded to this day.

The Qadd

The *qadd* (pl. *qudud*) is a popular song genre that originated in the city of Aleppo, Syria. For this reason, *qudud* are commonly called *al-qudud al-halabiyya* (Aleppan *qudud*). The word *qadd* in Arabic literally means “as much as” and was given to these vocal compositions in colloquial Arabic because they used existing religious melodies but replaced their lyrics with ones that dealt with love or other day-to-day secular themes.⁴ While the original religious melodies were used in Sufi *dhikr* circles,

⁴ The meaning of *qadd* in this context is equivalent to the term “contrafactum.”

qudud became very popular in secular celebrations such as weddings. There are also numerous instances of the reverse: originally secular songs in which religious lyrics were substituted for the original ones.⁵

Qadd lyrics are in the colloquial Aleppan (or sometimes Egyptian) dialects and are very accessible, down to earth, and easy to memorize. This has allowed *qudud* to survive and be well known to a wide audience. Most *qudud* that exist today were passed on orally and have no known composers. Table 8.1 shows some of the most popular *qudud*, classified according to their *maqam*.

The *qadd* is light in character, makes use of refrains, and is simple in structure and melody. *Qudud* make use of very basic and widely used *iqā'at* such as Maqsum (♩) and Malfuf (♩). This allows the *qadd* to come as a welcome relief after an intellectual and intricate suite of *muwashshahat* and may be an opportunity for the listeners to start dancing. For this reason, a typical Syrian *wasla* (suite) will have a few *muwashshahat* followed by a few *qudud*. While the public listens attentively to the *muwashshahat* in their richness, they ease up and participate when the time comes for *qudud* (which are no less *tarab* inducing).

Among the famous singers of *muwashshahat* and *qudud* from Syria are Bakri al-Kurdi, Muhammad Khayri, Sabah Fakhri, Marie Jubran, Hassan al-Haffar, Shadi Jamil, Sabri al-Mudallal, Ahmad al-Azraq, Omar al-Sarmini, Muhammad Hamadiyye, and Adib al-Dayekh.

The *Dawr*

The *dawr* (pl. *adwar*) is a composed vocal form that was developed in Egypt in the mid-1800s and finally acquired its basic structure with the work of prolific composer Muhammad 'Uthman toward the end of the 19th century.⁶ The *dawr* prospered for around a century and was the centerpiece of a *wasla* (vocal suite), but it gradually started going out of fashion by the 1930s as more contemporary forms (such as the *taqtuqa*) became more popular. Unlike other vocal forms in this chapter, which span wide regions of the Arab world, the *dawr* (pronounced “dor” in colloquial Egyptian) is very much an Egyptian genre, and its lyrics are always in Egyptian *'ammiyya* (colloquial/regional dialect), though many Egyptian *adwar* were adopted into the Aleppan repertoire in the 20th century.

The *dawr* is composed in a principal *maqam* and starts with a short *dulab* to establish that *maqam*. Unlike the use of the *dulab* in a *wasla* when preceding a *taqsim*,

⁵ Muhammad Qassas, personal communication with the author, 2002.

⁶ Ajjan (1990).

TABLE 8.1

Sample of Best-Known Aleppo <i>Qudud</i> Classified by <i>Maqam</i>	
<i>Maqam</i>	<i>Qudud</i>
Rast	"win-nabi yamma" "sayd il-'asari" "malik ya hilwa" "ya tayra tiri" "ya mal ish-sham"
Bayati	"auwal 'isbrit mabbubi" "al-beila al-beila" "il-arasiiya" "tabti hawdajha" "tikayidni leh" "ana-s-sabab" "zaman zaman" "mani ya hbayyib mani"
Bayati Shuri	"ah ya hilu ya msallini" "habibi ghab" "ya meimati"
Hijaz	"qadduka al-mayyas" "il-bulbul nagha" "beini we beinak (hali hali hal)" "ala al-'aqiq ijtama'na"
Sikah/Huzam	"yilba'lik shakk il-elmas" "marmar zamani" "yalla sawa"
Nahawand	"sibuni ya nas" "il-full wil-yasamin" "il-'uzubiiya"
Saba	"skaba ya dumu' il-'ein" "ya m-as'ad es-sabahiyya" "ya huwayda lak" "halla halla ya jamlo" "domik dom"
Jiharkah	"ar-rozana" "wahyat 'einayya"

the opening *dulab* in the *dawr* is usually only played once and is not followed by a pause or any measures on percussion. The next sections are the *madhhab* (refrain), which introduces the melodic theme, and the *ghusn* (branch or verse), which develops it. The *ghusn* is usually longer than the *madhhab* and may be marked by a shift in pace, a *maqam* modulation, or even a change in rhythm.

The distinguishing feature of the *dawr* is the third section, called the *ahat* (pl. of the expression “Ah!” in Arabic). The *ahat* section is only seen in *adwar*. It involves exchanging composed melodies using the melismatic syllable “*ah*” between the backing vocalists and the singer in a call-and-response fashion. Some innovative composers used the *ahat* section to introduce a little polyphony and add an Italian opera flavor. This can be especially seen in the *dawr* “*dayya’ti musta’bal hayati*” by Sayed Darwish, who was influenced by Italian composer Giuseppe Verdi (and considered himself the Egyptian Verdi⁷), as well as the *dawr* “*ahibb ashufak*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab, who in turn admired and was influenced by Sayed Darwish. The *ahat* section ends with a short return to the theme and starting *maqam* established in the *madhhab*.

Traditionally, only simple *iqa’at* are used in the *dawr*. In many cases, the entire *dawr* uses *Iqa’ Masmudi Kabir* (8) throughout; in others, *Masmudi Kabir* is used in the *madhhab* while *Wahda* (4) is used in the *ghusn*, with a possible variation to *Maqsum* (also 4). Composer Abdel Rahim al-Maslub broke that tradition and used the odd-metered *Iqa’ Aqsaq* (9) in the *ghusn* of his *dawr* “*fi zaman il-wasl*,” while Zakariyya Ahmad used *Iqa’ Sama’i Darij* (3) in the *madhhab* of the *dawr* “*in kan fu’adi*” and *Iqa’ Dawr Hindi* (8) in the *madhhab* of the *dawr* “*yalli tishki min il-hawa*.”

Among the early *dawr* composers were ‘Abdu al-Hamuli (1836–1901), who composed the *dawr* “*allah yisun dawlit husnak*” in *Maqam Hijazkar*; Muhammad ‘Uthman (1854–1900), who composed the very popular *dawr* “*asl il-gharam*” in *Maqam Rast*, the *dawr* “*yama-nta wahishni*” in *Maqam Hijazkar*, and the *dawr* “*kadni il-hawa*” in *Maqam Nahawand*; and Dawud Husni (1870–1937) who composed the *dawr* “*sharraf habib il-alb*” in *Maqam Hijazkar* and the *dawr* “*il-bo’d allimni-s-sabar*” in *Maqam Bayati*.

The next generation of composers who sustained the *dawr* in the 20th century was led by three groundbreaking and innovative musicians who composed and sang their own *adwar*: Sayed Darwish (“*ana haweit*” in *Maqam Kurd*, “*il-habib lil-hagri mayil*” in *Maqam Rast*, and “*dayya’ti musta’bal hayati*” in *Maqam Bayati Shuri*), Zakariyya Ahmad (“*emta-l-hawa*” in *Maqam Huzam*, “*inta fahim*” in *Maqam Huzam*, “*yalli tishki min il-hawa*” in *Maqam Bayati*, and “*min illi al*” in *Maqam*

⁷ Sahhab (1987).

Rast), and Muhammad Abdel Wahab (“*ahibb asbufak*” in Maqam Nahawand, “*ishē’ti ruhak*” in Maqam Kurd, and “*il-albi yama-ntazar*” in Maqam Nikriz). The *dawr* “*il-albi mal lil gamal*” by Syrian composer and singer Bakri al-Kurdi is one of the last *adwar* composed in the 20th century.

Among the prominent *dawr* singers in the 20th century were Umm Kulthum, Munira al-Mahdiyya, Leila Mourad, Marie Jubran, Yusuf al-Manyalawi, Abdel Hayy Hilmi, his nephew Saleh Abdel Hayy, Salama Hegazi, Zaki Mourad (father of singer Leila Mourad), and Abdel Latif al-Banna. A younger generation of *dawr* singers kept the tradition alive in the second half of the 20th century by covering *adwar* originally composed for the earlier generation. Among them were Su’ad Muhammad, Muhammad Khayri (Syria), Sabri al-Mudallal (Syria), Sabah Fakhri (Syria), and Lotfi Bouchnak (Tunisia).

Adwar are very demanding to compose and perform, which is why many composers and singers shy away from them. For a singer, the *dawr* is more demanding to memorize than more recent vocal forms because it usually includes longer and more complex musical phrases. Hence, only singers who are serious about their vocal craft include some *adwar* in their repertoire. For this reason, many fans of that genre consider Umm Kulthum’s *adwar* repertoire of the 1930s to be her best work. Whether that opinion is valid or not, the *dawr* repertoire certainly defined an era that placed technical excellence ahead of entertainment value. Unfortunately, the *dawr*’s popularity peaked in the 1930s, and today no new *adwar* are composed.

The Taqtuqa

The *taqtuqa* (Egyptian slang for “simple and light song”) is a widely popular and simple vocal form, performed by a solo vocalist accompanied by an ensemble and possibly backing vocalists. The best-suited ensemble for a *taqtuqa* is the traditional *takht*, giving the *taqtuqa* an intimate and traditional feel. The *taqtuqa* (pl. *taqatiq*) is composed in a principal *maqam* and typically starts with a short introduction to establish that *maqam*, then alternates several verses (*ghusn* or “branch” in Arabic) with a fixed refrain (*madhhab* in Arabic).

The *taqtuqa* was very popular in Egypt in the first half of the 20th century, later superseded by the more elaborate *ughniya* (free-form long-song). *Taqatiq* use simple and easy to memorize lyrics in colloquial dialect and do not have to adhere closely to a single rhyme (though they are typically rhymed). The *taqtuqa* was a departure from the more serious and elaborate *dawr* in that it had a simpler structure and was more accessible to the audience. For this reason, the number of *taqatiq* composed far surpasses the number of *adwar*.

Typical examples of a simple *taqtuqa* structure, in which verses have a fixed melody and don't change with every repetition, are “*‘ala balad il-mahbub waddini*” by Umm Kulthum, “*hayrana leh*” by Leila Mourad (1930; music by Dawud Husni), “*aminti bil-lah*” (vocals and music by Laure Daccache, 1917–2005), “*abu da-lli sar*” and “*khafif ir-rub*” (music and vocals by Sayed Darwish), and “*il-bahr biyidhak*” (music and vocals by Sheikh Imam, 1918–1995). Muhammad Abdel Wahab uses the same structure in “*lamma-nta nawi*” but expands the second verse with a mini-*mawwal*.

More complex examples are Umm Kulthum's “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*” and “*ya bid' il-ward*” by Asmahan (music by Farid al-Atrash), in which each verse uses a different melody and makes use of *maqam* modulations. Another variation on the *taqtuqa* structure is to replace the refrain with an instrumental theme that is repeated between the verses, as in Umm Kulthum's “*ha ablu bukra*” or “*il-wardi gamil*.” Some *taqatiq* have a hybrid structure in which the last part of the refrain is repeated, followed by an instrumental theme, as in Umm Kulthum's “*ma dam tihibb bitinkir leh*” (composed by Muhammad al-Qasabgi in 1940), Muhammad Abdel Wahab's “*emta-z-zaman*,” and Riyadh al-Sunbati's elaborate *taqtuqa* “*leh ya banafsig*.”

The *taqtuqa* continued to be a hugely popular vocal compositional form throughout the second half of the 20th century, probably due to its concise length and easy to memorize format. Among the prolific *taqtuqa* performers, to name only a few, were Lebanese singers Sabah, with “*‘al-basata*,” “*ya dala' dalla'*,” “*hilwit libnan*,” and dozens of others; Wadih al-Safi, with “*jayin ya arz il-jabal*,” “*al-laylu ya layla*,” and “*jannat*”; and Fairouz, with “*ya mirsal il-marasil*,” “*ya dara duri fina*,” and “*‘ala jisir il-lawziyyi*.” Today the *taqtuqa* is alive and well, in the form of the modern Arabic pop song, and on the most basic level it is equivalent to simple verse-refrain song forms used around the world.

The *Ughniya* (Long-Song)

The word *ughniya* (literally, “song” in Arabic; pl. *aghani*) refers to any general composed Arabic song that doesn't fit into any of the vocal forms described previously. Although that definition is very broad and made up the bulk of the Arabic music repertoire in the second half of the 20th century, a narrower definition exists in the context of the Golden Age of Arabic music: the *ughniya* refers to the long and elaborate song (also called *ughniya tawila*, literally, “long-song”), the genre popularized by Umm Kulthum starting in the 1940s and culminating in her most famous songs that made up the bulk of her repertoire in the latter half of her career.

The *ughniya* tends to be longer, more complex, and less constrained by traditional or inherited compositional guidelines than other Arabic vocal forms. Added

complexity translates into more sections, a longer introduction, more rhythmic changes, and more *maqam* modulations. *Aghani* also lend themselves to a richer arrangement, performed using larger ensembles (usually full Arabic orchestras). This form was also the vehicle of choice for introducing new Western instruments to the Arabic scene, such as the *org* (Arabic electric organ), electric guitar, saxophone, and trumpet. *Aghani* give the composer much more freedom, although for that reason they can also be more challenging to compose than a simpler and more constrained form.

As the *dawr* form experienced a decline, the long-song form became the preferred vehicle for composers such as Baligh Hamdi, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Muhammad al-Mougi, and Riyad al-Sunbati, and for major singers such as Umm Kulthum, Abdel Halim Hafez, Warda, and Fayza Ahmad (1934–1981). Other singers only performed long *aghani* occasionally. Such is the case for Muhammad Abdel Wahab, with “*al-nabr al-khalid*” (1954), “*kulli da kan leh*” (1954), and “*min gheir leh*” (1989), and for Farid al-Atrash, with “*al-rabi*” (1949) and “*awwil hamsa*” (1950).

A long-song can last from 15–20 minutes to over an hour, depending on how many sections it includes and how many phrases/sections are repeated in a live setting.⁸ One innovation that added to the length of the long-song is the elaborate instrumental introduction (called *muqaddima*). The *muqaddima* (pl. *muqaddimat*) became trendy around the mid-20th century, as superstar composers wanted to grab a bigger piece of the limelight. The *muqaddima* is described in detail in chapter 9: Instrumental Forms.

The long-song is also the ideal setting for the singer to perform a *tafrid* (literally, “individual performance”; pl. *tafarid*), a free-form vocal improvisation that digresses from—but stays tethered to—a composed section, usually toward the second half of the song, when the singer is warmed up and the audience is ripe. A *tafrid* may be a minute to more than 10 minutes long. In a *tafrid*, the singer picks a few words from the section’s lyrics and repeats them over and over, using different improvised melodies that start in the current *maqam* but can also modulate to other *ajnas*. The ensemble supports a *tafrid* the same way they support a *mawwal*: with droning, *tarjama*, and a steady *iqāʿ* such as Ciftetelli (♩) or Wahda (♩). Needless to say, a *tafrid* takes the singer to the height of *saltana* (modal ecstasy; see chapter 23: *Tarab*).

When long introductions, repeated sections, and *tafarid* are included, a single long-song could make up an entire commercial recording such as an

⁸ The difference in length between studio and live versions of the same song can be considerable. For example, the studio version of Umm Kulthum’s “*rubaʿiyyat al-khayyam*” (1950) lasted 35 minutes, while the live version of the same song recorded in Morocco in 1968 lasted 85 minutes.

album, CD, or cassette (some live recordings of Umm Kulthum's songs last over an hour). As such, the long-song gradually replaced the more traditional *wasla* (suite) starting in the mid-20th century as a "super-form": a framework containing other forms.

The Monologue

The monologue (the French word was adopted as is in Arabic) is a composed song based loosely on the *aria* in Opera music. The monologue is performed by one singer with an accompanying ensemble. It does not have any repeating sections, which means it keeps introducing new phrases and melodies from start to finish. As such, the monologue's melody must form one dramatic arc from beginning to end in order to maintain the listeners' attention during the entire song.

One of the early pioneers of the monologue was Sayed Darwish, who had studied classical music in Italy and was very influenced by Italian opera. In 1920 he composed the first monologue in Arabic, called "*wallahi tistabil ya albi*." But the first Arabic monologue to achieve wide success was Umm Kulthum's "*in kunti asamih*," composed by Muhammad al-Qasabgi in 1928. Like Darwish before him, Qasabgi was another early 20th-century Arabic music pioneer who was influenced by European classical music, and he masterfully introduced elements such as harmony into some of his compositions, arguably without diluting the Arabic character of his music.

Muhammad Abdel Wahab quickly followed suit and composed (and sang) two monologues in 1928—"fil-leil lamma khala" and "ahun 'aleik"—followed by "*sikitti leh ya lisani*" in 1931 and "*marreit 'ala beit il-habayib*" in 1932. Muhammad al-Qasabgi, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, and later Riyad al-Sunbati continued to compose in the monologue form for over a decade until it stopped being fashionable. Umm Kulthum's last monologue was "*in-noum yida'ib 'uyun habibi*" by Riyad al-Sunbati (1938), while Asmahan left behind a very memorable monologue called "*ya tuyur*" by Muhammad al-Qasabgi (1940).

The Duet

The duet (also called "dialogue" in Arabic) is a composed piece with two singers, taking turns or singing together. This is by no means a traditional Arabic form, nor is it common. The Arabic duet form (sometimes called *duetto* from Italian) was pioneered by Sayed Darwish, who featured it in his operettas.

The duet is usually structured as a song in which a male and a female singer exchange lines, then join together for a refrain. The duet's lyrics tend to be romantic, dramatic, and theatrical, and are often made up of actual lines from a musical play or a movie.

The duet tends not to have a constant repeating melodic structure; instead, the music just follows and supports the dramatic lines, which don't necessarily have to rhyme or follow a poetic meter. The singing in duets often resembles the theatrical delivery of lines and can sound acted, while other lines may be casually spoken as if by a character in a movie or a play. The duet is not considered a great vehicle for *tarab*, as its primary goal is to serve the theatrical product.

Muhammad Abdel Wahab composed two memorable duets that he sang with Egyptian singer/actress Leila Mourad for the movie "*yahya al-hubb*" (Long Live Love, 1938): "*ya din-na'im*" (My Heart Is in Heaven) and "*tal intizari*" (I've Been Waiting Too Long). In contrast to Abdel Wahab's dramatic style, another memorable duet was the very lighthearted and comedic "*ya salam 'ala hubbi wi hubbak*" (My Love and Your Love), sung by Farid al-Atrash and Egyptian singer/actress Shadia (born Fatima Ahmad Kamal, 1931–2017), from the movie "*inta habibi*" (You Are My Love, 1957).

Duets became extremely popular in Lebanese operettas, especially from the 1950s through the 1970s. The prolific Lebanese Rahbani Brothers composed dozens of operettas, for example "*sabrit il-hubb*" (An Evening of Love, released with the alternative English title "Oriental Evening", 1971), which often dealt with romantic and patriotic plots set in a romanticized Lebanese village. These operettas featured many duets by Fairouz and male singers such as Wadhi al-Safi or Nasri Shamseddin (1927–1983). Likewise, Lebanese diva Sabah sang her share of duets during her musical plays, for example "*shahr il-'asal*" (The Honeymoon) in 1974. These types of duets were not musical pieces in their own right, but rather dialogues from a play that were set to music.

The *Wasla*

The *wasla* (literally, "connection" or "link" in Arabic; pl. *waslat*) is a "super-form." It is a multisectional suite, consisting of several related compositions and improvisations, all based on the same *maqam*. The *wasla* may be instrumental only (*aliyya*, from *ala*, instrument) or vocal (*ghina'iyya*, from singing, *ghina*'), although the vocal *wasla* is much more common and traditional, since Arabic music is primarily vocal. A rich *wasla* combines both vocal and instrumental forms and both composed and improvised forms.

In terms of duration, a short *wasla* can be about 5 or 10 minutes long, a medium-size *wasla* can be 20–25 minutes long, and a long *wasla* could run from 45 minutes to an hour. In general, the longer the *wasla*, the heavier the *tarab* content, although a *wasla* on the longer side would require a more experienced and patient audience. A full concert may be organized as three to four *waslat*, each devoted to one *maqam*; an Arabic music CD could have anywhere from one very long *wasla* to two or three shorter *waslat*.

The *wasla*'s pieces are organized in such a way as to produce a narrative arc that rises gently and saves the highest intensity for the end. The optimal duration of a *wasla* has a lot to do with the optimal time for listeners to get immersed in one *maqam* (albeit with modulations to other *maqamat*). Too short a time would not take listeners through a full *tarab* cycle, while too long a time would cause saturation and desensitization, leading to boredom.

The *wasla* is the ultimate framework to consume a *maqam*. If individual forms are like delicious recipes, the *wasla* is the five-course dinner that includes an appetizer, a soup, a salad, a main course, a side dish, and a dessert. By the end of a *wasla*, the *maqam* runs deep in the listeners' ears and consciousness, which is what *tarab/saltana* is really about (the intimate relationship between a *wasla* and *tarab* is discussed at length in chapter 23: *Tarab*).

The start of a vocal *wasla* (the appetizer) is usually instrumental, as the singer needs to hear the *maqam* for a few minutes in order to deliver his or her best performance. The *dulab*, *taqsim*, *bashraf*, or *sama'i* instrumental forms can all be used to open a *wasla*. The first course is usually vocal and may consist of a few *muwashshahat* performed back to back. *Muwashshahat* would be a comfortable start for singers, since they would be mostly delivering a composition instead of improvising. In between courses, if time permits, one of the musicians in the *takht* usually plays a short *taqsim*. Here the root of the word *taqsim* (literally, “subdivision” or “partition”) becomes apparent. The second course could be a long *mawwal* or *qasida* that showcases both the *maqam* and the singer's virtuosity. That's when the *wasla*'s intensity starts rising. The third course is frequently a *dawr*; this is the meat dish and the centerpiece of the *wasla*. A *wasla* could end there or could unwind with some lighter songs, usually *qudud* or *taqatiq* (the dessert). This is by no means a fixed formula, although it is found frequently; in practice any set of pieces or songs played in sequence in the same *maqam* can be considered a *wasla*, and master vocalists may improvise the *wasla*'s structure on the spot in live performance, when working with ensembles that know their repertoire well.

A medium-size *wasla* example is Egyptian singer Saleh Abdel Hayy's 24-minute *wasla* in Maqam Rast centered on the *tagtuqa* “*leh ya banafsig*” (Why, O Violets?), composed by Riyad al-Sunbati in 1930. That *wasla* comprises a *taqsim* on the ‘*ud*,

Sama'i Rast by Kemani (violinist) Tatyos Efendi Ekserciyan with a two-minute violin *taqsim* (inserted—as tradition requires—before the fourth *khana*), a very brief *qanun taqsim*, a *layali* in Maqam Rast, and finally the *taqtuqa* itself.

At the longer end of the spectrum, a one hour *wasla* example in Maqam Rast from the double CD *The Aleppo Music Room* (Vol. II, 1998) by Ensemble al-Kindi comprises a *nay taqsim*, a *sama'i*, a *qanun taqsim*, some *layali*, four *muwashshahat* back to back, a long improvised *qasida* (the centerpiece), an 'ud *taqsim*, a shorter *qasida*, and finally to unwind, a *qadd*. The transition from *muwashshahat* or *adwar* to *qudud* marks the end of the formal part of the *wasla* and brings a very relaxed mood, as the *qadd* is a much simpler form for listeners to memorize and sing along with and has the added advantage of being sung in a colloquial dialect.

Aleppan singer Sabah Fakhri produced a series of 14 recordings in 1978 called *Nagham al-Ams* (Tunes of the Past). Each episode (sometimes two) in the series was devoted to one *maqam* and was organized as a *wasla*, starting with instrumental pieces such as a *sama'i* or a *bashraf*, followed by several *muwashshahat*, then some *taqsim*, then a *dawr*, a long *mawwal* or improvised *qasida*, and finally some *qudud* to conclude. This archival series covers eight of the nine most common *maqam* families (the Nikriz family was not included) plus Maqam Jiharkah. *Nagham al-Ams* clearly shows the principal place that the *wasla* occupies in showcasing a *maqam* and creating an extended listening experience that best delivers *tarab*.

The *Maqam* in Composed Forms

All of the forms described here and in chapter 9: Instrumental Forms draw upon the melodic framework of *maqam*, and *maqam* is much more than just a scale (as described in detail in the theory chapters). *Maqamat* have their own rich, internal structure, based on the large-scale movement of melodies from one part of a scale (a *jins*) to another, and changes to different notes within the scale (modulation). We can see that melodic structure within the compositional forms, supporting and interacting in different ways with the other aspects of the form described already.

A *maqam* has a built-in story or dramatic arc, as described in chapters 19, 20, 21, and 23: an opening in a particular *jins*, with stereotypical, familiar melodies; a development through modulations to new areas, some familiar and some unfamiliar; and a return and resolution to the starting point. Successful compositions use that *maqam* arc to full advantage.

Songs and instrumental compositions with a verse-refrain format use the refrain as both the starting and ending point for the *maqam* arc, with a strong melodic emphasis in the core *jins* of the *maqam*. The refrain must tell a mini-story all its

own, using one or at most two *ajnas* to create a satisfying exposition as well as a resolution. Verses can take advantage of other areas within the *maqam* to add interest and drama.

Some simple forms, such as the *qadd* or the simple *taqtuqa*, have verses that repeat the same melody with different words, in which case the *maqam* arc can expand slightly, but not too far. Often the verses begin in the most common secondary *jins* for the *maqam* and lead back toward the refrain to resolve the melody back to the final tonic. Other forms allow for different melodies in each verse, including more complex *taqatiq* and the verse-refrain instrumental forms such as the *sama'i*, *bashraf*, and *longa*. In these cases, each verse typically explores a new area of the *maqam*, building drama from verse to verse through modulations that are more distant from the root *jins*.

Muwashshahat and *maqtu'at* can often have an even more complex structure, with some repeating melodies, but a format less strict than verse-refrain. In that case, more distant modulations are possible, because the form doesn't always return to the "home" area of the *maqam* (the root *jins*) in between excursions to different areas, as it does when there is a constantly repeating refrain. These forms allow a richer development of the *maqam*'s narrative arc.

Forms with even less of a repetitive structure, such as the composed *qasida*, the *dawr*, and the *monologue*, can more fully embrace the *maqam*'s *sayr* on its own terms, journeying through numerous areas before returning back home. In this case, the *maqam* itself can provide the major signposts that articulate the song's structure by using each new *jins* to articulate a different section. The same is true when forms with a more repetitive structure have sections that allow for improvisation, such as some *taqatiq* and *maqtu'at* as well as the *tahmila*; the improvisations allow for greater *maqam* exploration, often emphasizing new secondary *ajnas* that are not covered in the composed sections of the piece.

Finally, larger-scale forms, in particular the *ughniya* (long-song) and the *wasla*, allow for a full exploration of a *maqam*'s potential and even modulations to other, more distant, *maqamat*. The *wasla*, a suite of multiple songs, instrumental compositions, and improvisations, requires an exhaustive treatment of the *maqam*; since all of the components are nominally in the same *maqam*, in order to prevent boredom, each song should explore a slightly different area of the *maqam*, and by the time the *wasla* is over, the entire breadth of possible journeys can be covered.

The *ughniya* (and its *muqaddima*) has been the vehicle for the greatest experimentation within the *maqam* system, since its large-scale form is not set by tradition. Yet it maintains the aesthetic requirements of *tarab*: some elements of familiarity and repetition combined with surprises and detours. Within these broad parameters, different composers were able to create new *maqam* structures that expanded upon the tradition and expanded the *maqamat* themselves.

9

INSTRUMENTAL FORMS

ARABIC INSTRUMENTAL MUSIC comes in many forms, called *qawalib* in Arabic (singular *qalab*, literally meaning a “mold” or “shaped container”). This chapter focuses mostly on the major composed forms used in the urban traditions from Egypt and Greater Syria, from what is known as the Golden Age of Arabic music (1930s–1960s). All these forms serve to showcase the Arabic *maqam* and create *tarab* in its listeners.

Ottoman Instrumental Composed Forms

The *sama'i*, *bashraf*, and *longa* forms are part of the Ottoman classical music repertoire, adopted into the Arabic repertoire during the late Ottoman period, ending with World War I. Initially, Arab musicians studied and performed pieces in these forms composed by Ottoman musicians (who included Turks, Armenians, and Greeks), but over time musicians in the Arab world started composing their own pieces in these forms, and they still do so to this day. Although these forms have survived well, now they tend to appeal only to classical Arabic music fans and aficionados. It would be unlikely, for example, to hear a *sama'i* or a *longa* performed today on Arabic commercial radio or in a nightclub.

These three instrumental forms have a basic verse-refrain structure in which a principal refrain comes back after every new verse. As such, all three forms share the same naming convention for their structural components: the *khana* (pl. *khanat*), derived from the Persian word *khaneh* (literally, “home” or “house”), is a verse, while the *taslim* is the recurring refrain or motif.

The three forms are composed and anchored in a principal *maqam* that lends its name to the composition. Traditionally, compositions in all three forms maintain a very tight connection to their principal *maqam*, and while the melody from the second *khana* onward usually modulates to other areas of the *maqam*, the *taslim* always returns to the central area of the *maqam* and the primary, root *jins* of that *maqam*. For this reason, one possible way to look at the *sama'i*, *bashraf*, and *longa* forms is as etudes¹ in a *maqam* as they showcase its habitual and rich melodic behavior.

THE *SAMA'I*

The *sama'i* (also spelled *samai*, pl. *sama'iyyat*) is a composed instrumental form that consists of four *khanat*, each followed by the same *taslim*. The Turkish name for this form is *saz semai*, which is in turn derived from the Arabic word *sama'i* (an adjective that means “aural” or “for listening,” and is now back in Arabic as the form’s name). The Turkish *saz semai* and the Arabic *sama'i* are essentially the same form, with subtle differences in the overall feel of their performances and where they fit in a musical suite.

The *sama'i* is by far the most prominent Ottoman instrumental form in Arabic music. It is a great teaching tool and a standard benchmark for instrumentalists, allowing them to achieve and demonstrate technical and artistic mastery of their instruments. The *sama'i* is usually named after the composer and the principal *maqam* it is anchored in, as in the ubiquitous and obligatory “Sama'i Bayati Ibrahim al-'Aryan” or “Sama'i Hijazkar Kurd Tatyos Efendi.” Even musicians who have very few compositions will have their names immortalized in the *sama'i*'s title itself.

The *sama'i* is composed in the ¹⁹/₈ *iqā'* called Sama'i Thaḳil (Sama'i for short), which is extremely similar to the Turkish *usul Aksak Semai* that the Turkish form is composed in (the Arabic version has two *dum*-s instead of one in the second half of the *iqā'*). The *iqā'* Sama'i Thaḳil is observed during the first three *khanat*

¹ Dr. Samer Ali, conversation with the author, 2015.

and the *taslim*. The fourth *khana*, which precedes the last statement of the *taslim*, is usually composed in a short and odd-metered *iqāʿ*, typically Samaʿi Saraband ($\frac{3}{8}$). Contemporary composers have occasionally used $\frac{5}{8}$, $\frac{7}{8}$, or $\frac{9}{8}$ *iqāʿat* in the fourth *khana*, with tradition strongly favoring an odd-metered *iqāʿ*. Innovative composers may have an elaborate fourth *khana* with multiple sections, each based on a different *iqāʿ* (e.g., “Samaʿi Bayati Marcel Khalife”). In addition, while the first three *khanat* usually consist of four to six measures, the fourth *khana* allows the most freedom by not enforcing a set number of measures, and it therefore may be a little longer.

Although the *samaʿi* is used to end a suite in the Ottoman classical tradition, it often plays the opposite role in the Arabic tradition. The *samaʿi* is a great form for opening a concert or a set and to set the mood for a *maqam* before starting a *taqsim*, *mawwal*, or any composed vocal form, especially a suite of *muwashshahat*. Quite often, only part of a *samaʿi* is enough to set the mood, and many recordings use only the first *khana* followed by the *taslim* as a substitute for the more standard *dulab*. Table 9.1 lists some of the Ottoman and Arabic *samaʿiyyat* that have survived well and are still being performed and taught today.

THE BASHRAF

The *bashraf* (pl. *basharif*) is a composed instrumental form that consists of four *khanat*, each followed by the same *taslim*. The name *bashraf* comes from the Turkish *peşrev* (an instrumental prelude, from the Persian *peshrev*, meaning “that which precedes”), because a *bashraf* is usually played as the opening composition in a suite of several pieces in the same *maqam*, in the Ottoman classical tradition.

Unlike the *samaʿi*, the *bashraf* usually follows one single *iqāʿ* throughout the composition, in most cases an even-metered *iqāʿ*, such as Masmudi ($\frac{8}{4}$), Dawr al-Kabir ($\frac{28}{4}$), Mukhammas ($\frac{16}{4}$), or Shanbar ($\frac{24}{4}$), and in many cases one of the even longer *iqāʿat* from the Ottoman repertoire. In some cases, the *iqāʿ* is so long that one measure suffices for an entire *khana* or *taslim*.

Of the three Ottoman instrumental forms, the *bashraf* is the least common in contemporary Arab music performance and the most archaic sounding. Very few Arab composers write *basharif* nowadays, and these tend to be mostly used as study aids. Among the popular *basharif* that have survived well are “Bashraf Farahfaza Ismail Hakki Bey” and “Bashraf Rast Tatyos Efendi.”

TABLE 9.1

Popular <i>Sama'iyyat</i> Being Performed Today, Listed by <i>Maqam</i>		
Name (<i>Maqam</i>)	Composer	Origin
Sama'i Bayati al-Thaqil	(Traditional)	Unknown
Sama'i Bayati	Ibrahim al-'Aryan (1892–1953)	Egypt
Sama'i Bayati	Marcel Khalife (b. 1950)	Lebanon
Sama'i Rast	Kemani Tatyos Efendi Eskerciyani (1858–1913)	Armenian/ Ottoman
Sama'i Rast	George Michel (1917–1998)	Egypt
Sama'i Rast	Muhammad al-Qasabgi (1892–1966)	Egypt
Sama'i Nahawand	Mesut Cemil (1902–1963)	Turkey
Sama'i Nahawand	Safar 'Ali (1884–1962)	Egypt
Sama'i Muhayyar	Tanburi Cemil Bey (1871–1916)	Turkish/Ottoman
Sama'i 'Ushshaq	Neyzen Aziz Dede (1840–1905)	Turkish/Ottoman
Sama'i Shadd 'Araban	Tanburi Cemil Bey (1871–1916)	Turkish/Ottoman
Sama'i Huzam	Muhammad Abdel Wahab (1902–1991)	Egypt
Sama'i Nawa Athar	Jamil 'Uways (1890–1955)	Syria
Sama'i Kurd	Abdo Dagher (b. 1936)	Egypt
Sama'i Kurd	Abraham Salman (1931–2014)	Iraq/Israel
Sama'i Hijazkar Kurd*	Kemani Tatyos Efendi Eskerciyani (1858–1913)	Armenian/ Ottoman

*This *sama'i* is composed in the Turkish Makam Kürdili Hicazkar, but it is often classified among Arab musicians as being in Maqam Kurd.

THE LONGA

The *longa* (pl. *longat*) is a composed instrumental form that has its roots in Eastern Europe. The *longa* consists of two to four *khanat*, each followed by the same *taslim*, although there are numerous variations and exceptions to this standard form (unlike the *sama'i* and *bashraff* forms, which more strictly adhere to the verse-refrain/*khana-taslim* format).

The *longa* is anchored in a principal *maqam* that lends it its name. The first, second, and third *khanat* are usually in simple $\frac{2}{4}$ lively and sparse *iqā'* called Fox, while the last *khana* occasionally follows a short, odd-metered *iqā'* like Sama'i Saraband ($\frac{3}{8}$) or Yuruk Semai ($\frac{8}{8}$). The *taslim* is usually either in Iqā' Fox or another $\frac{2}{4}$ variation such as Iqā' Malfuf or Karachi. Generally, each *khana* and the *taslim* consists of eight to sixteen measures.

Even though the *longa* form migrated well into the Arabic repertoire, *longat* have maintained their Eastern European flavor² and are still predominantly composed in *maqamat* that do not include “quartertunes” (i.e., the “semitonal” *maqamat*), such as Nahawand, Nikriz, Nawa Athar, and Hijazkar.

Longat are very lively and beckon performers to play them faster and faster, because of the light and energetic $\frac{2}{4}$ Iqa‘ Fox that carries them. For this reason, they make a great vehicle for a virtuoso performer or an instrumental ensemble to shine technically.

Among the popular *longat* that have survived well are “Longa Farahfaza Riyad al-Sunbati” (Egypt), a standard repertoire piece for any Arabic ensemble, and “Longa Nahawand Tanburi Cemil Bey” (Turkey).

Arabic Instrumental Composed Forms

Instrumental pieces in their own right were not widespread in Arabic music until the 20th century, since historically Arabic music is a primarily vocal tradition. Indeed, the idea of creating *tarab* without a *mutrib* (the name given to the vocalist in Arabic, literally “the person who causes *tarab*”) goes against the long-established vocal aspect of Arabic music. For this reason, live performances and recorded albums consisting entirely of instrumental Arabic music are still rare.

Some instrumental forms, like the *muqaddima* and the *dulab*, are historically part of larger vocal forms, although today the *dulab* stands on its own as a form, and in practice the *muqaddima* often appears independently, even when it was originally composed for an *ughniya* (long-song). Other instrumental forms are still not very popular and are virtually unknown to the mainstream public, but they hold a great appeal to musicians and musicologists. Among these are the *tahmila*, *darij*, and *istihlal*. By far the most popular Arabic instrumental composed form today is the *maqtu‘a* (free-form instrumental piece), used frequently in the *raqs sharqi* repertoire. The following sections discuss most forms that have survived well and are still being composed in the 21st century.

THE *SAMA’I DARIJ*

The *sama’i darij* (*darij* for short) is a simple instrumental composition that is named after Iqa‘ Sama’i Saraband ($\frac{3}{8}$), which it uses. *Sama’i darij* compositions were widespread in the Arab world before the 20th century, but nowadays they are very rarely performed

² The origin of the *longa* form/genre is believed to be Bulgarian (Sahhab, 1987).

or composed. Like the Ottoman forms, the *sama'i darij* composition is anchored in a principal *maqam* that lends it its name, followed by the composer's name. Among the well-known *sama'i darij* examples are the traditional Sama'i Darij Hijaz (composer unknown), and Sama'i Darij Bayati composed by violinist Sami al-Shawwa.

THE DULAB

In the early 20th century, the *dulab* form (pl. *dawalib*) existed simply as a brief introduction to a song, setting the mood and *maqam*, and was played only once. This can be heard for example in the Dulab Huzam that opens *dawr* “*inta fahim*” (by Zakariyya Ahmad), the Dulab Bayati Shuri that opens the *dawr* “*dayya'ti musta'bal hayati*” (by Sayed Darwish), the Dulab Nahawand that opens the *dawr* “*ahibb ashu-fak*” (by Muhammad Abdel Wahab), and the Dulab Hijazkar that opens the *dawr* “*ya ma-nta wahishni*” (by Muhammad 'Uthman). Such *dawalib* may be extracted as stand-alone instrumental pieces and be performed without the songs they were meant to introduce.

Later, the *dulab* (Arabic for wheel or cycle) was made more independent and became a short instrumental composition with a few simple phrases. The *dulab* is the standard form used to introduce a *maqam*'s basic scale to the audience, and it takes its name from that *maqam*. A *dulab* acts like a sneak preview or a movie trailer for a *maqam*, or as a nonverbal announcement that means: “And now: presenting Maqam Rast!” Figure 9.1 shows a very popular Dulab Rast on C from the traditional oral repertoire.



FIGURE 9.1 Dulab Rast on C (traditional).

As an independent form, the *dulab* still maintains its introductory flavor, in part because it is so brief and its melodies are usually very straightforward. As such, it is most often used to open a *wasla* or to precede a *mawwal* or *taqsim*. Because *dawalib* are very short, their main melody can repeat over and over again until the *maqam* really sinks in, which is where the concept of the wheel comes in. Repetitions may

be separated by two measures played solo on a percussion instrument. In many cases, the number of repetitions is left to be decided during the live performance.

A good recorded example of a *dulab* repeated multiple times is the one introducing the *muwashshah* “*yamurru ‘ujuban*” in Maqam Hijazkar Kurd, recorded by Sabah Fakhri (Live at the Palais des Congrès in Paris, 1978). The *dulab* in Kurd (originally composed by Sayed Darwish for the opening of his *dawr* “*ana haweit*”) was repeated four times, and judging by the hesitation in the orchestra as they were about to start the last cycle, it seems that the number of repetitions was not agreed upon before the performance.

Aside from presenting the *maqam* to the listeners, the *dulab* helps musicians get into the mood of a *maqam* and get their ears attuned to the new scale. This is especially important for singers because their correct intonation depends on hearing the *maqam* scale well before they start.

Dawalib are usually composed either in the $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqa’ Wahda, which is slow and sparse because it has only one *dum* per measure (hence the name *wahda*, meaning one), or the lively $\frac{4}{4}$ Iqa’ Maqsum, if a lighter and faster feel is needed. Often, however, *dawalib* start in Wahda but may switch to Maqsum after one or more repetitions.

THE TAHMILA

The *tahmila* (pl. *tahmilat*) is a composed instrumental form that features a prominent call-and-response section, highlighting a soloist. The composition is anchored in a principal *maqam* that lends it its name. The *tahmila* is usually performed by a traditional *takht* and favors a $\frac{4}{4}$ *iqa’* like the lively Maqsum at moderate tempo. The $\frac{4}{4}$ *iqa’* Wahda could also be used if performed at a sufficiently energetic pace.

The *tahmila* starts with the *takht* playing a composed theme melody (the refrain) together. The theme melody consists of short motifs that showcase the *maqam*’s phrasing. Then each musician in turn plays a short solo phrase, performed with the rhythm, with a previously agreed-upon ending, and the ensemble responds by repeating the theme melody or a short version of that. All *takht* members can take turns being the soloist (even the percussionist, in some modern recordings). This way every musician gets the chance to showcase his or her talent and instrument.

A good example of a simple *tahmila* is Tahmila Saba, first recorded by the Syrian violinist Sami al-Shawwa (and transformed into Tahmila Bayati, with a simple alteration of the 4th scale degree, by Egyptian violinist Ahmad al-Hifnawi). More elaborate *tahmilat* have a call-and-response section for every soloist who navigates the *maqam* in steps and does one or more modulations on each step. The soloist starts each of these steps with an agreed-upon phrase that the ensemble uses to respond to him or her.

By far the most widely known and performed *tahmila* is Tahmila Suznak (anchored in Maqam Suznak on C), for which the steps are 3rd (E♭) with modulations to the Maqam Sikah family members, 4th (F) with modulations to the Maqam ‘Ajam family members, and 5th (G) with modulations to Maqam Bayati and its derivatives, such as Maqam Saba. After the final modulation in the final step, the soloist then signals he or she is ready to go back to the theme by starting the first few notes, to be followed by the entire ensemble. Interestingly, many of the modulation ideas and even phrases in Tahmila Suznak have been handed down orally and have become clichés that most musicians perform in the same way, even though the original purpose behind the *tahmila* form is to have each soloist improvise new material.

An excellent 14-minute video recording of Tahmila Suznak was made in the 1950s by an all-star ensemble of Egyptian musicians led by violinist Ahmad al-Hifnawi, with George Michel on ‘ud, Mahmud ‘Iffat on *nay*, Hassan Anwar on *riqq*, Mahmud al-Hifnawi on cello, and Mahmud Ahmad on *qanun*. Naturally, Tahmila Suznak appears in many classical Arabic music recordings, and one of the best versions is found in Simon Shaheen’s 1992 recording *Turath*. A very interesting twist on Tahmila Suznak was done by Ensemble Morkos (Lebanon) in their 2005 recording *Cèdre*, which is entirely in Maqam Bayati; their *tahmila* is a Maqam Bayati transposition of Tahmila Suznak.

The *tahmila* form was more popular in the first half of the 20th century, while today it would not be the first choice as a form to compose in. In general, *tahmila* compositions and recordings are few and far between compared to other instrumental forms and tend only to be enjoyed by the classical Arabic music connoisseur crowd.

THE MAQTU‘A

The *maqtu‘a* (Arabic for “piece”; pl. *maqtu‘at*), also colloquially called *qit‘ah* (another word for “piece”), is an elaborate free-form instrumental composition, usually composed for a *takht* or preferably an orchestra. It is also alternatively called *ma‘zufa* (Arabic for an “instrumental performance”; pl. *ma‘zufat*). Some sources simply call an instrumental composition by the generic term *musiqi* (music).

The *maqtu‘a* is typically divided into diverse melodic sections, with or without a refrain, involving complex phrases. Each section may have its own *iqā‘* and possibly a modulation to a new *maqam*. A good *maqtu‘a* includes opportunities for solo sections or interesting arrangements and offers breaks in the melody where a short *taqsim* can be inserted if desired.

When the Egyptian film industry started to flourish, many composers wrote *maqtu‘at* to be featured in soundtracks. Farid al-Atrash and Muhammad Abdel Wahab were prolific *maqtu‘a* composers. In a live setting, and in the absence of a singer, the *maqtu‘a* primarily features the composer and the performers. Having said

that, many *maqtu'at* were composed as dance pieces and have a name that begins with *raqsat* (dance); these *maqtu'at* feature the dancer. The more rich and diverse the composition, the more material it offers the dancer to choreograph and shine artistically on.

Among the classic *maqtu'at* that any serious practitioner of classical Arabic music should know by heart are “*dhikrayati*” by Muhammad al-Qasabgi; “*raqsat al-jamal*,” “*kahramana*,” and “*tuta*” by Farid al-Atrash; and “*balad il-mahbub*,” “*‘aziza*,” “*bint il-balad*,” and “*khatwit habibi*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab, all of which are also standards in the *raqs sharqi* repertoire.

THE MUQADDIMA

The *muqaddima* (Arabic for “introduction”; pl. *muqaddimat*) is an instrumental composition used to introduce a vocal piece. The *muqaddima* is longer, richer, and more complex than *dawalib* or short introductions. A complex *muqaddima* may have several sections with different tempos and frequently modulates to several *maqamat* before the vocal sections begin.

Rich *muqaddimat* can be very entertaining in their own right and usually include several short notated solos to showcase the principal instrumentalists in the ensemble (these solos are usually well received by the audience and are met with heavy applause in a live setting).

Muqaddimat as complex pieces in their own right came about around the middle of the 20th century with composers such as Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Baligh Hamdi, Sayed Makkawi, Muhammad al-Mougi, and Riyadh al-Sunbati, who wanted a modest share of the stage before stellar vocalists such as Umm Kulthum, Warda, and Abdel Halim Hafez started singing. An elaborate *muqaddima* can last five minutes or more.

One of the most well-known and well-liked *muqaddimat* is that of Umm Kulthum’s “*alf leila we leila*” (by Baligh Hamdi), which could run up to 8 minutes (depending on the recording and the number of section repetitions), while the entire song runs over 40 minutes. That *muqaddima* was so memorable that it was sampled and remixed as a club anthem in the 2000s by various artists with more contemporary instruments (synthesizer and electronic rhythm machines). The same goes for the *muqaddima* to Umm Kulthum’s “*inta ‘umri*” (by Muhammad Abdel Wahab).

Other famous *muqaddimat* open Umm Kulthum’s “*leilet il-hubb*” and “*ya msah-barni*,” Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*qari’at al-finjan*” and “*nibtidi minein il-hikaya*,” and Warda’s “*fi youm we leila*.” Many of these famous *muqaddimat* are today part of the standard repertoire of a *raqs sharqi* (belly dance) ensemble, although they were not originally composed for that purpose.

10

ARRANGEMENT

THIS CHAPTER DISCUSSES arrangement, as well as the occasional uses of harmony, in the context of music composed in the Arabic *maqam* system. Since *maqam* music is primarily monophonic, meaning it is based on one melody without accompanying harmony, one might expect all instruments (except for the percussion section) to play the same melody in unison. In practice, though, ensembles do more than play in unison all the time. Depending on the size of the ensemble and available instruments, Arabic music can be enriched using a variety of arrangement techniques. These techniques were developed extensively in the 20th century, especially by Egyptian and Lebanese composers, resulting in the creation of rich and varied ensemble sounds despite the absence of harmony and polyphony (elements that are central to Western arrangement techniques).

Arrangers

In Arabic music, one cannot easily buy sheet music for a classical piece or a long-song arranged for an orchestra. The most widely available scores are not original (they are scores that have been transcribed and published by someone other than the composer/music publisher). These are usually made up of one melodic line without any

additional information about arranging the piece. Instead of that being a drawback, it ends up being an advantage because it leaves orchestration choices entirely open.

Small Arabic ensembles of the size of a *takht* (traditional chamber group) don't usually need an arranger if all the members are experienced enough. In that case, arrangement generally can be guided by the aesthetic tradition, and musical parts can be arranged informally by consensus. Members of a small ensemble usually arrive at an agreement on how to layer the various parts of a musical piece (deciding which instrument skips what part) after a short discussion.

Larger ensembles and orchestras are more likely to require an arranger (usually the conductor), who also takes on the task of transcribing pieces for the ensemble from recordings or from the oral tradition, then arranging them into scores suitable for that ensemble. Scores created by the arranger usually have notated parts for each group of instruments, especially if some of them include solos. When performing the piece in a live concert, the orchestra may or may not use the score (the Umm Kulthum Orchestra performed for decades without any scores, and they always memorized their arrangements).

Arrangement Approaches

The Arabic word for musical arrangement is *tawzi'* (meaning "distribution," in this case the distribution of roles, i.e., the musical division of labor). Arabic arrangement can be thought of as a form of subtraction rather than addition. While the entire ensemble or orchestra can theoretically play one melody in unison, the arranger judiciously decides when some instruments should refrain from performing some parts, when to take turns, what combinations of instruments sound good together, and what instruments are appropriate for a solo line. This arrangement strategy can alleviate monotony by creating a question-and-answer (call-and-response) interchange between different musicians. The subtractive approach is very common in *lazimat* (sing. *lazima*, a short instrumental phrase that separates two long vocal phrases), in which only a few instruments or one section of the ensemble plays the *lazima*.

The double (upright) bass has evolved to perform a specific role within Arabic arrangements. Bass players do not normally play the entire melody line as composed; instead they usually play a skeletal version of the melody, paying particular care to include notes that fall on the main rhythmic accents (*dum* and *tak*) in order to emphasize the *iqa'* and support percussion instruments. There are, however, a few cases in which the double bass is used to play the same melodic line as the remaining melodic instruments; this is usually done for a short phrase (frequently a *lazima*)

and has the effect of emphasizing a melodic passage, before returning to playing the skeletal version of the melody and emphasizing the *iqā'* instead.

Aside from deciding who plays what melody, arrangement in Arabic music is also concerned with tonal range, color, volume, and the diversity of ornamentation leading to agreeable heterophony. The dynamics of a piece are also an important consideration, as the arranger chooses the right instruments to convey the desired mood. For all these reasons, arrangement in Arabic music is an art that requires a lot of experience.

Instrumentation

As discussed in chapter 1: Melodic Instruments, a very useful classification for arranging Arabic music is the one that separates melodic instruments into the sustaining (*sabb*) and percussive (*naqr*) groups. Sustaining instruments such as the violin, *nay*, accordion, and *org* complement percussive instruments such as the *'ud*, *qanun*, *buzuq*, electric guitar, and double bass. A pleasing ensemble would ideally combine instruments from both groups. Examples of duets that combine both types of instruments are the *'ud* paired with the violin and the *qanun* paired with the *nay*.

The next important consideration is how to match instruments to the human voice, itself a prime sustaining instrument. The most popular instrument to be paired with the voice is the *'ud*, because it is percussive, warm, and not too loud. In addition, the *'ud* has a wide pitch range that includes the vocal range of most singers and allows very fine control of intonation to match the singer's intonation. Songs in which a singer is accompanied by the *'ud* alone are as popular as songs involving a singer and a guitar in American folk music. On the other hand, it would be unusual to hear a performance of voice accompanied by the *nay* or the violin alone. Voice and *qanun* are also very well suited as long as the *qanun*'s volume doesn't overshadow the voice. That pairing becomes extremely popular when the *qanun* does reinterpretation (*tarjama*) behind a singer during a vocal improvisation.

The guitar, piano, and all instruments based on the 12-tone ET system need special attention when playing *maqamat* that include one or more quartertones in their notated scale. Unless these instruments are Arabized (enhanced to include quartertones), they need to avoid all quartertones in the entire melody.

An interesting strategy for achieving that has been developed over the years. Musicians don't simply skip the quartertones but play all other notes; that would sound too obvious (like a piano missing a key). Instead they skip short phrases that involve quartertones, so they weave in and out of playing in order to sound more consistent. Some guitar players take an approach similar to a bass player and only accent the rhythm on the *dum* and *tak* sounds, or they develop that into simple bass lines or riffs. Other guitar or piano players just supplement the music with simple minor or major chords, which allows them to avoid quartertones entirely.

In order for instruments to work together and with a singer when performing a composed piece, the arranger must pay attention to such considerations as their timbre, volume, range, and intonation precision. Beautiful and rich color is achieved by pairing sustaining instruments with percussive instruments. By doing that, the arranger creates a continuous and full sound accented by percussive notes that mark the rhythm. Greater volume is achieved by layering instruments, mostly in the string section, by adding more violins and some cellos. Greater tonal range is achieved by combining instruments strong in the high register (*nay*, violin), middle register (*'ud*, *qanun*), and low register (cello and double bass).

Diversity of ornamentation leading to heterophony is a very important goal in arrangement. Each instrument has different strengths and weaknesses and therefore ornaments differently. When playing a melodic line, having every instrument in the ensemble ornament by leveraging the strengths of their instruments creates a very rich texture that is one of the immediately recognizable aspects of Arabic music.

In some styles or compositions, diversity of texture and ornamentation and a louder volume are not desirable all the time. It is often aesthetically desirable to have quiet and subtle sections, interleaved with rich and loud sections. This is very much the case when playing a *sama'i* (described in detail in chapter 9: Instrumental Forms). There, the *taslim* (refrain) is performed by the whole ensemble while each *khana* (verse) is minimally arranged to highlight few or sometimes a single instrument at a time (plus percussion). Arrangement here is subtractive instead of additive, and minimalism and subtlety are the main priority.

Droning

Although *maqam*-based Arabic music is made of a single melodic line, the arrangement can occasionally supply additional melodic lines that support the main melody. Because the main melody remains clearly featured, and the use of such countermelodies tends to be isolated to a few brief passages, this practice doesn't truly bring Arabic music into the realm of counterpoint or polyphony.

The most common supporting melody is simply a drone. One instrument continuously plays the same note (usually the tonic of the active *jins*) while the melody is performed on another instrument or by the voice. Droning is very common when a vocal or instrumental solo is taking place, but could also be used as an added melodic layer when arranging a composed piece.

Droning is very popular in Arabic music because it gives it more depth (as a minimal form of harmony) and highlights the different groups of instruments: those droning and those carrying the melody. Droning also creates tension in the music

and draws the listener's attention to the melodic line being supported by the drone, especially when the active *jins* changes and the drone changes with it.

During an improvisation, arrangement is concerned with how to support the solo instrument (including the voice). One approach is to have all other instruments drone (whether they are sustaining or percussive). Another approach is to have just a few instruments drone while the remaining instruments quiet down. When *tarjama* is involved (see chapter 22: Vocal Improvisation for an explanation of *tarjama*), it can be performed either by the entire ensemble or by a select few instruments while others quiet down or drone.

String instruments such as the *'ud* and the *qanun* can also be used to perform their own drones, usually in the lower register. The violinist can play a drone using a technique called double-stop, in which two strings are bowed simultaneously, with one carrying the melody and the other droning. Another instrument that supplies its own drones is the *buzuq*; droning on the lower string is central to its ornamentation aesthetic.

Some instruments have a built-in drone feature. This is the case with the *arghul* (a folk wind instrument popular in Egypt and Palestine). The *arghul* is made up of two pipes. The shorter one has holes and is used for playing the melody; the other one is longer (and therefore bassier), has no holes, and is used to play the drone continuously.

Melodic *Iqa'at*

Another possible division of labor, especially common during a vocal or instrumental improvisation, is to have some melodic instruments mimic the *iqa'* performed by the percussion section, by playing the *dum*-s and *tak*-s as a melody (what Marcus describes as “playing a repeated melodic and/or rhythmic ostinato pattern”¹). The simplest version of a melodic *iqa'* only uses two pitches, one acting as the *dum* and the other acting as the *tak*. However, the melody can be more elaborate than the strict *iqa'* skeleton and can be ornamented with a few more notes to produce a richer line. The result sounds similar to a vamp in jazz or a riff in pop or rock and roll music.

Any melodic instrument can be used in a melodic *iqa'*; however, much of its accent comes from *naqr* (percussive) melodic instruments (which include the plucked double bass and plucked violins playing pizzicato).

¹ Marcus (2007).

The most common example of a melodic *iqā'* is based on the ubiquitous Iqā' Ciftetelli, used in almost every improvisation. The notes actually played on the *dum* and *tak* beats vary² with the size of the given *jins* used (see chapter 13: The *Jins* for the definition of the size of a *jins*). When the melody is in *Jins Rast* or *Nahawand* (5-note *ajnas*), for example, the *dum* and *tak* notes are typically a perfect fourth interval apart, with the 5th degree in the lower octave playing the *dum*-s and the tonic playing the *tak*-s (see figure 10.1).



FIGURE 10.1 Iqā' Ciftetelli played melodically under *Jins Rast/Nahawand* on C.

With the melody in *Jins Bayati* or *Hijaz* (4-note *ajnas*), the *dum* is usually played on the 7th degree in the lower octave, and the *tak* on the tonic (see figure 10.2).



FIGURE 10.2 Iqā' Ciftetelli played melodically under *Jins Hijaz/Bayati* on D.

Another example of a rhythmic melodic line is the one on Iqā' Bambi from Muhammad Abdel Wahab's 1932 song "*gafnuhu 'allam al-ghazal*" in *Maqam 'Ajam* (see figure 10.3).



FIGURE 10.3 Iqā' Bambi played melodically under *Jins 'Ajam* in the song "*gafnuhu 'allam al-ghazal*."

During a vocal improvisation underpinned by a melodic *iqā'*, the instrument providing *tarjama* breaks ranks after every vocal pause to reiterate the last few phrases, then goes back to the riff when the vocalist resumes.

Melodic *iqā'at* can also be a composed feature. The opening line of the *raqs sharqi* standard instrumental piece "*kahramana*" (1950) by Farid al-Atrash features the

² For no apparent reason other than tradition.

percussive instruments ('*ud*, *qanun*, bass) playing a simple rhythmic melodic line along with the percussion section over what sounds like Iqa' Hacha' in $\frac{4}{4}$, while the violin section plays a slow melody over that, thereby creating two composed melodic lines.

Harmony

Harmony, which is a fundamental aspect of all Western music genres, is incompatible with the Arabic *maqam* system, for many reasons. The first is pragmatic and technical: many of the Arabic *maqam* scales don't have the necessary tonal intervals for creating pleasing chords (this is described in detail in chapter 11: Tuning System). Chords sound harmonious when the intervals between notes can be defined using small integer ratios; while most *maqam* scales have simple ratios between their tonic and their 4th or 5th degrees, many lack such simple ratios between other notes. For example, strumming a 3-note chord made up of the 1st, 3rd, and 5th degrees of the Rast or Sikah *maqam* scales is considered discordant according to traditional understandings of harmony.

The second reason for the incompatibility is more aesthetic. *Maqam*-based music has traditions that guide its *sayr* (melodic course), and these traditions do not include harmony. This is very different from a harmonic musical tradition in which the melody is often constructed with (or constrained by) underlying chords. In such music, chords can often be inferred from hearing the melody played alone. In Arabic music, on the other hand, the focus is on the variations and elaborations of single melodic lines, and for this reason harmony would in some sense serve as a distraction from a *maqam*'s traditional *sayr*.

Ornamenting Using Harmony

Despite harmony's incompatibility with *maqam*-based Arabic music, it can nevertheless be used in small amounts as an ornament. While using more elaborate harmony is not traditional, composers and arrangers started introducing some harmony and chords in the early to mid-20th century as European music's influence grew in the Arab world, and Western instruments such as the piano became commonplace. Such a use of harmony was the result of a conscious decision on behalf of these composers and arrangers to innovate and include a Western touch in their music, the most prominent among them being Sayed Darwish and Muhammad al-Qasabgi. When used judiciously, a little harmony can result in a pleasant embellishment and doesn't compromise the melodic quality of Arabic *maqam* music too much.

Harmony (*ta'aluf* in Arabic) has a very polarizing effect on the Arabic *maqam* landscape, as it divides *maqamat* (and their families) into two groups: *maqamat* that are compatible with harmony/chords and those that are not. The difference between the two groups comes down to a single very important criterion: whether or not the notated *maqam* scale includes quartertones. As far as harmony is concerned, the “semitonal” *maqam* families (such as Nahawand, ‘Ajam, Kurd, Hijaz, and Nikriz) are more or less compatible with chords and can be easily supported with simple chords in the background, while the “quartertonal” *maqam* families (such as Rast, Bayati, Sikah, Saba, and Jiharkah) are rarely if ever accompanied with chords. The exception to this rule of thumb is Maqam Bayati, which, by virtue of its minor 3rd scale degree, is more or less compatible with a minor chord on the tonic and is sometimes supported with minimal harmony.

In terms of arrangement, the electric guitar, *org*, and keyboard often supplement melodic lines with simple minor or major chords, adding occasional harmony as a color. In general, chords used to embellish *maqam*-based music from the 20th century tended to be simple because harmony was still treated as being of secondary importance to the melodic line. A common choice is a major chord for *maqamat* that have a major third interval on their third note (e.g., Hijaz, ‘Ajam) and a minor chord for *maqam* families that have a minor third interval on their third note (e.g., Nahawand, Nikriz, Bayati, and Kurd). As an alternative, melodies in Maqam Kurd can be supplemented with a major instead of a minor chord, in a manner that evokes Flamenco music. The major chord used in Maqam Kurd can clearly be heard in the opening of Umm Kulthum’s “*amal hayati*” as it was strummed on the electric guitar. The *maqamat* Rast and Sikah rarely utilize chords because they lack a minor or major third interval; however, in a later verse in Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*nibtidi min-ein il-bikaya*,” instrumental melodies in Rast are in fact accompanied with a minor chord on the *org* and the electric guitar.

Umm Kulthum’s song “*il-albi yi’sha’ kulli gamil*” is a very good example of harmony that discretely supplements and ornaments Arabic *maqam* music. Although the song is in Maqam Bayati and has a very traditional Arabic mood, the electric guitar is used in the introduction to strum minor chords on the *maqam*’s tonic without diminishing the Arabic mood of the song.

Harmony on Traditional Instruments

Toward the second half of the 20th century, harmony was readily delivered by the electric guitar, the *org* (Arabic electric organ), and the Arabic keyboard, which are all polyphonic instruments. Although traditional Arabic instruments such as the

'*ud*, *qanun*, *nay*, and violin were not designed to produce polyphonic music, they do offer the limited harmonic possibilities outlined in this section.

At the most basic level, '*ud* technique sometimes exploits the just fourths and fifths between notes in many *maqam* scales, by strumming open strings together with other notes. By virtue of its multiple strings, the '*ud* can enable more complex chords to be played (in theory). However, given that it is a fretless instrument, chord fingering is ergonomically more difficult (relative to fretted instruments), depending on the complexity of the chord (number of notes and spacing of the intervals) and what tonic the chord is in. In general, simple chords like the 3-note major and minor chords can be played relatively easily as long as the chord has enough open strings. However, many transpositions of simple chords, as well as more complex chords, become very challenging to play because each finger must fall exactly on the correct point on the string (not simply close to a fret) in order to sound in tune.

As for the *qanun*, it is possible to use it to play simple chords using a multi-finger plucking technique, an innovative approach used by some players (this approach, which is already widespread among Turkish *kanun* players, is becoming increasingly popular in the Arab world). However, what is more common on the *qanun* is plucking two simultaneous notes, in other words playing the melody together with a transposed version of the same melody, usually a third or fourth above. This technique can be heard from Muhammad Abdo Saleh in the introduction to Umm Kulthum's "*fakkaruni*."

The violin can be used to play two notes in harmony (using the double stop technique, in which two adjacent strings are bowed together). A variation of that technique is to keep playing a drone on the first string, while playing the melody on the second. This effect is common when playing folk genres like the *dabke*.

Finally, the *nay* allows a very limited polyphonic effect, which is to simultaneously blow a note and its octave, using a combination of mouth and fingering techniques.

Counterpoint in the *Dawr*

Counterpoint is a type of polyphony combining two or more independent melodies that are harmonically unified but rhythmically distinct.³ Developed as a major feature of Western classical music and reaching its pinnacle during the Baroque period (1600–1750), counterpoint is extremely rare in Arabic music.

The rare trend to include counterpoint in Arabic music started in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, within the Egyptian genre known as the *dawr* (discussed in

³ Detailed discussion of counterpoint is outside the scope of this book.

detail in chapter 8: Song Forms). The *ahat* section in the *dawr* has a call-and-response exchange between the singer and a choir, at the end of which they occasionally start singing a short counterpoint passage consisting of two melodic lines. For example, Sayed Darwish's *dawr* "*dayya'ti musta'bal hayati*" (1914) and Muhammad Abdel Wahab's *dawr* "*ahibb ashufak*" (1930) both include very memorable *ahat* sections with counterpoint. In a sense, the limited use of countermelodies in 20th-century arrangements can be viewed as a descendant of their usage within the *dawr*.

Harmonic Arabic Music

Some Arabic music is composed harmonically from the start, not based in the *maqam* system at all. This category of Arabic music started in the late 19th century, but really came to prominence around the second half of the 20th century, reaching a huge level of popularity as the Arab world became increasingly exposed to European pop music and wished to imitate it. Harmonic Arabic music is still very much considered Arabic, not by virtue of its musical content, but because it is music with Arabic lyrics performed by an Arab singer and ensemble for an Arab audience.

Harmonic Arabic music is based on the Western equal-tempered tuning system, and it includes chords that are usually played on a Western polyphonic instrument such as the piano, the electric piano, the electric guitar, the electric organ, or the now ubiquitous keyboard. What makes this music sound different than Western music composed outside the Arab world (besides the possible inclusion of some traditional Arabic instruments for a more authentic Arabic "feel") is that it still includes phrasing and ornamentation reminiscent of semitonal Arabic *maqamat* such as 'Ajam, Nahawand, Hijaz, and Kurd (as we discuss throughout this book, it is more than just the scale that defines the character of a *maqam*).

Because harmonies used in this style of Arabic music are essentially Western harmonies, taken from classical or European/American pop music (i.e., not derived from an indigenous Arab tradition), they exclude melodies based on the quarter-tonal *maqam* families such as Rast, Bayati, Saba, Jiharkah, and Sikah.

Composing Western-style songs was a staple of the early operettas of Sayed Darwish, as well as a smattering of songs in early Egyptian film. Lebanese diva Fairouz and her team of composers, brothers Assi and Mansour al-Rahbani, were some of the most prolific producers of harmonic Arabic music from the 1960s onward. They wrote numerous harmonic Arabic songs, some of which were originally composed for musical theater and a few motion pictures. That repertoire heavily used Western instruments such as the piano, the accordion, and the flute in its arrangements.

Much of the Arabic pop and club music repertoire of the 1990s onward, performed by such icons as Ragheb Alama, Nancy Ajram, Amr Diab, Asala Nasri, and Kazem al-Saher, is harmonic to some degree, and relies primarily on synthesizer/sampler keyboards to deliver that harmony.

Polyphony with *Maqam*-Based Music

A number of late 20th- and 21st-century Arab composers have experimented with creating polyphony based on the Arabic *maqam*. Two excellent examples of multiple ‘*ud* combinations are *‘Ud Duet* (1998), by Iraqi father and son team Munir and Omar Bashir, and *Jadal* (1995), the ‘*ud* duet double CD by Lebanese ‘*ud* masters Marcel Khalife (b. 1950) and Charbel Rouhana (b. 1965), parts of which were later arranged for orchestras. Three ‘*ud*-s can also produce beautiful harmonies, as can be heard in the prolific compositions of Le Trio Joubran, an ‘*ud* trio of three Palestinian brothers Samir, Wissam, and Adnan Joubran.

While these examples have kept away from quartertonal *maqamat* in order to more closely match the Western music sense of consonance, more recent attempts at producing polyphony have embraced the microtonal *maqamat* and created an expanded palette of sounds in which the more complex dissonances that result from microtonal intervals are acceptable. This is the case with the recent music composed by Iraqi American trumpeter and *santur* player Amir ElSaffar (b. 1977), which draws on the contemporary traditions of free jazz and creates polyphony from the Iraqi Maqam.⁴

⁴ Rastegar (2013).

TUNING SYSTEM

THIS CHAPTER BEGINS an in-depth exploration of the Arabic *maqam* system. Arabic music is very diverse and includes many genres, styles, and local traditions, but the vast majority of these genres (barring modern ones that emerged toward the end of the 20th century, discussed in chapter 10: Arrangement) have one unifying factor: the *maqam*. As a starting point, the *maqam* can be briefly described as a scale or modal system associated with a rich tradition of orally transmitted melodic pathways.

The intonation of *maqam* scales is one of the unique, defining features of Arabic music, and it has been a subject of intense interest and discussion for centuries. Because we feel that the theories used to describe the *maqam* and *maqam* scales have diverged far from actual practice, we aim to present a more coherent view, one we hope readers will find more comprehensible.

The Arbitrariness of the Scale

Intonation and musical scales are cultural products, not mathematical objects. That makes them easy to comprehend on a practical level but challenging on a theoretical level. On a practical level: we have personally found that even American children, with no prior hearing of Arabic music, can sing *maqam* scales in tune immediately

when asked to imitate basic melodies in call-and-response fashion (the central technique of oral transmission).

At the same time, on a theoretical level we have encountered so many misconceptions, misunderstandings, and misrepresentations—stemming from both Western and Arabic sources, in historical scholarship as well as in internet discussions, and even from the mouths of master musicians themselves—that we find it necessary to examine and critique some of the underlying assumptions about scales and intonation before proceeding with a description of the system in use.

The most problematic assumption we wish to dispel is the idea that intonation and scales are *determined* by some kind of mathematical logic. We understand the roots of this misconception: the ancient Egyptian discovery of “rational” harmonic relationships (i.e., based on small-integer ratios) among strings of different lengths, resulting in “consonant” sounds—which Pythagoras learned on his travels to Egypt and developed into a rich tetrachord theory, influencing all subsequent music theory in the Arab world and Europe.

The harmonic relationships are indeed very real, based on physical reality: sound waves produce upper harmonics in integer multiples of their base frequencies, and the act of blending two sound waves whose frequencies relate to each other in simple integer ratios (e.g., $3/2$, $4/3$, $5/4$, $2/1$) results in combined sounds that are simple and periodic (and which many perceive to be “pleasing”). Figure 11.1 shows the combination of waves from two frequencies related in the harmonic ratio of $3:2$, an interval known as the “just fifth.”

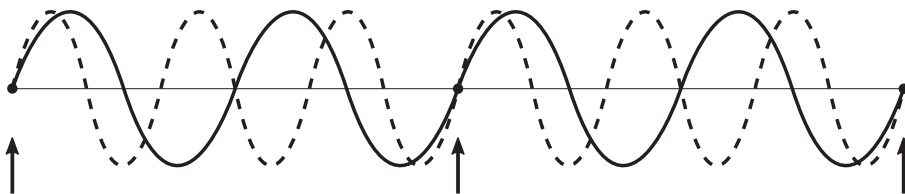


FIGURE 11.1 Waveforms of two frequencies related in the harmonic ratio of $3:2$. The arrows show points at which they periodically start a new cycle together.

However, this phenomenon obscures the fact that it was nonetheless *a cultural choice to utilize such intervals* in scales—and even a choice to blend two different pitches together in the first place. The ideas of “consonance” and “harmonious” or “pleasing” sounds are dependent on cultural factors, based on the preferences of human beings, and shared and transmitted in various ways. Cultures around the world use different musical scales that are not based on such ratios, yet make music that is acceptable and pleasing to them.

In fact, most American and European music is no longer based on those ratios, either. A long historical process in Europe, spanning several centuries, resulted in

the development of what we now know as the equal-tempered (ET) scale system, in which all intervals are of equal size, resulting in a logarithmic¹ scale in which *none* of the intervals is rational (rational in the mathematical sense described previously, meaning “based on simple integer ratios”), except the octave. The equal-tempered system is therefore *dissonant*, not *consonant*, from the perspective of the pure harmonic ratios discovered by the ancient Egyptians.

The process of change in the European scale system is instructive and reveals two fundamental truths: (1) the changes were the result of artistic *choices* and (2) through the process, the human ear was conditioned to accept new definitions of “consonance” and “harmonious.”

The brief sketch that follows is no substitute for a deeper dive into the history of scale evolution in Europe, and readers are encouraged to explore that further, as it is outside the scope of this book. Nonetheless, we highlight the major signposts along the way:

- The just intonation system: all intervals are based on harmonic ratios ($3/2$ frequency ratio = the just fifth, $4/3$ = the just fourth, $5/4$ = the just major third, and $6/5$ = the just minor third; $9/8$ and $10/9$ are two different major seconds). The scale resulting from this construction is very beautiful but very difficult to use if music modulates (“modulation” here means moving to a different “key” on which to start a scale). In that case, significant dissonances result, and compromises must be made.
- The Pythagorean system: the entire scale is based on just fourths and fifths ($3/2$ and $4/3$ ratios). This is very practical for stringed instruments, but results in a scale in which thirds are dissonant ($81/64$ frequency ratio), and completing the circle of fifths results in a dissonant octave.
- The mean-tone system: thirds are more consonant, but fourths and fifths are adjusted slightly off from just intonation, to allow for more modulations in the scale overall.
- Various kinds of well-temperament: some adjustments were made in the previous systems to accommodate more modulations, based on some of the concepts introduced in the mean-tone system.
- The equal-tempered system: a pure logarithmic scale with equal irrational intervals no longer based on small mathematical ratios.

¹ A logarithmic series is one in which each number is multiplied by (instead of added to) the same constant to obtain the next number. The equal-tempered scale is a logarithmic scale in which each note’s frequency is multiplied by the 12th root of 2 (approx. 1.06) to obtain the next note’s frequency.

Many people remain confused by this history because of the presence of mathematical rationales for various changes, so it is important for us to point out that *there were non-mathematical choices being made that resulted in the development of new systems*, for which new mathematical frameworks were *then* developed. The math didn't drive the process; the aesthetic/cultural choices did. And at every step of the way, the human ears of the musicians and audiences adjusted to the various changes in interval sizes, accepting them for use in melodies (and harmonies).

Currently there seems to be a bias toward believing that the ET system is the most perfect musical system, and where musical realities don't match, elaborate and complex rationales are developed to "prove" that a non-ET system is actually based on some kind of modification of ET—with 24, or 54, or even many more divisions of the octave.

But the reality is very different from a practicing musical standpoint, at least for Arabic scales. Arabic scales, as discussed later in this chapter, are rooted in the Pythagorean system and use just fourths and fifths between well-tuned strings. However, there are many intervals that cannot be described using simple harmonic ratios and that observation shows have varied over historical time and geographic region.

These tiny differences in interval sizes are perceptible to the ear, enough so that they can be used to *identify* the region and time period of the practitioner, in the same way that an accent in spoken language can *identify* the geographic origin of a speaker. And just like accents and dialects, such differences in musical intonation can be learned perfectly by anyone through oral transmission.²

It is on the basis of this reality that we assert³ that musical intervals and scales are fundamentally *arbitrary* (following Saussure's definition of the *arbitrariness of the sign*⁴), by which we mean that they are the result of cultural choices and conventions—even in cases when there are mathematical relationships expressed in some of them. "Arbitrary," in this technical sense, is very different than the colloquial understanding of the term, which people take to mean "random," "unjustified," or "capricious." Instead, for us it means based on *choices*, which are then shared by communities and passed down.

Our understanding of Arabic intervals and scales shares one more feature with Saussure's concept of the *arbitrariness of the sign*: these musical elements do not *appear* arbitrary to practitioners immersed in their usage; instead they appear to be

² Abu Shumays (2009).

³ But we do not have the space to prove this in the present work.

⁴ Saussure ([1916] 2011).

immutable, determined, and part of fundamental Truth. That is because the *individual* practitioner inherits them through tradition and cannot *individually* change them; they only change extremely gradually over time, and only by the unconscious activity of whole communities. It is only with a comparative approach (as in linguistics) that their arbitrariness becomes apparent.

We can state our objection to the underlying assumptions common in both Western and Arab music theory in another way: we do not find that there are *rules* governing music, but *habits*. The elements of music must be *learned* individually; they cannot be *derived* from other elements of music. Therefore, the function of music theory, from our perspective, is not to create rules that explain music. We have found that this activity always leads to contradictions and inconsistencies and imposes an overly restricted view of what really happens in practice. Instead, we hope to document the knowledge musicians embody and inherit. It amazes us that in the other arts, people fully recognize that one must *learn* each dance step, or each cooking technique, or each brushstroke, while in music so many people falsely assume that one can derive scales from mathematical principles and melodies from rules.

What follows (in this chapter and throughout the book) is a *description* of cultural knowledge. It cannot offer the knowledge itself, which can only be learned through listening to and practice of the sounds themselves.

Arabic Scales

While the piano is used as the standard for defining the European ET tuning system, the *‘ud* has historically been the principal instrument performing that role in Arabic music; early Arabic music theory defined *maqam* scales and scale fragments (known as *ajnas*) using the *‘ud*.

The *‘ud*, the predecessor of the European lute, uses double strings for most notes, but for ease of discussion we can refer to each course of two strings as a “string” (see chapter 1: Melodic Instruments). The earliest *‘ud*-s used four strings (i.e., four courses), typically tuned in just fourths. The most common Arabic *‘ud* tuning of C-F-A-D-G-C (from low to high) is also tuned using just fourth intervals, with the exception of the F-A interval, which is the Pythagorean major third that results. Arabic *‘ud* tuning, and as a result the Arabic scale system as a whole, is rooted in Pythagorean tuning. The preference for just (harmonically perfect) fourths and fifths in Arabic tuning means that many other intervals in *maqam* scales conform to Pythagorean tuning, including major seconds and some minor and major thirds.

However, harmonic relationships are not as important as they are in Western music. Arabic music is not fundamentally harmonic in nature; it is melodic. Since there is no requirement to produce chords that sound beautiful and to progress from one chord to another, there is no reason why other (fingered) notes on the *‘ud* must result from some kind of harmonic relationship. Without that requirement, there is a very wide range of possibility for constructing scales that still fit largely within the Pythagorean framework of the *‘ud*, while including other notes outside of it. Arabic scales exploit that possibility, along with the fact that aural perception allows for a large number of fine distinctions.

The result is that many *maqam* scales include notes that don't result from any harmonic relationship and are therefore free to occur at arbitrary intervals. The exact pitches are determined by the collective community interactions we call “cultural tradition” and are passed down by ear over generations. These notes are “variable” because they change from region to region and shift over time, very much like an accent in a language; however, they are *not* variable within a specific time period or regional practice, and Arab musicians are extremely precise about the exact tuning of these notes within the scales they use.

The Prototypal Maqam Rast Scale

A good example of the combination of harmonic ratios and arbitrary intervals used to build an Arabic *maqam* scale is the Maqam Rast scale anchored on C as its tonic. This scale is prototypal in Arabic music in the same way that the C major scale is in Western music. Figure 11.2 shows the prototypal Maqam Rast scale on C.

Given the standard *‘ud* tuning of C-F-A-D-G-C, five out of seven notes in the Maqam Rast scale are based on *‘ud* open strings. This means that a very precise intonation can be achieved with minimum fingering effort. However, scale degrees 3 and 7 have variable intonation across different regional practices and time periods, and their precise intonation must be learned by ear.

Level of Detail

Given the approach adopted in building the Arabic tuning system, many variations of intervals and pitches exist across Arabic *maqam* scales. The result is much more fine-grained than music that uses a 12-tone ET scale, in which the smallest possible interval is a semitone. Instead, Arabic music includes many distinct pitches that all fit within a semitone or even half of that, a quartertone.

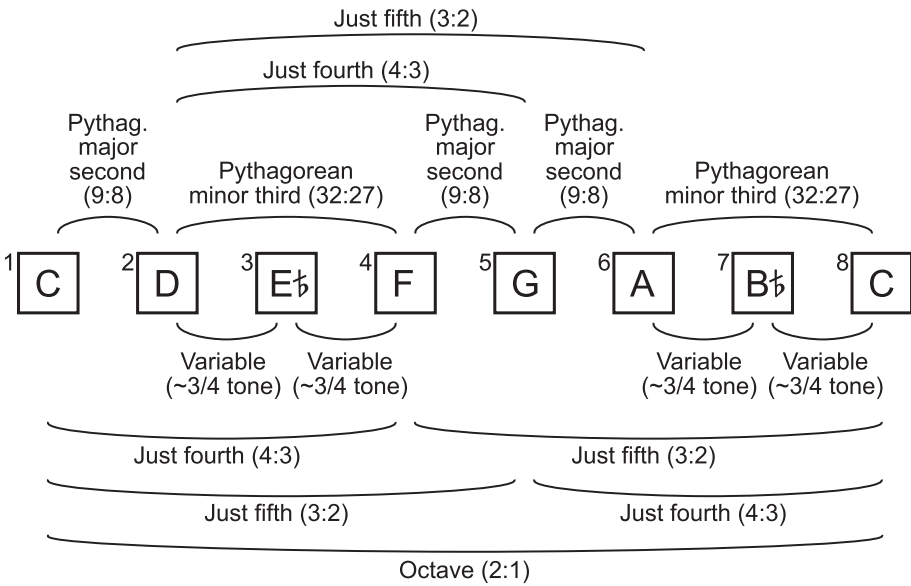


FIGURE 11.2 The prototypal Maqam Rast scale on C, showing all of its intervals.

If we take, for example, the ET semitone between the notes E $\flat$ and E $\sharp$, at least 10–12 aurally distinct pitches from different maqam scales occur within it.⁵ Figure 11.3 shows several of these (the drawing is not to absolute scale; it is meant to be illustrative of the point, using approximate relative positions).

The difference between the 3rd degrees of the Jiharkah *maqam* scale, the ‘Ajam *maqam* scale, and the equal-tempered major scale (all using C as their tonic) is on the order of a few cents, which is a tiny fraction of a quartertone. The difference

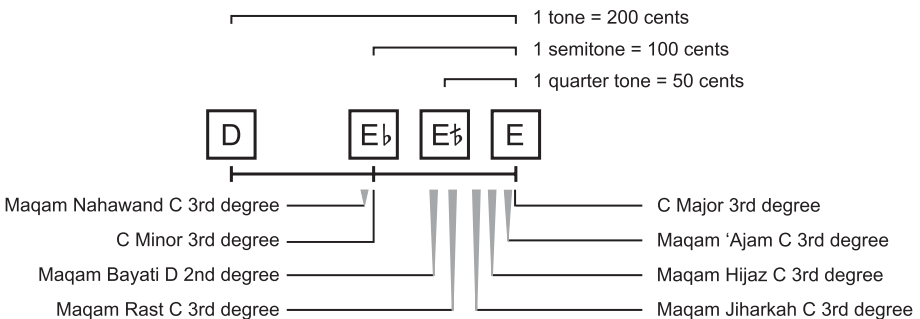


FIGURE 11.3 An example of different pitches used in Arabic music that occur within the span of an equal-tempered semitone (distances are approximate).

⁵ Marcus (1993b); Abu Shumays and Farraj (2007).

between the 3rd degree of the Rast *maqam* scale on C and the 2nd degree of the Bayati *maqam* scale on D is also on the order of a few cents.

The different pitches described in figure 11.3 raise an important question: Can we really tell those different notes apart? The smallest pitch difference noticed or discerned by the human ear and brain is called the just noticeable difference (JND) in acoustics. It is difficult to accurately quantify the JND using an absolute unit such as cents, for many reasons. First, it varies greatly from person to person. Second, it varies with the timbre (the type of instrument) of a note. Finally, it varies a lot with the volume and the frequency range being heard. However, while references differ on its exact value, there is a consensus that it is on the order of half a dozen to a dozen cents, on average; trained musicians are able to make even finer distinctions.⁶

In that case, the difference between the notes previously described is certainly on the order of the JND or greater. Indeed, these notes can be routinely discerned aurally, and the majority of experienced Arabic musicians and listeners can tell them apart with sufficient exposure.

The Historic 24-Tone Arabic Scale

Given the Arabic tuning system's level of detail, listing every distinct note in every *maqam* scale would result in quite a large collection of pitches. The size of such a collection would make it very impractical to assign a unique name to each distinct pitch. If we counted notes in all the possible *maqam* scales and their transpositions, the result would add up to hundreds of notes.

To address this problem, Arabic music theorists expressed the rich and fine-grained Arabic tuning system by developing a theoretical scale that included 24 notes per octave, probably around the 18th century.⁷ The 24-tone scale was a metaphor that combined distinct pitches from every possible Arabic *maqam* scale and reduced closely neighboring pitches into a single conceptual note in order not to exceed 24 divisions per octave. The 24-tone scale was equal-tempered in theory,⁸ meaning that each of its steps spanned a quartertone.

⁶ In 2010 the Peterson tuning company took coauthor Abu Shumays into a recording studio to record a scale in Maqam Rast for potential use in an electronic tuner. In that hour-long session, the technician found that Abu Shumays's level of precision in tuning on the violin was less than 2 cents.

⁷ Marcus (2007, p. 19).

⁸ Marcus (1989a, p. 68; 1993b, p. 39).

The result was a super-scale (the superset of all *maqam* scales) that could be used to notate music in any Arabic *maqam*. This was a hugely convenient model, in which a concise vocabulary of notes was used to represent the much richer universe of possible pitches used in practice. Instead of remembering hundreds of different note names, musicians had to remember hundreds of distinct pitches in practice by memorizing every *maqam* scale as a melody, but referred to these pitches using a reduced vocabulary of note names, with the understanding that some notes acquire a slightly different pitch depending on the *maqam* scale in which they occur.

Documenting the 24-Tone Arabic Scale

The historic 24-tone Arabic scale is documented at length in Arabic music theory references from the mid-19th to the mid-20th centuries. Many notation artifacts were used to express its different pitches and intervals: exact frequencies, complex fractions, Pythagorean commas, and cents ($1/100$ of an equal-tempered semitone).

The 24-tone scale is also documented in different formats: as a circle, as a table, and using a musical staff. A few slightly different versions of that scale exist in different Arabic music theory books, especially ones that were produced many decades apart. These versions differ mainly in the convention they use to name each note. This is understandable, since most Arabic music practitioners before the 20th century relied mainly on memorization to learn and teach the music tradition, leading to minor discrepancies across different time periods and geographical locations.

The 24-tone scale spanned two octaves (sometimes three, depending on the reference) and adequately covered the range of acoustic instruments available in early Arabic music as well the human voice's range. Each of the 24 notes in one octave had a distinct name; when transposed up or down by an octave, a note acquired a new name. Arabic, Persian, and Turkish note names were all used, reflecting the historical influence of both Persian and Turkish cultures on Arabic music and music theory. In some cases, in order to differentiate notes that are one octave apart, the octave note below the tonic was prefixed with the word *qarar* ("bottom/floor"), and the octave note above the tonic was prefixed with the word *jawab* (literally, "answer/reply"). Prefixing a note with the word "*tik*" meant raising it by a quartertone, while prefixing it with the word "*nim*" meant lowering it by a quartertone.

Some notes (e.g., Rast, Dukah, and Nawa) matched the names of corresponding open strings on the *'ud*. Many of the notes in the 24-tone scale gave their name to Arabic *maqamat* that started on them or included them prominently in the scale. This is the case with Rast, Jiharkah, Husayni, 'Ajam, Hijaz, Sikah, Buselik, Mahur,

Muhayyar, Shahnaz, Sunbulah, Iraq, Kurdi, and Hisar. Some of these *maqam* names are still widely in use today.

By the end of the 20th century, archaic Arabic and Persian note names were practically obsolete. They had long since been replaced by the solfège naming convention (Do, Ré, Mi, Fa, Sol, La, Si), supplemented with sharps, flats, half-sharps, and half-flats. Today only a few of the archaic note names are in use as vestiges of the historic Arabic 24-tone scale, mostly by the older generation of musicians, who still call C “Rast,” D “Dukah,” E♭ “Sikah,” and G “Nawa.”

Table 11.1 shows the historic 24-tone Arabic scale as documented by Marcus in his PhD dissertation, in which he researched all available historic sources, pointing out the many versions of the scale, listing differences and discrepancies, and presenting the most coherent version.⁹ Each note is shown alongside its approximate modern-day equivalent in a 24-tone equal-tempered notation system, based on later references that documented that relationship. The half-flat symbol (♭) is approximately worth half a flat (a quartertone lower), while the half-sharp symbol (♯) is approximately worth half a sharp (a quartertone higher). These symbols are explained in detail in chapter 12: Notation.

Many note names in the 24-tone scale matched historic names of ‘*ud* strings (e.g., Kirdan is the high C string on the ‘*ud*, Nawa is the G string, and Dukah is the D string). Other names were derived from the Persian language, indicating gradual finger positions on a string instrument. For example, Dukah (pronounced “DOO-kah”) comes from the Persian words *du gah* (*du*, meaning two, and *gah*, meaning position). Similarly, Sikah (pronounced “SEE-kah”) comes from the Persian words *se gah* (third position), and Jiharkah (pronounced “jee-HAR-kah”) comes from the Persian words *chehar gah* (fourth position).

The Gap Between Theory and Practice

While many references (from the 19th and 20th centuries) described the 24-tone scale as equal-tempered, this is inaccurate, for several reasons. First, the skeleton of the scale system is Pythagorean, not ET. Second, numerous pitches are used, with distinctions much finer than a quartertone. Third, some of the individual pitches are “variable” depending on region and time period. Fourth, note names used to describe the Arabic tuning system are conceptual: some are based on precise pitches derived from open strings, and some are a convenient grouping of many shades of

⁹ Marcus (1989a, p. 99).

TABLE II.I

Historic 24-Tone Arabic Scale			
Degree	Approximate 24-Tone ET Note	First Octave	Second Octave
1	G	Yakah	Nawa
2	G [♯]	Qarar Nim Hisar	Nim Hisar
3	A ^b /G [♯]	Qarar Hisar	Hisar
4	A ^b	Qarar Tik Hisar	Tik Hisar
5	A	‘Ushayran	Husayni
6	A [♯]	Nim ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran	Nim ‘Ajam
7	B ^b /A [♯]	‘Ajam ‘Ushayran	‘Ajam
8	B ^b	‘Iraq	Awj
9	B	Kawasht	Mahur
10	B [♯]	Tik Kawasht	Tik Mahur
11	C	Rast	Kirdan
12	C [♯]	Nim Zirkulah	Nim Shahnaz
13	D ^b /C [♯]	Zirkulah	Shahnaz
14	D ^b	Tik Zirkulah	Tik Shahnaz
15	D	Dukah	Muhayyar
16	D [♯]	Nim Kurd	Nim Sinbulah
17	E ^b /D [♯]	Kurd	Sinbulah
18	E ^b	Sikah	Buzrak
19	E	Buselik	Jawab Buselik
20	E [♯]	Tik Buselik	Jawab Tik Buselik
21	F	Jiharkah	Mahuran
22	F [♯]	Nim Hijaz	Jawab Nim Hijaz
23	G ^b /F [♯]	Hijaz	Jawab Hijaz
24	G ^b	Tik Hijaz	Jawab Tik Hijaz
	G(octave)	Nawa	Jawab Nawa

Source: Marcus (1989a, p. 99).

a pitch under one note; therefore, using them to precisely define a single interval is meaningless.

Aside from the misconception that the 24-tone scale is ET, the incorrect notion that all notes in the 24-tone scale have constant (absolutely defined) pitches became prevalent, especially when Western staff notation was adopted in Arabic music, and each note in the 24-tone Arabic scale acquired its Western equivalent (which included some ET quartertones). This misconception is propagated in Arabic as well as Western references despite the fact that it does not reflect the reality of everyday performance practice.

The gap between the 24-tone scale theoretical model and actual intonation performed by musicians in practice was described in detail by Scott Marcus (1993b). He concludes that, aside from a small group of musicians who accepted the 24-tones at face values (i.e. having fixed pitches and equal-tempered), Arab musicians created various mechanisms to relate notes they perform in real life to the conceptual 24-tones by recognizing that certain notes deviate from their theoretical positions by a “comma” (used here informally to indicate a small amount), by describing shrunk augmented seconds (this coincides with the 2nd to 3rd interval in the Hijaz *jins*), by allowing for a general pitch variability as a function of tonal focus and/or personal preference, or by adding extra fixed notes to the 24-notes.

Regional Variations

Pinning down a universal Arabic scale is like pinning down the exact pronunciation of the English language. The challenge is that there is no single English accent; instead the exact pronunciation of the English language depends greatly on the place where it is spoken. Arabic music intonation is similar, although differences between regions are much subtler and sometimes only noticeable to the experienced ear.

Having said that, when learning the intonation of Arabic *maqam* scales in one region, local intonation is absolute, and musicians and listeners memorize it as one identical melody. For an ensemble performing in that region, a deviation from the precise intonation (i.e., speaking with a foreign accent) would be incorrect and would sound out of tune.

The ill-advised exercise of accurately documenting every note’s frequency in the Arabic 24-tone scale was undertaken¹⁰ at the 1932 Cairo Arabic Music Congress. Delegates spent many work sessions trying to measure and document the exact intonation of the Arabic scale, but their efforts were in vain, as it became very clear that each region had a slightly different intonation for some notes, especially the

¹⁰ Sahhab (1997); Maalouf (2002).

quartertones. In particular, the Sikah note in Arabic (notated as E $\flat$ using the Western notation system later adapted for Arabic music) exhibited the most regional differences compared to other notes.

In retrospect, proposing to unify the Arabic scale's intonation across different regions was problematic in two ways. First, it was not motivated by the desire of Arab musicians themselves but more by the congress's European sponsors, who consisted mainly of French, German, and British anthropologists and ethnomusicologists. More important, the task of standardizing the Arabic scale's intonation is as needless and impossible to achieve as would be the task of inviting delegates from, for example, every Spanish-speaking country in Latin America, recording and measuring their regional Spanish accents, deciding and documenting what the "standard" Spanish accent should be, then recommending that they all speak with that same accent. In the end that initiative was counterproductive and doomed to fail, given Arabic music's diversity and richness of regional detail.

Period Variations

Intonation in Arabic music evolves over time, just as a linguistic accent does. A good example of an interval that changes with time, like a fashion, is the interval between the 2nd and 3rd degrees in the Hijaz *maqam* scale. (In Western notation, for a tonic of D, that would be the interval between E $\flat$ and F $\sharp$, theoretically worth 1½ whole tones in ET.)

A good way of tracking the shift in what constitutes correct intonation is to compare different deliveries by the same singer over a 30-year period. Examining recordings in Maqam Hijaz by Egyptian Diva Umm Kulthum, considered a principal authority on correct intonation, from the 1930s to the 1960s reveals a gradual shift in the size of the (nominal) 1½-tone interval between the 2nd and 3rd degrees in Maqam Hijaz. As was the fashion back then, that interval was noticeably smaller in the 1930s than it was in the 1960s and 1970s, when the introduction of Western notation and instruments influenced Arabic music intonation and shifted it closer to ET intonation. In keeping with the changing fashion, Umm Kulthum adjusted her delivery of Maqam Hijaz over the years to follow the contemporary consensus. That difference gives 1930s recordings in Maqam Hijaz a very dated feeling. For this reason, any absolute pitch measurement would only be accurate for a given historical period, losing its accuracy with the passing of the decades.

Variations Among *Maqamat*

An interval between the same two notes, identified conceptually, may not be constant, and could vary depending on what *maqam* it occurs in. This is because some

note names in the Arabic tuning system are a convenient grouping of distinct pitches from different *maqam* scales that are very closely clustered together.

A classic example of this feature is the E $\flat$ (called E half-flat) conceptual note, which is used to designate the 3rd scale degree of Maqam Rast on C, the 2nd degree of Maqam Bayati on D, and the tonic of the Maqam Sikah on E $\flat$. Such a note is sometimes described as a “quartertone” because it is approximately halfway between two ET semitones. In practice, the E $\flat$ note in the Rast *maqam* scale may be played slightly higher than the E $\flat$ in the Bayati *maqam* scale, even though they are notated as one and the same note for the sake of convenience. This is because Rast, Bayati, and Sikah are independent *maqamat* whose correct intonation is learned by ear and has to be fine-tuned by the performer to the extent that the instrument permits.

Phrasing Variations

Another peculiarity of the Arabic tuning system is that within one *maqam*, the scale’s intonation may vary slightly depending on the musical phrase (this is what Marcus describes as “pitch variability as a function of tonal focus and melodic direction”¹¹). An everyday example can be clearly heard in Maqam Huzam, where if the melodic line descends to the leading tone (the note immediately below the tonic), then rises again, the leading tone is played slightly higher than it would if the melody continued descending past the leading tone. This is reminiscent of the “Law of Attraction” described formally in the neighboring Byzantine music tradition,¹² which aims to smooth out sharp bends in the melody. While this behavior is not formalized or necessarily practiced in every Arabic *maqam* or region, it is nevertheless passed on orally as part of the phrasing vocabulary of some *maqamat*.

Defining Correct Intonation

In the absence of a standard benchmark instrument such as the piano, and with the abundance of fretless instruments (such as the *‘ud* and violin) in the Arabic ensemble, the prime tool for judging intonation is the ear. While notes based on just fourth and fifth intervals are well defined, there’s no absolute quantitative standard for the intonation of variable notes in Arabic music (many books have made a huge effort to theorize correct intonation, but their results are not consistent and do not always reflect what musicians do in practice). As a result, a musician performing

¹¹ Marcus (1993b, p. 47).

¹² Issa Boulos, conversation with the author, 2011.

alone will have his or her individual mental intonation for variable notes (e.g., Sikah), just like an accent. But that mental intonation was not plucked from a void; it was acquired through years of oral training and imitation, which resulted in a consistent “accent” for a region and period. In this regard, our experience contradicts Marcus’s assessment of intonation, in which he states that “it is common to find musicians who perform together and yet differ as to how they conceptualize aspects of intonation.”¹³

For example, if we were to measure the pitch of the Sikah note as performed by dozens of musicians in Cairo in 1950, we would expect the result to look like a very tight bell curve. Today that bell curve is likely to be less tight because of the increased mixing of Arabized instruments with traditional ones, the exposure to intonations from different Arab regions, and the exposure to changing musical fashion from different decades of Arabic music in recordings from the 1930s onward. In short, today the margin for variable notes among Arab musicians is expected to be wider.

But when it comes to performing in an ensemble, musicians make every attempt to tighten that variability to the extent that their instruments allow and their ears can discern. The result is never perfect unison (as stated repeatedly), but the musicians’ intention certainly is to converge and unify their intonation. For example, when playing in a contemporary Arabic music ensemble, musicians cannot avoid bringing slightly varying intonations (their individual accents) into the mix, but after tuning and rehearsing together, that intonation is negotiated (or dictated by the conductor!) and must converge. A narrow consensus must be reached during a performance, or the result will sound dissonant and unfocused, and *maqamat* will not achieve the melodic intensity they were meant to deliver.

In order to achieve that unison, Arabic musicians’ discernment of pitch intervals must be a lot finer than a semitone, since they use “microtonal” scales (relative to the ET scale); they have to constantly pay attention to the *maqam* context and fine-tune each note accordingly. This takes up a lot of the musicians’ attention and energy but is accepted as one of the requirements for performing correct Arabic music, one that gets easier with experience.

Experienced Arabic music listeners are also acutely aware of correct intonation without the aid of any written intonation charts and would easily notice a musician’s performing out of tune. In a *taqsim* (traditional instrumental improvisation), for example, experienced listeners can tell the difference between two notes less than a quartertone apart and react accordingly. That’s because both performers and listeners are part of a community with an established and precise oral tradition.

¹³ Marcus (1993b, p. 40).

Microtonality

From the perspective of Western music after its adoption of the ET system, any other tuning system that includes intervals smaller than an ET semitone is described as “microtonal.” That also includes intervals larger than a semitone but that don’t add up to a whole number of semitones (e.g., $\frac{3}{4}$ tones, $1\frac{1}{4}$ tones).

The term “microtonal music” is qualitative rather than quantitative, because it doesn’t describe exactly what intervals make up the tuning system in question, only that it doesn’t fit in the ET system. Arabic music certainly qualifies as microtonal according to that definition, and much of it cannot be played faithfully on Western ET instruments such as the piano. Many musical traditions neighboring Arabic music, such as Persian classical music, Ottoman/Turkish classical music, and Byzantine music, are also microtonal in that sense.

However, it is important to keep in mind that the designation of Arabic music as microtonal says more about the frame of reference—Western 12-tone ET scales—than about Arabic music. The intervals used in Arabic scales need not be viewed from that reference point, because they developed independently from the evolution of the European scales. Those distinct Arabic intervals are put together into heptatonic (7-tone) scales, which are described in more detail in the following chapters. From the perspective of an Arabic scale, or a Pythagorean scale, it is the ET scale that is microtonal (and the *maqam* that is tonal).

Modern Arabic Tuning

In the 20th century, the Arabic tuning system was greatly influenced by the introduction of ET instruments to the Arabic ensemble (see chapter 2: Arabized Instruments and chapter 4: Ensembles), as well as the widespread adoption of Western staff notation, albeit with new symbols that enhanced its precision (see chapter 12: Notation). These two important factors contributed to a gradual shift in the Arabic tuning system toward a 24-tone ET system.

While in the 12-tone ET tuning system (meaning all the notes on a piano) the smallest interval is a semitone, and each octave is composed of 12 equal semitones, the 24-tone ET scale defines the quartertone (half a semitone) as the smallest interval and fits 24 ET quartertones in an octave. If the piano is the prototypal instrument for the 12-tone ET system, then its modern descendant, the Arabic/Oriental keyboard, is the prototypal instrument for the 24-tone ET system.

But equal temperament is not suited for Arabic music and differs from the Arabic tuning system in two important ways. First, it is not precise enough, as it cannot

faithfully deliver the correct tonality of the Arabic tuning system. Second, equal temperament is too rigid; it implies that all intervals are fixed and every note has an absolute frequency, while the Arabic tuning system affords variable notes in each *maqam* scale the luxury of following the consensus of a time and place like a fashion.

Arabic music theorist Mikhail Allah Wirdi describes the 24-tone ET scale as a “confining brace,” and compares the difference between equal temperament and the full-spectrum microtonal scale as “going from black and white to color cinema,”¹⁴ thereby allowing many more possibilities and levels of detail.

While equal temperament has been around for centuries in Western music and is accepted as the de facto tuning system, it is relatively more recent in Arabic music and is by no means the established or undisputed standard. However, 24-tone ET is certainly gaining ground in Arabic music as more and more ensembles and recordings rely on the Arabic keyboard as their main melodic instrument. This has compromised Arabic tuning, since mixing traditional Arabic instruments such as the *‘ud*, violin, and *qanun* with 24-tone ET instruments such as the accordion and keyboard undermines the ensemble’s overall intonation precision.

Today nothing stops *‘ud*, violin, and *qanun* players from tuning their strings in just fourths, but in practice many musicians use an electronic tuner to tune every string, which has the result of coercing the just fourth intervals into equal-tempered fourths. That in turn distorts the consonance of small ratios that are based on the harmonic series. Even if *‘ud* and violin players kept their instruments tuned in just fourths and performed the correct Arabic tuning, the result might still be a compromise if their instruments were combined with 12-tone or 24-tone ET instruments such as the piano, electric keyboard, electric guitar, and accordion.

Maqamat such as Jiharkah cannot be accurately played on 24-tone ET instruments, because its 3rd and 4th degrees would be indistinguishable from the *‘Ajam maqam* scale on such instruments (they are subtly different on more precise instruments). This may explain why *Maqam Jiharkah* is neglected in the mainstream pop repertoire even though many folk songs were composed in that *maqam*. Moreover, Arabic *maqam* scales include regional variations that make up much of their color. Unfortunately, 24-tone ET instruments eliminate these regional variations, reducing the Arabic *maqam* to its lowest common denominator.

Another factor that may be causing regional variations to shrink is media globalization within the Arab world itself. In the mid-20th century, state radio stations in the Arab world devoted a large part of their airtime to local repertoire; local performers, composers, and audiences were thus exposed and attuned to the intonation

¹⁴ Allah Wirdi (1964, p. 19).

of their local *maqam* scales. In comparison, the exchange of music across the Arab world became much more common toward the end of the 20th century, supported by the satellite television industry. This allowed the new pan-Arabic commercial pop song to flourish, with the Arabic keyboard as its principal instrument. Today it is no longer surprising to hear the same exact Arabic *maqam* intonation in the music of contemporary pop singers such as Kazem al-Saher (b. 1957, Iraq), Nancy Ajram (b. 1983, Lebanon), Ragheb Alama (b. 1962, Lebanon), Asala Nasri (b. 1969, Syria), Amr Diab (b. 1961, Egypt), and Saber Rebaï (b. 1967, Tunisia).

It is worth noting that all of the changes in scales and intonation described in this chapter have been cultural changes, resulting in intonation differences that have nonetheless proven acceptable to the ears of audiences and musicians. We wish to emphasize again that intonation is a cultural product, inseparable from all of the other cultural dynamics influencing musical practice.

NOTATION

ARABIC MUSIC HAD no tradition of writing down the musical dimension of songs until the early 20th century,¹ at which point Western staff notation, with a few simple extensions, came into use as the standard for Arabic music notation. Prior to that, Arabic music was only transmitted orally.

In his book *Arab Music and Musical Notation*, Issam El-Mallah (1997) concludes that the absence of a notation system before the 20th century was a choice made by Arab musicians themselves for reasons related to the character of Arabic music; the Arab musician's constant search for new forms of interpretation (improvisation and ornamentation) would have been made difficult by the documentation of a musical thought.

Thus, for better or worse, the entire Arabic music repertoire up to the early 20th century was transmitted orally. While some of that legacy survived in songs by “unknown” composers that we still perform to this day (e.g., many folk and religious songs, as well as *muwashshahat*), much was lost, except for lyrics, which have survived for centuries.

The adoption of Western notation was part of a wider phenomenon of Westernization in Arabic music, which included the creation of conservatories and institutionalized pedagogies, the proliferation of Western instruments in Arabic

¹ Marcus (2015a, p. 280).

ensembles, the creation of the Arabic orchestra and the use of a conductor, and the limited (almost experimental) use of harmony and counterpoint in an otherwise purely melodic modal tradition. This new notation standard, which is referred to here simply as Arabic notation, revolutionized the way in which Arabic music was preserved and transmitted in the 20th century.

Adopting Western Notation

In the early 20th century, the majority of the Arab world underwent major political and social changes linked to the fall of the Ottoman Empire and the arrival of British and French colonialism. During that transition period, European classical music deeply influenced Arab musicians and composers, some of whom traveled to study classical music in France and Italy. As contact between Arabic musicians and Western classical music became more frequent, leading Arab musicians in Egypt and Syria adopted the Western music style of notation to notate Arabic music. Marcus discusses the spread of solfège and Western notation: “Whereas Arab writers in the nineteenth century had discussed Arab music in its own terms (i.e. using only the Arabic/Persian names to refer to the notes), it became more and more common in the early years of the twentieth century to discuss the music in terms of Solfège and Western notation. We see the early stages of this shift in the works of al-Khulā‘i and al-Shawwa.”²

The common Arabic word for music notation is *nota*, derived from the Italian word *nota* or the French word *note*. From *nota* came the word *tanwīt* (to notate), although the word *tadwīn* (to transcribe) is also used, and from that comes the word *mudawwīn* (the transcriber).

The Arab world uses almost exclusively the fixed Do solfège naming convention. The syllables Do, Ré, Mi, Fa, Sol, La, and Si are used to name Arabic notes that match the C, D, E, F, G, A, and B notes in English. Similarly, the French words *dièse* and *bémol* are widely used in Arabic to mean sharp and flat, respectively. The common Arabic word for a measure is *mazura*, derived from the Italian *misura* or the French *mesure*.

Tapping into the clout and universality of Western notation offered huge advantages to Arab musicians, such as the ease of preserving and transmitting Arabic music. Arab musicians who studied Western music at home or in Europe were already well versed in Western notation and didn’t have to learn a new system. The same language could finally be used to teach and learn both Arabic and Western classical music.

² Marcus (1989b).

Moreover, adding foreign instruments such as the piano, accordion, guitar, saxophone, and trumpet to the Arabic orchestra and notating their parts became possible, since they and traditional Arabic instruments now spoke the same language. This can be seen in the early 20th-century transcriptions by Sayed Darwish, which included parts for traditional Arabic instruments as well as Western instruments such as the piano and the trumpet.

Extending Western Notation

Solfège notes, along with their sharp and flat versions, were designed to notate the Western diatonic scales, and eventually the 12-tone equal-tempered (ET) tuning system. That system had been the standard and most widely used tuning system in Western music for many centuries and is reflected in the way pianos are tuned. In Arabic music, however, many notes do not fall precisely on piano keys, which is why Arabic music is considered “microtonal” from a Western perspective (see chapter 11: Tuning System).

In order to bridge the gap between Arabic tuning and the 12-tone ET notation system, Arab musicians used two new symbols that allowed them to increase the precision of Western notation:

The half-flat symbol: $\flat$

The half-sharp symbol: $\sharp$

While the flat symbol ($\flat$) lowers a note’s pitch by a semitone, the half-flat symbol ($\flat$) lowers it by roughly half of that amount: a quartertone. Similarly, while the sharp symbol ($\sharp$) raises a note’s pitch by a semitone, the half-sharp symbol ($\sharp$) raises it by roughly half as much, that is, by a quartertone. Musicians in the Middle East commonly call these new symbols *nuss bémol* and *nuss dièse* (*nuss* means “half” in colloquial Levantine and Egyptian Arabic).

Transpositions are limited in Arabic music, and in most *maqam* scales only a very small number of notes use one of the quartertone symbols. In practice, half-sharps are less common than half-flats, and the following four quartertones are enough to notate the majority of *maqam* scales, at least in their standard keys: $E\flat$, $B\flat$, $A\flat$, and $F\sharp$.

A basic Arabic accordion model, which is mechanically modified to perform *maqam* scales with quartertones, might only have three or four of these quartertones in every octave. More expensive models may have more quartertones. Among the listed quartertones, $E\flat$ is the most frequently used note, and many musicians still call

it by its name from the historic Arabic 24-tone scale: Sikah. That note also lends its name to the *maqam* whose tonic it is, Maqam Sikah.

Obsolete Symbols

Before the half-flat and half-sharp symbols gained enough critical mass to be accepted as the Arabic notation standard, a few other contenders were used as the nascent new notation system underwent a few iterations. Among the alternative symbols is the mirror-image flat symbol (♭), worth a half-flat. Some references³ used the double-flat symbol (♭♭) to indicate a lowering of the pitch by $\frac{3}{4}$ of a tone, and the double-sharp symbol (♯♯) to indicate the raising of the pitch by $\frac{3}{4}$ of a tone. These alternative symbols are no longer used in practice, but they are worth mentioning for historical reasons, in case the reader comes across them in older books or musical scores.

The Quartertone

Extending Western staff notation with two new symbols (half-flat and half-sharp) was groundbreaking and allowed it to accommodate up to 24 intervals in each octave. This allowed Arabic notation to match the historic 24-tone scale in its level of detail. The resulting notation system reduced the microtonal Arabic scale into a 24-tone ET model in which all notes in a *maqam* scale are rounded to the nearest equal-tempered quartertone, and all quartertone intervals are equal. No other intonation details can be notated with the two additional symbols.

This means the prevailing Western staff notation endowed with quartertones still has the same limitations as the theoretical 24-tone scale in accurately representing the Arabic tuning system as it was performed in practice. These limitations are elaborated on in the section “The Gap Between Theory and Practice” in chapter 11: Tuning System.

Notating Arabic music using Western staff notation is like using one language’s alphabet to transliterate words in another language. Playing Arabic music in tune simply by reading the notation is challenging, especially for musicians who are new to Arabic music and have not sufficiently listened to it. In practice, notated Arabic quartertones (as well as many semitones) can only be played accurately in the context of the *maqam* that they are part of, and that requires a good deal of listening.

³ al-Hifni ([1938] 1972).

While the term “quartertone” is an approximation, and a nominal term rather than a precise one, the usage of that term is very widespread. Today Arabic music is very closely associated with quartertones, and musicians notate them and talk about them on a daily basis because they are very practical. For notation purposes, all quartertones are treated as equal, but when the time comes to teach and perform them, aural standards come into play.

Ironically, the proliferation of Arabic keyboards and other Western instruments in Arabic music in the second half of the 20th century and beyond has actually fulfilled the quartertone notation “prophecy,” by forcing quartertones heard in most contemporary music to be exact halves of an equal-tempered semitone.

Fine-Tuning Symbols

Since the half-flat and half-sharp symbols are not precise enough to convey the microtonality in Arabic music, some musical scores (especially handwritten ones) resort to adding other symbols to fine-tune the notation and bring it closer to the correct Arabic scale’s intonation:

The symbol ↑ next to or above a note means a slight raising of its pitch.

The symbol ↓ next to or above a note means a slight lowering of its pitch.

Figure 12.1 shows an example of the Sikah Baladi *maqam* scale on G using fine-tuning symbols. These symbols can be used to help musicians who haven’t sufficiently heard the *maqam* scale achieve better intonation. However, in practice it is necessary for students to learn the correct intonation of these notes and intervals by ear, because the use of these symbols is approximate and not mandatory.



FIGURE 12.1 The Sikah Baladi *maqam* scale on G, using fine-tuning symbols to slightly raise and lower the pitch of some notes.

Tonal Interval Symbols

Some Arabic music theory books use symbols to indicate tonal intervals at a glance. These symbols are relative; they do not need to start or end on a specific note in the scale and are only concerned with the tonal interval between two notes. They are occasionally used within Arabic notation, mostly in descriptions of *maqam* scales and their building blocks.

Figure 12.2 shows the tonal interval symbols for $\frac{1}{2}$ tone, $\frac{3}{4}$ tone, 1 tone, and $1\frac{1}{2}$ tone. As an intuitive convention, the two symbols smaller than a tone are placed below the notes, while the two symbols equaling a tone and greater are placed above the notes. In keeping with the same precision as modern Arabic notation, which divides the octave into 24 equal-tempered tones, the tonal interval symbols are expressed as fractions or multiples of an equal-tempered tone, with the understanding that they are just as approximate as the notation system is.

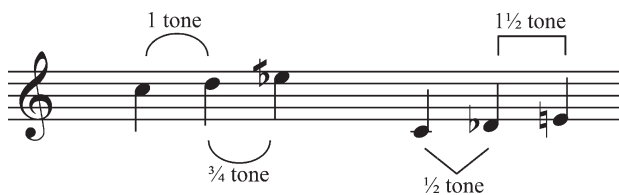


FIGURE 12.2 Tonal interval symbols for $\frac{1}{2}$ tone, $\frac{3}{4}$ tone, 1 tone, and $1\frac{1}{2}$ tone.

Key Signatures

Key signatures are called *dalil* in Arabic (literally, “guide” or “index”). Arabic music notation sometimes includes key signatures in the same way that Western music does, except that instead of having only two possible scales (major and minor) and 12 possible tonics for each one, Arabic music has dozens of possible *maqam* scales, but a very limited choice of tonics for each one. Figure 12.3 shows the key signature for Maqam Hijaz on D, while figure 12.4 shows the key signature for Maqam Rast on C.

Each composition in Arabic music is anchored in a starting *maqam*, and as such its key signature includes any sharps, flats, half-sharps, or half-flats used in that *maqam*’s scale. In addition to key signatures, the annotator may choose to write the *maqam* name above the staff, for clarity. In musical scores with frequent *maqam* changes (modulations), that can be a great help to the reader.



FIGURE 12.3 A key signature for Maqam Hijaz on D.



FIGURE 12.4 A key signature for Maqam Rast on C.

Since modulations (changes into a new *maqam* scale; see chapter 19: Modulation) are very common in Arabic music, compositions will inevitably break out of the initial

key signature and start using accidentals during the measures (or fractions of measures) where they are necessary. The exception is a long piece with multiple sections. If different sections modulate to different *maqamat*, the key signature can change with each section, making the result much more readable.

Reading Arabic Notation

Arabic music notation is somewhat limited and imprecise on many levels, and musicians reading it must supplement it with their aural experience and artistry in order to produce Arabic music of an acceptable quality.

The first area in which notation is limited is intonation. Contemporary Arabic music notation coerces microtonal *maqam* scales into a 24-tone ET model. Musicians need to render the notated *maqam* scale according to how they learned it by ear and restore its finer intonation details as precisely as their instruments permit. The precision of each melodic instrument's intonation varies; this is covered in depth in chapter 1: Melodic Instruments.

The second level of inaccuracy is more complex. Because of the great deal of variability in intonation, the correct intonation of some notes cannot be defined outside a particular *maqam* scale or even a particular musical phrase, as explained in detail in chapter 11: Tuning System. Let's take the conceptual note of E $\flat$. This note may have a slightly different intonation depending on what *maqam* it is part of. When part of Maqam Nahawand on C it is the 3rd note in the scale, while when part of Maqam Hijaz on D it is the 2nd note in the scale. These may appear to be the same note, but in actual practice the E $\flat$ of the Hijaz *maqam* scale is slightly higher than the E $\flat$ of the Nahawand *maqam* scale, enough to be noticeable to the trained ear.

Another area in which notation is limited is ornamentation, covered in detail in chapter 5: Ornamentation. Notated Arabic music is a basic or skeletal version of the melody, which each musician embellishes on each instrument. The musician adds a lot of know-how related to the instrument's mechanics and the prevailing aesthetic tradition in order to produce the fully ornamented result. Since a musician's ornamentation skills depend on his or her technique and experience, the same notated musical score will sound different with every year of experience that a musician acquires. The performance of the same score actually evolves with the interpreter's skills.

Syrian singer Zakiyya Hamdan once told a story⁴ about Egyptian veteran composer Zakariyya Ahmad, who spent a month in Beirut in 1950 teaching her ensemble his newly composed song “*ya halawit id-dunya*” using a score he had

⁴ Taha (2006).

notated. When he was satisfied that they had memorized it well, he said to the ensemble: “*And now, we’re going to put aside the sheet music, and play according to how we feel* [our moods].!”

Arabic musicians understand that notation is a minimal guide, and that they are expected to produce a result far richer in detail than the bare-bones notated piece. The most useful aspect of notation is as a memory or learning aid. Indeed, notation can be very useful when learning a new piece or when performing a complex piece that an ensemble hasn’t sufficiently rehearsed.

Notating for Multiple Instruments ---

As harmony is very rare in *maqam*-based Arabic music, chords are very infrequent in Arabic music notation. This is because Arabic music is for the most part purely melodic, which means it is primarily made up of one melody and no harmony. For this reason, the vast majority of Arabic music scores use only a single staff. In some cases, however, they may include parts for multiple instruments, each on a different staff. One such example is notating a separate bass line; another is a line for a specific instrumental solo. But by and large, one melody is played in unison notated over a single line.

Having said that, when each musician sees the notated melody, he or she reads it (or more accurately interprets it) differently. No musician reads notated Arabic and plays it “word for word” as notated. Each musician adds ornaments appropriate for that instrument, to the extent that his or her technical and musical experience allows. This is very similar to having a group of people read the same text aloud, delivering it with different accents, voice timbres, and affects. When multiple musicians are reading and playing the same piece together, the result is called heterophony, a beautiful peculiarity of Arabic music in which each instrument ornaments the melody in a way typical to that instrument. Heterophony is discussed in more detail in chapter 5: Ornamentation.

Notating Arabic Lyrics ---

Notating Arabic lyrics presents a very tough challenge: Western notation is left to right, like all Latin languages, while Arabic text is right to left, like all Semitic languages. This means that if lyrics were to be printed in Arabic, they would start at the wrong end of the page and go in the direction opposite that of the score.

Over the years a few solutions were devised to solve this discrepancy. The most common solution in use today is to break the Arabic text into syllables or parts of a word that must line up with their own note or notes, then write these parts in reverse order,

meaning left to right, in order to match the notated music. This solution is quite awkward to get used to for native readers of Arabic and feels very much like going on vacation and driving on the “wrong” side of the road, but it is by far the most prevalent one.

Another solution, practiced mostly outside the Arab world, is to transliterate the lyrics into a Latin script (e.g., English) that does line up nicely with the notated music (this is the solution adopted in the transcriptions used in this book). Although reading the lyrics with the underlying notes becomes smooth and intuitive, transliteration takes away a lot of pronunciation details and can be quite ambiguous sometimes, especially if the reader doesn’t actually know Arabic.

The last solution, which is quite rare, is to keep the Arabic lyrics running in the correct direction, right to left, but to reverse the notated music so it runs from right to left as well. Some attempts to notate music using this method were made by missionaries⁵ in the 19th century in Syria, but it is no longer used in practice.

Sheet Music

It’s not easy to walk into a music store and buy sheet music for your favorite Arabic song. Acquiring sheet music is a challenging undertaking, except for the very top tier of best-selling performers such as Umm Kulthum, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Abdel Halim Hafez, Warda, and Fairouz. Selling sheet music is not a booming business in the Arab world, and most composers don’t even bother publishing a book of sheet music for their compositions along with the lyrics, simply because there isn’t a big enough market for that. The sheet music industry that exists for Western music, including printed copies, copyright, and royalties, is virtually nonexistent in Arabic music.

Most books containing sheet music of the songs of Umm Kulthum, for example, were not published by her record labels, her composers, or her, but rather were published decades later by musicians who painstakingly transcribed some of her songs by ear. For this reason, there is no definitive (and copyrighted) volume of Umm Kulthum’s notated songs.

In contrast to the sheet music market, the audio recording market is huge, and top-tier performers sell millions of recordings to their fans. But while it would be difficult to find an Arabic musician who hasn’t played an Umm Kulthum song on his or her instrument, the overwhelming majority of these musicians learned that repertoire from recordings or from other musicians rather than from sheet music.

For this reason, in most cases the exercise of transcription is not undertaken for publication purposes. Instead it is either undertaken by composers teaching their

⁵ Lewis (1872).

new pieces to an ensemble or by arrangers and conductors who want to teach their ensembles a piece from the huge body of recorded or oral traditional Arabic music repertoire. For this reason, many transcriptions include a note at the top giving credit to the transcriber right below the composer and lyricist. Most of these transcriptions remain private and are sought after by students.

Transcribing Arabic Music

The exercise of transcribing any recorded piece demands expertise in music and in the notation system, but in Arabic music it presents additional challenges. One such challenge is deciding what part of a melody is ornamentation (to be left out) and what part is the raw or skeletal melody (to be transcribed). When a composer is notating his or her own score, this is a judgment call. But when a transcriber is notating a score from a recorded piece, it's a challenge to strip away the ornaments, which really belong to the singer or instrumentalist in a specific performance, and leave the bare-bones melody that the composer conceived.

In his book *A Collection of Eastern (Oriental) Musical Pieces*, Syrian violinist Tawfiq al-Sabbagh (1935) notated a collection of *sama'iyyat* and *basharif*, both Turkish instrumental forms that continue to be common in Arabic music. In the book's introduction, he explains his philosophy for notating an oral repertoire: "I adopted a balanced approach in notating [these pieces] so that they're not too dry and rigid, or too full of unnecessary detail in way that hides their essence and meaning."

This can be quite a tough call, since any ornaments that are not notated will not be preserved in sheet music for posterity. The converse is also risky: notating too much detail forces future musicians to perform the same ornaments over and over again, thereby limiting their choices for personal interpretation and expression and confining the score to the fashion of a time period.

In a conversation with Palestinian 'ud player and singer George Ziadeh, he explained his approach to transcribing Umm Kulthum's *"ruba'iyyat al-khayyam"* from a recording:

I cannot transcribe the melody note for note because there are many recorded versions that differ slightly, and even in the same version there are repetitions that differ in their syncopation. Some of these repetitions even stretch some lyrics as Umm Kulthum was in a state of *saltana* [elation], and to her maintaining that state was more important than faithfully interpreting the composition. In fact, one challenge to this transcription is that there is no rigidly

defined melody; instead the composition is intended by the composer to be raw material for the singer. The transcriber has to bear that in mind and accommodate the singer or more generally the performer.⁶

For these reasons, transcription is a task that demands a lot of expertise and artistry, a task in which the transcriber leaves his or her stamp on the notated piece in very subtle ways. Given that process, it is normal and acceptable to have slightly different notated versions of the same standard piece, just as it is normal and acceptable to have slightly different versions of a piece that was transmitted orally.

Notation Versus Memorization

When learning a new piece of music or performing it, Arabic musicians have a range of approaches available to them, from strictly reading sheet music during every rehearsal and performance, all the way to learning the piece by ear then performing it from memory. Hybrid approaches exist, such as using the score in the rehearsal but not in the performance, or using the score in the performance as a memory aid but striving to eventually discard it and rely solely on memory once the piece is full memorized.

The plus side of reading during a performance is that it ensures accuracy and adherence to the score, especially if the piece is long, complex, or unfamiliar. On the other hand, playing from memory is a very good practice, as it frees musicians from spending needless energy deciphering notes; instead, they can focus more on interpretation and ornamentation. Given that an Arabic music performance is a team effort that involves heterophony, ornamentation, spontaneous improvisations, unplanned repetitions of verses, and group negotiation of speed and loudness, it requires careful listening and frequent interaction. The musicians' ability to make eye contact with the ensemble and the audience greatly improves the music's freshness and cohesion.

Throughout her long career, Umm Kulthum always insisted that her ensemble memorize every piece and perform it without reading notation. To achieve such a level of memorization, rehearsals for some of her long-songs sometimes lasted months. By the end of that period, musicians knew every note and every syllable by heart. "This sense of security gave each participant the freedom to make music in a way that cannot be achieved by playing from written music. Umm Kulthum could thus be assured that the musicians could follow every improvised idea and every

⁶ George Ziadeh, personal communication with the author, 2015.

repeated phrase of hers during the whole performance, without having to discuss each variation beforehand.”⁷

In an informal jam session, called *jalsa* in Arabic (a sit-down gathering), musicians usually show up with no preplanned repertoire. As they decide what the next song should be, a very typical question is, “Do you know [some piece]?” What musicians are being asked is whether or not they have memorized the piece. A very flattering Arabic adjective to describe an Arabic musician is *hafidh* (*hafiz* in colloquial), literally one who has memorized. Interestingly, the root of that adjective is the verb *hafidha*, which means to memorize, but also to preserve/conserve. Being able to play pieces from memory is an essential skill for any serious Arabic musician. Seasoned musicians are expected to dish out the popular vocal and instrumental standards from memory, as nobody arrives to a jam session with a briefcase full of music scores of his or her favorite repertoire.

But the deeper reason that memorizing the classics is important is that it means knowing the repertoire, and knowing the repertoire means carrying the tradition in one’s head. This body of memorized music is then mined for habitual phrases, established melodic pathways, and ornamentation and intonation conventions. This allows the musician to play within the tradition, not reinvent the wheel.

The Impact of Adopting Western Notation

Using the present (Western) notation system to notate Arabic music is much like using a foreign alphabet to transliterate the Arabic language. It is imperfect, and also deceptive if the reader doesn’t realize that it is imperfect. Some letters that differ slightly appear to be the same, and for the purposes of transliteration they are considered the same. Similarly, when using notation artifacts such as the semitone and quartertone to notate notes in the Arabic *maqam* scale, Arabic notes may appear deceptively similar to Western notes, unless the reader learns them correctly through listening.

Even though Western notation is deeply entrenched in Arabic music today, and it would be unthinkable to switch to another system, it is not a perfectly precise system for notating the finer details of Arabic music. Instead of the music forcing a change in the notation system (which it did, to a very limited degree), the notation system has increasingly forced a change in the music.

The effect of learning and performing Arabic music based on Western notation instead of learning and transmitting it orally is a loss of the finer details of intonation

⁷ El-Mallah (1997, p. 68).

and ornamentation and the blurring of regional particularities. It produces music that is much more rigid (or dry) if learning is not supplemented with extensive listening to traditional recordings.

El-Mallah discusses the unquestioned use of notation in Arabic music in great detail and argues that it has had a negative effect on the structure and performance of Arab music. “The tyranny of notation tends to limit improvisation and ornamentation, characteristics that previously were the hallmarks of Arab musical style.”⁸

These points are reiterated by Marcus:

Moreover, the new reliance on notation changed the music which that notation was meant to preserve and disseminate. When a given piece had existed in the aural realm musicians routinely varied its melodic lines, but once written down, the melody was regarded as fixed. According to an age-old performance aesthetic, musicians had been encouraged to render a given melody according to their creative impulses and the idiosyncratic capabilities of their instruments; this quality was often lost with staff notation, where a melody would be performed uniformly, and without variation.⁹

Ironically, the adoption of Western notation brought Arabic music much closer to one of the goals of the 1932 Cairo Arabic Music Congress, which was to standardize Arabic music intonation across the Arab world. Indeed, Western notation has no room for regional “accents” or differences in intonation or in ornamentation styles. When notated, Arabic music becomes one music, or worse, it almost becomes one with Western music.

⁸ El-Mallah (1997).

⁹ Marcus (2015a, p. 280).

THE *JINS*

ALTHOUGH ARABIC *MAQAMAT* have historically been defined as heptatonic (7-note) scales, a scale alone does not reveal a *maqam*'s inner structure and complexity. We can gain a more accurate understanding of the *maqam* by looking first at its most basic building block: the *jins* (pronounced “jince,” pl. *ajnas*), a scale fragment of 3 to 6 notes.

The Basic Melodic Unit

The best translation for *jins* in English is “genus” (and the usage of *jins* in medieval Arab music theory is taken directly from the ancient Greek concept of the “tetra-chord genus”¹). This book develops a broader meaning of *jins* than is found in traditional Arabic or Greek music theory,² and the broader definition of “genus” fits very well: a type, a kind, or a group marked by common characteristics.

The definition of a *jins* in terms of its notes and intervals is only the tip of the iceberg; the *jins* is also the basic melodic unit of Arabic music. Given that Arabic music is primarily vocal, Arabic melodies tend to stay in a range of just a few notes for a period of time before moving up or down to another part of the scale—like most vocal music in the world, which is defined by the limited registers of the voice.

¹ al-Faruqi (1981).

² Marcus (2015a).

These “areas of melody” are the *ajnas*, but the *jins* defines more than just the range and intervals: each *jins* has very recognizable and distinct melodies that have been preserved and transmitted orally for centuries.

Within the musical language of each *jins*, small melodic fragments made up of just a few notes are added together to build longer melodies. Practicing musicians have a large vocabulary of these melodic fragments from which they can compose or improvise an infinite variety of melodies. Ethnomusicologists have used the term “melodic formulas,” jazz scholars have adopted the term “riffs,” and some contemporary Western music theorists have used the term “schemas” to name this phenomenon, but the best and simplest analogy is to the *words* of spoken language, which are strung together to build larger *phrases* and *sentences*.³ Using this analogy, each *jins* has a distinct vocabulary of *melodic words* that musicians have learned through the oral tradition—and those distinct melodies define the *jins* as much as its particular intervals do.

Finally, each *jins* conveys a distinct mood or character (but not necessarily one that can be easily described in words). The mood of each *jins* is subjective, and no study in ethnomusicology has found any evidence that it is perceived in the same way by all (or even majority of) listeners. *Ajnas* are very much like colors in the way they affect people. However, as with colors, *ajnas* do follow trends and conventions, and certain *ajnas* have traditionally been associated with a certain lyrical content or emotional expression. In addition, even when those moods can be difficult to pin down for an individual *jins*, the change from one *jins* to another in a melody is always felt as a distinct change in character, and these changes in mood (called modulations) have a powerful effect on both listeners and musicians.

Arabic music today is a mosaic of *ajnas* that originated from different parts of the Arab world and in some cases from neighboring regions (modern-day Iran and Turkey), and different *ajnas* were used in different eras. Some two dozen *ajnas* were used in Arabic music throughout the 20th century. The nine most commonly used *ajnas* (listed alphabetically), described in detail in chapter 14, are:

‘Ajam, Bayati, Hijaz, Kurd, Nahawand, Nikriz, Rast, Saba, and Sikah.

³ By making this analogy to words and sentences, we by no means imply that the melody words used to make up larger melodic sentences are referential or have meaning, in the way the words of spoken language do. But other aspects of the words of spoken language are analogous: discrete chunks of melody, made up of a fixed sequence of pitches, held in the memory of musicians (and listeners), and combined in variable ways to make longer utterances; just as words are discrete chunks of speech, made up of a fixed sequence of phonemes, held in the memory of speakers, and combined in variable ways to make longer utterances. We will develop this analysis further in future works; but as a matter of evidence from the oral tradition, these melody words have a factual, concrete existence in the minds of musicians—some of whom have an explicit awareness of that, and some of whom don’t.

While these and other *ajnas* can be combined to build potentially hundreds of different *maqam* scales, a much smaller number of combinations are used in practice, resulting in around 20 commonly used *maqamat*, along with a few dozen typical modulations among them.

A *maqam* can be described more or less as a pathway among its constituent *ajnas*. Indeed, when analyzing a long-song or melodic work, it becomes apparent that as the melody moves within the same *maqam* and between different *maqamat*, at a more basic level it is merely navigating from one *jins* to another during its entire course.

Interval Structure

Each *jins* has a unique structure defined by the intervals between its consecutive notes. These intervals do not change when the starting note of the *jins* is transposed up or down. In addition, intervals define the sound of a *jins* and make it familiar and recognizable to the ear, regardless of what *maqam* scale it occurs in. This familiarity is acquired by repetitive listening to *maqam*-based Arabic music.

Intervals between consecutive notes of a *jins* come in different sizes, as discussed in chapter 11: Tuning System. It is typical to describe and notate these intervals as fractions of a whole (equal-tempered) tone, such as:

$\frac{1}{4}$ tone, $\frac{1}{2}$ tone, $\frac{3}{4}$ tone, 1 tone, $1\frac{1}{4}$ tone, and $1\frac{1}{2}$ tone.

However, these labels are only approximate; they are useful for classification and notation but are not precise in defining the size of intervals. The exact intervals and intonation of each *jins* can only be learned through repeated listening.

Musicians often view the *jins* as a set of intervals rather than a set of absolute notes, since the second view changes with the choice of tonic. It's not uncommon for musicians in a rehearsal, for example, to say "that should be Rast, not Nahawand" when they mean to talk specifically about a *jins*'s 3rd degree (the 3rd of Jins Rast is about a quartertone higher than the 3rd degree of Jins Nahawand, all other notes being equal). This is because the main difference between the 2 notes is not seen in the abstract; rather, it is seen through its effect on the *jins* as a unit.

The scales of many *ajnas* include some intervals that vary slightly with the region and the time period, very much like an accent in spoken language. Nevertheless, each *jins* is still broadly recognizable and distinct, partly because its melodic vocabulary is also consistent and recognizable across regional and historical differences. However, in any given performance, the intonation of each *jins* is constant (except in rare cases when some phrases in a *jins* slightly distort certain intonations for aesthetic reasons). For this reason, in a fixed context, habitual listeners have no problem discerning one

jins from another, even when some of their intervals differ by a very small fraction of a semitone.

The Tonic

Each *jins* has a note of principal melodic emphasis around which phrasing takes place. In Arabic, that note is called *qarar* (the “bottom/floor,” also the “resting point”) or *darajat al-rukuz* (“the resting point”). This note is widely described in English as the tonic (borrowing a term from Western music theory). Traditional Arabic music references always equate the tonic with the first note in a *jins*’s scale. While this is correct for the vast majority of *ajnas*, this book includes two newly cataloged *ajnas* in which the tonic is in fact the last (upper) note of the scale fragment and several *ajnas* in which the tonic is in the middle of the *jins*. For this reason, a better and more meaningful definition for the tonic of a *jins* (or *maqam*, for that matter) is *the note that the melody returns to for resolution*.

The Leading Tone

The note immediately below the tonic of a *jins* is called the leading tone (again borrowing a term from Western music theory), or the *hassas* in Arabic (literally, “the sensitive note”). A *jins* is rarely performed without its leading tone, which has a strictly defined interval underneath the tonic, particular to each *jins*.⁴ In fact, in many cases the *jins* can be recognized merely by hearing its leading tone followed by its tonic, in other words from one single interval.

For example, hearing Jins Rast’s leading tone followed by its tonic is a sure indicator of an opening of a phrase in Rast, and many *taqasim* (instrumental improvisations) in Maqam Rast use the leading tone in their opening phrase. Changing the leading tone clearly signals an impending change in the *jins*, and in some cases musicians will change only the leading tone of a *jins* during a melody, in order to hint at a new *jins*, resulting in a very brief modulation that adds color. These melodic practices demonstrate this note is fundamentally part of the *jins*’s structure, as much as the notes above the tonic.

⁴ In Western music, the leading tone is more narrowly defined as always being a half step interval. This is because the half step is crucial to creating the sense of tonicization in both the harmony and melody of Western tonal music. A common modulation technique in that music is to raise a tone by a half step in order to lead up to the next note. However, this is a historically defined practice, not a law of music—as one can see by observing pretonal modal music in Europe, in which there are examples of “leading tones” that are a whole step below the tonic but nonetheless lead melodically upward. The sense of “leading” is a melodic phenomenon that is the result of expectation created through repeated, habitual melodic phrasing.

The *Ghammaz*

Melodies can emphasize other notes besides the tonic of a *jins*, and a note of emphasis can also act as a modulation point, becoming the tonic of a new *jins*. While there are multiple options for emphasis and modulation, each *jins* (with a few exceptions) has a specific note that is both the most important note of melodic emphasis and the most common modulation point to new *ajnas*.

Figure 13.1 is a transcription of the opening phrase of the recording “*layali Rast*” by Sheikh Abu al-‘Ila Muhammad (1884–1927), illustrating one of the prototypal opening melodies in Maqam Rast on C with its strong melodic emphasis on the 5th scale degree.

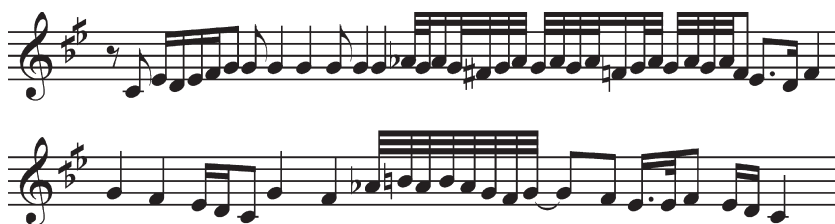


FIGURE 13.1 *Ghammaz* example from “*layali Rast*” by Abu al-‘Ila Muhammad.

Borrowing a term historically used for *maqam* scales, this book calls this note the *ghammaz*. In the context of the traditional definition of a *maqam* scale, the *ghammaz* is defined as the starting note for the second *jins* in the scale.

As such, *ajnas* are chained together at the *ghammaz* to form *maqam* scales (see chapter 18: The *Maqam* Scale). Chaining a new *jins* above the first one means starting the new tonic on the same note as the *ghammaz* of the first *jins*. Chaining a new *jins* below the scale means having the *ghammaz* of the *jins* below coincide with the current tonic. Any time one *jins* begins where the previous *jins* ends (at the *ghammaz*), it creates a link in a chain that spans two or more *ajnas*. *Maqam* scales are the result of a chain or two (sometimes three) *ajnas*, with no gaps or overlaps between them. For example, figure 13.2 shows the Maqam Suznak scale as a chain of two *ajnas* with no overlap.

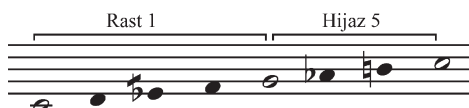


FIGURE 13.2 Maqam Suznak scale showing a chain of two *ajnas* with no overlap.

This phenomenon of chaining *ajnas* at the note with the strongest secondary melodic emphasis does have several exceptions. In some cases, the note of strongest

secondary melodic emphasis is not where most modulations occur, even if another *jins* can be located there (such as in the *ajnas* Saba, Saba Zamzama, Nahawand Murassa', and Mukhalif Sharqi). In other cases, the note on which most modulations occur is actually outside the *jins* (Jins Hijazkar and Jins Sikah Baladi). In these cases, the *ghammaz* is more difficult to define.

Size of a *Jins*

The best and most intuitive definition of the size of a *jins* is the one offered by Abu Shumays as “the distance between the tonic and the *ghammaz*,”⁵ because this is the fundamental range of melodic activity, and reflects how a *jins* is used in practice. Most *ajnas* have a strictly defined *ghammaz*, which defines the boundary between *ajnas*.

Although every note within a *jins* can be emphasized melodically at one point or another, there is always a primary modulation point at which the next *jins* is most often chained (the *ghammaz*). That note may be the 3rd, 4th, 5th, or the 6th scale degree. Thus, the simplest and most basic classification of *ajnas* is by size into 3-note, 4-note, or 5-note groups (see chapter 14: The Most Common *Ajnas* for a sample classification).

This approach to sizing a *jins* is fundamentally different than the approach taken in historic music theory references, because the medieval Arab theorists who borrowed from Greek tetrachord theory took at face value the assertion that scale fragments must always be defined in 4-note groupings—and that approach persists to the present day (see the section “*Ajnas* and Tetrachords” in this chapter for a more detailed discussion of this). By defining every *jins* as a 4-note group (with a small number of exceptions), full *maqam* scales frequently did not include a continuous chaining of *ajnas*; instead they allowed for gaps between *ajnas* (e.g., when one tetrachord starts on the 1st scale degree, and the second tetrachord starts on the 5th scale degree, a gap results between the 4th and 5th scale degrees). However, when examining the use of *ajnas* in practice (in the 20th-century repertoire), we find that the melody is never “outside” a *jins*. Instead it is always in a *jins* scale, going up and down a continuous chain of *ajnas*.

As noted previously, in practice there are several exceptions in which a few *ajnas* do not have an easily definable *ghammaz*. Nonetheless, these *ajnas* do modulate according to predictable patterns, on specific notes, often in a way that is related to the way other *ajnas* modulate. For example, Jins Saba shares many modulation pathways with Jins Bayati and the other *ajnas* in the 4-note group, and Saba can substitute for Bayati in numerous contexts. Jins Nahawand Murassa' shares modulation pathways with Jins Nahawand and can substitute for it as well. So, we can group Saba with the

⁵ Abu Shumays (2013).

4-note *jins* group and Nahawand Murassa‘ with the 5-note *jins* group, for the sake of better understanding the typical modulation structures of *ajnas*.

Extended *Jins* Scale

The vast majority of Arabic music theory books do not go beyond defining each *jins* as a 3- to 5-note scale fragment. However, in practice the melodic course of any typical *jins* includes phrases that go beyond its basic scale fragment yet still maintain the mood and melodic emphasis of the *jins*. Abu Shumays formally documented the extended *jins* scale, using the term “*jins* baggage” to describe it.⁶

In the extended *jins* scale, melodic phrases often go 1 or 2 notes below the *jins*’s tonic and even 1 or 2 notes above the *ghammaz*, while maintaining the clear feeling that the music is still “in” a particular *jins* and hasn’t modulated yet to a new *jins*. That feeling of modulation can sometimes be ambiguous, but it is easiest to define in terms of mood and tonicization: when a new note starts to feel like a true tonic or note of resolution (and no longer like the *ghammaz* of the original tonic), then a *jins* modulation has definitely occurred. Figure 13.3 shows a notated sample from the song “*mashghul ‘aleik*,” which uses the extended scale of Jins Kurd on D, including the notes below the tonic and above the *ghammaz*.



FIGURE 13.3 The opening of “*mashghul ‘aleik*,” a melody using the extended *jins* scale of Jins Kurd D, going both below the tonic (D) and above the *ghammaz* (G).

Because there can be extended melodic movement without modulation, the full melodic vocabulary of a *jins* requires an extended scale. While for the purposes of classification and chaining *ajnas* together, only the basic scale fragment of 3 to 5 notes is usually considered, the extended scale is what is performed in practice. Melodies that expand beyond the basic scale fragment of the *jins* are in some cases slightly flexible in terms of intervals compared to melodies within the basic scale fragment, and in some other cases, are just as strict. Usually there is a typical or

⁶ Abu Shumays (2013).

expected set of intervals above and below the *jins*, but different variations are also possible. The leading tone tends to be the most fixed of the notes below the *jins*. Figure 13.4 shows the extended scale of Jins Rast, including the leading tone, the tonic, and the *ghammaz*.

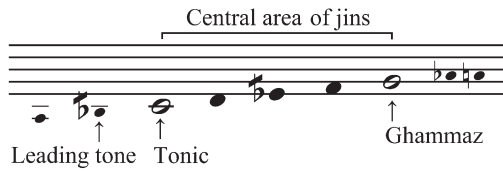


FIGURE 13.4 The extended Jins Rast scale on C, showing the leading tone, the tonic, and the *ghammaz*.

When chaining two *ajnas* together, the upper *jins*'s extended scale (below the tonic) may not include the same exact notes as the ending of the lower *jins*. Similarly, the extended scale of the lower *jins* (above the *ghammaz*) may not have the same exact notes as the beginning of the upper *jins*. In such cases, the tuning of the *jins* that the melody is in at any particular moment prevails. The same idea applies to *ajnas* in which modulations overlap the scale of one or more of them. For example, if the melody modulates from Jins Rast to Jins Sikah on the 3rd degree of Rast, Sikah's leading tone may not coincide with the 2nd degree of Rast. In that case, the tuning of Sikah's extended scale prevails. When that modulation is over and the melody goes back to Jins Rast, the Rast 2nd degree's tuning is reinstated. Figure 13.5 shows Jins Sikah and Jins Rast with their common notes aligned and highlights the difference between Rast's 2nd degree and Sikah's leading tone.



FIGURE 13.5 The extended scales of Jins Sikah (above) and Jins Rast (below), showing the difference between Rast's 2nd scale degree and Sikah's leading tone.

Ajnas and Tetrachords

The apparent similarities between the Greek tetrachord and the Arabic *jins* preoccupied Arabic music theorists for centuries, as they attempted to formulate Arabic *maqam* theory using the same concepts and terminology used in ancient Greek music theory.

The Greek influence on Arabic music theory began in the middle of the 9th century⁷ as Arab scholars living in Baghdad translated the works of Greek mathematicians, philosophers, and music theorists. Among these Arab scholars was music theorist Ya'qub Ibn Ishaq al-Kindi (805–873), who presented music as a mathematical science, with individual notes in a scale identified in terms of numerical relationships.

Many Arabic music theory books, including recent ones, claim that all *ajnas* are tetrachords (i.e., they are exactly 4 notes long). However, unlike ancient Greek music, in which each mode is made of exactly two tetrachords, the second of which starts on the 5th scale degree, the second *jins* in Arabic music often starts on the 3rd or 4th scale degree.

In order to adapt tetrachord theory to describe Arabic *ajnas* and resulting *maqam* scales, Arabic music theorists described different styles of joining (chaining) *ajnas* together, depending on whether the last note of the first *jins* was below, the same as, or above the first note of the second *jins*. To this end, they created an unnecessarily complex new terminology, calling these types of connections disjunct (*munfasil*), conjunct (*muttasil*), and overlapping (*mutadakhil*), respectively.

References that coerced every *jins* into a tetrachord had to devise a creative solution for the Sikah 3-note *jins*, which bifurcates into three possible second *ajnas* after its *ghammaz* on the 3rd degree. Some references⁸ created three tetrachord (4-note) variants of Sikah, using each of the three possible notes in the second *jins* above Sikah to complete each tetrachord. Thus, the individual 3-note Sikah *jins* was replaced with the Sikah, 'Iraq and Huzam tetrachords, named after the three corresponding *maqamat* in the Sikah family.

Most references, however, had a more malleable version of the Greek tetrachord theory and introduced three possible *ajnas* sizes: the trichord (3 notes), the tetrachord (4 notes), and the pentachord (5 notes). For purely historical reasons, “pentachord” was translated into Arabic as *'aqd* (pl. *'uqud*), while “tetrachord” and “trichord” were both translated as *jins* (pl. *ajnas*). While this approach more accurately matched the reality of how *ajnas* behave in Arabic music, these three sizes were not assigned to *ajnas* according to the size of their basic scale fragments (from the tonic to the *ghammaz*); instead the size assignment was somewhat arbitrary. For example, many references correctly considered the Nikriz *jins* a pentachord and the Sikah *jins* a trichord, but counted all remaining *ajnas* as tetrachords.

The reduction of Arabic *ajnas* into tetrachords is also problematic for reasons beyond size and classification: the tetrachord view of a *jins* never includes or mentions

⁷ Marcus (2015a, p. 273).

⁸ Salah al-Din (1950a); al-Hilu ([1961] 1972).

the extended scale, which is an integral part of any *jins*'s melodic pathways. It also ignores other aspects of its melodic behavior, such as its habitual phrases and customary modulations. For all these reasons, the terms trichord, tetrachord, and pentachord are inaccurate in describing Arabic *ajnas* and are not used in this book, except when describing scale fragments (which are not synonymous with *ajnas*).

The Standard Tonic

When learning a *jins* orally or notating it for teaching purposes, one standard tonic is usually chosen for each *jins*. For example, Jins Rast in absolute (when defined by itself) is usually notated with the C tonic. Of course, Jins Rast frequently starts on other tonics such as F or G, but the C version is the prototypal version used to teach and study this *jins*.

The choice of a *jins*'s standard tonic is often derived from the ergonomics of playing the Arabic *maqam* system on string instruments tuned in just fourth intervals (like the *'ud* and the violin) and from the desire to maximize the number of *ajnas* that start or end (or both) on open strings.

While several tonics may satisfy that goal for a given *jins*, the other factor in associating a *jins* with a tonic is historic, as some *ajnas* were named after actual notes in the historic Arabic 24-tone scale (see chapter 11: Tuning System). For example, Rast is the historic name for C, Sikah is the historic name for E♭, and 'Ajam is the historic name for B♭. For this reason, some *ajnas* (and the *maqamat* named after them) became associated with their historic 24-tone scale namesake, which serves as their standard tonic.

Transposition

Ajnas are recognized by their intervals, which do not change no matter what note the *jins* starts on. In practice, though, each *jins* is usually performed on a handful of possible starting notes, on the order of four or five at the most. The reason for this limitation is historic and has to do with exploiting the full potential of string instruments such as the *'ud* (or suffering their mechanical limitations, depending on the musician's viewpoint). Open string notes are preferred because their sound is louder and clearer, and their precise intonation is a given without any fingering effort.

Musicians greatly favor using open strings as a tonic or a *ghammaz* (or both). The 4-note *ajnas* like Bayati, Hijaz, and Kurd span a perfect fourth interval: the same interval between most adjacent *'ud* and violin strings. As such, transpositions

that anchor the first or last note of a *jins* (or both) in the C, F, A, D, and G notes (matching the standard Arabic ‘*ud* tuning) are preferred over others.

The chaining of *ajnas* into *maqam* scales means that limited choices for starting one of them also imply limited choices for starting the next one in the chain. Given that many *ajnas* span a perfect fourth or a perfect fifth interval, and that most ‘*ud* and violin strings are tuned in fourths and fifths, it is very likely that the open string choices made for the first *jins* continue to propagate up a chain of *ajnas*.

For example, *Jins Rast* is almost always started on C and G, and sometimes on F. This means it ends (and the next *jins* starts) on G, D or C, which are also open strings. *Jins Bayati* is frequently started on D, as well as G or A, all of which are open strings. This means that it ends on G, C, or D, also open strings. *Jins Sikah* is rarely started on any other notes than E♭ and B♭, which means it ends (and the next *jins* starts) on the D or G open strings.

Because of that relationship, the same limited number of quartertone notes serves most *ajnas* that include approximate $\frac{3}{4}$ -tone intervals, as long as the piece remains in the limited range of the popular starting notes for each *jins*. One of the early Western instruments that was mechanically modified and fitted with these quartertones was the accordion. The basic “Arabized” accordion model only included the E♭, A♭, B♭, and sometimes F♯ as extra notes. Another example of an instrument with a limited choice of possible quartertones is the *buzuq*; although it can be fitted with new frets, the standard frets usually only cover the same four quartertones as the accordion. For these instruments, the issue with uncommon transpositions is no longer about cumbersome fingering or imprecise intonation; it is about feasibility altogether.

Identity of a *Jins*

So far we have described the concept of *jins* in terms of three characteristics. The first is its structure in terms of intervals, which doesn’t change when a *jins* is transposed. This structure includes notes of emphasis—the tonic and the modulation point—as well as expected intervals for the notes on either side of the *jins*. The second characteristic of a *jins* is its melodic vocabulary, which is learned through the oral tradition. The third is the mood of the *jins*, which is subjective in association but nonetheless distinct and characteristic.

However, it is important to note that for experienced musicians and listeners, each *jins* is more than simply the sum of its defined characteristics: rather, each *jins* takes on a distinct identity that makes it immediately recognizable to experienced listeners and musicians, no matter the context. A good analogy is how we identify people. When we meet new people, we might initially think of them in terms of

their distinguishing characteristics, for example “the tall man with glasses in a suit” or “the lady with curly hair and a small chin.” But once we know people well, we recognize them immediately as individuals, even if they’ve changed their hair or have grown older, gained or lost weight, and so forth. That quality of immediate recognition applies to *ajnas* as well: each has a distinctive character and identity that goes beyond any particulars.

These distinctive characters can be evocative of particular moods or places, or can remind us of particular songs—but whatever association people may have with different *ajnas*, it is important to realize that this quality of immediate recognition is important to our understanding of *maqam* and modulation. Composers and musicians take advantage of this recognizable quality because it enables them to make very quick passing modulations, using just a few notes, or to change the whole mood of a composition through a *jins* modulation that doesn’t appear to change very many intervals on the surface. This is one of the key ingredients of *tarab* (musical joy), because the musician can rely on the listeners to react to even the minutest of changes.

Therefore, the most important task for someone hoping to understand how the *maqam* system works isn’t reading about or memorizing the characteristics of each *jins*, but instead developing familiarity with the sound of each *jins* in as many different contexts as possible. This familiarity is the key to informed listening, fluent performance, and effective analysis.

THE MOST COMMON AJNAS

REFERENCES ON ARABIC music theory often differ on the classification of *ajnas*, especially the name and size of each *jins*. There is no consensus on a definitive and comprehensive list of all *ajnas* that has gathered agreement from every Arab region and has survived the test of time. These discrepancies are due in part to regional differences and to the evolution of naming conventions and classification approaches over time, as well as to the absence of a centralized authority on Arabic music theory.

This book does not attempt to present yet another definitive list that negates previous ones; instead we present one possible broad list based on current common practice, while accepting that different classifications also exist. As such, this and the following two chapters list what we feel to be the most important *ajnas* used in traditional Arabic music during the 20th century, within the *sharqi* tradition practiced from Aleppo to Cairo.

Every classification scheme is subject to exceptions, usually numerous ones, and the way we have chosen to classify *ajnas* reveals some inconsistencies. This is because the Arabic *maqam* system did not grow out of a perfectly coherent and internally consistent mathematical foundation; instead it developed over centuries based on common practice and usage. This book simply observes it and attempts to extract broadly consistent behavioral traits, with the understanding that they are not absolute rules. Each “inconsistency” has important lessons for how we understand the

maqam system, but the fundamental lesson is that every *jins* truly is different from every other, and their individual characteristics aren't rules for them to follow, but simply differences revealed through comparisons with other *ajnas*.

The Nine Most Common Ajnas

The nine *ajnas* described in this chapter make up the vast majority of melodies used in traditional Egyptian and Syrian music. The *maqamat* they can be combined into (20–30 in common practice) and the modulations among them form the core of Arabic *maqam* music as practiced in the 20th century.

A useful Arabic phrase that music students learn in Syria¹ is “*sunī’a bisihrika*” (ضِنْعٌ بِسِحْرِكَ—it was made with your magic), which contains the initials for the eight most popular *jins/maqam* names: Saba, Nahawand, ‘Ajam, Bayati, Sikah, Hijaz, Rast, and Kurd. This book also classifies Jins Nikriz among the most popular *ajnas* because of its frequency in the performed repertoire. Thus, this chapter includes the following nine *ajnas* (listed alphabetically):

‘Ajam, Bayati, Hijaz, Kurd, Nahawand, Nikriz, Rast, Saba, and Sikah.

All nine *ajnas* share their names with a *maqam* in which they occur in the first (root) position. Because of their extensive use in the repertoire, each of these *ajnas* (Saba is the exception) affords multiple choices for the succeeding *jins* up the scale. As such, they create *maqam* families, that is, multiple *maqamat* rooted in the same first *jins* but having a different second *jins*.

These nine *ajnas* are also those that can best be described using traditional theory: their melodic content is largely above the tonic, stretching up to their *ghammaz*, whether it is on the 5th, 4th, or 3rd scale degree, with melodies below the tonic and above the *ghammaz* mostly reinforcing the area in the center, which provides the main identity of the *jins*.

These *ajnas* are categorized by size, as determined by their basic scale span from tonic to *ghammaz* (in all cases except Jins Saba), because that size is a major factor in determining how the *jins* is used within the *maqam* and in modulation. If we put aside the many specifics of modulation, in the broadest sense it is most common for *ajnas* of the same size to modulate to each other on the same tonic. It is also quite common for a 4-note *jins* and a 5-note *jins* to chain together to form the basic skeleton of a *maqam*, because a perfect fourth and a perfect fifth chained together make

¹ Dr. Samer Ali, conversation with the author, 2016.

TABLE 14.1

Nine Most Common *Ajnas*, Classified by Size

Size	<i>Ajnas</i>
3-note	Sikah
4-note	Bayati, Hijaz, Kurd, Saba*
5-note	‘Ajam, Nahawand, Nikriz, Rast

*Jins Saba is listed with the 4-note *ajnas* because of its strong similarity to Jins Bayati and because it acts like the other 4-note *ajnas* when it occurs as a secondary *jins*. Yet Jins Saba is difficult to classify, because it has strong melodic emphasis on its 3rd scale degree, while its primary modulation point is on its 6th scale degree.

an octave. Following this classification, table 14.1 shows these nine most common Arabic *ajnas* with their size.

Characteristics of a *Jins*

The characteristics of each *jins* can be divided into four main areas:

- the mood, character, and identity of the *jins*,
- the intervallic structure of the *jins*’s scale,
- the melodic vocabulary used in the *jins*, and
- the modulation pathways followed by the *jins*—either as the base of a *maqam* or as a secondary *jins* within other *maqamat*.

The descriptions in this and the following two chapters start with a brief statement on the mood, character, and identity of each *jins*. Some of the information about a *jins*’s mood may be subjective; some is cultural and historical. Other details, such as the origin of the *jins*’s name, are also presented, followed by a notated version of the *jins*’s extended scale. Normal-sized notes indicate the basic scale, while small notes indicate the extended scale. The single larger-size open note is the tonic, while the normal-sized open note is the *ghammaz* (if applicable).

Each *jins* section includes a comprehensive guide to its characteristics, presented in tabular form. These are the intervallic structure of the *jins* (including the standard tonic); the size of the *jins* (determined by the basic scale span from the tonic to the *ghammaz*); a description of characteristic notes and intervals; and a description of the common modulation pathways of the *jins*, used both as the main *jins* of a *maqam* and as a secondary *jins* in other *maqamat* (a secondary *jins* is any *jins* used by a *maqam* that doesn’t start on the *maqam*’s tonic).

Next is a list of songs in which each *jins* can be found and a transcription of a melody from one of them, illustrating a typical usage of the *jins*. This is followed by a list of compositions in which it is used as a secondary *jins*.

All of this is intended as a richly detailed reference for the reader interested in experiencing Arabic music, whether through listening or playing. We hope that such readers will find the descriptions of each *jins* useful to return to over the course of the multiyear time period it usually takes to become familiar with all of the *ajnas* by ear. While these chapters can probably be read in one sitting, the information contained in them cannot be properly digested without hundreds of hours of listening.

The goal of readers of this book should not be to memorize the characteristics of each *jins*, but to use the characteristics provided here as a guide for identifying the *jins* when it occurs in the repertoire and listening to it until it becomes as familiar as a good friend. We have provided numerous examples within the repertoire where each *jins* can be found, as well as a transcription of a melody from a well-known song using the *jins*; these are the most important pieces of information in the descriptions provided.

Jins Rast

Rast is the iconic Arabic *jins* and one of the most common *ajnas* in the repertoire we focus on, without which Arabic music as we know it would probably not exist today. Melodies in Rast often have a grand or expansive character and a joyous/celebratory mood. It is also the sound of one of the most common *adhan* (Muslim call-to-prayer) melodies used throughout the Islamic world. The word Rast (pronounced “rust”) is originally Persian and means “right” or “straight.” Jins Rast is named after the note *Rast* in the historic Arabic 24-tone scale, which coincides with modern-day C4.

The Rast extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.1 with its standard tonic on C4; its main characteristics are listed in table 14.2.



FIGURE 14.1 Jins Rast on C.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Rast in their openings:

- Fairouz’s *taqtuqa* “*ya dara duri fina*”
- Traditional Aleppo *qadd* “*sayd il-‘asari*”
- Umm Kulthum’s *taqtuqa* “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*” (see figure 14.2)

TABLE 14.2

Jins Rast Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C ₄ (F and G are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth
Playable on Western Instruments	No
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	The 3rd scale degree is a quartertone note, roughly $\frac{3}{4}$ of a tone above the 2nd scale degree. The 3rd degree coincides with the Sikah note in the historic Arabic 24-tone scale and undergoes a subtle regional variation in the same way an accent does (e.g., it is higher in Aleppo than it is in Cairo).
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (5)	Upper Rast (5/8),* Nahawand (5), Hijaz (5), Bayati (5), Saba (5)
Other Common Modulations**	Sikah (3), Saba Dalanshin (6/8), Jiharkah (8)
<i>Maqamat</i> in Rast Family	Rast, Kirdan, Suznak, Nairuz, Suzdalar, Mahur, Dalanshin
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 4th of Bayati, Hijaz, and Kurd on the 6th of Sikah/Huzam

*The notation (5/8) means that the basic scale fragment of Jins Upper Rast starts on the 5th scale degree of the *maqam*, but its actual tonic occurs on the 8th scale degree of the *maqam*. This notation is also used with Jins Upper ‘Ajam (5/8), whose tonic is at the top of its basic scale fragment as well, and with Jins Saba Dalanshin (6/8), whose tonic is in the middle of its basic scale fragment (see chapter 16 for the descriptions of these three *ajnas*).

**These are not intended to be comprehensive; see the *sayr* diagrams in chapter 24 for a fuller list.

FIGURE 14.2 A sample phrase in Jins Rast from Umm Kulthum’s *taqtuqa* “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*.”

Jins Rast is the root *jins* of the very popular Rast family of *maqamat*. Because Rast is tremendously common in the repertoire, there are many options for modulation to the succeeding *jins*, and as such the Rast *Maqam* family has a large number of branch *maqamat*. In Syria, it is said that “if you want your night to be long, sing in [Maqam]

Rast,” both because there are so many songs in Maqam Rast and because the particular energy of the *jins* sustains *tarab* very well. The following songs prominently feature Rast as a secondary *jins* (a *jins* used by a *maqam* other than the root *jins*):

- The Aleppan *qadd* “*qadduka al-mayyas*” opens with Jins Rast on the 4th of Maqam Hijaz.
- Umm Kulthum’s long-song “*awwidti ‘ini*” uses Jins Rast on the 4th of Maqam Kurd at the end of every verse to transition to the ending.
- Farid al-Atrash’s “*nura nura*” has a short *mawwal* in Jins Rast on the 4th of Maqam Bayati.
- The *muwashshah* “*jadaka al-ghaythu*” uses Jins Rast on the 6th of Maqam Sikah in the third verse.

Jins Nahawand

Nahawand will sound to the Western listener like the bottom half of a minor scale, because it has the same basic intervals, though Nahawand is not equal-tempered in its proper form.

The Nahawand extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.3 with its standard tonic on C4. Its main characteristics are listed in table 14.3.



FIGURE 14.3 Jins Nahawand on C.

Jins Nahawand is the root *jins* of the Nahawand family of *maqamat*, and while it is less common as a root *jins* than Rast, for example, it is tremendously common as a secondary *jins* in many *maqamat*. The name “Nahawand” comes from the Persian word *Nihavent*, a city in the Northwest of present-day Iran. *Nihavent* is also the name of the Turkish version of Nahawand.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Nahawand in their openings:

- Umm Kulthum’s long-song “*alfleila we leila*,” starting from the introduction
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab’s instrumental “*balad il-mahbub*”
- Ziad Rahbani’s song “*shu hal-iyam*”
- The *muwashshah* “*lamma bada yatathanna*” (composer unknown); see figure 14.4

In Western music, the “relative major/minor” relationship is a very common modulation, but in Arabic music it is much less common between Nahawand and

TABLE 14.3

Jins Nahawand Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C4 (D, F, and G are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	The 3rd scale degree, a minor third above the tonic, is typically tuned as a Pythagorean minor third, lower than both the equal-tempered and just minor thirds. Some musicians make it even lower than that in certain phrases. The small semitone between the 2nd and 3rd scale degrees is often exploited melodically.
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (5)	Kurd (5), Hijaz (5), Bayati (5)
Other Common Modulations	Nikriz (1), Nahawand Murassa' (1), 'Ajam (3)
<i>Maqamat</i> in Nahawand Family	Nahawand, Farahfaza, 'Ushshaq Masri
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 4th of Bayati, Hijaz, and Kurd on the 5th of Rast, Nikriz, and 'Ajam on the 3rd of Sikah

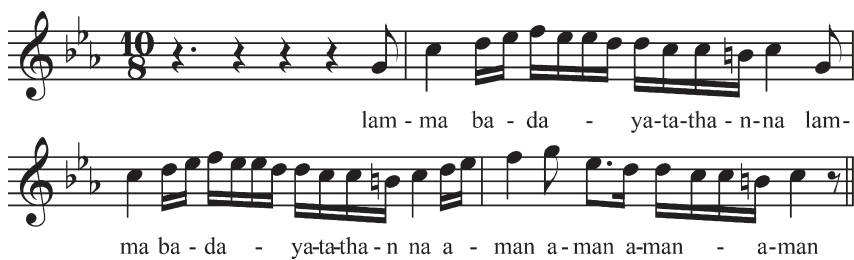


FIGURE 14.4 A sample phrase in Jins Nahawand from the *muwashshah* “*lamma bada yatathanna*.”

'Ajam. This illustrates the fact that modulation paths are cultural and conventional, rather than absolute. Nahawand behaves similarly to Rast, with its most common modulations on its 5th scale degree.

Examples that feature Jins Nahawand as a secondary *jins* abound, including the following:

- On the 5th of Maqam Nikriz: Abdel Wahab's *dawr* "*il-albi yama-ntazar*"
- On the 5th of Maqam Suzdalara: Sabah's "*yana yana*" and Umm Kulthum's "*fakkaruni*"
- On the 3rd of Maqam Huzam: the fourth verse of Umm Kulthum's "*il-wardi gamil*"
- On the 4th of Maqam Bayati: Farid al-Atrash's "*nura nura*" at the phrase "*ismik 'ala rasmik sura*"

Jins Nikriz

Nikriz has a very "Oriental" sound to Western ears, due in part to the prominent augmented second ($1\frac{1}{2}$ -step) interval that it shares with Jins Hijaz (although the interval occurs in a different location in Nikriz). For this reason, Nikriz is often confused with Hijaz, especially when they occur in the secondary position in a *maqam* scale.

The Nikriz extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.5 with its standard tonic on C4.



FIGURE 14.5 Jins Nikriz on C.

The name Nikriz (alternatively spelled Nakriz) comes from the Persian phrase "*na goriz*," which means "don't run away." Many references alternatively call it Jins Nawa Athar, because it is the root *jins* for both the Nikriz and Nawa Athar *maqamat*.

Nikriz is much more common as both a *jins* and a *maqam* in Turkish and Eastern European music than it is in Arabic music. It is used in profusion in the Turkish instrumental genre *longa*, which was imported into Arabic music toward the end of the Ottoman period (late 19th and early 20th centuries). For this reason, Nikriz still sounds very Eastern European to Arab listeners. In Arabic music, it more commonly occurs as a modulation from Jins Nahawand (it is equivalent to raising Nahawand's 4th scale degree) or Jins Rast (especially in the Aleppan repertoire) or as part of Maqam Hijazkar on the 4th degree. The main characteristics of Jins Nikriz are listed in table 14.4.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Nikriz:

- The song "*hawwil ya ghannam*" by Elia Matni
- Farid al-Atrash's "*gamil gamal*"

TABLE 14.4

Jins Nikriz Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C4 (D, F and G are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	1½-step interval between 3rd and 4th scale degrees, not to be confused with the equivalent interval between the 2nd and 3rd scale degrees of Jins Hijaz (see “Jins Hijaz” section)
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (5)	Nahawand (5), Hijaz (5), Hijazkar (5)
Other Common Modulations	Nahawand (1), Rast (1)
<i>Maqamat</i> in Nikriz Family	Nikriz, Nawa Athar
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 4th of Hijaz (in Maqam Hijazkar) on the tonic of Nahawand and Rast

- The *muwashshah* “*bayna qasiyunin wa rabwa*” by Omar al-Batsh
- Umm Kulthum’s “*ansak da kalam*” (see figure 14.6)

The image shows a musical score for a sample phrase in Jins Nikriz. It consists of two staves of music in 4/4 time, with a key signature of two flats (B-flat and E-flat). The melody is written in a treble clef. The lyrics are written below the notes: "wa - hib - bi ta - ni leh - - -" on the first staff and "- - - wa` mil fi hub - ba-k eh - ." on the second staff. The music features a characteristic 1½-step interval between the 3rd and 4th scale degrees, which is a defining feature of Jins Nikriz.

FIGURE 14.6 A sample phrase in Jins Nikriz from Umm Kulthum’s *ughniya* “*ansak da kalam*.”

Because Maqam Nikriz is not very common in Arabic music, Jins Nikriz has a limited number of modulation options. It more frequently occurs as a secondary *jins* (in Maqam Hijazkar) or as a modulation from Nahawand or Rast. The following songs prominently feature Nikriz as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 4th of Maqam Hijazkar: “*harramt ahibbak*” by Warda
- On the 4th of Maqam Hijaz: the fourth verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*ana fi-ntizarak*”
- On the 4th of Maqam Bayati: the third verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*ba’id ‘annak*”

Jins 'Ajam

'Ajam (also transliterated as Ajam) will sound to the Western listener like the bottom half of the major scale, although like Nahawand, it is not equal-tempered, and its melodic phrasing is different than what is used in Western music on the major scale. It is a less common *jins* within the repertoire we cover in this book, and in Arabic music it doesn't necessarily have the same joyful mood associations as the Western major scale.

Jins 'Ajam has two versions: a 5-note version, which is the most common version used when it is the root of a *maqam*, and a 3-note version, which occurs mostly when 'Ajam is used as a secondary *jins*, for example on the 6th scale degree of Maqam Bayati. The 3-note version is a holdover from the Maqam known 'Ajam 'Ushayran, an archaic version of Maqam 'Ajam that modulated primarily on its 3rd scale degree rather than its 5th, and which fell out of use during the 20th century.

The 'Ajam extended *jins* scale is notated in its 5-note version in figure 14.7 (with its standard tonic on C₄), and its 3-note version is notated in figure 14.8 (with its standard tonic on B₄^b).



FIGURE 14.7 Jins 'Ajam in its 5-note version with its standard tonic on C₄.



FIGURE 14.8 The 3-note version of Jins 'Ajam with its standard tonic on B₄^b (the octave above 'Ajam 'Ushayran, where this *jins* most often occurs in a secondary *jins* context).

The word *'ajam* means “foreign” (specifically, Persian) in classical Arabic, which reflects the fact that Arab musicians viewed the sound of this *jins* as somewhat foreign to the sound of Arabic music and/or more closely associated with Persian music. (The irony here is that many of the names of other *ajnas* actually come from Farsi, and many Persians were very involved in Arabic music theory in the medieval period.)

The note B₃ in the historic Arabic 24-tone scale is known as 'Ajam 'Ushayran, and as a result many theoretical sources continue to emphasize it as the standard tonic

TABLE 14.5

Jins ‘Ajam Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C ₄ , or B ₃ (‘Ajam ‘Ushayran note; F and G are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth; or 3 scale degrees, major third (occurring as root of ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran, often tuned as a Pythagorean major third due to the typical tuning of B ₃ in Maqam Bayati D and others)
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Major third above the tonic is slightly variable, sometimes as low as a just major third, sometimes as high as a Pythagorean major third, depending on composition and context (whether or not it is a secondary <i>jins</i>).
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (5)	Upper ‘Ajam (5/8), Hijaz (5), Nahawand (5)
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (3)	Bayati (3), Kurd (3), Hijazkar (3)
Other Common Modulations	Saba Dalanshin (3/5)
<i>Maqamat</i> in ‘Ajam Family	‘Ajam, Shawq Afza, ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran (archaic)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	3-note version: on the 6th of Bayati, Kurd, or Saba 5-note version: on the 4th of Hijaz (in Maqam Zanjaran)

for this *jins*. F and G are also common tonics. The main characteristics of Jins ‘Ajam are listed in table 14.5.

The following songs prominently feature Jins ‘Ajam:

- Umm Kulthum’s “*lissa fakir*”
- Fairouz’s “*il-buwab*”
- The Iraqi traditional “*tal’a min beit abuha*” (made popular by Nazem al-Ghazali)
- Sayed Darwish’s “*til’it ya m-abla nurha*” (see figure 14.9)



FIGURE 14.9 A sample phrase in Jins ‘Ajam from the song “*til’it ya m-abla nurha*.”

As mentioned previously, ‘Ajam in contemporary usage acts very much like the other 5-note *ajnas* Rast and Nahawand, with modulations on its 5th scale degree, though it does have some unique modulations that differ from the others. As a secondary *jins*, ‘Ajam uses either the 5-note version or the 3-note version, depending on context. The 5-note version used on the 4th scale degree of Hijaz produces the rare but beautiful Maqam Zanjara. The following songs prominently feature ‘Ajam as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 6th of Maqam Bayati: traditional Aleppan *qadd* “*ah ya bilu*” opens with Jins ‘Ajam
- On the 6th of Maqam Saba: Umm Kulthum’s “*huwwa sahib*,” 3rd verse
- On the 4th of Maqam Zanjara: Zakariyya Ahmad’s “*ya halawit id-dunya*”

Jins Bayati

Bayati (or Bayyati, also called Bayat) is one of the most popular and common *ajnas* in Arabic music and is especially popular in folk music and dance. Versions of this *jins* are also used in the folk and classical music of Iraq, Iran, and Turkey, as well as in Kurdish music.

This is another “microtonal” *jins*, with the quartertone note on its 2nd rather than 3rd scale degree (its intervals are nearly identical to those of Jins Rast from 2nd to 5th scale degrees). For this reason, many new listeners to Arabic music have trouble distinguishing between these two *ajnas*. As with Rast, the quartertone note, roughly $\frac{3}{4}$ step above the tonic, varies with the region like a dialect or accent and must be learned precisely by ear. The word *Bayati* in Arabic is the name of a historic tribe from Saudi Arabia, and the *jins* is also used to begin any recitation of the Qur’an.

The Bayati extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.10, with its standard tonic on D4.



FIGURE 14.10 Jins Bayati on D.

TABLE 14.6

Jins Bayati Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	D $\sharp$ (G, A, E and C are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	4 scale degrees, just fourth
Playable on Western Instruments	No
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	2nd scale degree is a quartertone note, roughly $\frac{3}{4}$ of a tone above the tonic (this note is variable by region, like an accent)
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (4)	Nahawand (4), Rast (4), Hijaz (4) (Maqam Bayati Shuri)
Other Common Modulations	'Ajam (6); Husayni (5-4), a suspended emphasis on the 5th scale degree, one step above Rast 4 (often mistaken for Bayati 5); 'Ajam (3)
<i>Maqamat</i> in Bayati Family	Bayati, Husayni, Bayati Shuri
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 5th of Rast and Nahawand on the 3rd of Sikah on the octave of Maqam Kurd

In this notated version, the 2nd degree (E $\flat$) falls on the Sikah note in the historic Arabic 24-tone scale. Interestingly, the Sikah note also occurs in the *ajnas* Sikah and Rast, and while it is the same conceptual note, its precise intonation varies with each *jins* and must be learned by ear. The main characteristics of Jins Bayati are listed in table 14.6.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Bayati:

- Fairouz's "*sa'aluni-n-nas*"
- The traditional Levantine folk song and line dance "*dal'ona*"; the entire song pretty much stays in the first 5 notes of Maqam Bayati
- Farid al-Atrash's "*nura nura*" (see figure 14.11)

FIGURE 14.11 A sample phrase in Jins Bayati from the song "*nura nura*."

Bayati is the prototypical 4-note *jins*, with melodic emphasis and modulations on its 4th scale degree. It also modulates to ‘Ajam on its 6th scale degree. As a secondary *jins*, it is interchangeable with Hijaz and Saba. The following songs prominently feature Bayati as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 5th of Maqam Rast: the *dawr* “*asl il-gharam*” by Muhammad ‘Uthman
- On the 5th of Maqam Rast: Muhammad Abdel Wahab’s “*khayyi khayyi*”
- On the 3rd of Maqam Sikah/Huzam: second verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*il-wardi gamil*”
- On the octave above Maqam Kurd: *taslim* and 3rd *khana* of Sama‘i Kurd by Abdo Dagher

Jins Hijaz

Hijaz is possibly the most recognizable Arabic *jins* because of its prominent augmented second (1½ step) interval. Melodies using this interval have long been used to evoke the “exoticism” of the Middle East, especially in 19th-century European Orientalist depictions of Arabic music, such as in the music of composers Camille Saint-Saens and Nikolai Rimsky-Korsakov. It is also often used in Hollywood film soundtracks to depict Arabic music or to evoke the Arabian Desert. To add insult to injury, these short Orientalist riffs in Jins Hijaz are invariably played on equal-tempered instruments!

Yet Jins Hijaz is also a deeply rooted Arabic sound, being used as one of the common melodies for the *adhan*, the Muslim call-to-prayer (the other common one being in Rast). In fact, the word *Hijaz* in Arabic refers to a region in western Saudi Arabia along the Red Sea, the region including the holy cities of Mecca and Medinah.

The Hijaz extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.12 with its standard tonic on D4. The name Hijaz was also given to the G♭/F♯ note in the historic 24-tone scale, which in the D version of the *jins* falls on the 3rd degree. Its main characteristics are listed in table 14.7.



FIGURE 14.12 Jins Hijaz on D.

TABLE 14.7

Jins Hijaz Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	D ₄ (G, C, and A are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	4 scale degrees, just fourth
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes, poorly
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	The 1½-step interval between the 2nd and 3rd scale degrees. While the interval is notated as an augmented second, in practice it is narrower than the equivalent equal-tempered interval and must be learned by ear. In the neighboring Turkish <i>makam</i> tradition, the interval is even narrower than in Arabic music.*
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (4)	Nahawand (4), Rast (4), Nikriz (4), ‘Ajam (4)
Other Common Modulations	Sikah (6), Hijazkar (8)
<i>Maqamat</i> in Hijaz Family	Hijaz, Zanjaran, Hijazkar (the <i>maqamat</i> known as Shadd ‘Araban, Suzidil, and Shahnaz are transpositions of Maqam Hijazkar, rooted on low G ₃ , A ₃ , and D ₄ respectively)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 5th of Rast, Nahawand, ‘Ajam, and Nikriz on the 4th of Bayati (Maqam Bayati Shuri) on the 4th of Nahawand (in Maqam Nahawand Murassa’) on the 3rd of Sikah on the 3rd of Saba, Saba Dalanshin, and Saba Zamzam

*Tracking the Hijaz intonation starting from the 1930s to the present day shows a clear shift toward equal temperament. Although this is generally the case for all Arabic *ajnas*, playing the Hijaz *jins* in equal temperament is particularly egregious. For this reason, the equal-tempered version of Hijaz has earned the derogatory name “Piano Hijaz.”

The following songs prominently feature Jins Hijaz:

- Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*bahlam bik*”
- The traditional Aleppan *qadd* “*il-bulbul nagha ghusn il-full*”
- Fairouz’s “*tila’li il-biki*”
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab’s dance instrumental “*zeina*” (see figure 14.13)



FIGURE 14.13 A sample phrase in Jins Hijaz from the dance piece “zeina.”

Hijaz is a fairly common *jins* and the root of several *maqamat*. It also is frequently used as a secondary *jins* in many other *maqamat*. The following songs prominently feature Hijaz as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 5th of Maqam Suznak: Umm Kulthum’s “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*”
- On the 5th of Maqam ‘Ajam/Shawq Afza: Umm Kulthum’s “*lissa fakir*”
- On the 3rd of Maqam Huzam: Umm Kulthum’s “*il-wardi gamil*”
- On the 4th of Maqam Bayati: the traditional Aleppan *qadd* “*ah ya hilu*”

Jins Kurd

Kurd is analogous to what is known in the West as the Phrygian mode, because of its lowered 2nd scale degree. In Arabic music in the period we cover, Jins Kurd (and its *maqam* family) is less common than any of the other *ajnas* mentioned in this chapter. However, perhaps because of its ease in transferring to Western equal-tempered instruments, Kurd has become a very popular *jins* (and *maqam*) in contemporary Arabic pop music, which is heavily Westernized in its arrangements. This trend started in the 1950s in Egypt, the period that saw the first expansion in the usage of Maqam Kurd. Umm Kulthum’s most famous song “*inta ‘umri*,” composed in 1964 by Muhammad Abdel Wahab, is in Maqam Kurd. Jins Kurd (pronounced “koord”) was originally called *kurdi*, meaning Kurdish in Arabic.

The Kurd extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.14 with its standard tonic on D4. The name Kurd was also given to the Eb note in the 24-tone historic Arabic scale, which falls on the 2nd degree when the tonic is D. Its main characteristics are listed in table 14.8.



FIGURE 14.14 Jins Kurd on D.

The following songs prominently feature Kurd:

- Umm Kulthum’s “*‘awwidti ‘ini*” and “*ya zalimni*”
- The *muwashshah* “*yamurru ‘ujuban*” (by Omar al-Batsh)
- Karem Mahmoud’s “*mashghul ‘aleik*” (see figure 14.15)

TABLE 14.8

Jins Kurd Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	D ₄ (A, G, and C are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	4 scale degrees, just fourth
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Minor second interval between 1st and 2nd scale degree. In traditional Arabic playing, the interval is slightly wider than a semitone, but this distinction has been largely erased.
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (4)	Nahawand (4), Rast (4)
Other Common Modulations	‘Ajam (6), Bayati (8), Hijazkar (8), and Nikriz (4); Nahawand (1), Hijaz (1), and Saba Zamzama (1)
<i>Maqamat</i> in Kurd Family	Kurd, Hijazkar Kurd
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 5th of Nahawand on the octave of Bayati on the 3rd of Sikah (a rare, archaic usage) on the tonic of Hijaz (a modern usage)

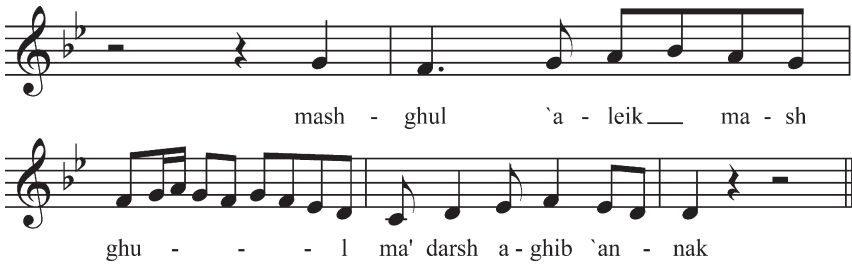


FIGURE 14.15 A sample phrase in Jins Kurd from the song “*mashghul ‘aleik.*”

Modern usage of Maqam Kurd mirrors the usage of Maqam Bayati and Maqam Hijaz (having a *ghammaz* on the 4th scale degree; prominently featuring modulations to the *ajnas* Nahawand and Rast). Older versions of Maqam Kurd descended from the octave and often prominently featured Bayati on the octave. Hijazkar-Kurd is an archaic *maqam* that started with Hijazkar at the octave but ended its *sayr* with Jins Kurd at the root.

Contemporary usage tends to emphasize chromatic (half-step) melodic motion, substituting Jins Hijaz (raised 3rd), Jins Nahawand (raised 2nd), and Jins Saba Zamzama (Kurd with a lowered 4th) on the same root, within melodies in Jins Kurd. Its use as a secondary *jins* is more or less limited to Maqam Nahawand (and rarely

within the archaic Maqam Ajam Ushayran), though it also substitutes for Bayati on the octave. The following songs prominently feature Kurd as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 5th of Maqam Nahawand/Rast: the middle of the second verse of Abdel Wahab's "*khayyi khayyi*"
- On the 5th of Maqam Nahawand: Umm Kulthum's "*alf leila we leila*"
- On the 5th of Maqam Nahawand: the opening of Warda's "*batwannis bik*"

Jins Saba

Jins Saba has one of the most distinctive and recognizable sounds particular to Arabic music, in part because of its very close sequence of intervals. And while most *ajnas* in this chapter are shared among neighboring *maqam* traditions, the Arabic Jins Saba intonation is strikingly different from the Turkish or Greek Saba.

The Saba extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.16 with its standard tonic on D₄.



FIGURE 14.16 Jins Saba on D.

Saba's mood is variously described as one of extreme sadness or mourning, and it is one of the few *ajnas* around which there seems to be a great deal of agreement about its mood and character. *Saba* (pronounced "subba") is an Arabic word that means "yearning." The name Saba was also given to a type of wind called *rih al-saba* in present-day Saudi Arabia, because it yearns for the holy Ka'bah in Mecca. The main characteristics of Jins Saba are listed in table 14.9.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Saba:

- Umm Kulthum's *dawr* "*huwwa sahib*" by Zakariyya Ahmad
- Sabah's *taqatiq* "*ya kawini ya 'ali*" and "*marhabtayn*"
- The *muwashshah* "*ahwa qamaran*" by Darwish al-Hariri
- The traditional Aleppan *qadd* "*skaba ya dumu' il-'ein*" (see figure 14.17)



FIGURE 14.17 A sample phrase in Jins Saba from the *qadd* "*skaba ya dumu' il-'ein*."

TABLE 14.9

Jins Saba Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	D ₄ (G and A are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	To note of melodic emphasis: 3 scale degrees, Pythagorean minor third; to primary modulation point*: 6 scale degrees; Pythagorean minor sixth
Playable on Western Instruments	No
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	The 2nd scale degree is a quartertone note that, like Rast, Bayati, and Sikah, must be learned by ear. The 4th scale degree is extremely low, creating an interval smaller than a half step between the 3rd and 4th scale degrees. This sequence of small intervals— $\frac{3}{4}$ step, $\frac{3}{4}$ step, small $\frac{1}{2}$ step—gives the <i>jins</i> a very intense feeling that most Arab listeners would qualify as deeply sad. In addition, there is a $1\frac{1}{2}$ -step interval between the 4th and 5th scale degrees, resulting in an overlapping Hijaz <i>jins</i> within Saba itself (with the difference that the interval between the 3rd and 4th scale degrees is smaller than a half step, unlike in typical versions of Jins Hijaz, where it is slightly larger than an equal-tempered half step).
Typical Modulations	‘Ajam (6), Nikriz (6), Hijaz (3) (emphasized melodically but not tonicized)
Other Common Modulations	Bayati (1), ‘Ajam (3), Nahawand (4)
<i>Maqamat</i> in Saba Family	Saba
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 5th of Rast and Nahawand on the 3rd of Sikah (in Maqam Bastanikar)

*Unlike in most other *ajnas*, the typical note of modulation in Jins Saba—the note that becomes a second tonic—is not the same as the main secondary note of melodic emphasis. Therefore, it is difficult to define one *ghammaz*; the argument could be made that it is either the 3rd or 6th. Complicating matters further is the fact that Saba is often interchangeable with Bayati and the other 4-note *ajnas* when acting as a secondary *jins*.

As a *maqam*, Saba has a very fixed sequence of *ajnas* and modulations, with no additional “branches” or modulation options. As a *jins*, it is also unusual in having another *jins* overlapping within its basic *jins* scale—Hijaz on the 3rd scale degree—but this Hijaz is not truly tonicized in Saba melodies (unlike in Saba Dalanshin; see chapter 16: Newly Classified *Ajnas*); it does not precisely match true Jins Hijaz intonation; and it is very melodically limited, not using most of the melodic content expected of a true Jins Hijaz. The only true modulation is to the 6th degree, where Jins ‘Ajam is tonicized; the 8th scale degree is also typically lowered from the octave, resulting in a version of Nikriz on 6, which sometimes reaches up to a full Hijazkar scale built on the 3rd scale degree of Saba.

When songs or improvisations wish to depart from the very strict Maqam Saba framework, they typically utilize the parallel with Maqam Bayati—modulating to Bayati 1, ‘Ajam 3, or Nahawand 4. Saba is frequently used as a secondary *jins*, however, in many of the same locations Bayati or Hijaz occur; a frequent trick is to lower the 4th scale degree of Jins Bayati, which then becomes Saba. The following songs prominently feature Jins Saba as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 5th of Maqam Suznak: second verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*”
- On the 3rd degree of Maqam Bastanikar: Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*zalamu*”

Jins Sikah

Sikah is unique among all the *ajnas* for tonicizing a quartertone note—what would be the 3rd scale degree of Jins Rast. This gives the *jins* a slightly unsettling or suspended feeling, especially to those unfamiliar with it, because the quartertone notes are notes of tension and instability whenever they occur in other *ajnas*.

The Sikah extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 14.18 with its standard tonic on E♭₄.



FIGURE 14.18 Jins Sikah on E♭.

Jins Sikah is very popular in the folk music of the Arab world (e.g., the “*abu-z-zuluf*” genre in Lebanon), and as part of Maqam Huzam it is similar in its intonation to the second mode in Byzantine music, used extensively in church liturgy. Like Bayati, Sikah is also widespread among *maqam* traditions outside the Arab world, in Turkey, Iran, Azerbaijan, and Central Asia—where it is referred to as Segah.

The word *Sikah* (pronounced “SEE-kah”) comes from Persian *sehghah*: *seh* (three) and *gah* (place/position). For this reason, it is alternatively spelled *Sigah* (and pronounced “see-gah,” depending on the Arabic region). Essentially, this refers to the 3rd note in the Arabic 24-tone scale above Rast, or E♭, and the *jins* shares the name of the note it tonicizes. The *Sikah* conceptual note is ubiquitous in Arabic music, as it also occurs in the *ajnas* Rast, Bayati, and Saba (with its own variable intonation in each).

The *Sikah* note is challenging even to experienced Arabic musicians because of the difficulty of getting the same exact intonation on different instruments, especially when combining traditional Arabic instruments such as the ‘*ud* and violin with Western ones that have been mechanically modified to play the Arabic intonation (see chapter 2: Arabized Instruments), such as the accordion and Arabic keyboard, or with Arabic instruments that are not continuously tunable, like the *qanun* and

TABLE 14.10

Jins Sikah Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	E♭ ₄ (B♭, and A♭ are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	3 scale degrees, an interval in between a major and minor third (regionally variable)
Playable on Western Instruments	Not even close
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	The tonic is a quartertone note. In some phrases, the leading tone can be raised from a ¾ step below the tonic, to an interval just slightly larger than a ¼ step below the tonic.
Typical Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (3)	Hijaz (3), Bayati (3), Saba (3), Nahawand (3)
Other Common Modulations	Rast (6) An emphasis/tonicization of its 5th scale degree, lowered to a just fifth above the tonic
<i>Maqamat</i> in Sikah Family	Huzam, Rahat al-Arwah (a transposition of Huzam), Sikah, ‘Iraq, Bastanikar, Awj ‘Iraq
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	Mostly used as a modulation tonicizing the 3rd scale degree of Rast, this modulation to Sikah can also occur where Rast is a secondary <i>jins</i> : e.g., in Maqam Hijaz, where Rast is on the 4th scale degree, Sikah can tonicize the 3rd scale degree above that, which is the 6th scale degree above Hijaz.

the *buzuq*. It would not be unusual for an Arabic ensemble with diverse instruments to “negotiate” the Sikah note in order to arrive at an acceptable consensus before a long-song or suite in a Sikah *maqam* family member. The main characteristics of Jins Sikah are listed in table 14.10.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Sikah:

- The *muwashshah* “*ya ghusna naqa*” (by Ahmad Abu Khalil al-Qabbani)
- Ziad Rahbani’s *tagtuqa* “*il-hali ta’bani ya layla*”
- Fairouz’s song “*sawa rbina*” (by the Rahbani Brothers)
- Umm Kulthum’s “*il-wardi gamil*” by Zakariyya Ahmad (see figure 14.19)



FIGURE 14.19 A sample phrase in Jins Sikah in E♭ from the song “*il-wardi gamil*.”

Sikah has a wide variety of modulations on its 3rd scale degree and many branch *maqamat* as a result. Traditional theoretical sources often listed Rast as one of the modulations on the 3rd scale degree, but they missed the fact that this was actually Jins Upper Rast leading up to tonicize the 6th scale degree with Rast. The scalar structure of *maqamat* in the Sikah family differs from most other *maqamat* in requiring three *ajnas* to reach an octave; for example, Maqam Huzam is made of Jins Sikah, Jins Hijaz on the 3rd degree, and Jins Rast on the 6th degree. The following songs prominently feature Sikah as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 3rd of Maqam Rast: the fourth verse of Umm Kulthum's "*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*," starting with "*ahliflak bi rabb il-beit*"
- On the raised 6th of Maqam Bayati (what would be the 3rd degree of a secondary Jins Rast modulation on the 4th degree of Maqam Bayati): Fairouz's "*ya rayt minun*" (by Philemon Wehbe) modulates to Jins Sikah in the second verse at the phrase "*shu bikrah hayati*"
- On the 6th of Maqam Hijaz: the Aleppan classic *qadd* "*qadduka al-mayyas*" includes a modulation to Sikah on 6 during the customary improvisations in the verse (which is on Rast 4)

LESS COMMON AJNAS

THE *AJNAS* COVERED in this chapter occur much less often than those in chapter 14, and in most cases they are not identified as *ajnas* in traditional theory, but as *maqamat*. The *maqamat* by the same name are not very common either and do not have multiple branches or a rich set of secondary modulations associated with them. Instead, when we survey the repertoire, we find that the *ajnas* listed here (except for Lami) occur more frequently as a secondary *jins* within another *maqam* context, rather than as a full *maqam*.

Chapter 14: The Most Common *Ajnas* illustrates the principle that any *jins* that is the root of a *maqam* can also act as a secondary *jins* within some other *maqam* (according to the conventions of that particular *maqam*). The *ajnas* in this chapter illustrate a related point: that a *jins* doesn't have to be used as the root of its own *maqam* in order to occur as a secondary *jins* modulation within other *maqamat*. Rather, any distinctive area of melodic activity that can be defined in terms of a particular interval sequence, particular idiomatic melodic phrasing, distinct mood, and specific modulation profile must be considered a *jins*.

Some of these are archaic *maqamat* that have mostly fallen out of use; Sazkar, Musta'ar, and to some extent Jiharkah fall into that category. Others are more modern constructions: Athar Kurd and Saba Zamzam are *ajnas* that can fit in the 12-tone Western scale system (even if their intervals are not equal-tempered when played on traditional Arab instruments) and were used for chromatic experimentation by

mid-20th-century composers, particularly in Egypt. Lami is similar to these two in terms of its use in Egypt, where it acts as a kind of modern chromatic variant in the Kurd family, despite its origins as an Iraqi folk melody. Nahawand Murassa‘ falls a little bit into both categories; while it is a chromatic variant of Nahawand, it is documented as a key modulation within Maqam Nahawand in the early 20th century, with melodic phrasing distinct from Nahawand. At the same time, it seems to have grown in popularity in Egypt in the mid-20th century, occurring frequently as a substitute for Nahawand where that *jins* occurs in a secondary modulation (which is quite common).

It must be added that while in several cases there are not a large number of songs in the repertoire that use these rarer *ajnas*, they tend to be used more commonly in the melodic vocabulary of traditional improvisations (instrumental and vocal). Some of that knowledge informs the descriptions given here, in addition to what is possible to document with recorded songs.

Jins Jiharkah

Jiharkah resembles ‘Ajam (or the Western major mode), with a slight difference: the major third scale degree is lowered, but not low enough to be the 3rd scale degree of Rast. The Rast 3rd is approximately $\frac{3}{4}$ of a tone above the 2nd scale degree, the ‘Ajam 3rd is a whole tone above the 2nd scale degree, and Jiharkah falls somewhere in the middle. This distinction may be lost on unfamiliar listeners (it is lost on many Arabs, as Jiharkah has fallen out of common usage) because it is on the order of an 8th of a tone. The leading tone under the tonic is a $\frac{3}{4}$ -step interval, equivalent to the leading tone of Rast.

In addition, a more careful listening reveals that the 4th scale degree is also slightly lowered. The particular melodic phrasing of Jiharkah (distinct from either ‘Ajam or Rast) heavily exploits the close interval between the 3rd and 4th scale degrees. That unique intervallic relationship gives this *jins* a sweet and intense quality, one favored by aficionados of *tarab*.

The Jiharkah extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 15.1 with its standard tonic on F. The arrow symbols attached to the accidentals signify the slight lowering of pitch for those notes.



FIGURE 15.1 Jins Jiharkah on F.

The name “Jiharkah” (alternatively spelled Jihargah) comes from the Persian words *chehar gah* (fourth position). Jins Jiharkah is named after the Jiharkah note in the historic Arabic scale, the 4th note above Rast (equivalent to F). The main characteristics of Jins Jiharkah are listed in table 15.1.

TABLE 15.1

Jins Jiharkah Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	F ₄ (C, G, and even B $\flat$ are also possible tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth
Playable on Western Instruments	No. However, Jiharkah's typical melodic phrasing (including a dwelling on the 3rd and 4th scale degrees) can be used to evoke the <i>jins</i> when playing it on a 24-tone ET instrument, so even though the intervals are those of 'Ajam/major, the melody suggests Jiharkah to familiar listeners.
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Slightly lowered 3rd scale degree from a major third lowered 4th scale degree (It is worth noting that the interval between the tonic and the 4th is smaller than a just fourth, resulting in a note slightly wider than a whole step between the 4th and 5th scale degrees.) The 7th scale degree under the tonic is a $\frac{3}{4}$ -step leading tone equivalent to that used under the Rast tonic—another illustration of the fact that the notes under the tonic of a <i>jins</i> are often crucial to its identity.
Typical Modulations	"Ajam Murassa" (1), Upper Rast (5/8),* Sikah Baladi (1)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 8th of Rast on the tonic of Sikah Baladi on the 3rd of Bayati (now more commonly a modulation to 'Ajam) There are occasional examples—usually in improvisations or improvised variations to song melodies—in which skilled performers will use Jiharkah in place of Rast on its tonic, such as on the 6th of Sikah or the 4th of Bayati.

*The notation (5/8) means that the basic scale fragment of Jins Upper Rast starts on the 5th scale degree of the *maqam*, but its actual tonic occurs on the 8th scale degree of the *maqam*. This notation is also used with Jins Upper 'Ajam (5/8), whose tonic is at the top of its basic scale fragment as well, and with Jins Saba Dalanshin (6/8), whose tonic is in the middle of its basic scale fragment (see chapter 16 for the descriptions of these three *ajnas*).

Because of the challenge in performing its correct intonation on contemporary equal-tempered Arabic instruments, Jins Jiharkah and its *maqam* are relatively less known and used today than, for example, Jins 'Ajam. As contemporary Arabic music arrangements rely increasingly on 24-tone ET instruments such as the

Arabic accordion and keyboard, the number of new compositions in Jiharkah has greatly declined as it gradually became a niche *jins* that is only heard and appreciated by more traditional listeners. This is not the case for Jins ‘Ajam, for example, which is extremely popular on contemporary ET instruments since it is simply (yet imprecisely) performed as a Western major scale.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Jiharkah:

- The *muwashshahat* “*kallili ya subbu*” by Muhammad ‘Uthman and “*anta sultanu al-milah*” by Majdi al-‘Aqili
- The Aleppan *qadd* “*wahyat ‘einayya*” (traditional)
- The *taqtuqa* “*‘ala rubi ana il-gani*” by Saleh Abdel Hayy
- The *taqtuqa* “*fou’ ghusnik ya lamuna*” by Farid al-Atrash
- “*‘ar-rozana*” (traditional folk song from Syria/Lebanon/Palestine); see figure 15.2



FIGURE 15.2 A sample phrase in Jins Jiharkah from the traditional folk song “‘ar-rozana.”

Jiharkah is quite limited as a *maqam*; of the songs that use it, several do not modulate at all. The *muwashshah* “*kallili ya subbu*” modulates to the rare *jins* Ajam Murassa‘ on the same tonic (though that *jins* emphasizes the 5th scale degree melodically). The modulation from Jiharkah to Jins Sikah Baladi exploits the similarly lowered 3rd and 4th in that *jins*, modifying the 2nd scale degree only. Jiharkah is more common (though still rare) as a modulation from other *ajnas* and *maqamat*. The most common of these is on the octave of Maqam Rast. The following songs prominently feature Jiharkah as a secondary *jins*:

- On the octave of Maqam Rast: the *qadd* “*ya mal ish-sham*” by Ahmad Abu Khalil al-Qabbani at the phrase “*tal il-matal, tal wu tawwal*”
- On the 4th of Maqam Kurd: Umm Kulthum’s “*‘awwidti ‘ini*” (by Riyad al-Sunbati) in the 3rd verse at the phrase “*w-asrah wi fikri ma‘ak*”

Jins Sazkar

Sazkar (also spelled Saz Kar) is an archaic variant of Rast, with a raised 2nd scale degree. It is known as a *maqam* in traditional references, a variant of Maqam Rast whose melodic *sayr* starts at the octave and descends. The famous *muwashshahat* “*sihtu wajdan*” and “*ya shadi al-alhan*” (both composed by Sayed Darwish), which are now thought of as being part of the Maqam Rast repertoire, were originally considered¹ to be in Maqam Sazkar, and the versions notated in the *muwashshah* compilation Min Kunuzina include the raised 2nd degrees in their melodies, although that usually doesn’t appear anymore in contemporary performance. As such, Sazkar more or less disappeared from use, at least in song compositions, after the mid-20th century.

The Sazkar extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 15.3 with its standard tonic on C.



FIGURE 15.3 Jins Sazkar on C.

One reference² describing Maqam Sazkar mentions that the raised 2nd degree (compared to Rast) is not constant; instead it is used as an occasional color or accidental, and the rest of the time the 2nd degree matches that of Rast (this can be seen in the versions of “*sihtu wajdan*” and “*ya shadi al-alhan*” notated in Min Kunuzina). However, for clarity we refer to *Jins* Sazkar (as opposed to *Maqam* Sazkar) as the variant of Jins Rast that occurs when the 2nd degree is raised, because this *jins* can also occur as a variant of Rast in other contexts, such as when Rast is a secondary *jins* in Maqam Hijaz or Maqam Bayati.

Sazkar is a combination of two Persian words. The word *saz* means instrument or apparatus, and the word *kar* means work. The main characteristics of Jins Sazkar are listed in table 15.2.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Sazkar:

- Archaic versions of the *muwashshahat* “*sihtu wajdan*” and “*ya shadi al-alhan*” by Sayed Darwish.
- The song “*ya dala’ dalla’*” by Lebanese diva Sabah (see figure 15.4). This is a rare modern piece (1960s) using Sazkar, but note the alternation between the normal and raised 2nd scale degrees that is characteristic of Maqam Sazkar as a variant of Rast.

¹ al-Hilu (1965); al-Darwish (1955).

² Salah al-Din (1950a).

TABLE 15.2

Jins Sazkar Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C4 (F, G, and D are also possible tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth
Playable on Western Instruments	No
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Its 3rd scale degree is the characteristic quartertone 3rd scale degree of Rast, but the 2nd scale degree is raised, similar to the leading tone of Sikah.
Typical Modulations	Hijaz (5), Nahawand (5), Upper Rast (5/8)
Other Common Modulations	Sikah (3)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the tonic of Rast on the 4th of Hijaz substituting for Rast anywhere it occurs as a secondary <i>jins</i> (possible, but archaic and quite rare)



FIGURE 15.4 A sample phrase in Jins Sazkar from Sabah's song "ya dala' dalla"

Sazkar is strongly related to the Sikah *jins* that starts on the 3rd scale degree of Rast, in that the raised 2nd scale degree hints at a tonicization of the 3rd scale degree (in fact, Sazkar's 2nd degree is tuned similarly to Sikah's leading tone, which is slightly lower than a true D $\sharp$). However, Sazkar would be the *jins* that occurs when Sikah is *not* tonicized. The two *ajnas* (Sazkar and Sikah) are intimately linked with Rast. If we start Sazkar on the Rast tonic, and Sikah on the Rast 3rd degree, the three *ajnas* (shown side by side in table 15.3) match in their intonation (except for the Rast/Sazkar 2nd degree) and can easily modulate from one to the other.

TABLE 15.3

Comparison of the Rast, Sazkar, and Sikah <i>Jins</i> scales, with the Tonic of Each Shaded					
<i>Jins</i>					
Rast	C	D	E♭	F	G
Sazkar*	C	~D#	E♭	F	G
Sikah		~D#	E♭	F	G

*The (~) sign indicates a note that changes its pitch depending on the phrasing.

Outside of this Rast-Sazkar-Sikah complex, Sazkar’s modulations and *maqam* pathways are more or less identical to those of Rast, using Hijaz, Nahawand, and Upper Rast on the 5th scale degree (the *ghammaz*). Sazkar can also theoretically substitute anywhere Rast occurs as a secondary *jins*, as a kind of accidental/orna-ment (though in contemporary practice this is quite rare).

The *qasida* “*mudnaka jafahu marqaduhu*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab, in Maqam Hijaz, features a prominent Sazkar modulation on the 4th scale degree above Hijaz in the instrumental melody preceding the middle section of the song.

Jins Musta’ar

Jins Musta’ar (also transliterated as Mustaar) is the root of the archaic Maqam Musta’ar, a member of the Sikah family that tonicizes Nahawand on the 3rd scale degree (as opposed to the more common Hijaz or Bayati), using a raised 2nd scale degree as a leading tone to the Nahawand tonic. In contemporary practice, it functions mostly as a secondary Jins, either as a variation of Jins Sikah or on the 3rd scale degree of Rast. In either case, both the raised 2nd and the Nahawand *jins* fragment starting on the 3rd scale degree are crucial for the identity of Musta’ar.

The Musta’ar extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 15.5 with its standard tonic on E♭.



FIGURE 15.5 Jins Musta’ar on E♭.

The interval between the tonic (the ¾-step note shared with Jins Sikah, the 3rd scale degree above Rast) and the raised 2nd scale degree results in a very unusual interval, approximately 1¼ steps, which is unique in this repertoire and creates a feeling of resolution on both the tonic and the *ghammaz*.

The word *musta’ar* means “borrowed” in Arabic. Jins Musta’ar is sometimes called Shi’ar. The anecdotal explanation for this alternative name is that once the word *musta’ar*

TABLE 15.4

Jins Musta'ar Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	E $\flat$ ₄ (B $\flat$ is another possible tonic)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	3 scale degrees, an interval in between a major and minor third.
Playable on Western Instruments	No
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Tonic is a quartertone note like Sikah. 2nd scale degree is raised as a leading tone to the 3rd scale degree, resulting in a unique 1 $\frac{1}{4}$ -step interval between the 1st and 2nd scale degrees.
Typical Modulations	Nahawand (3)
Other Common Modulations	Sikah (1), Upper Rast (3/6), Rast (6th scale degree in the octave below the tonic); an emphasis/tonicization of its 5th scale degree, lowered to a just fifth above the tonic
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the tonic of Sikah on the 3rd of Rast

in Arabic was miscopied, and by changing a few dots it was spelled as the word *shi'ar*.³ Whether that story is accurate or not, the word *Shi'ar* is documented as a possible alternative name for *Musta'ar*.⁴ The main characteristics of *Jins Musta'ar* are listed in table 15.4.

There are a few recorded examples of *Jins Musta'ar*:

- Fathiyya Ahmad's song "*haramuha minni w haramuni*" is in Maqam *Musta'ar* and showcases *Jins Musta'ar* very clearly.
- Umm Kulthum's song "*habbeit wala banshi 'alayya*" is anchored in *Jins Sikah* but makes full use of *Jins Musta'ar* as a modulation.
- Umm Kulthum's song "*raqq il-habib*" at the phrase "*fidilt afakkar fi ma'adi, w-ahsib li orbo alfi hisab*" (notated in figure 15.6) and her song "*il-amal*" at the phrase "*w-ag'alak fiha nadimi*" both modulate to *Jins Musta'ar*.
- *Jins Musta'ar* is also used briefly within Maqam *Rast* in Abdel Wahab's *mawwal* "*kull illi habb itnasaf*."



FIGURE 15.6 A sample phrase in *Jins Musta'ar* from the song "*raqq il-habib*."

³ Salah al-Din (1950a).

⁴ al-Sabbagh (1954).

TABLE 15.5

Comparison of the *Ajnas* Sikah, Mukhalif Sharqi, and Musta'ar on the Same Tonic

<i>Jins</i>	1st	2nd	3rd
Sikah	E♭	F	G
Mukhalif Sharqi	E♭	F	G♭
Musta'ar	E♭	F#	G

Jins Musta'ar is nearly always succeeded by Jins Nahawand on its 3rd scale degree, and its 2nd scale degree functions as a leading tone to that Nahawand. In contrast, for Jins Sikah, the *ajnas* Bayati and Hijaz are more common successors on its 3rd scale degree.

Jins Musta'ar shares a lot with Jins Sikah, including the same tonic (the 1st degree) and *ghammaz* (the 3rd degree). These *ajnas* as well as Jins Mukhalif Sharqi (discussed in chapter 16: Newly Classified *Ajnas*) are listed side by side in table 15.5. While they differ only in the 2nd scale degree, modulating from Sikah to Musta'ar is a very straightforward and common modulation. It usually is brief enough to pass as an accidental, but its character and melodic development are consistent enough to qualify as a change of *jins* in its own right.

Musta'ar is also a popular modulation starting on the 3rd scale degree of Maqam Rast or descending from Jins Nahawand on the 5th scale degree of Rast.

It should be added that Musta'ar shares the same intervallic sequence as the Tunisian Maqam Rast al-Dhayl, but in that *maqam*, the tonic is on the equivalent Rast tonic. In some instances, where Musta'ar occurs on the 3rd scale degree within an overall Rast context, the Rast tonic still feels more strongly tonicized than the 3rd, and therefore the melody could be considered in Rast al-Dhayl rather than Musta'ar (this could be argued of the passage in “*raqq il-habib*” shown in figure 15.6).

Jins Nahawand Murassa'

Nahawand Murassa' (also transliterated as Murassaa) is a variant of Nahawand, with a lowered 5th scale degree. This gives the *jins* the sound of a blues scale to Western listeners, and the mood is an intensification of the dark sound of Nahawand. Jins Nahawand Murassa' typically occurs as a modulation from the regular Jins Nahawand. Briefly lowering Nahawand's 5th degree can be treated as a modulation hint or an accidental. Alternatively, the melody can stay in Nahawand Murassa' and be further developed as a *jins* with its own unique melodic pathways.

The Nahawand *Murassa'* extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 15.7 with its standard tonic on C.



FIGURE 15.7 Jins Nahawand *Murassa'* on C.

The word *murassa'* means “inlaid” or “decorated” in Arabic, and this *jins* acquired that adjective because it is a modified version of Jins Nahawand. The main characteristics of Jins Nahawand *Murassa'* are listed in table 15.6.

The following songs prominently feature Nahawand *Murassa'*:

- Horeyya Hassan’s “*min hubbi fik ya gari*” in the second verse
- Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*khusara*” by Baligh Hamdi (see figure 15.8)

TABLE 15.6

Jins Nahawand <i>Murassa'</i> Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C4 (D, G, and F are also possible tonics—basically anywhere that Nahawand might occur)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	It is difficult to define the <i>ghammaz</i> precisely. The 4th scale degree is the strongest note of melodic emphasis, with motion to the lowered 5th to build tension. However, while a modulation to Hijaz on the 4th is possible, it is actually more likely to experience modulations on the 5th scale degree—not the lowered 5th of the <i>jins</i> itself, but the normal 5th of Jins Nahawand.
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	minor third, as with Nahawand flattened 5th scale degree
Typical Modulations	Hijaz (4)
Other Common Modulations	Hijaz (5), Bayati/Saba (5)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 4th of Bayati, Hijaz, or Kurd (usually as an ornament to Jins Nahawand in those positions)



FIGURE 15.8 A sample phrase in Jins Nahawand Murassa' from the song "khusara."

As a variant of Nahawand, Jins Nahawand Murassa' follows mostly the typical modulation pathways of Nahawand with modulations on its 5th scale degree. Yet melodically, its *ghammaz*, or note of melodic emphasis, is its 4th scale degree. As a secondary *jins*, Nahawand Murassa' can also occur anywhere that Nahawand might.

Jins Athar Kurd

Athar Kurd is an extraordinarily rare *jins* in the Arab repertoire, which experienced a brief period of experimentation in the mid-20th century in Egypt. It is not found at all in the traditional (Aleppan/Egyptian) *muwashshah* repertoire; as a result, it has a very modern, exotic feel in the context of traditional Arabic music. Listeners may find that it resembles an Indian Raga more than an Arabic Maqam, as it shares the interval sequence with Rag Todi in Indian classical music.⁵

The Athar Kurd extended *jins* scale is shown in figure 15.9 with its standard tonic on C.



FIGURE 15.9 Jins Athar Kurd on C.

Athar Kurd is a 5-note *jins* that can be described as merging Jins Nikriz (alternatively called Nawa Athar) with Jins Kurd. As such, it is a complex, hybrid *jins*, and its name is the result of combining the names "Nawa Athar" and "Kurd." The word *athar* means trace or effect, in both Persian and Arabic, while the word *kurd* here references Maqam Kurd itself. The main characteristics of Jins Athar Kurd are listed in table 15.7.

⁵ Gaurav Shah, personal communication with the author, 2017.

TABLE 15.7

Jins Athar Kurd Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C4 (F, G, D, and A are also possible tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Flat 2nd, flat 3rd, raised 4th—resulting in an augmented second (1½ step) interval between the 3rd and 4th scale degrees, like Jins Nikriz—but without any overlapping Hijaz <i>jins</i> . This is a unique interval sequence within the Arabic scale system.
Potential Modulations	Hijaz/Hijazkar (5), Kurd (5), Saba Zamzam (5)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the tonic of Nahawand, Nikriz, Kurd, or Saba Zamzam

Athar Kurd is extraordinarily rare as a full *maqam*. (The authors are only aware of “*ya fagri nurak halli w ban*” as a complete composition using Maqam Athar Kurd.) We have found a few isolated examples of its usage as a modulation within another *maqam* context. Athar Kurd can occur as a modulation from Jins Kurd by raising its 4th scale degree by a semitone, or alternatively from Jins Nikriz by lowering its 2nd scale degree by a semitone. As a result, there is ambiguity about whether Athar Kurd fits within the 5-note *jins* framework (as a modulation from Nikriz or Nahawand) or within the 4-note *jins* framework (as a modulation from Kurd or Saba Zamzam).

Two songs sung by Leila Mourad illustrate the different treatments of this *jins*: “*raydak*,” in Maqam Kurd, has a verse in Athar Kurd (obtained by raising the 4th scale degree), while “*il-hana wil-widd*,” in Maqam Nahawand (see figure 15.10), has its 3rd verse in Athar Kurd (obtained by lowering the 2nd scale degree and raising the 4th). Umm Kulthum’s song “*il-hubbi kida*” uses Jins Athar Kurd in the introduction to the second verse, combined with Jins Saba Zamzam.



FIGURE 15.10 A sample phrase in Jins Athar Kurd from the song “*il-hana wil-widd*,” sung by Leila Mourad.

Jins Saba Zamzam

Saba Zamzam is a version of Saba with a flat 2nd scale degree, rather than a $\frac{3}{4}$ step. As a result, Saba Zamzam has no quartertones and as such is able to commonly modulate to Kurd and Athar Kurd. Like Athar Kurd, Saba Zamzam did not exist in the earlier *tarab* repertoire and has a modern, chromatic feel. At the same time, it also shares some of the melodic pathways of regular Jins Saba. The word *Zamzam* in Arabic is the name of a city in historic Saudi Arabia.

The Saba Zamzam extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 15.11 with its tonic on D. Its main characteristics are listed in table 15.8.



FIGURE 15.11 Jins Saba Zamzam on D.

An example of a song that prominently features Jins Saba Zamzam is Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*nibtidi minein il-hikaya*,” just before and during the unmetered section.

Although Jins Saba Zamzam resembles Jins Saba in terms of its complex makeup, it is unusual to modulate from Saba to its semitonal version Saba Zamzam. Instead, Jins Saba Zamzam is a lot closer in its mood to Jins Kurd and can be used as a modulation from Kurd. This modulation became quite typical in the latter half of the

TABLE 15.8

Jins Saba Zamzam Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	D4 (C and G are also possible tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	As with Jins Saba, the 3rd scale degree is a strong note of melodic emphasis, while the 6th is a note of tonicization, so the <i>ghammaz</i> is difficult to pin down. Also, in parallel with Saba, it is common for Saba Zamzam to move to Kurd by raising its 4th scale degree and to utilize the melodic phrasing of Kurd, placing this <i>jins</i> in the 4-note <i>jins</i> group.
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Flat 2nd, flat 4th
Typical Modulations	Kurd (1), Athar Kurd (1), Hijaz (3), ‘Ajam (6)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the tonic of Kurd or Athar Kurd on the 5th of Nahawand (in place of Kurd)

20th century and is used, for example, in the introduction of Umm Kulthum's "*amal hayati*" in Maqam Kurd. The same popular modulation is used in the introduction of Abdel Halim Hafez's "*sawwah*," also anchored in Maqam Kurd, and in the second verse of Abdel Halim Hafez's "*zalamu*" (see figure 15.12). Saba Zamzam is also frequently paired with Athar Kurd in brief concluding phrases, to highlight the descent to the tonic.



FIGURE 15.12 A sample phrase in Jins Saba Zamzam from the second verse of "*zalamu*."

The following songs prominently feature Saba Zamzam as a secondary *jins*:

- "*ya bint is-sultan*" by Ahmad Adaweya, from Jins Kurd on the same tonic
- The introduction of "*'ala hisbi widad albi*" by Abdel Halim Hafez, from Jins Bayati on the same tonic
- On the 3rd of Maqam Bastanikar: Abdel Halim Hafez's "*zalamu*," composed by Muhammad Abdel Wahab (see figure 15.12)

Jins Lami

Lami is an Iraqi Maqam originally borrowed from that repertoire by the Egyptian composer Muhammad Abdel Wahab, who encountered Iraqi music at the 1932 Cairo Arabic Music Congress, as well as on his visits to Baghdad. A few other 20th-century composers in the *sharqi* tradition followed Abdel Wahab's lead, but that *maqam* nevertheless remains extremely rare outside of Iraq.

The Lami extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 15.13 with its standard tonic on D.



FIGURE 15.13 Jins Lami on D.

When borrowed into the *sharqi* tradition, Jins Lami is essentially identical to Jins Kurd with a lowered 5th scale degree (although the Iraqi intonation is slightly different). The Lami melody is traditionally understood as a *maqam*, rather than a *jins*, but since, like the other *ajnas* in this chapter, it is limited to a few notes rather than a whole scale, it can justifiably be named a *jins*.

The word *lami* means related to Lam, an old Arab Bedouin tribe in Iraq, as this *jins*'s melodies were historically used by camel herders from that tribe. Iraqi composer

TABLE 15.9

Jins Lami Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	D ₄
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	4 scale degrees, just fourth
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Lowered 5th scale degree (semitone above the <i>ghammaz</i>); flat 2nd above the tonic (like Jins Kurd)
Possible Modulations	Kurd (4), Kurd (1)

and Iraqi Maqam reciter Muhammad al-Qubbanji is credited with taking Lami folk melodies and developing them as a full *maqam* in the Iraqi repertoire.⁶ The main characteristics of Jins Lami are listed in table 15.9.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Lami:

- Muhammad Abdel Wahab's "*albi bi ulli kalam*"
- Wadih al-Safi's "*in-najmat saru yis'alu*"
- Sabri al-Mudallal's "*ahmad ya habibi*"
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab's "*il-burtu'al*," probably the most famous melody in Lami outside the Iraqi repertoire (see figure 15.14)

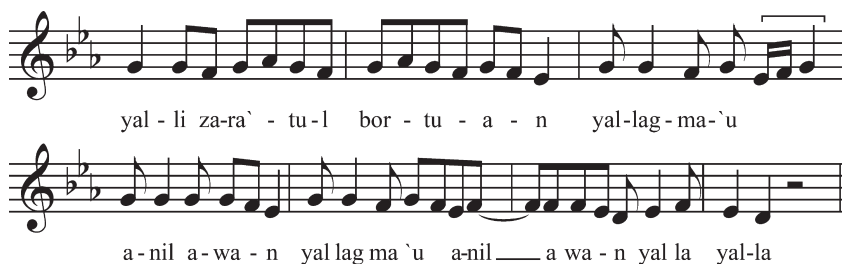


FIGURE 15.14 A sample phrase in Jins Lami from the song "*il-burtu'al*."

Jins Lami can be extended into Maqam Lami beyond the 5th degree by starting another Jins Kurd on its 4th degree. It is not really accurate to describe a common modulation pathway beyond these two *ajnas*, since modern composers have taken their own liberties when composing songs rooted in this *jins*. The authors have not (yet) encountered this *jins* occurring as a secondary *jins* modulating from other *ajnas* (other than as an ornamental lowering of the 5th scale degree of Jins Kurd in some improvisations).

⁶ al-Mahdi (1993a, p. 42).

NEWLY CLASSIFIED *AJNAS*

THE *AJNAS* COVERED in this chapter have been newly identified and classified in this book. While this is an innovation in *maqam* theory, it is important to note this does not reflect an innovation in *practice*, but rather the fact that many of the central *ajnas* within the traditional melodic practice of *maqam* were either misidentified or not identified at all by traditional theory.

In the majority of cases identified here, the *jins* in question was previously identified with the name of one of the primary nine *ajnas*: Upper Rast as Rast, Upper ‘Ajam as ‘Ajam, Saba Dalanshin as Saba, Hijazkar as Hijaz or Nikriz linked to another Hijaz, and Hijaz Murassa’ and ‘Ajam Murassa’ as mere “accidentals” to Hijaz and ‘Ajam. *Jins Sikah Baladi* was identified as a *maqam* by the same name, while *Mukhalif Sharqi* and *Semitonal Sikah* were never formally classified.

In all cases, the lack of identification reflects the central bias of traditional theory, which, following ancient Greek music theory, identified a *jins* solely by a tetrachord, focusing on the scale and ignoring melodic activity and vocabulary altogether.

Tonicization

The first five *ajnas* listed in this chapter (Upper Rast, Upper ‘Ajam, Saba Dalanshin, Hijazkar, and *Sikah Baladi*) were never identified as such, and their lack of identification

reflects the failure of traditional theory to deal with the phenomenon of tonicization: the action of making a particular note feel like a tonic (a note of melodic resolution) through specific melodic motions and the phenomenon of changing that tonic.

Understanding (and being able to hear) tonicization is crucial to understanding these five *ajnas*, because it is first and foremost through tonicization that their structure differs from the traditionally defined *ajnas* sharing the same or a similar name. Rather than having their tonic as the 1st note of the *jins*'s basic scale fragment, the tonic is either at the top (Upper Rast and Upper 'Ajam) or somewhere in the middle (Saba Dalanshin, Hijazkar, and Sikah Baladi). Given that, their melody doesn't happen mostly above the tonic as do the *ajnas* in the previous two chapters. In the case of the three *ajnas* Upper Rast, Upper 'Ajam, and Saba Dalanshin, the leading tone remains as the note immediately below the tonic, which places it *within* the basic scale fragment rather than underneath it (in the extended scale).

Ironically, two of the *ajnas* with a nontraditional structure (Upper Rast and Hijazkar) are among the most common to occur in the Arabic repertoire, as frequently as the nine *ajnas* listed in chapter 14: Most Common *Ajnas*, arguably *more* frequently than the *ajnas* Saba and Nikriz, and definitely much more frequently than Jins Kurd in the traditional repertoire (Kurd moved to the center of the *maqam* system only toward the end of the 20th century).

Jins Versus Accidental Modification

The last four *ajnas* described in this chapter (Mukhalif Sharqi, Hijaz Murassa', 'Ajam Murassa', and Semitonal Sikah) have a more traditional structure (the tonic is the 1st note, melodies are mostly above the tonic, and 3 out of 4 have a discernible *ghammaz*) but are so rare as to go mostly unnoticed.¹ They do not occur as the root of any *maqam* (except for a few novelty compositions in "Sikah al-Buyut" extending Semitonal Sikah into a full *maqam* analogous to Sikah/Huzam without any quartertones) and have mostly been identified as "accidentals" to more familiar *ajnas*, when they are noticed at all.

This begs the question: Why classify them as *ajnas* at all? Why not simply create a rule saying that certain *ajnas* can have accidental modifications to them in specific places? For example, Jins Hijaz can have its 5th scale degree lowered, Jins 'Ajam can have its 4th scale degree raised, and Jins Sikah can have its 3rd scale degree lowered.

That approach ignores one of the crucial features of Arabic music that makes it distinct from Western music (in which accidentals are more liberally applied): every intervallic

¹ As was the case in chapter 15, documenting some of the rarer *ajnas* in this chapter was challenging using composed songs alone, and as such the authors had to rely on the vocabulary used in improvisations.

change, no matter how subtle, results in an identifiably different character/mood, a key element of *tarab*, in which the shift of just one note can drive listeners to ecstasy.

The “accidental” approach to classification would also have to contend with the following inconsistency: Why not just identify Saba as an “accidental” to Bayati (lowering the 4th), Nikriz as an “accidental” to Nahawand (raising the 4th), Athar Kurd as an “accidental” to Nikriz (lowering the 2nd), and Saba Zamzam as an “accidental” to Kurd (lowering the 4th)? The fact is that these different intervallic structures also carry with them different melodic phrasing, making them truly distinct *ajnas* in their own right. The same is true of the four *ajnas* newly classified here. We suspect it is a result of their extreme rarity that this distinction was not made, but in the few instances where they do occur, they have all the characteristics of a *jins*: a distinct interval sequence, a distinct set of melodic phrases, and a distinct mood.

Jins Upper Rast

Jins Upper Rast² is the *jins* that starts on the 5th scale degree of Maqam Rast. This *jins* has been misclassified as Jins Rast in traditional theory because its intervals from the first to the 4th note are identical to Jins Rast (and also because in traditional theory Jins Rast itself is classified as a 4-note *jins*/tetrachord). However, a closer examination of melodies in Maqam Rast reveals fundamental differences between the two *ajnas*. While Jins Rast clearly tonicizes its 1st degree, and its 5th degree functions as its *ghammaz* (modulation point), Jins Upper Rast has a very strong tonicization of its 4th degree (the octave of Maqam Rast) as the note of melodic resolution, leading up to it rather than down to its 1st scale degree. Moreover, we would have to say that its *ghammaz* (its most frequent modulation point) is on its 1st degree rather than its 4th degree. Having the *ghammaz* on the 1st scale degree and the tonic on the last (basic) scale degree is a rare anomaly that is shared only with Jins Upper ‘Ajam.

As a result of this functional difference, the two differ in the size of their basic scale span, as we define it: Jins Upper Rast is 4 notes long while Jins Rast is 5 notes long.

The Upper Rast extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 16.1 with its standard tonic on C₅.



FIGURE 16.1 Jins Upper Rast with its tonic on C.

The fact that the note of melodic resolution in Jins Upper Rast is on the 4th degree, while for the majority of *ajnas* (e.g., Nahawand) it occurs on the 1st degree, goes a long

² Jins Upper Rast was originally labeled “Secondary Rast” by Abu Shumays (2013).

way to explain why in most traditional references the two Rast Maqam scale variants have a melodic direction ascribed to them: [Rast + Upper Rast] is associated with ascending melodies, while [Rast + Nahawand] is associated with descending melodies, consistent with the direction in which the tonic is attained in each version of the scale.

Another crucial difference between Jins Rast and Jins Upper Rast is in their leading tones. When Jins Rast is active, its leading tone is a $\frac{3}{4}$ -tone interval below the tonic. This is not the case for Upper Rast, as when it is active in the Maqam Rast scale, the note below its 1st scale degree does not get raised to a $\frac{3}{4}$ tone underneath it. In fact the true leading tone is its 3rd degree, which is the note leading up to its tonic.

The only clear example of a true Jins Rast tonicization on the 5th of Maqam Rast occurs in Umm Kulthum’s long-song “*fakkaruni*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab. This modulation uses the intervals expected underneath a Jins Rast tonic, a modification of the notes of the original Maqam Rast scale that doesn’t occur with Jins Upper Rast—which is another demonstration that the *jins* introduced in this book as Upper Rast is distinct from Jins Rast itself.³

Despite all these differences, the mood and character of Upper Rast is more or less identical to that of Jins Rast; this *jins* is an inseparable part of the identity of Maqam Rast. Its main characteristics are listed in table 16.1.

TABLE 16.1

Jins Upper Rast Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C ₅ (G, F, and D are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	minus-4 scale degrees, a just fourth down from the tonic
Playable on Western Instruments	No
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	$\frac{3}{4}$ -step interval leading up to the tonic
Typical Modulations	leading up to Jins Rast, with which it shares a tonic (either Jins Rast on the octave or from a version of Jins Upper Rast underneath the root tonic up to the root Jins Rast) to Jins Nahawand on 5th of Rast; to Hijaz on the 5th of Rast; to Saba Dalanshin (6/8) on the same tonic
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i> Other Than in <i>Maqam</i> Rast	on the 5th of Jiharkah (or the 4th underneath) on the 3rd of Sikah, leading up to Jins Rast on 6

³ See Abu Shumays (2013) for a full discussion and analysis of “*fakkaruni*” and how it illustrates this distinction. That article introduced the concept of “Upper Rast,” referring to it as “Secondary Rast” (we’ve since decided the name “Upper Rast” is better). See also maqamlessons.com for the analysis with audio clips.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Upper Rast:

- The song “*hayrana leh*” by Leila Mourad
- Umm Kulthum’s “*aruh li min*,” the ending of every verse and opening melodies of the fourth verse
- The Syrian traditional *qadd* “*ya mal ish-sham*”
- The *muwashshahat* “*sihtu wajdan*” and “*ya shadi al-alhan*” by Sayed Darwish (a sample melody from the latter *muwashshah* is notated in figure 16.2)



FIGURE 16.2 A sample phrase in Jins Upper Rast from the *muwashshah* “*ya shadi al-alhan*.”

Jins Upper Rast is actually a very common *jins*, despite being unrecognized previously. It occurs in the vast majority of songs in Maqam Rast and often when Jins Rast itself occurs as a secondary *jins*, whenever the melody dips beneath its tonic. Although it is never the root of its own *maqam* distinct from Rast, it is used very prominently to open Maqam Rast, when Rast is using a descending *sayr* (starting the melody at the octave and descending to the root tonic), something that was more typical of the early-20th-century version of Rast (also known as Maqam Rast Kirdan or simply Maqam Kirdan).

In addition to its usage in Maqam Rast, Jins Upper Rast has two other prominent uses: as the upper *jins* of Maqam Jiharkah (usually occurring underneath the tonic rather than above the root *jins*) and as the second *jins* of Maqam Sikah starting on the *ghammaz* (3rd scale degree), connecting Jins Sikah to the Jins Rast that tonicizes the 6th degree. The following songs prominently feature Upper Rast as a secondary *jins* on the 3rd of Maqam Sikah:

- Umm Kulthum’s “*il-wardi gamil*,” in the last verse
- The *muwashshah* “*jadaka al-ghaythu*,” in the *khana* melody

Jins Upper ‘Ajam

Jins Upper ‘Ajam is the analogous *jins* to Upper Rast that occurs in Maqam ‘Ajam; it starts on the 5th scale degree of ‘Ajam, and its melodies move up to and tonicize

the octave *jins* (or if Upper ‘Ajam occurs underneath the tonic, the melodies move between the tonic and the 4th below, maintaining the feeling of the ‘Ajam tonic).⁴

The Upper ‘Ajam extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 16.3 with its standard tonic on C₅.



FIGURE 16.3 Jins Upper ‘Ajam with its tonic on C.

Like Upper Rast, Jins Upper ‘Ajam was always classified as Jins ‘Ajam in traditional music theory because of the similarity between their basic scales. However, enough differences exist between them to warrant its classification as a separate *jins*. Besides tonicizing its uppermost note, its *ghammaz* (most frequent modulation point) is functionally its 1st scale degree, and its leading tone is the note below the tonic (therefore, its 3rd degree).

As is the case with Maqam Rast, melodies in Maqam ‘Ajam do not tonicize a new ‘Ajam on the 5th (in contrast to what is one of the most standard modulations in Western music). Tonicizing ‘Ajam on the 5th would require raising the 4th scale degree (by a half step) as a leading tone to the 5th, something that doesn’t occur.

The mood of this *jins* is identical to that of Jins ‘Ajam—other than the fact that the melodic energy and direction points upward to the tonic, rather than resolving down. The main characteristics of Jins Upper ‘Ajam are listed in table 16.2.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Upper ‘Ajam:

- “*tal’a min beit abuha*” (Iraqi Traditional)
- Sheikh Imam’s “*sharrafti ya Nixon baba*”
- The 3rd verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*lissa fakir*,” in Maqam Shawq Afza (see figure 16.4)

Jins Upper ‘Ajam occurs underneath the tonic (or leading up to the octave tonic) in Maqam ‘Ajam, but also anywhere Jins ‘Ajam itself occurs as a secondary *jins*. One particularly common occurrence is underneath the ‘Ajam tonic that occurs on the 6th scale degree in Maqam Bayati—hence starting on the 3rd scale degree and leading up (see figure 16.5).

⁴ Marcus, personal communication with the author, 2017, feels that D’Erlanger anticipates this concept in *La Musique Arabe*, volume 5 (pp. 78–79), with his description of a melodic phrase he calls a “suspended tetrachord” and labels “*‘ajam mu’allaq*.” Whether he was truly referring to the same phenomenon, or this is more analogous to the “extended *jins* scale” under Jins ‘Ajam, is unclear, as we have not encountered any other instance in oral tradition or in any English- or Arabic-language literature corroborating D’Erlanger on this point or referring to a distinct *jins* such as we define here.

TABLE 16.2

Jins Upper 'Ajam Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C ₅ (B $\flat$, F, and G are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	minus-4 scale degrees, a just fourth down from the tonic
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	identical to the top 4 notes of the major scale (although not equal-tempered when played on traditional Arab instruments)
Typical Modulations	leading up to Jins 'Ajam on the same tonic to Jins Nahawand on the 5th of 'Ajam; to Hijaz on the 5th of 'Ajam; to Saba Dalanshin (6/8) on the same tonic
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i> Other Than in Maqam Ajam	underneath the tonic of Jins Nahawand starting on the 3rd of Bayati or Kurd leading up to Jins 'Ajam on 6

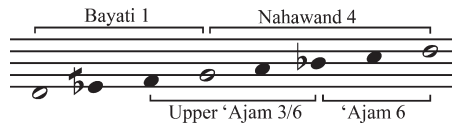

 FIGURE 16.4 A sample melodic line in Jins Upper 'Ajam from the song “*lissa fakir*.”


FIGURE 16.5 Jins Upper 'Ajam occurring in Maqam Bayati on D.

This occurrence of Jins Upper 'Ajam within Maqam Bayati, and the tonicization of the top note of its scale fragment, can be very clearly seen in Abdel Halim Hafez's song “*zayy il-hawa*” by Baligh Hamdi, as well as in the third verse of Umm Kulthum's “*huwwa sahib il-hawa ghallab*” by Zakariyya Ahmad.

Jins Upper ‘Ajam also occurs prominently underneath the Nahawand tonic (this is the equivalent of the top half of melodic minor in Western scales). The following songs prominently feature Upper ‘Ajam as a secondary *jins*:

- Underneath the Nahawand tonic: “*khusara*” by Abdel Halim Hafez (composed by Baligh Hamdi)
- Leading up to the 6th degree of Bayati: “*zayy il-hawa*” by Abdel Halim Hafez (composed by Baligh Hamdi)

Jins Saba Dalanshin

Jins Saba Dalanshin (pronounced “dah-lan-SHEEN”) is an alternate version (or a special case) of Jins Saba that, analogous to the *ajnas* Upper Rast and Upper ‘Ajam, leads upward to a tonic rather than having the tonic at the base of its *jins* scale. In contrast with the regular Jins Saba, the 3rd scale degree of Saba Dalanshin is more strongly tonicized than the 1st scale degree, and the intervals above it (3-4-5-6) are more or less identical to the normal Jins Hijaz (in contrast with the Hijaz-like portion of the regular Jins Saba, which is altered to fit the intervals of Saba).

The Saba Dalanshin extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 16.6 with its standard tonic on C₅.



FIGURE 16.6 Jins Saba Dalanshin on C.

What may confuse musicians who have a familiarity with Turkish music is that the Turkish version of Saba acts like Saba Dalanshin, rather than the version of Jins Saba that occurs as the root *jins* of Maqam Saba in Arabic music. Turkish Saba tonicizes what would be considered the 3rd scale degree above the tonic of Arabic Saba and emphasizes the Jins Hijaz intervals above that tonic.

We have given this *jins* the name “Saba Dalanshin” because it is the opening *jins* of Maqam Dalanshin (a version of Maqam Rast that starts on the octave with a flat 9th scale degree, emphasizing the melodic area between the 6th scale degree and the octave). Typical theory calls this *jins* “Saba on the 6th degree of Rast,” but listening to actual melodies reveals that the 6th scale degree is not tonicized, and instead melodies tonicize the octave of Rast. This, as well as having different enough melodic pathways and modulation possibilities, warrants classifying Jins Saba Dalanshin separately from regular Jins Saba.

TABLE 16.3

Jins Saba Dalanshin Characteristics

Standard Tonic	C ₅ (G and B $\flat$ are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	minus-3 scale degrees, a minor third interval down from the tonic
Playable on Western Instruments	No
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Like Saba, this <i>jins</i> has a close sequence of small intervals: a $\frac{3}{4}$ step underneath the tonic and another $\frac{3}{4}$ step below that, a large $\frac{1}{2}$ step above the tonic (like the slightly larger $\frac{1}{2}$ step of Jins Hijaz). The main difference in intervals with ordinary Jins Saba is this $\frac{1}{2}$ step, which in ordinary Saba is <i>smaller</i> than an equal-tempered $\frac{1}{2}$ step (between the 3rd and 4th scale degree), and in Saba Dalanshin is <i>larger</i> than an equal-tempered $\frac{1}{2}$ step. Saba Dalanshin also has a $1\frac{1}{2}$ -step interval between its 2nd and 3rd scale degrees, tuned like the same interval in Jins Hijaz.
Typical Modulations	as (6/8), to and from Upper Rast (5/8) or Upper 'Ajam (5/8) using the same (octave) tonic of the <i>maqamat</i> Rast or 'Ajam; from there frequently to Nahawand on the 5th scale degree of the <i>maqam</i> ; as (3/5) tonicizing the 5th scale degree of 'Ajam, moving between Jins 'Ajam (1) and Jins Hijaz (5)

The name *dalanshin* comes from the Persian expression *dil neshin* (close to the heart, pleasant). The main characteristics of Jins Saba Dalanshin are listed in table 16.3.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Saba Dalanshin in Maqam Rast/Dalanshin:

- The *dawr* “*ishna w shufna*” by Muhammad ‘Uthman
- The *qadd* “*ya mal ish-sham*,” at the phrase “*mishta’lik ya nur ‘uyuni*” (see figure 16.7)

Jins Saba Dalanshin is always a secondary *jins* in Arabic music, and it has basically two uses: to tonicize the octave of Maqam Rast or Maqam ‘Ajam (with melodic descent to the 6th scale degree) and to tonicize the 5th scale degree of Jins/Maqam



FIGURE 16.7 A sample phrase in Jins Saba Dalanshin from qadd “*ya mal ish-sham*.”

‘Ajam (*de rigueur* in Maqam Shawq Afzah) with melodic descent to the 3rd scale degree. It is this last modulation that is used in the famous second verse of Umm Kulthum’s *ugniya* “*lissa fakir*.” Usually confused with Saba on 3 of ‘Ajam, it is clear that it is the 5th scale degree, not the 3rd scale degree, that is tonicized by these melodies, hence making this verse one of the most prominent and extended versions of Jins Saba Dalanshin in the Egyptian repertoire.

It is worth noting, in addition, that Saba Dalanshin and the ordinary Jins Saba are entered from completely different modulation points when they occur as secondary *ajnas*. For example, in Maqam Rast, modulations to Jins Saba are possible from the 5th scale degree above Jins Rast, while the modulation to Jins Saba Dalanshin occurs descending from the octave to the 6th scale degree. The following songs prominently feature Saba Dalanshin as a secondary *jins* in Maqam ‘Ajam:

- Tonicizing the octave of ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran in the *muwashshahat* “*da’i al-hawa qad saba*” (music by Omar al-Batsh) and “*ayqadha al-hubbu fu’adi*”
- Tonicizing the 5th of Maqam Shawq Afza in the 2nd verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*lissa fakir*” by Riyad al-Sunbati
- Tonicizing the 5th of Maqam Shawq Afza in Fairouz’s “*zabrit il-janub (iswarit il-’arus)*” by Philemon Wehbe

Jins Hijazkar

Jins Hijazkar is the *jins* centered around the octave of the Maqam Hijazkar scale, or the *ghammas* (5th degree) of the Nawa Athar scale. This is a tremendously common *jins* in terms of actual use in the repertoire, but one that has gone completely unrecognized in *jins* classifications so far. While traditional theory explained Hijazkar’s melodies as occurring between two distinct *ajnas* (Nikriz on the 4th degree—or Hijaz on the 5th degree—followed by Hijaz on the 8th degree/octave) that meet in the middle, these melodies actually create one central feeling of tonicization, and the fluid movement above and below the tonic results in unique melodic phrases that don’t exist within either of those *ajnas*.

Moreover, such melodies cannot be explained by having an active Jins Hijaz at the octave, since its leading tone is a prominent whole step under the tonic, while the leading tone of Jins Hijazkar is a half step below the tonic. This creates a chromatic sequence of two half-step intervals that is not found in any other *jins*, giving Hijazkar an identity quite distinct from Hijaz. As such, Jins Hijazkar clearly illustrates that the notes underneath the tonic are equally important melodically as those above.

The Hijazkar extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 16.8 with its standard tonic on C.

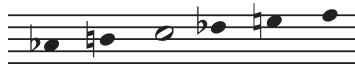


FIGURE 16.8 Jins Hijazkar on C.

The name Hijazkar (also spelled Hijaz Kar) derives from Hijaz (see “Jins Hijaz” in chapter 14) combined with the word *kar* (which comes to Arabic from Persian and means *work*). The main characteristics of Jins Hijazkar are listed in table 16.4.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Hijazkar:

- On the octave of Maqam Hijaz: 4th verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*ana fi-ntizarak*” by Zakariyya Ahmad
- On the octave of Maqam Hijazkar: in the *taqtuqa* “*ya nas ana mutti fi hubbi*” by Sayed Darwish
- On the octave of Maqam Hijazkar: in Warda’s “*harramt abibbak*” (music by Salah al-Sharnubi)
- On the octave, opening Maqam Hijazkar-Kurd: the *muwashshah* “*tif ya durri*” (music by Sayed Darwish/Omar al-Batsh); see sample phrase in figure 16.9



FIGURE 16.9 A sample phrase in Jins Hijazkar from the *muwashshah* “*tif ya durri*.”

Hijazkar is the opening *jins* of Maqam Hijazkar, starting on the octave above what will be the final tonic of the *maqam*. Hijazkar descends from there to Nikriz a fifth below (on the 4th scale degree above the *maqam*’s root tonic), then down to Hijaz at the tonic. Maqam Hijazkar-Kurd follows a similar sequence, but the Nikriz 4 is eventually modified to Nahawand 4 (by lowering the 7th scale degree), and the final descent is to Jins Kurd rather than Hijaz.

TABLE 16.4

Jins Hijazkar Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	C ₅ (an octave above the root of Maqam Hijazkar; G, D, and A are also common tonics)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	There is no true <i>ghammaz</i> within this <i>jins</i> ; the typical motion to another tonic is down a fifth to Nikriz, a note that doesn't exist within the extended scale of Jins Hijazkar itself.
Playable on Western Instruments	Sort of, at the same level of imprecision as Hijaz on Western instruments
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	two augmented second (1½-step) intervals, between the 2nd and 3rd scale degrees above the tonic, and between the 6th and 7th scale degrees below the tonic; also the sequence of two ½-step intervals from the 7th to the tonic to the 2nd scale degree, which doesn't occur in any other <i>jins</i> in Arabic music. The intervals are not perfectly semitonal/equal-tempered, and they follow the intonation of Hijaz.
<i>Maqamat</i> in Hijazkar Family	Hijazkar, Hijazkar Kurd, Suzidil (a transposition to low A), Shahnaz (a transposition to D), Shadd 'Araban (a transposition to low G)
Typical Modulations	down a fifth to Nikriz, Nahawand, or Rast
Other Common Modulations	to Jins Hijaz or Bayati on the same tonic
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 5th of Nikriz (in Maqam Nawa Athar), Nahawand, Rast, and Athar Kurd

As a secondary Jins, Hijazkar occurs in similar positions as Jins Hijaz: on the 5th of Nikriz or Rast. The following songs prominently feature Jins Hijazkar as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 5th of Maqam Nawa Athar: Farid al-Atrash's "*gamil gamal*"
- On the 5th of Maqam Rast: Umm Kulthum's "*aruh li min*" by Riyad al-Sunbati, 3rd verse

Jins Sikah Baladi

Jins Sikah Baladi is the primary *jins* in Maqam Sikah Baladi. It typically occurs at the octave above the *maqam* tonic, but more frequently it occurs as its own *jins* outside

that *maqam*. Sikah Baladi is not at all widespread and is rarely used to anchor an entire composition or improvisation. Instead it is almost always a modulation from the *ajnas* Rast, Nahawand, or Hijazkar.

It is difficult to notate this unusual *jins* with a good degree of precision, even by using the half-flat and half-sharp symbols. The scale shown in figure 16.10, with its tonic on G, is an approximate representation of Sikah Baladi using the “fine-tuning” arrows described in chapter 12: Notation.



FIGURE 16.10 Jins Sikah Baladi on G.

Maqam Sikah Baladi is commonly understood as a hybrid of Maqam Hijazkar and Maqam Sikah: to move from Hijazkar to Sikah Baladi, squeeze the two augmented second intervals between 2nd to 3rd and 6th to 7th, which are already narrower than three equal-tempered semitones, slightly smaller, so that the 2nd and 3rd scale degrees, and the 6th and 7th scale degrees, approach quartertones. This makes the interval sequence for Jins Sikah Baladi almost, but not quite, the same as that of Jins Sikah if transposed to a non-Sikah tonic (it is more like a distorted Sikah). For this reason, Maqam Sikah Baladi has sometimes been classified in the Sikah family rather than the Hijaz/Hijazkar family (we do not treat it as belonging to either family in chapter 24: *Maqam* Index).

The fact that the Sikah Baladi tonic occurs on a note that is perceived as a “normal” non-quartertone note (e.g., an open string) creates a very unusual sense of resolution that for many listeners will take the unsettled feeling of the Sikah tonic to another level. In terms of melodic behavior, however, Jins Sikah Baladi is much closer to Jins Hijazkar than Jins Sikah, as it has no obvious *ghammas*, and it uses notes above and below the tonic with equal prominence.

The name Sikah Baladi comes from Sikah and the word *baladi*, which means from the village/countryside—a word frequently used to evoke rural areas/culture in Arabic. This very challenging *jins*, from a Western equal-tempered viewpoint, is at home in the folk music of Egypt and the Arab world. The main characteristics of Jins Sikah Baladi are listed in table 16.5.

The similarity between Jins Hijazkar and Jins Sikah Baladi’s intonations and centeredness around their tonic can be exploited when melodies modulate from Hijazkar to Sikah Baladi and back. While the two *jins* intonations are close, their moods and identities are distinctive (even with a difference of about an 8th of a tone between their second degrees), and for listeners familiar with both *ajnas*, going into Sikah Baladi from Hijazkar creates an instant feeling of *tarab*. This modulation is beautifully exploited by Lebanese singer Wadiah al-Safi in his song “*adat tusa’iluni*,”

TABLE 16.5

Jins Sikah Baladi Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	G ₄ , also C ₅ is a common tonic; D ₄ is another option
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	no true <i>ghammaz</i> . This <i>jins</i> occurs on the tonic and the octave of Maqam Sikah Baladi, and the modulation pathway occasionally also tonicizes a few other tones within the scale, but none strongly enough to be a clear secondary tonic.
Playable on Western Instruments	Hahahahahahaha!!!
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	Every interval is microtonal from a Western viewpoint, and although to some degree its intervals resemble those of Jins Hijazkar, it does not sound like any other <i>jins</i> in Arabic music.
Possible Modulations	to the 5th above the tonic of Maqam Sikah Baladi (an emphasized tone difficult to classify as a <i>jins</i>); to modified versions of Hijaz, Bayati, and Nahawand on its 3rd scale degree (analogous to Jins Sikah's typical modulations); to Jiharkah on its tonic; back to Rast or Nahawand on the same tonic
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the tonic, <i>ghammaz</i> , or octave of another <i>maqam</i> . This is such an unusual <i>jins</i> that there is no "typical" occurrence for it. There is one typical modulation on the same tonic, between Sikah Baladi and Jiharkah, by modifying the 2nd scale degree (that note is lower in Sikah Baladi).

at the 2nd verse starting with phrase "*ma ziltu l-il-hubbi ahyā*." That verse goes back and forth between Hijazkar and Sikah Baladi phrases, as al-Safi sings Sikah Baladi phrases mostly above the tonic, while the *lazimat* (short instrumental phrases between vocal phrases) clearly go to Jins Hijazkar below the tonic.

Another example of the Sikah Baladi and Hijazkar interplay can be heard in Abdel Halim Hafez's song "*ahwak*" (composed by Muhammad Abdel Wahab), in which the second verse is preceded by a long instrumental introduction featuring Jins Hijazkar, then the vocal part (starting with "*w-anadik*") modulates to Jins Sikah Baladi.

Not many other singers attempt a Sikah Baladi verse in a composed song, probably because the *jins* is not very widespread and therefore achieving correct intonation requires more experience. However, as one would expect, the two Egyptian vocal giants, Umm Kulthum and Muhammad Abdel Wahab, have each sung their fair share of verses in Sikah Baladi, and these can be used as learning aids to study this *jins*.

The following songs prominently feature Sikah Baladi, in all cases as a secondary *jins* modulating from another *maqam* context:

- Umm Kulthum sings Sikah Baladi in the 2nd verse of “*yalli kan yishgik anini*” (on the 4th of Maqam Kurd), the 3rd verse of “*aruh li min*” (on the tonic of Maqam Rast), and the 3rd verse of “*shams il-asil*” (on the 4th of Maqam Hijaz), all composed by Riyad al-Sunbati.
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab sings Sikah Baladi in “*sabirtu minhu al-layali*” (on the 5th of Maqam Nahawand), “*tal intizari*” (on the tonic of Maqam Nahawand), “*il-habib il-maghul*” (on the tonic of Maqam Nahawand), and “*kulli da kan leb*” (on the 4th of Maqam Bayati), all of which are his compositions.
- Wadih al-Safi sings Sikah Baladi in the 3rd verse of his song “*jannat*” on the octave of Maqam Kurd, at the phrase “*wi sdur bithattim jabal.*”

A sample melody in Sikah Baladi taken from Abdel Wahab's famous tango "*sahirtu minhu al-layali*" is shown in figure 16.11.

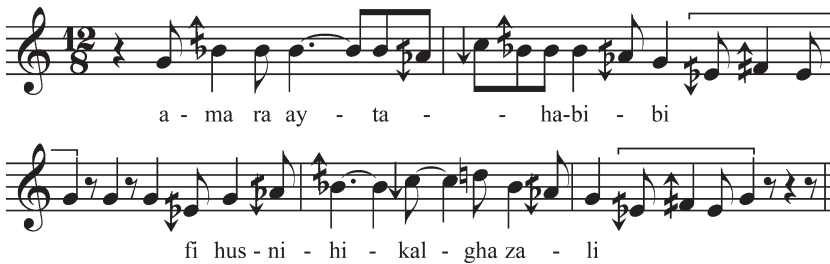


FIGURE 16.11 A sample phrase in Jins Sikah Baladi from Muhammad Abdel Wahab's tango "*sahirtu minhu al-layali*."

Sikah Baladi can be worked into a full *maqam* scale, usually by descending an octave—but it most often occurs just as a single *jins*. When it does modulate, it can sometimes tonicize the note a 4th under its tonic (the 5th above the root of Maqam Sikah Baladi). In other instances, the 3rd above the tonic is used almost like the *ghammaz* of Jins Sikah, with modulations to modified versions of Hijaz, Bayati, and Nahawand.

Jins Mukhalif Sharqi

Jins Mukhalif Sharqi is a 3-note *jins* that resembles, and is named after, Maqam Mukhalif in the Iraqi Maqam tradition. Musicians in Egypt and Syria typically refer to this *jins* simply as Mukhalif (while others refer to it as Maqam Ramal), but the

similarities are superficial, and a closer comparison reveals noticeable differences in intonation, as well as in melodic practice. The Iraqi Mukhalif has a rich, complex melody, while the version practiced in the *sharqi* tradition is little more than a variation on Jins Sikah, with its 3rd scale degree lowered by a semitone. Hence the adjective *sharqi*⁵ helps to differentiate it from the proper Iraqi Maqam Mukhalif. The word *mukhalif* in Arabic literally means “contrarian” or “rule-breaker.”

The Mukhalif Sharqi *jins* fragment is notated in figure 16.12 with its standard tonic on E♭. Its main characteristics are listed in table 16.6.



FIGURE 16.12 Jins Mukhalif Sharqi on E♭.

Mukhalif Sharqi doesn’t occur as a stand-alone *maqam* and essentially exists only as a modulation from (and back to) Sikah, by lowering Sikah’s 3rd scale degree (see table 15.5 for a side-by-side comparison of these two *ajnas* along with Sikah’s other variant, Musta’ar). The modulation between Jins Sikah and Jins Mukhalif Sharqi is usually brief enough to pass as an accidental, but its character and melodic development are consistent enough for it to qualify as a *jins* in its own right. In fact, this modulation is so prevalent, however brief, that it has become a cliché in improvisations utilizing Sikah. The Mukhalif modulation from Sikah is featured in many songs and melodies anchored in *maqamat* from the Sikah family, such as *maqam*

TABLE 16.6

Jins Mukhalif Sharqi Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	E♭ ₄ (other possible tonics are B♭, and A♭)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	N/A (there is no <i>ghammaz</i>)
Playable on Western Instruments	No way
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	The tonic is Sikah (E♭), which is the 3rd scale degree of Rast. Above that tonic, the 3rd scale degree is lowered.*

*Listeners are advised not to confuse this *jins* with Saba, which shares a similar sequence of intervals (¾ step followed by ½ step) from its 2nd to 4th scale degrees.

⁵ While *sharqi* literally means “Eastern” in Arabic and was originally used to describe music of the Near East (Eastern Mediterranean) from the perspective of Europe—the reciprocal adjective being *gharbi*, which literally means Western—*sharqi* eventually became synonymous with music of the area from Egypt through Syria, regardless of the point of comparison. See the introduction.

Huzam. It is also a common modulation in songs anchored in *maqamat* from the Rast family, after a modulation to Jins Sikah on the 3rd degree of Rast.

Probably the most recognizable recorded example of such a Mukhalif Sharqi modulation from Jins Rast is Umm Kulthum's "*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*," in the third verse ("*ablif lak bi rabb il-beit*") on the phrase "*l-ashirkum iza ghanneit*" (shown in figure 16.13). Meanwhile Umm Kulthum modulates from Sikah to Mukhalif Sharqi in the *dawr* "*emta el-hawa*" (by Zakariyya Ahmad) at the phrase "*ma hi ghaltitak/eh ya'ni law rayyabtini*." Other recorded examples of Jins Mukhalif Sharqi are found in the instrumental "*raqsat al-sous*" (Rahbani Brothers) and the *dawr* "*lisan il-dam'i*" (composed by Muhammad 'Uthman).



FIGURE 16.13 A sample phrase in Jins Mukhalif Sharqi from Umm Kulthum's song "*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*."

Jins Hijaz Murassa'

Hijaz Murassa' (also spelled Murassaa) is a version of Jins Hijaz with a lowered 5th scale degree (to a semitone above the *ghammaz*). Although this *jins* and Jins Hijaz only differ in their extended scale (they have the same basic scale), the difference between their moods and usage warrants a different classification. We coined the name "Hijaz Murassa'" to indicate that it is a decoration (*murassa'* literally means "inlaid") of Jins Hijaz, analogous to Nahawand Murassa' as a decoration of Nahawand.

The Hijaz Murassa' extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 16.14 on D.



FIGURE 16.14 Jins Hijaz Murassa' on D.

This *jins* is not the root of any *maqam* and has a very limited usage; it is an occasional variation that occurs during the descent to the root in concluding phrases in Maqam Hijaz/Hijazkar. Its main characteristics are listed in table 16.7.

The following songs prominently feature Jins Hijaz Murassa':

- The *muwashshah* "*zarani-l-mahbub*," at the phrase "*rawwa' il-mashroub, wi mala li-l-kas*"
- The *muwashshah* "*laha badru-t-timm*" (by Sheikh Mahmud Subh), at the end of each section at the phrase "*aman*"

TABLE 16.7

Jins Hijaz Murassa‘ Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	D4 or C4 (any tonic at which Hijaz might occur is a possible tonic)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	4 scale degrees, just fourth
Playable on Western Instruments	yes, to the extent that Hijaz is
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	lowered 5th scale degree above Hijaz. Otherwise it preserves the other intervals of Jins Hijaz.

- The *muwashshah* “*badru timmin haza husnan*,” at the phrase “*hayyara al-afkar*”
- The *dawr* “*il-hubbi ma hush bis-sabl*” (by Dawud Husni) in Maqam Hijazkar, at the end of the first section (at the phrase “*il-hubbi min tab‘o byitdalla*”)
- Umm Kulthum’s “*ana fi-ntizarak*,” at the end of every verse (see figure 16.15)

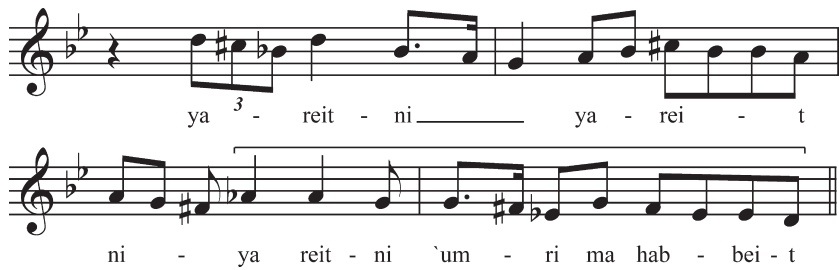


FIGURE 16.15 A sample phrase in Jins Hijaz Murassa‘ from the song “*ana fi-ntizarak*.”

Jins Hijaz Murassa‘ is basically a variation of Jins Hijaz, so while it might theoretically occur wherever that *jins* occurs—and it seems to have a slightly more widespread use in Turkish music than in Arabic music—in practice it really only occurs on the root of *maqam* Hijazkar at the end of descending phrases, as previously stated. As such, there really are no further modulation options (while we have heard this *jins* in a few instances occurring in *taqasim* where Hijaz occurs as a secondary *jins* for an extended passage, e.g., on the 5th of Rast or Nahawand, we have found no examples in songs other than on the root of Maqam Hijaz or Hijazkar).

Jins ‘Ajam Murassa‘

Jins ‘Ajam Murassa‘ is a variation of Jins ‘Ajam with a raised 4th scale degree. Those familiar with the Western modes may recognize this as the first 5 notes of the Lydian

mode in Greek music, while those familiar with Indian classical music will recognize the similarity to Raga Kalyani's intervals.⁶ We coined the name "‘Ajam Murassa'" to indicate that it is a decoration of Jins ‘Ajam, analogous to Nahawand Murassa'. The ‘Ajam Murassa' extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 16.16 with its tonic on F.



FIGURE 16.16 Jins ‘Ajam Murassa' on F.

Although casual observation might mistakenly consider this a tonicization of 5th scale degree (with the 4th as its leading tone)—basically a variation on Jins Upper ‘Ajam—the feeling of tonicization remains on the original tonic, making this a distinct 5-note *jins*. This is an extremely rare *jins* in Arabic music, and its most common usage is on the same tonic as a modulation from Jiharkah or ‘Ajam. Its main characteristics are listed in table 16.8.

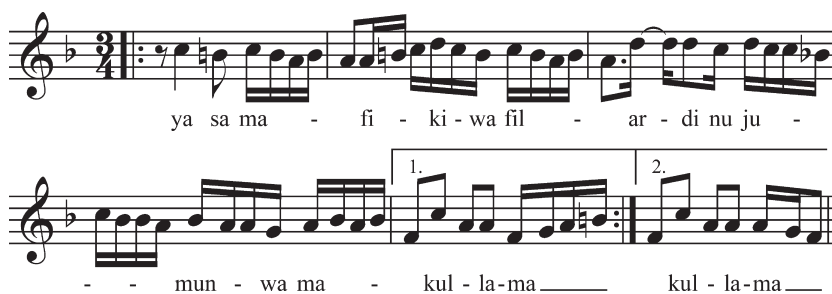
The following songs feature Jins ‘Ajam Murassa':

- The *dawr* “*sabbahṭi min ‘ishāk abki*” by Abdel Hayy Hilmi
- Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*qari’at al-finjan*,” at the phrase “*wa sataṣ’alu ‘anha mawga-l-bahr*”
- Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*nibtidi minein il-hikaya*,” at the phrase “*we abilna-l-hasdin we shafuna/wala hanshi ‘aleihum yifutuna*”
- The *muwashshah* “*kallili ya subbu*” (see figure 16.17)

TABLE 16.8

Jins ‘Ajam Murassa' Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	F4 (other possible tonics are C, G, and D)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	5 scale degrees, just fifth
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	its raised 4th scale degree, which provides a strong emphasis, without tonicization, to its 5th scale degree; its major third above the tonic, like ‘Ajam. Its scale fragment is equivalent to the bottom 5 notes of the Lydian mode.

⁶ Gaurav Shah, personal communication with the author, 2017.

FIGURE 16.17 A sample phrase in Jins ‘Ajam Murassa’ from the *muwashshah* “*kallili ya subbu*.”

This is an archaic/rare *jins*, whose more extended modulation pathways have been lost, but it found a minor resurgence in the mid-20th century, as can be seen from some of the other examples listed previously. The song “*ya fagri nurak*” used it very creatively as a modulation from Athar Kurd—a very dramatic and distant modulation from the perspective of the traditional *maqam* system, but one made easy through the fact that this *jins* shares a raised 4th with Jins Athar Kurd (and through the composer Yusuf Shawqi’s own cleverness).

Jins Semitonal Sikah

Jins Semitonal Sikah is a rare tonicization of the 3rd scale degree of ‘Ajam or Hijaz that uses the melodic phrasing of Jins Sikah. This melodic phrasing gives the feeling that the tonic is a “Sikah” note (this feeling can be difficult to describe to those who are unfamiliar with Arabic music, but it is basically the feeling that a tonic is set out of the frame of the normal scale, with its just fourths and fifths). Yet there are no “microtones” in this *jins*.



FIGURE 16.18 Jins Semitonal Sikah on E.

The Semitonal Sikah extended *jins* scale is notated in figure 16.18 with its tonic on E.

Jins Semitonal Sikah occurs primarily as a secondary *jins* in traditional *maqam* contexts; however, it has a parallel history. When the famous composer Muhammad Abdel Wahab visited the homes of wealthy patrons in Egypt in the early 20th century, they would inevitably treat him by having one of their children play one of his compositions on the piano (an instrument that was ubiquitous in the homes of well-to-do Egyptians). When they would play one of his compositions on Sikah—the piano of course doesn’t have the necessary note—the *maqam* would be altered, and Abdel Wahab coined the term “*Sikah al-Buyut*,”

which means “Homemade/Homestyle Sikah,” referring to the homes of the various wealthy patrons he visited.⁷

But aside from this somewhat unintentional usage, the *jins* does have a specific traditional usage: tonicizing the 3rd scale degree of ‘Ajam or Hijaz (both of which have a major 3rd above their respective tonics) by using a raised 2nd scale degree as a leading tone.

We coined the name “Semitonal Sikah” to illustrate that this *jins* is a variant of Jins Sikah that can be notated without quartertones, whose intonation is closer to an equal-tempered version of Sikah (its intonation changes slightly with the context in which it occurs, especially on the 3rd degree of Jins Hijaz). Of course when this *jins* is played on the piano its intonation will be equal-tempered, but this is not necessarily the case when it is played on traditional Arabic instruments. The main characteristics of Jins Semitonal Sikah are listed in table 16.9.

The song “*ib’id ya hubb*,” sung by Afaf Radi, prominently features Jins Semitonal Sikah as the root *jins* of the *maqam*; this is the only song the authors are aware of that

TABLE 16.9

Jins Semitonal Sikah Characteristics	
Standard Tonic	no standard tonic (possible tonics are E $\flat$, F $\sharp$, B $\flat$, and A $\sharp$)
Basic Scale Span, Tonic to <i>Ghammaz</i>	3 scale degrees, minor third
Playable on Western Instruments	Yes
Characteristic Notes or Intervals	raised leading tone under the tonic; flat 4th. In terms of its intervals alone, this <i>jins</i> appears to be identical to Saba Zamzam—but the two could not be further apart in terms of mood and melodic content, illustrating the fact that a <i>jins</i> is much more than its intervals.
Possible Modulations from <i>Ghammaz</i> (3)	Hijaz (3), Nahawand (3), Upper ‘Ajam (3/6)
Other Possible Modulations	‘Ajam (6)
Usage as a Secondary <i>Jins</i>	on the 3rd of Jins ‘Ajam or Jins Hijaz. In that context, it appears on the 6th of Maqam Zanjaran (the 3rd of the ‘Ajam that is on the 4th of the root Hijaz) and on the 6th of Maqam Bayati Shuri (the 3rd of the Hijaz that is on the 4th of the root Bayati).

⁷ Dr. Alfred Gamil, conversation with the author in Cairo, 2002.

is a complete composition in the Maqam Sikah al-Buyut (intentionally). A sample melody in Jins Semitonal Sikah on B $\flat$ taken from that song is shown in figure 16.19.

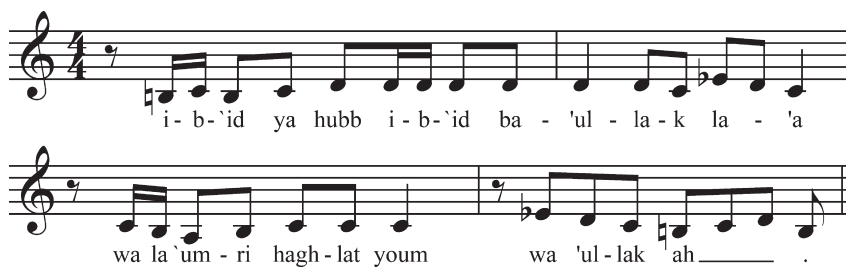


FIGURE 16.19 A sample phrase in Jins Semitonal Sikah on B, from the song “*ib'id ya hubb*.”

The song “*ib'id ya hubb*” illustrates not only melodic phrasing that is analogous to Sikah without the quartertones, but also modulation pathways that are analogous: to Hijaz on the 3rd scale degree and 'Ajam on the 6th scale degree. In the repertoire, however, this *jins* is much more common as a passing/brief tonicization of the 3rd scale degree of 'Ajam or Hijaz, and it can even occur where 'Ajam and Hijaz are themselves secondary *ajnas* within another *maqam*. The following songs prominently feature Semitonal Sikah as a secondary *jins*:

- On the 3rd of Maqam Hijaz: instrumental intro to Abdel Halim Hafez’s “*bahlam bik*”
- On the 3rd of Maqam Ajam: “*wallahi tistabil ya albi*” by Sayed Darwish
- On the 6th of Maqam Zanjaran: the *mawwal* “*amana ya leil*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab
- On the 6th of Maqam Bayati Shuri: the *muwashshah* “*hibbi da'ani lil-wisal*” (see figure 16.20)

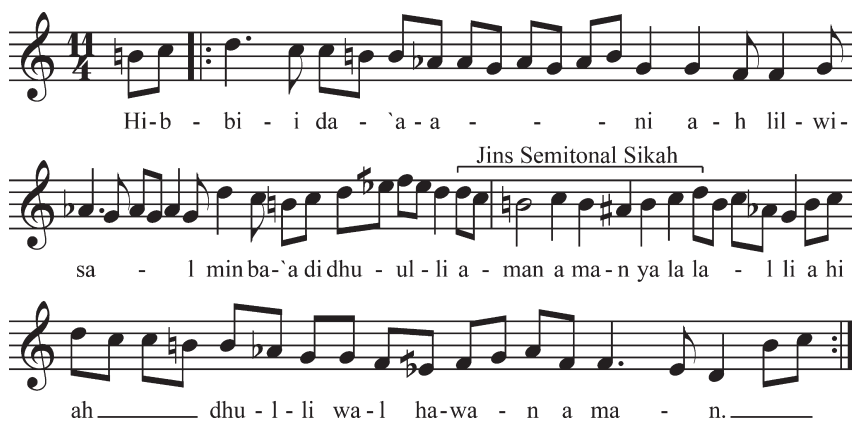


FIGURE 16.20 A sample phrase in Jins Semitonal Sikah from the *muwashshah* “*hibbi da'ani lil-wisal*.”

Other Melodic Entities

In addition to the new *ajnas* defined in the chapter, we have noted several other melodic entities in the *maqam* system that are more difficult to define formally as *ajnas*, but are distinct as melody types from the other *ajnas* listed in the three *ajnas* chapters. This brief examination of the borders of the *maqam* system can help us understand the fluid nature of classification.

SABA BUSELIK

This *jins*, defined in theory, does not occur in the repertoire we cover in this book. It is a version of Saba with a raised 2nd scale degree (as opposed to Saba Zamzam, which has a lowered 2nd scale degree). Greek Rembetiko and Smyrnaiko music makes use of this *jins*, as it is another way of making Saba into a semitonal *jins*. The *jins* is also found in Coptic church music in Egypt.

HUSAYNI

Husayni is more properly defined as a *maqam* in the Bayati family (see chapter 24: *Maqam* Index), in which the melody starts on Bayati's 5th scale degree (named Husayni in the Arabic 24-tone scale), which is also the 2nd scale degree above the Jins Rast that occurs on the 4th scale degree of Jins Bayati. This distinctive melody starts with the feeling of being suspended on 5, before resolving down 5-to-4, and then down to the root tonic on 1. However, since it has a distinct melodic profile from Jins Rast, it could be argued that it is a distinct *jins*, a kind of unstable Jins Bayati on 5 above Bayati. It is also worth noting that older versions of Maqam Hijaz often utilized this melody in a way parallel to Maqam Bayati/Husayni (unresolved 5, resolving down to Rast/Nahawand 4), which gives credence to the idea of classifying Husayni as a *jins*.

THE 5TH SCALE DEGREE OF SIKAH

A common melody in *maqamat* of the Sikah family is to emphasize the 5th scale degree above the tonic, which is also a quartertone note, when slightly lowered from the 3rd scale degree of Jins Hijaz on 3. This note, though never truly feeling like a real tonic, is nonetheless strongly emphasized. Sometimes it takes the form of a kind of Jins Hijaz, descending from the octave tonic of Maqam Sikah, which could be understood as a "pseudo-hijaz" (as shown in figure 16.21).



FIGURE 16.21 Jins Pseudo-Hijaz F# in Sikah Bb.

But the note can be emphasized even without the Hijaz contour that results from raising the 7th degree of the scale, and it is common to hold this note especially in improvisations where there is a drone on the tonic. Moreover, the 4th scale degree is often raised to an interval of about a semitone underneath the 5th scale degree and behaves very much like the Jins Sikah leading tone. In any case, there is clearly a distinct set of melodies in this area, but because it is not a true tonicization, and because this “*jins*” is not transferable to another *maqam* context, it is not clear that the label “*jins*” is justified here.

HIJAZ GHARIB

While some sources use the name Hijaz Gharib (*gharib* means “weird/strange” or “foreign”) to refer to Jins Sikah Baladi, other sources in Aleppo⁸ use it to classify a version of Hijaz with a lowered 4th scale degree (so that the just fourth that would normally occur is detuned), which is distinct from Sikah Baladi. The authors have not found any examples within compositions in the repertoire, but it occurs sometimes in Qur’anic recitation and in the *adhan* and can be represented as shown in figure 16.22.



FIGURE 16.22 Jins Hijaz Gharib on D.

ATHAR BAYATI

This is a typical phrase occasionally used in Aleppo within improvisations in Maqam Bayati, raising the 4th scale degree (G# in Bayati on D) as a passing leading tone to momentarily emphasize the 5th scale degree. If treated as a *jins* it would resemble Athar Kurd with a half-flat second scale degree, but its usage is arguably too narrow for such a classification.

NAHAWAND ON THE 5TH DEGREE OF RAST

When Jins Nahawand occurs on the 5th scale degree of Rast, its 3rd scale degree (the lowered 7th of the Rast *maqam* scale) is often lower than it is where Nahawand

⁸ Muhammad Qassas and Abdel Basit Bakkar, personal communications with the author, 2002.

occurs in other contexts. Furthermore, the melodic profile of this Jins Nahawand is somewhat distinct from the Nahawand that occurs as a root *jins*, or on the 4th scale degree of *maqamat* such as Hijaz and Bayati, as its melodies are often limited to 4 notes instead of 5.

An argument could be made that this is a distinct *jins*—which begs the question of whether other *ajnas* also have distinct versions when they occur in a secondary position in other *maqamat*. In fact, they do. From a practical, musical point of view, the expert musician must in reality learn each *jins* in each *maqam* as though it is a distinct melodic entity—meaning that there are upwards of 300 distinct *ajnas* in practice. However, from a classification point of view this is obviously impractical, and in the vast majority of cases the similarity of interval and dominant melodic patterns is enough to create a conceptual identity even when there are noticeable contextual differences. The Nahawand that occurs on the 5th of Rast is arguably the most distinct, while still being similar enough to Nahawand in other contexts to remain classified as such.

RAISED 3RD DEGREE IN NAHAWAND

In certain melodic contexts, the 3rd scale degree of Nahawand (the minor 3rd) is raised as a leading tone to the 4th scale degree, before lowering again in a descent to the tonic. An argument could be made that there is a momentary Jins ‘Ajam here (because of the major 3rd); an alternative argument could be made that if we do not classify this as a modulation to a distinct *jins*, how can we justify the classification of Nahawand Murassa‘, or the even rarer Hijaz Murassa‘ and ‘Ajam Murassa‘ defined previously? The reality is that such classifications are arbitrary. Our justification here is that Hijaz Murassa‘ and ‘Ajam Murassa‘ have a stronger, more separable melodic profile (which is certainly the case with Nahawand Murassa‘). The raised 3rd in Nahawand truly occurs in a passing function only, because if it remained long enough to be distinct, we would have moved to ‘Ajam, which doesn’t typically occur. Nonetheless, this example serves to highlight the imprecise nature of classification.

THE MAQAM

THIS BOOK HAS so far defined the Arabic *maqam* very briefly, as a system of scales, habitual melodic phrases, modulation possibilities, ornamentation norms, and aesthetic conventions, that together form a very rich artistic tradition.

While the Arabic *maqam* as a concept is well understood (at least implicitly) by practitioners, it has been poorly described in written music literature. The gap between written material about the *maqam* and actual performance practice is described by Marcus: “In many cases, new understandings gained from the dynamic realm of performance differ significantly from the theoretical definition, highlighting the existence of distinct worlds of theory and practice.”¹ Marcus’s extensive work since 1989 has filled in much of the gap in English-language scholarship, by documenting oral practices more thoroughly—corroborating our own experience with the informal music theory explanations that expert musicians give. When it comes to the most glaring discrepancy between oral and written understandings—the static single-scale model of *maqam* versus the practice of including multiple *ajnas* within a *maqam* performance—Marcus’s writings (listed in the References) provide an excellent starting point. Marcus defines the following performance characteristics as part and parcel of the *maqam* definition: “intonation, accidentals, melodic leaps,

¹ Marcus (2007, p. 25).

the use of multiple upper tetrachords, modulation, and a characteristic order of progressing through each of the *maqam*'s defining features."²

We have attempted here to bring both the written and the oral knowledge—which has its own weaknesses and contradictions—into a more coherent theory, especially through the modified definition of *jins* provided in the last several chapters. This chapter explores the existing definitions, metaphors, and models used to explain the *maqam* in literature as well as oral tradition; points out their limitations; and offers a more elaborate and detailed view of what a *maqam* is, based on examining and analyzing the musical practice.

What Is a *Maqam*?

The usual starting point for talking about *maqam* is the scale,³ a collection of seven musical pitches in ascending order that repeats at the octave (the 8th pitch): think “Do—Ré—Mi—Fa—So—La—Si—Do (octave).” Each *maqam* is then defined in terms of the different possible intervals between each pitch. A further refinement groups the notes in the bottom half and the top half of the scale as distinct *ajnas*, defined also by their interval relationships, and states “Maqam X = Jins Y on the bottom + Jins Z on the top.” For example, Maqam Bayati and Maqam Suznak are shown in figures 17.1 and 17.2 in that traditional form.

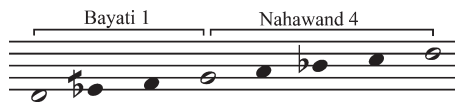


FIGURE 17.1 Traditional view of Maqam Bayati.



FIGURE 17.2 Traditional view of Maqam Suznak.

² Marcus (2007). Another detailed definition of the *maqam* by Marcus (2015, p. 281) goes as follows: “Melodies are built from melodic modes called *maqamat*, and any given *maqam* dictates a wealth of melodic features. These include the notes used (conceived today as a specific scale with a tonic); ideas about the intonation of the notes and which notes should be emphasized; a specific tetrachordal structure with the possibility of alternative tetrachords; a sense of tessitura (how high and how low a melody extends); the idiomatic use of specific accidentals; common melodic motives and modulations to other *maqams*; a characteristic general progression (a kind of road map for moving through a mode’s various features); and for some *maqams*, extra-musical associations.”

³ Marcus (1989b) provides a thorough discussion of how changes in Arab music theory in the 20th century resulted in an overly simplified definition of *maqam*, partly in response to cultural pressure to Westernize. In the first “period” of theory he refers to, scale was not even present, and instead melodic

TABLE 17.1

Several <i>Maqamat</i> in the Rast Family Defined through Their Primary <i>Ajnas</i>	
<i>Maqam</i>	Primary <i>Ajnas</i>
Rast	Rast 1 + Upper Rast 5/8
Suznak	Rast 1 + Hijaz 5
Nairuz	Rast 1 + Bayati 5
Dalanshin	Rast 1 + Saba Dalanshin 6/8

Maqam “families” are then defined as *maqamat* that share the same bottom *jins*—the *jins* that defines the main tonic of the *maqam* (the “Do” or the 1). For example, several *maqamat* in the Maqam Rast family are shown in table 17.1. This definition of *maqam* is the one that forms the basis of conventional Arabic music theory and analysis.

But if we really wish to understand *maqam*, we are going to have to question this concept, and even the basic idea that the scale is the true framework for *maqam*. We must start with the evidence of the music itself, with melody. The first question is: Is the scale the basic unit of melody?

In Western classical music, the answer is yes. In any piano sonata by Mozart or Beethoven we will find scales, and scale sequences, in every other measure. Where there are not scales, there are arpeggios, which skip notes in the scale but still emphasize octave-spanning melodies. The predominant instrument in Western classical music is the piano—used to compose, accompany, theorize, and arrange—and it is built on the scale system. It is no wonder that the scale is the dominant framework for thinking about music theory. Yet like the fish that doesn’t perceive the water it swims in, music theorists don’t realize that they think of the scale as the dominant framework for music *precisely because the scale is actually musically significant to the particular idiom out of which that music theory developed*—rather than being an abstract, absolute concept defining all music for all time.

Scales do occur in *maqam*-based music, but they are much less frequent and do not provide the dominant framework for melody. As discussed in chapter 13: The *Jins*, Arabic melodies typically use a span of 4–5 notes for a longer period of time before moving to a new area, rather than going up and down a full scale repeatedly. Each area can be defined as a *jins* (pl. *ajnas*), based on the intervals of the scale fragment (the 4–5 notes in ascending order), the melodic patterns used, and the mood.

fragments were used to illustrate the *maqam*. Thus, in some regards theory from that period *better* reflected practice than later theory.

Jins-to-Jins Motions

To understand the deeper problems with the scale framework, we must next ask: What happens when a melody goes from one *jins* to the next? How does the melody of a whole piece of Arabic music work? To answer these questions, let's look at several pieces defined as being in Maqam Rast, starting with the *muwashshah* “*ya shadi al-alhan*”⁴ notated in figure 17.3.

Jins Upper Rast 5/8

Ya sha-dil - al han ah as - mi` - na \_\_\_\_\_ ran na - ta-l-`i -

Jins Nahawand 5 Jins Hijaz 5

da - n ya la la-l li ya la la - ah - ya la la-l-li ran - na -

Jins Rast 1 Upper Rast 5/8 Jins Rast 1

ta-l-`i - da - n ah-i as - mi` - na - - - ah ya la - l li

ya la la la la ah ya lal - li .

FIGURE 17.3 The *muwashshah* “*ya shadi al-alhan*” with *jins* analysis shown above.

This same piece can be presented as a *jins-to-jins* analysis, as shown in figure 17.4. (Box 17.1 describes the style of *maqam* analysis diagrams used in this book.)

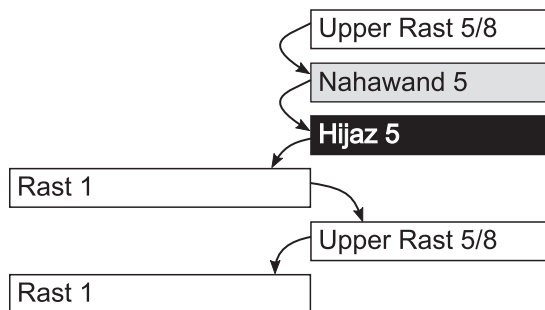


FIGURE 17.4 *Jins-to-jins* analysis of the *muwashshah* “*ya shadi al-alhan*.”

⁴ *Muwashshah* “*ya shadi al-alhan*” is a perfect example for demonstrating the secondary *ajnas* in Maqam Rast and was previously used thus in Fath Allah and Kamel (1974, p. 136); El-Mallah (1997, p. 56); Marcus (2007, p. 36); and Abu Shumays (2013).

BOX 17.1

This chapter includes several *jins*-to-*jins* analysis diagrams in which each *jins* is represented as a rectangle containing its name and the scale degree of its tonic relative to the overall *maqam*'s tonic. Rectangle borders and shadings have been applied to make *ajnas* more visually distinct. The lines between *jins* rectangles indicate a two-way modulation unless they have an arrowhead, in which case they indicate a one-way modulation. The rectangle's width reflects the size of the *jins*'s basic scale, and its horizontal placement reflects the position of the basic scale within the *maqam* scale.

The exception to this convention is the occurrence of Jins Nahawand on the 5th degree of Maqam Rast (see the section "Other Melodic Entities" in chapter 16: Newly Classified *Ajnas*); the size of that particular usage of Jins Nahawand is drawn as 4 notes wide to reflect the fact that this *jins*'s melodic activity on the 5th degree of Maqam Rast is limited to the 4 notes from the *ghammaz* to the octave tonic.

Let's compare this with four more analyses of songs in Maqam Rast from Egypt: the classic "*hayrana leh*" (see figure 17.5), composed by Dawud Husni for Leila Mourad in 1930; "*ya wabur*" (see figure 17.6), composed and performed by Muhammad Abdel Wahab in 1938; the song "*ma takhudshi 'ala kida*" (see figure 17.7), by the contemporary *sha'bi* singer Hakim (b. 1962), in 1998; and the late Umm Kulthum song "*il-hubbi kullo*" (see figure 17.8), composed by Baligh Hamdi in 1971. Rather than looking at transcriptions, the picture of *jins*-to-*jins* movement will be clearer through the model used in figure 17.4, following the time stamps in the most commonly available recordings of these songs.

What can we observe from these examples? First, encountering a full scale is quite rare. Second, every one of these songs uses more than two *ajnas*. Third, there are five *ajnas* that are common to all of them: Rast 1, Upper Rast 5/8, Nahawand 5, Hijaz 5, and Rast 8 (Rast on the octave). There are a few additional *ajnas* that occur, but not in every song—Nahawand 8, Hijazkar 5, and Sazkar 1 in "*ya wabur*" and Bayati 5 and Saba 5 in "*ma takhudshi 'ala kida*"—but these other *ajnas* represent only a very small portion of the overall melodies.

In addition, we can observe a few more things about the sequence of *ajnas*. First, there are multiple different sequences of the five common *ajnas*. This is crucial to understand, in contrast to the explanations practicing musicians give, detailed

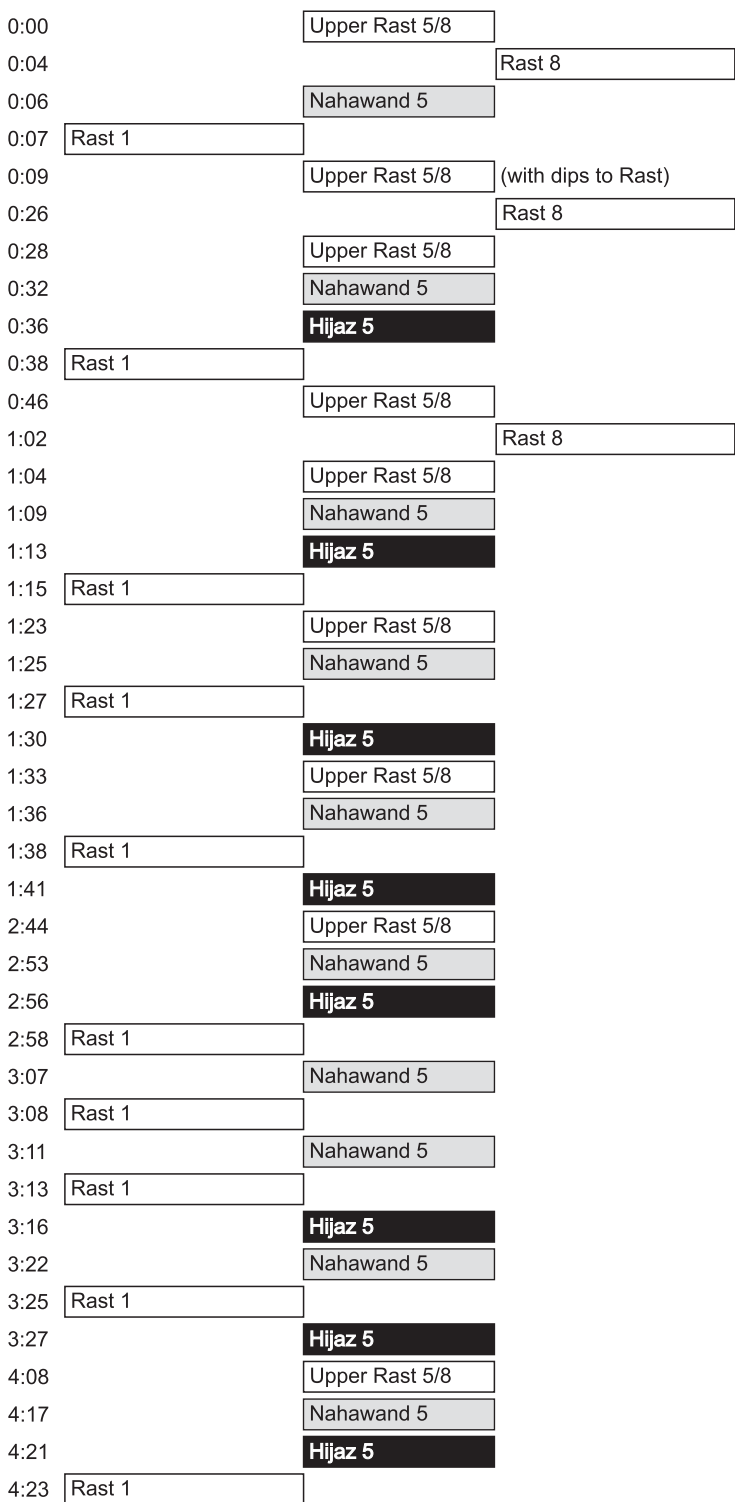


FIGURE 17.5 *Jins-to-jins* analysis of “*hayrana leb.*”

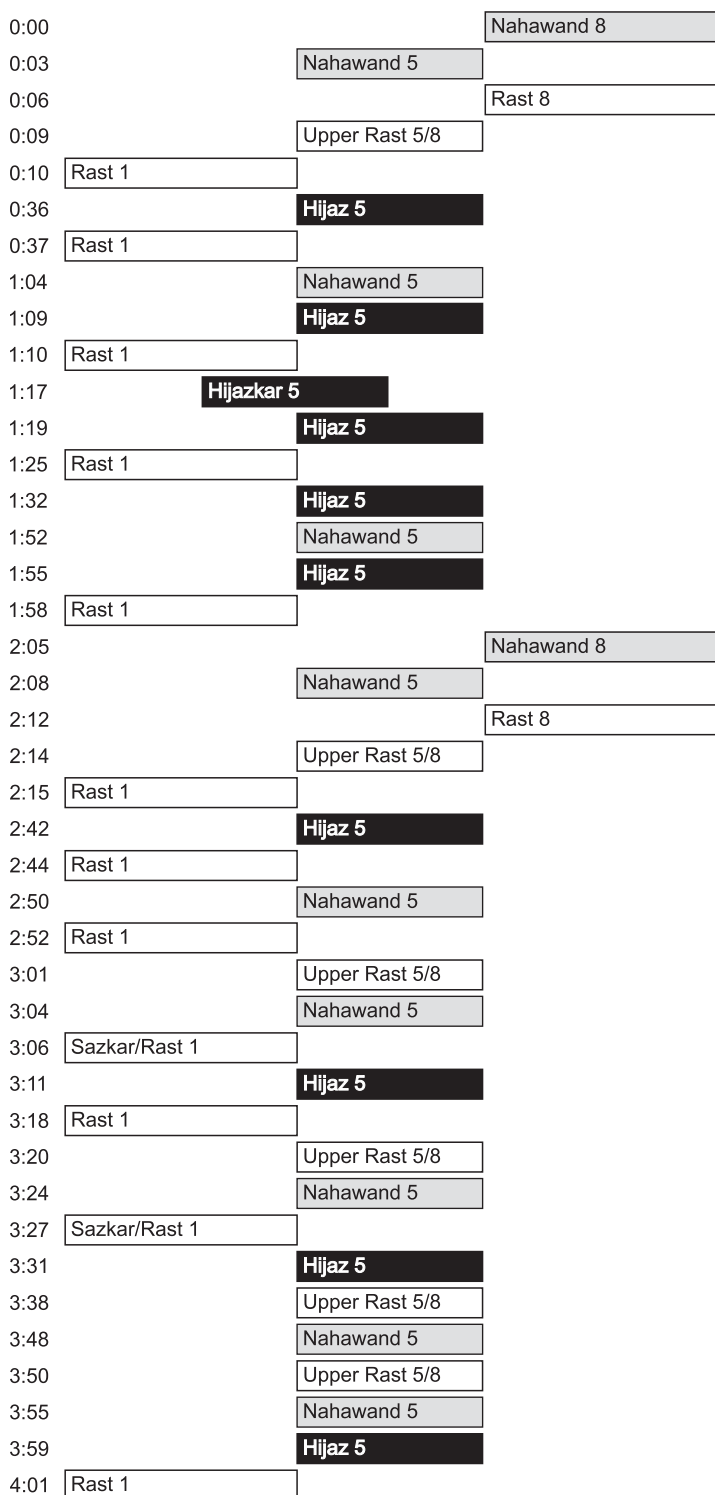


FIGURE 17.6 *Jins-to-jins* analysis of "ya wabur."

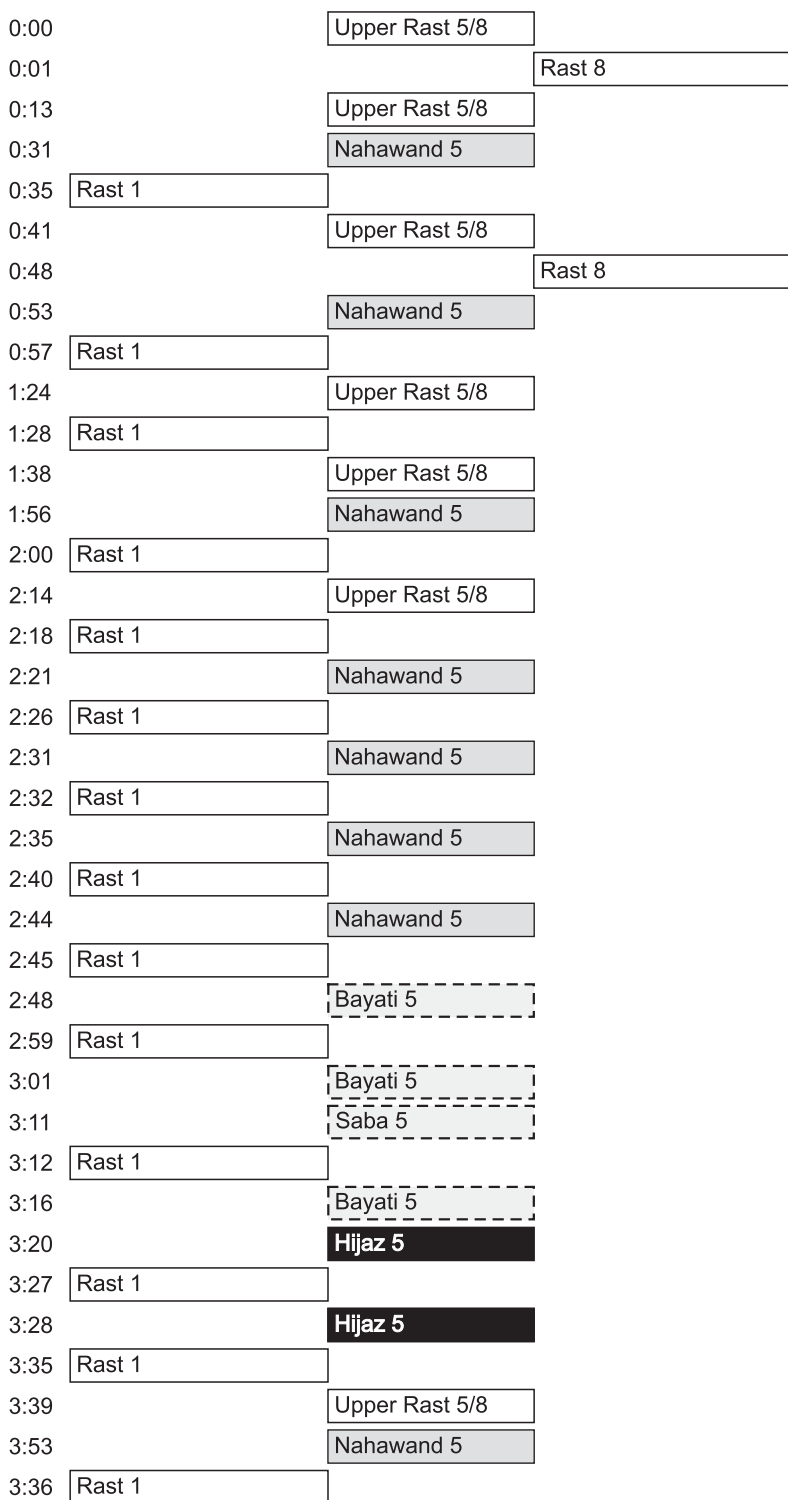


FIGURE 17.7 *Jins-to-jins* analysis of “*ma takhudshi 'ala kida.*”

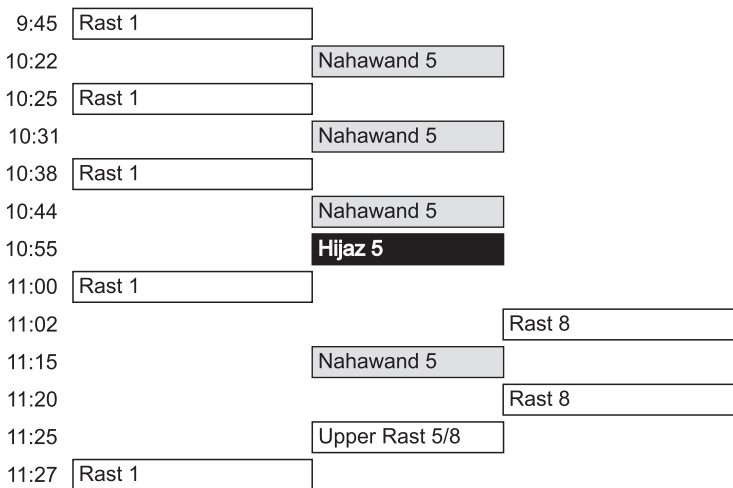


FIGURE 17.8 *Jins-to-jins* analysis of “il-hubbi kullo,” verse 1.

by Marcus;⁵ in those explanations, different *ajnas* occur in particular fixed linear sequences. In reality, there are multiple orders possible, which leads us to the network view of *maqam* structure discussed below.

Second, although the “root” *jins* of the *maqam*, Jins Rast on the root tonic (“Rast 1”), occurs at the end of many sequences and at the end of each song, there are multiple ways to get to Rast (it follows Upper Rast 5/8, Nahawand 5, and Hijaz 5 in different sequences).

Third, the upper, secondary *ajnas* to the *maqam* can follow each other without returning to the root *jins*. This last point is an important one for understanding one of the main problems with the traditional conception of modulation.⁶

⁵ Marcus summarizes the description offered by one of his teachers in Cairo for the sequence used in Maqam Nahawand as follows: “If there is any more explicit verbalizing, it might be a naming of the sequence of tetrachords: A Nahawand tetrachord on C, then the two upper tetrachords, Kurd and Hijaz on G, then a Nahawand tetrachord on the upper octave C, returning, perhaps with the Kurd tetrachord on G and finally closing on the tonic” (2015b, p. 285). Marcus also quotes D’Erlanger’s description of Hijaz: “The performance of this mode starts from the first tetrachord . . . and after showing this tetrachord there is a descent to the note Yakah with a Rast tetrachord . . . then an ascent to play sometimes a Rast tetrachord on Nawa and sometimes a Nahawand tetrachord, following this is an ascent to play Nahawand on the note Muhayyar and from there” (1989b, p. 38). Finally, in his article on Maqam Bayati Marcus (2002) provides a sequence of *ajnas* that form, for him, a clear progression, after which he makes what we feel to be unwarranted claims of a “functional” melodic practice, in which each *jins* performs a specific function within the *maqam*. In our view, the expectation of *ajnas* following each other, built in oral tradition by repeated listening, can give the false impression of both fixed sequences (because aural expectation is a real phenomenon) and functions—in part because of the particular characteristics of individual *ajnas*. But this is an illusion resulting from the network structure, in our view. The reality is both much simpler and more flexible: *ajnas* can move in multiple possible sequences, governed by multiple possibilities of aural expectation. Function is simply a misunderstanding of expectation, which is fundamentally based on arbitrary sequences, repeated enough times to develop in listeners the sense of expected movement.

⁶ As described in Marcus’s earlier writings (1989a, 1992).

If we believe that Maqam Rast looks like figure 17.9,



FIGURE 17.9 Maqam Rast represented as a scale made up of two *ajnas*.

or even that it has “two different versions” depending on whether melodies are ascending or descending (a typical explanation), as shown in figure 17.10,

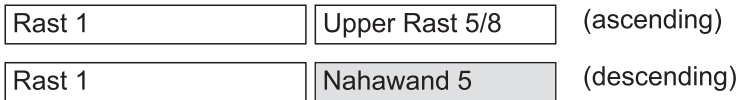


FIGURE 17.10 Maqam Rast represented as two scale alternates, ascending vs. descending.

then if we encounter Jins Hijaz on 5, we must have modulated to Maqam Suznak. Taking the scalar understanding of *maqam* seriously, we should expect modulation sequences always to occur as shown in figure 17.11.

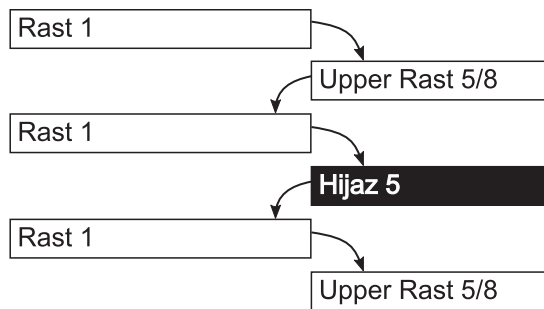


FIGURE 17.11 Modulation sequence in Rast using full scales to modulate.

In other words, the change of the upper *jins*, in that case, would always occur as part of a reference to the full “Maqam Suznak scale”; Jins Rast 1 would always serve as the reference or go-between for other *ajnas*. That’s not what we find; instead we see sequences like those in figures 17.12 and 17.13.

As a final observation, the high frequency of Jins Hijaz modulations, intertwined and in different sequences with the other *ajnas*, suggests that this *jins* is actually part of the core melody of Maqam Rast. (Marcus corroborates the fact that in practice, most musicians understand that upper *jins* modulations are part of, rather than separate from, the prevailing *maqam*.⁷)

⁷ Marcus (1989b; 2002; 2007, p. 23; and 2015a, p. 283).

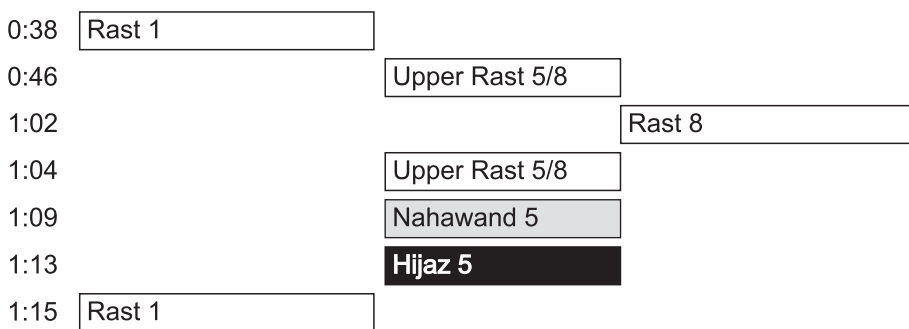


FIGURE 17.12 Jins sequence from "hayrana leh."

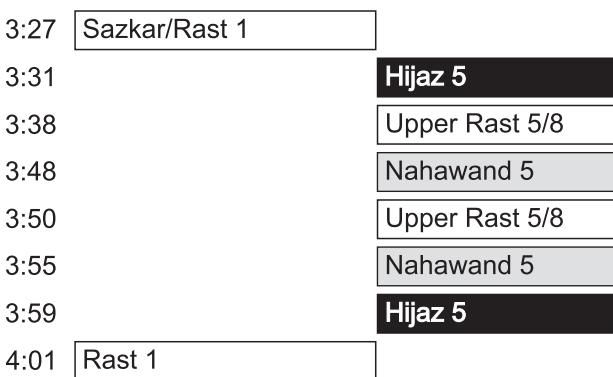


FIGURE 17.13 Jins sequence from "ya wabur."

Listening to all four of these pieces together, we can begin to see that despite stylistic differences, all four feel like the same *maqam*. So what happened to Maqam Suznak? As shown in chapter 18: The *Maqam* Scale, there are *other* songs in which Jins Hijaz on 5 is much more dominant than it is in these songs, occurring at a frequency closer to the frequency with which Nahawand and Upper Rast occur here.

Finding the Right Metaphor

How we conceptualize melody is largely metaphorical. "High" and "low" for pitches are metaphors, using a visual/spatial reference to represent differences in pitch frequency. A scale is often visualized as a staircase, another metaphor. *Maqam* itself is a metaphorical word for position, which in Arabic is used for social class position as well as position in a melodic scale. Examining the metaphors more closely can help us critique the analysis and the theory; finding a better metaphor that is more analogous to the musical reality can help us conceptualize *maqam* more clearly.⁸ Let's consider the strengths and weaknesses of several metaphors.

⁸ Here we follow the view advanced by Lakoff and Johnson (1999, 2003) that cognition is highly conditioned by metaphor. The metaphors forming the basis for music theory explanations are—like all the

THE STAIRCASE

The staircase is a great metaphor for a scale; we can go up and down. We reach the top and come back down again. But Arabic melodies don't only behave this way; there are lots of other kinds of motion.

THE CHAIN

We can represent the motion among *ajnas* as links in a chain. The benefit of this approach is that we can analyze sequences that go beyond the 8-note scale more effectively, for example:

Rast 1--Hijaz 5--Nahawand 8

In this example, the chain analogy helps us understand why we might encounter Nahawand on the octave above Rast, because it is actually linked to Hijaz 5, and in Maqam Hijaz, Jins Nahawand is the most common *jins* to occur on the 4th scale degree above Jins Hijaz.

However, the chain metaphor has the same problem as the staircase metaphor in that it is *linear*. Actual Arabic melodies, as we see from the examples above, don't only move up and down the *ajnas* in a linear sequence, even if it appears abstractly that these *ajnas* are stacked above each other or chained together.

THE TREE WITH BRANCHES

This metaphor is commonly used to explain *maqam* families. According to the metaphor, *maqamat* in the same family share the same trunk (what we've referred to as the "root *jins*" of the *maqam*), and the different branches represent the variant upper *ajnas*. This metaphor is great for understanding that in a typical Arabic song, the root *jins* doesn't change, but there are numerous upper variants. It is also useful for understanding the relationship among different *maqamat* that share the same bottom *jins*.

The weakness of this metaphor is that it doesn't allow for movement between branches without going back to the trunk; the branches aren't connected to each other. This was the third point we raised when observing the preceding examples (that upper *ajnas* can move among each other without reference back to the bottom *jins*), and the problem with the metaphor is analogous to the problem with conventional theory, which views the full scale as the primary unit rather than the *jins*.

metaphors embodied in cognition—largely unrecognized and unquestioned. We attempt to examine them more closely here in order to give a clearer picture of the *maqam*. In addition to examining existing metaphors, we have developed additional metaphors in chapters 19–22, as conceptual aids.

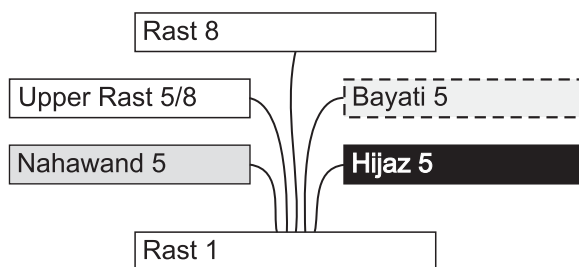


FIGURE 17.14 The “Tree with Branches” metaphor used to describe a *maqam* family.

Representing Maqam Rast as a tree based on the examples above, we would have something that looks like figure 17.14, which is more or less the visualization traditionally used to describe *maqam* families.

THE SUBWAY MAP

The subway map metaphor captures two things very well. First is the sense that the motion among *ajnas* in a *maqam* can be viewed metaphorically as a kind of journey, traveling to multiple stops and then returning home. Second, in a robust subway system there are multiple pathways among major hubs, as shown in figure 17.15.

Other advantages of this metaphor are the fact that there is more than one hub (unlike the tree, which has only one trunk), there are several hubs with multiple connections, and there are peripheral hubs with few connections (like the occurrence of Jins Saba 5 in “*ma takhudshi ‘ala kida*” or Jins Nahawand 8 in “*ya wabur*”).

The disadvantages of this metaphor are not as significant as those already mentioned, but they are worth mentioning. In the subway map in figure 17.15, there are many stops in between hubs that have only one path in or out (e.g., 23rd Street on the 1 train), which is not usually true among *ajnas* in *maqam*. In other words, the *maqam* system is *more densely connected* than the subway map, with more lines among *all* of the stops. The second disadvantage is that the subway map is more static than the *maqam* system. It took nearly 80 years to add a 2nd Avenue Subway Line in New York City after it was first proposed in the 1940s, but in that same time period the *maqam* system has undergone dynamic changes.

THE HOUSE WITH ROOMS

The late New York-based Armenian ‘ud player Haig Manoukian came up with his own metaphor to describe the *maqam* system to students: he viewed a *maqam* as a house with many rooms. Everybody, both those living in the house and their guests, spends a lot of time in the main living room. This, for Manoukian, was the main *jins* of the *maqam*. There are other rooms off the main room, up the stairs, and even in



FIGURE 17.15 The New York City subway system in midtown Manhattan, shown before the Second Avenue line was built.

the basement, which people visit less frequently. These are the secondary *ajnas* to the *maqam*, whether they occur above or below the main *jins* or even on the same level.

This metaphor shares the strengths and weaknesses of the Subway Map metaphor. It captures very well the fact that there are multiple areas, and multiple possible pathways among them, and some rooms that are more important than others. However, a house is a much less dynamic entity than the *maqam* system.

THE NETWORK

Though it is more of an abstraction than the previous metaphors, the network structure has become easier for most people to visualize. Not only do more elements of modern life explicitly involve systems that are linked through complex networks,

but we have also begun to understand the network structures underlying many naturally occurring systems. Social relationships can be represented as a network among people; spoken language has been shown to be based on a network system (with words being hubs and possible sequences of words being the links); and the brain is a network of neurons linked through synapses.⁹ And of course, we have the internet, with its complex network of hyperlinks. All of these networks have a number of characteristics similar to the *maqam* system: there are multiple hubs; there are numerous pathways to get from any hub to any other; and any two hubs, no matter how apparently distant, can be linked through a short pathway with a small number of steps (the “six degrees of separation” phenomenon of global population).¹⁰

Each *jins* can be represented as a node in the network (a box), and each sequence of one *jins* to the next can be represented as a connection (a line). Taking into account all of the possible sequences from one *jins* to another occurring in the songs analyzed here, we get the network shown in figure 17.16.

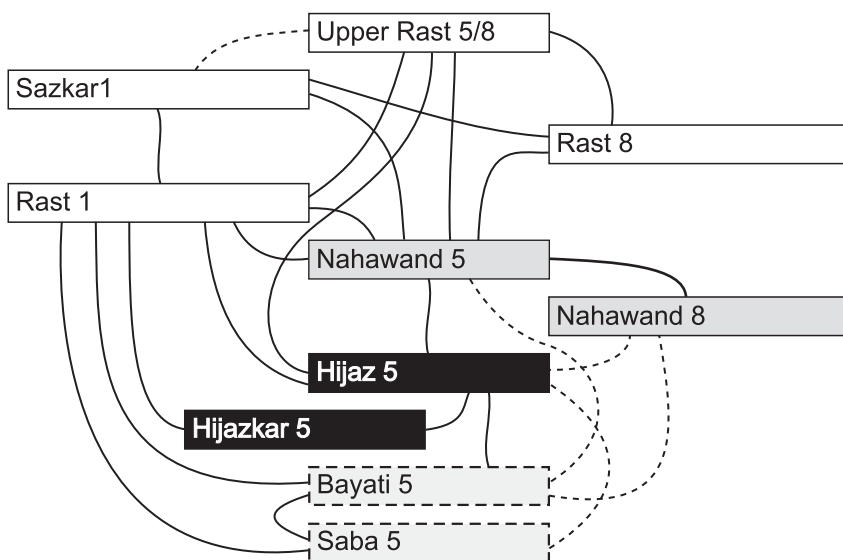


FIGURE 17.16 The network metaphor used to explain the Maqam Rast family. The dashed lines represent connections that did not occur in the five songs analyzed here, but that do occur in other songs and improvisations in Maqam Rast.

⁹ Strogatz (2003); Watts and Strogatz (1998).

¹⁰ Abu Shumays (2013) makes the claim that the *maqam* system is an example of a “Small-World Network,” which has the characteristic of short pathways even in a large and complex system. In the late 1990s this type of network was defined mathematically by Stephen Strogatz and others and discovered to occur in a large number of natural systems (as summarized accessibly in Strogatz, 2003). In future research, we hope to demonstrate that the *maqam* system has this mathematical structure not just among *ajnas* but also among the units of melodic vocabulary.

The dashed lines in figure 17.16 represent connections that didn't occur in the five songs analyzed here, but that do occur in other songs and improvisations in Maqam Rast.

We can make several observations:

- While Jins Rast 1 is clearly the most important hub of the network (with eight direct connections, to all the other *ajnas* except Nahawand 8), Jins Nahawand 5 is almost equally important, with seven direct connections.
- Hijaz 5 also has seven direct connections (five if we only count those that occurred in the examples above).
- Upper Rast 5/8, which in the traditional theory is considered the most important upper *jins* for Maqam Rast, actually has fewer connections than Nahawand 5 or Hijaz 5 (five connections, only four if you count those that occurred in the examples).
- Finally, even the more peripheral *ajnas* (Saba 5, Nahawand 8, Hijazkar 5, and Sazkar 1) have multiple connections.

The longest path length occurs between Saba 5 and Nahawand 8: it takes three steps using the links that occurred in the examples, but only two steps if we include the dashed connections.

There is one more *jins* that occurs quite frequently in Maqam Rast, which was left out of this network because it didn't occur in the examples above: Jins Sikah 3. This *jins* has links to Rast 1, Sazkar 1, Nahawand 5, Hijaz 5, Bayati 5, and Upper Rast 5/8.

One important characteristic of Arabic music becomes clearer when we look at this network structure: infinite possibility and variation resulting from a finite collection. In other words, even though the network has a finite number of nodes and a finite number of connections, there are an infinite number of different sequences that can be produced, simply by following different pathways in different orders. In this way, it is possible for each song/improvisation/*maqam* pathway to be unique from every other, while at the same time sounding similar enough to other songs using the same *maqam*. These unique compositions can be clearly identified as one unified group having the same overall melodic shape, just like the five songs analyzed here.

This characteristic of *maqam* is common to spoken language. Although there are a finite number of words in any individual's vocabulary, every sentence he or she utters is new and unique, and an infinite number of sentences could be produced that still remain comprehensible within the language. This phenomenon is easy to visualize through reference to the network structure of both *maqam* and spoken languages.

Modulation and *sayr* are two important concepts necessary to understand more fully the structure of *maqam*. Although we cover these two concepts in a lot of detail in the following chapters, here we offer a brief introduction to how they fit into our understanding of *maqam*.

Modulation

Modulation is the process of moving from one place to another in music. It involves a shift of perception: the melody resolves to a different note, hence the feeling of resolution (to a note called a “tonic”) changes. In chapter 13 we redefine the concept of *jins* to emphasize the importance of resolution (“tonicization”) within it. Modulation, then, is the movement from one *jins* to another: the shift of tonicization. While there are numerous specific techniques to accomplish that (discussed in chapter 19: Modulation), the movement from *jins* to *jins* is its essence.

In the traditional theory, modulation is viewed as a process outside of *maqam*: there are *maqamat*, and the music modulates from one to the other. Instead, we view modulation as being part of the fundamental *inner* structure of *maqam*. Take “*hayrana leb*”: in the first 4'23" of the song there are 40 modulations, averaging one every six seconds. The longest time spent in one *jins* is from 1'41" to 2'44", slightly more than a minute in Jins Hijaz—and this is longer than any other period in any of the other four songs. Something that happens so frequently must be a fundamental component of *maqam*, not something extraneous to it. Clearly *maqam* can't exist without modulation.

We have defined a *maqam* as being a pathway among a small set of *ajnas*; the pathways are the modulations from one *jins* to the other. Hence Maqam Rast, as defined by the musical example above, is the *ajnas* Rast, Upper Rast, Hijaz, Nahawand, Rast on the octave, and a few others, along with the modulations among them.

This begs the question: Can music modulate from *maqam* to *maqam*? What does that look like if a *maqam* already has modulation from *jins* to *jins* built into it? The answer is yes, with two caveats. First, modulation from *maqam* to *maqam* is difficult to perceive or understand before one has a clear sense of what the core *ajnas* within every *maqam* within the system are.¹¹ This is because a modulation from *maqam* to *maqam* looks at first like any other modulation from *jins* to *jins*, until one realizes that the music has moved to a new *jins* that isn't part of the identity of the original *maqam*. Second, the phenomenon is extremely rare in the older, more traditional

¹¹ Although that perception may very well be implicit for listeners and musicians immersed in the system. By “understand” we do not mean “intellectualize” or “conceptualize”; we mean something more like “to have experience of.”

Arabic music, and very rare in any shorter song. In Egypt, Muhammad Abdel Wahab was almost the only composer in the early 20th century to utilize *maqam-to-maqam* modulations. Later, with the invention of the long-song (*ughniya*—very popular in Umm Kulthum’s repertoire post-1948) in the mid-20th century, the technique became more fully developed as a way to give greater structure to compositions that were 30–60 minutes long.

Sayr

Sayr is a concept that describes the overall melodic direction of a *maqam*. The concept is not fully developed in traditional theory, where it mainly refers to whether the melody tends to start at the bottom or the top of the scale, and whether it goes up or down before resolving at the end. But despite that lack of depth in analysis, the concept is very thoroughly manifested by the repertoire itself. Although there are many possible ways to travel through the core *ajnas* of a *maqam*, a closer look reveals that there are dominant pathways that give the music an overall sense of direction.

If we were to refine our network metaphor by looking back at the musical examples, we would see that among the wide variety of options for traveling through the *ajnas*, there are a few common sequences that are repeated over and over, sometimes identically and sometimes with slight variations. So the network drawing, to be more accurate, would show some pathways as being much thicker (more heavily trafficked) than others.

“*Hayrana leh*” and “*ya shadi al-alhan*” both follow very similar pathways; they open at the octave with Jins Upper Rast and pass through Nahawand and Hijaz on the way down to a resolution to Rast 1. This pathway is repeated over and over with variations (including the minute-long passage in Jins Hijaz in “*hayrana leh*”), and it is that overall direction that is the *sayr* of this version of Maqam Rast. It’s not just a descending scale as the traditional theory would put it, but an emphasis on Upper Rast, Nahawand, and usually Hijaz (with particular emphases on the lowered 7th and lowered and raised 6th scale degrees), that defines the *sayr* (as shown in figure 17.17).

The other three songs reveal a different *sayr* for Rast. Although “*ma takhudshi ala kida*” starts with an opening improvisation that copies the descending *sayr* of



FIGURE 17.17 *Jins* sequence from “*hayrana leh*.”

“*hayrana leh*,” and “*ya wabur*” starts with an instrumental melody that has the descending *sayr*, both of these songs, along with “*il-hubbi kullo*,” actually use a different *sayr* for most of their main melody. This alternate *sayr* for Maqam Rast starts with the root Jins Rast and ascends to the 5th, typically using modulations to Nahawand and/or Hijaz 5, before briefly reaching the octave with Upper Rast and coming back down again, usually with Nahawand. While it is true that we could simplify this by saying that the *maqam* has an “ascending *sayr*,” in fact a close look at the repertoire overall reveals that there are specific *ajnas* and specific melodies that are a core part of the *sayr*; it is not simply about a direction (see figure 17.18).

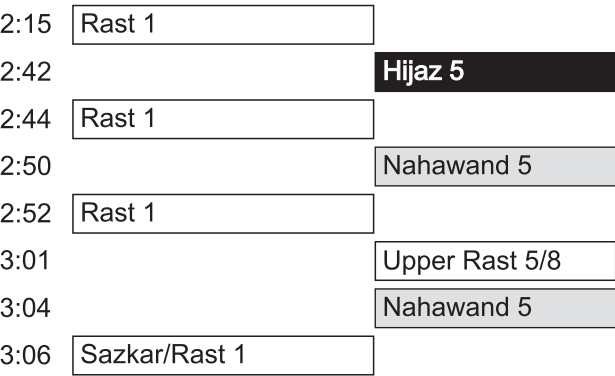


FIGURE 17.18 *Jins* sequence from “*ya wabur*.”

In fact, melodic vocabulary is a key part of the identity of *sayr*. Specific opening and closing melodies provide the identity of the *maqam*, allowing for a certain degree of variation and ornamentation. The student wishing to truly understand *sayr* and *maqam* must actually learn the fundamental melodic vocabularies of each *maqam*, a process that can only be done by ear. This is because the real expression of *sayr* is the sense of aural expectation regarding which *jins*/melody is going to come next. This sense of expectation is built from years of hearing music that has similar sequences and similar melodies.

This higher-level sense of expectation ingrains in listeners and musicians particular longer sequences of *ajnas*; *maqam* then becomes not just a sequence of *ajnas*, but rather a sequence of these larger-scale, multiple-*jins* sequences. To sum up: modulation is the process of moving from one *jins* to another, and *sayr* is the expectation of certain typical sequences. These phenomena are the core building blocks of *maqam*, as shown in table 17.2.

TABLE 17.2

Core Building Blocks of the <i>Maqam</i> System	
<i>Jins</i>	An area for melody with a distinct identity
Modulation	A motion from one <i>jins</i> to another
<i>Sayr</i>	A typical sequence of modulations/larger melodic pathway
<i>Maqam</i>	A larger melody network built from multiple <i>sayr</i> -s

THE MAQAM SCALE

THIS AND EACH of the following chapters develop a particular view of *maqam*—and we rely on different metaphors to help understand each aspect. The metaphor underlying this chapter is the scale as a chain. We intend that metaphor in two senses. First, the *maqam* scale is built by a chain of intervals linking pitches, which are fixed in size and sequence regardless of transposition (this is already the widespread understanding of scale). Second, and particular to Arabic music, *ajnas* (groupings of 3, 4, or 5 notes, described in chapter 13: The *Jins*) are chained together, linked by their tonics and *ghammaz*-s (important notes of emphasis) to build full *maqam* scales. Readers may not even realize the metaphorical nature of the scale, since it is such a common and unexamined way of thinking about music (see chapter 17: The *Maqam* for a comparison of different metaphors).

The *Maqam* Scale

Traditionally, each *maqam* is based on a scale, a set of notes arranged in a well-defined order and tonal intervals. *Maqam* scales are usually heptatonic (made of 7 notes that repeat at the octave), although in a few cases *maqam* scales may extend beyond 8 notes. In addition, a few *maqam* scales do not achieve octave equivalence at the 8th note.

The tonic (or 1st note) in a *maqam* scale is called *darajat al-rukuz* (the point of stability/the resting point) in Arabic. The octave below the tonic (and sometimes the tonic itself) is called *qarar* (the bottom/floor). The 8th note or octave is called *jawab* in Arabic (literally, the “reply” or “response” to the tonic).

The *maqam* scale, like the *jins* scale fragment, has the same exact sequence of intervals regardless of what note it is based on. For this reason, a *maqam* scale is recognizable to the trained ear regardless of its choice of tonic. More important, *ajnas* that make up a *maqam* scale stand out individually and are quickly recognizable from their intervals. Even when a *jins* is used as a building block in dozens of *maqam* scales, its individual character is still salient.

The Standard Tonic

The concept of standard tonic for a *jins* is discussed in chapter 13, and the same concept applies to *maqam*. As part of a *maqam*’s teaching tradition, *maqam* scales are usually notated on a specific tonic, reflecting the most common tonic used to perform that scale. For example, Arabic music theory references always list the Rast *maqam* scale as starting on C. This doesn’t mean that the C tonic is mandatory, but the C version is the prototypal version to teach and study this *maqam*, as discussed in chapter 12: Notation.

The *maqam*’s standard tonic is usually identical to that of its root *jins*. This convention is broken in some cases where, for historic reasons, a transposed version of a *maqam* scale is recognized under a different name. For example, although Maqam Rahat al-Arwah is rooted in Jins Sikah (whose standard tonic is E♭₄) and has the same interval sequence as Maqam Huzam, it acquired a distinct identity with a mandatory tonic of B♭₃. Other examples of *maqam* scales with mandatory alternate tonics are the transpositions of Maqam Hijazkar, officially anchored on C₄, to G₃ (Shadd ‘Araban), D₄ (Shahnaz), and A₃ (Suzidil).

Transposition

Transposition (called *taswir* in Arabic; literally “creating an image”) is limited for *maqamat* as a result of its being limited for a *maqam*’s constituent *ajnas* (discussed in detail in chapter 13). Each *maqam* scale primarily uses three or four comfortable tonics in practice, mainly because of instrument tuning.

The real challenge with limited *maqam* scale transpositions is matching a singer’s comfortable vocal range. This is because the playable choices of *maqam* tonics are often separated by thirds or fourths. For example, Maqam Bayati’s standard tonic is

D, and it is also commonly started on A or G, but asking an ‘*ud* or a violin player to play Bayati on C# or B would not be a welcome proposition. The same goes for the *nay*, unless the *nay* player is really well equipped and has the right *nay* for that transposition. With the Arabic accordion and the *buzuq*, the problem is even worse because many transpositions are physically impossible to perform, due to the lack of selective “quartertone” notes.

Often the singer’s ideal tonic falls somewhere between two comfortable transpositions, especially if the singer’s vocal range is not very wide. And while being able to transpose a *maqam* scale by one tone could mean the difference between hitting and not hitting that high (or low) note for a singer, such a transposition might not always be achievable. In these cases, deciding the tonic becomes a matter of negotiation, the outcome of which has a lot to do with the singer’s clout. The more important the singer, the more the ensemble will be willing to accommodate, sacrificing comfort and ergonomics.

One very common solution for dealing with this issue is changing the string instruments’ tuning altogether. In a majority of cases, the tuning is moved down by one or two semitones (since that would be mechanically safer than moving up for string instruments). Of course, string instruments like the ‘*ud* and violin cannot entirely retune for a three-minute song, then tune back at the end of the song, as such a tuning exercise could take as long as the song itself. For this reason, retuning is usually done for an entire recording session or a live performance. Alternatively, some players (e.g., the ‘*ud* and the violin) may bring two instruments that are tuned differently and use them in different pieces.

Retuning an ensemble down explains why it is sometimes difficult to match the intonation of a recording to any of the *maqam*’s usual tonics. This practice was so widespread in Egypt in the 20th century that tuning down a whole step acquired the name “*tabaqa sughayyara*” (lower pitch, literally “small register”), while concert pitch was called “*tabaqa kebira*” (higher pitch, literally “large register”).

Chaining *Ajnas*

Each *maqam* scale can be built by chaining together two (or in some cases three) *ajnas*. The *maqam* gets its intervals, melodic behavior, and overall mood from these constituent *ajnas*. The first *jins* always starts the *maqam* scale with its tonic at the 1st degree, and the second *jins* starts at the *ghammaz* (modulation point) of the first *jins* (usually the top note of its scale fragment). If a third *jins* is used, its tonic coincides with the second *jins*’s *ghammaz*, and so on.

The simplest and by far the most common example of such a *jins* chain is one that combines a 4-note *jins* with a 5-note *jins* (in either order) to make an 8-note *maqam* scale. For example, figure 18.1 shows the combination of the Nahawand 5-note *jins* in the first position and the Hijaz 4-note *jins* in the second position, resulting in the Nahawand *maqam* scale.

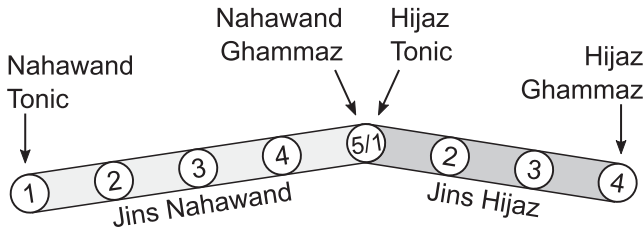


FIGURE 18.1 An example of *jins* chaining: Jins Nahawand chained to Jins Hijaz results in the scale for Maqam Nahawand.

Most *maqam* scales made by chaining a 4-note and 5-note *ajnas* (in any order) have “octave equivalence,” meaning that melodies (and scales) are duplicated at the octave. Because a perfect fourth and a perfect fifth add up to an octave, it is easy to repeat the bottom *jins* at the octave, starting the same scale again (just as in Western scales).

Some chains require a third *jins* to reach up to the octave, when the first two *ajnas* don’t add up to 8 notes. This means that the 8th scale degree is part of the third *jins* in the chain and may or may not be an octave of the tonic. For example, the chain of *ajnas* making up the Huzam *maqam* scale is Sikah + Hijaz + Rast. In this case Jins Rast (the third *jins*) starts on Hijaz’s *ghammaz* (the 6th scale degree of the *maqam*), and the 8th scale degree matches the tonic’s octave, as shown in figure 18.2.

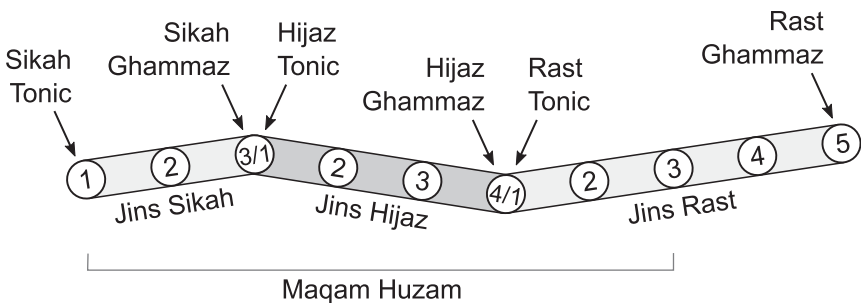


FIGURE 18.2 An example of chaining three *ajnas*: Jins Sikah, Jins Hijaz, and Jins Rast form the scale for Maqam Huzam.

The Bayati Shuri *maqam* scale also needs a third *jins* to reach the octave and may or may not have octave equivalence, depending on which *jins* is used on top (see figure 18.5 in the following section).

Maqam Saba's scale is built by chaining Jins Saba (with Jins Hijaz¹ on its 3rd), and either Jins Nahawand or Jins 'Ajam on the 6th scale degree. Because Jins Hijaz usually has Jins Nahawand on its 4th scale degree, Jins Nahawand on the 6th is the primary variant of Maqam Saba, resulting in an 8th scale degree that is a half step below the octave. Jins 'Ajam on the 6th is the most typical next modulation, and it brings back the octave 8th scale degree, but the primary variant of the Maqam Saba scale is the one with the lowered 8th (see figure 18.8 in the following section)

Some melodies even use a chain of *ajnas* that is not historically cataloged as a *maqam* scale. A good example is from Umm Kulthum's long-song "*siret il-hubb*" (composed by Baligh Hamdi), in which the phrase "*w leil 'ala babo*" descends the 10-note scale made up from chaining together the *ajnas* Sikah + Bayati + Hijaz. This sequence, shown in figure 18.3, would be the same as having the Bayati Shuri *maqam* scale starting on the 3rd scale degree above Jins Sikah. On the other hand, a very similar sequence of *ajnas*, made up of the Sikah + Saba combination, happens to be cataloged as Maqam Bastanikar, as shown in figure 18.4.

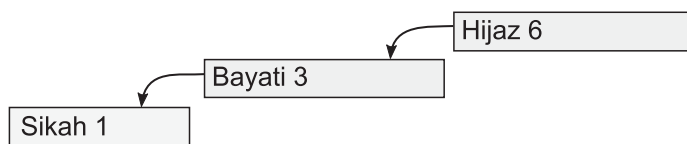


FIGURE 18.3 Descending sequence of *ajnas* used in the verse endings of "*siret il-hubb*."

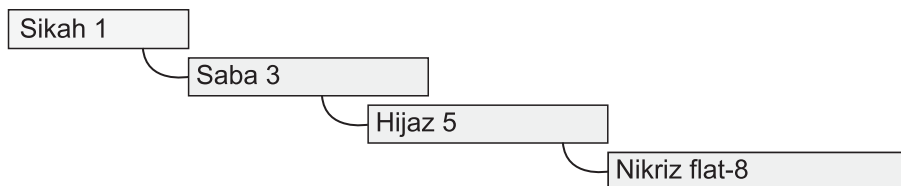


FIGURE 18.4 *Ajnas* forming the core of Maqam Bastanikar.

Although theoretically a very large number of *ajnas* combinations (chains) could exist, this is not the case in practice, because each *jins* has a limited number of typical chaining combinations (another way of identifying "typical modulations" listed with each *jins* in previous chapters). Combining and chaining *ajnas* in the Arabic *maqam* tradition is guided by very tight conventions. Some combinations are favorable and some are not, in reality for arbitrary and purely historic reasons. The

¹ Jins Saba is unusual in that it has an overlapping Jins Hijaz on its 3rd degree, although this Hijaz is not truly tonicized in Saba melodies (see the section Jins Saba in chapter 14: The Most Common *Ajnas*).

best way to learn about the conventions of combining *ajnas* in Arabic music is by listening to a wide number of examples from the tradition.

The “typical” chaining patterns of *ajnas* are another way of looking at the “typical grouping” of *ajnas* in a *maqam*, as shown in the networks at the beginning of chapter 17. The expected *ajnas* that join to each other are partly a result of the conventions of the *maqamat* in which they occur. At the same time, the possible moves within a *maqam* from *jins* to *jins* are partly the result of the typical modulations for each *jins*. The conventions around *jins* movements and overall *maqam* motion are thus fundamentally intertwined.

Octave Equivalence

Most Arabic *maqamat* achieve octave equivalence, at least in current practice. As a result, many musicians (and some theorists) treat nonequivalence at the octave to be the exception to the rule. This is especially true for references² that explain Arabic music theory using Greek tetrachord theory. In these theories, all Arabic *maqamat* are scales of 7 notes, and the 8th note is always an octave of the 1st note, after which the same exact scale duplicates itself in the second octave.

In practice, however, octave equivalence is not the case for a number of *maqamat* scales.³ That doesn’t mean octaves are not important in Arabic music; on the contrary, octaves play a major role in melodies for many *maqamat*. A *taqsim* (instrumental improvisation) in *maqamat* such as Rast, Bayati, and Nahawand uses the octave as a major point of melodic suspense and fulfillment, without which no *taqsim* in these *maqamat* would feel complete.

Octave equivalence most often happens when the *maqam* scale is made up of the combination of 4-note and 5-note *ajnas*, in any order. That does account for the vast majority of *maqam* scales, but not all. As *maqam* scales are made from chaining *ajnas* together (because *maqam* melodies are the result of chaining *jins* melodies together), octave equivalence is in an important sense actually the *result* of chaining 4-note and 5-note *ajnas* together, rather than the *cause* of that chaining. When that type of chaining doesn’t occur, the melody doesn’t treat the 8th scale degree as an octave.

For example, earlier versions of Maqam Bayati Shuri (shown in figure 18.5) treated the 7th scale degree—the *ghammaz* above Jins Hijaz on the 4th scale degree of Jins Bayati—as a more important tonic than the octave, tonicizing it with Jins Nahawand or Jins Rast and treating the octave as the 2nd scale degree above that *jins* tonic.

² Al-Hifni ([1938] 1972); Salah al-Din (1950a).

³ Marcus (1989a, p. 512) catalogs numerous examples of octave nonequivalence.

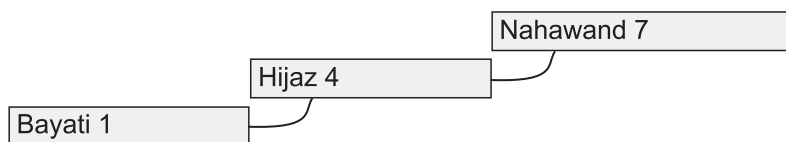


FIGURE 18.5 Archaic version of Maqam Bayati Shuri tonicizing the 7th scale degree with Jins Nahawand, resulting from chaining Jins Nahawand on the *ghammaz* of Jins Hijaz.

Even when the octave is prominent, some *maqamat* have a different *jins* starting at the octave than the one at the tonic, a phenomenon⁴ that was much more common in the *sayr* of *maqamat* in the early 20th century than it is today. For example, Maqam Dalanshin, shown in figure 18.6 in descending form, emphasizes the octave tonic above Rast, but the *jins* surrounding it (Saba Dalanshin) is completely different than the *jins* used on the lower tonic (Rast) and results in the interval between the octave and the note above it (a half step) being completely different than the interval between the root tonic and the second scale degree (a whole step).

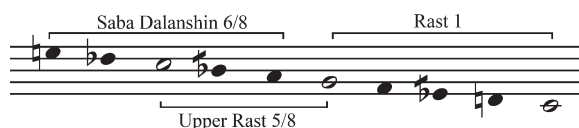


FIGURE 18.6 Maqam Dalanshin scale shown in descending form.

Numerous other examples exist, such as in Maqam Hijazkar, in which versions from the early 20th century frequently used Jins Nahawand on the octave tonic rather than Hijaz (shown in figure 18.7 in descending form), and Maqam Hijazkar Kurd, which opens with Hijazkar on the octave but resolves to Kurd on the tonic. Maqam Kurd, meanwhile, often includes Jins Bayati rather than Kurd at the octave (see the *sayr* diagrams in chapter 24: *Maqam Index* for these examples).



FIGURE 18.7 Maqam Hijazkar version from the early twentieth century, which frequently used Jins Nahawand on the octave tonic rather than Jins Hijaz.

But Maqam Saba remains the greatest exception to octave equivalence, because in its most basic form, its 8th scale degree is a half step below what would be an octave above the root tonic. Starting on its standard tonic of D, Maqam Saba is shown in figure 18.8.

⁴ Marcus (1989a, p. 528) lists modes (*maqamat*) that have nonequivalence at the octave in earlier theory and practice, but have simple octave equivalence in the present-day period.



FIGURE 18.8 Maqam Saba basic scale, showing lack of octave equivalence.

As the fashions changed, and the *sayr* of most *maqamat* shifted over the course of the 20th century to start more frequently at the root tonic rather than at the octave, the majority⁵ of instances of nonequivalence at the octave fell out of use. But Saba remains in this form to this day.⁶

Maqam Families

According to tradition, *maqamat* are classified into families based on sharing the same first or root *jins* (the starting *jins*, according to ascending scalar order). This is because the root *jins*, based on the *maqam*'s main tonic, plays the largest role in defining the *maqam*'s character.

Many Arabic music theory references call the first (lower) *jins al-jidh'* (the trunk) or *al-asl* (the origin), and the second (upper) *jins al-fur'* (the branch), comparing

⁵ Some musicians have attributed the change to the use of microphones, which radically changed vocal styles around the world, allowing singers to sing in a much lower range than when unamplified.

⁶ Marcus attributes the shift to the practice of starting *maqamat* at the tonic (even in *maqamat* that were previously understood to be descending *maqamat*) in part to a new simplified music theory that was taught at all conservatories and schools of music in the Arab world from the late 1930s to the 1940s (Marcus, 1989b, p. 40). Music students were taught a new understanding of the “tonic” note. Previously, Arab theory labeled this note *al-qarar* (the resting point or *finalis*), and indeed, this was and is the case for many *maqamat*: melodies descend and resolve to the tonic. But the tonic was renamed in the new theory as *al-asas*, the basic or fundamental note. This created a new sense of the primary importance of the tonic (an idea from Western music theory), which the students and teachers accepted over time. Marcus provides an example of a teacher at the Cairo conservatory playing a *taqsim* in Maqam Hijazkar in a *qanun* lesson starting at the tonic rather than the traditional octave starting point. This hypothesis is certainly plausible and is undoubtedly part of the story—but it implicitly assumes that theory drives practice, an idea worthy of much skepticism. We are more convinced by the argument that the shift in vocal styles as the result of amplification led to this change, because the change is dramatic and very much in evidence in recordings made during the first half of the 20th century. Furthermore, the vocal practice of Umm Kulthum and Muhammad Abdel Wahab, artists whose career straddled the transition, corroborates our view: they began their careers in the earlier period and used the high registers of their voices, but shifted down to the lower register before it could have been required of them technically due to their age. They were both masters of the theory (at least implicitly) from their earliest recordings and are unlikely to have changed their vocal practices because conservatories, which they did not attend, began to teach the *maqam* differently. But both experienced the dramatic transition from primarily acoustic performance to amplified performance, coinciding with the time period of their dramatic shift in register.

each *maqam* family to a family tree (as discussed in chapter 17). The practice adopted in this book is to call the first and common *jins* the “root” *jins*. “Root” is also a word commonly used in Western music theory to refer to the tonic of a chord or of a composition. Essentially, the root *jins* is the *jins* whose tonic is the overarching tonic of the entire *maqam*, and by extension, of the *maqam* family. Using this classification, eight of the main nine *ajnas* define *maqam* families, while the remaining *jins* (Saba) only gives its name to a single *maqam*.

Maqam families are named after the principal and most widespread *maqam* in the family, which also shares the name of the root *jins* of that family. In turn, many *ajnas* are named after an archaic note name in the historic Arabic 24-tone scale, resulting in cases such as the note “Rast” (C in today’s notation), Jins Rast, Maqam Rast, and the Rast *maqam* family all sharing the same name.

The branch *maqamat* in the same family are based on the use of a different second (upper) *jins*. While *maqamat* actually use multiple upper *ajnas* in the course of their *sayr*, the predominant upper *jins* is the one that distinguishes each *maqam* within a family and matches the traditional definition of the upper *jins* in the *maqam* scale. Even with the expanded definition of *sayr* and *maqam* developed in this book, the traditional scheme is still the one that makes the most sense for classification pur-



FIGURE 18.9 Traditional form of Maqam Suznak.

poses. We can illustrate this principle with a musical example in Maqam Suznak, one of the main branches of the Rast family. Traditionally, Maqam Suznak is defined as the scale with Jins Rast as the first *jins* and Jins Hijaz as the second (see figure 18.9).

The most famous song in Suznak is “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*,” composed by Zakariyya Ahmad for the 1945 film *Sallama*, starring Umm Kulthum. Analyzing it as we do the song examples in chapter 17, the result can be seen in figure 18.10.

In this example, we notice both similarities and differences from the examples at the beginning of chapter 17 (in Maqam Rast).

The following are the major similarities:

- Rast 1 is the root *jins* and ends every major section.
- Hijaz is prominent.
- Nahawand, Bayati, and Saba 5 are all present.
- The *sayr* of moving from Rast 1 up to its 5th scale degree, and emphasizing Hijaz and several other *ajnas*, is in common with several of the songs analyzed in chapter 17 (“*il-hubbi kullo*,” “*ma takhudshi ‘ala kida*,” and “*ya wabur*”).

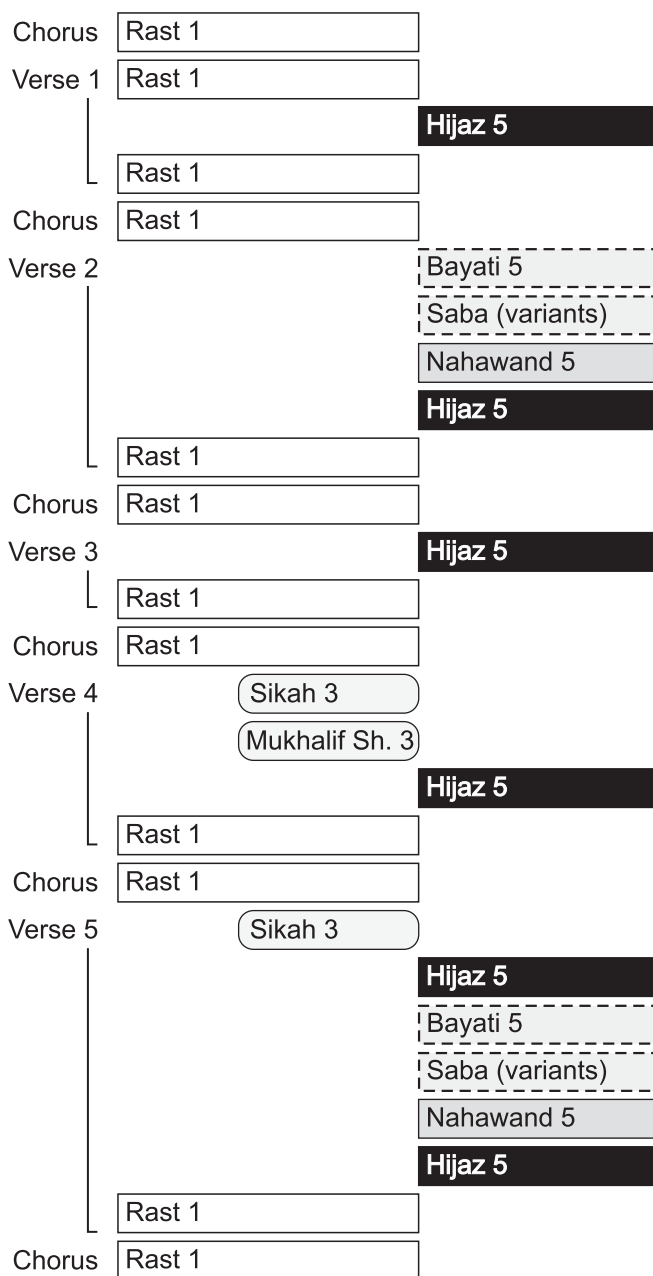


FIGURE 18.10 *Jins* analysis of the *taqtuqa* “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*,” according to its verse-refrain song form, rather than using time stamps.

The following are the major differences:

- Upper Rast $5/8$ doesn't occur at all in "*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*."
- Hijaz is much more prominent in "*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*," preceding the return to Rast in every instance and being the only other *jins* in two of the five verses.
- Jins Sikah 3 (and its variant Mukhalif Sharqi) occur in "*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*," but not in the other examples.

If we were to represent "*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*" as a network of *ajnas*, we would see that the network has a lot of overlap with the network graph shown in chapter 17 for Maqam Rast, but with some differences. In fact, if we were to include Jins Sikah in the Maqam Rast graph because it occurs frequently in other songs in Maqam Rast, we could say that the Maqam Suznak graph is a *subset* of the Maqam Rast graph.

It is typical for longer songs or improvisations in a particular *maqam* to use many (or most) of the different possible secondary *ajnas*, and multiple *sayr*-s. As a result, we can visualize the *maqam* family as a particularly large network, and each "branch" as a subset of that network. Each "branch" *maqam* uses some, but not all, of the pathways of the main *maqam*.

This way of visualizing the *maqam* to understand its larger structure doesn't contradict the traditional concept that there are still versions of *maqamat* with the same root *jins*, but that emphasize different upper/secondary *ajnas*. Therefore, the tree metaphor is still useful to understand the *maqam* family superstructure, and the simplified representation of each *maqam* as a scale built by chaining two primary *ajnas* is still useful for classification purposes.⁷

⁷ Hence in chapter 2.4: *Maqam* Index, we identify each *maqam* both with its traditional scalar representation, using two to three chained *ajnas*, as well as with its expanded *sayr* diagram, through the ideas developed in chapters 17, 19, and 20.

MODULATION

MODULATION IS THE practice of moving from one *jins* to another, and more generally from one *maqam* to another. In Arabic, modulation is called *intiqal*, plural *intiqalat* (moving to, transferring to) or *tahwil*, plural *tahwilat* (transforming into or diverting to). Modulation is the bread and butter of working with the Arabic Maqam and a defining aspect of the Arabic music modal tradition. It is practiced with vocal or instrumental music and composed or improvised music, and it is a must if the musician wants to fully explore the *maqam*'s character and *sayr* (melodic motion/behavior).¹

The journey is the dominant metaphor for *maqam* explored in this chapter, complete with its multiple stops and multiple options for pathways. This metaphor expands the traditional one-dimensional, linear view of *maqam*, exemplified by the chain, into a more two-dimensional, spatial perspective (similar to the subway map metaphor used in chapter 17: *The Maqam*).

Modulation is one area where mastering Arabic *maqam* theory provides the musician with a huge advantage. But learning the theory alone is not enough; modulation (like ornamentation) fits in a long-established aesthetic tradition of what

¹ Marcus identifies modulation as being an essential component of *maqam*, despite being inadequately treated in the theoretical literature (Marcus, 1992, p. 171). He identifies key *jins*-to-*jins* modulations within the *maqam* in (2002; 2007, p. 23; and 2015a, p. 283).

sounds good and what doesn't. Mastering the art of modulation cannot be complete without learning that tradition orally, through attentive listening and imitation.

In fact, the aesthetic tradition, "what sounds good," is just the big-picture view of what is expected and unexpected (and the balance between them), in the context of the many modulation pathways that form a vocabulary for musicians. As we saw from the examples in chapter 17, there are a finite number of typical modulations that are acceptable within a particular *maqam* context (and a few unusual or rare modulations that occur very infrequently). These moves are repeated over and over in songs, improvisations, and so forth. The musician trained orally learns them by hearing them over and over and can execute them even without thinking about it—and the sense of expectation for listeners is also the result of repeated hearing.

Improvisation (vocal or instrumental) is where modulation truly shines, because it is the preeminent tool for displaying musical knowledge and performance experience by a soloist in order to create *tarab* for listeners. Indeed, a large part of learning how to improvise is learning how to modulate. Many musicians reach an acceptably good level in their technique, intonation, ornamentation, and phrasing, but may be handicapped by their lack of modulation skills; in such a case their improvisations would remain lacking. On the other hand, performing unusual or uncharted modulations indicates that the musician possesses advanced experience and knowledge of Arabic *maqam*.

Modulation is one of the principal techniques that capture the listener's attention because it is a more dramatic change than melodic motion within a *jins* or *maqam*. In a *taqsim* (traditional instrumental improvisation), modulation creates anticipation (called *tashwiq* in Arabic) that makes the audience feel to a certain degree as though they're watching a thriller or a football game. "Where will the musician go next?" is the question in (active) listeners' minds. Putting the suspense element aside, a melody that stays in the same *jins* or *maqam* too long often sounds lacking and tedious, as modulation draws from the full palette of *ajnas* and *maqamat* traditionally available. Often, the more of them are showcased in an effective manner, the richer the piece. To use an art analogy, composing or improvising a piece in one *maqam* without any modulations is like painting using different shades of a single color.

A Modulation Analogy

Modulation is like a scenic bus ride from one end of town to the other, then back, going through two-way streets interrupted by intersections, forks, and roundabouts. With the composer or improviser in the driver's seat, the goal of the drive is not to arrive fast or to find the shortest distance to the destination, but quite the

opposite: the drive is about exploring as many beautiful streets as time allows before heading back home.

At every intersection, fork, or roundabout, the bus driver has choices. Some paths are tried and tested, and the driver and the passengers have been over them hundreds of times (and still enjoy them), and some are less traveled. The more experienced the driver, the more he or she will explore less-frequented paths without getting lost and bring the bus back to the safety and familiarity of the more traveled paths.

This is where the driver's skills and knowledge of the neighborhood are a great asset. Some drivers inspire confidence, some don't, and the passengers can totally gauge their experience or feel their hesitation from the way they drive. An experienced driver can intrigue the passengers and create suspense by pausing at some of the big roundabouts and letting them wonder which way they're going next. This game of building expectation (*tashwiq*) can be played for a while as the driver circles the roundabout a few times before finally breaking the tension and exiting into one of the possible streets.

Modulation then is about choice, the choice of which *jins* or *maqam* to engage in next. While exercising these choices within the aesthetic tradition, the musician can chart a route that traverses these *ajnas* and *maqamat* in the most beautiful and personalized way possible.

This is the paradox and challenge for the musician: while the vocabulary of possible choices is mostly fixed as a result of oral tradition, the musician must animate those choices in a way that feels individual and unique in context. This can happen by creating distinctive longer sequences of modulations (as noted in chapter 17, while the number of direct *jins*-to-*jins* modulations is small, the possibilities for longer sequences are infinite). The musician can also use variation and ornamentation to make an expected modulation seem new. Finally, delay is a very important technique that can be used to build suspense and expectation. For example, if one is in Maqam Rast and has already used the *ajnas* Rast, Upper Rast, and Nahawand, listeners will begin to expect Jins Hijaz. Drawing attention to the *ghammas* of Jins Rast (which will become Hijaz's tonic), but delaying the switch of intervals, can create an exciting tension until it is resolved, even if everybody knows that Hijaz is coming.

Understanding modulation in this context makes it clearer why creating entirely new modulations is not an acceptable or common technique, at least in traditional performances. An entirely new modulation doesn't have the same level of expectation around it that can create exciting tensions resulting in *tarab*. When we examine the repertoire more closely, there are very few instances of a single modulation done by a master musician that hasn't been done by others. Master musicians distinguish themselves by the judicious use of extremely *rare* modulations (and by unique longer sequences), in the same way that experienced writers will judiciously use rare

vocabulary (a practice distinct from coining new words). They are therefore displaying deep *knowledge* of the content of oral tradition.

Jins Modulation Techniques

There are two basic *jins* modulation techniques² used in Arabic music:

1. Altering the intervals (changing the *jins*) around the tonic
2. Changing the tonic (which results in a change of *jins*, but may not necessarily result in a change of intervals)

It is worth noting that these same two techniques of modulation are also the techniques used in Western music: modulating from a major scale to a minor scale on the same tonic, or modulating to a new tonic. While the use of harmony in Western music can make the second type of modulation clearer and less ambiguous, there are still many cases in which moving the tonic remains ambiguous. Similarly, the motion from tonic to tonic (and the tension around the root tonic vs. various new tonics) provides a large part of the overall melodic structure of Western compositions. In the abstract, Western music and *maqam*-based music are therefore identical in terms of basic modulation technique and structure, with differences resulting from the much wider range of *ajnas* in use (in the case of Arabic music) and from the use of harmony (in the case of Western music)—and of course differences in the cultural conventions guiding which modulations are acceptable and which are less common.

FIRST TECHNIQUE: ALTERING INTERVALS

As a simple example of the first technique, a melody can start in *Jins Nahawand*, then switch to *Jins Rast jins* on the same tonic, by altering the interval between the 2nd and 3rd scale degrees from a $\frac{1}{2}$ step to about a $\frac{3}{4}$ step (i.e., by raising the 3rd scale degree). The next modulation could switch to *Jins Nikriz*, still on the same tonic, by altering the 3rd and 4th scale degrees. Another very common *jins* modulation is switching back and forth between the *ajnas* Bayati and Hijaz on the same tonic. As you can see from these examples, altering only one note/interval by as little as a quartertone may be sufficient to modulate, although a modulation could also involve changing more than one interval at the same time.

² Marcus (1992). Although Marcus refers to these as *maqam* rather than *jins* modulations (consistent with the oral theory sources he and we consulted), he makes this distinction clear as well.

In this type of modulation, it's worth mentioning that singers or musicians playing instruments that allow fine-tuning of every note (e.g., the 'ud or violin) may need to slightly adjust the tuning of the common notes in the new *jins/maqam*, since they may not sound exactly as they did in the starting *jins/maqam*. For example, the first 3 notes of Jins Nikriz are conceptualized as/notated like the first 3 notes of Jins Nahawand, but do not have the same exact intonation. This correct intonation therefore depends on what *jins* is "active" at the time, a topic that was discussed in detail in chapter 11: Tuning System.

Ajnas with the same size in their basic scale (in other words, *ajnas* sharing the same tonic and *ghammaz*) are more readily able to modulate to one another (e.g., Bayati, Hijaz, Kurd in the 4-note group, or Nahawand, Rast, Nikriz in the 5-note group) than ones with a different size, but that is not a hard-and-fast rule; there are indeed some cases in which modulations between *ajnas* of the same size are rare or avoided (e.g., between Rast and 'Ajam on the same tonic). The opposite is also true: modulations on the same tonic may in some cases go back and forth between *ajnas* of a different size (e.g., from Jins Bayati or Saba to Jins Nahawand). Above all, what makes two *ajnas* compatible for modulation on the same tonic are not abstract and absolute rules, but rather conventions guiding movement from *jins* to *jins* (cultural tendencies that must be learned) and the prevailing aesthetic of working with the *maqam* in question.

Nothing stops a musician from modulating between Rast and Saba on the same tonic, for example, but that would be unexpected in the tradition of urban secular music, whereas it occurs more commonly in Qur'anic chanting. Modulating between Rast and Nahawand, on the other hand, is a long-established and recognizable combination in both traditions that immediately satisfies the listeners' expectations.

SECOND TECHNIQUE: CHANGING THE TONIC

The second technique of modulation is to change the tonic. The most common instance of this technique is moving from the tonic of a *jins* to its *ghammaz*, but many other (secondary) modulation points are possible. The important point to note here is the distinction between *emphasis* and *tonicization*. It is possible, for example in Jins Rast, to emphasize the 5th scale degree above the tonic (its *ghammaz*), but that emphasis in and of itself doesn't guarantee tonicization. Instead, tonicization occurs when the melodic motion makes the listeners feel that a new note is now the tonic—the note of resolution. In other words, it is possible to emphasize the 5th scale degree of Rast, while still maintaining a firm tether to the tonic on the 1st scale

degree. Emphasis of this kind is a very common technique that creates melodic tension resulting from lack of resolution to the tonic.

A simple example of the second technique is to modulate from Jins Hijaz to Jins Nahawand on its 4th degree (the Hijaz *ghammaz*). Here, the new tonic is the Jins Nahawand tonic. This modulation is essential to working within Maqam Hijaz. Another common example is to modulate from Jins Bayati to Jins ‘Ajam on its 6th degree. The new tonic in this case is the Jins ‘Ajam tonic. That modulation is part and parcel of working with the Bayati *jins/maqam*.

Sometimes this type of modulation can be ambiguous, and different listeners or musicians might disagree that a modulation has actually occurred (whereas the first type of modulation is completely unambiguous, because in that type of modulation an interval is definitely altered). This ambiguity is especially common if not very much time has been spent in the “new” tonic area—and for that reason, a definitive shift in tonic takes time to settle in order to change the listener’s perception of where resolution occurs. The more time is spent resolving melodies to the new tonic and creating notes of tension around that tonic, the clearer the modulation becomes.

A common instance of such an ambiguity occurs in Maqam Bayati, when the melody uses notes starting with the 4th scale degree (the *ghammaz*) and above. Some melodies may extend from the 4th degree to the flat 6th scale degree above the Bayati tonic, while maintaining a strong feeling of tonicization on the root. A conventional analysis would automatically assume that a modulation to Jins Nahawand had occurred, but then it would be impossible to make the distinction between this type of melody and a melody using the same notes (4-5-6 above the Bayati tonic) that truly tonicizes the 4th degree and results in an actual modulation to Jins Nahawand. Relying on the ear’s sense of resolution is a better guide and reveals this weakness in conventional *maqam* theory.³

Within the context of a full *maqam* performance, it is possible for listeners to maintain the sense of the original tonic or to feel that there is more than one tonic present simultaneously; this creates another kind of tension within the larger-scale melody of the *maqam*. Experienced musicians are often expert at creating this kind of tension and using it to give shape to the full performance, delaying the feeling of complete resolution until the end of a *taqsim*, *mawwal*, or song, which results in a greater experience of *tarab* for the listener.

³ It is for this reason that Abu Shumays argued (2013) that the definition of a *jins* must be expanded beyond the conventional tetrachord to account for melodies that maintain a sense of the tonic but stretch outside the 4 or 5 notes traditionally used to define the *jins*. See the discussion of the extended scale in chapter 13: The *Jins*, which Abu Shumays called “*jins* baggage” in 2013.

COMBINING *JINS* MODULATION TECHNIQUES

Of course, in a full exploration of a *maqam* that occurs within a composition or improvisation, a combination of these two modulation techniques is used. One very typical basic sequence might start from a *maqam*'s tonic, with the melody exploring its first *jins*, then moving to a second *jins* starting on the *ghammaz* (using the second technique of modulation), then modulating to another *jins* on that same new tonic (using the first technique), then returning to the original *jins* and resolving on the *maqam*'s tonic. For example, the melody can be anchored in Maqam Hijaz and start by developing Jins Hijaz starting on the root tonic, then it can visit Jins Nahawand on the *maqam*'s 4th degree (the *ghammaz*, turning it into a new tonic), modulate to Jins Rast on the same new tonic, then resolve back to Jins Hijaz on the original tonic. This type of extended pathway is the bread and butter of a *maqam*'s *sayr*.

The Mid-*Jins* Switch

One method of executing the first *jins* modulation technique is to play part of a *jins*, then switch halfway (on the same degree) to another *jins*, then complete the phrase using part of the other *jins*. The “mid-*jins* switch” therefore involves two *ajnas* that share the same tonic and *ghammaz* (i.e., they start and end on the same notes).

The most widespread example of a mid-*jins* switch is from Jins Hijaz to Jins Bayati on the same tonic, in a descending motion switching on the 3rd degree (see figure 19.1). Using a tonic of D, instead of descending G-F#-E♭-D as a straightforward Hijaz phrase, the melody switches from the Hijaz 3rd degree (F#) to the Bayati 3rd degree (F) and continues with F-E♭-D. The lateral switch from F# to F may sound like a chromatic accidental in a melody, but to the trained ear it is a clear switch from one familiar *jins* to another. This classic mid-*jins* switch is used in Umm Kulthum's “*fat il-ma'ad*” (1967, composed by Baligh Hamdi) and is shown in figure 19.2.

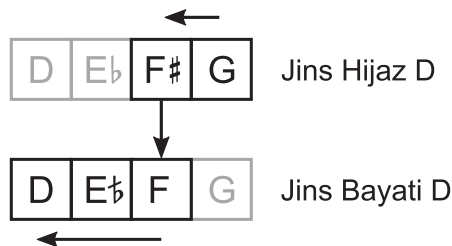


FIGURE 19.1 A mid-*jins* switch in which the descending melody switches from the 3rd degree of Jins Hijaz to the 3rd degree of Jins Bayati.

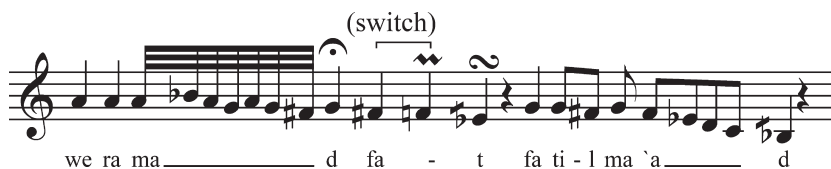


FIGURE 19.2 A mid-*jins* switch example from Umm Kulthum’s “*fat il-ma’ad*,” in which the descending melody in Jins Hijaz switches to Jins Bayati on the 3rd degree above Jins Sikah.

The manner in which the musician switches between *ajnas* makes all the difference in how listeners perceive it. The switch has to be exploited fully to achieve the biggest dramatic effect, and that means doing it slowly and clearly. In the preceding example, it is customary to slide from the F# to the F and tease the audience for as long as possible. Instruments that allow continuous sliding between notes (e.g., the violin, the *nay*, and of course the human voice) are best suited for this.

The mid-*jins* switch can have a very powerful effect on the melodic flow; it creates tension between the two *ajnas* and their moods. It also plays on the listeners’ expectations and teases them, since before the first *jins* is even complete the melody takes them to another one. Experienced listeners recognize a *jins* as it starts with the first (or the last) 2 notes, and they can be pleasantly surprised when the melody slides to an entirely new mood.

Exploiting Overlapping *Ajnas*

It is possible to use the second *jins* modulation technique (altering the tonic, without altering the intervals) to exploit a new *jins* (or *jins* fragment) that overlaps the starting *jins*. This means that the starting *jins* shares some of its intervals with a whole or a part of another *jins*. For example, the 3rd, 4th, and 5th degrees of Jins Rast’s basic scale share the same (notated) pitches as the 1st, 2nd, and 3rd scale degrees of Jins Sikah. (The intonation might not be precisely the same in the two *ajnas* and would be fine-tuned by the musician according to which *jins* is active.) Because of this overlap, it is possible to modulate from Jins Rast to Jins Sikah on the 3rd degree (which is neither its tonic nor its *ghammaz*) and fully exploit Jins Sikah’s *sayr*, including modulating to related *ajnas*.

An interesting special case of exploiting overlapping *ajnas* occurs in Jins Saba Dalanshin, whose tonic (note of melodic resolution) is on its 3rd scale degree. In this *jins*, the 3rd to the 6th degrees share the same (notated) intervals with the basic scale of Jins Hijaz. A modulation of Jins Saba Dalanshin to Jins Hijaz therefore occurs on the same tonic, without altering any intervals. Despite not altering the tonic or the intervals, such a modulation is nevertheless apparent because of its phrasing, as well as the use of the Hijaz *ghammaz* on its 4th degree and the choice of *ajnas* modulations from that note. This modulation can be heard prominently in the *khana* of the *muwashshah* “*mala al-kasat*” (in Maqam Rast) by Muhammad ‘Uthman.

Accidentals and Modulation Hints

When working with a *jins* or *maqam*, its *sayr* sets a clear expectation of its habitual pathways and possible modulations (as discussed in detail in chapter 20: *Sayr*). This means that if a note in a melody falls outside these confines, it is heard and noticed. While many accidentals can be an expected part of the melodic course, in the subtle language of melodic music, hitting an unexpected note outside a *maqam* scale is a wink to the listener.

Accidentals can be very eloquent and succinct, and sometimes while the melody is in one particular *jins*, a musician may hint at a modulation. Hinting is done by playing 1 or 2 notes from a new *jins* without fully developing it. The bus driver in our metaphor seems to be saying, “Here’s one street where I could go, but I won’t,” and the trained ear can immediately react to that hint from just 1 note.

Accidentals add a lot of color to a melody without overwhelming it with too many full modulations. But they have an even more useful role in ornamentation in which the accidental is too short to be part of the melodic line but long enough to ornament the melody.

Perhaps the most established and overused ornamentation of this kind is to hint at Jins Saba from Jins Bayati, by touching the Saba 4th note instead of the Bayati 4th, without ever completing Jins Saba. Another all-time favorite accidental is hinting at Bayati Shuri from Bayati, by touching the Bayati Shuri 5th note instead of the Bayati 5th, then going back to regular Bayati without ever fully modulating on Bayati Shuri. A similar example is to hint at Nahawand Murassa‘ from Nahawand, by briefly touching the Nahawand Murassa‘ 5th degree instead of the Nahawand 5th degree. Some of these accidentals are well-established clichés in their own right (in the starting *jins*) and are no longer truly a conscious hint at a modulation to another *jins*.

This raises an interesting question about accidentals and modulation hints: What would it take to consider them actual modulations? The answer really depends on the amount or length of their melodic development, and the correct analysis may be partially a subjective judgment call, in limited cases. A brief accidental is a hint, whereas using the accidentals for a whole melodic phrase could be considered a modulation. However, at the end of the day that classification is largely academic, and the use of accidentals under any label is melodically pleasant and conveys a familiar message to listeners.

Jins Pairs

As noted previously, Bayati can hint at Saba with just a slight accidental (by lowering of its 4th scale degree), and Nahawand can hint at Nahawand Murassa‘ by lowering

its 5th. The ease of moving among these pairs of *ajnas* also means that a full-fledged modulation, and not just a hint or accidental, is also possible and easy to accomplish. For example, the following five pairs of *ajnas* modulate in this way:

Bayati	↔	Saba (by lowering the 4th)
Nahawand	↔	Nahawand Murassa' (by lowering the 5th)
Sikah	↔	Mukhalif Sharqi (by lowering the 3rd)
Rast	↔	Sazkar (by raising the 2nd)
Hijaz	↔	Hijazkar (by raising the 7th underneath the tonic)

The *jins* on the left is the more common one, and the one on the right can be viewed as a less common variant (even though they do have distinct identities). Of these five, the Rast-Sazkar pair is the least common in contemporary practice, though it was extremely common in the first few decades of the 20th century.

Because these modulations are so easy, wherever the *jins* on the left appears in the *sayr* of a *maqam*, the *jins* on the right could potentially substitute for it (and in the examples shown in chapter 17, these Saba, Sazkar, and Hijazkar substitutions all occurred). While these substitutions do occur in songs in the repertoire, they are much more common in *taqasim* and are exploited to demonstrate a musician's mastery as well as to play on the subtle variations in mood that occur from these minor changes. However, they can also be overused by careless improvisers, disturbing the clarity of the *sayr* and the sense of *tarab*.

Readers might wonder why Nahawand ↔ Nikriz isn't included in this list. Ironically, even though the modulation from Nahawand to Nikriz only involves the alteration of one accidental (the 4th of Nahawand is raised to get Nikriz), this substitution isn't as common as one might think. Even more important, the substitution is quite rare when Nahawand functions in a secondary context—except on the 4th scale degree in Maqam Hijaz. While it does occur occasionally, it is not the kind of fluid swapping that occurs in these other cases; rather, it tends to create a more pronounced, dramatic contrast.

Transitional Melodies

The examples of mid-*jins* switches and melodic accidentals highlight a principle of modulation in general: that it relies on specific melodic motions to transition from one *jins* to another. How this happens may not be immediately clear to the beginner or intermediate musician. Perhaps he or she has already started to absorb the melodic vocabulary and idiomatic phrases of individual *ajnas* and while performing in one *jins* is able

to sound traditional and convincing. But when attempting to modulate to another *jins*, there may be an awkward passage before a new *jins* is established.

In fact, modulation is also dependent on melodic vocabulary, just like a *jins*, and that modulation vocabulary must be learned phrase by phrase before a musician has full command of a *jins* or *maqam*. Each modulation that is typical within the tradition, including all of those previously described (Rast to Hijaz on its 5th scale degree, Bayati to Hijaz on the same tonic, etc.), has typical phrases used to establish it. These phrases may be simple and quick, or they may be elaborate. And as with all melodic phrases that make up the *maqam*, the individual performer has room to personalize, elaborate, ornament, or otherwise alter the phrase, as long as its basic identity is preserved. Nonetheless, tradition and convention guide the ear of the experienced musician, and looking more closely at musical examples reveals that most similar modulations use similar, or nearly identical, melodies from musician to musician and from composition to composition, demonstrating that musicians have absorbed these modulation melodies by ear just as deeply as they have absorbed the melodies that define each *jins*.

This book is not the place to attempt to catalog all of the typical modulation melodies, any more than it attempts to catalog all of the melodies used in each *jins*. But it is important to keep in mind that modulation, like *jins*, is not an abstract phenomenon that can be described with a few rules or descriptions of intervals; it is actually a rich and fully elaborated part of the *maqam* system. Readers who wish to understand modulation more deeply must immerse themselves in listening and practice because, while the outlines can be sketched here, the details are too numerous to list, and they are essential to masterful performance and true appreciation.

Jins Versus Maqam Modulation

In traditional *maqam* theory, the conventional view of modulation is that it always occurs from *maqam* to *maqam*.⁴ As such, many references equate a *maqam* to a 7-note scale that repeats at the octave and only discuss modulation as occurring between a 7-note scale and another 7-note scale (either on the same tonic or a different one). But if we listen more closely to melodies in the traditional repertoire, it becomes apparent that modulations rarely involve a full *maqam* scale (as we saw in the songs analyzed in chapter 17: *The Maqam*). This is because the vast majority of

⁴ Marcus highlights the distinction of modulations within a *maqam* vs. modulations to other *maqamat* in his more recent writings (2002, briefly in 2015a, and 2007), while his earlier works (1989a, 1992) do not make that distinction.

melodic phrases in Arabic music are confined to the range of just a few notes (unlike in Western music, which frequently has melodies that use a whole scale or jump-up scales using arpeggios). As such, the majority of modulations in Arabic music can best be understood as modulations from *jins* to *jins*, rather than from *maqam* to *maqam*.

The idea of modulating from one whole *maqam* to another suggests something else that doesn't actually occur in the vast majority of modulations: the development of a new *maqam*'s *sayr*. Once we understand that a *maqam* cannot be reduced to a scale of two *ajnas*, but includes numerous additional secondary *ajnas* and conventional pathways among them (its *sayr*), we can see that each individual modulation doesn't usually bring all of that along with it. If in fact the new *maqam*'s *sayr* is fully covered, then we *would* be justified in describing a modulation as one to a new *maqam*. But since most modulations do not go so far, it makes much more sense to think of them as being from *jins* to *jins*. And since both types of modulations *do* actually occur (although those from *maqam* to *maqam* are much rarer), we lose the ability to distinguish between these types if we refer to *every* modulation as being between *maqamat* rather than *ajnas*.

A special case of the *jins* versus *maqam* modulation ambiguity comes into play when it occurs within a *maqam* family. Every *maqam* in a family shares the same root *jins*, followed by one, or at most two, upper *ajnas*. In traditional Arabic *maqam* theory, any change between the upper *ajnas* is equated with a modulation to another *maqam* within the same family. The exceptions to this principle are *maqamat* that have two variants (two possible upper *ajnas*), both classified—arbitrarily, for historic reasons—under the same name.

For example, in that conventional view of *maqam*, a melody in Maqam Rast that switches the second *jins* from Jins Nahawand to Jins Hijaz, then to Jins Bayati, would be considered to have modulated from Maqam Rast to Maqam Suznak, then to Maqam Nairuz and back. But considering a passing modulation to a different second *jins* as a full *maqam* modulation is too extreme. This is because it is so common for compositions and improvisations in Maqam Rast to include Jins Hijaz on the 5th scale degree, and in fact it makes more sense to consider that *jins* part of the essential *sayr* of Maqam Rast (as discussed in chapter 17).

This excerpt from a previous work by one of the coauthors illustrates this point in detail: “I suggest the following criteria as a way to distinguish *Maqam* Suznak from the use of *Jins* Hijaz within *Maqam* Rast: when *Jins* Hijaz on the 5th above Rast is 1. heavily emphasized as a long-term modulation (as in the second verse of Umm Kulthum's long song “Aruh Li-Meen”), when it 2. takes precedence over the other secondary *ajnas* (as in “Ghannili Shwayya”), or when it 3. opens the melody of the

song or piece (as in the instrumental “Tahmila Suznak”), then we should say we are in Maqam Suznak.”⁵

Modulating to a New *Maqam*

There are instances, much more common in larger-scale compositions (such as those pioneered by the composers for Umm Kulthum starting in the 1940s and reaching their heyday in the 1950s–1970s), of true modulations from *maqam* to *maqam*, each *maqam* being understood in the larger sense of an extended pathway through multiple *ajnas*, rather than simply a scale utilizing two *ajnas*. A deliberate *maqam*-to-*maqam* modulation is much more noticeable than a *jins*-to-*jins* modulation and is often a milestone in the melodic development of a song or *taqsim*. Such a modulation should exercise the new *maqam*’s *sayr* to the fullest.

The first *maqam* modulation technique is to stay in the same tonic and root *jins*, but change the second *jins*. This is a modulation within the same *maqam* family. The grouping of *maqamat* by family is one of the foundations of melodic behavior in Arabic music, because melodies frequently travel between the various branches of one family while remaining grounded in the root. This is by far the most common and straightforward modulation technique between *maqamat*.

An example is going from Maqam Bayati to Maqam Bayati Shuri, or from Maqam Rast to Maqam Suznak. This could be qualified as a mere second *jins* modulation if done very briefly, but if the musician fully develops the new *maqam*, then it can be considered a full *maqam* modulation. As the two are technically the same (scale-wise), listeners have to rely on their ears to judge which one is taking place, just as they do in other ambiguous modulations.

The second *maqam* modulation technique is staying on the same tonic but moving to a new *maqam* in a different family (changing the root *jins*). This is identical to the technique of moving to a new *jins* on the same tonic, but in the case of a true *maqam* modulation, both the original *maqam* and the second *maqam* are fully worked out in their scale and their *sayr*. Like that *jins* modulation technique, these *maqam* modulations also tend to move to *maqamat* that share a *ghammaz* on the same scale degree above the root tonic and/or share numerous common tones. Popular examples include modulating from Maqam Rast to Maqam Nahawand or from Maqam Bayati to Maqam Saba (since the first 3 notes are in common) or from Maqam Nahawand to Maqam Nikriz or Nawa Athar (since the first 3 notes are in common).

⁵ Abu Shumays (2013, p. 243).

The third *maqam* modulation technique is moving to a new *maqam* on a new tonic altogether. The most common way to do this is by moving to the *ghammaz* note of the starting *maqam* (the note where its second *jins* starts) and developing that new tonic fully into a new *maqam*. An example is starting with Maqam Hijaz and modulating to Maqam Nahawand or Maqam Rast starting on the 4th scale degree of the original Maqam Hijaz. Again, this resembles one of the common *jins* modulation techniques—modulating to a new tonic, often the *ghammaz* of the prior *jins*—but the difference lies in the extent of *sayr* development.

The new *maqam* could theoretically start on any secondary *jins* of the original *maqam*, not simply on the *ghammaz*. An example of this type of modulation is from Maqam Rast to Maqam Huzam or Maqam Sikah on its 3rd scale degree. Even though the secondary Sikah *jins* was heard while covering the melodic pathways of Maqam Rast, using it to start a brand-new *maqam* has a dramatic effect because it shifts the listeners' attention to the new tonic.

Maqam Modulations in the Long-Song Genre

The *maqam-to-maqam* modulation techniques just described, which rarely occurred in the traditional repertoires of Arabic music before 1940 or so, became fully developed in the long-song genre. Initially, modulations of this type almost always start with a new *jins* modulation that could be considered part of the *sayr* of the original *maqam*. However, rather than continuing with the *sayr* of the original *maqam*, the new *jins* develops in its own direction to become the root of its own *maqam*, pulling in subsequent *ajnas* that would typically be associated with it. The more these new *ajnas* are truly distinct from the *ajnas* within the original *maqam*, the clearer the full *maqam* modulation becomes. The next few examples clarify this technique.

The long-song “*siret il-hubb*” is in Maqam Rahat al-Arwah, a *maqam* in the Sikah family. The typical *ajnas* forming the *sayr* of Maqam Rahat al-Arwah⁶ are shown in figure 19.3.

However, in “*siret il-hubb*,” *Jins Bayati* is developed into a full version of Maqam Bayati, as shown in figure 19.4, including additional *ajnas*. These additional *ajnas* are clearly very distant from the root Sikah *Jins*; the 3rd degree above Nahawand is a flat third (B $\flat$), roughly a quartertone lower than the octave of Sikah, while the 3rd note above Hijaz is a raised third (B), roughly a quartertone higher than the octave of Sikah. These modulations strongly destabilize the original tonic and allow us to

⁶ Shown here on its traditional key of B $\flat$, although Umm Kulthum recorded “*siret il-hubb*” a step lower.

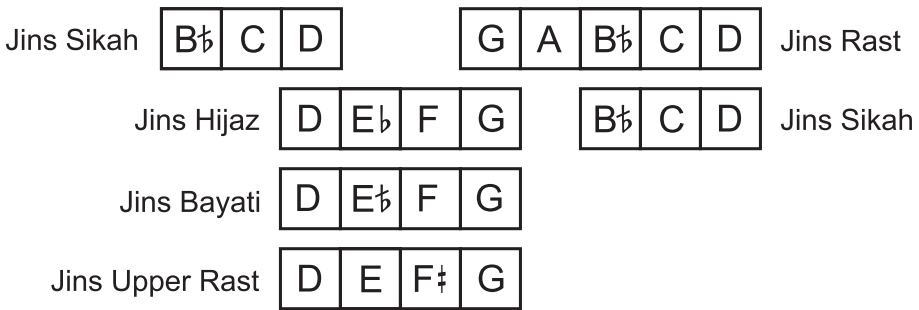


FIGURE 19.3 The typical *ajnas* used in the *sayr* of Maqam Rahat al-Arwah.

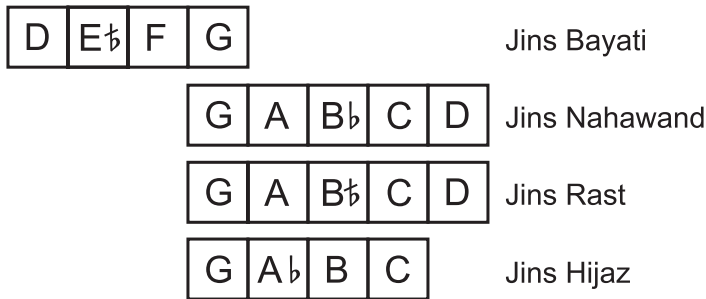


FIGURE 19.4 Typical *ajnas* used in the *sayr* of Maqam Bayati D, expanded from Jins Bayati D, occurring in Umm Kulthum's long-song "*siret il-hubb*" in Maqam Rahat al-Arwah.

feel momentarily that we are in Maqam Bayati, until the eventual return to the root Jins Sikah of the whole composition.

Although the distinction between *jins-to-jins* and *maqam-to-maqam* modulations was never identified in traditional theory, making that distinction here offers a level of clarity about how complex compositions can be put together. Each individual *maqam* can be viewed as a particular kind of journey, to return to our bus metaphor, one that has a number of expected stops along the way. Listeners and musicians very familiar with traditional repertoire and traditional improvisations expect many of these stops to occur. They are not, in and of themselves, detours from the journey, or tangents from the story told by a *maqam*. But they can *become* detours, and we can feel that we're being taken on a bigger journey, by starting at one of the expected stops to travel to other areas that are close to it but not part of the originally scheduled journey. In the network view of *maqamat*, this would be equivalent to using two overlapping networks—the original *sayr* network of the first *maqam* overlapping (through one or two common *ajnas*) with part of the *sayr* network of another *maqam*—to construct a larger network or a larger pathway/journey through the two networks.

This type of *maqam-to-maqam* modulation definitely allows for a greater degree of creativity in terms of modal structure (the large-scale structure created by "*siret*

il-hubb” is unique in the repertoire, and that is true of many of the long-songs composed for Umm Kulthum and her contemporaries and successors). Yet at the same time, because the traditional *sayr* of many *maqamat* is large enough already, these detours don’t feel so dramatically outside of the tradition. On the level of the individual *jins*-to-*jins* modulations that occur within these larger *maqam*-to-*maqam* shifts, they are mostly typical local modulations, using the typical melodies associated with such modulations.

As a result, these longer compositions were accepted by listeners in the Arab world in the 20th century as part of the tradition, as much as they were innovative. More important, because of the connection to traditional paths of modulation among *ajnas*, the connection to *tarab* was preserved (via the continual use of expectation and surprise), and these long-songs enabled Umm Kulthum, in particular, to have a new vehicle for an enormously powerful large-scale experience of *tarab*.

Tradition Versus Innovation

Arabic music fits within an aesthetic tradition (one that progresses gently), and this tradition defines what is aurally pleasant and what is not. Modulation in Arabic music is like cooking in a regional cuisine; there are many ingredients, and they’re all delicious and interesting, but people don’t go about mixing these ingredients willy-nilly.

At the center of the tradition are very common and tried and tested modulations. These are the highways in the scenic drive metaphor. Then there are less frequent modulations, only practiced by experienced musicians. These are the one-way streets and alleyways in the metaphor. Then there are previously uncharted modulations only undertaken by the very experienced musicians. These are the equivalent of driving the musical bus in the metaphor on a dirt road and having the confidence to bring it back safely to the main road.

Infrequent modulations are riskier, especially during an improvisation, because the performer needs to plan a smooth, plausible, and pleasant melodic return to the starting *jins/maqam* while creating beautiful melodies in the new *jins/maqam*. The more common the modulation, the easier it is to achieve that. Musicians with enough clout (such as Muhammad Abdel Wahab) can introduce a new modulation idea, and if they use it enough times, they can make it part of the tradition going forward.

Marcus discusses the tension between wanting to sound traditional and the desire to innovate: “Additionally, while composers and improvisers generally stay within tradition (not trying to be ‘out there,’ in the manner of some jazz musicians), there is always the possibility that an insightful musician might present a *maqam* in a new

way. Depending on the reception of that novelty, it might over time be adopted into the mainstream understanding of the mode, or it might be rejected and continued only in that musician's performances."⁷

If we were to collect statistics about modulation usage in the Arabic repertoire, we would certainly find that some modulations occur more than others. The more a musician becomes experienced and listens to the masters, the more he or she may use rare and unusual modulations (although the musician may equally well decide to stay with the tried and tested and find his or her own voice within that). Of course, some musicians will push the boundary further and come up with their own new ideas for modulation. Listening to a *taqsim* and hearing a brand-new modulation idea can be fascinating for an experienced listener. In a live concert, that could cause an uproar among the crowd.

Enjoyable and interesting music includes a combination of tried and tested modulation formulas and a small dose of exploration. Too much familiar material can become repetitive. On the other hand, venturing too much outside the tradition can sound too experimental and foreign. A good Arabic musician knows how to find the right balance.

⁷ Marcus (2015a, p. 281).

SAYR

SAYR (LITERALLY, “COURSE” or “motion” in Arabic) is the expected and habitual melodic behavior of a *jins/maqam*. *Sayr* is the body of traditions, aesthetics, and conventions used by musicians when “working” (composing/improvising) with a *maqam*. It includes correct intonation, ornamentation aesthetics, habitual phrases, melodic pathways, and possible modulations, which together give each *maqam* its unique character and identity. Composed songs express a *maqam*’s *sayr*, but improvised melodies, whether vocal or instrumental, are the best vehicle to fully showcase it.

Using a linguistic analogy, learning a *maqam*’s *sayr* to its full extent is the equivalent of achieving fluency in a language, which includes learning its rich vocabulary, correct grammar, idiomatic expressions, pronunciation, and accent.

Sayr is sometimes translated as “melodic development,” which may suggest that the *maqam*’s melodic course in a composition or improvisation is developed from scratch or in a completely original manner. However, this is not at all the case. Instead, when creating traditional Arabic *maqam* music, a musician is navigating the *maqam*’s traditional melodic pathways (called *sikak* in Arabic, sing. *sikka*; literally, “rail/path”), established by consensus through decades of communal performance.

At face value, losing the ability to create free-form melodic compositions in a *maqam* sounds limiting. In practice, however, compositions in traditional Arabic

music are as prolific, rich, diverse, and personalized as they are in any other musical tradition. What is gained from adhering to an established and habitual melodic course is the constant reenactment of a *maqam*'s familiar character and the constant revisiting of its established melodic pathways. Only that familiarity can ultimately lead to *tarab*.

Thus, familiarity or custom is the metaphor for *maqam* underlying the explanations in this chapter. Familiarity breeds expectation, from the high frequency of some journeys to the rarity of others. This metaphor adds the dimension of time to the spatial dimension of the metaphors for modulation: the time to develop that familiarity and those expectations; the time over which a custom or tradition is established; and the greater or lesser time spent in different parts of a journey within a single piece of music.

With the concept of *sayr*, we can begin to understand the bigger picture of *maqam* and melody within Arabic music. The *jins* is the smallest unit of melody, in which phrases use the range of just a few notes and tonicize only one note. Modulation begins to expand melody outside of a *jins*, moving from one *jins* to the next. *Sayr* answers the next question: What is the large-scale structure of a melody, from the beginning to the end of a composition or improvisation?

As a result, *sayr*, even in this most general sense, can be very important in differentiating two *maqamat* that may share the same tonal intervals but are transposed versions of one another. This is the case with the *maqamat* Nahawand and Farahfaza, for example. Often one of these *maqamat* is a guest that was incorporated into Arabic music from a neighboring tradition (Farahfaza is originally Turkish). In this case, the guest *maqam* may still retain some of its historic *sayr* peculiarities and have a slightly different *sayr* than its Arabic version sharing the same intervals.

Another great example of a vastly different *sayr* for *maqamat* sharing the same scale occurs between Maqam 'Ajam 'Ushayran and Maqam 'Ajam.¹ In the archaic Maqam 'Ajam 'Ushayran, the *ghammaz* is the 3rd scale degree, while in Maqam 'Ajam (as used in Egypt in the 20th century) the *ghammaz* is on the 5th, similar to the *maqamat* Rast and Nahawand. The secondary *ajnas*, melodic pathways, and overall direction of the two 'Ajam *maqamat* are also both completely different.

¹ We feel that, in addition to the dramatic differences in *sayr*, there are also some slight differences in intonation between these two versions of 'Ajam, with 'Ajam 'Ushayran using a higher, Pythagorean third above the tonic, and the more modern version of 'Ajam using a slightly lower, more variable major third, reflecting different positions within the Pythagorean skeleton determined by oud tuning (see chapter 11). The lack of a huge body of repertoire in these *maqamat*, and their infrequency in contemporary practice, makes this claim more difficult to substantiate, but it is certainly clear when 'Ajam Ushayran occurs as a secondary *jins* on the 6th scale degree of Maqam Bayati.

Documented *Sayr*

Many Arabic music theory books from the 20th century have attempted to formally document the *sayr* of each *maqam* to varying levels of detail. We reviewed over a dozen references² from 1904 to 1993, published in Syria, Lebanon, Egypt, and beyond, to compile a summary of what aspects of *sayr* have been documented.

The vast majority of books did not go beyond focusing on a *maqam* scale and therefore made intonation their primary concern. Books from the first half of the 20th century mostly used a list or a table with Arabic/Persian notes to describe the scale, while references from the second half of the 20th century used Western notation that divided the scale into 24 equal intervals (or combined that with Arabic/Persian notes). Some references used a single octave, while others covered two, and some references defined different scales for the ascending and descending directions.

Marcus summarized the state of documented *sayr* in Arabic theory as follows: “When present-day Arab music theory introduces each *maqam*, it usually limits its attention to three structural features: a single-octave scale transcribed in staff notation, analysis of the intervals in each scale in terms of quartertones, and tetrachordal analysis.”³

The preoccupation with defining correct intonation sometimes went beyond specifying notes by name, as some references⁴ used absolute frequencies to define each note’s pitch, supplemented with commas (borrowed from Turkish *makam* notation) and fractions/ratios to define each interval in the scale. To his credit, al-Sabbagh included qualitative instructions to aid the learner in achieving correct intonation of a *maqam* scale, by “slightly” raising or lowering the pitch of specific notes⁵ (presumably relative to how these notes are normally played).

Starting from the mid-20th century, references started describing the two primary *ajnas* making up each *maqam* scale, either by mentioning their name and starting note or by superimposing them on the notated *maqam* scale itself. Al-‘Abbas also described secondary *ajnas* superimposed over the *maqam* scale with its primary *ajnas*.⁶ Some discrepancies over *ajnas* names or sizes exist among the references examined.

² al-Khula'i (1904); al-Hifni ([1938] 1972); Allah Wirdi (1948, 1964); Salah al-Din (1950a); al-Shawwa (1950); al-Sabbagh (1954); al-Hilu (1965); Fath Allah and Kamel (1974); al-‘Aqili (1976); al-Jabaqji (1988b); al-Mahdi (1993a, 1993b).

³ Marcus (2007).

⁴ Allah Wirdi (1948); al-Sabbagh (1954).

⁵ al-Sabbagh (1954).

⁶ al-‘Abbas (1986).

Sayr definitions proper appear when some references define the *jins* or note to start from when “working” with the *maqam*, which direction (upward or downward) to use for melodic traversal, and what note to end the melody on (usually the tonic). Some references⁷ pointed out notes of emphasis in each *maqam* scale, while others⁸ suggested customary *jins/maqam* modulations from the current *maqam* scale.

Problems in Documenting *Sayr*

When reading the body of *sayr* guidelines and conventions documented in Arabic music theory books, one might think that all Arabic music students faithfully study them and apply them in their compositions or improvisations. This is not the case, for many reasons.

First, *sayr* conventions were not standardized in Arabic music throughout the 20th century. Even different references from a similar time period did not document the same exact *sayr* for each *maqam*. This is not surprising, since the same gap exists in the standardization of *jins/maqam* names, scales, and intonations. This goes back to the fact that Arabic music has never been a homogenous body; instead it is rich and diverse due to its many local traditions. Therefore, it is very challenging for any music theory book to faithfully capture that richness.

In addition, Arabic music theory was still somewhat intertwined with Turkish music theory for a few decades after the fall of the Ottoman Empire; therefore, it would have been difficult for a music student of the early 1900s to find a reference strictly on Arabic *maqam sayr*. Some Arabic references⁹ explained a *maqam*’s foreign origin (often with a Persian name), described its historic *sayr*, then presented the Arabic deviation into a local *maqam*, clearly illustrating the Arab musicians’ continued involvement in both the Arabic and foreign traditions.

Documenting the melodic course of every Arabic *maqam* gradually started becoming obsolete toward the second half of the 20th century, after Arabic music had experienced a huge renaissance (the Golden Age), and defined itself as a clearly separate entity from its sister traditions (Turkish/Ottoman and Persian). Explicit and rigorously documented *sayr* conventions were to a great extent a legacy from these two traditions, which to the present day maintain their own detailed *sayr* conventions to a much greater extent than Arabic music does.

⁷ al-Shawwa (1950); Allah Wirdi (1948).

⁸ Allah Wirdi (1948); al-Sabbagh (1954); and al-Hilu ([1961] 1972).

⁹ al-Khula’i (1904); Allah Wirdi (1948).

The bigger problems inherent in documenting *sayr* are the same ones that arise in attempting to commit any other aspect of Arabic music (e.g., intonation, ornamentation, or phrasing) to writing:

1. The inadequacy of written language and notated music in capturing full aural detail, and
2. The variability over time and geography.

We have discussed elsewhere the inadequacies of notation to communicate intonation and ornamentation in Arabic music. These musical elements are much like accent, tone, and idiom in spoken language, and while they can be documented in recording, documenting them in written form strips them of an enormous amount of information and detail. The problem is compounded when we deal with larger-scale structures such as typical melodic phrases (which in addition to including details about intonation and ornamentation also include rhythmic components) and larger melodic movements. What tends to happen in documented *sayr* is the reduction of these melodic movements into much broader, more generic steps. But the reality of the melodic motion is that the bigger picture includes all of the smaller details as well, so that any inadequacies of notation are amplified and compounded.

The second problem is that these musical elements change with time and place (and even to a certain extent from performer to performer). *Sayr* is fashion, and any work documenting that fashion as absolute can quickly become outdated when that fashion inevitably changes. For example, many *maqamat* in the early 20th century began their melodies at the octave and descended eventually to the root tonic, but over the course of the 20th century a *sayr* starting from the lower root tonic, ascending, and then descending again became much more common (see the discussion in chapter 18: The *Maqam* Scale).

For all of these reasons, Arabic music theorists gradually moved away from explicit *sayr* instructions and started abridging them, dropping them altogether or even criticizing them. In *Falsafat al-Musiqa al-Sharqiyya*, Mikhail Allah Wirdi illustrates this last direction: “Finally, it’s clear that such confining [*sayr*] rules would result in all Farahfaza melodies sounding like the same pattern. For this reason, free thinkers tend not to abide by these rules and conventions, rather they prefer to sail in the limitless sea of art, seeking creativity and searching for beauty. . . . If one were to explore contemporary compositions, they would find too many variations to list in this book.”¹⁰

¹⁰ Allah Wirdi (1948, p. 390).

Sayr conventions that were codified in detail in a 1930s book, for example, became archaic and fell out of favor by the mid-20th century. They are useful to a limited degree to someone trying to learn Arabic music theory and history, but if a musician wants to perform beautiful Arabic music, a better approach would be listening to the rich repertoire and learning *sayr* aurally from a large number of examples. For this reason, Arabic musicians today rarely ever read about *sayr* before learning to play a *taqsim* or compose a piece. It's just not realistic, any more than it's realistic to learn the correct intonation of a *maqam* scale from a book.

Sayr in the Oral Tradition

The limited ability to document *sayr* in writing by no means implies that Arabic music has no *sayr* tradition to pin down, or that musicians are free to work with Arabic *maqamat* any way they imagine (contrary to Allah Wirdi's quoted statement). Arabic music has a rich, detailed, and well-defined body of *sayr* traditions that live implicitly in the extensive oral legacy, and musicians acquire them by repeated listening (and musicians may *feel* that they are "sailing" in the "limitless sea" because they are not following *explicitly articulated* conventions, unaware that they are nonetheless following *implicit* oral conventions).¹¹

In practice, the habits and conventions that establish the correct use for every *maqam* form a rich consensus. The majority of pieces are at the center of the consensus, while there are fewer and fewer examples as one starts moving toward the periphery. Just like a fashion, that center may be different for different periods and regions. The tightness of the consensus depends on the tradition. In the Iraqi *maqam* tradition, for example, musicians adhere very tightly to the center of the convention. In contemporary Arabic pop, on the other hand, *sayr* norms are largely ignored. The remaining cases fall somewhere in between.

The next three sections address some of the main elements that make up the aural conventions around *sayr*: notes of melodic emphasis within a given *maqam*, special intonations and changes in intonation for *ajnas*, and melodic phrasing.

¹¹ Here as elsewhere we follow this rule: pay attention to what musicians do, not what they say. Arabic music has such a rich tradition of implicit conventions, which are so thoroughly misunderstood because of the imposition of faulty theory (both Western and Arabic), that musicians' statements about what they are doing are not reliable. Of course the distinction between implicit and explicit knowledge is one that has always been confusing for thinkers from any region and time period.

Notes of Melodic Emphasis

A *maqam's* *sayr* often includes emphasizing important notes in the *maqam* scale. While these notes are used in composed melodies, they are very obvious during a traditional improvisation such as a *taqsim* or a *mawwal/qasida*. This means that the melody touches specific notes in a specific order, just like the route of a mail delivery truck, for example. These routes don't dictate the actual melody in detail, only its skeletal course and points of interest. While this concept overlaps with the concept of pathways among *ajnas*, it adds an additional layer of structure to the *maqam* as a whole.

THE TONIC

The first note in terms of importance (but not necessarily in musical sequence) is the *maqam's* tonic, which is the first note in the scale (and also coincides with the tonic of the root *jins*). The tonic is fundamental to working with the *maqam*, as it is the note that the melodies resolve to in order to attain closure. The tonics of each *jins* used within the *maqam* are also key notes of emphasis (as we've stated, the root *jins* and the *maqam* as a whole share the same tonic). Many other notes in the scale contribute to a *maqam's* character and showcase its beauty. This type of emphasis tends to be more visible during an improvisation.

THE OCTAVE

Reaching the *maqam* scale's octave in a melody is definitely a milestone, without which most *maqamat* are not fully realized. In a *taqsim* or *mawwal*, for example, reaching the octave is a very emotional stage of the melodic course that can be highly fulfilling. For *maqamat* that have octave equivalence, going past the octave provides a glimpse of the original root *jins* transposed up by an octave. In songs or vocal improvisations, singing in the higher register requires more power and therefore sounds more energetic and stimulating. Therefore, the melodic behavior of the octave *jins* is slightly different than that of the root *jins*, even when they are the same. In the *sayr* of some *maqamat*, the octave may also be the starting point of the melody.

THE LEADING TONE

Another important note is the leading tone (called *al-hassas*, in Arabic), which is the note immediately below the tonic. The leading tone is part of the *maqam's* melodic

course, as well as of the root *jins*'s extended scale. The leading tone followed by the tonic can be used to open an improvisation and teases listeners into guessing the root *jins* (and therefore the *maqam*) just from a single interval.

THE GHAMMAZ

Another important note is the one already referred to as the *ghammaz*. In a *maqam*, this is the *ghammaz* of the root *jins*, usually the top note in its basic scale fragment as well as the first note of the succeeding *jins*. The *ghammaz* of a *maqam* is a note of frequent melodic emphasis, as well as the most frequent starting point for modulation. It is very easy and intuitive to switch among multiple choices of secondary *ajnas* starting on the *ghammaz*, while keeping the first *jins* constant. In the *sayr* of some *maqamat*, the *ghammaz* may also be the starting point of melody.

OTHER NOTES

Upon closer analysis of a traditional improvisation, it can be divided into multiple sections, each revolving around different notes in the *maqam* scale. In Maqam Rast, for example, in which the typical motion is to ascend the scale starting from the tonic, the emphasis points are the tonic; the 3rd, 4th, and 5th degrees; and finally the octave. Each note requires a few phrases and lots of repetition to showcase it. In such a *taqsim*, the notes are called *'atabat* (sing. *'ataba*; literally, “threshold” or “step”) and allow the listener to have a more comfortable ascent through the scale by breaking it into manageable steps.

Emphasizing special notes in a *maqam* scale can be achieved by playing them more often, playing them longer, or playing them louder. Another very common emphasis technique is doubling up a note with its lower octave or alternating between a note and its lower octave. A third technique is droning. On a sustaining instrument (e.g., the *nay* or violin), this is done by dragging out the note over many measures, with or without vibrato. On a percussive instrument (e.g., the *'ud*, the *qanun*, or the *buzuq*), droning means interleaving the melody with frequent occurrences of the drone or just playing a tremolo (*rashsh* in Arabic; literally, “spraying”) on the note for extended periods.

The use of every note in a *maqam* scale can certainly be documented, but such an exercise would be limited because it wouldn't capture enough detail, and more importantly because the use of important notes is part of a tradition that's not static. The best way to learn how to “use” a *maqam* is by listening to numerous examples from a period and region of choice.

Intonation and *Jins* Alterations

The overall *sayr* for a *maqam* can be expressed in terms of a pathway among various *ajnas*, but the conventions guiding the melody within a *maqam* also result in variations in the intonation and melodic vocabulary within individual *ajnas*. In other words, the overarching *maqam* shapes the *ajnas* within it, just as the constituent *ajnas* shape the *maqam* as a whole.

One example of a special note in a *maqam* scale that occasionally changes its intonation depending on phrasing is the 5th scale degree of Maqam Bayati. In some phrases, it is performed slightly raised, as if it's trying to reach the 6th degree, especially when it is the peak of a melody that ascends to it and then descends. This is very subtle; it can be heard, for example, in Umm Kulthum's song "*'ala balad il-mahabbub waddini*." This is a prevalent (although slightly old-fashioned) practice that is not explicitly documented, but is carried on orally.

In some *maqamat*, the 7th scale degree has its own intonation convention that depends on phrasing. For example, in the Sikah *maqam* family, the 7th degree is often slightly raised when it is used as a turning point from a descending melody to an ascending one, meaning that if it occurs at the bottom of a melodic curve, that curve should be a little straighter.

As part of the *sayr* of a given *maqam*, some of its constituent *ajnas* may behave slightly differently than they do in different *maqamat*. In other words, the *maqam*'s *sayr* may influence the constituent *jins*'s *sayr*. For example, the melodies used in Jins Rast when it occurs as the second *jins* on the *ghammaz* of Maqam Bayati are slightly different than those used when Rast is the second *jins* on the *ghammaz* of Maqam Hijaz. Many of the melodies are the same—enough so that it is always clearly identifiable as Jins Rast—but there are differences, especially in the hands of a masterful musician.

Jins Nahawand differs even more dramatically when it is a secondary *jins* in Maqam Rast (as noted in the "Other Melodic Entities" section in chapter 16: Newly Classified *Ajnas*), compared to when it occurs as a secondary *jins* in Maqam Bayati. Nahawand is a 5-note *jins*, and so its *ghammaz* falls on the octave of the root tonic of Bayati, when it tonicizes Bayati's 4th scale degree. However, in the context of Maqam Rast, since Jins Nahawand tonicizes Rast's 5th scale degree, its expected *ghammaz* does not fall on the Maqam Rast octave; in practice, melodies here don't usually emphasize the typical *ghammaz* of Nahawand, which would be the 9th scale degree above the root tonic (a step above the octave). In addition, the intonation and the melodies within Jins Nahawand are different depending on which *maqam* it is part of. For example, a common practice is slightly lowering the 2nd and 3rd degrees of Jins Nahawand when it occurs on the 5th degree of Maqam Rast. This can

be heard in many Muhammad Abdel Wahab recordings from the 1930s (e.g., “*leilet il-wada*”), but it has gradually gone out of fashion. On the other hand, the behavior of Jins Nahawand when it occurs as the second *jins* in Maqam Bayati is much more similar to its behavior as the root *jins* in Maqam Nahawand.

All of these subtleties could be documented in an extensive list, but for musicians they must be learned one by one, through hearing numerous musical examples and learning the repertoire of Arabic music. It is for this reason that learning the full richness of the *maqam* system takes at least a decade to master—and in reality, a lifetime of study. And contrary to what some might think, all of these details, when learned, don’t constrain the master musician with more and more rules to follow; instead they give the master a larger and larger vocabulary to play with, to create interesting and original combinations with, and to make rich connections throughout the repertoire.

Melodic Phrasing

While there are many possible abstractions and metaphors that help explain *sayr* at a higher level, the basis for a *maqam*’s melodic behavior is ultimately its phrasing vocabulary (as discussed in chapter 13: The *Jins*). This component is rarely documented in any detail in music theory books, but it can be easily learned by listening to a dozen *taqasim* in one *maqam*. *Taqasim* illustrate habitual phrases at a greater level of detail than can ever be captured in writing.

Phrases (called *jumla* in Arabic, pl. *jumal*) are usually short (under a dozen notes) and don’t span a large tonal range. At the most basic level, melodic phrases are associated with a *jins* regardless of what *maqam* it occurs in. This can be seen very clearly in a *taqsim* where, as the melody flows (hence the literal meaning of *sayr*) from one *jins* to the next, habitual phrases follow. For example, Maqam Suznak (starting with Jins Rast followed by Jins Hijaz on the 5th degree) exploits typical Rast phrases in the first *jins* and typical Hijaz phrases in the second *jins*. Many of the same phrases typical of the Rast and Hijaz *ajnas* are used regardless of what *maqam* or position they occur in. There are also typical phrases that span an entire *maqam* scale. A traditional *qafila* (cadence; literally, “closure” in Arabic) is a good such example, one that musicians reuse or imitate to the extent that it becomes cliché.

Phrases are like idiomatic expressions in a language, without which speakers or writers cannot be considered fluent and their speech or writing would remain bland. For example, while a recent English learner would say “my friend is feeling sick,” a native English speaker might say “my friend is under the weather.” Using an idiom (and possessing a good accent, analogous to using good intonation) makes all the difference between sounding like a native speaker or a foreign one.

For this reason, a *jins* or a *maqam's sayr* is never complete without the use of its established and expected musical phrases. Moreover, phrases, just like linguistic idioms, can be regional. For example, when a person says “Forget about it!” (pronounced “Fuhgeddaboudit”), he or she is likely to be from New York City. Similarly, regional musical phrases (along with a matching regional intonation) allow the performer to convey the geographical location of the performance within the wider Arabic tradition.

In many cases (some described in the previous section), *sayr* trumps intonation just as idiomatic expressions trump accent in a language. Immigrants who speak with a heavy foreign accent and distort some letters but use very local expressions can still sound regional. For the same reason, when electric guitar pioneer Omar Khorshid performs a *taqsim* in Maqam Hijaz, his *taqsim* can sound plausibly traditional as long as his phrasing is adequate (this is the case even when his intonation is strictly 12-tone equal-tempered, which delivers quite an imperfect Hijaz intonation; see chapters 2: Arabized Instruments and 5: Ornamentation).

Phrasing is such an important tool for branding a *jins* or *maqam* that a *maqam* can be recognized simply from its phrasing, even when it is performed out of tune. To use an example from the neighboring Greek music tradition, this phenomenon can be seen in many 1920s and 1930s Greek songs originally from Smyrna (the modern-day city of Izmir, Turkey) that were later recorded with more contemporary instruments such as the *bouzouki*. Their phrasing clearly betrays the fact that they were originally composed in Maqam Bayati, but their correct intonation was coerced into an equal-tempered Kurd *maqam* scale when the *bouzouki* instrument, which is fretted and equal-tempered, was later introduced to Greek music.

Similarly, it is the shared vocabulary of melodic phrases that makes neighboring *maqam* traditions recognizable to each other, even when there are differences in intonation and ornamentation style, such as the higher 3rd scale degree in Maqam Rast in Syria versus Egypt and the dramatically higher 3rd scale degree in the Turkish version of Rast, all identifiable as Rast due to shared melodies.

A New Understanding of *Sayr*

The traditional definition of *maqam* lacks almost everything discussed so far in this book, from understanding *ajnas* as melodic units, to traditional melodic phrasing, to multiple pathways for modulation among *ajnas*. Instead, it presents the scale as an abstract entity, within which, presumably, we must fit these other concepts. But just as we discussed modulation as taking place in a melodic framework guided by traditions and conventions, a more accurate understanding of the *maqam* would be that it is also guided by a larger, but still convention-based, melodic framework. That

framework is the “big picture” of *sayr*, the melody that guides the presentation of a *maqam* in its entirety.

An examination of *sayr* in the oral tradition reveals a much richer picture of *maqam* than simply a scalar sequence of *ajnas*. Just as individual modulations between *ajnas* are guided by conventions that make some modulations typical and expected and others rare and unexpected, and by still other theoretical modulation possibilities that are more or less nonexistent, there are conventions guiding the overarching structure of a *maqam* performance, from the beginning to the end.

A look at the traditional scalar model of the *maqam* would suggest that every *maqam* starts with the bottom *jins*, then moves to the upper *jins*. Traditional documentation of *sayr*, as described above, is slightly more detailed. It tells us that some *maqamat* start with the upper *jins* and eventually end on the lower *jins*; others start on the octave tonic and work their way down; and others actually do start on the bottom *jins*, go up, and then come down again. Slightly more detailed descriptions of *sayr* list options for modulation away from the two to three *ajnas* defining the basic *maqam* scale, but these are presented as “detours” from the true *sayr* of the *maqam*.¹²

As discussed at the beginning of chapter 17: *The Maqam*, a closer look at the repertoire, comparing numerous songs and improvisations in the same *maqam*, tells a different story. For example, many songs in Maqam Rast include a similar group of modulations, starting from Jins Upper Rast and moving to Jins Rast on the octave, Jins Hijaz on 5, and Jins Nahawand on 5, then eventually descending to Jins Rast on the root tonic. These modulations don’t always occur in the same order, but they often happen repeatedly in the same composition and with similar melodic phrasing across different pieces. Charting the options for these modulations creates a network, with lines between the *ajnas* indicating possible modulations. Box 20.1 describes the format and style of the diagrams used to express *sayr*.

BOX 20.1

Similarly to chapter 17, this chapter includes several *jins*-to-*jins* analysis diagrams in which each *jins* is represented as a rectangle with its name and the scale degree of its tonic relative to the overall *maqam* scale. The rectangle’s width reflects the size of the *jins*’s basic scale, and its horizontal placement reflects the position of the basic scale within the *maqam* scale. Although Jins Nahawand is usually defined as a 5-note *jins*, its occurrence on the 5th degree of Maqam Rast is shown as having the width of a 4-note *jins*. This special case of Jins Nahawand has its melodic activity mostly confined to 4 notes and is discussed in detail in the “Other Melodic Entities” section in chapter 16.

¹² Marcus (1989b) provides an interesting analysis of the way music theory changed over the 20th century, which goes some way to explaining the incompleteness and inconsistency in descriptions of *sayr*.

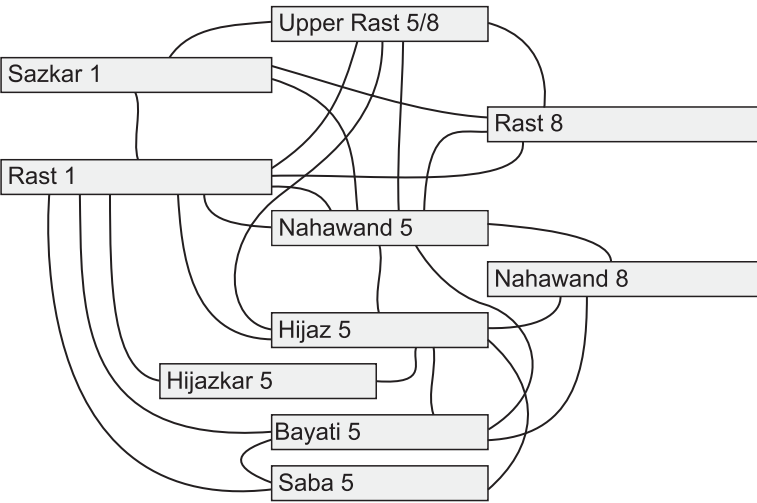


FIGURE 20.1 The bigger view of the *sayr* of Maqam Rast.

Figure 20.1 shows the bigger view of *sayr* and *maqam*: if certain modulations are so typical that they are expected to occur, then they must be considered part of the *maqam* itself, rather than extraneous to it. And *sayr*, rather than being a single linear path from beginning to end, is a group of pathways that connect the starting *jins* of a *maqam* (which may not be the bottom *jins*) with the ending *jins* of the *maqam*, through numerous optional but expected modulations.

Sayr as a Subnetwork

We can refine this view by looking not simply at the individual modulations, but also at the longer sequences of several modulations. In the song examples from chapter 17, we saw multiple variations on the melodic descent to the root *Jins* Rast, illustrated in figure 20.2.

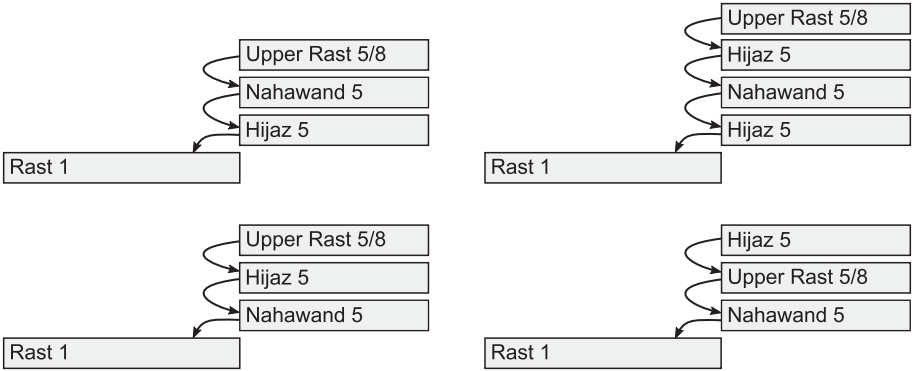


FIGURE 20.2 Four different variations on the melodic descent to the root *jins* in Maqam Rast.

In other words, taking all of these variations and more (which occur in the repertoire), we have a small network, illustrated in figure 20.3. This is the network view of the “Rast Descending Sayr.” (Beginning with figure 20.3, we introduce a stylistic convention for *sayr* diagrams: the use of rounded boxes to indicate potential starting points for the *sayr* and the use of a black background to indicate the endpoint. The styles can be combined to indicate a *jins* that is both a starting and endpoint for the *sayr*.)

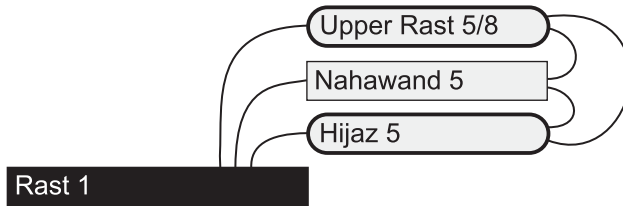


FIGURE 20.3 Variations on the melodic descent to the root *jins* in Maqam Rast, represented as a small network.

Another common *sayr* is the one that starts with Rast and ascends to the 5th scale degree. Taking the variations that occur in the repertoire and summing them up into one network, we have something that looks like figure 20.4.

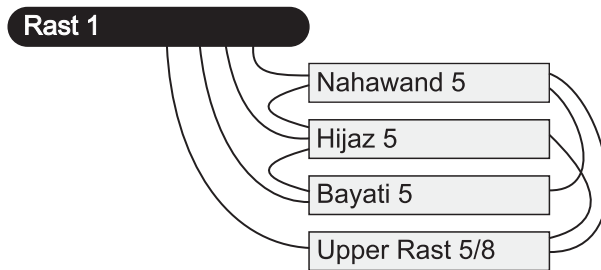


FIGURE 20.4 Maqam Rast ascending *sayr* represented as a network.

If we compare these two *sayr*-s with the overall Rast network shown in figure 20.1, we can see that both of these are contained *within* the larger network for Maqam Rast. We can then view the *maqam* not simply as a network of individual modulations, but as a network of larger-scale melodic pathways, or *sayr*-s. Some pieces in the *maqam* will tend to emphasize one particular *sayr*, some will emphasize another, and others (like “*ya wabur*”) will take advantage of both. While there are options for single modulations, even these connect to the major *sayr*-s within a *maqam*. The process of combining *sayr*-s involves a kind of interpolation/intersplicing of bigger melodies, and that is one way in which the individuality of any particular composition or improvisation can be expressed.

Interpolation

Interpolation is a concept known in other kinds of music. It is basically the insertion of something additional in the middle a sequence. If a sequence is:

$$A \rightarrow B$$

Interpolation puts something in the middle:

$$A \rightarrow C \rightarrow B$$

Here's an example using plain English:

- “I love to listen to Umm Kulthum’s song *ghanni li shwayya shwayya*.”
- “I love to listen *loudly and enthusiastically* to Umm Kulthum’s song *ghanni li shwayya shwayya*.”

The interpolation doesn’t take away from the overall meaning or direction of the sentence, but it delays the motion, adding something else of interest or deeper expression. And while the syntax of musical expression is vastly different than that of spoken language, in both cases an interpolation can’t be put just anywhere, but occurs in such a way as not to disrupt the larger *sayr*.

Looking back at the networked structure of *sayr* shown in the previous section, we can see interpolation everywhere. In fact, the structure $A \rightarrow C \rightarrow B$ can better be represented as shown in figure 20.5.

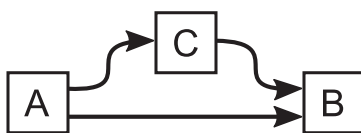


FIGURE 20.5 Interpolation shown as a network diagram.

We can then understand the *sayr* network diagrams as presenting options for interpolation in melodic sequences. But since the options themselves are learned and defined by convention/oral tradition, they are part of the fundamental structure of what we unconsciously experience as *sayr*.

Sayr of a *Jins*

Looking at the repertoire as a whole and seeing subnetworks within networks, one thing that becomes more obvious is that each *jins* has its own *sayr*. In fact,

we have already defined these in the prior chapters describing each *jins*: the *sayr* of a *jins* is the network of the most common modulations to and from a particular *jins*. At the same time, the *sayr* of a *jins* is the smallest subnetwork around that *jins* when it occurs within a *maqam*. These are simply two different ways of looking at the same phenomenon: either from a *jins* looking out, or from a *maqam* looking in.

We can illustrate the point with Jins Hijaz. A complete diagram of the *sayr* of Maqam Hijaz might look like figure 20.6, while the *sayr* of Jins Hijaz could be represented as shown in figure 20.7 (The acronym “LO” in the *jins* boxes indicates the “Lower Octave.”).

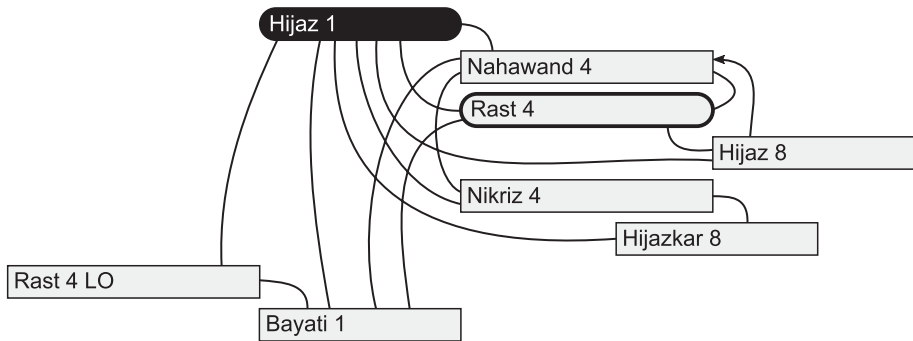


FIGURE 20.6 A possible complete diagram of the *sayr* of Maqam Hijaz.

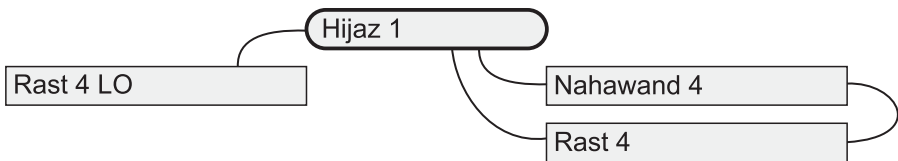


FIGURE 20.7 The *sayr* of Jins Hijaz.

It is this smaller *sayr*, representing the most common immediate pathways around a *jins*, that is most likely to be interpolated into other *maqam* contexts. In other words, when Jins Hijaz occurs as a secondary *jins* in another *maqam*, it can be presented simply and quickly. Or a song or improvisation can dwell on it, and the more that happens, the more we expect to hear some of the immediate connections available to the *jins*, as defined by aural expectation, which we represent as a network illustrating the *sayr* of the *jins*. (This is the first step in developing the *maqam*-to-*maqam* modulations described in chapter 19.) There is an example of this in the next section, in the *sayr* of Maqam Suznak.

Sayr and Maqam Family

All of these tendencies become even clearer when we look more broadly at multiple *maqamat* within a *maqam* family. Sticking with the Rast family, one common early 20th-century version of Maqam Rast emphasized the upper octave in its *sayr*, as shown in figure 20.8.

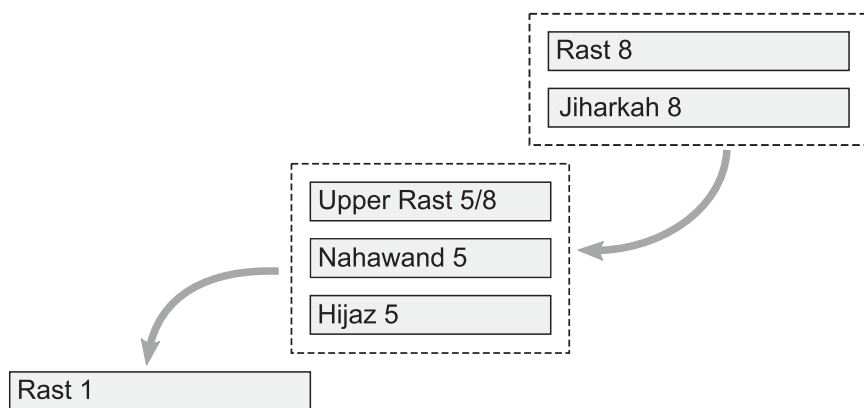


FIGURE 20.8 Early twentieth-century *sayr* of Maqam Rast, emphasizing its upper octave.

Now let's look at some typical *sayr* examples for three major branch *maqamat* of Rast: Suznak, Nairuz, and Dalanshin. We're not using any specific songs as illustrations, but rather our experience with aural tradition and *taqasim*. The reader wishing for examples can delve into the repertoire, including recorded *taqasim* and *mawawil*.

By looking at the *sayr* diagrams in figures 20.8, 20.9, 20.10 and 20.11, we can make the following observations.

First, each one of the *sayr* examples here has a similar network structure, resulting from the fact that the sequence of modulations doesn't have to happen in a completely strict order, but can involve variations, going back and forth, and interpolation. It is also worth repeating, even though it is not shown in these diagrams, that the *sayr* includes within it all the notes of melodic emphasis, particularities of intonation, melodic phrasing, and alterations of the *ajnas* described in prior sections, and that these elements of the *sayr* also have the network variability of being able to occur in different orders.

Second, we can see from these examples that *sayr* represents not simply a large-scale direction for a *maqam*, but specific sequences of *ajnas*/modulations that are repeated and varied over the course of a song. Instead of analyzing a song by the smallest chunk—modulations from *jins* to *jins*—we could analyze it by larger chunks: which *sayr* is in use.

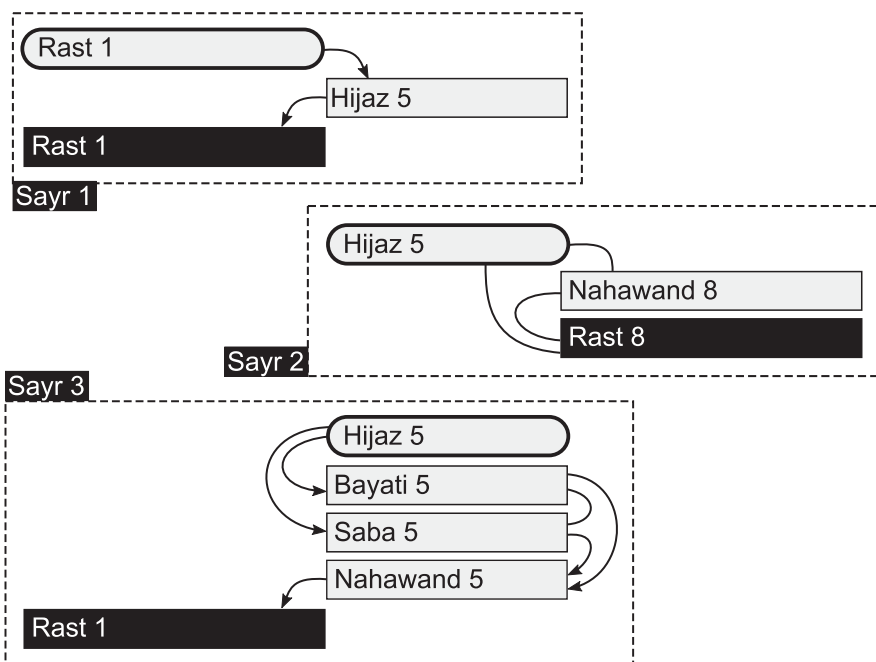


FIGURE 20.9 *Sayr* options in Maqam Suznak; *sayr 2* expands Jins Hijaz 5 as a *maqam*.

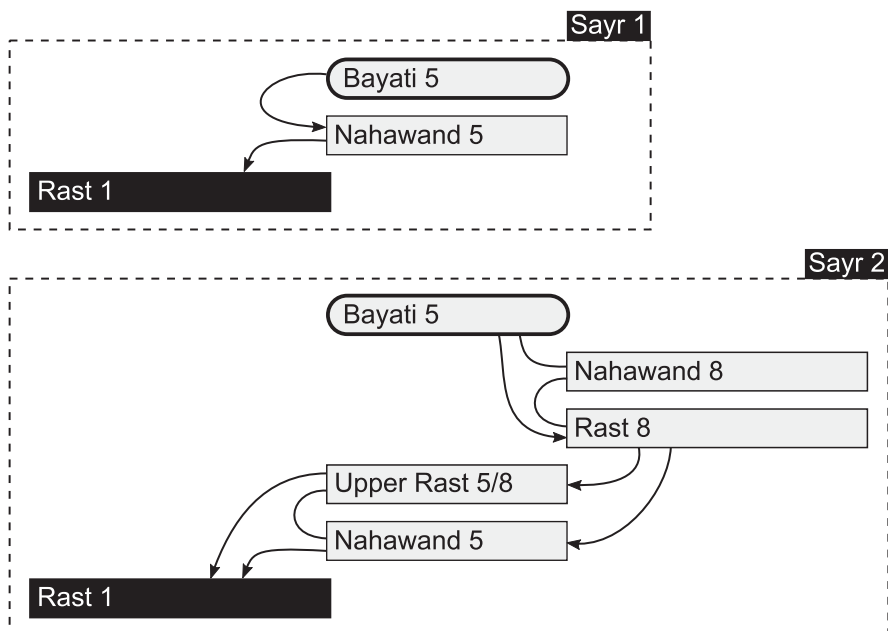


FIGURE 20.10 *Sayr* options in Maqam Nairuz; *sayr 2* adds an interpolation to *sayr 1*.

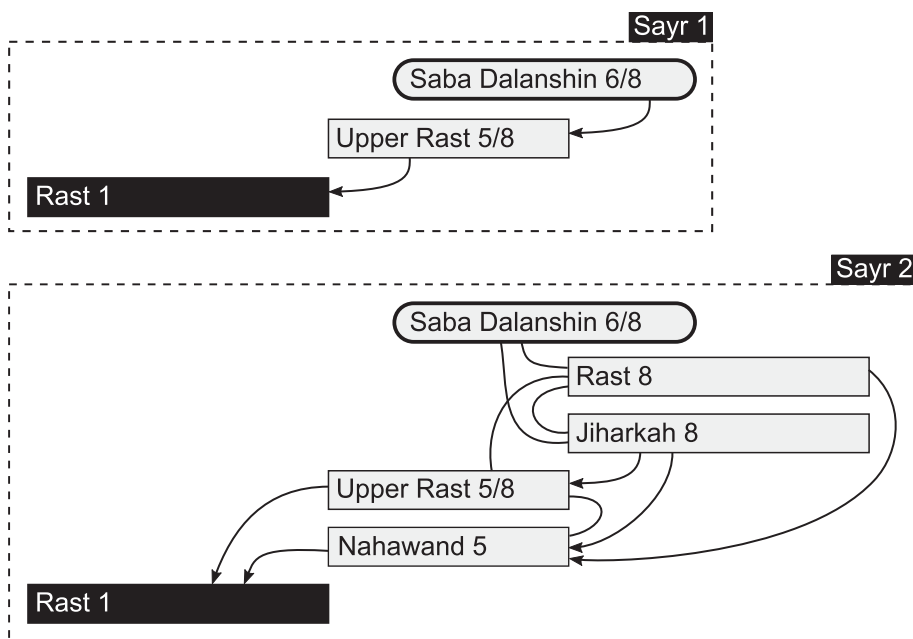


FIGURE 20.11 *Sayr* options in Maqam Dalanshin; *sayr* 2 adds an interpolation to *sayr* 1.

Third, the “descending *sayr*” of Maqam Rast (figure 20.3) appears embedded in some form within *every maqam* in the family. Upper Rast and Hijaz are to some extent optional within that *sayr*, but the descent from Nahawand 5 to Rast 1 is almost universal.

Finally, “extra” *ajnas* (beyond the most essential *ajnas* for each *maqam*) are typically resolved either through a connection to the “main” secondary *jins* of the *maqam* (Hijaz 5 for Maqam Suznak, Bayati 5 for Maqam Nairuz, Saba Dalanshin 6/8 for Maqam Dalanshin) or to the descending *sayr* of Maqam Rast.

We can see, then, that each “branch” of the *maqam* family tree doesn’t simply use different options for upper *ajnas*; it also uses particular *sayr*-s that connect those upper *ajnas* with the root *jins* or with each other in different ways.

We also notice from the repertoire, and especially from *taqasim*, that for the “main” *maqam* of a particular family (in this case, Maqam Rast), all of the particular *sayr* options used in branch *maqamat* can potentially be used during the performance. Each “branch” *maqam* usually has only one unique *sayr* (in some cases two), but it can also use the main “descending” *sayr* of the main *maqam*.

We can reconcile the “tree” metaphor and the “network” metaphor in this way: the *maqam* family takes the form of one very big network that contains all of the possibilities for modulations and all of the *sayr* possibilities within the network, while each branch within the family draws upon a smaller set of modulations and *sayr*-s. Nonetheless there is typically a particular descending/concluding *sayr* that

occurs in every branch *maqam*—and this is what is most analogous to the trunk of the tree (the prototypal melody for that descending *sayr* is the *qafla* melody for the *maqam*). The branches of the network are indeed connected to each other, but they retain their distinctness by focusing on a smaller number of possible modulations. All of this is illustrated in the diagrams in chapter 24: *Maqam* Index, which maps out all of the *maqam* families by modulations and *sayr*.

The overlap of larger-scale *sayr* from different versions of a *maqam* creates interesting possibilities for an experienced musician. He or she can mix these versions in a skillful *taqsim* or *mawwal*, thus demonstrating deeper knowledge of the *maqam* system as a whole.

This view of *sayr* also reconciles the dilemma raised by Allah Wirdi: the idea of *sayr* as a single linear pathway is really too strict for actual practice, but actual practice is not a free-for-all, either. The knowledge of multiple pathways, each of which is individually guided by convention, creates a larger network of possibilities that still remains aesthetically connected. This network effect enables musicians to invent completely new large-scale sequences that nonetheless remain within the network (which has infinite possibilities of movement among a finite number of stops) and therefore still feel traditional while being completely new.

This is the fundamental question to be asked about any improvised or modal music practice: How can individuality and tradition be reconciled? How can one improvise “in a mode” while still producing something original? We believe that the answer lies in the flexibility of networks, just as it does for spoken language. The finite number of possible *ajnas*, modulations, and *sayr*-s maintains the unity and cohesiveness of the sound—but the infinite number of possible sequences, the possibilities of variation, interpolation, and so forth, allow an unlimited amount of creativity for the musician who learns the practice fully.

THE *TAQSIM*

DRAMA OR NARRATIVE is the dominant metaphor for *maqam* used in this chapter—or more broadly speaking, artistry. Improvisation tells a particular story of a *maqam* through the artistry of an individual musician—and that story has a clearly discernible narrative arc. This metaphor adds yet another dimension to the *maqam*—that of emotional content and expression, teasing, suspense, and resolution.

This chapter covers instrumental improvisation through the lens of the most widely used form (arguably the only form, encompassing all melodic instrumental improvisation in traditional Arabic music): the *taqsim* (pl. *taqasim*, literally “partitioning” or “subdividing”). The *taqsim* (sometimes used in its feminine form in colloquial Arabic: *taqsima*) is an instrumental improvisation anchored in a *maqam*, and one of the pillars of Arabic music. Ranging from under one minute to 10–15 minutes or even more, it is one of the best avenues leading to *tarab* because it allows an instrumentalist to intensely connect with the audience. The reason for using the word “partition” as a name for the *taqsim* is historic. In the Arabic tradition, which is overwhelmingly vocal, a *taqsim* rarely stood as an independent piece and was used instead as a short instrumental interlude to separate vocal pieces (see chapter 8: Song Forms for the *taqsim*’s origins in the *wasla*). The Arabic word for improvisation was subsequently borrowed by Turkish music (as *taksim*) and even Greek music (as *taksimí*).

The general word for artistic improvisation in Arabic is *irtijal* (“creating spontaneously”), while performing a solo is referred to as *ʿazf munfarid* (“individual

performance”). But the *taqsim* is much more than a solo performance; it is an exercise in showcasing a *maqam* and its *sayr* (melodic motion/behavior), while at the same time representing the musical aesthetic of a time and region, revealing the beauty and capabilities of the instrument, and demonstrating the virtuosity and individual style of the performer. The challenge of a good *taqsim* is to weave all those threads together and keep them balanced.

A *taqsim* can be accompanied by supporting instruments or be entirely solo, it may be performed with a background rhythm (on the beat) or can flow freely, and it can be in the beginning or the middle of a piece or an independent piece by itself.

The word *taqsim* is not used to describe percussion instrument solos. That is because there is an intimate relationship between a *taqsim* and the Arabic *maqam* tradition, and percussion solos cannot convey that relationship.

A Modal Improvisation

A *taqsim* is anchored in a particular *maqam* and cannot exist outside of the *maqam* framework. It begins and ends in the same *maqam* (unless the purpose of the *taqsim* is to take the musical performance from one *maqam* to another). For this reason, a recorded *taqsim* is named after its *maqam* and the instrument, followed by the performer’s name, for example, “Taqsim Rast ‘Ud, by George Michel” or “Taqsim Qanun Bayati, by Muhammad Abdo Saleh.”

The *taqsim* is in a sense an etude on a *maqam*’s *sayr* (melodic motion/behavior, described in detail in chapter 20: *Sayr*). This includes delivering familiar phrases, emphasizing notes of particular importance in the *maqam* scale, and using the *gham-maz* and other modulation points to visit related *ajnas* and *maqamat*, before coming back to the original *maqam* scale and tonic. Musicians coming to Arabic music from other musical traditions sometimes miss this concept; indeed, performing an improvisation on a *maqam* scale that does not adhere to the *maqam*’s traditional *sayr* is not a *taqsim*. For example, the type of “unguided” or free-form exploration of one *maqam* scale often used in the Arabic-jazz fusion repertoire lacks many elements of a traditional *taqsim*.

The Fashion of a Time and Place

Performing a *taqsim* is bound by traditions, conventions, and aesthetic norms that guide improvisation, such as the *maqam*’s *sayr*, its intonation, idiomatic phrasing, the instrument’s vocabulary, and ornamentation style (discussed in detail in chapter 5: Ornamentation), as well as the rhythmic pulse, pace, and dynamic range of the *taqsim*.

These traditions vary slightly within each region of the Arab world, so as to follow the local fashion. And while they maintain their accumulated broad elements, they also gradually and subtly shift over time. As a result, it is possible for an experienced listener to recognize an Iraqi *‘ud taqsim* or an Egyptian *‘ud taqsim*, for example, without necessarily knowing the *‘ud* player. By the same token, *taqsim* from the same period (e.g., 1930s) have a lot of commonality in style and can generally be traced back to that period, compared to *taqsim* recorded in the 1960s, for example.

The challenge in documenting the art of the *taqsim* is therefore the same one facing *sayr* and ornamentation: a *taqsim* changes with fashion, and any detailed book on *taqsim* would quickly become dated and would appear too specific outside of its region. Instead, performers learn their local *taqsim* tradition aurally by immersion and imitation.

Virtuosity

The *taqsim* allows musicians to shine and demonstrate their virtuosity as no composed form can. Although a composed piece affords performers a lot of room for ornamentation and stylistic interpretation in which to display their technique, they are nevertheless melodically constrained. On the other hand, while a *taqsim* is somewhat constrained by the use of traditional phrases, clichés, and the *maqam*’s *sayr*, it still offers a wide opportunity for performers to showcase their abilities (see the end of chapter 20 for our explanation of how individuals are able to create completely original expressions within the context of a traditional and finite framework—an age-old aesthetic dilemma).

The *taqsim* is also an excellent vehicle for a skilled musician to reveal the many dimensions of an instrument: the tonal range (lowest to highest pitch); the dynamic range (softest to loudest volume); and the multitude of timbres, ornaments, or sound effects it can perform. But instrumental technique (sound quality, speed and agility of phrases, and correctness of intonation) is only one facet of the performer’s virtuosity. The *taqsim* is also a platform to demonstrate the musician’s knowledge of *sayr* (including traditional phrases and commonly used modulations), the body of *taqsim* from a time and place, and Arabic *maqam* theory in general.

For these reasons, performing a great *taqsim* is a stronger indication of musical mastery than performing a composed piece and is considered an essential skill in traditional Arabic music. It would be very embarrassing for a musician to be asked to do a medium-length *taqsim* in a well-known *maqam* to open a song (as happens often, spontaneously, on stage) and not be able to do a good job of it. Being able to perform a *taqsim* without any preparation in bread-and-butter *maqamat* such as

Rast, Bayati, Sikah, Hijaz, or Nahawand is a given for any professional. Performing a *taqsim* in less common *maqamat* such as Athar Kurd or Bastanikar would understandably require a little more preparation. The more experienced the musician, the wider his or her repertoire of *taqsim*.

Finding One's Voice

Given the need to adhere to the traditions and conventions of a *maqam's sayr* and the aesthetics of a time and place, one might expect musicians to create the same cookie-cutter *taqsim* every time, for a given *maqam*. In practice, though, *taqsim* are as diverse as musicians themselves. This is because all these constraints are broad enough to give the performers enough room to develop their own voices. Even if the same musician tried to perform the same *taqsim* in the same *maqam* on the same instrument every day, he or she wouldn't be able to do so, although granted, many common ideas and phrases would be repeated.¹

A good analogy to explain the diversity of *taqsim* is to compare them to stories (e.g., "The Story of Maqam Nahawand"). Each *maqam* offers a skeletal story along with a familiar setting (the *maqam* scale), vocabulary (musical phrases), characters (notes to emphasize), and a handful of common scenarios and dramatic events (*jins* and *maqam* modulations) to choose from. The ending of the story is always known. The storytellers' job is to tell the same story in their own style, multiple times over, while fleshing out the skeleton with their own details until they reach the expected ending. Different storytellers focus on different scenarios, and some storytellers might occasionally contribute a new scenario. Far from boring listeners, a good storyteller can weave a broadly known story over and over using his or her own artistic voice and still entertain.

Therefore, a good *taqsim* must deliver a balanced mix of expected material and new and personalized material. Too much expected material would be boring; too much new material and the *taqsim* would no longer sound traditional. A junior *'ud* player who tells the same exact story told by Farid al-Atrash 40 years earlier would shine technically but would not be considered mature until he or she could tell that broad story in his or her own voice. Even a musician who repeats the same story he or she told the previous year becomes uninteresting.

The art of *taqsim* is about finding one's voice, expressing one's ideas and personality, and having the musical imagination to create something slightly new with every new *taqsim*, using more or less the same vocabulary and grammar offered by

¹ Nettl and Riddle (1973).

the tradition. With time, performers gradually personalize the tradition and take it forward, each in a different direction, and imprint their performances with their individual and recognizable voices.

Uses of a *Taqsim*

The *taqsim* can be a musical performance in its own right or can also be used as a transition between pieces, an introduction to a piece, or as an interlude in the middle of a piece.

THE SOLO INSTRUMENTAL *TAQSIM*

The most straightforward type of instrumental *taqsim* is performed on a melodic instrument without any other accompanying instruments. This type of *taqsim* also qualifies as a solo performance (*ʿazf munfarid*).

A solo *taqsim* is very demanding, as the performer is exposed to the audience without the support and comfort of an ensemble or even a percussionist. On the upside, this type of encounter can be thrilling for the performer, since the audience's attention and admiration is focused solely on that person. In this type of *taqsim*, the performer can demonstrate mastery and make an imprint on the tradition by contributing his or her own individual style of ornamentation, phrasing, and favorite modulations.

Interestingly, even without a supporting rhythm or any apparent meter, the solo *taqsim* often has a pulse of its own, an internal metronome that guides each phrase and underpins notes within each phrase. This is especially true for percussive (*naqr*) melodic instruments such as the *ʿud*, *qanun*, and *buzuq*. Indeed, *taqsim* can be notated one phrase or section at a time based on that underpinning pulse. The pulse often changes speed, or stops during rests, then starts again. It is most apparent when the musician plucks the same note over and over again as a drone. This inherent (but informal) rhythm provides a very useful structure that supports phrasing and conveys the speed of the phrase to the listener. Changing the speed of the pulse is one technique used by the performer to vary the level of excitement in a *taqsim*.

Many great musicians of the Golden Age left a legacy of solo *taqsim* recordings. A classic example is Riyad al-Sunbati's seminal 1979 CD *Taqaseem ʿUd*, which includes six *taqsim* tracks anchored in the *maqamat* Nahawand, Hijazkar, Sikah, Kurd, Rast, and Bayati. Sunbati's CD is considered a benchmark for *ʿud* technique, style, and ornamentation, but also a rich demonstration of *sayr* (as far as phrasing

and modulation choices) for each *maqam* explored. Another great example of a solo *taqsim* CD is *Liban: Hommage à un maître du buzuk*, recorded in 1972 by Matar Muhammad (Lebanon, 1939–1995). Muhammad's CD, with only three tracks, has so far been unsurpassed in its mastery of the *buzuq*.

Many more 'ud solo recordings exist, as their number far outstrips the number of solo recordings in other *takht* instruments, and as such *taqsim* CDs for the *nay*, the *qanun*, and the violin are few and far between.

AS AN INTRODUCTION TO A PIECE

Taqsim that open a piece are very common in the more traditional repertoire of the early to mid-20th century, although they tend to be brief and mostly serve the purpose of introducing the *maqam* and creating a favorable mood that facilitates engaging in the vocal or instrumental piece. Farid al-Atrash took that tradition to new heights with his landmark seven-minute 'ud *taqsim* in Maqam Kurd at the opening of his song "awwil hamsa" (The First Whisper) in 1972. That 'ud solo became a piece in itself and drove an excited crowd to roar after his masterful and flamboyant delivery of each phrase.

The opening *taqsim* finds its ideal place in the beginning of a *wasla*. This type of performance is discussed in detail in the *wasla* section of chapter 8: Song Forms. It tends to include many instrumental *taqsim* both at the start and during the *wasla*, as well as vocal improvisations. Such was the case with many of the *waslat* recorded by Egyptian *mutrib*-s Saleh Abdel Hayy (1896–1962), 'Abbas al-Blaydi (1912–1996), and Ibrahim al-Haggar (1922–2000) in the 1950s and 1960s.

IN THE MIDDLE OF A PIECE

Performing a *taqsim* in the middle of a composed piece is another typical practice. It is used in some *sama'iyyat*, traditionally after the fourth *khana* and before the last *taslim*. Such a *taqsim* is brief, unmetered, and usually performed on the 'ud. It creates a break from the continuous rhythm and builds anticipation for the final repetition(s) of the *taslim*.

Inserting a short *taqsim* in the middle of a composed piece can add a lot of color and open up a short space to escape the composed melody and connect directly with the improviser. Such a *taqsim* can be done on the beat or without rhythm and may reiterate themes from the composed melody. In general, it stays on the same *maqam* as the piece unless its goal was to modulate to a new *maqam*. This is the case with the 'ud *taqsim* in the middle of the instrumental composition "dhikrayati" by

Muhammad al-Qasabgi, which opens with Jins Bayati on the 5th degree of Maqam Nahawand, then closes with Jins Nahawand on the tonic. The *'ud taqsim* performed by Qasabgi in the original recording was strongly imitated in subsequent covers of that composition, especially its *qafila* (cadence). Egyptian violinist Abdo Dagher also often adds short or medium-sized *taqsim* by himself and other musicians during performances of his compositions.

A number of instrumental *maqtu'at* and *muqaddimat*, which make use of a variety of *iqā'* and *maqam* changes, include a section in the middle intended specifically for improvisation over the beat. The practice is quite simple in execution: somewhere in the middle of the piece, the *iqā'* switches to one of the *iqā'at* commonly associated with improvisation (Ciftetelli in the vast majority of cases), and one of the instrumentalists performs a brief *taqsim*, before leading into the next melody of the piece. The popular dance piece "*raqsat al-jamal*," composed by Farid al-Atrash in 1947, has such a short composed melody that, in the original recording, it goes to two sections of Iqā' Ciftetelli in between returns of the theme: one for a *'ud taqsim* and another for a *qanun taqsim*.

AS A TRANSITION BETWEEN PIECES

As its name indicates, the *taqsim* was traditionally played in between different parts of a *wasla* (a combined vocal and instrumental suite of pieces in the same *maqam*) to separate vocal pieces and give the singer a break. Today, the imperative verb "*qas-sim!*" (literally, "subdivide!" in Arabic) is still used to mean "please improvise."

A very good recording illustrating the ability of *taqsim* to nicely partition an otherwise continuous and long recording into separate pieces is the hugely popular *Bil Afrab* (To Happiness!/Cheers!), produced by Lebanese musician, composer, and arranger Ziad Rahbani in 1976. The recording is entirely instrumental and includes covers of 10 compositions² in the *maqamat* Hijaz, Bayati, Rast, Nahawand, and 'Ajam. *Bil Afrab* uses a very short *taqsim* between pieces to delineate them, to give the listener a break without stopping the musical flow, and to introduce the next *maqam* when needed. This approach offers musicians their 30 seconds of fame each and a chance to shine and showcase the beauty of their instruments and the *maqam* of the anticipated piece. The *taqsim* in *Bil Afrab* include the *qanun*, the *buzuq*, the *nay*, and the *'ud* (unfortunately Rahbani didn't give the violin and the accordion any *taqsim*, although they did perform solo sections as part of the arrangement).

² Out of the ten tracks, only two were composed by Ziad Rahbani.

It is very common to have one *taqsim* per musician in a classical Arabic recording, especially one that is organized as a *wasla*. An example of a recording with different instrumental *taqasim* is *Cèdre*, by the Lebanese Ensemble Morkos (2005). The CD is based on a 45-minute *wasla* entirely in Maqam Bayati and includes short *taqasim* on the *qanun*, the violin, and the ‘*ud* (the ensemble did not include a *nay*). Another good example of this approach is *Une Variété Musique Arabe*, by the Slah El-Manaa Ensemble from Tunisia (1995). The CD has 11 tracks, 5 of which are *taqasim*. In other words, every member of the *takht* (*qanun*, violin, *nay*, ‘*ud*, and *riqq*) has a medium-length *taqsim* (three to eight minutes). The effect of each *taqsim* is not so much to partition pieces; rather, it creates a comfortable transition between pieces by momentarily lowering the performance dynamics and inserting a more intimate and personal pause. The *riqq* solo³ recorded on that CD is very precious, since very few percussionists perform *riqq* solos in recordings.

Anatomy of a *Taqsim*

A good *taqsim* has a narrative arc analogous to that of a play or movie. The narrative arc follows a broad formula dictating how the plot is structured over the span of the story and details how to divide the story into acts, as well as how the acts are connected or hinged over pivotal and transforming events that occur at predefined instants in the story. While unspoken, the narrative arc sets the expectations of spectators and allows them to enjoy such plays and movies in a predictable way.

Listening to a good *taqsim* can be compared to watching a *Star Wars* or *Harry Potter* movie. The general story is already known: a villain wants to rule the world, and brave heroes succeed in stopping him while facing many grueling challenges along the way. Despite that foreknowledge, each new sequel can be interesting because it has a different way of telling that same broad story.

The dramatic arc of a *taqsim* is a very good example of the *tarab* arc, described in detail in chapter 23: *Tarab*. Each *taqsim* is rooted in one principal *maqam* and starts and ends in the same *maqam* (except in rare cases where the purpose of the *taqsim* is to transition a performance to a new *maqam*).

The central plot of every *taqsim* is the melodic course (*sayr*) of that *maqam*. The *taqsim* broadly develops that plot over three acts: a beginning, a middle, and an end (although very lengthy and elaborate *taqasim* can include more acts). Throughout its development, the *taqsim* follows a fundamental principle that enables *tarab*: the

³ Calling the *riqq* solo a *taqsim* would not be correct because a *taqsim* implies a performance based in the *maqam* melodic realm.

combination of repetition and variety, of familiarity and unfamiliarity, judiciously kept in balance.

The first act of the *taqsim* is an exposition of the *maqam*, and the opening melodic phrases of that act are more or less completely set by tradition. These typical phrases are familiar to experienced listeners, and as they are heard again, they build a sense of expectation and *tarab*. The first act's phrases gradually build the story's introduction⁴ by exploring the opening *jins* of the *taqsim* (which may be the *maqam*'s root *jins* or may be an upper *jins*). Every idea or section in the first act typically has a mini *qafla* (cadence, ending) followed by a brief pause. These short pauses are extremely important both to partition small ideas and to let them sink in. There are typically several resolutions to the tonic of the *maqam*, with a very decisive resolution marking the end of this first act.

The second act introduces modulations from the main *maqam* to any number of new *ajnas*, usually starting on the *ghammaz* or a secondary modulation point, and frequently a modulation up to the octave tonic (unless the *taqsim* opened with the octave tonic). This section is generally the longest and showcases the musician's technical virtuosity and theoretical knowledge. Here, the expectation of modulations is guided by the listener's and the performer's shared familiarity with the typical modulation pathways of the *maqam*. The performer continues to follow expectations, building comfort until such point as he or she begins to stretch and eventually violate expectations, leading to greater excitement for the listener, and building on *tarab*. The second act is made of many phrases, which are interspersed with short *qaflat* (cadences) to mark the completion of a small musical idea and let the listeners digest it for a second. Finally, the performer returns to familiar territory, "resolving" the tension of previous phases. Repetition with slight variations is key to this sense of resolution.

The second act ends with a type of phrasing that clearly signals that the development is over and the journey back to the original *maqam* scale (and its tonic in particular) is about to begin. This is the *point of no return* as far as the listeners are concerned, and any backtracking into the second act would sound hugely out of place. The third act (usually very short) is the *qafla* (cadence), the climactic journey that reaches its peak when the *taqsim* returns triumphantly to the tonic of the starting *maqam*.

From our perspective—as elaborated in chapter 23: *Tarab*—we see the structure outlined here, which is also shared with vocal improvisation, as fundamentally

⁴ During a rehearsal with Palestinian oud/violin virtuoso Simon Shaheen, he commented on the opening (first act) of a musician's *taqsim*—"You said 'Good Morning' ten times!"—by which he meant that the *taqsim*'s opening story was repetitive and wasn't progressing.

equivalent to the structure of *sayr* and *maqam* itself. To return to the metaphor of the driver as performer developed in chapter 19: Modulation—in which the driver (musician) takes his passengers (the audience) on a journey (*sayr*) through (modulation) multiple stops (*ajnas*) within a particular region (the *maqam*)—for a master improviser, the driver, the vehicle, and the roadway are all one. The particular types of phrasing and sections described in this chapter (long vs. short phrases, pauses, different types of phrases in different sections) serve to articulate, accent, or emphasize the different stops on the journey, but the core of the *taqsim* (or *layali* or *mawwal*) is the journey itself, which is the *maqam*. The *taqsim* is but a manifestation of *maqam*, and the *maqam* is nothing more or less than a sum of its manifestations. Master improvisers understand this implicitly.⁵

Tashwiq

Teasing listeners is called *tashwiq* in Arabic (“creating a craving/longing”) and is a very established technique used during vocal and instrumental improvisations. During a *taqsim*, the plot is slowly built up using musical phrases. A crowd of Arabic music lovers and connoisseurs listening to an interesting *taqsim* is much like a crowd of soccer (football) fans watching a game. They all hold their breath together in anticipation and cheer together when the musician resolves a tension point.

A trained listener knows the *maqam*’s melodic behavior and its habitual pathways by immersion, without the need for study, in the same way that a native speaker learns conventions for speech in a local dialect (and close friends can finish each other’s sentences). Armed with that knowledge and habit, attending a *taqsim* performance becomes an exciting affair, since the listener sort of knows what the story is about, but is about to hear it yet again from a new storyteller (or even the same storyteller if he or she is good enough not to be repetitive).

The plot really thickens when modulations start happening (what we have referred to in the preceding discussion as the second act). Which one will take place, how it will be engaged, and more important, how the performer will get back to the starting *maqam* are the questions on the listeners’ minds (though not necessarily consciously). If bifurcating into a modulation requires care and experience, ending the modulation and returning smoothly and effortlessly back to the starting *maqam* is all the more demanding.

Listeners also get titillated when the musician embarks on a rare and unexpected modulation (one that is nevertheless convincing and aesthetically pleasing), after

⁵ Even when their verbal descriptions of what they are doing don’t align.

getting the listeners comfortable and leading them to believe they are about to embark on a more familiar modulation. The experienced crowd is often heard mumbling a deep “hmm” when their curiosity is aroused. A good *taqsim* therefore must “tease the ear.”

A technique that titillates experienced listeners and gets them excited is for the musician to hint at a modulation with one or two accidental notes, but not actually engage in it. A rare incident once happened in a concert that one of the authors attended, during a long and very enjoyable *buzuq taqsim*. In the heat of the moment, while passionate phrases were being delivered at lightning speed, the musician’s fingers slipped, and he hit the string one fret higher than intended. The effect was to transform Jins Nahawand into Jins Rast, for only a split second. One note was all it took; experienced listeners in the crowd immediately caught that note and instantly cheered, thinking it was an intentional but very brief modulation to Jins Rast. The musician in question, of course, took full credit for that unintended embellishment and continued with his *taqsim*.

The *Qafila*

The *qafila* (cadence, from the Arabic verb *qafala*: “to lock” or “to close”; pl. *qafilat*) is the ending of a *taqsim* (or a musical piece, section, or phrase), in which all the tension built up during the plot is finally resolved and the listeners are safely brought back to the *maqam*’s tonic. The *qafila* is the most exciting and the most eagerly awaited point in a *taqsim*.

The last act of the *taqsim* begins when the performer decides to head back home. Trained listeners can recognize that instant (which we call “the point of no return”) because the phrasing stops exploring new areas and starts heading back to the original *maqam*’s tonic. A performer who hints at or gives the impression of starting a *qafila*, then changes course, will leave listeners with an unresolved and confused feeling.

A *qafila*’s length varies with the length of the *taqsim*. A short *taqsim* can have a simple and unceremonious *qafila*, while a long *taqsim* merits a richer and more elaborate *qafila*. However, like the opening of the *taqsim*, the actual melodies used for the *qafila* are more or less completely set by the tradition for each *maqam*. The creativity of the musician is displayed in how many of these traditional phrases to use, how much to ornament, and the timing and balance of the buildup and conclusion.

The vast majority of *qafilat* are descending phrases to the root tonic. To make the *qafila* long and elaborate, the performer may start from the *jawab* (upper tonic note)

of the *maqam* scale, or higher, in order to have the longest possible span to cover. Now that the starting note and the ending note are known, the performer imaginatively starts playing phrases that stop and hover around the *maqam* scale's most important notes, all the way down to the tonic.

A *qafila* that takes too long to arrive leaves the listeners frustrated, while a *qafila* that's too short leaves the listeners feeling cheated out of their enjoyment. A good musician knows how to balance the two and keep the tension high until the very last note. The audience celebrates their arrival back to the tonic as the culmination of their *taqsim* journey.

Taqsim on the Beat

A *taqsim* performed over an *iqā'* provided by one or more percussion players is called *taqsim mawzun* (weighted/metered) or *taqsim muwaqqa'* (rhythmic). It is also called *taqsim 'ala al-wahda*, meaning over an *iqā'* in general, or more specifically over Iqā' Wahda, a simple ($\frac{4}{4}$) Arabic rhythmic cycle with a single *dum* per measure.

Ironically, the most instantly recognizable and iconic *iqā'* for Arabic *taqsim* is not originally Arabic, but the Turkish ($\frac{8}{8}$) Iqā' Ciftetelli. That *iqā'* is rarely used for composed music, and so as soon as it starts, listeners get ready with anticipation (with an almost Pavlovian reflex) to hear a *taqsim* or a vocal improvisation (*mawwal* or *qasida*) on the beat. Another popular *iqā'* for a *taqsim* on the beat is Bambi, an ($\frac{8}{8}$) fast-paced *iqā'* that is more common in Egypt. Potentially any *iqā'* can be used to support a *taqsim*, including Maqsum ($\frac{4}{4}$), Malfuf ($\frac{7}{4}$), Yuruk Semai ($\frac{6}{8}$), Sama'i Thaqil ($\frac{10}{8}$), Aqsaq ($\frac{9}{8}$), Jurjina ($\frac{10}{8}$), or even the very rare Khosh Rang ($\frac{17}{8}$).⁶

When one member of an ensemble is performing a *taqsim mawzun*, other melodic instrumentalists usually play a rhythmic melody (a riff) that highlights the *iqā'*'s skeleton. This is easier to achieve with percussive (*naqr*) instruments such as the 'ud, *qanun*, or *buzuq* but can also be done with sustaining instruments such as the violin or the *nay*.

The one-on-one collaboration between a melodic instrument improviser and a backing percussionist is very interesting because of the opportunities it presents. The percussionist can be very clearly heard and has an important (albeit unequal) part in the *taqsim*; he or she can contribute to it very much and even influence it. While in some *taqsim* the percussionist is modest and reserved and pretty much carries one *iqā'*, one speed, and one volume from start to finish without wavering,

⁶ Probably the only recorded *taqsim* on Iqā' Khosh Rang is on the *qanun taqsim mawzun* on track 5 of Ensemble al-Kindi's CD *The Crusades Seen Through the Eyes of the Orient*, CD II (Harmonia Mundi, 2001), with Egyptian percussionist Adel Shams el-Din on the *riqq*.

the opportunities for variations in these three elements (plus ornamentation) are numerous and certainly inviting. However, to do so requires a good amount of trust between the two musicians, trust that is founded on prior joint performances. Good *taqsim* “on the beat” show the rich interplay between melodic instrumentalist and percussionist, in which the latter is almost a partner in the *taqsim*.

The most interesting questions in this type of collaboration are: Who is leading whom, and what exactly should the percussionist be doing? To answer the first question, the melodic musician is leading the percussionist most of the time—after all, it’s his or her *taqsim*. But it would be wrong to assume that the soloist is not, in turn, actively listening to the percussionist and reacting to changes in *iqā‘*, tempo, loudness, and ornamentation. A good Arabic musician is a good listener and must acknowledge signals from other members of the ensemble if the context requires it, since group performance is a team exercise. If the percussionist reacts to a shift in the *taqsim* by shifting his or her part as well, the feedback loop between them becomes active, and the soloist can in turn react to rhythmic changes. The mood of the *taqsim* could shift in peaks and troughs several times before it ends. When he or she is not contributing to the feedback loop, the percussionist’s role is to be solid and constant while listening to the direction in which the soloist is taking the *taqsim* and supporting it. The challenge for the percussionist is to negotiate that fine balance.

But then how does the soloist interact with the percussionist and the supporting rhythm? The soloist uses the rhythm as a foundation and weaves in and out of it. In other words, playing the entire *taqsim* in rhythm is boring and very restricting and confining to the soloist. On the other hand, playing the entire *taqsim* in free tempo while the supporting rhythm is ticking in the background sounds very awkward. The best way to utilize the supporting rhythm in a *taqsim* is to interact with it—but not all the time. The contrast between the two pulses meeting and diverging creates a very interesting kind of rhythmic counterpoint. Negotiating the delicate balance between adhering to the rhythm at times and playing freely at other times is the soloist’s challenge.

Toward the end of some *taqsim* performances, the solo instrumentalist gives the percussionist two measures to play alone, then joins the performance again and repeats that a few more times before ending the *taqsim*. This creates a dialogue that is very similar to the interaction between jazz soloists and their drummers.

Excellent *taqsim* on the beat have been recorded by all the great instrumentalists of the Golden Age, including Umm Kulthum’s *qanun* player Muhammad Abdo Saleh; her violinist Ahmad al-Hifnawi; and violinists Sami al-Shawwa, Aboud

Abdel Al, and Abdo Dagher, to name a few. A good example of a *taqsim* on the beat from a more contemporary recording is Simon Shaheen's appropriately named "Taqsim on the Beat" track from the CD *Turath: Masterworks of the Middle East* (1994). The 9½-minute *taqsim* in Maqam Nahawand starts with Iqa' Bambi on the *riqq*; gradually speeds up, then changes to Baladi and Maqsum; and toward the end shows a nice call-and-response interaction between the soloist and the percussionist, in which for all practical purposes they are both improvising together.

VOCAL IMPROVISATION

THIS CHAPTER COVERS vocal improvisation in Arabic music through the most widely used forms: the *layali* (always a plural), the *mawwal* (pl. *mawawil*), and the improvised *qasida* (pl. *qasa'id*). These forms are the ultimate vehicle for improvisation by a musician, because the voice is the most expressive, revealing, and demanding instrument. Indeed, a vocal improvisation is the most direct way for a singer to communicate her or his emotions to listeners without the intermediary of a composed melody or an instrument.

Like the *taqsim*, vocal improvisation is equally anchored in a *maqam*; it represents a vehicle for exploring the *maqam's sayr* through the musical aesthetic of a time and place and for showcasing the beauty of Arabic poetry, the singer's voice, diction, technique, artistry, and individual style. A good vocal improvisation must combine all of these aspects. As such, many of the topics discussed in chapter 21: The *Taqsim* apply to vocal improvisation as well, in particular the sections on the anatomy of a *taqsim*, creating anticipation in the listeners, and the *qafla*.

Like instrumental improvisation, vocal improvisation tells a story through the *maqam*, in addition to, and interacting with, the story told through the lyrics. The melodic structure of vocal improvisation is equivalent to the structure of *sayr* and *maqam* itself, just as vocal improvisation is the purest manifestation of *maqam*

within Arabic music. And masterful vocal improvisation is at the core of both the *tarab* phenomenon and the *tarab* repertoire.

While the *layali*, *mawwal*, and improvised *qasida* forms are always anchored in one *maqam*, only the *layali* form is named after the *maqam* (e.g., “Layali Bayati”). The *mawwal* and *qasida* are named after the first few words in the sung poem followed by the singer’s name, for example the *qasida* “*qul lil-maliha*” by Sabah Fakhri or the *mawwal* “*min furgit il-khill*” by Muhammad Khayri.

The *Layali*

The *layali* form is named after the plural of the word *layl* (“night” in classical Arabic, rhymes with “veil” when sung in colloquial Arabic), and as such that form has no singular name. The *layali* is the simplest and most immediate vocal improvised form because it does not require memorizing and reciting a poem. Instead, the *layali* uses the long-established set lyrics of “*ya leil, ya ‘ein.*”¹ These literally mean “O night, O eye” in Arabic, although when listeners hear these words from a singer they rarely think about their literal meaning.

The *layali* form is a quick and easy way to deliver the *maqam* vocally without the distraction of poetic lyrics. And while it can stand on its own in a performance or a recording (many recordings of *layali* alone exist, starting from the early 1900s with Sheikh Abu al-‘Ila Muhammad), it is most often used to open a vocal suite or as a prelude to a *mawwal/qasida*, a *muwashshah*, or a *dawr*. The *layali* can be sung with one or more supporting instruments or simply a cappella (using only the voice). It can be supported by rhythm or be unmetered. It can take place in the beginning of a song or in the middle of a song, or be its own stand-alone piece. It can start immediately or can be introduced by a short *taqsim* or a *dulab*.

A more embellished version of the *layali* lyrics is “*ya leili, ya ‘eini,*” which means “O my night, O my eye.” Another common word used in singing *layali* and *mawawil* is “*aman,*” a Turkish word that means “Mercy!” In a *layali*, that single word can be used alone for several minutes, as it can be charged with a full spectrum of emotions. *Aman* is pronounced “ah-MAHN” with a long and stretched out second syllable. In fact, the long, open vowels in these words used in *layali* (“ah,” “ee,” and “oo”) are what really matter. They provide an outlet for the singer’s voice to perform melismata, to warm up, and to open up, especially in the high register. As a last resort, some singers simply use the syllable “ah” for a short *layali*.

¹ ‘Ajjan (2001) mentions that the origin of using the word “*ya leil*” is the *qasida* “*ya laylu al-sabbu mata ghaduhu*” (“O Night, When Will This Yearning End?”) by Qayrawani Husri (1029–1095).

Vocal improvisations in Syria and Lebanon frequently use the syllables “*auf*” (pronounced “oaf,” a vocalization of emotions with no literal meaning) and “*yaba*” (“O Father!”) in the same way that Egyptians and Syrians use “*ya leil ya ‘ein*”: as syllables for melodic expression ahead of (or instead of) actual lines of poetry.

All of these syllables, in addition to creating a stand-alone vocal improvisation, can also be used to open a *mawwal* or improvised *qasida* before introducing the poetic lyrics. In that scenario, they provide an informal sound check, a voice-warming opportunity while the singer gets comfortable with the *maqam*’s melody and register, before the singer tackles the first line of poetry. Alternatively, these syllables can be used as a vocal filler and can be interspersed between the verses of poetry within a *mawwal* or improvised *qasida* performance.

The *Mawwal*

Mawwal is generally used to describe any vocal improvisation using poetic lyrics in colloquial language (in a local dialect). The *mawwal*’s lyrics typically cover romantic topics such as beauty, unrequited love, broken hearts, and the betrayal of friends.

Like the *layali*, the *mawwal* can be sung with one or more supporting instruments or a cappella. It can be sung over a beat (most frequently using one of the *iqā‘at* Ciftetelli or Wahda, but also occasionally Maqsum) or be unmetered. It can take place in the beginning or middle of a song or be its own stand-alone piece. It can start immediately or can be introduced by a short *taqsim* or *dulab*. Regardless of these possibilities, in a *mawwal* the singer is the focus of the listeners’ attention and is always the one who leads the remaining musicians.

The origin of the word *mawwal* lies in the *mawwal baghdadi*, a genre of colloquial poetry based on a seven-line form that originated in Baghdad, also called *mawwal sab‘awi* (seven-based, from *sab‘a*, seven). The *sab‘awi* poem has seven free-form lines (lines that do not follow a classical Arabic poetry meter) of 12 syllables each. What makes the *sab‘awi* peculiar is its rhyming system: lines 1–3 end with the same homonym (called *jinas* in Arabic; words have the same spelling/sound but have a different meaning in each line), while lines 4–6 end with a second homonym; finally line 7 ends back with the first homonym, matching lines 1–3.

Baghdadi *mawawal* are the norm in the Aleppo repertoire because of historic and geographic affinity, and they were frequently performed by Syrian *mutrib*-s Muhammad Khayri and Sabah Fakhri, as well as by Lebanese *mutrib* Elia Baida, who was locally nicknamed “the King of the Baghdadi *Mawwal*.” Despite the fact that the *mawwal baghdadi*’s lyrics are colloquial, they may still present a challenge

to the singer if they are not in his or her native accent. This is the case for a Lebanese or Syrian singer, for example, delivering a Baghdadi *mawwal*. Singers must always perform this *mawwal* in the Iraqi dialect it was written in, not in their own local dialects.

The Baghdadi *mawwal* is not the only *mawwal* form by any means, as Arabic singers such as Abdel Hayy Hilmi were performing simple unmetered rhyming colloquial poetry (usually made of four lines) for their vocal improvisations since the *nahda* period (late 19th to early 20th centuries). These forms were also called *mawwal*. Many Lebanese, Syrian, and Egyptian singers in the 20th century (e.g., ‘Abbas al-Blaydi, Wadih al-Safi, and Muhammad Abdel Wahab) performed and recorded many *mawawil*, outlined in the “*Mawwal* Recordings” section.

A regional and folkloric type of *mawwal* that is widespread in Lebanon is the *‘ataba* (pronounced “a-TAH-ba”). The *‘ataba* uses four lines of colloquial poetry (lines that do not conform to any classical Arabic poetry meters) made up of about 10 syllables each. The first three lines of *‘ataba* must end with a homonym, and the last (fourth) line must rhyme with the long sound “-ab,” like the word “*‘atab*” (literally, “blame/disappointment directed at a loved one”), from which the form gets its name. While the *‘ataba* form is hugely popular in Lebanon, it is not strictly a *mawwal* because the melody is only partly improvised (the broad *‘ataba* melody is set, is always in Maqam Bayati, and must end in a descending fashion on the Bayati tonic). Another similar folkloric *mawwal* genre practiced in Lebanon is the “*abu-z-zuluf*,” which is always in Maqam Sikah/Huzam (and frequently doesn’t extend beyond the root *jins*). Lebanese singers Sabah, Wadih al-Safi, Nour al-Hoda, and Nasri Shamseddin excelled in the “*abu-z-zuluf*” genre.

Mawwal Recordings

The *mawwal* as its own musical piece was more common in the Golden Age of Arabic music and is becoming less common in the 21st century. That form is generally supported by melodic musicians and sometimes by percussion instruments and is rarely performed a cappella.

Mawwal recordings as independent performances started to appear in the early 20th century at the end of the *nahda* era, with singers such as Abu al-‘Ila Muhammad, Yusuf al-Manyalawi, and Abdel Hayy Hilmi. Following in their footsteps, Muhammad Abdel Wahab recorded 11 *mawawil* as individual performances between 1927 and 1932, among them “*illi inkatab ‘al-gibin*” in Maqam Kurd, “*illi rah rah*” (What’s Gone Is Gone) and “*amana ya lei*” (O Night I Beg You) in Maqam Zanjaran, “*ashki li min il-hawa*” (Who Do I Tell of Love’s Pain) in Maqam Kurd,

"*kull illi habb itnasaf*" (Everybody Who Loved) in Maqam Rast, and "*maskin we hali 'adam*" (Woe Is Me) in Maqam Nahawand. These examples are all non-rhythmic and start with a brief *taqsim* on the *qanun*, usually followed by a short *layali* before the lyrics proper. Abdel Wahab's *mawawil* are considered among musicians to be a benchmark for the clarity of their diction and enunciation, the precision of their intonation, the beauty of their vocal ornamentation, and their rich and sometimes rare *maqam* modulations.

Other Egyptian singers, such as Saleh Abdel Hayy, recorded many *mawawil*, among which are "*minnein agib is-sabr*" (Where Would I Find Patience?) in Maqam Huzam, "*garahiti albi*" (You Hurt My Heart) in Maqam Saba, "*dumu' 'eini*" (Tears of My Eyes) in Maqam Rast, and "*ya hadi al-'is*" (O Camel Herder) in Maqam Rast. Muhammad Abdel Mottaleb also recorded *mawawil* in the 1950s and 1960s, such as "*ghaddar ya zaman*" (Tracherous Times) in Maqam Rast, "*ya mas'ad il-qalbi law yifrah*" (The Happy Heart) in Maqam Bayati, and "*sallimti amri li sahib il-amri*" (I Have Surrendered) in Maqam Rast, while 'Abbas al-Blaydi recorded *mawawil* such as "*yalli nawait il-gharam*" (If You Decide to Fall in Love) in Maqam Bayati and "*ana wi habibi*" (My Lover and I) in Maqam Rast. All these *mawawil* were non-rhythmic; sung in colloquial Egyptian Arabic; and started with a *dulab* and/or a very short *taqsim* to set the mood, then some *layali* to warm the voice before going into the lyrics.

Lebanese singer and composer Wadih al-Safi recorded many *mawawil* in colloquial Lebanese as individual pieces. One of the most famous *mawawil* is "*walaw hayk btitla'u minna*" (How Could You Turn Your Back on Us?). Other well-known *mawawil* recorded by al-Safi include "*sarkhit batal*" (A Hero's Cry), "*asfur*" (The Bird), and "*libnan ya it'it sama*" (Lebanon, Piece of Heaven). Many of Wadih al-Safi's *mawawil* were only semi-improvised and were more or less performed with the same melody every time.

The two Aleppo singers Sabah Fakhri and Muhammad Khayri were very prolific at performing *mawawil*, especially the *sab'awi* kind, alongside *qasa'id*, *adwar*, *muwashshahat*, and *qudud*, which are all central to the Aleppo vocal tradition. Sabah Fakhri often used semi-composed and semi-improvised *mawawil*, for example *mawwal* "*ya hadi al-'is*" (O Camel Herder), recorded live in Paris on the CD *Sabah Fakhri au Palais des Congrès* (1978). Muhammad Khayri inserted a *mawwal* into nearly every other song in his *waslat* and was considered by many in Aleppo to be one of the greatest masters of the genre, despite the greater commercial fame enjoyed by Sabah Fakhri.²

² Muhammad Qassas, personal communication with the author, 2003.

The Improvised *Qasida*

The *qasida*'s melody can be semi-composed or even fully improvised, exactly like a *mawwal*, except that it has a classical Arabic poem (the original meaning of *qasida*) for its lyrics (see chapter 8: Song Forms for a discussion of the *qasida* as a poetic genre and a composed song form). For this reason, an improvised *qasida* is sometimes mistakenly referred to as a *mawwal*, although one sure way to tell them apart is that the *mawwal*'s lyrics are always in a colloquial (regional) spoken Arabic, while the *qasida*'s lyrics are always in classical Arabic (*fusha*).

The improvised *qasida* starts in a principal *maqam* and returns to that *maqam* when ending. In between, however, it begs for a rich melodic development that includes complex phrases and interesting *maqam* modulations. For this reason, this type of *qasida* is a great vehicle for singers to showcase their singing technique, ornamentation skills, and knowledge of Arabic *maqam* theory (often implicit rather than explicit knowledge).

The improvised *qasida* can be delivered without any accompanying *iqā'*, in which case it is referred to as *qasida mursala* (unmetered, unconstrained by rhythm), or it can be sung over an *iqā'* in the background. The most widely used *qasida iqā'* is Wahda (¼) because it's not too busy (it has only one *dum* per measure) and can be slowed down to leave plenty of room for singers to ornament, while providing them with adequate support. The *qasida* form accompanied by *Iqā' Wahda* is called *qasida 'ala al-wahda*³ and was developed during the *nahda* period.

One of the leading improvised *qasida* singers of the 19th century was 'Abdu al-Hamuli (Egypt, 1836–1901), who was the first to put the famous *qasida* "*araka 'asiyya al-dam'i*" (You Defy the Tears), by poet Abu Firas al-Hamdani, to music. Other pillars of the improvised *qasida* form in the *nahda* period were Salama Hegazi (Egypt, 1852–1917) and Yusuf al-Manyalawi (Egypt, 1850–1911).

Aleppan singer Muhammad Khayri was a prolific and masterful singer of improvised *qasā'id* and *mawawil*, which he usually performed as part of a *wasla*. Among his most memorable recorded *qasā'id* are "*ya man yara admu'i*" (You Who Sees My Tears) and "*salabat su'adu min al-'uyuni ruqadi*" (Su'ad Has Deprived My Eyes of Sleep).

Another master of the semi-composed and fully improvised *qasida* and fellow Aleppan is Sabah Fakhri, with his signature *qasā'id* "*khamrat al-hubb isqiniha*" (Give Me the Wine of Love), "*ana fi sukrayn min khamrin wa 'ayn*" (I'm Twice Drunk, from Wine and Your Eyes), and "*lamma anakhu qubaila as-subhi*" (When They Lowered Their Camels, Just Before Morning). His masterpiece and most memorable *qasida*

³ Eventually *qasida 'ala al-wahda* acquired the more general meaning of a *qasida* on any *iqā'*.

is the 24-minute-long “*qul lil-maliha*” (Tell the Beautiful Lady) in Maqam Huzam, recorded on his CD *Beiteddine Festival*, vol. 2 in 1995 and performed on many other occasions. Due to its length, the starting *maqam* in this *qasida* is all but meaningless, since by the time it ends, Fakhri performs every conceivable modulation before heading back to the starting *maqam*.

Getting in the Mood

A singer can start a *qasida* or *mawwal* directly, without any preamble. However, for best results, it helps tremendously to put the singer (as well as the listeners) in the mood of the *maqam* beforehand (known as *saltana*; see chapter 23: *Tarab*). Getting in the mood of a *maqam* requires hearing the scale and its familiar phrases enough times that it sits well in the person’s mind. A good *taqsim*, however short, can create that feeling of comfort in the *maqam* and start the feeling of *tarab*. For this reason, most vocal improvisations are preceded by a *taqsim* as a matter of routine. For a more elaborate preparation, the musician performing the *taqsim* in turn needs to feel the *maqam* and get in the mood before starting. A common practice in this case is playing a *dulab*, part of a *sama’i*, or even a short musical interlude composed for that purpose as a prelude to the *taqsim*.

A recording of *mawwal* entitled “*fik nas ya leil*” (Night People) by Egyptian singer Saleh Abdel Hayy follows that formula. It starts with a *dulab* in Maqam Huzam (one minute), a *qanun taqsim* (two minutes), a three-minute *layali* until his voice is really warmed up, then the *mawwal* proper (with the lyrics) for six minutes. That *mawwal* became very popular and was later covered by many other singers, including George Wassouf and Sheikh Imam.

Using the same approach, Muhammad Khayri recorded the *mawwal sab’awi* “*durran tanathara bi madhika*” (Pearls Scattered When You Were Praised), which starts with *dulab* Rast (50 seconds) followed by a brief violin *taqsim* in Maqam Rast (50 seconds). Khayri then opens the vocal part with the phrase “*aman, ya ‘uyuni*” (part of the *layali* vocabulary; a standard warm-up technique for vocalists), then engages in the *qasida* proper for about five minutes.

Improvising a Cappella

A cappella vocal improvisations are very demanding and are not very common in recordings, as singers feel totally exposed and have the burden of keeping their intonation from drifting while they sing with no instrumental support.

Many of the singers mentioned in this chapter were trained in the art of *tajwid* (the practice of chanting verses from the Qur'an a cappella, in a highly prescribed and ornamented style, using the Arabic *maqam* as a melodic foundation). The important connection between *tajwid* performance experience and virtuosic Arabic singing, especially during improvisation, is highlighted by Victor Sahhab:

There is a direct connection between *tajwid* of the Qur'an and maturity in the art of Arabic music and singing. Among the many benefits of *tajwid* is to train [the singer] to improvise, to master the traversal of *maqam* pathways and excel in modulating between them, to improve their Arabic pronunciation and diction, to learn the rhythm and music inherent in Arabic words and to fit them to the melody, and to train the diaphragm to hold the breath longer in order to read longer verses. As such, the reader learns to control both their voice and their breath.⁴

A cappella vocal improvisations are very common in the Sufi repertoire, because many Sufi traditions only allow voice and possibly percussion instruments. A cappella *qasa'id* usually cover sacred topics such as divine love, spiritual intoxication, and praise for the prophet Muhammad and his family. When performed in a secular setting, these same *qasa'id* could be interpreted as dealing with romantic love and the enjoyment of fine wine. As such, Sufi *munshid*-s (cantors) who also perform at secular events often borrow material from their devotional repertoire.

One of the most accomplished Aleppan Sufi *munshid*-s today is Hassan al-Haffar (a member of the Mawlawi Sufi practice), who is widely recorded, and almost never accompanied by any melodic instruments. Among Haffar's popular recordings is a highly perfected, nine-minute-long a cappella version of the *qasida* "*ya jirat al-sha'b al-yamani*" (O Neighbors of the Yemenites) from his CD *Hassan Haffar Live*, recorded in Paris in 1995. This *qasida* is a benchmark in singing technique, diction, intonation, ornamentation, and especially the richness of its *maqam* modulations. Another great *qasida* recorded a cappella by Haffar is "*man mithlukum li rasulil-lahi yantasibu*" (Who, Like You, Is Related to God's Messenger) from the CD *Muezzins of Aleppo* (1980), recorded with veteran Aleppan singer Sabri al-Mudallal.

One of the most memorable and sublime *qasa'id* from the secular repertoire performed a cappella is the 9½-minute-long cover of "*ya jarat al-wadi*" (Neighbor of the Valley), recorded by Lebanese singer Nour al-Hoda. That *qasida* was originally composed and recorded by Muhammad Abdel Wahab in 1928. Nour al-Hoda's recording was never released on a CD but can be found in Arabic music archives. What makes

⁴ Sahhab (1987, p. 16).

it such an important benchmark is the clarity and beauty of the singer's voice, her clear diction, the richness of her ornamentation, the depth of her emotional engagement, and the precision of her pitch throughout.

The Short *Mawwal* During a Song

A short version of the *mawwal* can either start a song or be performed in the middle of a song. In either case, the *mawwal* may or may not be accompanied by rhythm. This style of *mawwal* was relatively more common among Lebanese/Syrian singers such as Farid al-Atrash, Sabah Fakhri, Muhammad Khayri, Fairouz, Sabah, and Wadhi al-Safi, as opposed to their Egyptian counterparts.

The *mawwal* can nicely partition a song into two parts, introduce a *maqam* change, or simply showcase the singer's beautiful voice and vocal range in a way that singing a composed song cannot quite do. Performing a brief *mawwal* in the middle of a song also provides a very colorful diversion. The rhythm can stop completely to give way to such a *mawwal*, or it may actually continue to run and allow the *mawwal* to ride and interplay with it.

Farid al-Atrash's *taqtuqa* "*hibbina*" illustrates this idea very well. In the middle of the song, which starts in Maqam Hijaz, al-Atrash sings a short composed but non-rhythmic *mawwal* that modulates to Jins Rast on the 4th scale degree (see chapters 13: The *Jins* and 19: Modulation) before resuming the song in Maqam Hijaz. In another *taqtuqa* by Farid al-Atrash, "*ishta'tillak*," in Maqam Bayati, he sings a short *mawwal* in the middle of the song in Jins Rast, accompanied by the orchestra over Iqa' Ciftetelli. He does the same thing in the *taqtuqa* "*nura nura*" in Maqam Bayati, where a *mawwal* modulates to Jins Rast, then returns to the root Jins Bayati before the rest of the song resumes. His *taqtuqa* "*zeina*" with Egyptian singer Shadia has a very interesting one-minute *mawwal* in the middle of the song that modulates from the song's Maqam Saba to Jins Sikah two degrees below the octave (using the same principle as Maqam Bastanikar, in which Jins Saba follows Jins Sikah on the 3rd degree). Muhammad Abdel Wahab also uses the *mawwal* in the middle of a song, for example in his song "*khayyi khayyi*," which has a *mawwal* over Iqa' Ciftetelli in Maqam Rast that lasts over a minute.

Both Lebanese divas Fairouz and Sabah often used a *mawwal* to start a song, mostly without rhythm. Farouz's song "*ya rayih*" starts with a short *buzuq taqsim* to set the mood of Maqam Bayati, then a short instrumental interlude followed by a two-minute *mawwal* with no rhythm before starting the song proper. Fairouz's song, "*fayi ya hawa*," has a short precomposed *mawwal* in Maqam Bayati (with no

rhythm) in the middle of the song, lasting about 3½ minutes. Fairouz's song "*jayibli salam*" opens with a very short composed *mawwal* with no rhythm; the *mawwal* starts in Maqam Rast and expertly and smoothly ends in Maqam Bayati, where the song remains. Finally, "*ya dara duri fina*" has a short composed *mawwal* in Maqam Rast, backed by Iqa' Ciftetelli.

Lebanese diva Sabah frequently made use of the *mawwal* in the middle of her songs. Her recording of "*ya dala' dalla'*" has a two-minute *mawwal* over Iqa' Ciftetelli five minutes into the song; the *mawwal* modulates to Jins Bayati on the 5th degree of Maqam Rast, then brings the melody back to the Maqam Rast tonic. In "*ghaltan bin-nimra*," Sabah sings a short *mawwal* of about one minute over a fast-paced Iqa' Maqsum and stays on the principal Bayati *maqam*. Finally, her song "*al-'asfuriyyeh*" includes a one-minute *mawwal* (without rhythm) that starts with a few phrases on the *nay* and stays in the principal Maqam Rast, while "*allo, bayrut*" includes a half-minute *mawwal* that modulates to Jins 'Ajam on the 6th degree on the principal Bayati *maqam*, then transitions to the chorus melody, which opens in the same *jins* modulation, before ending on the Bayati tonic.

Iqa'at Used in the *Mawwal* and *Qasida*

The most popular *iqa'* for *mawawil* or *qasa'id* improvised over the beat is Ciftetelli. Iqa' Ciftetelli, which also happens to be the most popular *iqa'* for *taqasim* on the beat, can be played as a fast $\frac{4}{4}$ or a slow $\frac{8}{4}$ depending on the desired speed. Other *iqa'at* can also be used, such as Wahda ($\frac{4}{4}$) and Maqsum ($\frac{4}{4}$).

Just as in a rhythmic *taqasim*, the singer can interact with the underpinning rhythm, ride it at times, and pull away at other times. This back-and-forth interplay creates a nice contrast between the vocal line and the *iqa'* running in the background. The background rhythm also conveniently fills vocal pauses when the singer takes a breath. Occasionally the *mawwal* can get livelier toward the end, and the *iqa'* may gradually speed up and switch from a Wahda or Ciftetelli to Maqsum or Malfuf.

Tarjama: The Art of Translation

Tarjama (literally, "translation") is the art of accompanying a vocal improviser on a melodic instrument. *Tarjama* is the next level of involvement by accompanists after simply droning on *maqam's* tonic. This is obviously a challenging task, because the "translator" doesn't know what the singer's next phrase is going to be unless the

singer has a habit of repeating the same semi-composed *mawwal* or *qasida* in every performance. Syrian singer Sabah Fakhri, for example, made a habit of repeating the same vocal improvisation in different performances in the later part of his career (1980s onward), although his *mawawil* and *qasa'id* remained extremely popular despite (or perhaps because of) their predictability.

Tarjama involves two tasks: following along with the singer while he or she is singing, and playing instrumental phrases in between vocal phrases. Such phrases usually summarize or interpret the melodic content of the previous group of vocal phrases. During the first task, the instrument provides melodic support to the singer, helping to keep him or her in tune and amplifying the singer's phrases as it would in a composed song. The second task is what might be more accurately described as brief reiteration or summation: to recap and interpret the last vocal phrase to the audience while the singer catches his or her breath. The singer and translator alternate after every few phrases and create a musical continuum for the listeners. Without translation, there would be awkward silences between long and vocally demanding phrases.

Tarjama is done using long and leisurely phrases toward the beginning of the *mawwal*, where ideas are still forming in the singer's mind and the *mawwal* is still relatively calm. As the dramatic arc of the *mawwal* progresses, the singer's phrases will become shorter and more frequent, and the instrumentalists have to perform shorter phrases to keep up with the pace and make room for the singer's faster pace and higher energy.

Good instrumentalists can do more. Instead of merely repeating the singer's last single phrase, they can summarize the singer's last several phrases. This needs a lot of skill, as it is very similar to a linguistic summarization exercise. The "translator" has to be very attentive and listen to every phrase in the vocal improvisation in order to digest it, condense it, and present it back to the audience. *Tarjama* (along with improvisation) is another aspect of Arabic music in which listening skills are paramount and musical notation is no help at all.

In some rare cases (judging by the recorded repertoire), the instrumentalist, in a daring move, may add a little something to the mix at the end of the *tarjama* phrase: a *maqam* modulation idea for the next vocal phrase. An instrumentalist who does that may well be overstepping his or her bounds, as the singer may have an entirely different idea brewing in his or her mind while waiting for the *tarjama* to finish. Relatively safe opportunities to do that are when the *mawwal* is performed in the same exact way every night and becomes repetitive, when the translator is a lot more experienced than the singer, or when they have a mutual trust relationship and the singer considers the translator a partner in the improvisation.

This happened, for example, in a recording of the revered Sheikh Muhammad ‘Umran singing the religious *qasida* “*ya sayyid al-kawnayn*” (O Master of the Two Universes), accompanied by the violin virtuoso Abdo Dagher, with Muhammad Abdel Wahab himself hosting the musical gathering. Abdo Dagher clearly suggested a modulation to Jins Saba, and Sheikh ‘Umran obliged. In another fascinating example, in the middle of an extended *layali* performance in Maqam Bayati by Saleh Abdel Hayy, the *qanun* player made a modulation to Bayati Shuri in one of his sections of *tarjama*, which Abdel Hayy had not performed yet but might reasonably be expected to go to next, based on the *sayr* of the *maqam* and his performance up to that point in the *layali*. The *qanun* player developed the modulation and gave it a solid *qasfa*, in preparation for the singer’s next phrase. But instead of following him, Saleh Abdel Hayy opened his next phrase with a completely different modulation, this time to Husayni (the natural 5th scale degree above Bayati), and didn’t even bother with Bayati Shuri for the rest of his performance—almost as though since the *qanun* player had covered it, he didn’t have to!

Tarjama Instrumentation

The most popular instrument for *tarjama* is the *qanun*. Reasons for this choice are traditional and go back to the *qanun*’s powerful volume (all strings are open and most are in triplicate) and consistent pitch on every note (for the same reason). More generally, favorite *tarjama* instruments are of the percussive (*naqr*) variety rather than the sustaining (*sahb*) variety because percussive instruments better complement the sustaining human voice. The most common melodic instruments for backing a *mawwal* singer are therefore the *qanun*, the ‘*ud*, and more recently (albeit in limited genres) the *buzuq*.

It is less common to hear a violin backing a vocal improvisation, but when that happens, instead of complementing the human voice, it mimics it, creating the effect of a second human voice imitating the first. It’s unusual to hear a *nay* provide *tarjama* alone, although in an ensemble where multiple instruments are providing *tarjama*, the *nay* may be given a few select phrases. Having said that, aside from the instrument, the choice of *mutarjim* (translator) also depends greatly on the seniority and clout of the musicians. In an ensemble that includes Sami al-Shawwa, Aboud Abdel Al, or Ahmad al-Hifnawi, the violin will most certainly be the translator.

Aside from being a percussive or a sustaining instrument, the principal (or only) translating instrument must possess one essential quality: it must have an intonation

spectrum that can potentially deliver any *maqam* scale that gets thrown at the translator during a modulation. For this reason, the traditional *takht* instruments are the best suited for *tarjama*.

A very common scenario is to have a whole ensemble back a vocalist during a *mawwal*. Sometimes sustaining instruments such as the violin and cello play a continuous drone (which they are best suited for), while percussive instruments such as the *qanun* and *‘ud* interpret the singer’s phrases. At other times the entire ensemble performs *tarjama* together. When that happens, the result is an extreme case of heterophony. At yet other times, several instruments may follow the singer while he or she is singing, but one individual instrument will perform the *tarjama* summarization that occurs after the singer’s phrase ends.

Tarjama, Sayr, and Saltana

New listeners to Arabic music are often astonished by *tarjama*. How does the instrumentalist follow along so closely with the vocalist while he or she is singing? How does the instrumentalist know how to repeat or summarize long musical phrases after only one hearing? The most basic answer to these questions is that the instrumentalist and the vocalist have the same *sayr* in their minds for each *maqam*. *Sayr* as we have described it includes more than just direction, more than just specific modulation pathways; in fact, it includes everything down to the granular level of specific expected melodic phrases and even ornamentation.

That doesn’t mean that the *sayr* is identical each time, like a composed melody, but that it has shared, common, familiar elements that retain a level of cohesiveness even when combined and elaborated in different ways. The fluency of expert *tarjama* is not about following every note exactly, but about following larger chunks of notes. Thus *tarjama* demonstrates a musical phenomenon analogous to mastery of chess: master chess players are not thinking in terms of single moves, but in terms of larger chunks of multiple moves. Just as with chess, the greater level of mastery attained corresponds to a higher level of “chunking” or grouping—in the case of *maqam*, the grouping of notes into larger melodic chunks and the grouping of those learned chunks into even larger chunks.

Within those larger chunks—analogueous to sentences in spoken language—specific smaller chunks can be swapped out or altered while retaining the same basic meaning (analogueous to interpolation, covered in chapter 20: *Sayr*), and this is more or less how *tarjama* works: the instrumentalist and the vocalist have the same larger sentences in mind, and while some smaller details may not be exact in their delivery, they are able to reach the same place at the same time. The more that particular

musicians work together, the more aligned their internal pictures of *sayr* become, just as good friends can easily complete each other's sentences.⁵

Add to that the magic of *saltana*, the state of effortless mastery and being in sync with the *maqam* (described in chapter 23: *Tarab*). In the case of *tarjama*, *saltana* is simply the Arabic version of musicians being in sync with each other, a well-known phenomenon in recent music cognition research. The foundation of this sync isn't mysterious; it is that shared vocabulary, from the small scale to the large scale, underlying *sayr*. But when musicians really listen to each other, they create a feedback loop that amplifies all of that, which can astonish even the most familiar listener.

Translation as a Metaphor

We can use translation as a metaphor to illustrate the relationship of vocal improvisation to the *maqam*. Translation is when we connect or transform one thing into something else with a very similar, but not exact, structure. (Two things that are exactly equal are not subject to translation; translation is never exact, but has a range of acceptable variation.) Each element in the original is made equivalent to an element in the translation, and this is what makes communication between different systems possible.

Vocal improvisation is the most direct translation of the *maqam* into a musical performance for listeners, and in fact it performs several kinds of translation all at once. It translates the *maqam*, in the abstract, into concrete melodies. It translates lyrics into melody (a much less exact translation). It translates the feelings and experiences of the *mutrib* into a new experience for listeners. And finally, with *tarjama*, the instrumentalists join in translating the *maqam*'s *sayr* and the vocalist's melody.⁶

This activity reveals that the *maqam* is not something that can exist in the head of one single person, but must be shared, communicated, and translated back and forth, in order to live. The version of the *maqam* living in each performer's or listener's head is slightly different from person to person, but they share enough commonality to be mutually translatable. Thus, the *maqam* can be seen, through this metaphor, as a complex object linking the minds of a community, just like a spoken language. Vocal improvisation simply enacts those links in performance.

⁵ Or books.

⁶ *Raqs Sharqi*, also known as "belly dance," embodies another, similar kind of translation and adds another layer of equivalence to this complex. Just as in musical *tarjama*, belly dancers frequently utilize simultaneous improvisation: interpreting the improvisation of a vocalist, an instrumental *taqsim*, or a drum solo through their own movements.

TARAB

EVERY MUSICAL TRADITION in the world exists because it brings pleasure to listeners and participants, yet each tradition creates a slightly different flavor of musical pleasure. The Arabic flavor is called *tarab*. The word *tarab* in Arabic literally means “a state of intense joy” and has been translated on various occasions as ecstasy, ecstatic engagement, enchantment, elation, euphoria, exaltation, or rapture. While the word *tarab* in Arabic doesn’t semantically pertain exclusively to the realm of music, it is by and large used in that context.

Tarab is a state of being in the groove, when the listener feels he or she is one with the music and the performer. It is when everything comes together: the melody, beautiful-sounding instruments, beautiful *maqam* scales, correct intonation, ornamentation, modulation, instrumental and vocal virtuosity, Arabic *iqā’at*, and a good interaction between performers and listeners. It is the Arabic music tradition at its best.

Tarab as a phenomenon and concept crosses regions in the Middle East; any genre of Arabic music from Morocco to Iraq can be rich in *tarab*. While it is also a regionally specific practice, *tarab* represents an activity and an attitude; it is the delivery of the Arabic *maqam* tradition from a virtuosic performer to an attentive listener. To enjoy *tarab*, listeners should be familiar with the musical tradition and should express their pleasure back to the performer.

But *tarab* goes beyond the enjoyment of the music. When a state of *tarab* is reached, the performers and listeners all resonate with a *maqam* scale. *Tarab* is therefore intimately linked to *maqam*-based music and is not usually discussed outside that framework. The presence of a vocalist and the inclusion of rhythm and Arabic lyrics greatly enhance that experience, but these are not prerequisites (indeed, an instrumental *taqsim* can very quickly lead to *tarab*).

In the next few sections, we discuss numerous aspects of the *tarab* phenomenon through the lens of our contemporary experience and link those to our understanding of *maqam*. Those wishing to understand the history, scholarship, and practice of *tarab* in greater detail are encouraged to consult Jihad Racy's masterful 2003 book *Making Music in the Arab World: The Culture and Artistry of Tarab*.

The *Tarab* Genre of Music

By the 20th century, the word *tarab* had also come to refer to a performance practice including the full collection of genres of Arabic vocal music that induce *tarab*. The name *al-tarab al-asil* (authentic *tarab*) is often used to describe that performance practice. Today, the "authentic *tarab*" genre is synonymous with music from the late 19th to the mid-20th centuries, which consists by and large of vocal composed forms such as the *dawr*, the *taqtuqa*, the *muwashshah*, the *qadd*, and the *ughniya*, and vocal improvised forms such as the *layali*, the *mawwal*, and the *qasida*.

Tarab music is primarily vocal because a singer can carry much more energy to the audience than an instrumentalist or an instrumental ensemble can. In *tarab* music, the singer is called a *mutrib* (fem. *mutriba*) in Arabic (grammatically, "the person who causes *tarab*"). This is a much more prestigious title than simply "singer" (*mughanni*, fem. *mughanniya*) and shows the huge importance placed on vocal performance in Arabic music. A *mutrib/mutriba* is the principal conveyor of *tarab*, and the name suggests that without him or her no *tarab* can take place. In other words, the *mutrib/mutriba* is the main act, and the music is there to support him or her. This was certainly the case in Arabic music until the 20th century, when instrumental music and *taqasim* (improvisations) became more widespread and were used to create *tarab* in their own right. As long-songs became more popular in the second half of the 20th century, the responsibility to deliver *tarab* was shared among the composer, orchestra, soloist(s), and singer.

Another usage of the word *tarab* is to categorize musical instruments; *tarab* instruments (*alat al-tarab*) are Arabic instruments that are used to perform the *tarab* genres of music and are synonymous with the instruments of the *takht* (traditional Arabic chamber group).

Tarab and the *Maqam*

It is difficult to discuss *tarab* music outside of the Arabic *maqam* framework. *Tarab* music strives to showcase the Arabic *maqam*'s familiar phrases, pathways, and modulation possibilities using the melody as a vehicle. *Tarab* grows from the repeated hearing of the *maqam*'s familiar and established melodies and ornaments. A person who is new to the tradition and who lacks that familiarity can certainly enjoy an Arabic performance but is not likely to reach the depth of *tarab* felt by those immersed in that tradition.

That doesn't mean that the listener needs to know *maqam* music theory as a prerequisite. The vast majority of Umm Kulthum fans cheering wildly at her concerts had little understanding of the words Bayati, Rast, or Sikah. Many singers and instrumentalists reached high levels of fame and virtuosity without understanding *maqam* theory much, which underscores the fact that what we articulate in this book as Arabic music theory is merely a description of a performance practice that can be learned in its entirety aurally and unconsciously. In other words, for a performer or listener, what matters far more than explicit theoretical knowledge is deep familiarity with the traditional *maqam* melodies and phrases, a familiarity that is acquired unconsciously from repeated listening and/or performance.

The starting point of *tarab* is the repeated listening to a *jins*'s scale and familiar phrases. Many simple *dabke* (Lebanese/Syrian/Palestinian village line dance) melodies hardly ever leave the extended scale of Jins Bayati, yet they produce a very deep and enjoyable *tarab* groove for long periods of time. This is where good intonation is paramount, as it takes only one instrument playing out of tune to hinder the beautiful mental and emotional buildup.

Many *dawalib* simply exercise the root *jins* of a *maqam* and repeat two or three short phrases until they sink in. Other *dawalib* can be more elaborate and can cover the entire *maqam* scale (including the secondary *jins/ajnas*), with greater effect.

When every musician is in tune and has heard the *maqam*'s familiar phrases and pathways enough times, the *maqam* will "sit" (as the Arabic expression goes). A *dulab* can be immediately followed by a *taqsim*, *layali*, or *mawwal* in the same *maqam*. After a few minutes of a *taqsim* or *layali* (or even a few opening phrases, if the mood is conducive and the performer is experienced), the performers' and listeners' minds resonate with the principal *maqam*.

A long *taqsim*, *mawwal*, or *qasida* may cover many *maqamat* by way of modulation, but the listener's ear still saves the starting (and in most cases, ending) *maqam* scale and mood in a special place. By the end of a good improvisation, listeners are fully in tune with the *maqam*. Not only that, but listeners strongly resonate with the tonic (starting note) of that *maqam*. For this reason, during a *tarab* experience,

changing abruptly to an unrelated *maqam* or even transposing the same *maqam* to another tonic creates discomfort and causes the listeners to lose their accumulated groove.

The effect of retaining a *maqam*'s mood and its tonic is very powerful. As a matter of practice, musicians rehearsing backstage just before the opening of a concert make sure not to be in the mood of any *maqam* other than the coming *maqam* used to open the concert. One musician may tell another "*huttna bil-rast*" ("put us in Rast"). The mood-setting aspect of *tarab* is especially important for singers, who need to feel *tarab* before starting their *layali*, *mawwal*, *qasida*, or a long-song. After a *tarab*-inducing warm-up session, the singer will be more ready to sing and improvise in the *maqam*.

The *Tarab* Arc

Each *maqam* has a mood that lingers in the listener's ear and mind. That mood has inertia, which means it needs a little time to be fully established and takes a little time to fade away. The most pleasing approach for listeners is to introduce each *maqam* gradually and let it run its full course. Changing *maqamat* too frequently (by doing a full *maqam* modulation as opposed to a *jins* modulation) is detrimental to *tarab*. Although seasoned musicians and listeners can jump into any *maqam* and feel it, it takes ordinary people a good two to three minutes for the mind to be fully immersed and in tune with the *maqam*. Until that state is achieved, any music heard may be entertaining, but it would lack the necessary emotional depth.

Tarab is felt in stages, as it builds up, plateaus for a while, then fades down. It is like a long and delicious meal made up of appetizers, a main course, and a dessert (which is the same metaphor we used to describe the *wasla*). Therefore, the best way to build up the arc is to do it slowly, in stages (over minutes or tens of minutes), by means of a *wasla* (a long suite comprising smaller individual forms) or a long-song.

A good *tarab* arc spans 15–20 minutes to an hour, and it is not at all satisfying (or desirable) to reach the peak too soon. Indeed, in a heated Umm Kulthum, Abdel Halim Hafez, or Warda concert involving a long-song, listeners often interrupt, cheer, and force the orchestra and the singer to repeat verses until they are ready for the next section. In these types of long performances, there are many peaks as the middle part of the *tarab* arc is more fully developed.

The *wasla*'s structure and how it creates a *tarab* arc are covered in depth in chapter 8: Song Forms. In a long-song, the sequence of sections or verses introduces the *maqam*, then builds up the arc gradually. *Tarab* gets deeper with every new verse, usually built on a new modulation from the starting *maqam*, and reaches one

or multiple peaks. This is when the singer totally owns the audience (and the ensemble). At that point, many long-songs include a *mawwal* or a vocal improvisation over a heavily repeated phrase (called *tafrid* in Arabic), because the height of *tarab* comes less from composed music and more from a spontaneous communication of musical phrases and ideas from the performer to the audience. The singer and the ensemble keep the listeners in that peak phase as long as possible, then the song starts winding down and wrapping up. A good arc ends when the listeners have had their fill.

Tarab in the Maqam Structure

The *tarab* arc is inherent in the very structure of a *maqam*, which comprises its main *ajnas*, its modulation pathways, and its *sayr* (melodic behavior/course). In other words, *tarab* that develops from a long performance in a *maqam* merely reflects the well-developed progression of that *maqam*'s *sayr*.

To start with, a *maqam* has a customary opening *jins* (which may or may not be the root *jins*). The opening *jins* contains melodies that are very formulaic and seem to be mostly set by tradition (very similar to “Once upon a time” in storytelling). This phraseology builds a very important factor of expectation and comfort in listeners; they know what they are listening to. The performer can choose from many opening phrases that are more or less similar, then add subtle variations. As such, the feeling of *tarab* begins to focus through repetition with slight variations.

Next, besides a customary set of melodies in the root *jins*, a *maqam* has a set of customary modulations to secondary *ajnas*, which the listener is also trained to expect. The typical melodies in these modulations are slightly more varied than the melodies in the opening *jins*; this is an opportunity for the performer to introduce variety while still being in his or her comfort zone.

A *maqam* also has more distant options for modulations or more unusual melodies within common modulations, which are known within the community of more experienced musicians (and listeners) but less commonly heard by ordinary listeners. When the musician uses them at the right moment, they can be a little more surprising and exciting, especially if the audience is under the impression that the musician just improvised these modulations on the spot. More experienced performers actually do occasionally create original modulations on the spot, but these instances are few and far between.

Finally, the *maqam* is expected to return to the root *jins*. This return is built into the structure of the *maqam* itself and may include multiple options that all lead to one basic conclusion (see chapter 20: *Sayr*). This involves combining the performer's

original ideas (how to get back) with the expected *maqam* behavior (the *qafla*, or cadence).

Hence we can say that in an effective *tarab* performance, the emotional journey matches the *maqam* journey: starting with the familiar, moving to less familiar territory, introducing a few surprises, and then returning in a satisfying way back to where the journey began. While *sayr* correctly expresses the *maqam* as a collection of intervals, *ajnas*, typical phrases, and modulations pathways, the big picture goes beyond the sum of its parts. Ultimately the *maqam*, as a modal system, is a vehicle for a performance that leads to *tarab*.

Performers and Listeners

Performers and listeners (the *sammi'a*) have a symbiotic relationship in Arabic music. During *tarab*, a feedback loop develops between them,¹ a very important ingredient for *tarab*, if not a prerequisite for it. When listeners hear beautiful music that is being performed for them, they react both in verbal and nonverbal ways to show their appreciation. In return, that confirms to musicians that their performance is being appreciated, and that they are provoking the desired reaction in the listeners. That motivates them to give more and to excel and keeps *tarab* moving forward.

Obviously the manner in which listeners voice their feelings is subject to social and practical protocols. A large audience in the hundreds or thousands will tend to be much louder in their cheers than an intimate gathering of a few dozen. The size and background noise level of the performance space is an important factor.

The exchange between the performer and the listener follows a back-and-forth rhythm. The performer, after all, is telling a story, and after each section in the story he or she expects (or at least hopes for) a reaction from the audience. In a small and intimate concert space, it's common for a member of the audience to call a performer by name after a satisfying *qafla*.

A good analogy for this exchange is a stand-up comedian and his or her audience. A stand-up comedian strongly relies on the audience laughing after every joke in order to carry the act and would surely be disappointed if the audience saved their laughter and applause until the very end of the act. When the comedian is telling a line, the audience listens, and when the comedian is finished with a line, the audience reacts. The same exchange happens in Arabic music, where the audience digests and reacts to each musical phrase in an improvisation.

¹ Racy (2003) devotes long sections of his book to the feedback loop between performers and the *sammi'a*.

Although listening to a live performance is powerful, listeners can adequately feel *tarab* from a good recording, especially if the recording is of a live performance and captures the musical energy well. A group of people listening to a musical recording or watching a video clip together can almost experience the same reaction as live listeners.

Expressing *Tarab*

The Arabic tradition's listening protocol provides quite a few expressions at the disposal of ecstatic listeners. By far the most common expression is "Allah!" meaning "God!" If one "Allah" doesn't suffice to express the joy, the listener could exclaim several quick ones in a row. Other popular expressions are "*aywa*" (yes), "*na'am*" (yes sir), "*ya 'ein*" (delightful to the eye), "*ya ruhi*" (my soul), "*ya sidi*" (my master), "*ya salam*" (how nice/peaceful), "*tayyib*" (very good), and "*jud*" (give generously), to name a few.

One expression often heard in Umm Kulthum's live recordings is "*azama*" (greatness). Enchanted listeners could dispense a few of these in a row, such as "*azama 'ala azama*" or "greatness upon greatness." Sometimes a pensive and approving "hmm" is sufficient during a passage that requires quiet concentration, as for example during an *'ud taqsim*.

Video footage of an Umm Kulthum concert provides a good example of non-verbal communication. The audience, dressed in very formal attire, stands up, claps, and cheers loudly as if they are watching a football game. And just like in a football game, that reaction is not saved for the end of the concert. Indeed, with songs running up to 45 minutes and more, the audience could hardly contain their excitement for that long.

Saltana

If *tarab* is the state experienced by the listener, *saltana* in turn is the state experienced by the performer, whether singer or instrumentalist. In Arabic, *saltana* (derived from the word *sultan*) means a state of reigning or ruling, or being ruled by, the music.² *Saltana* is a state of total mastery in which the performer, the instrument, and the music become one, and the musician transcends technique, music theory, melody, rhythm, and lyrics, as all these become vehicles for creating *tarab*.

² There is some ambiguity in this concept over what is ruling over what: the music over the performer or the performer over the music. We think understanding both perspectives together best explains the phenomenon of *saltana*.

Saltana requires technical mastery of an instrument as well as a deep knowledge (whether theoretical or intuitive) of the underlying music tradition. More often than not, *saltana* is experienced by a performer during improvisations or while performing a piece with much ornamentation and personal interpretation, because this is when the performer is freest to project his or her real self through the music. Very appropriately, two virtuosic instrumental improvisation albums carry that name: *Saltana* (1997), by Iraqi *qanun* player Abraham Salman, and *Saltanah* (1998), by Simon Shaheen/Vishwa Mohan Bhatt.

It is difficult, if not impossible, to enter into a state of *saltana* immediately; a suitable warm-up phase is physically, mentally, and emotionally necessary. Once warmed up, the performer is “on a roll” and giving the best possible performance. In that phase, the musician usually stops thinking about the details of the technique, theory, melody, rhythm, and lyrics as separate entities and proceeds straight to making music. The details all fade to give room to the big picture.

Although an experienced and capable musician can feel *saltana* without any listeners being present, one huge factor that promotes the state of *saltana* is the audience, as their presence stimulates and motivates the performer. For this reason, trying to attain that state of increased creativity and excellence in a studio is much more difficult than it is with a live audience. This is true for any Arabic music performance in general, where the audience is a partner in the music making.

During *saltana*, musicians often slightly exceed their normal (rehearsal/individual practice) parameters, such as speed, agility, range, stamina, and even creativity, imagination, and risk-taking. Certainly a lot of adrenaline is pumped in that state, and musicians often surprise themselves by breaking their usual barriers. This state is analogous to what some Western writers have termed “being in the zone,” a state of “effortless mastery” experienced by many across different creative fields. This state is built upon a foundation of complete mastery, then transcends it.

Saltana can strike an entire ensemble or orchestra. In that case, they all feed on each other’s energy and create something bigger than the sum of their parts. Having this requires many ingredients and is harder to achieve than with a single musician. The players all have to be experienced and proficient at their instruments, because a few weak members can take the entire ensemble’s energy down. And just as in any team activity, it pays to have the team members know each other well and trust each other musically. Everybody’s intonation and rhythm has to be in sync, a point that cannot be emphasized enough. Musicians must be team players and put the overall product before their own individual sound, to achieve *saltana*. Everyone should be heard and everyone should be listening attentively. When all these conditions are satisfied, the result can be amazing. Musicians stop feeling as though they’re playing an individual instrument, and instead the entire ensemble feels like one instrument.

Listeners (who also include performers) conjugate the word *saltana* as a verb or an adjective along with a specific *maqam* to mean being fully in the mood of the *maqam*. When a person says “*ana musaltin ‘ala maqam al-rast*” or “*ana mitsaltin bi-maqam al-rast*,” he or she is deeply feeling Maqam Rast in that moment. These feelings of *saltana* and *tarab* were explored in great detail in Dr. Ali Jihad Racy’s work, which translates these statements as “the *maqam* is ruling over the musician.” Racy translates *saltana* as a “modal ecstasy” and stresses the link between it and the *maqam* scale, the tonic pitch, and the intervallic structure.³ The person is enraptured by the *maqam* in a pleasurable and persistent way, after having sufficiently performed and/or heard it. When they finally reach this state, the listeners have the *maqam* intervals, phrases, and pathways resonating in their heads.

Finally, it is worth noting that although the terms *saltana* and *tarab* have distinct meanings—one being an emotional state affecting musicians, and the other being an emotional state affecting listeners—the terms are often used interchangeably to refer to the overall state of emotional high that affects musicians and listeners simultaneously. Since it would be rare to have a performance in which the musicians experience *saltana* but the audience doesn’t experience *tarab*, or the audience experiences *tarab* but the musicians don’t experience *saltana*, we can view these concepts as two sides of the same coin: the state everyone experiences when the musicians are in the zone, the *maqam* is in tune, the listeners are attentive, and the music is beautiful.

Saltana is also obviously a metaphor for a type of experience—the metaphor of *power*. This metaphor has a long history of association with *maqam* music, resonating even among audiences who don’t have any conception of other aspects of *maqam*. Using it to refine our understanding of *maqam*, we can say that it expresses the power of a shared vocabulary/tradition to bring performers and audiences into a shared state of mind. It is essentially the power of communication to link minds. Musicians feel simultaneously empowered and overpowered by the music; only by developing a high degree of mastery (power)—both technical mastery and the mastery of *sayr*—does the musician have the ability to fully succumb to the power of that music, which is bigger than the individual. The power goes in multiple directions; it is the strength of the links among the three poles of performer, audience, and tradition, all of which are dynamic and fed by this feedback loop. This idea takes the translation/*tarjama* metaphor to the next level: with *tarjama*, we understand that members of a community have the potential for shared knowledge, and with *saltana*, we understand that actually sharing it is incredibly powerful. Thus the *maqam*, as a medium of communication, is both the knowledge and the act of sharing it.

³ Racy (2003, p. 120).

MAQAM INDEX

HOW MANY *MAQAMAT* are there in Arabic music? This is a common question, with many different answers. If we consider a *maqam* simply as a scale built by combining two *ajnas* and consider only the most widely used nine *ajnas* in Arabic music, all possible combinations of any two *ajnas* would result in a hefty number of *maqamat*: $9^2 = 81$. The number would be even higher were less common *ajnas* added to the mix.

However, not every combination of two *ajnas* actually results in a *maqam* used in practice, as some combinations became favorable to listeners while others did not. The typical size for each *maqam* family (the group of *maqamat* sharing the same root *jins*) is under half a dozen, making the total number of *maqamat* used in practice on the order of 30.

Classification

Unlike for the Turkish *makam* and Persian *dastgah* traditions, listing and counting all Arabic *maqamat* is not a precise exercise. The *maqamat* listed in Arabic music theory references in the 20th century usually add up to four or five dozen, but the number differs with each reference. If we also count historic *maqamat* (with archaic Persian names) that are out of circulation today, the

number goes up. In practice, however, the number of *maqamat* that were actually used in compositions and recordings in the 20th century (the basis for this book) is much smaller.

One challenge in counting Arabic *maqamat* is that they are not all universal throughout the Arab world. While the main nine *maqam* families are very well known across the Near East, other *maqamat* are specific only to a local region. Efforts were made in vain during the Cairo 1932 Arabic Music Congress to catalog every Arabic *maqam* into one definitive list, then standardize the *maqamat* by unifying their intonation and use. These efforts continued throughout the 20th century at other congresses, but to this day there is no pan-Arab *maqam* reference (or more precisely, there isn't a *single* pan-Arab *maqam* reference) that has withstood the test of time.

One area in which references differ is in how they define a *maqam* as being “in use.” In practice, *maqamat* are dynamic, just like a language’s vocabulary. As such, they go in and out of fashion with the passing of time. Many *maqamat* that were included in compositions and recordings in the early 20th century went out of fashion toward the end of that century and have become archaic today. Some *maqamat* continue to be used in modulations but are no longer used as the principal *maqam* in a composition, such as Maqam Jiharkah.

One possible reason for this attrition is that during the early 20th century Arabic music was still heavily influenced by Ottoman Turkish music, especially in areas of intonation, forms, naming, and *maqamat* in use. As that influence faded with the end of the Ottoman Empire, many Ottoman *maqamat* became obsolete. In addition, no composer has succeeded in adding a new *maqam* to the Arabic tradition and having it widely adopted, at least not since the early 20th century (although during the 20th century, the *sayr*-s of most *maqamat* changed, and some *maqamat* saw their *sayr*-s dramatically expand—such as Maqam Kurd—so much so that they might be considered new *maqamat*).

In parallel to the formal and academic approach to *maqam* classification, musicians often adopt a more pragmatic approach, concerning themselves only with *maqamat* that have survived in known compositions or audio recordings. To quote Palestinian ‘ud player and restorer Najib Shaheen: “If you cannot name a song composed in a *maqam*, then it’s not really a *maqam*.”¹

This comment was born out of frustration with the inconsistency of Arabic music theory references, as well as their approach, which is overly theoretical. It takes more than a notated archaic *maqam* scale appearing in an old music theory book to claim that a *maqam* is in use. The *maqam* scale is nothing without practical,

¹ Najib Shaheen, conversation with the author, 2003.

living examples showing its use, because a *maqam*, as defined in previous chapters, is much more than a scale: it is a body of melodic vocabulary and conventions, with a specific mood and set of modulation pathways. Without living (or recorded) examples of the melodies, ornaments, intonations, and other *sayr* conventions typical for a *maqam*, there is no way to “derive” that content from the scale alone; the scale is merely the skeleton of a once-living thing.

For that reason, this book does not include a “definitive” list of all Arabic *maqamat* based on historic Arabic music references. Instead, we present the practical consensus: a shorter list of *maqamat* still in use that can be supported by compositions or recorded examples, with the understanding that more *maqam* scales exist in theory and may have been in use at another point in history (before the advent of recording technology).

Maqamat in Use

One way to catalog *maqamat* based on compositions alone is by examining the classical repertoire of *muwashshahat* (sing. *muwashshah*, a vocal form that originated in Andalusia but continued to be performed and flourish with new compositions during the 20th century; see chapter 8: Song Forms). Perhaps the most important *muwashshahat* reference is *Min Kunuzina* (From Our Treasures) by Nadim ‘Ali al-Darwish (Damascus, 1955). *Min Kunuzina* organizes its *muwashshahat* by suites in the popular *maqamat* (sorted here alphabetically based on their English spelling) shown in table 24.1. You may notice that in this reference, Maqam Kurd doesn’t exist; *muwashshahat* now considered to be in Maqam Kurd were then classified under Maqam “Hijazkar Kurdi.”

Another important *muwashshah* reference is *al-Muwashshahat al-Andalusiyya* (Andalusian Muwashshahat) by professor Salim al-Hilu (Lebanon, 1965). This book also organizes its *muwashshahat* by suites in popular *maqamat*, shown in table 24.2. Once again, *muwashshahat* now considered to be in Maqam Kurd were classified under Maqam Hijazkar Kurd.

The full discography of Egyptian diva Umm Kulthum includes over 300 songs that were classified under two dozen *maqamat*, shown in table 24.3.

Finally, Syrian singer Sabah Fakhri recorded in 1978 a series of 14 audiocassettes called *Nagham al-Ams* (translated as “Tunes of the Past,” although the word *nagham* in Syria is a synonym for *maqam*). Each volume in this archival series is organized as a *wasla* (suite) in one *maqam*, together covering eight of the most common nine *maqam* families plus Maqam Jiharkah (see table 24.4).

Sabah Fakhri chose not to record a *wasla* in the Nikriz *maqam* family, even though one could easily find enough compositions in the *maqamat* Nikriz and Nawa Athar, in the traditional Aleppan and Egyptian repertoires, to fill one more volume.

TABLE 24.1

Maqamat Used to Organize *Muwashshahat* into Suites
in *Min Kunuzina*

Maqam	Number of <i>Muwashshahat</i>
‘Ajam ‘Ushayran	4
Bastanikar	5
Bayati	8
Hijaz	11
Hijazkar	7
Hijazkar Kurdi	11
Husayni	3
Huzam	9
‘Iraq/Awj ‘Iraq	3
Jiharkah	2
Mahur	2
Nahawand	9
Nawa Athar	4
Nikriz	6
Rahat al-Arwah	6
Rast	9
Saba	3
Sazkar	2
Sikah	3
Suznak	7
Yakah	4
Zankula [Zanjaran]	4

Source: Adapted from Nadim ‘Ali al-Darwish and Fu‘ad Raja’i,
Min Kunuzina (From Our Treasures) (Damascus, 1955).

All these examples show that two to three dozen *maqamat* were considered to be “in use” throughout the 20th century. Marcus confirms this number: “There is no definitive list of existing maqam: conservatory students may be required to know over fifty for their exams, but many musicians recognize far fewer, labeling lesser-used ones simply as variations within the most prominent modes.”²

A final interesting point about *maqam* classification and naming is that some *maqamat* are implicitly born in a musical composition but are never named or classified. While every deviation from the body of classified *maqamat* is technically a new

² Marcus (2015a, p. 281).

TABLE 24.2

*Maqamat Used to Organize Muwashshahat into Suites
in al-Muwashshahat al-Andalusiyya*

Maqam	Number of <i>Muwashshahat</i>
Bastanikar	1
Bayati	17
Bayati Shuri	4
Hijaz	21
Hijazkar	6
Hijazkar Kurd	3
Hijaz Nawa	1
Husayni	5
Huzam	10
'Iraq	2
Jiharkah	3
Mahur	4
Nahawand	1
Nawa Athar	2
Nikriz	1
Rahat al-Arwah	1
Rast	12
Saba	9
Sazkar	1
Sikah	1
Suznak	4
Yakah	1
Zankulah [Zanjaran]	1

Source: Adapted from Salim al-Hilu, *al-Muwashshahat al-Andalusiyya* (Andalusian Muwashshahat) (Lebanon, 1965).

maqam, such *maqamat* don't gain any clout because it takes more than one composition (and one composer) to "create" a new *maqam* that gets named, classified, composed in, and taught. Al-Jabaqji calls the activity of juxtaposing intervals and *ajnas* to create new *maqam* possibilities *tarkib naghmi* ("melodic construction").³

The remaining sections of this chapter describe in detail *maqamat* that were in use in the 20th century, grouped by *maqam* family. Included with each *maqam* is a

³ al-Jabaqji (1998b).

TABLE 24.3

<i>Maqamat</i> Used to Classify Songs in the Umm Kulthum Discography	
Maqam	Number of Songs
‘Ajam	7
‘Ajam ‘Ushayran	2
Athar Kurd	1
Bayati	37
Bayati Shuri	5
Hijaz	13
Hijazkar	15
Hijazkar Kurd	8
Huzam	33
‘Iraq	2
Jiharkah	7
Kirdan	1
Kurd	22
Mahur	4
Nahawand	35
Nikriz	2
Nawa Athar	2
Rahat al-Arwah	8
Rast	51
Saba	8
Shahnaz	1
Suznak	1
Tarz Jadid	1
‘Ushshaq	1
Zanzaran	1
(unclassified)	40

Source: The Umm Kulthum discography was published in Khalil al-Masri and Mahmud Kamil, *Al-Nusus al-Kamila li Jami‘ Aghani Kawkab al-Sharq Umm Kulthum* (The Complete Texts for All the Songs of the Star of the East, Umm Kulthum), (Cairo, 1979), and was later adapted into an electronic spreadsheet by Dr. Virginia Danielson, who performed minor corrections and included it in her dissertation (Danielson, 1991).

diagram representing *sayr* pathways among its *ajnas*. Readers must keep in mind the incompleteness and provisional nature of these *sayr* diagrams, which are subject to both gradual change as well as individual innovation by improvisers and composers.

TABLE 24.4

Maqamat Used to Organize the *Nagham al-Ams*
collection of recordings by Sabah Fakhri

Maqam	Number of Volumes
‘Ajam	1
Bayati	2
Bayati Shuri	1
Hijaz	2
Hijazkar	1
Hijazkar Kurd	1
Huzam	1
Jiharkah	1
Nahawand	1
Rast	2
Saba	1

Source: Sabah Fakhri, *Nagham al-Ams* (Tunes of the Past), (Syria, 1978), audiocassette, 14 vols.

While listeners may encounter modulations in the repertoire not accounted for in the *sayr* diagrams, that doesn’t invalidate them; it just demonstrates the larger point about change. As such, these diagrams are not presented as definitive and do not reflect a static “standard” form of a *maqam*; rather, they illustrate the complexity of the *maqam* system and how *maqamat* differ from each other, not just in terms of scale and melody, but also in terms of their larger structure. Box 24.1 describes the format and design of these *sayr* diagrams.

Maqam Rast Family

MAQAM RAST

“If your night will be long, sing in Rast,” goes a saying from Aleppo, Syria. Maqam Rast is arguably the most important and prominent *maqam* in the repertoire of *tarab*—the urban classical vocal repertoire developed between Cairo and Aleppo from the late 19th to the mid-20th centuries. Because the *maqam* was so popular during this period and so many songs were composed in it, the number of possible expected *jins* modulations grew quite large. The possibilities include not only the *ajnas* shown in figure 24.1 (the core *ajnas* of the *maqam*), but in practice, all of the *ajnas* shown here in the branch family members, as the traditional habit of musicians is for the “main *maqam*” of the family to include all of the branches as modulation options. Figure 24.1 shows the Maqam Rast scale, while figure 24.2 shows its *sayr*.

The *sayr* diagrams in this chapter represent *ajnas* as rectangles, each containing the *jins* name and the scale degree of its tonic relative to the tonic of the *maqam*; for example, “Rast 1” means Jins Rast, whose tonic is the 1st scale degree of the *maqam*. For *ajnas* whose actual tonic is not at the traditionally assigned location at the bottom of their basic scale, two numbers are shown: the scale degree coinciding with the first note in the *jins* scale fragment and the scale degree of their actual tonic—for example, Upper Rast 5/8, Saba Dalanshin 6/8, and Upper ‘Ajam 3/6 (see chapter 16: Newly Classified *Ajnas*).

The horizontal placement of each *jins* rectangle reflects its position in the *maqam* scale (although successive *ajnas* in a *maqam* scale always share a common scale degree, this is not reflected in their rectangle placement; that is, two “joined” rectangles do not show an overlap).

For the *ajnas* Hijazkar, Sikah Baladi, and Saba Dalanshin, which stretch both below and above the tonic, the position of the rectangle reflects the melodic area of the *jins* (above and below the tonic), while the number reflects the tonic.

Scale degrees that happen to fall below the *maqam* tonic are followed by “LO” to signify lower octave; for example, Jins Rast on the 4th scale degree in the octave below the Maqam Bayati tonic would be “Rast 4 LO,” and Jins Upper Rast below the Maqam Rast tonic would be “Upper Rast 5/8 LO.”

The vertical placement of *ajnas* rectangles roughly reflects how frequently they occur in the *maqam*’s *sayr* (it’s not an exact science), with the most frequently used *ajnas* placed nearer the top of the stack and the less frequently used *ajnas* closer to the bottom (so those wishing for a simpler version can just look at the top half of each diagram).

The starting *jins/ajnas* of each *sayr* diagram are indicated by a rectangle with rounded corners and a thick border, while the ending *jins/ajnas* are indicated by a rectangle with white letters over a black background. *Ajnas* that are both the starting and ending point of a *sayr* diagram combine both styles (white letters on a black background inside a rectangle with rounded corners).

The lines between *ajnas* indicate a modulation path. All modulations are two-way (bidirectional), except when the line ends with an arrow on one side, in which case the modulation path happens only in the direction of the arrow.

Finally, the best way to use the *sayr* diagrams is to take a high-level glance first, spotting the start and end rectangles as well as any clusters of *ajnas* (which usually reflect a relative subsection of the *sayr*), before diving into details. Students wishing to study a particular *maqam* in detail, alongside recordings and repertoire, will find these diagrams a helpful guide to analysis.

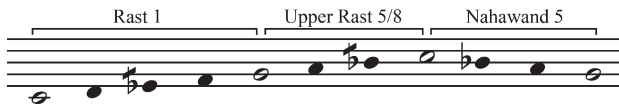


FIGURE 24.1 Maqam Rast scale.

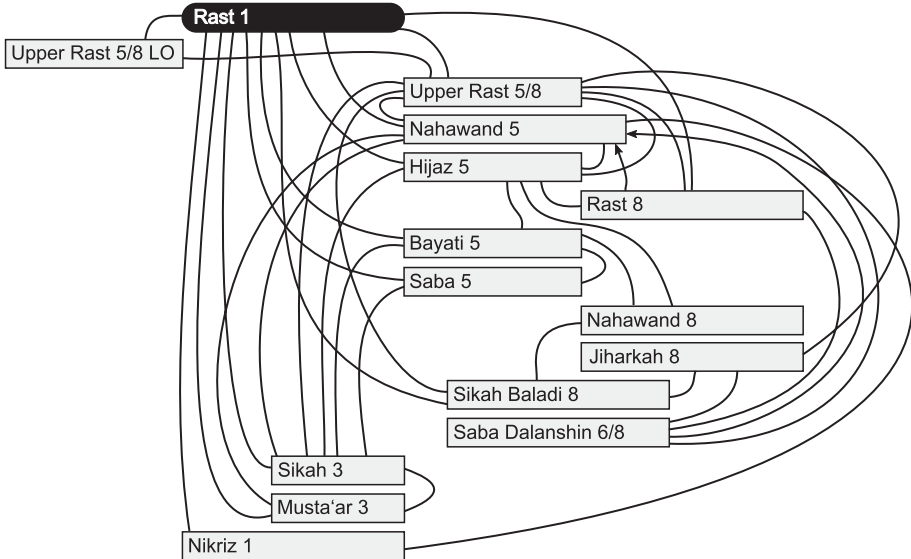


FIGURE 24.2 Sayr of Maqam Rast.

There are many songs from this repertoire in Maqam Rast; we name a few of the most popular here. From Egypt come the following:

- The *dawr* “*asl il-gharam*” by Muhammad ‘Uthman
- The *muwashshahat* “*ya shadi al-alhan*” and “*sihtu wajdan*,” both by Sayed Darwish
- Leila Mourad’s *taqtuqa* “*hayrana leh*”
- Umm Kulthum’s “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*,” “*ruba’iyyat al-khayyam*,” and “*ya msabharni*”
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab’s “*indama ya’ti al-masa*,” “*leilet il-wada’*,” and “*min ‘azzibak*”

From Syria are the following:

- The traditional *qudud* “*sayd il-‘asari*,” “*ya tayra tiri*,” and “*ya mal ish-sham*”
- The *muwashshahat* “*mala il-kasat*,” “*atani zamani*,” and “*dhabiyun min at-turki*”

MAQAM KIRDAN/MAQAM SAZKAR

Kirdan is the name in the Arabic 24-tone scale for C₅, the octave above C₄ (the note known as “Rast”). As such, this *maqam* is really a version of Maqam Rast whose *sayr* starts on the octave tonic and eventually descends to the root tonic. Sazkar is nearly identical, except for the prominence of the raised 2nd scale degree that occurs in some melodic passages (though not universally). Figure 24.3 shows the Maqam Kirdan/Maqam Sazkar scale, while figure 24.4 shows its *sayr*. The word *sazkar* comes from two Persian words: *saz* (musical instrument) and *kar* (work).

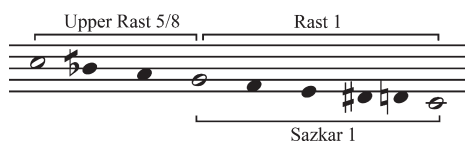
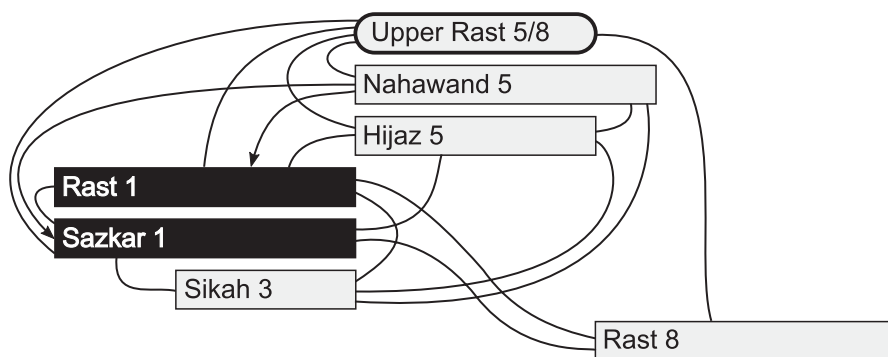


FIGURE 24.3 Maqam Kirdan/Sazkar scale.

FIGURE 24.4 *Sayr* of Maqam Kirdan/Sazkar.

The most prominent examples of complete songs in this *maqam*—the *muwashshahat* “*ya shadi al-alhan*” and “*sihtu wajdan*”—have both been labeled by various theorists as being in Maqam Kirdan, Maqam Sazkar, or simply Maqam Rast. The version shown in Min Kunuzina includes these *muwashshahat* as part of the Sazkar *wasla*, and in fact the D[#] occurs prominently in that version—but the overwhelming majority of recorded performances of these songs do not use the D[#].

In reality, the practical existence of this *maqam* as an independent entity is arguable; from the point of view of performance and recordings, except for a few instances, this has become more of a pathway within the larger Maqam Rast *sayr*.

Songs in this *maqam* include the following:

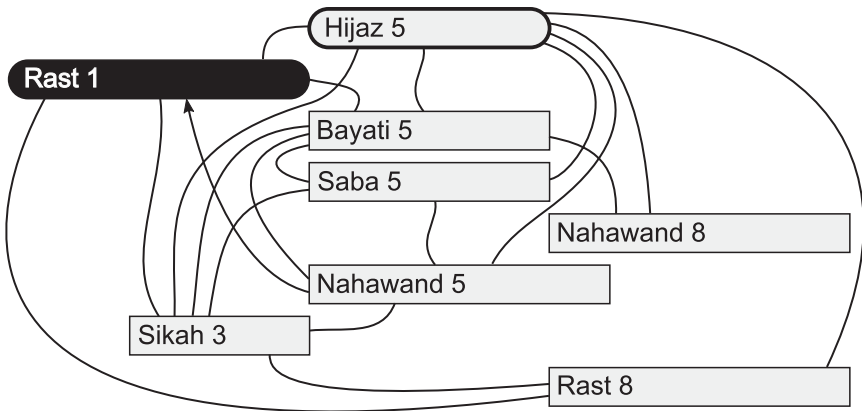
- The *muwashshahat* “*ya shadi al-alhan*” and “*sihtu wajdan*” by Sayed Darwish
- Leila Mourad’s “*hayrana leh*”
- The entrance to the chorus in “*ya dala’ dalla*” by Lebanese Diva Sabah

MAQAM SUZNAK

Maqam Suznak is the most popular version of Maqam Rast used in the 20th century, both in terms of songs composed and in improvisations in Maqam Rast, where the modulation to Jins Hijaz on the 5th scale degree is practically obligatory in any *taqsim* or *mawwal* starting on Jins Rast. Figure 24.5 shows the Maqam Suznak scale, while figure 24.6 shows its *sayr*. The word *suznak* means “burning, ardent” in Persian.



FIGURE 24.5 Maqam Suznak scale.

FIGURE 24.6 *Sayr* of Maqam Suznak.

The most common *sayr* of Suznak (starting with the root *jins*, ascending to Hijaz and other modulations emphasizing the *ghammaz* on 5, briefly reaching the octave tonic, and then descending back to the root) is also the most common *sayr* of Maqam Rast from the mid-20th century onward, when the descending *sayr* of Kirdan began to fall out of fashion.

Popular compositions in Maqam Suznak include the following:

- Umm Kulthum's *taqtuqa* “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*”
- Tahmila Suznak (traditional)
- The *qadd* “*malik ya hilwa*”

MAQAM NAIRUZ (YAKAH)

Maqam Nairuz is quite rare as its own independent entity, but it is prominent as a *sayr* within Maqam Suznak/Maqam Rast because of the affinity between Jins Bayati

on the 5th scale degree and Jins Hijaz. Maqam Yakah is an archaic version of Maqam Nairuz, based on G₃ in the Arabic superscale (named “Yakah”) rather than C₄. Figure 24.7 shows the Maqam Nairuz scale, while figure 24.8 shows its *sayr*. The word *nairuz* comes from the Persian *nowruz*, the name of the Persian new year (literally, “new day”).



FIGURE 24.7 Maqam Nairuz scale.

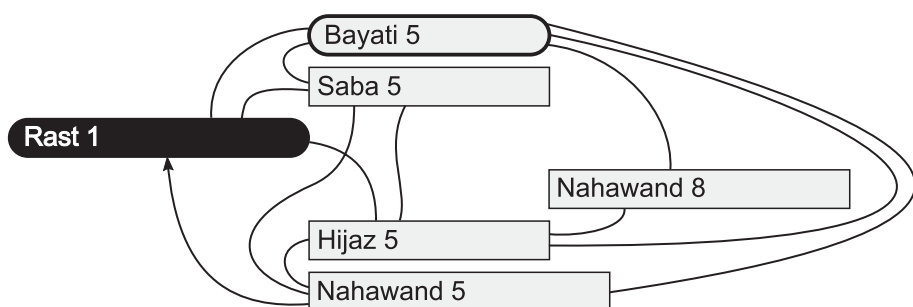


FIGURE 24.8 *Sayr* of Maqam Nairuz/Yakah.

Songs in Maqam Yakah are included in *Min Kunuzina*, but almost never performed, except for the rarity *muwashshah* “*mubarqa’u al-jamali*.” The *muwashshah* “*ya hilalan*” is probably the best-known example of Nairuz, but it is included in the Rast *wasla* in *Min Kunuzina*.

However, the *dawr* “*asl il-gharam*,” though it is nominally in Maqam Rast/Suznak, makes very prominent use of the Nairuz *sayr*, with several of its sections emphasizing Jins Bayati more prominently than anything else. The popular Um Kulthum *taqtuqa* “*ghanni li shwayya shwayya*” also prominently modulates to Jins Bayati in the famous verse “*il-maghna hayat ir-ruh*,” which in longer performances can be drawn out for a very extended period of time, resulting in a true manifestation of Maqam Nairuz. But listeners should expect to hear this modulation frequently in performances of Rast.

MAQAM DALANSHIN

Maqam Dalanshin is quite rare and archaic but used to be much more popular in the early 20th century. Its *sayr* is very close to that of Kirdan/Sazkar—the descent from the octave tonic above Rast—but it starts with the very striking version of Saba on

the octave that we have called “Saba Dalanshin.”⁴ That makes this *maqam* one of the best examples of the lack of octave equivalence that used to be much more common in earlier *maqam* practice. The jarring dissonance of its *sayr*—which has the flat 9th scale degree and the dark color of Saba transitioning down to Rast—makes it very recognizable and beautiful for those of us who relish the old modulations and *sayr*-s. Figure 24.9 shows the Maqam Dalanshin scale, while figure 24.10 shows its *sayr*.

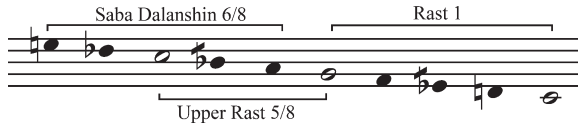


FIGURE 24.9 Maqam Dalanshin scale.

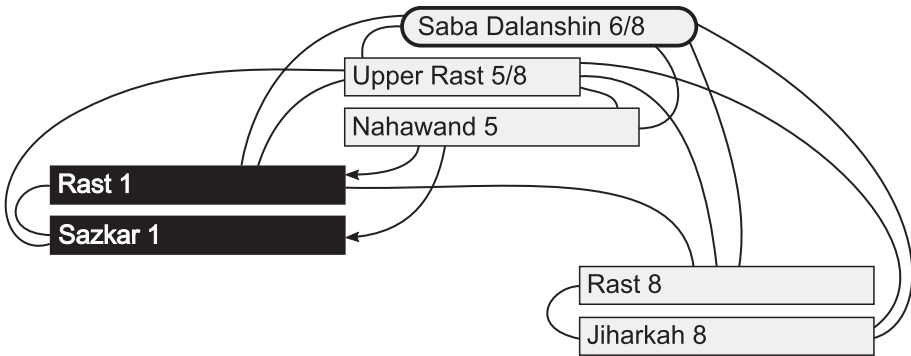


FIGURE 24.10 *Sayr* of Maqam Dalanshin.

While there are not too many complete songs in Maqam Dalanshin—Saleh Abdel Hayy’s *dawr* “*ishna wu shufna*” being one of the best examples—the *sayr* is very prominent in the middle of the enormously popular *qadd* “*ya mal ish-sham*,” as well as the once popular *muwashshah* “*mala il-kasat*.” Abdel Wahab’s *mawwal* “*kul illi habb itnasaf*” makes very prominent and extended use of Dalanshin, resulting in a shocking (and unique) modulation to ‘Ajam (facilitated by the once common usage of Jins Saba Dalanshin within the *sayr* of Maqam ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran).

MAQAM SUZDALARA

Maqam Suzdalara is quite archaic and almost nonexistent as an independent *maqam*, although its *sayr* is obligatory in nearly every performance and song in every branch

⁴ Jins Saba Dalanshin was originally called “Secondary Saba” in “Maqam Analysis: A Primer” (Abu Shumays, 2013). See the discussion of this *jins* in chapter 16: Newly Classified *Ajnas*.

of Maqam Rast; the Jins Nahawand on 5 of Rast is a universal transition device from other modulations, signaling the return to the root Jins Rast. Recordings and performances in this *maqam* are almost nonexistent; the one exception is the famous song “*yana yana*” by Sabah—redone as a pop version by Lebanese singer Rola Saad in the 2000s—which by virtue of never using Jins Upper Rast (or even Jins Hijaz) is a true example of Maqam Suzdalara in well-known repertoire. Figure 24.11 shows the Maqam Suzdalara scale, while figure 24.12 shows its *sayr*. The word *suzdalara* means “lover’s fire” in Persian.



FIGURE 24.11 Maqam Suzdalara scale.

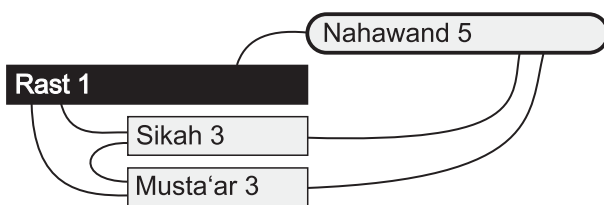


FIGURE 24.12 *Sayr* of Maqam Suzdalara.

MAQAM MAHUR

Whether Maqam Mahur exists as a *maqam* in the Arabic tradition is debatable. Mahur exists within the Ottoman Turkish repertoire, in which it is very close to what we’ve labeled Maqam Kirdan (Rast descending from the octave) in terms of *sayr* and scale. The two *muwashshahat* included in *Min Kunuzina*, rarely if ever performed, display the same tendency: basically, a version of Rast starting at the octave. However, possibly because of the different intonation of Rast in Turkey (where the 3rd and 7th scale degrees are much higher, making the *maqam* scale nearly indistinguishable from the major scale), and the way that was heard by Arabs,⁵ an Egyptian version of Mahur exists with Jins Upper ‘Ajam above Jins Rast, rather than Jins Upper Rast. This hybrid exists in a few contemporary compositions from mid- to late-20th-century Egypt, and among some living older musicians from both Egypt and Syria, but it is difficult to pinpoint exactly when this version of the *maqam* came into existence. Its sound is so different from all of the other modulations in the Rast

⁵ This is pure speculation, as none of our teachers have been able to give a clear answer regarding what Mahur is or why it evolved as such.

family that it is almost never included as a modulation in *tarab* performances of Rast. Figure 24.13 shows the Maqam Mahur scale, while figure 24.14 shows its *sayr*. *Mahur* is a Persian word meaning “a new moon” or “crescent.”



FIGURE 24.13 Maqam Mahur scale.

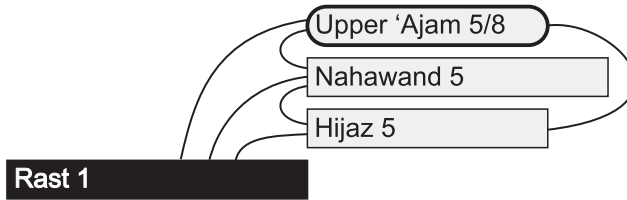


FIGURE 24.14 *Sayr* of Maqam Mahur.

Examples in Maqam Mahur include the following:

- The *muwashshahat* “*bi sifatini ja’alatni*” and “*hayyara al-afkar*”
- Sama’i Mahur by In’am Labib

Maqam Bayati Family

MAQAM BAYATI

Maqam Bayati is one of the most popular and common *maqamat* in the Arabic repertoire, and although it might be slightly less popular than Rast in the *tarab* repertoire, it far outstrips Rast in the folk and folk-inspired repertoire of the region. The most popular songs (and *‘ud taqasim*) of Farid al-Atrash are in Maqam Bayati, and versions of the *maqam* are also prominent in Lebanese, Turkish, Kurdish, Iraqi, and Iranian repertoires, making it arguably the most common and popular *maqam* in the region as a whole. Like Rast, its popularity has meant that its *sayr* has grown to include a large number of common modulations, although it doesn’t have as many branch *maqamat* in its family. Figure 24.15 shows the Maqam Bayati scale, while figure 24.16 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.15 Maqam Bayati scale.

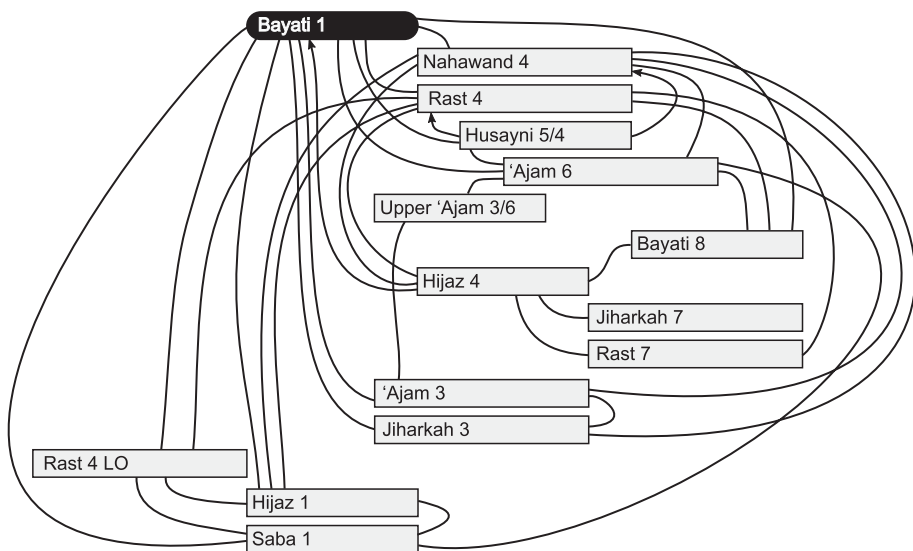


FIGURE 24.16 Sayr of Maqam Bayati.

Famous songs include the following:

- The *taqatiq* “*nura nura*” and “*ishta’tillak*” by Farid al-Atrash
- The songs “*‘ala balad il-mahbub waddini*,” “*ba’id ‘annak*,” and “*il-albi yi’sha’ kulli gamil*,” sung by Umm Kulthum
- The *mawwal* “*ya jarat al-wadi*” and the instrumental “*bint il-balad*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab
- The *taqtuqa* “*ib’atli gawab*” by Bakri al-Kurdi

MAQAM BAYATI SHURI

“Shur” is the name of the Persian *dastgah* system that most closely resembles Bayati Shuri—a version of Bayati with a lowered 5th scale degree.⁶ In the *sharqi* tradition, songs in Maqam Bayati Shuri are not tremendously common, but the modulation to Hijaz 4 is almost obligatory (even if brief) in songs and improvisations in Bayati. Figure 24.17 shows the Maqam Bayati Shuri scale, while figure 24.18 shows its *sayr*.

Complete songs in Maqam Bayati Shuri include the following:

- The *muwashshahat* “*hibbi da’ani lil-wisal*” and “*talaffata al-dhabiyu*”
- The *dawr* “*dayya’ati musta’bal hayati*” by Sayed Darwish
- The early Umm Kulthum *taqtuqa* “*mihtar ya nas*” (displaying the archaic *sayr* using Nahawand 7, which breaks octave equivalence in the *maqam*)

⁶ Although the 5th scale degree is not always lowered in Dastgah Shur, it is in fact variable.



FIGURE 24.17 Maqam Bayati Shuri scale.

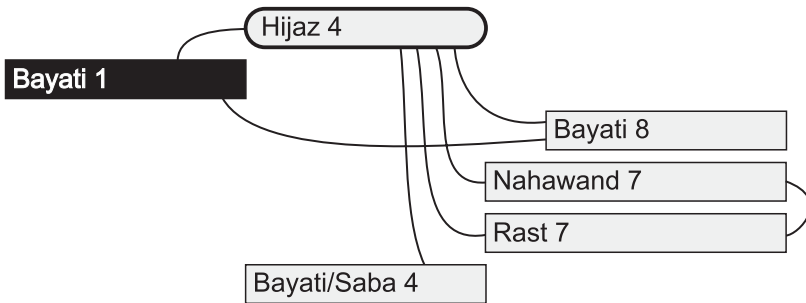


FIGURE 24.18 Sayr of Maqam Bayati Shuri.

- One of the most well-known examples, the *qadd* “*ah ya hili*,” which ends prominently in Bayati Shuri, although its opening is in Jins ‘Ajam 6
- The *qudud* “*habibi ghab*” and “*ya maymati*”

MAQAM HUSAYNI

Maqam Husayni is not very common as an independent *maqam* in the Arabic tradition, though its *sayr* (emphasizing the 5th scale degree as a note of tension resolving down to 4) is obligatory within Maqam Bayati (such as in the verse of Farid al-Atrash’s “*nura nura*” or the second *khana* of “Sama’i Bayati Ibrahim al-‘Aryan”). In the folk music of the wider region, this is actually the most common variant of Bayati. Figure 24.19 shows the Maqam Husayni scale, while figure 24.20 shows its *sayr*. Examples in Maqam Husayni are the *muwashshahat* “*hal ‘ala al-astar*,” “*khala al-‘idhar*,” and “*billadhi askara*.”



FIGURE 24.19 Maqam Husayni scale.

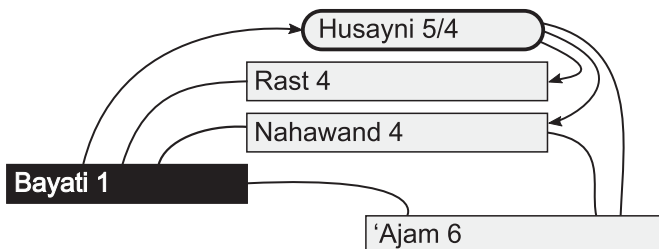


FIGURE 24.20 Sayr of Maqam Husayni.

Maqam Sikah Family

MAQAM HUZAM/MAQAM RAHAT AL-ARWAH

Maqam Huzam is actually the most prominent member of the Sikah family (rather than Maqam Sikah itself, although the two overlap significantly), and Jins Hijaz on the 3rd scale degree is the default for the whole *maqam* family. Rahat al-Arwah is a transposition of Huzam down to B♭, and though its *sayr* is now indistinguishable from that of Huzam, its mood is distinct enough that it has been given a name that translates as “the resting/comfort of the souls.” Figure 24.21 shows the Maqam Huzam/Maqam Rahat al-Arwah scale, while figure 24.22 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.21 Maqam Huzam scale.

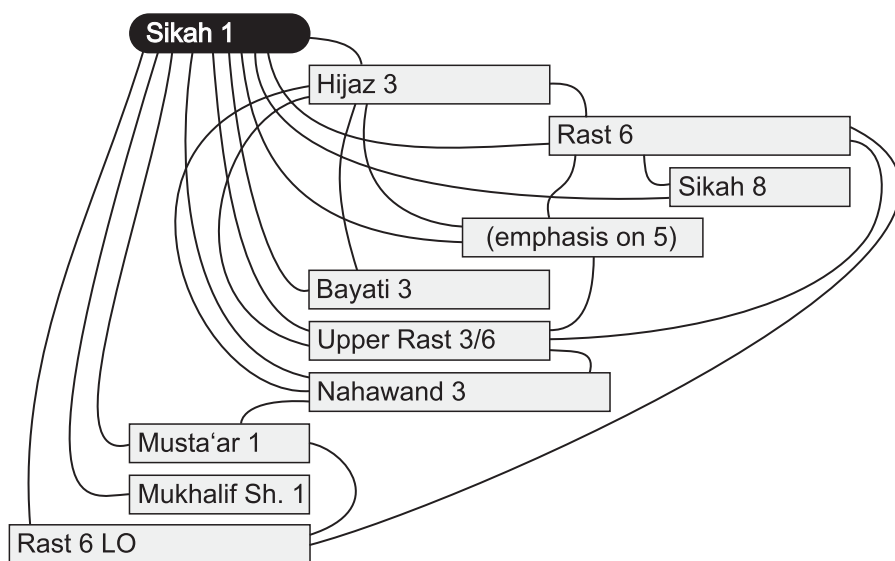


FIGURE 24.22 *Sayr* of Maqam Huzam/Rahat al-Arwah.

The tonic of the Sikah family is a half-flat note, giving these *maqamat* an unusual feeling of tonicization and resolution in comparison with other families. At the same time, Huzam is quite popular in upbeat folk music of Egypt and Syria—and in Byzantine liturgical repertoire. Like Rast and Bayati, this *maqam* was central in the *tarab* period and includes a large amount of repertoire and a large *sayr*.

Examples in Maqam Huzam/Maqam Rahat al-Arwah include the following:

- Umm Kulthum’s *adwar* “*emta-l-hawa*” and “*inta fabim*,” and her *taqtuqa* “*il-wardi gamil*,” all of which were composed by Zakariyya Ahmad

- “*yamma-l-amar ‘al-bab*” by Fayza Ahmad
- The *muwashshahat* “*ya ghusna naqa*,” “*ayyuha al-saqi*,” and “*ya wahid al-ghid*”

MAQAM SIKAH

Maqam Sikah is a rarer member of this *maqam* family, one that has confused nearly all theorists, who classify it as having Rast on the 3rd scale degree. In reality, Sikah tonicizes Rast on the 6th scale degree, and the notes leading up to it form Jins Upper Rast (from the 3rd scale degree to the 6th). This *sayr* can be seen prominently in the *khana* of the *muwashshah* “*jadaka al-ghaythu*.” The 3rd and 4th verses of Umm Kulthum’s “*il-wardi gamil*” also make prominent use of *maqam* Sikah (though the overall *maqam* is Rahat al-Arwah). Figure 24.23 shows the Maqam Sikah scale, while figure 24.24 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.23 Maqam Sikah scale.

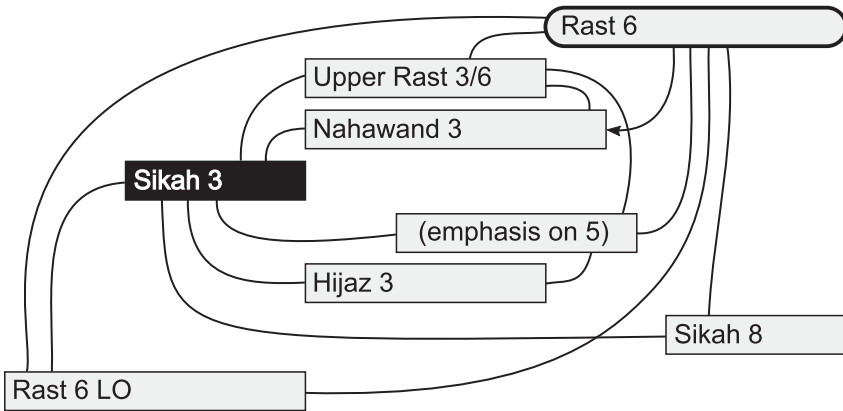


FIGURE 24.24 *Sayr* of Maqam Sikah.

MAQAM ‘IRAQ

Maqam ‘Iraq is a rare, archaic member of the Sikah family, although it is prominent as a *sayr* within Maqam Huzam (similar to the prominence of Maqam Nairuz’s *sayr* within Maqam Suznak, probably because of the strong affinity between the *ajnas* Bayati and Hijaz). Recordings of entire songs in this *maqam* are very difficult to find. Figure 24.25 shows the Maqam ‘Iraq scale, while figure 24.26 shows its *sayr*.

Examples in Maqam ‘Iraq include Samai ‘Iraq by Yusuf Basha and the *muwashshah* “*jalla man ansha jamalak.*”



FIGURE 24.25 Maqam ‘Iraq scale.

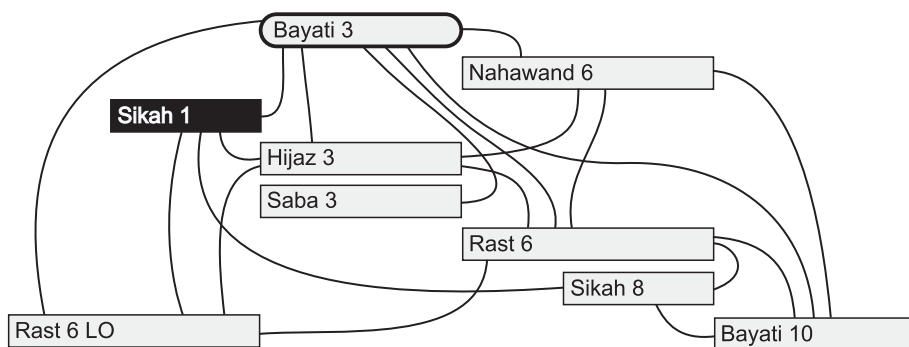


FIGURE 24.26 *Sayr* of Maqam ‘Iraq.

MAQAM BASTANIKAR

Maqam Bastanikar is common in the Ottoman Turkish repertoire but rare in the Egyptian/Syrian repertoire, though it is popular as a modulation within improvisations in Maqam Huzam. From a scalar point of view, Bastanikar is an extreme example of nonequivalence at the octave, as the presence of Saba on 3 eliminates the octave above the Sikah tonic, while Saba itself doesn’t have octave equivalence (see more on Maqam Saba later in this chapter). Figure 24.27 shows the Maqam Bastanikar scale, while figure 24.28 shows its *sayr*. The word Bastanikar comes from the Persian words *basta nigar*, which mean “bound to the beloved.”

In some sense, Bastanikar is an example of an esoteric *maqam* that is popular among instrumentalists hoping to prove the depth of their knowledge of obscure and complex modulations. However, its dark and unusual quality has contributed to several striking compositions, including Abdel Halim Hafez’s famous song “*zalamu*,” as well as a few *muwashshahat*, including “*aqbala al-subhu yughanni*” (Bakri al-Kurdi), “*nuzhatu al-arwahi*,” and “*anshidi ya saba*.” Umm Kulthum’s “*inti*



FIGURE 24.27 Maqam Bastanikar scale.

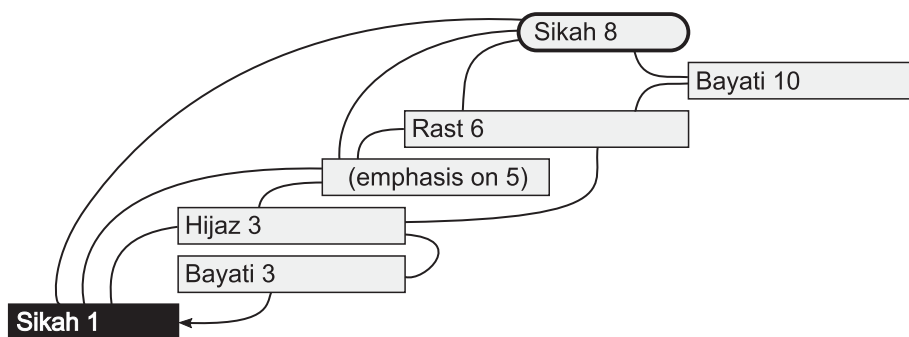


FIGURE 24.30 Sayr of Maqam Awj 'Iraq.

Like most *maqamat* whose *sayr* descended from the octave, Awj 'Iraq became archaic by the mid-20th century, though its *sayr* is still captured in improvisations in Maqam Rahat al-Arwah. Min Kunuzina lists the *muwashshahat* “*hayya wa nadim*” and “*jalla man ansha jamalak*” in Maqam Awj 'Iraq (although the *sayr* of “*jalla man ansha jamalak*” matches that of Maqam 'Iraq). And although the *muwashshah* “*ya samiri da'a sabri*” is classified as Rahat al-Arwah by Min Kunuzina, its *sayr* matches that of Maqam Awj 'Iraq.

MAQAM MUSTA'AR

Maqam Musta'ar (also spelled Mustaar) is extremely rare as an independent *maqam* but more common as a *jins*, or as a partial *sayr* within Maqam Huzam and Maqam Sikah. The transition from Upper Rast 3/6 to Nahawand 3, parallel to the same transition within Maqam Rast (from Upper Rast 5/8 to Nahawand 5 on the way down to the root *jins*), makes this a close cousin of Maqam Sikah, and it is rare to hear Musta'ar as a pathway without also hearing the Rast tonicization on 6. However, the unique interval between the raised 2nd and the tonic gives this *maqam* (and *jins*) a very distinctive sound within the *maqam* system as a whole, immediately identifiable when it occurs as a secondary *jins* or *sayr* within Huzam. Figure 24.31 shows the Maqam Musta'ar scale, while figure 24.32 shows its *sayr*.

Maqam Musta'ar has no complete *muwashshahat* or *qudud* we are aware of, and the only complete piece we've identified in the *maqam* from Egypt is the rare, early song “*haramuha minni*” of Fathiyya Ahmad. But the *sayr* of Musta'ar occurs

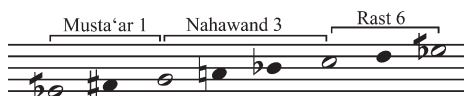


FIGURE 24.31 Maqam Musta'ar scale.

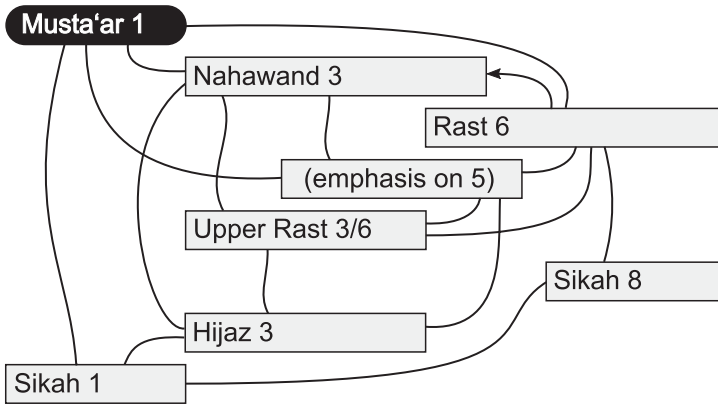


FIGURE 24.32 Sayr of Maqam Musta'ar.

in numerous songs, including Umm Kulthum's "*raqq il-habib*" and Leila Mourad's "*aktiblak gawabat*."

Maqam Hijaz Family

MAQAM HIJAZ

Maqam Hijaz is the iconic "Oriental" *maqam* for Western ears, with its distinctive augmented second interval, but it is nonetheless an important *maqam* family within the Arabic repertoires, both folk and *tarab*. The *maqam* is named for the region of Saudi Arabia including Mecca and Medina, where Islam first took root, and the most iconic melodies in Hijaz are those of the *adhan* (call to prayer). The ascending *sayr* and the descending *sayr* (from the octave) are both present within the repertoire and improvisations, but have not been identified as different *maqamat* (as is the case with Rast vs. Kirdan and Huzam vs. Awj 'Iraq).

Figure 24.33 shows the Maqam Hijaz scale, while figure 24.34 shows its *sayr*.

Examples in Maqam Hijaz include the following:

- Umm Kulthum's "*ana fi-ntizarak*"
- Farid al-Atrash's *taqtuqa* "*hibbina*"
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab's *qasida* "*mudnaka*"



FIGURE 24.33 Maqam Hijaz scale.

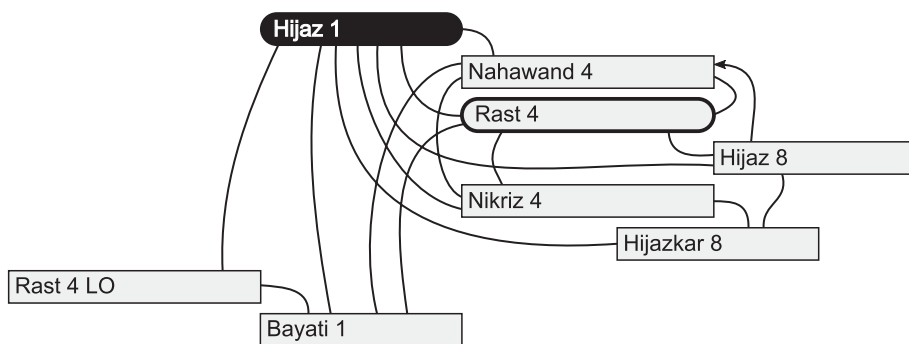


FIGURE 24.34 Sayr of Maqam Hijaz.

- The traditional Aleppan *qudud* “*il-bulbul nagha*,” “*qadduka al-mayyas*,” “*beini w beinak*,” and “*‘ala al-‘aqiq ijtama’na*”
- The entire Aleppan Fasil (suite) “*isqi al-‘itash*”

MAQAM HIJAZKAR (AND ITS TRANSPOSITIONS)

Maqam Hijazkar (with its various transpositions) is the most common variant of Maqam Hijaz. The *maqam* originated in Turkey, and “*kar*” (meaning “work” in Persian) refers to the doubling of Hijaz within the scale. The names for the various transpositions—Shadd ‘Araban (low G), Suzidil (low A), and Shahnaz (D)—also have more meaning within the Turkish context, but we have not found distinguishable *sayr*-s for different transpositions within Arabic compositions or improvisations. The word *suzidil* means “burning heart” in Persian, while the word *shahnaz* comes from the Persian words *shah* (“king”) and *naz* (“endearment”).

This *maqam* also has some level of theoretical confusion, because while it appears that the scale has two Hijaz *ajnas* stacked (on 1 and on 5), in reality the primary *ajnas* within the *sayr* are Nikriz on 4 descending to Hijaz on 1—with melodies that stop on 5 having in most cases the suspended feeling of waiting to descend to 4.

The archaic version of Hijazkar displays a striking lack of octave equivalence with its use of Nahawand on the octave.⁸ Although Maqam Hijazkar does have a fair amount of repertoire dedicated to it, it is even more common as the primary modulation from Maqam Hijaz, occurring as the *khana* or verse modulation in numerous *muwashshahat* and songs in Hijaz.

Figure 24.35 shows the Maqam Hijazkar scale, while figure 24.36 shows its *sayr*.

⁸ See Marcus, 1989b, p. 41 for a full discussion of this *sayr* and the change in how it was viewed.



FIGURE 24.35 Maqam Hijazkar scale.

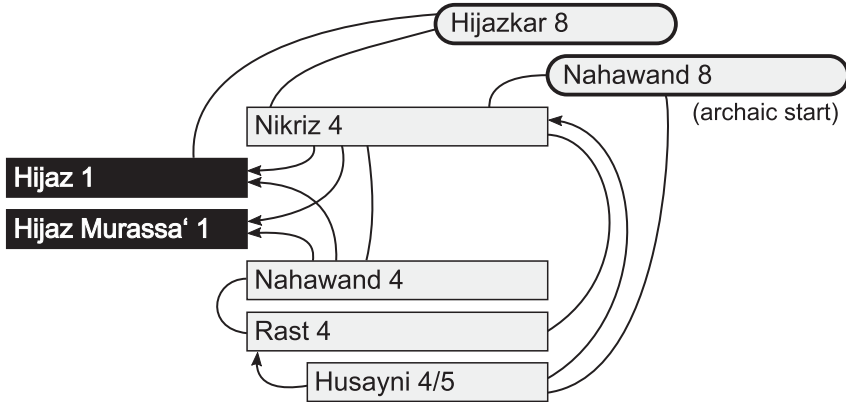


FIGURE 24.36 Sayr of Maqam Hijazkar.

Examples in Maqam Hijazkar include the following:

- The *dawr* “*ya ma-nta wahishni*” by Muhammad ‘Uthman
- The 4th verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*ana fi-ntizarak*”
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab’s instrumental “*khatwit habibi*”
- Farid al-Atrash’s instrumental “*raqsat al-jamal*”
- The *khana* of the *muwashshahat* “*ma-htiyali*” and “*salla fina al-lahdhu hindiyya*” (archaic version of Hijazkar)

MAQAM ZANJARAN

Maqam Zanjaran is a quite rare and beautiful *maqam*, having a sound that we might associate more with Indian classical music (its intervals in fact match those of Rag Ahir Bhairav),⁹ in part because of its semitonal scale (lacking quartertones). It is rare for Zanjaran to occur as a modulation within songs based in Maqam Hijaz, arguably because of the tendency of ‘Ajam and Rast not to substitute for each other on the same tonic.

Practically the only well-known song in Zanjaran is the *taqtuqa* “*ya halawit id-dunya*” composed by Zakariyya Ahmad, but it claims several *muwashshahat* in *Min Kunuzina* (rarely performed), as well as a very striking *mawwal* by Muhammad Abdel

⁹ Gaurav Shah, personal communication with the author, 2016.

Wahab, “*amana ya leil*,” which includes a rich development of Jins ‘Ajam 4 into a full Maqam ‘Ajam presentation, with multiple modulations of its own. One of the coauthors of this book (Abu Shumays) also composed a Dulab Zanjaran included on the 2009 CD *Cinematic*.

Figure 24.37 shows the Maqam Zanjaran scale, while figure 24.38 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.37 Maqam Zanjaran scale.

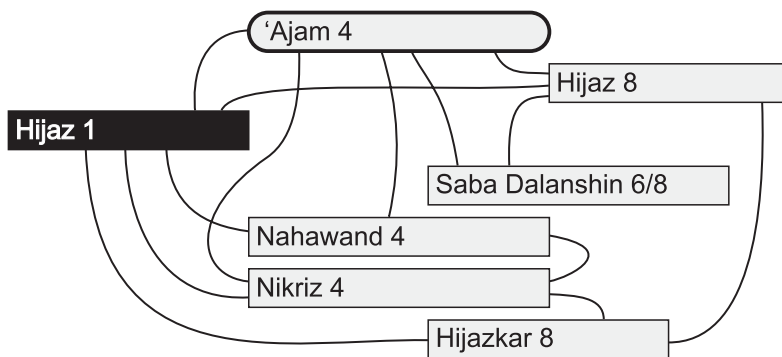


FIGURE 24.38 *Sayr* of Maqam Zanjaran.

Maqam Nahawand Family

MAQAM NAHAWAND

While Maqam Nahawand’s basic scale is equivalent to the minor scale in Western music, and several of its main modulations mirror the “natural,” “harmonic,” and “melodic” versions of the minor scale (using Jins Kurd, Jins Hijaz, and Jins Upper ‘Ajam respectively—the last also known as Maqam “Tarz Jadid”), its *sayr* and melodic identity make it quite distinct from Western music. The Nahawand transposition on low G is called Maqam Farahfaza, and while it is classified as its own *maqam* in the Ottoman system (and has a distinct *sayr* there), it does not really exist in Arabic repertoires as a *maqam* with a distinct *sayr*.

Nahawand is an important *maqam* family within the *tarab* tradition, as well as being featured in numerous dance and instrumental compositions from the mid-20th century. However, with the decline in the use of the quartertonal *maqamat* beginning in the late 20th century, it (along with Maqam Kurd) became one of the dominant *maqamat* used in Arabic pop.

Figure 24.39 shows the Maqam Nahawand scale, while figure 24.40 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.39 Maqam Nahawand scale.

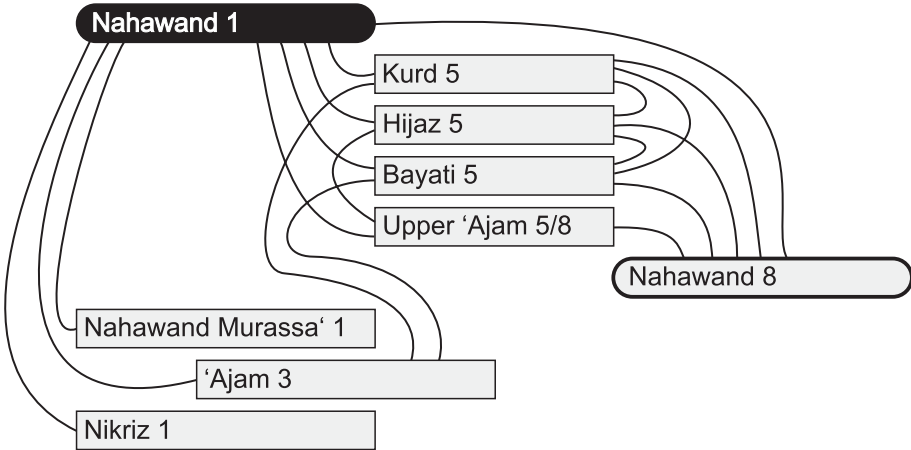


FIGURE 24.40 Sayr of Maqam Nahawand.

Examples of Maqam Nahawand include the following:

- Muhammad al-Qasabgi's instrumental "*dhikrayati*"
- The *muwashshahat* "*munyati 'azza-stibari*," "*ramani bi sabmi hawahu*," "*bat isqiniha*," "*lamma bada yatathanna*," and "*subhana man sawwar husnak*"
- The traditional Aleppan *qudud* "*sibuni ya nas*," "*il-fulli wil-yasamin*," and "*il-'uzubiyya*"
- Umm Kulthum's long-song "*alf leila we leila*"
- Muhammad Abdel Wahab's instrumental "*balad il-mahbub*"
- The instrumental "*Longa Farahfaza*" by Riyad al-Sunbati

MAQAM NAHAWAND MURASSA'

The word *murassa'* means "inlaid/decorated" in Arabic, and this *maqam* is basically Maqam Nahawand with a lowered 5th scale degree, which gives it a resemblance to American blues scales. While it occurs most often as a variant/ornament within songs in Maqam Nahawand, it does occasionally come into prominence as a distinct *maqam*.

Figure 24.41 shows the Maqam Nahawand Murassa' scale, while figure 24.42 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.41 Maqam Nahawand Murassa' scale.

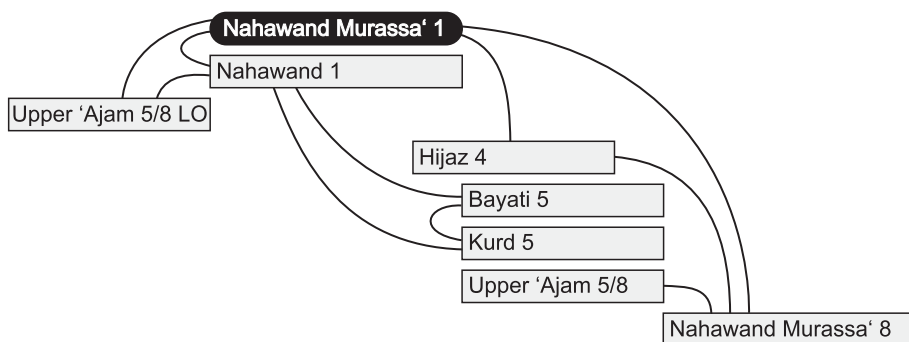


FIGURE 24.42 Sayr of Maqam Nahawand Murassa'.

Examples in Maqam Nahawand Murassa' include the following:

- Abdel Halim Hafez's song "*khusara*"
- Verses of Horeyya Hassan's song "*min hubbi fik ya gari*"
- A dulab composed by this book's coauthor Abu Shumays, included on the 2009 CD *Cinematic*.

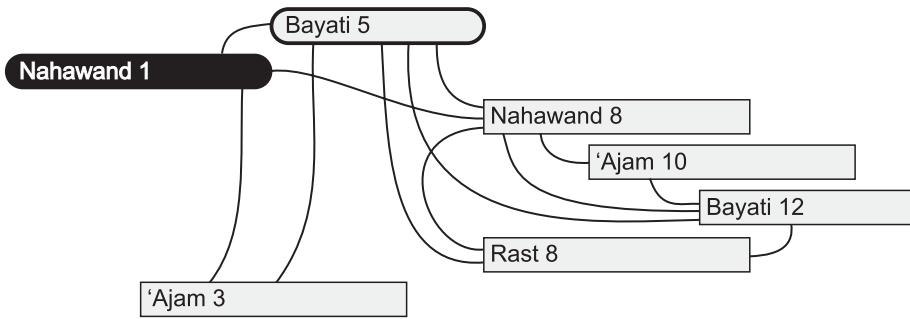
MAQAM 'USHSHAQ MASRI

It is difficult to pinpoint songs clearly based in Maqam 'Ushshaq Masri, as opposed to songs in Nahawand making prominent use of Jins Bayati on 5. That modulation to Bayati is quite prominent and important within Maqam Nahawand, however, and seems to have been more common than Hijaz or Kurd 5 in the early 20th-century versions of Nahawand (such as in performances by Abu al-'Ila Muhammad: "*layali Nahawand*" and "*ba'd il-khisam*"). Muhammad Abdel Wahab's *dawr* "*ahibb ashu-fak*" is one exception that does clearly articulate Maqam 'Ushshaq Masri.

Figure 24.43 shows the Maqam 'Ushshaq Masri scale, while figure 24.44 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.43 Maqam 'Ushshaq Masri scale.

FIGURE 24.44 *Sayr* of Maqam 'Ushshaq Masri.

Maqam Nikriz Family

MAQAM NIKRIZ

The Nikriz *maqam* family is much less represented in the Arab tradition than in Ottoman Turkish music and related music from Eastern Europe, including music of the Roma, where it is extremely common. Nikriz can be easily confused with Hijaz by unfamiliar listeners because of the augmented second interval between its 3rd and 4th scale degrees, but its melodies and *sayr* make it completely distinct for those familiar with the Arab tradition. The archaic Maqam Nikriz lacked octave equivalence; the *ghammaz* above *ajnas* based on its *ghammaz* reached the 9th scale degree, making the octave above the tonic feel quite unstable. The modulation to Rast on 5 (not Upper Rast 5/8, unlike the analogous position in Maqam Rast) is known by the theoretical name “Maqam Basandida”; no complete songs are known in that *maqam*, but the Abdel Wahab *dawr* “*il-albi yama-ntazar*” makes prominent use of that modulation, as do several of the other songs listed here.

Figure 24.45 shows the Maqam Nikriz scale, while figure 24.46 shows its *sayr*.

Examples in Maqam Nikriz include the following:

- The *muwashshahat* “*ya qawam al-ban*,” “*zarani tahta al-ghayahib*,” and “*bayna qasiyunin wa rabwa*,” all composed by Omar al-Batsh
- The *dawr* “*il-albi yama-ntazar*” by Muhammad Abdel Wahab
- The *dawr* “*yalli awamak ya'gibni*” by Sayed Darwish



FIGURE 24.45 Maqam Nikriz scale.

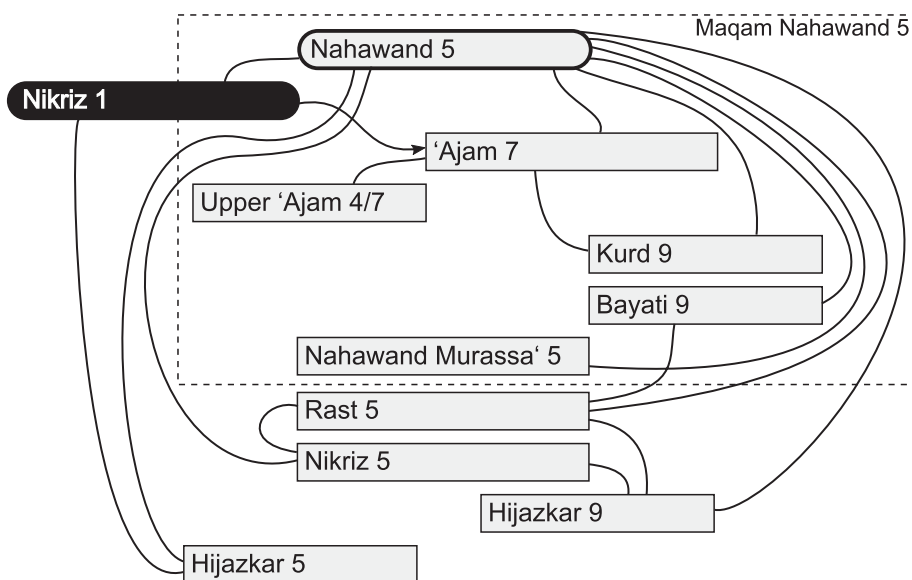


FIGURE 24.46 Sayr of Maqam Nikriz.

- Verses in Umm Kulthum's long-songs "*ba'id 'annak*," "*ansak*," and "*ya msabharni*"

MAQAM NAWA ATHAR

Maqam Nawa Athar is slightly more popular than Nikriz, although it remains somewhat peripheral within the *tarab* repertoire. Its *sayr* is much more "regular" than that of Maqam Nikriz, being similar to the *sayr* of Maqam Nahawand or Maqam Suznak.

Figure 24.47 shows the Maqam Nawa Athar scale, while figure 24.48 shows its *sayr*. The name Nawa Athar comes from the Persian words *nav* (new/fresh—the "v" in Persian becomes "w" in Arabic) and *athar* (effect, trace, or mark).

Examples of Maqam Nawa Athar include the following:

- Farid al-Atrash's "*gamil gamal*"
- An instrumental section in Umm Kukthum's long-song "*fakkaruni*"
- The *muwashshah* "*adhbku al-hubba*"
- Sama'i Nawa Athar by Syrian violinist Jamil 'Uways



FIGURE 24.47 Maqam Nawa Athar scale.

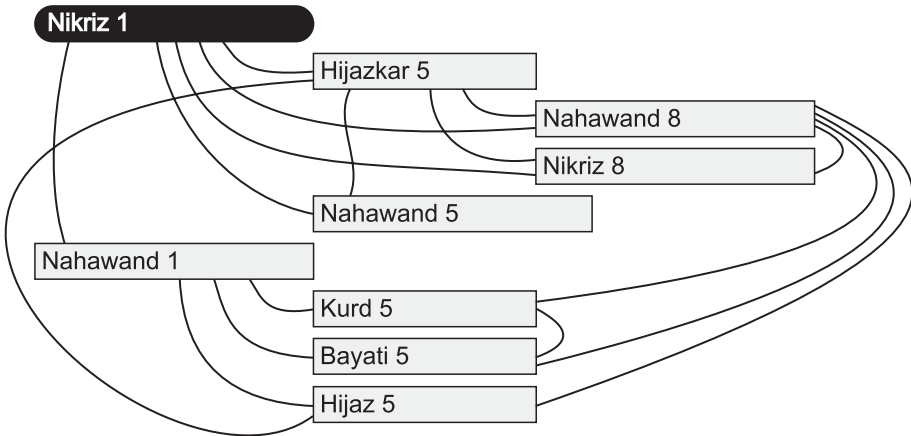


FIGURE 24.48 Sayr of Maqam Nawa Athar.

MAQAM ATHAR KURD

Maqam Athar Kurd is a very rare *maqam* that appears to be a 20th-century development. The scale is a hybrid between Nawa Athar (with the raised 4th and 7th) and Kurd (with the lowered 2nd), hence the name. Because it was never fully developed or utilized prominently, composers have treated it alternately as part of the 5-note Nikriz family or the 4-note Kurd family. The only complete song we have identified in this *maqam* is “*ya fagri nurak*” (vocals by Baligh Hamdi, music by Yusuf Shawqi), while two Leila Mourad songs display Athar Kurd as a *jins* modulation within Nahawand (the third verse of “*il-hana wil-widd*”) or within Kurd (the third verse of “*raydak*”). Finally, verse 3 of Abdel Halim Hafez’s song “*habibaha*” modulates to Athar Kurd at the phrase “*wa sirtu wahdi sharidan*.”

Figure 24.49 shows the Maqam Athar Kurd scale, while figure 24.50 shows its *sayr*.

Maqam Kurd Family

MAQAM KURD

Maqam Kurd really only came into its own as a *maqam* in the 20th century, and it remains fairly rare within the *tarab* repertoire. Originally evolving from Maqam Hijazkar Kurd (the *muwashshahat* we associate with *wasla* Kurd are

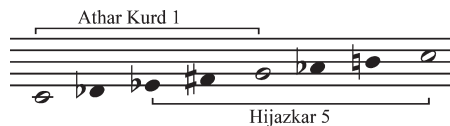
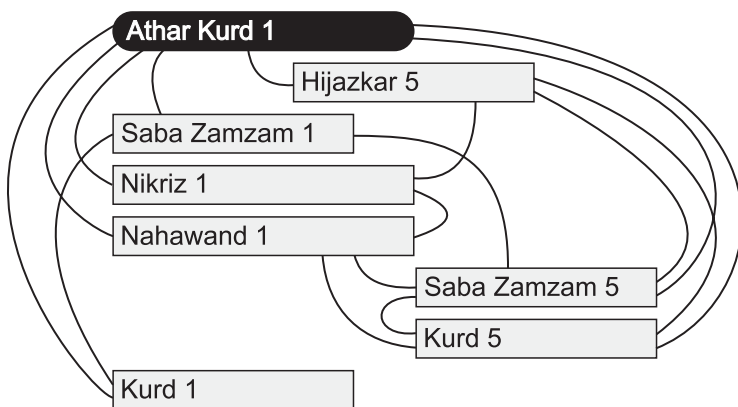


FIGURE 24.49 Maqam Athar Kurd scale.

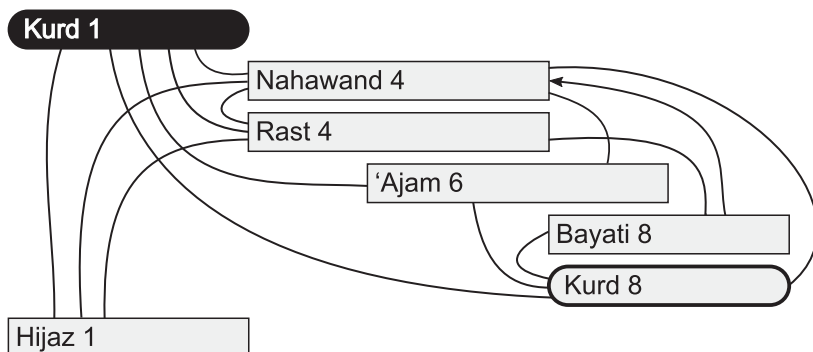
FIGURE 24.50 *Sayr* of Maqam Athar Kurd.

labeled “Hijazkar Kurdi” in the collection *Min Kunuzina*), by the mid-20th century Kurd, as practiced in new Egyptian compositions, had a *sayr* resembling Bayati and Hijaz (ascending *sayr*, with modulations to Nahawand and Rast on its 4th scale degree). As it evolved, it developed a series of experimental chromatic modulations (see the version of Kurd labeled “1950s Expansion” below), but then toward the end of the 20th century became simplified again for pop music (and losing the modulation to Rast 4). The *sayr* shown here represents both the mid-20th-century Egyptian consensus and the lingering structure of Kurd in contemporary pop.

Figure 24.51 shows the Maqam Kurd scale, while figure 24.52 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.51 Maqam Kurd scale.

FIGURE 24.52 *Sayr* of Maqam Kurd.

Examples in Maqam Kurd include the following:

- The *dawr* “*ana haweit*” by Sayed Darwish
- The *muwashshahat* “*yamurru ‘ujuban*” and “*ya bahjet ir-roh*”
- Leila Mourad’s “*sanatein w-ana ahayil fik*”
- Karem Mahmoud’s “*mashghul ‘aleik*”
- Sama’i Kurd by Egyptian violinist Abdo Dagher

MAQAM HIJAZKAR KURD

The name “Hijazkar Kurd” refers to two distinct *maqamat*: the archaic classification of what most now call Maqam Kurd (shown in the prior section) and an archaic version of Kurd whose *sayr* starts with Jins Hijazkar on the octave. (The reason for the archaic classification of Kurd is that the scale was conceptually on C, the tonic of Hijazkar; this is in parallel with the Ottoman Turkish Makam “Kürdili Hicazkar,” which is also a version of Kurd on C.) The chart displayed in Figure 24.53 shows the latter: the *maqam* whose *sayr* starts with Hijazkar on the octave, then lowers the “raised” intervals on the way down to a *qafila* on the root Jins Kurd. *Min Kunuzina* classifies *muwashshahat* of both types as “Hijazkar Kurd,” although the ones that actually use Hijazkar within their *sayr* are “*tifya durri*,” “*ya dha al-qawam al-samhari*,” and the *khana* section of “*hibbi zurni ma tayassar*.” Another example is the early *taqtuqa* “*izzay tibi’ni w-ana ashtirik*” by Saleh Abdel Hayy.

Figure 24.53 shows the Maqam Hijazkar Kurd scale, while figure 24.54 shows its *sayr*.

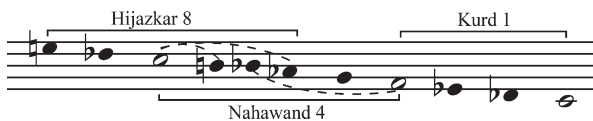


FIGURE 24.53 Maqam Hijazkar Kurd scale.

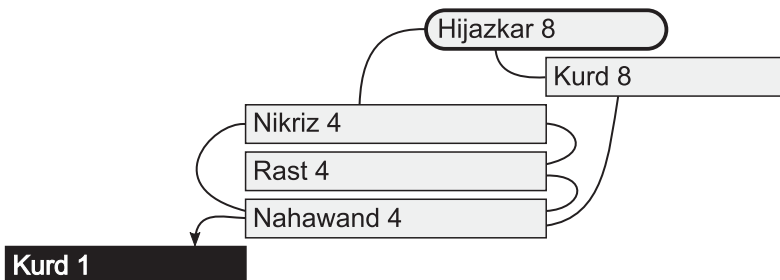
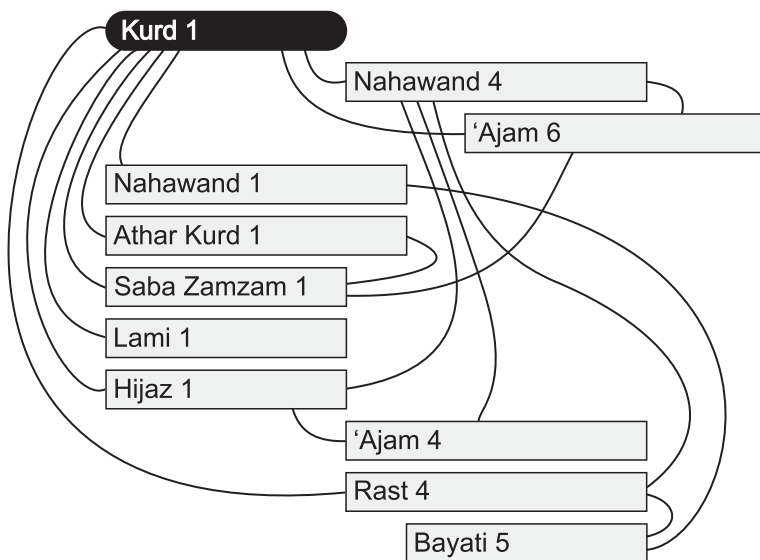


FIGURE 24.54 *Sayr* of Maqam Hijazkar Kurd.



Maqam 'Ajam Family

MAQAM 'AJAM (EGYPTIAN VERSION)

The word *'ajam* means “foreign” in Arabic—referring specifically to Persia (modern-day Iran)—and this *maqam*, whose basic scale is identical (conceptually) to the Western major scale, is in some sense foreign to the core of Arabic music as practiced in the early to mid-20th century. (And despite being semitonal, it has become even rarer in the pop era, unlike Kurd and Nahawand.) The version of Maqam 'Ajam represented in this section is rarely acknowledged by music theorists, who retain the archaic classification of 'Ajam 'Ushayran (discussed later in this chapter) as the only version of the *maqam*. But in fact, in the 20th century (dating back to Sayed Darwish) a version of 'Ajam evolved with a *ghammaz* on 5, whose *sayr* resembles that of Suznak or Nahawand. This version of Maqam 'Ajam is represented primarily in the Egyptian, rather than the Aleppan, repertoire; hence we have labeled it “Egyptian 'Ajam” or the “Egyptian version” of 'Ajam.

Figure 24.57 shows the Maqam 'Ajam scale, while figure 24.58 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.57 Maqam 'Ajam scale (Egyptian version)

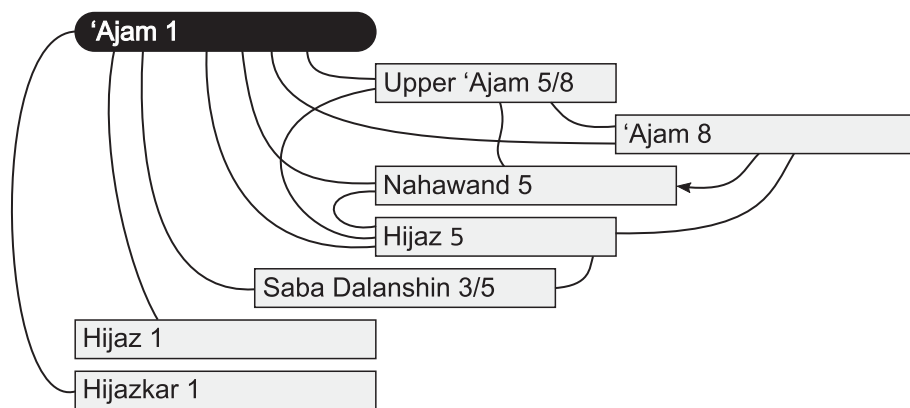


FIGURE 24.58 *Sayr* of Maqam 'Ajam (Egyptian version)

Examples in Maqam 'Ajam include the following:

- Sayed Darwish's "*til'it ya m-abla nurha*"
- The traditional Iraqi song "*tal'a min beit abuha*," made popular by Nazem al-Ghazali

- Umm Kulthum's long-song "*aghadan alqak*"
- Warda's long-song "*fi youm wi leila*"
- Muhammad Qandil's "*habl il-widad in'ata*"

MAQAM SHAWQ AFZA

Maqam Shawq Afza is the most common variant of Egyptian 'Ajam, with the prominence of Jins Hijaz on 5 being its distinguishing characteristic, as well as Jins Saba Dalanshin 3/5 (mislabelled as Saba 3 by many musicians and theorists alike).

Figure 24.59 shows the Maqam Shawq Afza scale, while figure 24.60 shows its *sayr*. The words *shawq afza* mean "more longing/yearning" in Persian.



FIGURE 24.59 Maqam Shawq Afza scale.

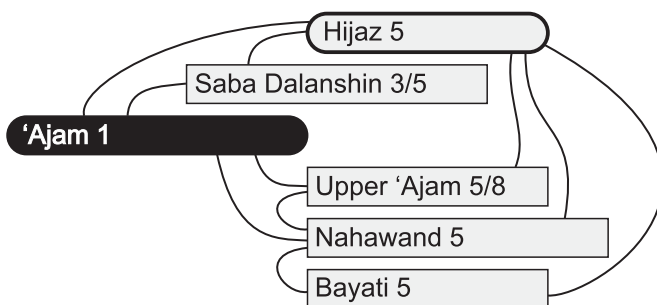


FIGURE 24.60 *Sayr* of Maqam Shawq Afza.

Examples in Maqam Shawq Afza include the following:

- Umm Kulthum's "*lissa fakir*"
- Fairouz's "*zabrit il-janub (iswarit il-'arus)*"
- Longa 'Ajam by Abdo Dagher

MAQAM 'AJAM 'USHAYRAN

Maqam 'Ajam 'Ushayran isn't simply an archaic version of Maqam 'Ajam with a different *sayr*; it has a completely different tonal emphasis than the versions of 'Ajam represented in figures 24.57 and 24.58. Rather than tonicizing its 5th scale degree (as do Rast, Nahawand, Nikriz, and Egyptian 'Ajam), 'Ajam 'Ushayran tonicizes its 3rd and 6th scale degrees (as Huzam does, though in a very different way). The presence of the *ajnas* Bayati and Hijazkar on the 3rd scale degree, the strong Nahawand on

6, and several other *ajnas* make this very distinct from “Egyptian” ‘Ajam, although there are a few *ajnas* that overlap (such as the descending Nahawand 5). ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran, despite its archaic status as an independent *maqam*, remains prominent as a modulation on the 6th scale degree of Maqam Bayati or Maqam Saba.

Figure 24.61 shows the Maqam ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran scale, while figure 24.62 shows its *sayr*.

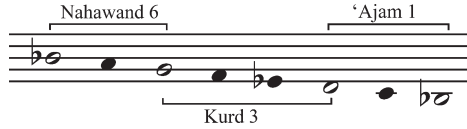


FIGURE 24.61 Maqam ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran scale.

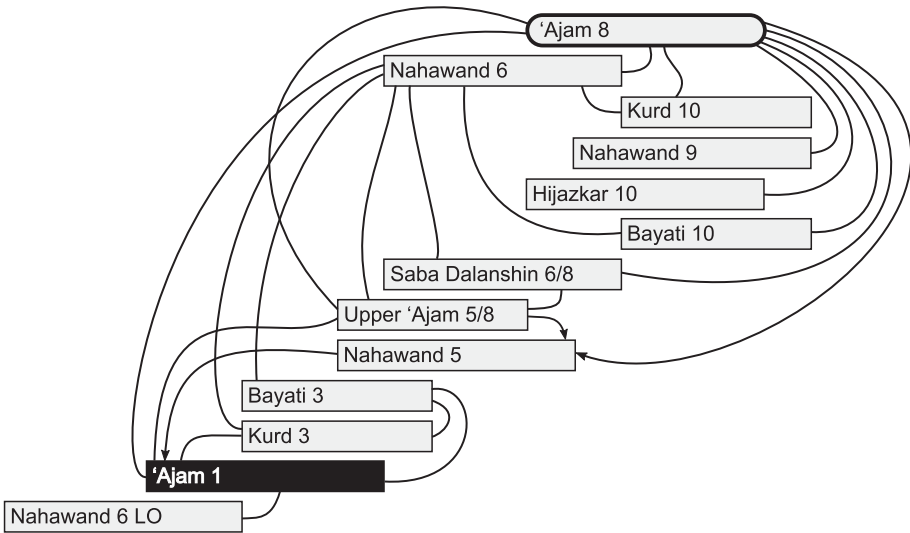


FIGURE 24.62 *Sayr* of Maqam ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran.

Maqam ‘Ajam ‘Ushayran features some rarely performed *muwashshahat* such as “*da’i al-hawa qad saba*,” “*ayqadha al-hubbu fu’adi*,” and “*ma li ‘ayni absarat*.” It does exist in very early recordings in Egypt, including the *taqtuqa* “*il-hubbi fi albi amana*” sung by Fathiyya Ahmad, but it is more common in a secondary context, such as in the third verse of Umm Kulthum’s “*huwwa sahib*” at the phrase “*il-albi ah*.”

Maqam Saba

Despite several similarities to Maqam Bayati (its root *jins* is identical to Bayati with a lowered 4th scale degree; it features a prominent Jins ‘Ajam on 6), Maqam Saba¹⁰

¹⁰ Maqam Saba is listed alongside the *maqam* families, despite the fact that it is a single *maqam*, because of its prominence in the repertoire and in historical classifications.

retains a distinctive *sayr* and character, one that makes it immediately recognizable due to the unique interval sequence between the 2nd, 3rd, 4th, and 5th scale degrees.

Figure 24.63 shows the Maqam Saba scale, while figure 24.64 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.63 Maqam Saba scale.

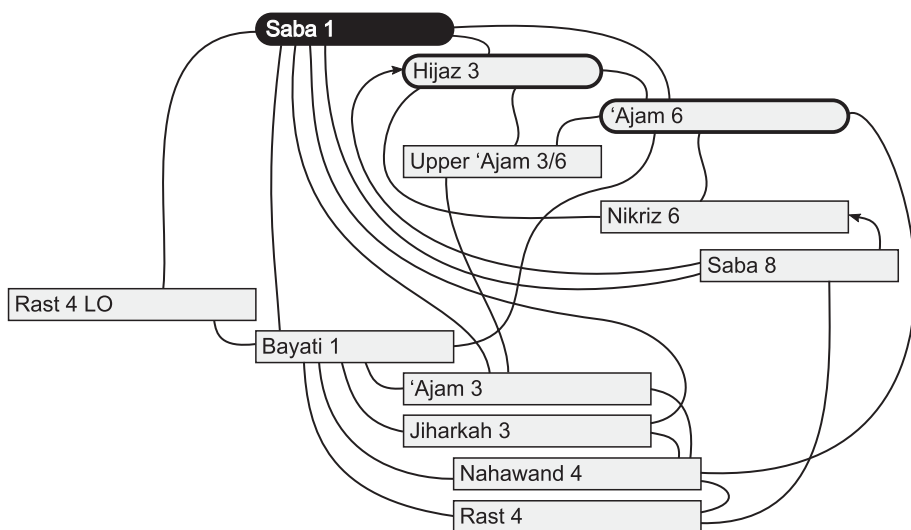


FIGURE 24.64 *Sayr* of Maqam Saba.

The mood of Maqam Saba is almost universally agreed upon as being melancholy, and its name comes from the expression “East Wind” in Arabic. It is the strongest remaining *maqam* that lacks octave equivalence; in fact, its 8th scale degree isn’t even an octave above the tonic, it is a flat octave! However, many folk songs do not use the entire *sayr* of Maqam Saba, remaining in the lower jins and avoiding the octave altogether.

Saba does not have any branch *maqamat* and doesn’t have a wide variety of options for modulations from each of its few modulation points (mostly 3 and 6, though occasionally the octave tonic is used, as well as Jins Rast underneath the tonic, similar to the *maqamat* Bayati and Hijaz). Hence its *sayr* is very constrained, adding to the intensity of the *maqam*, which tends to repeat a small set of common pathways.

Examples in Maqam Saba include the following:

- The *qasida* “*uhibbuki ya salma*” by Yusuf al-Manyalawi
- The *dawr* “*addi m-ahibbak zaʿlan minnak*,” recorded by Saleh Abdel Hayy

- The *muwashshahat* “*ahwa qamaran*” and “*ghuddi jufunik*”
- The songs “*ba’rit haba*” and “*ya falastiniyya*” by Sheikh Imam
- The traditional Aleppan *qudud* “*skaba ya dumu’ il-‘ein*,” “*halla halla ya jamlo*,” “*doumik doum*,” and “*ya m-as’ad es-sabahiyya*”
- Umm Kukthum’s long-song “*huwwa sahib*” by Zakariyya Ahmad
- Ahmad Adaweya’s “*salamitha ummu hasan*” and “*habba fou’*”
- Hakim’s “*wala wahid (wala milyun)*”

Other Maqamat

MAQAM SABA ZAMZAM

Maqam Saba Zamzam is represented in theory as a *maqam*, but it is in fact mostly a *jins* modulation. However, along with the expansion of Kurd and Athar Kurd in the mid-20th century, Saba Zamzam found several viable modulation pathways. Figure 24.65 shows the Maqam Saba Zamzam scale, while figure 24.66 shows its *sayr*. This diagram shows Saba Zamzam as having a similar *sayr* to Maqam Saba (since it can be viewed as a semitonal version of Saba, with its flat 2nd scale degree), but includes its distinct modulations to Kurd and Athar Kurd on the root tonic, which is really where it was used most frequently.



FIGURE 24.65 Maqam Saba Zamzam scale.

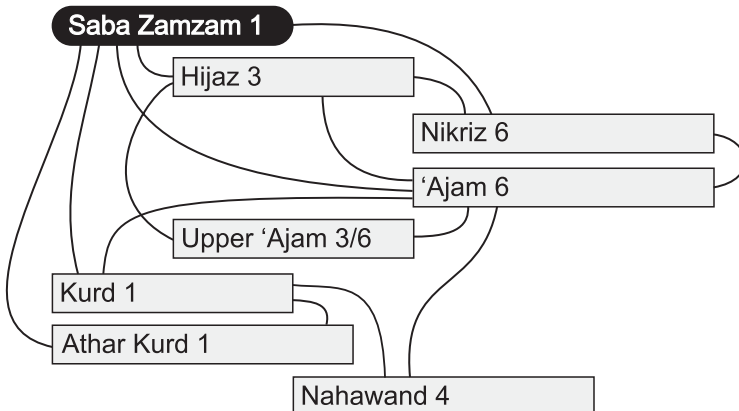


FIGURE 24.66 *Sayr* of Maqam Saba Zamzam.

Examples in Maqam Saba Zamzam include the following:

- Ahmad 'Adawiyya's "*ya bint is-sultan*"
- The ending of the introductions in Abdel Halim Hafez's songs "*sawwah*" and "*ala hisbi widad galbi*"
- The introduction in Umm Kulthum's "*amal hayati*," which modulates to Saba Zamzam

MAQAM LAMI

Maqam Lami is an Iraqi Maqam, created in the Iraqi tradition by Muhammad al-Qubbanji in the early 20th century.¹¹ Muhammad Abdel Wahab pioneered it in the *sharqi* repertoire with his famous song "*il-burtu'al*," then used it again, with slightly more development, in "*albi bi ulli kalam*." Muhammad Abdel Mottaleb used it in his song "*tislam idein illi-shtara*." A few other composers created songs for it—including Wadih al-Safi's "*in-najmat saru yis'alu*" and Sabri al-Mudallal's "*Ahmad ya habibi*"—but it remains more of an experimental novelty, as it never really caught on beyond those few compositions. In this *sharqi* version, it is basically Kurd with a flat 5th scale degree (its intonation in Iraq is somewhat different), but songs in the Maqam Kurd family don't ever modulate to it, which is why we have set it outside of that *maqam* family.

Figure 24.67 shows the Maqam Lami scale¹², while figure 24.68 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.67 Maqam Lami scale.

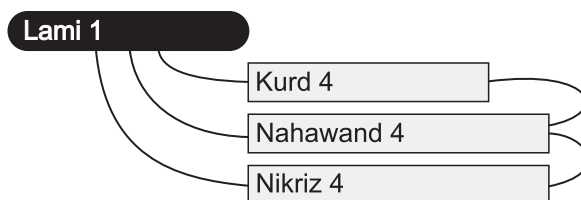


FIGURE 24.68 *Sayr* of Maqam Lami.

¹¹ al-Mahdi (1993a, p. 42).

¹² Because the melodic activity of Jins Lami includes the 5th scale degree (the note above the *gham-maz*), the bracket above that *jins* in the Maqam Lami scale spans 5 notes instead of 4.

MAQAM JIHARKAH

Maqam Jiharkah used to be much more common than Maqam ‘Ajam, which it resembles, but became archaic by the mid-20th century, with no new songs being composed in the *maqam* after the early 20th century. But its distinctive intervals (the 3rd scale degree somewhere in between that of Rast and ‘Ajam and its slightly lowered 4th scale degree) have made it a favorite of many musicians who have kept alive some of the older repertoire, many of whom retain the *jins* within improvisation, as a modulation within Maqam Rast, and in a few other places.

Figure 24.69 shows the Maqam Jiharkah scale, while figure 24.70 shows its *sayr*.



FIGURE 24.69 Maqam Jiharkah scale.

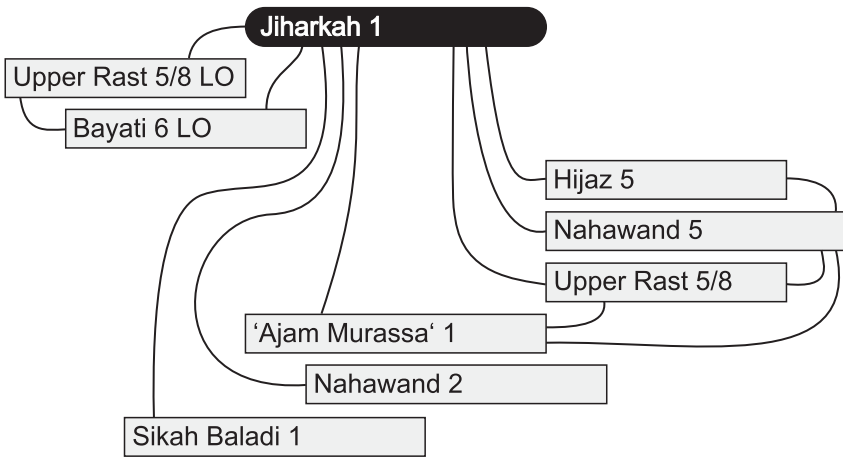


FIGURE 24.70 *Sayr* of Maqam Jiharkah.

Examples in Maqam Jiharkah include the following:

- Farid al-Atrash's "*fou' ghusnik ya lamuna*"
- The *muwashshahat* "*anta sultanu al-milah*," "*basimun 'an la'al*," and "*kallili ya subbu*"
- The traditional Aleppan *qudud* "*'ar-rozana*" and "*wahyat 'einayya*"

MAQAM SIKAH BALADI

Maqam Sikah Baladi is arguably the most challenging *maqam*, and it has remained mostly a specialty of musicians seeking to demonstrate the depth of their knowledge

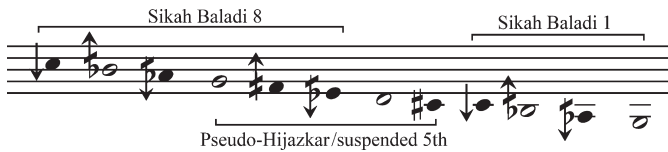


FIGURE 24.71 Maqam Sikah Baladi scale.

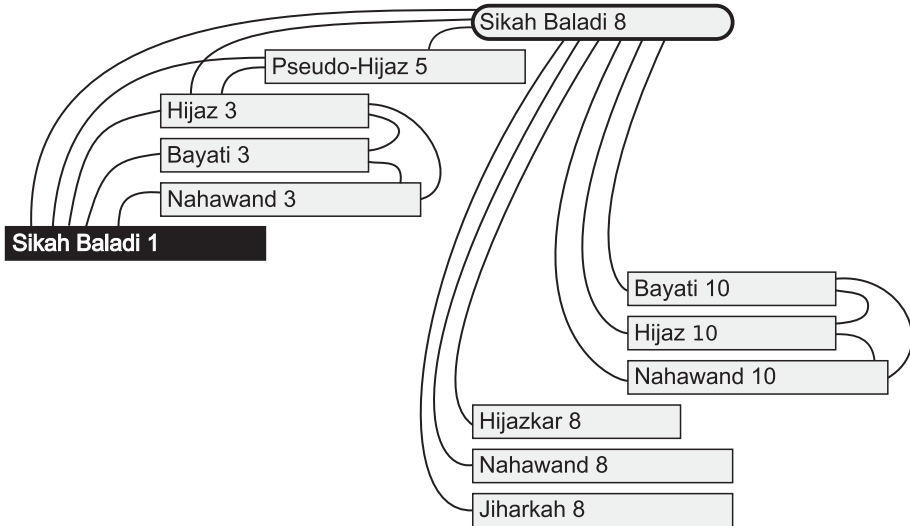


FIGURE 24.72 Sayr of Maqam Sikah Baladi.

and virtuosity. Its scale (and *sayr*) is something of a hybrid between a transposition of Maqam Huzam to an ordinary non-Sikah note, and Hijazkar—the intervals are not quite the same as either, but it sounds a bit like both—and none of the intervals matches either just or equal-tempered intonation, making it impossible to reproduce on anything but the voice and fretless instruments. It became a favorite display of compositional virtuosity by Abdel Wahab (after he gave up using Saba Dalanshin in everything, as he did in his early period), and he included it as a section in his songs “*sahirtu minhu al-layali*” and “*il-habib il-maghbul*,” as well as his composition “*ahwak*” for Abdel Halim Hafez. Other mid-20th-century Egyptian composers followed suit, with other prominent examples being the second verse of Nagat’s song “*ma-staghnash*” (composed by Kamal al-Tawil), the third verse of “*aruh li min*,” and the third verse of “*shams il-asil*” (both composed by Riyad al-Sunbati for Umm Kulthum).

Figure 24.71 shows the Maqam Sikah Baladi scale, while figure 24.72 shows its *sayr*.

Afterword: A Word of Caution

WE CAUTION READERS against misinterpreting the list of *maqamat*, *ajnas*, and *sayr*-s just presented in this book. It is far too easy, upon seeing such a list, to take it to be definitive or comprehensive. Doing so would deny the reality of this ever-changing system. It is also a habit of our way of thinking about music to assume that there are rules for what must be done—and rule breakers who chart their own paths; in that way of thinking, the content in the *maqam* and *ajnas* chapters, and in the chapters detailing each of the *ajnas*, must represent those rules for the *maqam*. There are no rules and no rule breakers in *maqam*. Instead, there is what is typical for the community of musicians to do, and there are things that are unusual or unique. And there are listeners who prefer the comfortable and conventional, and others who seek out the rare and original.

The list just presented is both too small and too big to be accurate. It is too small in several ways. First, it represents the knowledge of Johnny Farraj and Sami Abu Shumays, two actual finite human beings with finite experience in listening to and playing the music. We cannot have listened to everything in the repertoire we discuss, and so we must have missed things—both insignificant and significant.

Second, we created a standard that deliberately excluded some of what we have encountered: we insisted that everything represented here be demonstrable in at least two songs or compositions. In fact, one of the techniques of master improvisers and composers is to do something unique within the context of more conventional structures (a feature shared with art forms around the world). So if we heard a

particular modulation or *sayr* only once, we assumed that it was the original creation of the artist and did not include it here. But if someone else likes and copies that *sayr* or modulation, it begins to become the property of the community—the major process through which the *maqam* system expands.

Listeners to Egyptian and Lebanese music from the 1950s to the 1970s in particular are likely to encounter a number of experimental and unique modulations that are not captured in the preceding pages. It was the vogue to create new *jins* combinations in parallel with experimentation in harmony and the use of Western instruments. Most of those experiments, *maqam*-wise, involved the semitonal *maqamat* and the use of additional chromaticism (see “Maqam Kurd (1950s Expansion)” in chapter 24: *Maqam* Index). But not all: see the unique sequence of modulations on Saba in the introduction of Warda’s song¹ “*uhdunu-l-ayyam*,” or the unique but very natural-sounding use of Maqam Zanjari substituting for/expanding upon the Jins Hijaz that normally should occur on 5 of Rast, in the second verse of Wadih al-Safi’s song² “*al-allah t’ud*.” We do not wish to discourage future musicians from expanding the system in this or any other way, but the experienced and wise musician will recognize that originality only works well when it has a strong relationship to the conventional—something to play off of. Ultimately, this list is descriptive, not prescriptive.

Third, the list represents our position within the *maqam* system. This is related to the first point: that we are finite and cannot possibly have encountered everything. The same is true of every other participant in this shared body of community knowledge; everyone has a partial view. Geography is a major factor; those living in proximity are more likely to have a similar experience of the *maqam*, just as those living in the same community speak a similar dialect (with unique individual differences in speaking). We can see evidence of this in the gradual development of differences in the *maqam* system as practiced in different parts of the Arab world and the broader Middle East, at least in recordings from the early 20th century. The presence of mass media changed this phenomenon, especially for the repertoire we discuss, which was distributed across the Arab world and beyond in the 20th century through recordings, radio, film, and TV.

But at the same time that mass media began to erase geographic difference, they opened up a new possibility of difference: that of individual interest. We, the authors of this book, have a shared taste in what we love, exemplified by the more *tarab*-oriented work of artists such as Umm Kulthum, Muhammad Abdel Wahab, Saleh Abdel Hayy, Muhammad Khayri, and Sabah Fakhri. And we love to seek out and find the extremities of the *maqam* system, like pirates on a treasure hunt. So the *maqam* system as we see it represents our taste, which has guided our experience.

¹ Composed by Baligh Hamdi.

² Composed by Farid al-Atrash.

But there is more out there, and you, dear reader, will have a different taste, even slightly, which may lead you to things we haven't heard.

Finally, the information just presented isn't big enough because it reduces and simplifies what is really going on: a vocabulary of melodies. Each melody in the *maqam* system is unique and has an identity for participants; we all absorb thousands of melodies that make up our knowledge of the *maqam* as a whole, and dividing and classifying them into *ajnas* and modulations and *maqamat* is to an extent artificial and imposed from above. We hope that the classification presented here is *closer* to the reality of the music than the traditional theory we inherited, by being more granular as well as more flexible than that theory, but we also know that it, too, is an abstraction. If the reality is that sum total of melodic vocabulary, then the next level down between the abstraction presented in this book and the aural reality would be a lexicon of melodic phrases. Compiling such a lexicon is a possible activity, and a direction we recommend for further study, but we are guessing it would be at least twice³ as long as this book.

Paradoxically, the list just presented in chapter 24 is also too big. It represents more than any one musician is likely to learn, let alone master. As a matter of practicality, to readers out there with an ambition to perform, improvise, or compose in the *maqam* system, this is too much for you. It is easy to give in to the temptation to think that knowing it intellectually means you know it—and after all, if you've gotten this far, you've already read it through and learned something. No. You've learned the abstraction, learned the representation, if you've read this book . . . even if you've read it a hundred times. But each one of the *maqamat* on the preceding pages can be a lifetime of study alone (which is a joy difficult to describe to the uninitiated).

For some perspective and humility, consider this: what is presented here represents, in an abstracted form, a totality greater than the knowledge possessed aurally by either Umm Kulthum or Muhammad Abdel Wahab individually. It includes what they did, plus what the Aleppans did, and what Omar al-Batsh composed, and what Baligh Hamdi invented for Warda, and so forth.

It is certainly greater than the knowledge we, the authors, have mastered. A confession: some of the especially rare *maqamat* represented, in particular Maqam Nikriz and Maqam 'Ajam Ushayran, were *maqamat* we had to research and find examples of, examples that are not known to a majority of performers and listeners.⁴

³ Considering nobody has ever compiled a full lexicon of the melodic vocabulary of any given music tradition, it is very difficult to make a realistic estimate of how large it might be. Gjerdingen (2007) has made the effort we view as most similar to ours, by laying the framework for such a potential lexicon of Galant-period phrases, a level down from the abstraction presented as the "schema" in his work.

⁴ We certainly hope that writing about them will encourage readers to get to know those songs. Right now, we are enjoying getting to know the *dawr* "*yalli awamak ya'gibni*," composed by Sayed Darwish in Maqam Nikriz.

Based on the songs we found, we were able to make an abstraction of the *sayr* of that *maqam* (following the procedure mentioned previously, a *sayr* pathway represented here had to occur in at least two different songs). But we are still digesting those *maqamat* from a melodic vocabulary point of view, from the point of view of deep familiarity and fluency. We are ambitious but do not expect to digest everything represented in the preceding pages in our lifetimes, even if we know it is potentially available to us (our taste will continue to guide us to those *maqamat* we wish to inhabit more fully).

We can resolve the “too big”/“too small” paradox regarding knowledge and representation of *maqam* as follows: the information presented in the *Maqam* Index, and in the chapters detailing each *jins*, is a midpoint between what an individual might master in a lifetime of study and the total knowledge held by the community (at least held by the community in the mid-20th century).

In emphasizing the imperfect nature of what we’ve presented here, we are not engaging in self-criticism; we’re not saying that we haven’t done a good enough job in researching and finding examples of common modulations in each *maqam*. Instead, we are pointing to the imperfect nature of any such survey, taken within the limited, individual’s viewpoint. Each of the metaphors developed in these chapters reveals a partial shape, or single dimension, of *maqam*—but we have *no choice other than to rely on such partial viewpoints* (other equally valid snapshots could be taken), because the totality is too great for any individual mind to grasp. None of us, including the authors, can have a conception of its full shape; we will always see it in reduced form, like a 2D drawing of a 3D object. In this case, the two dimensions we do see are the shape and content of the knowledge as it appears in our own minds, and the missing dimension would be the network of connections among the community of all knowledge holders. The totality of *maqam* only exists in the collective minds of all the practitioners and participants of *maqam*. The metaphor for *maqam* underlying the *Maqam* Index is that of community: *maqam* as a form of community knowledge, like language or custom.

As this community shrinks, the knowledge inevitably shrinks as well. If the conditions exist for people to practice and enjoy this music, then the knowledge will continue to live through the community, which is a network of many minds in communication with each other. But we have seen the opposite trend, in which this music has been less and less valued, and the total global community has grown smaller—for *maqam*-based music just as for traditional music in general, and live music in particular. We are grateful that there are valiant efforts being made by many others to grow the community against this tide—both in the United States, where we write from, and in the Arab world, the music’s home—and we can point to a

number of small communities that have in fact experienced growth in the number of participants over recent decades.

Many people do consider this music valuable, and of course we must assume that you, dear reader, are one of them. We hope that you will share our joy, and also our desire to share that pleasure with others. Only in this way can we keep the community and the knowledge thriving. If we have struck a pessimistic tone at any point, that is because we have seen some shrinking in the extent of the *maqam* system in active practice, and to see any fading in something one loves so much can be painful. We have seen pressures to standardize, Westernize, and colonize that have kept this music on a lower plane than the West's admittedly brilliant, but not *more* brilliant, art forms. Yet despite any pessimism, our ambition is to offer whatever we are able in terms of information, to help keep more of it in the minds of our friends, fellow musicians, students, and strangers, if we can! If this effort can contribute to any expansion of the community that shares this beautiful art form, we will feel that we have offered something of value. But now shut these pages, and go put on a record of Umm Kulthum; she will explain it much better. And then go play that song with some of your friends.

Sami Abu Shumays
New York, February 2018

Glossary

a'raj (أعرج): Limping. Used to describe Arabic *iqā'at* with odd time signatures.

adhan (أذان): The Muslim call to prayer, performed a cappella five times a day, most commonly in Maqam Rast or Maqam Hijaz.

'afq (عَفَق): A fingering technique on the *qanun* that involves using the fingernail of the left thumb to press down on a course of strings in order to temporarily raise its tuning (literally, “pressing”). *'afq* has become a standard ornamentation technique on the *qanun*, especially during *taqasim*.

abat (آهات): Plural of the expression “*Ah*,” used to name the third section of the *dawr* form, which involves exchanging composed melodies between the singer and the backing vocalists in a call-and-response fashion, using the melismatic syllable “*Ah*.”

aliyya (آلية): Instrumental, from *ala* (آلة) (musical) instrument.

'ammiyya (عامية): Colloquial (regional) spoken Arabic.

'aqd (عَقْد) pl. *'uqud* (عُقُود): A group of 5 consecutive notes used as a building block for a *maqam* scale in traditional Arabic music theory.

'ataba (عَتَبَة) pl. *'atabat* (عَتَبَات): One of many notes in a *maqam* scale highlighted during an instrumental improvisation (literally, “a step,” “a threshold”).

'ataba (عتابا), pronounced “a-TAH-ba”: A regional and folkloric type of *mawwal* widespread in Lebanon.

'azama (عَظَمَة): “Greatness!,” an expression used by the audience to cheer a very well-respected *mutrib/mutriba* (e.g., Umm Kulthum) during a live performance when they strongly feel *tarab*.

'azf munfarid (عَزَف منفرد): A solo instrumental performance.

arghul (أَرْغُول): A traditional Egyptian and Palestinian wind instrument made with two single-reed pipes; the shorter one is used for melody and the longer one for droning.

- baladi* (بلدي): A musical genre that started in Egypt in the 1920s and early 1930s with singers such as Muhammad al-Kahlawi, Mahmud Sharif, and ‘Ali Isma‘il, and later Fatima Serhan. Also, the name of a popular *iqā’*.
- bandir* (بندير), also spelled *bendir*: A frame drum common in North Africa, often including a snare made of nylon wires.
- bashraf* (بشرف): A Turkish/Ottoman composed instrumental form that consists of four *khanat* (verses), each followed by the same *taslim* (refrain).
- batana* (بطانة): A group of two to four backing vocalists who accompany a principal singer (literally, “the lining of a garment,” because the chorus’s voices line and thicken the singer’s own voice).
- buzuq* (بُزُق), also spelled *buzuk* or *bouzouk*: A fretted stringed instrument with a small pear-shaped body and a long, thin neck, popular in the folk music of Syria, Lebanon, Palestine, and Jordan.
- dabit al-iqā’* (ضابط الإيقاع): The rhythm leader/controller in an Arabic ensemble, usually the *riqq* player (literally, “the officer of rhythm”).
- dabke* (دبكة): A Syrian, Lebanese, and Palestinian village line dance, from the verb *dabaka* (دبك), to stomp.
- daff* (دَف), pl. *dufiuf* (ذُفوف): A frame drum; also, an alternate name for the *riqq* in some countries.
- dalil* (دليل): Key signature for a *maqam* scale; may include half-flat or half-sharp notes (literally, “a guide”).
- darajat al-rukuz* (درجة الركوز): The principal note of melodic emphasis in a *jins* or *maqam* scale, and the note that the melody comes back to for resolution (literally, “the scale degree of stability/immobility”). This note is analogous to the “tonic” in Western music theory, the word we have adopted in this book.
- darij* (دارج): A simple $\frac{3}{4}$ *iqā’*; an instrumental composition in that *iqā’* (literally, “widespread” or “fashionable”).
- dawr* (دور), pl. *adwar* (أدوار): A composed vocal form that was developed in Egypt in the mid-1800s and remained popular until the mid-20th century; also, the opening melodic section in the *muwashshah* form, which is repeated more than once (literally, “a turn”).
- dhikr* (ذِكْر): A ritual Sufi ceremony in Islam in which participants chant and utter the word “Allah” and other phrases, in order to reach a state of trance. *Dhikr* ceremonies often include music and dance performance.
- dirbakki* (دربكّة): Another name for a *tabla* popular in Lebanon and Syria.
- doholla* (ذُهْلَة): An Egyptian percussion instrument shaped like a *tabla* but slightly larger and more bassy, used mostly to play a skeletal rhythm and support other percussion instruments.
- dulab* (دولاب), pl. *dawalib* (دواليب): A short instrumental composition with a few simple phrases, used to introduce a *dawr*, *taqtuqa*, or more generally a *maqam*’s basic scale, before a vocal or instrumental improvisation (literally, “a wheel,” or “a cycle”).
- dum* (ذَمْ): An onomatopoeia derived from the bassy and sustained sound produced by hitting a drum skin away from the rim; one of the two building blocks for Arabic *iqā’at*.
- duzan* (دوزان): Colloquial Arabic for the tuning of an instrument, and by extension, intonation or pitch (originally from Turkish *düzen*, meaning “orderliness,” “regularity”).
- firqa* (فرقة), pl. *firaq* (فِرَق): A group or ensemble; an orchestra.

ghammaz (غمان): The second most important note of melodic emphasis in a *jins/maqam* scale, and in most cases also the most common modulation point to new *ajnas/maqamat*.

gharbi (غربي): Western, from *al-gharb* (الغرب), the West.

ghina'yya (غنائية): Vocal, from the word *ghina'* (غناء), singing.

ghita' (غطاء): The *muwashshah* section that immediately follows the *khana*, where the melody repeats that of the first verse(s) called *dawr* (literally, “a cover”).

ghusn (غصن): A melodic section in a composition different than the refrain; a verse or couplet (literally, “a branch”). *Ghusn* is used to denote verses in the *dawr* and *taqtuqa* composed forms.

hafidh (حافظ), *hafiz* in colloquial: One who has memorized. From the verb *hafidha* (to preserve, conserve, or memorize).

hassas (حساس): The note immediately below the tonic of a *jins* or *maqam* scale, also called the “leading tone” in Western music theory (literally, “the sensitive one” or “the one who feels”).

intiqal (انتقال), pl. *intiqalat* (انتقالات): Modulation among *ajnas/maqamat* (literally, “moving to,” “transferring to”).

iqā' (إيقاع), also spelled *iqaa*, pl. *iqā'at* (إيقاعات): Rhythm, from the verb *waqa'a* (وقع), to fall/occur (literally, “making [the beats] fall”); a rhythmic metric cycle built from the *dum* and *tak* basic sounds arranged in a fixed order.

irtijal (ارتجال): Improvisation in music, poetry, or any performing arts genre.

islah (إصلاح): Tuning an instrument (literally, “correcting,” “straightening”).

istihlal (استهلال): A composed instrumental prelude, usually a stand-alone piece.

jalsa (جلسة): A sit-down gathering of musicians and listeners involving music performance, a jam session (literally “a sitting”). Also called *qa'da* or *qa'deh* (قعدة) in colloquial dialects from Egypt through Syria.

jawab (جواب): The octave note in a *maqam* scale (literally, “the answer,” a “reply” or “response” to the tonic).

jawqa (جوقة): A choir.

jinas (جناس): A homonym (two or more words that have the same spelling/sound but have a different meaning). Homonyms are used in the poetry of *mawwal* forms.

jins (جنس), pronounced “jince”; pl. *ajnas* (أجناس): A scale fragment of 3 to 6 notes that forms the basic melodic unit of Arabic music. *Ajnas* are the building blocks for *maqam* scales and include notes of emphasis, a melodic vocabulary, a distinctive mood, and a unique identity.

joza (جوزة): A traditional bowed string instrument used in Iraq. The *joza* has a twangy melancholic timbre and a round body made of a coconut shell (the literal meaning of *joza*).

jumla (جُملة), pl. *jumal* (جُمَل): A musical phrase; a linguistic sentence.

kamanja (كمنجة): A historic bowed string instrument used mainly in Egypt (from Persian *kamancheh*; literally, “little bow”); also, the Arabic name for a violin, which can be shortened to *kaman* (كمان).

katim (كأتم): A bassy frame drum that accompanies other percussion instruments and emphasizes the *dum* and *tak* notes in the skeletal rhythm (literally, “muffler/silencer”).

katm (كتم): An ornamentation technique on the *qanun* in which the right thumb silences the ringing of a string shortly after it is plucked (literally, “muting/muffling”).

- kawala* (كؤلة): A single-reed Egyptian wind instrument played by blowing across its end. It resembles the *nay* but has a deeper sound and is very popular in folk music.
- khana* (خانة) pl. *khanat* (خانات): A verse or a couplet in general; particularly, a verse in the three Turkish instrumental composed forms: *sama'i*, *bashraf*, and *longa*; a section in the *muwashshah* form in which the melody changes from that of the initial section(s) called *dawr* and usually involves a *maqam* modulation (derived from Persian *khaneh*; literally, “home/house”).
- khazza* (خَزَّة): A buzz in a frame drum, caused by a snare made of one or more nylon wires stretched across the skin.
- layali* (ليالي): A vocal improvisational form based on the words “*ya layl*” (يا ليل), Arabic for “O night, O eye,” usually used as a warm-up before an improvised *mawwal* or *qasida* (*layali* are sung in colloquial Arabic, in which *layl* is pronounced “lei”) (literally, the plural of *layl*).
- lazima* (لازمة), pl. *lazimat* (لازمات): A short instrumental phrase occurring in between vocal phrases in a vocal composition.
- longa* (لونجا), pl. *longat* (لونجات): A lively composed instrumental form that has its roots in Eastern Europe and consists of two to four *khanat* (verses), each followed by the same *taslim* (refrain).
- ma'zufa* (معزوفة), pl. *ma'zufat* (معزوفات): A free-form instrumental composition.
- madhhab* (مذهب): A repeating refrain (chorus) in a song, usually performed by backing vocalists.
- madhhabji* (مذهبي), pl. *madhhabjiyya* (مذهبية): A backing vocalist who sings the *madhhab*.
- maqam* (مقام) pl. *maqamat* (مقامات): A melodic mode/scale associated with a rich oral tradition defining correct intonation, idiomatic melodic phrases, notes of emphasis, and modulation possibilities (literally, “a place,” “a position”); the melodic/scale system as a whole.
- maqtu'a* (مقطوعة) pl. *maqtu'at* (مقطوعات): A free-form instrumental composition; also, colloquially called *qit'a* (قطعة) (literally, “a piece”).
- mawwal* (مؤال), pl. *mawwil* (مواويل): A traditional vocal improvisation performed on a poem in a colloquial Arabic dialect. *Mawwal baghdadi* (مؤال بغدادي) is a regional *mawwal* originally from Baghdad, with seven unmetred lines made of twelve syllables each;
- mawzun* (موزون): Rhythmic (literally, “weighted”).
- mazhar* (مزهر): A midsize frame drum common in Syria.
- mazura* (مازورة): The common Arabic word for a measure in music notation; derived from the Italian *misura* or the French *mesure*.
- mijwiz* (ميجوز): A folkloric wind instrument popular in Palestine, Lebanon, Jordan, Syria, and Iraq. Its name means “made of a pair” or “doubled up” because it is made of two bamboo reed pipes attached together. The two pipes have the same array of holes, allowing the performer to play a single melody on both pipes. The pipes are intentionally slightly mistuned so as to produce vibrant beats.
- mizan* (ميزان): Time signature of an *iqā'* (rhythmic cycle), known as “meter” in Western music.
- mizmar* (ميزمار): A double-reed wind instrument, made of wood and shaped like a cone at the end. It is very loud and is usually played outdoors in a village setting alongside a *tabl baladi*.
- mughanni* (مُغَنِّي), fem. *mughanniya* (مُغَنِّيَة): A singer.
- munshid* (مُنشِد): A religious cantor in the Muslim tradition.

muqaddima (مُقَدِّمَة), pl. *muqaddimat* (مُقَدِّمَات): A composed instrumental introduction that precedes a vocal piece.

murassa' (مُرَّسَع): Inlaid with pearls; more generally, decorated/ornamented. In the *maqam/jins* name Nahawand *Murassa'* it refers to a version of Nahawand “decorated” by lowering its 5th scale degree. We adopted that as a convention in this book to name two previously unnamed *ajnas*: Hijaz *Murassa'* (Jins Hijaz with a lowered 5th) and Ajam *Murassa'* (Jins Ajam with a raised 4th).

mursal (مُرْسَل), fem. *mursala* (مُرْسَلَة): Unconstrained by rhythm; for example, *qasida mursala* is a classical Arabic poem delivered using an improvised melody.

musharraq (مُشْرِق): Made to be Eastern, from *al-sharq* (أَشْرَق), the East; describes a musical instrument that has been altered to play additional notes found only in the Arabic tuning system (we translate that in this book as “Arabized”).

mutrib (مُطْرِب), fem. *mutriba* (مُطْرِبَة): An honorific title for the singer in the *tarab* musical genre (literally, “the person who causes *tarab*”), as opposed to *mughanni*.

muwaqqa' (مُوقَّع): Rhythmic, from *iqa'* (rhythmic cycle).

muwashshah (مُوشَّح) pl. *muwashshahat* (مُوشَّحَات): An Arabic poetic genre that appeared in Andalusia around the 9th century and introduced multiple rhymes, nontraditional meters, and a variable structure; the genre of vocal composition based on that poem.

nahda (النَهْضَة): The period from the late 19th to the early 20th centuries, during which Arabic music experienced a great cultural renaissance (literally, “the rising”).

naqr (نَقْر): A category of melodic instruments that have a percussive sound, for example, plucked or hammered string instruments such as the *'ud*, the *qanun*, and the *buzuq* (literally, “tapping,” “pecking”).

nay (نَاي), pl. *nayat* (نَايَات): A wind instrument made of hollowed-out cane open at both ends (from the Persian word *ney*, literally, “reed”); *nayati* (نَايَاتِي) is a *nay* player.

nota (نُوطَة): The common Arabic word for music notation; from the Italian word *nota* or the French word *note*.

org (أُورْج): An electric organ (transliteration of the French *orgue* as it sounds in Arabic).

qadd (قَدَّ), pl. *qudud* (قُدُود): A popular song genre with colloquial lyrics that originated in the city of Aleppo, Syria. *Qudud* are usually performed within a suite, along with other forms.

qafla (قَفْلَة), pl. *qaflat* (قَفْلَات): A musical cadence; ending phrase; from the verb *qafala* (قَفَلَ) (literally, “to close/lock”).

qalab (قَالَاب), pl. *qawalib* (قَوَالِب): A musical form (literally, “a mold,” “a shaped container”).

qanun (قَانُون): A string instrument consisting of approximately 78 to 81 strings stretched over a trapezoidal sounding board. The word *qanun* literally means “law” in Arabic. With its range of over three octaves, its consistent intonation, and its loud volume, it occupies a principal role as a *naqr* (plucked) instrument in the *takht*.

qaraqib (قَرَاقِب), sing. *qurqub* (قُرْقُوب): A metallic percussion instrument (an idiophone) made of two thin metal plates clanked together in each hand; used primarily in Morocco.

qarar (قَرَار): The tonic or lower octave of a scale (literally “the bottom/floor,” “the state of stability/steadiness”).

qasida (قَصِيدَة), pl. *qasā'id* (قَصَائِد): A metered poem written in the classical Arabic language, using a single rhyme throughout, and possibly stretching to hundreds of lines (most

analogous to the epic poem); the vocal forms (composed and improvised) using that poem for their lyrics.

rababa (ربابة): The name used for several kinds of bowed spike fiddles used from Egypt through Syria. It is worth mentioning that the European violin actually evolved from the Arab *rababa*, taken by troubadours to southern Europe, where it became the *rebec*, the ancestor of the viol family of bowed string instruments.

raqs sharqi (رقص شرقي): A dance form based in folk traditions of Egypt and the Arab world that was brought to the café and cabaret stage in the early 20th century and flourished with the advent of film and television in the early to mid-20th century. *Raqs sharqi* relies heavily on hip and torso movements and is commonly known in English as “belly dance.”

raqsa (رقصة), pl. *raqasat* (رقصات): A dance.

rashsh (رش): tremolo (literally, “spraying, sprinkling”).

riqq (رق), also spelled *riq*, pl. *ruquq* (زقوق): A small handheld tambourine made of an inlaid wooden frame traditionally covered with a goat or fish skin head, with five sets of two pairs of small brass cymbals. The *riqq* is the percussion instrument of choice in a *takht*, and its player is traditionally also *dabit al-iqa'* (ضابط الإيقاع, the rhythm controller).

sab'awi (سبعاعي): Based on the number 7; another name for the *mawwal baghdadi* (a vocal improvisation on a poem in seven verses).

sabb (سحب): A category of musical instruments that have a sustaining sound, for example wind instruments like the *nay* or bowed string instruments like the violin (literally, pulling).

sajat (صاجات), sing. *saga* (صاجة): Small brass cymbals, either worn on the fingers or found in a percussion instrument like the *riqq*; a dome-shaped metallic object. *Sajat* are called *sagat* in colloquial Egyptian and also commonly called *zills* in English (from the Turkish word *zil*; literally, “cymbal” or “bell”).

sakta (سكتة): A musical rest (literally, “a brief silence”).

saltana (سلطنة): A state of high mastery and intense creativity experienced by a performer (singer or instrumentalist) in which he or she has complete control of the instrument; literally, “reigning or ruling,” derived from the word *sultan* (سلطان), a sultan; also, a state of feeling very deeply in the mood of a particular *maqam* (figuratively, “being ruled by” the *maqam*).

sama'i (سماعي), pl. *sama'iyyat* (سماعيات): A composed Turkish/Ottoman instrumental form that consists of four *khanat* (verses), each followed by the same *taslim* (refrain).

sammi'a (سَمِيْعَة), sing. *sammi'* (سَمِيْع): Avid and experienced listeners who are essential for the performer-listener feedback loop that is part of *tarab*.

santur (سَنْطُور): A trapezoidal hammered dulcimer of ancient Babylonian origin, still in use today in Iran, Iraq, Greece, and many other countries, sometimes in slightly different forms.

sayr (سَيْر): The established and habitual melodic motion/behavior of a *jins/maqam* (literally, “course, motion”).

sha'bi (شعبي): A musical genre developed in Egypt in the 1960s and 1970s by singers such as Ahmad Adaweya and later Hakim (literally, “popular”).

sharqi (شرقي): Used to describe people and traditions native to the Eastern Mediterranean Arab countries, from the perspective of Europe and North African Arab countries (from *al-sharq*, the East). The adjective *sharqi* eventually became synonymous with the region of Egypt through Syria, regardless of the point of comparison. The reciprocal adjective is *gharbi*, Western, (from *al-gharb*, the West).

sikak (سيكك), sing. *sikka* (سيكة): The melodic pathways particular to a *maqam*'s *sayr* (literally, "a rail/path").

sunbati (سنباطي), also spelled *sombati*: A drum similar to the *tabla* but slightly larger in diameter, resulting in a bassier sound.

ta'aluf (تألف): Harmony.

tabaqa (طبقة): A register or range; *tabaqa sughayyara* (lower pitch) refers to the practice of tuning instruments down by a whole step (instead of transposing the piece) in order to accommodate a singer's vocal range, while *tabaqa kebira* (higher pitch) refers to tuning instruments to concert pitch.

tabl baladi (طبل بلدي): A large, cylindrical drum with skin on both sides and a very loud sound, traditionally used in village outdoor weddings and *dabke* performances (literally, "village drum").

ta'dil (تعديل): Tuning the strings on an instrument (literally, "adjusting" or "straightening").

tadwin (تدوين): Notating, notation.

tafrid (تفريد), pl. *tafarid* (تفاريد): A free-form vocal improvisation that digresses from a composed vocal section and includes many repetitions and melodic variations (literally, "performing individually").

tahmila (تحميلة), pl. *tahmilat* (تحميلات): A composed instrumental form that features a repeated call-and-response section, highlighting each soloist in turn.

tahwil (تحويل), pl. *tahwilat* (تحويلات): A modulation (a change from one *jins/maqam* to another *jins/maqam*); literally, "changing to," "transforming into."

tajwid (تجويد): The practice of chanting verses from the Qur'an in a highly prescribed and ornamented style.

tak (تاك): An onomatopoeia derived from the sharp and dry sound produced by hitting the side of a drum skin near (or together with) the rim; one of the two building blocks for Arabic *iqāat*.

takht sharqi (تخت شرقي), or more simply *takht*: The traditional chamber group in the *sharqi* tradition, consisting of an 'ud, a *qanun*, a violin, a *nay*, and a *riqq* (from Persian *takht*; literally "a bed" or "a raised platform," used to seat the ensemble.)

talbis (تلبيس): The practice of shifting the ongoing rhythm (by the *riqq* player) to follow a singer's digression; literally, fitting a person or object with a garment that matches his or her size exactly.

tanwit (تنويط): The act of notation (see *nota*).

taqsim (تقسيم), pl. *taqasim* (تقاسيم): A traditional and virtuosic instrumental improvisation anchored in a *maqam*.

taqtuqa (طقطوقة), pl. *taqatiq* (طقاطيق): Colloquial Egyptian for a simple and light song; a widely popular and simple song form that alternates several verses with a fixed refrain.

tarab (طرب): A state of intense musical joy and deep involvement in a particular *maqam* performance and mood. *Tarab* has been translated on various occasions as ecstasy, enchantment, elation, euphoria, or rapture. Also, the musical genre that leads to *tarab*.

tarjama (ترجمة): The art of accompanying a vocal improviser on a melodic instrument by restating his or her phrases and summarizing them after every pause (literally, "translation").

tarkib naghami (تركيب نغمي): The practice of juxtaposing intervals and *ajnas* to create new *maqam* possibilities (literally, "melodic construction").

- tasarruf* (تَصَرُّف): Performing a composed section of music according to one's individual style (literally "handling" or "taking charge of").
- tasdir* (تَصْدِير): A gradual slowing down of tempo that introduces a new musical section (literally, "to preface").
- tashkil* (تَشْكِيل): Used to describe interpreting/ornamenting an *iqā'* from its skeletal form (literally, "to give shape/form").
- tashwiq* (تَشْوِيق): Literally, "creating a longing" or "teasing"; a well-established technique used during vocal and instrumental improvisations to capture and maintain the listeners' attention.
- taslim* (تَسْلِيم): A recurring refrain or section in a composed form.
- taswir* (تَصْوِير): Transposition (literally "creating an image").
- tawziya* (تَسْوِيَة): Tuning the strings on an instrument (literally, "leveling out").
- tawzi'* (تَوَزِيع): Musical arranging (literally, "distribution" of parts).
- 'ud* (عود), also spelled *oud*, pl. *a'wad* (أَعْوَاد) or *'idan* (عِيدَان): A very popular string instrument made of a pear-shaped wooden body and a short wooden neck (literally, "a thin strip of wood," referring to the ribs used to construct its sound box). The European lute is a descendant of the *'ud* and took its name from it (in the form of *al-'ud*).
- ughniya* (أَغْنِيَة), pl. *aghani* (أَغَانِي): A composed song; also, more specifically, the long-song genre that developed in Egypt in the mid-20th century, exemplified by Umm Kulthum and other singers such as Warda and Abdel Halim Hafez
- 'urba* (غُرْبَة), pl. *'urab* (غُرَب): A slight lowering of the pitch; a vocal ornament; a mechanical lever in a *qanun* that alters a string's fine-tuning.
- ustadh* (أُسْتَاذ), pl. *asatidha* (أُسَاتِذَة): A teacher/professor; a very educated person.
- wasla* (وَصْلَة), pl. *waslat* (وَصَلَات): A multisectional suite, instrumental or vocal, consisting of several related compositions and improvisations, all based on the same *maqam* (literally, "a connection" or "a link").
- wishah* (وِشَاح): A highly ornamented scarf that included complex patterns of pearl and precious stones, worn by women in the Andalusian period.
- zakhrafa* (زُخْرَفَة): Ornamentation; the practice of adding embellishments to a plain melody, according to the aesthetics of a time and a place.
- zaffa* (زَفَّة), pl. *zaffat* (زَفَّات): A loud wedding procession involving group singing and instruments such as the *mizmar* and many varieties of frame drums.

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